

THE FLAVOR BIBLE

THE ESSENTIAL GUIDE TO CULINARY CREATIVITY, BASED
ON THE WISDOM OF AMERICA'S MOST IMAGINATIVE CHEFS



KAREN PAGE AND ANDREW DORNENBURG

IACP Award-Winning Authors of *What to Drink with What You Eat*

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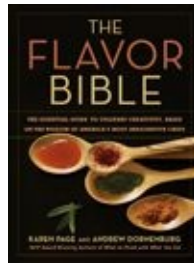
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LITTLE, BROWN AND COMPANY NEW YORK • BOSTON • LONDON



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At times our own light goes out and is rekindled by a spark from another person. Each of us has cause to think with deep gratitude of those who have lighted the flame within us.

—ALBERT SCHWEITZER

To Daniel Boulud, Patrick O'Connell, and Jean-Georges
Vongerichten—the leading lights of culinary creativity of
their generation—whose sparks always rekindle our flame

Gastronomy is the rational study of all related to man as he is eating. Its purpose is to keep humankind alive with the best possible food.

—JEAN-ANTHELME BRILLAT-SAVARIN (1755–1826)

In what art or science could improvements be made that would more powerfully contribute to increase the comforts and enjoyments of mankind?

—SIR BENJAMIN THOMPSON, COUNT RUMFORD (IN A 1794 ESSAY ON THE ART OF COOKERY)

PREFACE

“When we no longer have good cooking in the world, we will have no literature, nor high and sharp intelligence, nor friendly gatherings, nor social harmony.”

—MARIE-ANTOINE CARÊME, CHEF (1784–1833)

“Good cooking is an art, as well as a form of intense pleasure.... A recipe is only a theme, which an intelligent cook can play each time with a variation.”

—MADAME JEHANE BENOÎT, CHEF (1904–1987)

“You have to love either what you are going to eat, or the person you are cooking for. Then you have to give yourself up to cooking. Cuisine is an act of love.”

—ALAIN CHAPEL, CHEF (1937–1990)

The first quotation suggests why we do what we do, while the others suggest how. We published our first book in 1995, and it is exciting as we approach the publication of *The Flavor Bible* in 2008 to witness the realm of good cooking as it reaches a new “tipping point.”

No longer content simply to replicate others’ recipes, today’s cooks—professionals and amateurs alike—increasingly seek to create their own dishes. In doing so, they celebrate the creative *process* of cooking as much as the finished *product*.

Cooking at its most basic level is a creative act, one of transforming food through the application of heat and the incorporation of other ingredients. But there are different orders of creativity, and merely following a recipe is a creative

act of the most basic order, like painting by numbers.

When accomplished cooks grow restless, they start to analyze instructions before following them to see if they can improve upon the results, thus raising the act of cooking to a creative act of a higher order. As their experience grows, cooks are able to bring greater intuition and even inspiration to their cooking.

Traditional cookbooks are aimed at first-order cooks. Every cook owes a debt of gratitude to those who have brought progress to cuisine throughout history—those who famously codified classic cuisines through the painstaking chronicling of recipes, from Auguste Escoffier in France to others around the globe.

Appreciation is also due to those who have elevated and expanded the range of available ingredients and techniques, the essential building blocks of cooking.

Over the years, cookbooks have come to dictate precise measurement of ingredients along with instructions for their preparation and assembly, which has done much to improve the general accessibility of recipes. However, they also have come to provide a false sense of security for which the unsuspecting cook pays a price. When a recipe is rigidly scripted and blindly followed, it negates the cook's own creative instincts and good judgment—not to mention much of the pleasure of truly “being” in the moment.

“Great cooks rarely bother to consult cookbooks.”

—CHARLES SIMIC, U.S. POET LAUREATE

Those with the urge to innovate had long been on their own in the kitchen until many adopted our 1996 book, *Culinary Artistry*, as their muse. That book sought to break the mold of contemporary prescriptive cookbooks and to restore the creative instinct to chefs. Drawing on classic flavor combinations and preparations, it put the wisdom of history at cooks' fingertips for the first time—and with the same ease with which writers consulted a thesaurus.

As time passed, it became clear that chefs were thinking of flavors and their combination in new ways, beyond the classics chronicled in *Culinary Artistry*. Meanwhile, the gap between professionals and amateur cooks narrowed, as the latter installed Viking ranges at home to prepare a burgeoning array of new ingredients, with their TVs transformed into virtual twenty-four-hour cooking schools, given the advent of culinary programming.

“Food without wine is a corpse; wine without food is a ghost. United and well matched, they are as body and soul: living partners.”

—ANDRÉ SIMON, CHEF (1877–1970)

Since the year 2000 we have been studying the new ways in which flavors are being combined. It has been a privilege to interview many of the country’s most imaginative chefs and other food and drink experts (turning to an entirely different lineup from those we spoke to for *Culinary Artistry*). Some are well-established industry pioneers, while others have risen on the scene in recent years. All have wowed us with their savory cuisines and/or desserts, and often in spots less traveled, from Dallas to New Orleans to Hoboken. We’ve also combed the most recent culinary literature published in 2000 or later.

The first result was our 2006 book, *What to Drink with What You Eat*, which celebrated the harmonious combination of food and drink and, indeed, their inseparability, as suggested by the André Simon quotation.

The second result is *The Flavor Bible*, which, like *Culinary Artistry*, is not intended to be prescriptive; rather, it is an empowerment tool. *The Flavor Bible* is a comprehensive, easy-to-use single-volume reference of more than six hundred alphabetical entries listing modern-day compatible flavors, chronicling new flavor synergies in the new millennium.

Our books *Culinary Artistry* (classic flavor combinations before 1996), *The Flavor Bible* (modern flavor combinations since 2000), and *What to Drink with What You Eat* (classic and modern food and drink combinations) are essential to use in concert, as each covers different aspects of food and drink flavor harmony.



We believe cooking will continue to evolve, and not only as a means of “doing”

(i.e., putting dinner on the table, or “problem-solving” by “following a recipe”). Over time, we believe more people—including, perhaps, yourself—will have discovered it as a way of “being” in the world. We have learned enough over the past decade or two to question why cooking is done one way versus another. This thoughtful sensory engagement leads to a store of experiences that allow us to bring more intuition to the cooking process, synthesizing what we’ve done before into innovative approaches to creating a dish. Ultimately, cooking offers the opportunity to be immersed in one’s senses and in the moment like no other activity, uniting the inner and outer selves. At these times, cooking transcends drudgery and becomes a means of meditation and even healing.

It is little surprise to us, then, that when U.S. Poet Laureate Charles Simic was asked by the *New York Times Magazine*’s Deborah Solomon earlier this year, “What advice would you give to people who are looking to be happy?” his response was “For starters, learn how to cook.”

We hope this book makes you happy—literally.

—KAREN PAGE AND ANDREW DORNENBURG

New York City

April 2008



Chapter



FLAVOR = TASTE + MOUTHFEEL + AROMA +
“THE X FACTOR”: LEARNING TO RECOGNIZE THE
LANGUAGE OF FOOD

Magical dishes, magical words: A great cook is, when all is said and done, a great poet. . . . For was it not a visit from the Muses that inspired the person who first had the idea of marrying rice and chicken, grape and thrush, potatoes and entrecôte, Parmesan and pasta, eggplant and tomato, Chambertin and cockerel, liqueur brandy and woodcock, onion and tripe?

—MARCEL E. GRANCHER, *CINQUANTE ANS À TABLE* (1953)

FLAVOR = TASTE + MOUTHFEEL + AROMA + “THE X FACTOR”

Taste = What is perceived by the taste buds

Mouthfeel = What is perceived by the rest of the mouth

Aroma = What is perceived by the nose

“The X Factor” = What is perceived by the other senses—plus the heart, mind, and spirit

Our taste buds can perceive only four basic tastes: sweet, salty, sour, and bitter. The essence of great cooking is to bring these four tastes into balanced harmony to create deliciousness. It’s that simple—and that difficult. After all, flavor is a function not only of taste, but also of smell, touch, sight, and sound. Because we’re human beings, other nonphysical factors come into play, including our emotions, thoughts, and spirits.

Learning to recognize as well as manipulate both the obvious and subtle components of flavor will make you a much better cook. This book will be your companion in the kitchen whenever you wish to create deliciousness.

Learning to cook like a great chef is within the realm of possibility. However, it is something that is rarely taught; it must be “caught.”

Everyone who cooks—or even merely seasons their food at the table before eating—can benefit from mastering the basic principles of making food taste great. This complex subject is simplified by one thing: while the universe may contain a vast number of ingredients and a virtually infinite number of ingredient combinations, the palate can register only the four basic tastes.

Great food balances these tastes beautifully. A great cook knows how to taste, to discern what is needed, and to make adjustments. Once you learn how to season and how to balance tastes, a whole new world opens up to you in cooking. Of course, several factors conspire against your ever doing so—not the least of which is a culture that sees the publication of thousands of new cookbooks annually featuring recipes that promise to dazzle you and your guests if you follow them to the letter. And yet you’re often left wondering why the results aren’t as delicious as promised. That’s because great cooking is never as simple as merely following a recipe. The best cooking requires a discerning palate to know when a dish needs a little something or other—and what to add or do to elevate its flavor.

WHAT IS PERCEIVED BY THE MOUTH

Taste Buds

Sweetness. Saltiness. Sourness. Bitterness. Every delicious bite you've ever tasted has been a result of these four tastes coming together on your taste buds. We taste them as individual notes, and in concert. Each taste affects the other. For example, bitterness suppresses sweetness. In addition, different tastes affect us in different ways. Saltiness stimulates the appetite, while sweetness satiates it. Take the time to explore the four basic tastes.

Sweetness

It takes the greatest quantity of a substance that is sweet (versus salty, sour, or bitter) to register on our taste buds. However, we can appreciate the balance and “roundness” that even otherwise imperceptible sweetness adds to savory dishes. Sweetness can work with bitterness, sourness—even saltiness. Sweetness can also bring out the flavors of other ingredients, from fruits to mint.

Saltiness

When we banished more than thirty of America's leading chefs to their own desert islands with only ten ingredients to cook with for the rest of their lives (*Culinary Artistry*, 1996), the number-one ingredient they chose was salt. Salt is nature's flavor enhancer. It is the single most important taste for making savory food delicious. (Sweetness, by the way, plays the same role in desserts.)

Sourness

Sourness is second only to salt in savory food and sugar in sweet food in its importance as a flavor enhancer. Sour notes—whether a squeeze of lemon or a drizzle of vinegar—add sparkle and brightness to a dish. Balancing a dish's acidity with its other tastes is critical to the dish's ultimate success.

Bitterness

Humans are most sensitive to bitterness, and our survival wiring allows us to recognize it in even relatively tiny amounts. Bitterness balances sweetness, and can also play a vital role in cutting richness in a dish. While bitterness is more important to certain people than to others, some chefs see it as an indispensable “cleansing” taste—one that makes you want to take the next bite, and the next.

***Umami* (Savoriness)**

In addition to the four basic tastes, there is growing evidence of a fifth taste, *umami*, which we first wrote about in 1996 in *Culinary Artistry*. It is often described as the savory or meaty “mouth-filling” taste that is noticeable in such ingredients as anchovies, blue cheese, mushrooms, and green tea, and in such flavorings as monosodium glutamate (MSG), which is the primary component of branded seasonings such as Accent.

Mouthfeel

In addition to its sense of taste, the mouth has a sense of “touch” and can register other sensations, such as temperature and texture, that all play a role in flavor. These aspects of food, generally characterized as mouthfeel, help to bring food into alignment with our bodies, and bring some of a dish’s greatest interest and pleasure. The crunchiness and crispiness of a dish contribute sound as well as textural appeal.

Temperature

I always pay attention to temperature. I look at what I feel like eating now. If it is cold and rainy outside, I make sure that soup is on the menu. If it is hot outside, I make sure there are lots of salads on the menu.
—ANDREW CARMELLINI, A VOCE (NEW YORK CITY)

Temperature is one of the foremost among the other sensations that can be perceived by the mouth. The temperature of our food even affects our perception of its taste; for example, coldness suppresses sweetness. Boston pastry chef Rick Katz, with whom Andrew cooked at Lydia Shire’s restaurant Biba, first taught him the lesson of pulling out the ice cream a few minutes before serving so that the slight rise in temperature could maximize its flavor.

A food’s temperature can affect both the perception and enjoyment of a dish. A chilled carrot soup on a hot summer day—and hot roasted carrots on a cold winter day—could be said to be “healing” through their ability to bring our bodies into greater alignment with our environment.



Texture

I would never serve pike on a base of chowder, because balance and texture are so important when it comes to creating a dish. Is there a rich component, a lean component, a crunchy component, and a cleansing component? Are all the taste sensors activated so that you want to go back for a second bite? Cod works better over a richer preparation like chowder. I would also make sure to choose the right technique for the cod: I would not poach it, because if it is poached it would be silky on silky. If it is seared, it is crunchy on silky—which is more appealing because of the contrast.

—**SHARON HAGE**, YORK STREET (DALLAS)

A food's texture is central to its ability to captivate and to please. We value pureed and/or creamy foods (such as soups and mashed potatoes) as “comfort” foods, and crunchiness and crispiness (such as nachos and caramel corn) as “fun” foods. We enjoy texture as it activates our other senses, including touch, sight, and sound.

While babies by necessity eat pureed foods, most adults enjoy a variety of textures, particularly crispiness and crunchiness, which break up the smoothness of texture—or even the simple monotony—of dishes.

Piquancy

Our mouths can also sense what we often incorrectly refer to as “hotness,” meaning piquancy’s “sharpness” and/or “spiciness”—whether boldly as in chile peppers, or more subtly as in a sprinkle of cayenne pepper. Some people find the experience of these *picante* (as the Spanish refer to it, or *piccante* as the Italians do) tastes more pleasurable than others.

Astringency

Our mouths “pucker” to register astringency. This is a drying sensation caused by the tannins in red wine or strong tea, and occasionally in foods such as walnuts, cranberries, and unripe persimmons.

WHAT IS PERCEIVED BY THE NOSE

Aroma

Aroma is thought to be responsible for as much as 80 percent or more of flavor. This helps to explain the popularity of aromatic ingredients, from fresh herbs and spices to grated lemon zest. Incorporating aromatic ingredients can enhance the aroma of your dish and, in turn, its flavor.

Some qualities are perceived through both the sense of taste and smell, such as:

Pungency

Pungency refers to the taste and aroma of such ingredients as horseradish and mustard that are as irritating—albeit often pleasantly—to the nose as they are to the palate.

Chemesthesis

Chemesthesis refers to other sensations that tickle (e.g., the tingle of carbonated beverages) or play tricks on (e.g., the false perception of “heat” from chile peppers, or “cold” from peppermint) our gustatory senses.

WHAT IS PERCEIVED BY THE HEART, MIND, AND SPIRIT

“The X Factor”

When we are present to what we are eating, food has the power to affect our entire selves. We experience food not only through our five physical senses—including our sense of sight, which we address first below—but also emotionally, mentally, and even spiritually.



Heightening Flavor with Dominique and Cindy Duby of Wild Sweets

We believe that food preparation is 60 percent ingredients and 40 percent technique.

—DOMINIQUE AND CINDY DUBY, WILD SWEETS (VANCOUVER)

Flavor is the combination of the taste you experience on your tongue and the aroma you experience through your nose. We believe that as much as 90 percent of what we perceive as taste is actually aroma. When you eat a pineapple, the flavor really comes through the nose. So, if your pineapple is not ripe, it won't have much aroma. It may taste sweet, but it won't taste like pineapple.

There are two ways to bring flavor to a dish, through aroma or through chemical reaction. We always say that cooking is no different from doing a lab experiment: The minute you add heat to a raw product, you are changing the status of that product. When you use the Maillard reaction—which is what happens when you sear a piece of meat—you are getting a reaction of caramelization from the carbohydrates and amino acids. This chemical reaction creates flavor.

To add aroma to a dish, think of a piece of fish cooked in broth with herbs or lemon. The problem is that the flavor escapes into the air. If you walk into a room and it smells great, that means there is not much flavor left in the dish. The aroma has escaped. So, if you want to add aroma to a dish, the best way is through *sous-vide* cooking [which cooks encased food at long, slow temperatures]. This method traps the aroma into what you are cooking without letting it escape.

The problem is that *sous vide* is not available for home cooks. What a home cook can do is “sealed cooking,” where you take a heavy-duty freezer ziplock bag, put in what you want to cook with the liquid, then cook it over a steady heat on your stove. Another method that works is putting the bag in a pot with a single-cup water heater that goes to about 140 degrees Fahrenheit and, from time to time, stirring the water. [Note: Care must be taken with this low-temperature method of cooking to avoid food poisoning.]

This is a way to put—and keep—a lot of flavor in whatever you are cooking.

The Visual

The visual presentation of a dish can greatly enhance the pleasure we derive from it. Just a few decades ago, it was still possible to taste a dish with the eyes, but only those who'd spent time in worldclass kitchens knew the tricks of such artistic plate presentation. Since the advent of *Art Culinaire* and the Web, it's become easier to reproduce a great dish's elaborate form than its exquisite flavor.

How a dish looks can also affect our perception of its flavor in more direct ways; for example, the deeper the color of a berry sorbet, the more berry flavor is perceived. The stronger the connection between a particular food and a

particular color, the stronger the flavor impact—such as berries with red, lemon with yellow, and lime with green.

Compatible Flavors

An essential aspect of great cooking is harnessing compatible flavors—which involves knowing which herbs, spices, and other flavorings best accentuate particular ingredients.

A process of trial and error over centuries resulted in classic cuisines and dishes, some of which feature timeless combinations of beloved flavor pairings—for example, basil with tomatoes, rosemary with lamb, and tarragon with lobster.

However, today it's possible to use scientific techniques to analyze similar molecular structures to come up with new, compatible pairing possibilities, as odd as some might sound—such as jasmine with pork liver, parsley with banana, or white chocolate with caviar.

The Emotional

I say all the time that [my mother's Spanish potato and egg tortilla] is my favorite because it conveys a point: that sentimental value comes above all else.

—**FERRAN ADRIA**, EL BULLI (SPAIN)

We taste with our hearts as much as with our tongues. What else could explain adult preferences for one's mother's dishes over those prepared by a great chef? This also helps to explain the lasting appeal of traditional dishes and cuisines of countries around the globe, which stem from our love for their cultures, their people, and the deeply rooted culinary traditions that have sustained them over centuries.



Choosing a Cooking Technique with Michael Anthony of Gramercy Tavern in New York City

When we look at an ingredient, we ask, “How can we maximize the inherent flavor or quality of what this is?” As in any other progressive modern kitchen, there is a fascination with examining all the new techniques we can get our hands on. We have used *sous vide* [i.e., cooking vacuum-packed ingredients at low temperatures for long periods of time], but we are far from letting any technique drive a dish.

Alice Waters described something cooked via *sous vide* as “dead” food. I can understand her opinion because she is all about inflecting that “freshcut crunch” feeling into her food. *Sous vide* is all about a long, slow cooking process—and those products calling for that [such as tougher cuts of meat] will be awesome.

Why we choose any specialized piece of equipment for a dish always gets back to good oldfashioned cooking principles: What is the best way of capturing flavors?

That is how choosing a technique fits into my cooking.

I’m excited to eat in restaurants that are pushing the boundaries of presentation and technique. Yet my personal take on food that is too technically driven is that technique comes first and taste comes second. I feel the meals that hit home are ones where the flavor is there and you are eating a meal in a distinct time and place. I love it when people look back on a meal, and the time of year is what made it special. The ingredients they tasted seemed naturally a part of that moment because that is what is available then.

Sometimes straightforward flavors are the ones people can latch on to, even though the ingredients can be very sophisticated behind the scenes. If, ultimately, the flavor combination is one that is simple and straightforward, with an impressive balance of acidity and bitterness, and you remember it, then you win as a diner. Sometimes the meals that hit home are not the ones that were the most complicated.

The Mental

If we ate only for sustenance, we could probably survive on nutritive pills and water. But we also eat for pleasure. Because we typically eat three times a day, 365 days a year, we enjoy novelty, such as a twist on the traditional construct of a dish. Increasingly, since the 1980s and the advent of “tall” food, chefs have played with the presentation of their ingredients. Since the 1990s, the advent of avant-garde cuisine and so-called molecular gastronomy has seen chefs experiment more and more with both the chemical composition and presentation of dishes as well.

The Spiritual

The preparation, cooking, and eating of food is a sacrament. Treating it as such has the potential to elevate the quality of our daily lives like nothing else. Several of the world's leading chefs have worked to perfect each aspect of the dining encounter—from the food and drink to the ambiance to the service—to raise the overall experience to a new level imbued not only with pleasure, comfort, and interest, but also with meaning.

FLAVOR FROM THE INSIDE OUT

America's foremost chefs reached the pinnacle of their profession through their painstaking attention to every aspect of their cuisine and the restaurant experience. Chefs bring their own unique approaches to their cuisines, which are arguably rooted in either the physical, emotional, mental, or spiritual—although they can span two, three, or even all of them.

Chefs whose focus celebrates the **physical** realm include **Alice Waters** of Chez Panisse in Berkeley, California, with her pathbreaking focus on the quality of ingredients sourced and served, and **Dan Barber** of Blue Hill at Stone Barns in Pocantico Hills, New York, whose on-premises greenhouse, gardens, and pastures grow and raise much of what the restaurant serves.

Celebrating the **emotional** realm are those chefs whose cuisines are closely tied to a specific culture, its people, and their traditions. It includes chefs such as **Rick Bayless**, whose Frontera Grill and Topolobampo in Chicago elevate Mexican cuisine, and **Vikram Vij** and **Meeru Dhalwala**, whose Vij's and Rangoli restaurants in Vancouver honor and celebrate the cooking of India and tap Indian women exclusively to staff their kitchens.

Easily identifiable as part of the **mental** realm are chefs whose efforts are reconceptualizing how food can be manipulated and presented, such as Chicago's **Grant Achatz** of Alinea (with signature dishes such as bacon on a clothesline) and **Homaro Cantu** of Moto (whose dishes include incorporating edible paper printed with soy-based inks, and a doughnut soup that looks like eggnog and tastes just like a doughnut).

Through the elevation not only of their cuisines but of the creation and orchestration of ambiance and service as well, chefs such as **Daniel Boulud** of New York's Restaurant Daniel and **Patrick O'Connell** of The Inn at Little Washington in Virginia transcend the prior three categories to bring the dining experience to another level in the **spiritual** realm.

In the pages that follow, we'll share chefs' reflections on working in the first three realms. (As for their thoughts on the fourth, we invite you to visit or revisit our book *Culinary Artistry*.)

The Physical Realm

My motto has always been: Find the best ingredients possible, and listen to what they tell you about how they want to be prepared. Mess with them as little as you can. Keep their integrity, but at the same time, focus their flavor, which is where creativity comes in.

—VITALY PALEY, PALEY'S PLACE (PORTLAND, OREGON)

The best chefs work with the best ingredients available to them. The very best chefs don't settle for this, and seek out even better ingredients through working with foragers, developing relationships with farmers and other purveyors, and even growing their own produce and raising their own animals.

Monica Pope of T'afia in Houston

My cooking changed radically when we started hosting a farmers' market [located at T'afia]. I remember when I was cooking in California, and chefs would be waiting for an ingredient to come into season. When it arrived, their philosophy would be "Let's just slice it and not screw it up." I thought, "That is just not the way restaurants work." It's hard to believe that now I am saying the same thing that they used to say.

Since the advent of the farmers' market, when I get a product, it is phenomenal—because it was picked at the right time and has never even been refrigerated before it comes to my door. Sometimes I feel guilty because people will love something, and ask what I did to it. Often the answer is "Very little."

Our zucchini salad is a perfect example of celebrating what comes to our door. We get baby zucchini and we shave them raw. Then we add a flavored pecan oil, raw local pecan halves, shaved pecorino cheese, Mexican marigold, and a pinch of salt.

We also think a lot about the best way to present these ingredients. The salad has to be interesting the whole way through, and I want the customer to have the experience of interacting with it themselves. I want them to have the experience of lifting a shaved piece of cheese after their bite of crunchy yellow or light-green squash. They will see that the salad is dressed with oil, but then have to search and realize that it is pecan oil. Then they will take the next bite and get the herb that has a minty note to it. To achieve this, I will taste a dish night after night to make sure it is "eating" the way I want it to eat.

Michael Anthony of Gramercy Tavern in New York City

You want to have an infatuation with the ingredients you cook with. You want to tap all the hopes and dreams that went into producing that ingredient. You need to think, “Is this ingredient not only up to par, but is it brilliant?” When it is cooked, you want whoever bites into what you made to think that the flavor is bright, interesting, and delicious.

I take a simple approach to my food, but simple food does not mean unmanipulated food. Sometimes simple food is simply boring.

When I cook, I am looking to pull myself back from a dish rather than add to a dish. I would rather a dish feel too simple than too fussy. So, sticking to my core principles, I never want to overload a dish with too many ingredients. But cooking is not always one-two-three. Sometimes you need some extra ingredients as long as they work dynamically.

Dan Barber of Blue Hill at Stone Barns in Pocantico Hills, New York

Our pork dish starts not at the table with the cut of pork on the plate, but in the field with what kind of pork we choose to raise for our restaurant. I make a lot of decisions to get the most “pigness” out of our pork dish. We raise Berkshire pigs, which have a great flavor. They are an older breed that has a flavor profile that newer breeds don’t have. The pig has a great intramuscular profile that allows it to develop a better flavor.



We feed our pigs organic grains and that makes a huge difference. We feed them a wide variety of grains and they forage as well. We are also careful of how much corn the pigs eat. I proved unequivocally this summer the difference feed makes. We had a problem getting organic grain for about eight weeks and had to use conventional grain that has more corn in it because it is cheap to use in the feed. I tasted our pork that was raised exactly the same way side by side with the only change being the feed, and the flavor was as different as night and day. The flavor of the two was so different that a child could tell them apart.

We also make sure our pigs are slaughtered in a less stressful way. This makes for a calmer pig, and you can see a difference in the meat and taste the difference [in the texture] on the plate.

At Blue Hill when you order the pork at our restaurant, you don't know what cut you will be getting. We serve leg, shoulder, rack, loin, and belly; it is a mix on the plate. This makes for a more interesting experience, because you get a variety of flavors and textures. We keep the dish pretty straightforward. We will serve it with Brussels sprout leaves and chickpeas.

We don't want to do anything to hide the flavor. We make a pork stock, infuse it with more roasted scraps and bones to make a pork second [also known as a *remoulage*], then do one more pass with more pork and very little wine. This is water that has been infused with pork three times.

Depending on the season, I will make an infusion with herbs like a tea and add a little to the sauce if I want to add more flavor. The reason I do an infusion is to make sure the flavor is so light that you don't even know it is there.

The Emotional Realm

I have no professional cooking training. My starting point was, What do I know? I know Indian spices and flavors.

—MEERU DHALWALA, VIJ'S (VANCOUVER)

There are many emotional connections to draw from when creating dishes—from the bounty of a particular country and its historic evolution into a national cuisine, to the classic dishes of that culture, and of the families and even individual cooks within it—as each might bring a unique twist to the standards.

Maricel Presilla of Cucharamama and Zafra in Hoboken, New Jersey

I'm Cuban—but whether you are Cuban, Venezuelan, Chilean [or another nationality], there is an enormous pride in the flavors of your region and of your childhood. It is like mother's milk, your first compass. It doesn't matter how much you travel or how much you expand your palate: You always come back to this notion of basic flavors and ingredients, time and again.

For me, being a Cuban from eastern Cuba is my anchor. I am from Santiago, which has a very defined cuisine. It is more influenced by the neighboring islands such as Jamaica and Haiti, which both have European influences as well. The cooks from those islands brought flavors with them like allspice, which is not used in the rest of Cuba. My family uses allspice lavishly in our adobo and in other dishes. I use it a lot as well—and it is one of my favorite spices. Our cooking has more complexity than the food of Havana because of these influences.

We have the most interesting cuisine in the world—and I am not kidding. I have traveled throughout South America, cooking with chefs as well as elderly women, not to mention studying the history of our cuisine from pre-Columbian cooking through the influence of Spanish medieval cooking.

What is fascinating is that there is a lot of structure to our cooking and clearly defined rules to our seasoning.

I have learned how all these flavors work in their nationalities and regions, making Latin America my “backyard” of flavor. I am like a painter, and every painter has his or her own palette. I use this analogy because my father was a

painter, and there are colors that he would never use that would not be on his palette.

When I want to be creative, I am comfortable reaching across topographical boundaries. However, I do so with an understanding of all the basic elements of flavor in South American cuisine because I have studied them, eaten them, and lived them!

Vikram Vij of Vij's and Rangoli in Vancouver

The three secrets to my cooking? Number one, my wife, Meeru. Number two, treating the spices with integrity. And number three, using local produce as much as possible.

My own mother is from the northern part of India, so my style and flavors are a combination of different whole and ground spices. I love fenugreek and cinnamon and other aromatics. But one of my [signature dishes] is actually called Mother-in-Law's Pork Curry, because it is based on a recipe my mother-in-law gave me for stewed meat.

I wanted to make something new and was talking to Meeru, who told me her mother used to make a curry with lamb, cream, masala, and some other spices and that they loved it. I decided to try it with pork instead of lamb. It was vindaloo style with vinegar, and green onions added right at the end so that they stayed really fresh. There were too many spices in it to list on the menu so it just made sense to name the dish after her instead.

When I opened my first restaurant, I didn't have a liquor license and did not want to serve [soda] pop or anything with artificial ingredients or preservatives. I remembered growing up in India and having lemon water with a hint of salt and pepper as a homemade lemonade. [At Vij's,] we made some lemonade and added a little ginger, a pinch of salt, and sparkling water to give the refreshing effervescence of [soda] pop. We started out serving it with pepper as well, but customers couldn't get used to seeing black pepper in a drink.

It is wonderful at the beginning of the meal to refresh your palate.

Meeru Dhalwala Vij of Vij's and Rangoli in Vancouver

While working in India for eleven months, I visited Gujarat. Having been raised in the United States, to me "Indian food" was what my mom cooked. I had no idea there were other kinds!

If you watch a Bollywood movie, you see that the Punjabis and the Gujaratis make a lot of fun of each other. The Gujaratis find us Punjabis very volatile and show-offy. They will say, “Just like your cuisine, you are all fiery and hot!” We Punjabis, on the other hand, think the Gujaratis are quiet and dull. Of course, for me, that has all changed—I love all Indians.

In Gujarat, at the end of cooking a curry, they would add a teaspoon of sugar and a half a lime. The first time I tasted this, it was awful—but then I found out that the cook of the house was a crappy cook! When I had it done correctly, it was delicious, and had a nice, mellow aftertaste. So, I incorporated lime into my cooking after eating Gujarati food in India.

My kitchen is staffed by Punjabi women, who had a hard time using lime because it was not part of their cooking in Punjab. When they tasted it, they thought, “Yuck! What’s the point?” Since my Punjabi cooks don’t like lime, this led me to start using kaffir lime. I had more control over the recipes’ flavor because I could just say, “Add 15 leaves to the recipe.” And I learned that turmeric and lime leaf are wonderful together, by the way.

The Mental Realm

My menu may read as unusual, but everything is really just a slight flip on a traditional flavor profile. If I pull out one acid, I replace it with another. If I make a tagine traditionally, it will have preserved lemon. Then I'll ask, "Would it work with lime or orange juice?" It is still the same flavor profile in that it will still have a cutting acid—just maybe not the one that would be used traditionally.

—BRAD FARMERIE, PUBLIC (NEW YORK CITY)

In modern architecture and design, form is said to follow function. In the cuttingedge world of avant-garde cuisine, which turns classic dishes inside out for the sake of argument or even simple amusement, form follows flavor.

Homaro Cantu of Moto in Chicago

Moto is not meant to be an everyday experience. Neither is Charlie Trotter's [also in Chicago] or Daniel [in New York City]. Someone could say that these chefs are just cooking for themselves, and that is true to a certain extent. I am doing this style of [avant-garde] cooking because I am bored with other dishes. If I was all about the customer and just wanted to make people happy, I would cook paella, pizza, and burgers all day. Everyone would have smiles on their faces!

There is a little bit of selfishness, but there is also playfulness. We have to make sure guests are happy, and that our dishes are both inventive and seasonal. What is happening [in the world] right now is that we are expanding our repertoire of what good food is.



At Moto, when we start out with a concept, flavor is the most important thing but also the last thing we think about. Something might taste great, but who cares? What are we going to do with it? As it pertains to us, we look at a concept. Then it evolves into something where we tweak the flavor a little bit to make it taste more like it “should.” For example, once we wanted to make a cookie with a really concentrated flavor. So, we threw cookies into the dehydrator, and turned them into powder. This created a new building block for flavor. [Instead of the flour you would normally use in your dough,] you weigh the powdered cookies out as your starch in your normal cookie recipe. But this starch is now a carrier of flavor for the end product—so the resulting cookie now tastes more like it “should” than it would have just using regular flour.

A lot of our food is rooted in classic combinations—and it has to be. Why? The process by which we go about creating is so foreign that we have to make something that you are familiar with eating. In a tapas restaurant, you have had generations of trial and error to create a dish through local ingredients and techniques that have evolved into something that tastes good. For example, olives marinated with garlic and parsley has been around for a hundred years. Now, there is nothing wrong with that. But, for us, the idea of marinating olives with garlic and parsley is not fun. So, we are going to make a dish where the olives are actually the parsley and the garlic is the olives and so on. But it tastes

like something you'd want.

What's in a Pancake? Yes, we do serve real food. We got some BLiS syrup [handcrafted aged maple syrup] in the kitchen which is used by other top chefs around the country. This stuff is liquid gold! This syrup is aged in small bourbon barrels in Canada and is \$20 for a small [375 ml] bottle. The maker even handstamps each bottle with wax and writes the label by hand. When we got it in, we knew we had to do something with it.

We decided to make a pancake dish. We started with the question "How can we make this dish taste more like pancakes than pancakes?" So, we pureed cooked pancakes, then adjusted the liquid with milk. The cool thing about making a pancake puree out of cooked pancakes is that you can alter the concentration levels. You can't alter the concentration levels when you are making straight pancakes.

We wanted to trick the customer into thinking that they were going to eat a hot pancake topped with this syrup. Believability is so important in the process, so we even execute the dish in front of them [in the dining room]. We bring out a metal plate that looks hot [but is frozen and steaming from being immersed in nitrogen]. The pancake batter is then shot from a syringe. The batter freezes when it hits the metal. When we serve it, we top it with the BLiS syrup. Ninety-nine percent of the people who were served this dish swore they were getting a hot flapjack, and it was only when they tasted it that they learned it was cold.

Contrarian by Nature People want to say that wine is natural and has been around a thousand years. But is it natural or unnatural? We don't know. You have people in a foreign country stepping all over these grapes, putting foot fungus in there, and then creating a fermented thing that is controlled. I don't think that wine is all that natural! Every time you turn on the blender and puree something, you are crossing the line of natural versus unnatural. Nature did not intend for an electric motor to spin a blade and turn a solid into a liquid.

If you think an unripe green tomato tastes better than a ripe heirloom red tomato picked off the vine in August, then by all means eat the green tomato. That is flavor preference. What if I feed you an unripe green tomato but alter its taste so it tastes *better* than a vine-ripened red tomato? When we pick it off the vine earlier, it has a different quality—it is sharper. So, we will pair something that maybe should not go with it, like Parmesan cheese pureed with butter. This

will make it a little richer and compensate for the overtannic, overacidic qualities of the tomato. [If you enjoy it,] then you have succumbed to not following the seasons.

In the same manner, we'll serve a dish of unripe things that taste ripe because they are together! What do I prefer? Of course I prefer the vine-ripened tomato at the end of August. We would make the other dish just to ask the question.

Creating New Flavors I disagree with the notion that there are no new flavors. Maybe there are no new products, even though we don't know everything that exists in the sea. To create a new flavor, all you have to do is dissect an ingredient. For example, if I take an avocado and put it into a centrifuge, we would separate the fat and the water. The water will carry the avocado taste. If I take that water and create a snow with it or make it into a pill, it will have a much different taste than avocado, because avocado is thought of as something that is rich. But there would be no richness here; it is a completely different product. We just made up a new flavor.

How to Lengthen Flavors

Think of something in its pure form like passion fruit puree: It is strong, vibrant, and when it touches your tongue, you taste it [all at once]. I learned from Heston Blumenthal [chef of The Fat Duck, the Michelin three-star restaurant in England] that if you take that same passion fruit and make it into a gelée and cube it, then you will get the flavor little by little as the cube melts on your palate. The flavor release takes longer and lasts longer in your mouth.

—**JOHNNY IUZZINI**, PASTRY CHEF, JEAN GEORGES (NEW YORK CITY)

Sometimes we try to lengthen flavors, like you have with some wines [e.g., wines that are said to have “a long finish” that you taste long after swallowing]. I will think, “How long do I want a flavor to last? Do I want a blast, or do I want it to linger?”

We make a dish of a fried oyster with shiso and a wasabi, yuzu, and sancho pepper [also known as Szechuan pepper] sauce. That is a great way to experience length of flavor. The shiso wraps around the oyster like a taco shell. When you take a bite, you get the herbaceous punch from the shiso, then richness from the fried oyster that coats your tongue. Then you get the acid from the yuzu on the sides of your tongue. When you swallow the bite, the wasabi comes up the back of your nose. Then you get a small surprise because the pepper gives you a numbing effect across your palate. This is not a “two seconds of heaven” bite; we are talking about a twenty-second experience. We have orchestrated this not in a crazy chemical way, but just by playing with an oyster.

The cues come from the wine world: Sometimes you want bright and spritzy high-acid flavor, and other times you want something rich and long.

—**BRAD FARMERIE**, PUBLIC (NEW YORK CITY)

So now if I want to mimic an avocado, I would have to serve something rich with it. I could serve something dairy with it, like brown butter. I now have something that would go with a classical turbot dish with brown butter and capers, whereas fresh avocado would not have paired up with that dish very well.

Katsuya Fukushima of minibar in Washington, DC

I like to work with classic, preexisting flavor combinations that people can recognize. They may not recognize anything from the textures I use, but they will find recognition in the flavors.

To make our “Philly Cheesesteak,” we start with the bread. We put pita dough through a pasta machine so that it gets really thin, but puffs way up when you cook it. For the cheese element, we use a Vermont and Wisconsin cheddar cheese mousse that we pipe into the pita. For the beef, we serve seared Kobe beef. For the onions, we spread on caramelized onion puree. We then top that with truffles. So you have bread, cheese, beef, and onion, just like a Philly cheesesteak. We add the truffles just to push it over the top.

CHEFS' STRATEGIES FOR BALANCING FLAVORS

On every forkful—regardless of what's on the fork—there has to be salt, acid, and heat... However, unless you are serving a peppercrusted dish, or a lemon or vinegar dish, your seasoning should never be detected. Instead, your beans should taste like beans, and your rabbit should taste like rabbit. Diners don't need to know how much salt, acid, and heat are in the dish—and none should be obvious. You'll also have minor supporting players in a dish, such as the aromatic or picante levels that might come from your mirepoix or sofrito [a well-cooked sauce of tomatoes, garlic, onions, and herbs] or whatever else went in there. But when a diner tastes your dishes, all you want them to be thinking about is those beans, or that rabbit.

—SHARON HAGE, YORK STREET (DALLAS)

Over the past fifteen years, we have interviewed many chefs in an effort to understand how some of America's best chefs approach creating great food. What we learned is that there are as many approaches as chefs themselves. While some strategies overlap, others are unique and display strong self-knowledge as to what makes their individual cuisines so original and compelling.

Traci Des Jardins of Jardinière in San Francisco

The most important aspect of any dish is balance—between acid, fat, salt, and sweetness. It is the key to making food taste good.

The same is true in pastry. I am constantly working with my pastry chef when I taste desserts with her. I will taste something and say it is too sweet—that it is missing the acid balance, and needs some fat and a little salt. Using salt in pastry brings out the flavor, just as it does in savory food. When it comes to dessert, people think more in a “monochromatic” sweet fashion. But sweets need balance, too.

My favorite flavor is the harmony of these elements working together, whether it is sweet or savory.

Marcel Desaulniers of The Trellis in Williamsburg, Virginia

My cooking philosophy has always been simple: Don’t complicate things, and let the food speak for itself. I want the food to leave a clean taste in your mouth, and that goes for savory food as well as desserts.

We don’t use a lot of spices because they can have an intensity of flavor that can overwhelm other flavors. People can’t restrain themselves with certain ingredients—and, often, it’s garlic. At The Trellis, we use garlic in only one recipe: a dressing that has been on the menu for twenty-six years. Herbs can be overused as well, too. Rosemary and basil, which I love, are constantly overused, which results in a bitter flavor.

I tell cooks, “When in doubt, don’t use it.” The food you are starting with already has its own intrinsic flavor, whether it is a scallop or a filet of beef. Whatever you do to embellish the flavor should be a very minor part of the relationship, rather than sharing the stage fifty-fifty.

I thought of myself as a saucier from my days in New York, yet when I opened this restaurant in Williamsburg, it was not the way I wanted to present the food. Rather than sauces, I wanted to use vegetables and fruits as the accompaniments. They provide moisture as a natural component and they work on the plate, but not as a fifty-fifty partner.

An example of where fruit works great as a component is on our pork dish: We serve pork loin medallions, grilled sausage, sweet potatoes, tender cooked string beans, and bourbon-glazed peaches. So this is a dish with no sauce, except

the juice from the peaches.

Carrie Nahabedian of Naha in Chicago

You should always season something right from the start, and not just at the end. If you just add salt and pepper at the end, you are not doing a soup justice. You want those flavors to blossom.

Take our butternut squash soup as an example. We start our soup with hefty pieces of slab bacon, so we are already starting off with a lot of flavor. From there, we add the mirepoix and make sure it gets nice and caramelized. Then we start adding our salt, fresh-cracked pepper, and thyme sprig.

Next, we add roasted squash. The reason we roast it before it goes in the soup is because you can taste what state the squash is in. It may need a little help because it needed to age a couple more weeks in the cellar before we got it, so we may add a garnet yam. Now, we taste the soup and decide what kind of sweetness to add. That could be honey, molasses, or maple sugar—not just [white] sugar.

Next, we puree the soup and pass it [through a fine-mesh strainer] to achieve its smooth texture.

To the soup base, we add the garnishes. We already have bacon, but some smoked duck will be good, too. We add spaghetti squash and fried parsnips for additional texture and, in the case of the parsnips, sweetness as well. For a last note, we add a drizzle of maple syrup or barrel-aged sherry. These things just seal the soup so that the flavors all escalate. It is important to not rush things so that your flavors come together.



Andrew Carmellini of A Voce in New York City

Any kind of sauce boils down to acid, salt, sweetness, and two kinds of spice: savory spice, meaning cumin- or coriander-type spices, and heat spice, meaning chiles or pepper flakes. You can be making a vinaigrette or a Thai curry or a bouillabaisse, but its seasoning involves the same principles on the palate. As long as you can manipulate those things, you can get your palate excited.

If something is heavy or fatty on the tongue, add some vinegar or lemon or another type of acid. If you were making a Thai-style coconut curry that is too fatty and rich from the coconut milk, you would add some grated lime zest, lime juice, and a splash of fish sauce to cut the richness.

When you are adjusting the seasoning of a dish, you need to think about its origin. That is why traveling is so important. For example, you wouldn't use rice wine vinegar in a French bouillabaisse, but you might use a little bit of chili

flakes. You must understand the historical context of a dish, which is why you wouldn't thicken an Indian curry with strawberries.

Sharon Hage of York Street in Dallas

When I am building a dish, I use a tray we call “the four seasons,” which is *fleur de sel* [salt]; red pepper flakes, the ultimate marriage of heat and fruit; dry mustard, which I use all the time; and sumac, which is an acidic component.

When I make a dish, it starts with the dry ingredients first, and the salt is the first dry ingredient. Then I add the heat layer, such as a jalapeño or horseradish. Then I add acid: lemon juice, vinegar, *verjus*, or all three. Then, at the last second, I add the fat component—the oil or butter—to the sauce, which brings it all together.

Brad Farmerie of Public in New York City

When I come up with a new dish, I am looking at two things: The first is building up the richness, and the second is cutting that richness with acidity, spice, or herbaceousness.

I start by thinking, What is the rich component? How can I build richness? If it is a protein, we may cure the meat or fry the fish. If it is a vegetarian dish, I may start with eggplant, which is meaty, so I will build it up with miso or tahini, which will make it even richer and meatier. This is really important in a vegetarian dish, because I hate those flimsy veg plates of grilled vegetables and a lot of salad!

Texture is another way of building richness. If you add miso or tahini, that adds richness and texture. An emulsification also gives a sense of richness in your mind and across your palate. One way to add rich texture in a “fakey-jakey” way is to add palm sugar. It is [a less] sweet sugar, and we will shave it into a dish halfway through the cooking and temper it with tamarind. We use it so subtly that you don't even know it is there.

Now that I have my richness, the question becomes, “How can we cut that richness so it is light on the palate and in the belly?” We use a tremendous amount of acid, but it is always in check with what is on the plate. Choosing the right acid or herb will leave a light feeling on the palate and cut a rich dish.

With any fried food, you need a big zap of acidity to get through it. With fried fish, we will use preserved lemon, yogurt, or yuzu with a white soy dipping

sauce.

Cured meat is almost the epitome of richness. Cured meats have a salinity to them, and quite often there is sugar to balance the salt as well. You need some punchy flavors to cut the meat, or it will just be heavy on the palate.

Traditionally, you would use capers or caper berries. Mustard fruits [known in Italy as *mostarda*, these are fruits preserved in mustard-flavored sweet syrup] are another traditional approach. I like them because you have the added element of spice. We make our own mustard fruits and bastardize them a little by using kumquats, baby apricots, and gooseberries, which are not traditional in Italy. These fruits simply have beautiful flavor and color. The other thing we do is use whole mustard seeds. Mustard fruits are typically [made through] a refined process in that they become like a clear jam. We leave ours a little rougher and fold in a little dry mustard in the end to make the colors of the citrus fruits really pop.

Another way we cut richness is by using sweet-and-sour poached vegetables and fruit. We'll poach fennel or pearl onions in a sweet-sour liquid with licorice and star anise. The family of apples, pears, and quince also holds up very well, as do sour poached plums.

I like aromatic spices [for their ability to cut richness]. If I'm working on a dish inspired by India, my inspirations are the flavors of clove, cardamom, and coriander seed. They are aromatic spices that really cut the fat of a dish, so the dish is not big, fat, and flabby on the palate. Fresh turmeric gives you fruitiness and upfront flavor with a touch of acid that perks up a dish. If you add fresh turmeric to your curry, you will make a world of difference by adding this one small thing.

If I'm working on a dish inspired by Southeast Asia, I like galangal, lemongrass, and ginger. They all have natural acidity and zingy spice that will perk up anything. Even if you are not adding acid to coconut milk but just adding aromatics, it won't taste heavy.

Emily Luchetti, pastry chef at Farallon in San Francisco

I want my flavors to be clean, crisp, accentuated, and distinguished. From there, I look at what I feel like making. If I have peaches, do I want to make a trifle or a napoleon or something else? What is the star of the plate? Is it one thing and everything else is going to be showing it off? Or are there two main flavors that are both going to have equal billing? I make a peach-blueberry trifle that has a

mascarpone cream and is pretty intense. It is one of my favorite summer things to make. The peaches and blueberries are both the stars. If you make a pumpkin-cranberry upside-down cake, the pumpkin is the star and the cranberry is an accent.



You have to look at the ingredient and ask, “How am I going to bring out the best of its flavors? Do I cook it, or leave it alone? Does this piece of fruit need to be intensified because it wants to be the star, or is it not good enough on its own?” When you are working with fresh or dried fruit, the most important thing is the balance of sugar, salt, and lemon. If I am mixing fresh fruit for a shortcake or crisp, I always add some lemon juice and salt, because—just like in savory cooking—it helps bring out the flavor. We are talking a half teaspoon to a teaspoon of lemon and a large pinch of kosher salt.

Whenever you are cooking fruit with sugar to serve with something, taste the fruit first. If it is the peak of summer, that fruit may not need sugar. If you added some anyway, it would dull the flavors and make it taste too sweet. So, taste your fruit—and trust your palate! People trust their palates for savory food all the time. They’ll taste a tomato sauce and know it needs some salt. You need to trust your palate for sugar as well. You know when something is too sugary or salty.

When you are working with fresh fruit, the fruit has to be the guide. If you eat a piece of fresh fruit by itself, it is a dessert. So you want the dessert, in the end, to taste better than the fruit itself. To do that, you need to add things that go naturally. Blueberries and peaches go well together. Vanilla goes with practically any fruit. Almonds go with most fruits because they are light nuts that have a lot of flavor but not a lot of fat. Just starting with things that naturally go together, you will have a greater rate of success.

People will read that I think three flavors work in a dessert—then they’ll say, “Well, you used *four*....” That is not the point—the point is knowing when to stop! Too many chefs start adding things that in the end all taste muddled, because nothing can stand out on its own. When you are more restrictive, each thing tastes good on its own—and the dessert becomes more than the sum of its parts. It is hard to know when to stop. Many chefs seem to think, “Oh, I’ll just add this dot of mango....” Well, the taste of that one acidic dot can set the whole dessert off.



Flavor is a “language” that anyone who loves the pleasures of the palate will find to be well worth mastering. Once you master the language of flavor, you can use it to communicate—and become a better cook.



GREAT COOKING = MAXIMIZING FLAVOR + PLEASURE BY
TAPPING BODY + HEART + MIND + SPIRIT:
COMMUNICATING VIA THE LANGUAGE OF FOOD

Happy and successful cooking doesn't rely only on knowhow. It comes from the heart, makes great demands on the palate, and needs enthusiasm and a deep love of food to bring it to life.

—GEORGES BLANC, MICHELIN THREE-STAR CHEF IN
VONNAS, FRANCE

The defining trait of a great cook is more than a great palate, and more than great technique; it is sound judgment. It is not only knowing what to do with ingredients, but also when, where, why, and how to serve them. Cooking involves the thoughtful combination and manipulation of ingredients. Good cooking results in those ingredients tasting even better. Great cooking not only celebrates the ingredients, but also celebrates the moment.

Recipes evolved as a way to teach less experienced cooks how to prepare particular dishes, by providing specific proportions of compatible ingredients along with step-by-step instructions. However, anyone who believes that every recipe followed verbatim will always produce consistent results is kidding themselves, given the diversity within individual ingredients, whether the sweetness of fruit or the thickness of a fish fillet. Slavish followers of recipes, who treat them as gospel instead of guidelines, make the mistake of putting more faith in someone else's instructions than they do in themselves. Many people would do better in the kitchen if they *didn't* blindly follow recipes. In fact, following recipes may be holding *you* back from achieving your potential as a cook.

Take the time to learn and master some of the general principles of how to make food taste great—such as what to pair with various ingredients, and how to prepare them—which is the subject of this book. After all, more than a dozen years after the advent of the Food Network turned every TV set in this country into a virtual 24/7 cooking school, supplementing the burgeoning food

programming on many of the other major channels, Americans are better-trained cooks than at

any previous point in history. Most of us can now whip up a dish with our general knowledge of how to boil pasta, sauté an onion, or grill a steak. Today, long, detailed recipes are rarely needed for most cooking (with the exception of baking, whose chemistry requires precise measurements).

Training wheels can be useful when first learning to ride a bike, as can “painting by numbers” when first learning to paint. Likewise, following a recipe can be useful when first learning to cook—for understanding the order of completing certain steps, and internalizing their intrinsic logic. But great cooking should be more akin to meditation: you—and all of your senses—are in the moment, and fully awake and aware. You can taste the ingredients, and know what you need to do to make them taste their best. You know, as chef Judy Rodgers famously told us for our book *Becoming a Chef*, to “look out the window and see what the weather is and decide what the soup wants to be.” Be fully grounded in the moment that is part of that second, that minute, that hour, that day, that month, that season, that year of your life—all at once.

To elevate your cooking to a whole new level, develop a better appreciation for the essence of ingredients, which provides insight into when and how to best use them. Celebrating the essence of ingredients allows you to work with them more intuitively and effectively. This book will help you decide what ingredients to reach for in the kitchen, and why, and what to do with them when you do.

HOW TO MAKE FOOD TASTE GREAT

A great cook is able to make food taste great by doing two basic things:

1. Understanding the essence of the **moment**, which comprises everything from the meal's driving force to the occasion, to the weather, to the available time, budget, and/or other resources (for example, ingredients, equipment, etc.).
2. Understanding the essence of the **ingredients**, which comprises their season, regionality, weight and volume, function, flavor, and/or flavor affinities.

The deeper your understanding of both, the greater your ability to bring them together into a dish that is the perfect expression of the ingredients and the moment.

Understanding the Essence of the Moment

Why do you need or want to cook in the first place? In a day and age when more of the meals we consume are prepared *outside* the home than *at* home, cooking has become relatively infrequent. So, what's driving *you*?

Always keep in mind your starting point in the kitchen, the reference point serving as the inspiration for your cooking—which can be virtually anything. Following its essence logically or intuitively will lead you to each subsequent step toward creating something delicious. Your starting point is your initial desire. It may be an ingredient, or a dish, or a country: you're excited to prepare the first

heirloom tomatoes of summer; you're craving your grandmother's cheesecake; or you want a dish that will take you to Italy to relive the flavors you enjoyed on your last vacation.

Other factors provide the parameters of how you'll act on that desire. They might be time ("I want to spend the day cooking for pleasure" versus "I have only fifteen minutes to get something on the table"), budget (\$5/person versus "money is no object, so bring on the truffles"), occasion (dinner on a Tuesday night, or someone's birthday), availability of ingredients (your neighbors just gave you fresh vegetables from their garden), season (the arrival of the first asparagus of spring, or the last corn of Indian summer), weather (wanting a chilled lunch to help you cool off on a hot summer day), or something else.

Your starting point, whatever it is, has an essence: Your desire to host a barbecue to celebrate the beautiful summer weather will bring up associations that will in turn bring up other associations, until you have a long list of associations, for example:

- Desire to enjoy the 80-degree sunny summer day (starting point: season, weather)
 - Have a summer barbecue (craving)
 - Invite friends over to enjoy it, too
- Prefer to cool down (function)
 - Serve cold drinks
 - Serve at least some chilled dishes
- Serve corn bought at the market this morning (available resources)

- Serve corn salsa on grilled chicken or fish
- Serve corn on the cob
- Have best friends over for dinner (guests)
 - Everyone eats chicken
 - One of them is from New England and can bring lobster
- Avoid turning the oven on (temperature)
 - Cook outside → fire up the grill
 - Cook on the stovetop only → boil water

So, starting with your driving factor and its essence, you can follow these associations to their logical conclusion and come up with the perfect meal. For one person, it might be serving grilled chicken with a corn salsa in the backyard. For another, it might be hosting a lobster and corn boil in an air-conditioned dining room. It's all about taking everything into consideration at once, and using sound judgment to determine how to proceed.

Occasion

Even if it wasn't the driving force behind why you're cooking in the first place, you'll still want to consider the importance and significance of the meal. A quick dinner on a time-pressed weeknight will be different from a dinner made on the weekend when there is more time to enjoy the sensual process of cooking. Keep the occasion in mind when planning your meal, with the knowledge that any meal can be elevated to a special occasion—or simplified in a crunch. The elements of breakfast take on a different level of importance when they are used for a special brunch. A quick fried egg and a toasted English muffin on a Tuesday can morph into poached eggs with Canadian bacon with hollandaise sauce on an English muffin for a weekend brunch, or vice versa.

But a true special occasion—a birthday, anniversary, or holiday—definitely calls for something equally special to celebrate it. If lack of time is a factor, a birthday isn't the time to undertake making and decorating a cake from scratch. However, it might inspire you to pick up a half gallon of the birthday boy or girl's favorite ice cream, toast some pecans, and whip up some homemade chocolate sauce—which would take only minutes, as opposed to hours.



Weather

While seasonality will drive your choice of ingredients, the weather will drive your decision as to how to prepare and serve them. On the coldest days, you'll want to warm your home as well as your body with slow-braised dishes, soups, and stews, and on warmer days, you'll want to keep your home (and yourself) cooler by doing more grilling or on the hottest days serving quick-cooked or even chilled dishes—no matter what season those days may fall in.

Some cooks believe you can serve anything at any time of the year. Our eyebrows have raised upon seeing heavy braised dishes on restaurant menus in August. However, chefs have defended them by arguing that once someone is seated in an air-conditioned dining room, they forget what it's like outside! Those chefs may be giving customers what they want while they are at the table... but what happens when those same customers leave the restaurant after finishing their braised short ribs and walk out into the heat and humidity? They might feel as out of sorts as they would wearing long wool overcoats on such a night! A lighter meal on a hot night won't sap your energy in the same way.

Even in the middle of summer, there will be unseasonably cool days that might suggest a warm dish that would offend the sensibilities on the season's hottest, most sweltering day. Even during the dead of winter, the sun can break through and create an unseasonably warm day on which hot, slow-cooked braised dishes would not be appealing.

Considering the weather means taking into consideration the natural rhythms of nature. One of the easiest clues available to inform your cooking is to look out the window, and ask yourself what you feel like eating. If you look out the window on a sunny summer morning, are you more tempted by hot oatmeal—or by granola and yogurt? That afternoon, as the temperature rises, does your mouth water thinking of hot tomato soup—or chilled gazpacho? That night, does the temperature fall enough to make you want to turn on the oven to roast a chicken—or would you rather grill it on your stovetop?

On our first visit to a certain New York City restaurant on one of the hottest nights of summer, we were surprised to be sent an *amuse-bouche* from the kitchen that was a tall glass of hot yellow pepper soup. While the soup itself might have been made from seasonal ingredients and tasty in a vacuum, unfortunately what we remember even more vividly was how unappealing we found it, especially as our first taste after a sweltering taxi ride to the restaurant. If the same soup had been served to us cold, we expect it would have been more successful as the welcoming gesture it was intended to be.

Understanding the Essence of the Ingredients

Once you're clear about "the problem" of what to cook, the right ingredients, well prepared, provide the ideal "solution." To prepare any ingredients well, it's vital to understand and respect their essence.

What do we mean when we talk about an ingredient's "essence"? Every ingredient has associations with it, and the sum total of those associations comprises its essence. An ingredient's essence is more than its flavor. Take two sample ingredients, both salty:



- What comes to mind when you think of soy sauce? Common associations besides its saltiness might include Asia (region), rice (as a common flavoring for), and/or scallions (compatible ingredient).
- What comes to mind when you think of Parmesan cheese? Aside from saltiness (flavor), its common associations might include Italy (region), pasta or pizza (which it is a common flavoring for), and/or basil and tomatoes (compatible ingredients).

While certain other ingredients—such as chicken, garlic, and onions, which are all used around the world—may be neutral in their universality, many ingredients are rooted in distinct associations.

Some of the primary aspects of any ingredient's essence include its **seasonality**, its **taste**, its **volume**, its **function**, its **regionality**, its **weight**, and its **flavor affinities**. While the importance of each factor varies, depending on the dish, the goal when cooking is to ensure that all of these factors are respected in the ingredient's use.

Seasonality

It is almost a cliché to talk about seasonality if you are a New American chef. You are cooking that way naturally. I had a customer complain that his favorite pea ravioli was not on the menu. I explained that peas were not very good at the time, so that we were featuring corn ravioli. I don't focus on making an ingredient that is not at its peak taste better; I simply take it off the menu. Chefs still pay more attention to seasonality than customers do. We still have diners who want berries in the middle of February!

—ANDREW CARMELLINI, A VOCE (NEW YORK CITY)

Cooking with ingredients at their seasonal peak is such a central tenet of good cooking that it bears constant repeating. In stores across the country, you can find almost any ingredient at almost any time of year. However, an ingredient's mere availability offers no assurances of its quality.

Each season suggests a different palette of ingredients, and different ways of preparing and serving them. Classic holiday dishes represent time-tested ways of

celebrating the season: Picture a grilled hamburger followed by a red, white, and blue strawberry shortcake accented with blueberries and whipped cream served on the Fourth of July, or roasted turkey with stuffing, cranberry sauce, and pumpkin pie on Thanksgiving. (If you're not convinced of the perfection of each dish's expression of the season and occasion, just imagine eating each menu on the *other* holiday!) Each season also suggests its own beverages; for example, summer calls more often for lighter-bodied white and rosé wines, just as winter calls for fuller-bodied reds.

Taste

Every ingredient has its *stereotypical* taste (bananas are sweet), plus its *actual* taste, which may be a function of its age or ripeness. For example, a banana may increase noticeably in sweetness as it ripens and its color changes from green to yellow to brown. That is why it's crucial to taste your ingredients when cooking. If you don't—and, as a result, don't end up making other adjustments (for example, slightly decreasing the amount of sugar used when using very ripe bananas)—you'll find your dishes to be out of balance. Even seemingly similar ingredients (such as regular versus aged balsamic vinegar, or Italian versus Thai basil) can vary dramatically.

Weight

It was through our study of wine that we developed an appreciation for the critical role of understanding a wine's body, or weight—and, in turn, the relative weights of various foods. In fact, weight has eclipsed color as the key factor in pairing wine with food.

Weight and season often go hand in hand, as we crave lightness in summer and heavier dishes when temperatures fall. In summer, that craving for lightness could be satisfied with a salad of fresh greens topped with shrimp or chicken and tossed in a vinaigrette. Our winter cravings for more substance and warmth might lead us to a hearty stew made with red meat and root vegetables in their own thick sauce.

There is a spectrum of wine and ingredients that suggests itself for warmer versus cooler seasons or days, as well as for lighter versus heavier appetites:



<i>White Wines</i>	Riesling	Sauvignon Blanc	Chardonnay
<i>Red Wines</i>	Pinot Noir	Merlot	Cabernet Sauvignon
<i>Vegetables</i>	Bibb lettuce	Carrots	Celery root
<i>Grains</i>	Couscous	Rice	Bulgur wheat
<i>Fruits</i>	Watermelon	Apples	Bananas
<i>Seafood</i>	Shrimp, sole	Salmon, tuna	
<i>White Meat</i>		Chicken, pork, veal	
<i>Red Meat</i>			Beef, lamb, venison
<i>Sauces</i>	Citrus/lemon Vinaigrette	Butter/cream Olive oil	Demi-glacé Meat stock

York Street's Sharon Hage on Classic Flavor Pairings

I try to eat a lot of different foods and read a lot of different types of books to try to break away from classic pairings. I have had a million pork dishes, and I keep thinking that there has to be something else besides pork with sage! I try all these different things then turn to another cook and say, "Got any sage?"

There is a reason for tomatoes with basil, and for lamb with mint. What I don't make is lamb with mint jelly—but there will likely be some mint someplace on the dish.

Roasted beets work with salty cheese, whether it is [Italian] ricotta salata, or [Mexican] queso fresco, or another country's version of salty cheese.

The fun part is to discover what the classic pairing is, then present it to people in a way that makes them think it is different, while still being true to you as a chef. It would be hard to imagine summer tomatoes without the basil component. We might add some chives or mint or sumac, but the dish will still have some basil as well.

Volume

One important aspect of an ingredient's flavor essence is its "volume." Think of a stereo dial with "1" indicating a "quiet" seasoning of chopped parsley, and "10" suggesting a "loud" mound of freshly chopped habanero chile peppers. You'll use them very differently to create very different effects, while striving to achieve the same all-important balance in the final dish.

So, is the ingredient you're working with quiet, moderate, or loud? You need to be aware of an ingredient's volume whenever combining it with other ingredients. If a dish is overspiced to the point where you can't taste its essence, it's wrong. Consider:



Proteins

Light and/or quiet: fish, shellfish, tofu

Medium and/or moderate: white meat (chicken, pork, veal)

Heavy and/or loud: red meat (beef, lamb, venison)

Cooking Techniques

Light and/or quiet: poaching, steaming

Medium and/or moderate: frying, sautéing

Heavy and/or loud: braising, stewing

Herbs

Light and/or quiet: chervil, parsley

Medium and/or moderate: dill, lemon thyme

Heavy and/or loud: rosemary, tarragon

Function

Different tastes serve different functions. Saltiness stimulates thirst (think of all those free salty peanuts in bars!), while sourness quenches it (think lemonade). Saltiness heightens the appetite, making this flavor especially effective in appetizers. Bitterness also stimulates the appetite, and can promote the other tastes with which it is paired while adding a note of lightness to a dish. Sourness is refreshing, and adds a fresh note to any dish to which it is added. Sweetness is famously satiating, making it ideal (not to mention customary) to end a meal with a sweet dessert, or at least a sweet note (such as a cheese course with honey or sweet figs).

Certain foods, such as the spices cinnamon and nutmeg, are thought of as “warming” foods, so their addition to dishes is thought to add a warming quality that might be especially welcomed on a cold day. There are also “cooling” foods (such as cucumber and mint) that can be used just as judiciously.

Keeping an ingredient’s function in mind will help you use it most wisely, and avoid unfortunate mismatches of flavor and function. We still remember an otherwise delicious beet salad we were once served as an appetizer in New Orleans that was so sweet it killed our appetite for the rest of our meal.

Region

Determining the region that will serve as the reference point for whatever you’re cooking is one of the easiest ways to create successful flavor marriages in the kitchen. Thinking regionally is as important to good pairing as thinking seasonally is to good cooking. Many people are familiar with the maxim “If it grows together, it goes together,” and this is still the best place to start as a guide. Knowing what country you want to draw on will narrow your list of ingredient choices, often for the better! For example, as chicken is the world traveler of ingredients, if you’re making a chicken dish, you’ll especially need to decide on a region of inspiration. Are you going to root your dish in Mexico by topping it with salsa, or take it to France by finishing it with a mustard cream sauce? The

accompaniments you choose will reinforce the dish's sense of place. Would rice and beans, or boiled new potatoes, be most appealing served alongside it?

Flavor Affinities

A perfect ingredient served plainly can be an extraordinary thing, whether a perfectly ripe and sweet piece of fruit, or a silky slice of raw fish as sashimi. But in the real world, perfect ingredients are all too rare—and there are few ingredients whose flavors can't be helped along by a pinch of this or a splash of that. A sprinkle of sugar will bring out the flavor of strawberries. A squeeze of lime will bring out a melon's sweetness. A drizzle of vinegar will provide a tasty counterpoint for salty French fries.

Understanding what herbs, spices, and other seasonings will best bring out the flavor of whatever it is you're cooking is some of the most important knowledge any cook can master. The pages that follow emphasize modern-day flavor affinities that have been proved in some of the best-respected kitchens in this country in this millennium.

Studying the language and syntax of ingredients in these pages will allow you access to the collective wisdom—and impeccably sound judgment—of some of America's most imaginative chefs.





Chapter
3



FLAVOR MATCHMAKING: THE CHARTS

Good cooking does not depend on whether the dish is large or small, expensive or economical. If one has the art, then a piece of celery or salted cabbage can be made into a marvelous delicacy; whereas if one has not the art, all the greatest delicacies and rarities of land, sea or sky are of no avail.

—YUAN MEI, EIGHTEENTH-CENTURY CHINESE POET

When you're creating in the kitchen, the starting point for a dish or a menu can be literally anything. It can begin with the seasonal availability of a particular ingredient—vegetable, fruit, meat, or seafood—or even a cooking style, such as grilling in the summer or braising in the winter. It can begin with a craving for the flavors of a particular country or region: the garlic and herbs of Provence, or the garlic and ginger of Asia. Or it can begin with simple curiosity, the urge to experiment with a new ingredient or technique.

Recognizing this, we've provided a similarly broad range of starting points in the A-to-Z (achiote seeds to zucchini blossoms) lists that follow: the seasons (with listings for autumn, spring, summer, and winter); an extensive variety of vegetables, fruits, meat, seafood, and other ingredients; dozens of world cuisines; and a broad array of flavorings and seasonings (from avocado oil to fennel pollen to Kaffir lime), including dozens of different salts, peppers, herbs, spices, oils, and vinegars.

Below each, we've distilled and summarized key aspects of an ingredient's essence: its season, taste, weight, volume, and primary function. You'll also find its most recommended cooking techniques and some useful tips to keep in mind when working with it. After all, some ingredients lend themselves to being prepared in a particular manner: While chicken is versatile enough to be cooked in a number of ways, delicate fish beg to be served lightly cooked or even raw, while tougher cuts of meat beg to be braised or stewed.

When perusing the listings of compatible flavors, readers of our book *What to Drink with What You Eat* will recognize our ranking system to let you know

which pairings are truly stellar. Those ingredients that appear in **BOLD CAPS** with an asterisk (*) are ethereal, time-honored classics: these “marriages made in heaven” comprise the top 1 or 2 percent of pairings. Next we have very highly recommended pairings in **BOLD CAPS. Bold**, noncapitalized listings are frequently recommended pairings; and plain text pairings are recommended pairings. But remember: Even when just a single top expert recommends a flavor combination, it’s very high praise indeed.

In some cases, we’ve also noted flavor pairings to **AVOID** or steer clear of, to prevent overpowering or clashing with your star ingredient.

For many listings, we’ve also indicated “flavor trios” and other “flavor cliques” to get you started on compound flavor combinations. In other cases, you’ll find some of America’s most creative chefs’ signature dishes, so you can gain inspiration from some of the most celebrated restaurant kitchens across the country.

Throughout these pages, you’ll also find several insightful sidebars on cooking with herbs, mushrooms, pastas, steaks, and more. They’ll serve to help you learn not only the “whats” of combining flavors, but also the “whys” and “hows.”

Keep an eye out for the distinctions being made among ingredients. After all, not even all salts are created equal. As you hone your selections, you’ll hone the quality of the flavors you’re able to create.

Since the turn of the new millennium, we have traveled throughout the United States and Canada, spending thousands of hours interviewing dozens of the most creative chefs and other experts on their most recommended flavor pairings. We’ve scoured these experts’ memories—along with their post-1999 restaurant menus, Web sites, cookbooks, and other highly recommended books—for pairing insights. Then we synthesized their advice into the comprehensive, easy-to-use listings that follow. These listings represent a treasure trove of pairing ideas for you to put to work in your own kitchen.

Armed with the extensive information that follows, you’ll learn how to better show off virtually any ingredient, or to recreate the flavors of any world cuisine, you can think of. From here on out, you’ll have the expert advice of some of America’s most imaginative culinarians at your disposal when you want to inspire your own creativity. Whether you’re exploring a new-to-you ingredient or looking for additional ideas for working with an ingredient you’ve cooked a thousand times, you’ll find insightful tips and a plethora of pairings here.

MATCHING FLAVORS

KEY: Flavors mentioned in regular type are pairings suggested by one or more experts.

Those in **bold** were recommended by a number of experts.

Those in **BOLD CAPS** were very highly recommended by an even greater number of experts.

Those in ***BOLD CAPS** with an asterisk (*) are “Holy Grail” pairings that are the most highly recommended by the greatest number of experts.

SEASON: The ingredient’s seasonal peak(s)

TASTE: The ingredient’s primary taste(s), e.g., bitter, salty, sour, sweet

FUNCTION: The ingredient’s intrinsic property, e.g., cooling vs. warming

WEIGHT: The ingredient’s relative density, e.g., from light to heavy

VOLUME: The ingredient’s relative flavor “loudness,” e.g., from quiet to loud

TECHNIQUES: The most commonly used techniques to prepare the ingredient

TIPS: Suggestions for using the ingredient

FLAVOR AFFINITIES: Compatible flavor groups

AVOID: Incompatible flavors

[A to Z Listings](#)

[A](#)

[ACHIOTE SEEDS](#)

[ACIDITY](#) (See Sourness)

[AFGHAN CUISINE](#)

[AFRICAN CUISINE](#) (See also Ethiopian and Moroccan Cuisines)

[AFRICAN CUISINE \(NORTH\)](#) (See also Moroccan Cuisine)

[AFRICAN CUISINE \(SOUTH\)](#)

[AFRICAN CUISINE \(WEST\)](#)

[ALLSPICE](#)

[ALMOND OIL](#) (See Oil, Almond)

[ALMONDS](#)

[AMARETTO](#) (sweet almond liqueur)

[ANCHOVIES](#)

[ANGELICA](#)

[ANISE](#) (See also Anise, Star, and Fennel)

[ANISE HYSSOP](#)

[ANISE, STAR](#)

[APPETIZERS](#)

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[APRICOTS—IN GENERAL](#)

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[ARGENTINIAN CUISINE](#) (See also Latin American Cuisine)

[AROMA](#)

[ARTICHOKES](#)

[ARTICHOKES, JERUSALEM](#)

[ARUGULA](#) (See also Lettuces—Bitter Greens and Chicories)

[ASIAN CUISINE](#) (See Chinese, Japanese, Vietnamese, etc. Cuisines)

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[ASPARAGUS, WHITE](#)

[ASTRINGENCY](#)
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[AUTUMN](#)
[AVOCADO OIL](#) (See Oil, Avocado)
[AVOCADOS](#)

[B](#)

[BACON](#)
[BALANCE](#)
[BALSAMIC VINEGAR](#)
[BANANAS](#)
[BARLEY](#)
[BASIL](#) (See also Basil, Thai, and Lemon Basil)
[BASIL, LEMON](#) (See Lemon Basil)
[BASIL, THAI](#)
[BASS](#) (See also Bass, Sea, and Bass, Striped)
[BASS, BLACK](#)
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[BASS, STRIPED](#)
[BAY LEAF](#)
[BEANS—IN GENERAL](#) (See also specific beans below)
[BEANS, BLACK](#)
[BEANS, BROAD](#) (See Beans, Fava)
[BEANS, BUTTER](#) (See Beans, Lima)
[BEANS, CANNELLINI](#) (See also Beans, White)
[BEANS, FAVA \(aka Broad Beans or Horse Beans\)](#)
[BEANS, FLAGEOLET](#)
[BEANS, GARBANZO](#)
[BEANS, GREEN](#)
[BEANS, KIDNEY](#)
[BEANS, LIMA](#)
[BEANS, NAVY](#)
[BEANS, PINTO](#)

[BEANS, RED](#)

[BEANS, WHITE](#) (e.g., Cannellini, Navy)

[BEEF—IN GENERAL](#)

[BEEF—BRISKET](#)

[BEEF—CHEEKS](#)

[BEEF—KOBE](#)

[BEEF—LOIN](#) (aka shell, sirloin, tenderloin)

[BEEF—OXTAILS](#)

[BEEF—RIBS](#)

[BEEF—ROAST](#)

[BEEF—ROUND](#)

[BEEF—SHANK](#)

[BEEF—SHORT LOIN](#)

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[BEEF—STEAK: IN GENERAL](#)

[BEEF—STEAK: CHUCK](#)

[BEEF—STEAK: FILET MIGNON](#) (aka Beef Tenderloin)

[BEEF—STEAK: FLANK](#)

[BEEF—STEAK: HANGER](#)

[BEEF—STEAK: RIB EYE](#)

[BEEF—STEAK: SKIRT](#)

[BEEF—STEAK TARTARE](#)

[BEER](#)

[BEETS](#)

[BELGIAN CUISINE](#)

[BELL PEPPERS](#)

[BERRIES—IN GENERAL](#) (e.g., Cannellini, Navy)

[BITTER DISHES](#) (e.g., greens, barbecue food)

[BITTERNESS](#)

[BLACKBERRIES](#)

[BLACK-EYED PEAS](#)

[BLACK PEPPER](#) (See Pepper, Black)

[BLUEBERRIES](#)

[BLUEFISH](#)

[BOK CHOY](#)

[BONITO FLAKES, DRIED](#) (See also Tuna)
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[BROCCOLI](#)
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[BRUSSELS SPROUTS](#)
[BULGUR WHEAT](#)
[BUTTER, BROWN](#) (aka Beurre Noisette)
[BUTTERMILK](#)
[BUTTERSCOTCH](#)

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[CABBAGE—IN GENERAL](#)
[CABBAGE, NAPA](#) (aka Chinese cabbage)
[CABBAGE, RED](#)
[CABBAGE, SAVOY](#)
[CABERNET SAUVIGNON](#)
[CAJUN CUISINE](#)
[CALAMARI](#) (See Squid)
[CALF’S LIVER](#) (See Liver, Calf’s)
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[CAYENNE, GROUND](#)

[CELERY](#)

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[CELERY SALT](#)

[CELERY SEED](#)

[CHAMOMILE](#)

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[CHARD \(aka Swiss chard\)](#)

[CHARDONNAY](#)

[CHEESE—IN GENERAL](#) (See also specific cheeses)

[CHEESE, ASIAGO](#)

[CHEESE, AZEITAO](#)

[CHEESE, BLUE](#) (See also Gorgonzola, Roquefort, Stilton, etc.)

[CHEESE, BRIE](#)

[CHEESE, BURRATA](#)

[CHEESE, CABRALES](#)

[CHEESE, CAMEMBERT](#)

[CHEESE, CHEDDAR](#)

[CHEESE, COLBY](#)

[CHEESE, COMTÉ](#)

[CHEESE, COW'S MILK—IN GENERAL](#)

[CHEESE, CREAM](#)

[CHEESE, EMMENTAL](#)

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[CHEESE, EXPLORATEUR](#)

[CHEESE, FETA](#)

[CHEESE, FONTINA](#)

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[CHEESE, GARROTXA](#)

[CHEESE, GOAT'S MILK—IN GENERAL](#)

[CHEESE, GOAT—FRESH](#)

[CHEESE, GORGONZOLA](#)

[CHEESE, GOUDA](#)

[CHEESE, GRUYÈRE](#)

[CHEESE, HOJA SANTA](#)

[CHEESE, JACK](#)

[CHEESE, MAHON](#) (aged Spanish cheese)

[CHEESE, MANCHEGO](#)

[CHEESE, MASCARPONE](#) (See Mascarpone)

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[CHEESE, MOZZARELLA](#)

[CHEESE, MUENSTER](#)

[CHEESE, PARMESAN](#)

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[CHEESE, RICOTTA](#)

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[CHEESE, SHEEP'S MILK—IN GENERAL](#)

[CHEESE, SPANISH](#) (See Cheese: Cabrales, Manchego)

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[CHICKPEAS \(aka garbanzo beans\)](#)

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[CHILE PEPPERS, ANCHO](#) (dried poblanos)

[CHILE PEPPERS, CHIPOTLE](#)

[CHILE PEPPERS, GUAJILLO](#)

[CHILE PEPPERS, HABANERO](#)

[CHILE PEPPERS, JALAPEÑO](#)

[CHILE PEPPERS, PASILLA](#)

[CHILE PEPPERS, PIMENTS D'ESPELETTE](#)

[CHILE PEPPERS, POBLANO](#)

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[CHORIZO](#) (See also Sausages) Taste: salty; spicy

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[COCONUT AND COCONUT MILK](#)

[COD](#)

[COD, BLACK](#)

[COD, SALT](#)

[COFFEE AND ESPRESSO](#)

[COGNAC](#)

[COLDNESS](#) (of indoor or outdoor temperature; See also Winter)

[COLLARD GREENS](#) (See Greens, Collard)

[COOLING](#)

[CORIANDER](#)

[CORN](#)

[CORNED BEEF](#) (See Beef—Brisket)

[CORNISH GAME HENS](#)

[COUSCOUS](#)

[COUSCOUS, ISRAELI](#)

[CRAB](#)

[CRAB, SOFT-SHELL](#)

[CRANBERRIES](#)

[CRAYFISH](#) (aka crawfish)

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[CREAM, SOUR](#) (See Sour Cream)

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[DANDELION GREENS](#) (See Greens, Dandelion)

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[ENDIVE](#)

[ENDIVE, CURLY](#) (See Frisée)

[ENGLISH CUISINE](#)

[EPAZOTE](#)

[ESCALAR](#)

[ESCAROLE](#)

[ETHIOPIAN CUISINE](#)

[EUROPEAN, EASTERN CUISINES](#) (See Eastern European Cuisines)

F

[FALL](#) (See Autumn)

[FENNEL](#)

[FENNEL POLLEN](#)

[FENNEL SEEDS](#)

[FENUGREEK](#)

[FETA CHEESE](#) (See Cheese, Feta)

[FIDDLEHEAD FERNS](#)

[FIGS, DRIED](#)

[FIGS, FRESH](#)

[FILET MIGNON](#) (See Beef—Steak: Filet Mignon)

[FINES HERBES](#)

[FISH—IN GENERAL](#) (See individual fish; Seafood)

[FISH SAUCE](#)

[FIVE-SPICE POWDER](#)

[FLOUNDER](#)

[FOIE GRAS](#)

[FRENCH CUISINE—IN GENERAL](#)

[FRENCH CUISINE, NORTHERN](#)

[FRENCH CUISINE, SOUTHERN \(aka Provençal Cuisine\)](#)

[FRESHNESS](#)

[FRISÉE \(a fine-leaved variety of curly endive\)](#)

[FRUIT, DRIED](#) (See also Dates, Figs, Raisins, etc.)

[FRUIT, FRESH](#) (See also specific fruits)

[FRUIT, TROPICAL](#) (See also specific fruits, e.g., Mangoes, Papayas, Pineapples, etc.)

[G](#)

[GAME—IN GENERAL](#) (See also Rabbit, Venison)

[GARAM MASALA](#)

[GARLIC](#)

[GEORGIAN CUISINE \(RUSSIAN\)](#)

[GERMAN CUISINE](#)

[GIN](#)

[GINGER](#)

[GINGER, GROUND](#)

[GOAT CHEESE](#) (See Cheese, Goat)

[GRAPEFRUIT](#)

[GRAPES](#)

[GREEK CUISINE](#) (See also Mediterranean Cuisines)

[GREEN BEANS](#) (See Beans, Green)

[GREENS—IN GENERAL](#) (See also specific greens)

[GREENS, COLLARD](#)

[GREENS, DANDELION](#)

[GREENS, KALE](#) (See Kale)

[GREENS, MUSTARD](#)

[GREENS, SALAD](#) (See also Lettuce, Sorrel, Watercress, etc.)

[GREENS, TURNIP](#)

[GRILLED DISHES](#)

[GRITS](#)

[GROUPER](#)

[GUAVAS](#)

H

[HADDOCK](#) (See Cod)

[HALIBUT](#)

[HAM](#)

[HAM, IBÉRICO](#)

[HAM, SERRANO](#)

[HAZELNUT OIL](#) (See Oil, Hazelnut)

[HAZELNUTS](#)

[HERBES DE PROVENCE](#)

[HERBS](#) (See specific herbs)

[HONEY](#)

[HONEY, BLUEBERRY](#)

[HONEY, CHESTNUT](#)

[HONEY, RASPBERRY](#)

[HONEYDEW](#)

[HORSERADISH](#)

[HOTNESS](#) (of indoor or outdoor temperature; see also Summer)

[HUNGARIAN CUISINE](#)

[HYSSOP](#)

I

[INDIAN CUISINE](#)

[INDONESIAN CUISINE](#)

[IRANIAN CUISINE](#) (aka Persian Cuisine)

[ITALIAN CUISINE—IN GENERAL](#)

[ITALIAN CUISINE, NORTHERN](#)

[ITALIAN CUISINE, SOUTHERN](#)

J

[JAMAICAN CUISINE](#) (See also Caribbean Cuisines)

[JAPANESE CUISINE](#)

[JICAMA](#)

[JUNIPER BERRIES](#)

K

[KAFFIR LIMES AND KAFFIR LIME LEAF](#) (See also Lemons, Limes, etc.)

[KALE](#)

[KIWI FRUIT](#)

[KOHLRABI](#) (See also Rutabagas, Turnips)

[KOREAN CUISINE](#)

[KUMQUATS](#)

L

[LAMB—IN GENERAL](#)

[LAMB, CHOPS](#)

[LATIN AMERICAN CUISINE](#)

[LAVENDER](#)

[LEEKs](#)

[LEGUMES](#) (See Beans, Lentils, Peas, etc.)

[LEMONS](#)

[LEMONS, MEYER](#)

[LEMONS, PRESERVED](#)

[LEMON BALM](#)

[LEMON BASIL](#)

[LEMONGRASS](#)

[LEMON THYME](#)

[LEMON VERBENA](#)

[LENTILS](#)

[LETTUCES—IN GENERAL](#)

[LETTUCE, BIBB](#) (aka Boston or butter lettuce)

[LETTUCES—BITTER GREENS AND CHICORIES](#) (See Arugula, Escarole, Frisée, Radicchio)

[LETTUCES—MESCLUN GREENS](#)

[LETTUCE, ROMAINE](#)

[LIMES](#)

[LIMES AND LIME LEAF, KAFFIR](#) (See Kaffir Limes and Kaffir Lime

Leaf)

[LIVER, CALF'S](#)

[LIVER, CHICKEN](#)

[LIVER, DUCK OR GOOSE](#) (See Foie Gras)

[LOBSTER](#)

[LOTUS ROOT](#)

[LOVAGE](#)

[LUXURIOUS](#)

[LYCHEES](#)

[M](#)

[MACADAMIA NUT OIL](#) (See Oil, Macadamia Nut)

[MACADAMIA NUTS](#)

[MACE](#)

[MÂCHE](#)

[MACKEREL](#)

[MAHI MAHI](#)

[MALT](#)

[MANGOES](#)

[MAPLE SYRUP](#)

[MARJORAM](#)

[MASCARPONE](#)

[MEATS](#)

[MEDITERRANEAN CUISINES](#) (See also French [southern], Italian, Middle Eastern, Moroccan, and Spanish Cuisines)

[MELON/MUSKMELONS—IN GENERAL](#) (See also Cantaloupe, Honeydew, etc.)

[MENU](#)

[MERLOT](#)

[MEXICAN CUISINE](#)

[MIDDLE EASTERN CUISINE](#)

[MINT—IN GENERAL](#)

[MINT, DRIED](#)

[MINT, PEPPERMINT](#)

[MIREPOIX](#)

[MISO AND MISO SOUP](#)

[MOLASSES](#)

[MONKFISH](#) (See also Fish—In General)

[MORELS](#) (See Mushrooms, Morels)

[MOROCCAN CUISINE](#)

[MUSHROOMS—IN GENERAL](#) (See also specific mushrooms)

[MUSHROOMS—CHANTERELLES](#)

[MUSHROOMS—CREMINI](#)

[MUSHROOMS—MATSUTAKE](#)

[MUSHROOMS—MORELS](#)

[MUSHROOMS—PORCINI / CEPES / KING BOLETE](#)

[MUSHROOMS—PORTOBELLO](#)

[MUSHROOMS—SHIITAKE](#)

[MUSSELS](#)

[MUSTARD](#)

[MUSTARD GREENS](#) (See Greens, Mustard)

[N](#)

[NECTARINES](#) (See also Peaches)

[NORTH AFRICAN CUISINE](#) (See also Moroccan Cuisine)

[NUTMEG](#)

[NUTS—IN GENERAL](#) (See also Pecans, Walnuts, etc.)

[O](#)

[OATMEAL / OATS](#)

[OCTOPUS](#)

[OIL, ALMOND](#)

[OIL, AVOCADO](#)

[OIL, CANOLA](#)

[OIL, GRAPESEED](#)

[OIL, HAZELNUT](#)

[OIL, MACADAMIA NUT](#)

[OIL, OLIVE](#) (See Olive Oil)

[OIL, PEANUT](#)

[OIL, PECAN](#)

[OIL, PISTACHIO](#)

[OIL, PORCINI](#)

[OIL, PUMPKIN SEED](#)

[OIL, SESAME](#)

[OIL, TRUFFLE](#)

[OIL, WALNUT](#)

[OKRA](#)

[OLIVE OIL](#)

[OLIVES](#)

[OMELETS](#) (See Eggs and Eggbased Dishes)

[ONIONS—IN GENERAL](#)

[ONIONS, SWEET](#) (e.g., Vidalia)

[ORANGES—IN GENERAL](#)

[ORANGES, BLOOD](#)

[ORANGES, CLEMENTINE](#) (See Oranges, Mandarin)

[ORANGES, MANDARIN](#) (includes Clementines and Tangerines)

[OREGANO](#)

[OXTAILS](#) (See Beef)

[OYSTERS](#)

[P](#)

[PANCETTA](#)

[PAPAYAS](#)

[PAPRIKA—IN GENERAL](#)

[PAPRIKA, SMOKED](#)

[PARSLEY](#)

[PARSNIPS](#)

[PASSION FRUIT](#)

[PASTA](#)

[PEACHES](#)

[PEANUT OIL](#) (See Oil, Peanut)

[PEANUTS AND PEANUT BUTTER](#) (See also Nuts—In General)

[PEARS](#)

[PEAS—IN GENERAL](#) (See also Snap Peas)

[PECAN OIL](#) (See Oil, Pecan)

[PECANS](#) (See also Nuts—In General)

[PEPPER, BLACK](#)

[PEPPER, GREEN](#) (as peppercorns)

[PEPPER, PINK](#)

[PEPPER, RED](#) (See also Cayenne, Ground)

[PEPPER, WHITE](#)

[PEPPERS, BELL](#) (See Bell Peppers)

[PEPPERS, CHILE](#) (See Chile Peppers)

[PEPPERS, PEPPADEW](#)

[PEPPERS, PIQUILLO](#) (Spanish peppers)

[PEPPERS, SPANISH](#)

[PERSIMMONS](#)

[PHEASANT](#)

[PICKLES](#)

[PIMENTON](#) (See also Paprika)

[PINEAPPLES](#)

[PINE NUTS](#)

[PINOT NOIR](#)

[PIQUANCY](#)

[PISTACHIO OIL](#) (See Oil, Pistachio)

[PISTACHIOS](#) (See also Nuts—In General)

[PLANTAINS, GREEN](#)

[PLANTAINS, SWEET](#)

[PLUMS](#)

[PLUMS, DRIED](#) (aka prunes)

[POLENTA](#)

[POMEGRANATES](#)

[POMEGRANATE MOLASSES](#)

[POMELOS](#) (See also Grapefruit)

[PONZU SAUCE](#)

[POPPY SEEDS](#)

[PORK—IN GENERAL](#)

[PORK—BACON](#) (See Bacon)
[PORK—BELLY](#)
[PORK—CHOPS](#)
[PORK—HAM](#) (See Ham)
[PORK—LOIN](#)
[PORK—RIBS](#)
[PORK—SAUSAGE](#) (See Sausages)
[PORK—SHOULDER](#)
[PORK—TENDERLOIN](#)
[PORTUGUESE CUISINE](#)
[POTATOES](#)
[POTATOES, NEW](#)
[POULTRY](#) (See Chicken, Turkey, etc.)
[PROSCIUTTO](#)
[PRUNES](#) (See Plums, Dried)
[PUMPKIN](#) (See also Squashes, Winter)
[PUMPKIN SEED OIL](#) (See Oil, Pumpkin Seed)
[PUMPKIN SEEDS](#)
[PURSLANE](#)

Q

[QUAIL](#)
[QUATRE ÉPICES](#)
[QUINCE](#)

R

[RABBIT](#) (See also Game—In General)
[RADICCHIO](#)
[RADISHES](#)
[RAISINS](#)
[RAMPS](#) (aka wild leeks; see also [Leeks, Onions, and Scallions](#))
[RASPBERRIES](#)
[RED SNAPPER](#) (See Snapper)
[RHUBARB](#)

[RICE, WHITE—IN GENERAL](#)
[RICE, ARBORIO OR CARNAROLI \(aka risotto\)](#)
[RICE, BASMATI](#)
[RICE, CARNAROLI](#) (See Rice, Arborio)
[RICE, JASMINE](#) (See Thai Cuisine)
[RICE, WILD](#)
[RIESLING](#)
[ROASTED DISHES](#)
[ROMAINE](#) (See Lettuce, Romaine)
[ROSE \(Hips, Petals, Water\)](#)
[ROSEMARY](#)
[RUM](#)
[RUSSIAN CUISINE](#)
[RUTABAGAS](#)

S

[SAFFRON](#)
[SAGE](#)
[SAKE](#)
[SALADS](#) (See also Lettuces and other vegetables)
[SALMON](#) (See also Fish—In General)
[SALMON, CURED](#)
[SALMON, SMOKED](#)
[SALSIFY](#)
[SALT—IN GENERAL](#)
[SALT, FLEUR DE SEL](#)
[SALT, HAWAIIAN](#)
[SALT, JAPANESE](#)
[SALT, KOSHER](#)
[SALT, MALDON](#)
[SALT, SEA—COARSE](#)
[SALT, SEA—FINE](#)
[SALT, SMOKED](#)
[SALT, TRUFFLE](#)

[SALT, VANILLA](#)

[SALTINESS](#)

[SARDINES](#)

[SAUERKRAUT](#)

[SAUSAGES](#) (See also Chorizo)

[SAUVIGNON BLANC](#)

[SAVORY](#)

[SCALLIONS](#)

[SCALLOPS](#)

[SCANDINAVIAN CUISINE](#)

[SCOTCH](#)

[SEAFOOD—IN GENERAL](#) (See also specific fish and Shellfish)

[SESAME OIL](#) (See Oil, Sesame)

[SESAME SEEDS, BLACK](#)

[SESAME SEEDS, WHITE](#)

[SHALLOTS](#)

[SHELLFISH](#) (See also Crab, Lobster, Scallops, Shrimp, etc.)

[SHIITAKE MUSHROOMS](#) (See Mushrooms—Shiitakes)

[SHISO LEAF](#)

[SHORT RIBS](#) (See Beef—Short Ribs)

[SHRIMP](#) (See also Shellfish)

[SKATE](#)

[SLOW-COOKED](#)

[SMOKED SALMON](#) (See Salmon, Smoked)

[SMOKINESS](#)

[SNAP PEAS](#) (aka sugar snap peas)

[SNAPPER](#) (aka red snapper)

[SOLE](#)

[SORREL](#)

[SOUR CREAM](#)

[SOURNESS](#)

[SOUS-VIDE COOKING](#)

[SOUTHEAST ASIAN CUISINES](#)

[SOUTHERN CUISINE \(AMERICAN\)](#)

[SOUTHWESTERN CUISINE \(AMERICAN\)](#)

[SOY SAUCE](#)

[SPANISH CUISINE](#)

[SPICES](#) (See also individual spices)

[SPINACH](#) (See also Greens—In General)

[SPRING](#)

[SPROUTS](#)

[SQUAB](#)

[SQUASH, ACORN](#) (See also Pumpkin; Squash, Butternut; and Squash, Winter)

[SQUASH, BUTTERNUT](#) (See also Pumpkin; Squash, Acorn; and Squash, Winter)

[SQUASH, KABOCHA](#) (See also Squash, Winter)

[SQUASH, SPAGHETTI](#) (See also Squash, Winter)

[SQUASH, SUMMER](#) (See also Zucchini)

[SQUASH, WINTER](#) (See also Pumpkin; Squash, Acorn; and Squash, Butternut)

[SQUASH BLOSSOMS](#) (See Zucchini Blossoms)

[SQUID](#) (aka red snapper)

[STAR ANISE](#) (See Anise, Star)

[STEAK](#) (See Beef)

[STRAWBERRIES](#)

[STRIPED BASS](#) (See Bass, Striped)

[STUFFING](#)

[SUGAR](#)

[SUGAR, PALM](#)

[SUGAR SNAP PEAS](#) (See Snap Peas)

[SUMAC](#)

[SUMMER](#)

[SUNCHOKES](#) (See Artichokes, Jerusalem)

[SWEDISH CUISINE](#)

[SWEETBREADS](#)

[SWEETNESS](#)

[SWEET POTATOES](#)

[SWISS CHARD](#) (See Chard)

[SWORDFISH](#)

[SZECHUAN CUISINE](#) (See also Chinese Cuisine)
[SZECHUAN PEPPER](#)

[T](#)

[TAMARIND](#)
[TANGERINES](#) (see Oranges, Mandarin)
[TARRAGON](#)
[TECHNIQUES](#)
[TEQUILA](#)
[TEX-MEX CUISINE](#) (See Mexican Cuisine, Southwestern Cuisine)
[THAI CUISINE](#)
[THYME](#)
[THYME, LEMON](#) (See Lemon Thyme)
[TOFU](#)
[TOMATILLOS](#)
[TOMATOES](#)
[TROUT](#)
[TROUT, SMOKED](#)
[TRUFFLES, BLACK](#)
[TRUFFLES, PACIFIC NORTHWEST](#)
[TRUFFLES, WHITE](#)
[TUNA](#)
[TURBOT](#)
[TURKEY](#)
[TURKISH CUISINE](#)
[TURMERIC](#)
[TURNIP GREENS](#) (See Greens, Turnip)
[TURNIPS](#)

[U](#)

[UMAMI](#)

[V](#)

[VANILLA](#)

[VEAL—IN GENERAL](#)

[VEAL—BREAST](#)

[VEAL—CHEEKS](#)

[VEAL—CHOP](#)

[VEAL—LOIN](#)

[VEAL—SHANKS](#)

[VEAL—TENDERLOIN](#)

[VEGETABLES](#) (See specific vegetables)

[VEGETABLES, ROOT](#) (See specific root vegetables, e.g., Carrots)

[VEGETARIAN DISHES](#)

[VENISON](#)

[VERJUS](#)

[VIETNAMESE CUISINE](#)

[VINEGAR—IN GENERAL](#)

[VINEGAR, BALSAMIC](#)

[VINEGAR, BANYULS](#)

[VINEGAR, CABERNET SAUVIGNON](#)

[VINEGAR, CHAMPAGNE](#)

[VINEGAR, CHARDONNAY](#)

[VINEGAR, CIDER](#)

[VINEGAR, FRUIT](#)

[VINEGAR, ICE WINE](#)

[VINEGAR, MALT](#)

[VINEGAR, RED WINE](#)

[VINEGAR, RICE WINE](#)

[VINEGAR, SHERRY](#)

[VINEGAR, TARRAGON](#) (herb-flavored vinegar)

[VINEGAR, VINCOTTO](#) (Cooked Wine)

[VINEGAR, WHITE WINE](#)

[VODKA](#)

[W](#)

[WALNUT OIL](#) (See Oil, Walnut)

[WALNUTS](#) (See also Nuts—In General)

[WARMING](#)

[WASABI](#)

[WATER CHESTNUTS](#)

[WATERCRESS](#)

[WATERMELON](#)

[WHISKEY](#) (See also Bourbon)

[WILD RICE](#) (See Rice, Wild)

[WINE](#) (See individual varieties)

[WINTER](#)

[Y](#)

[YAMS](#) (See Sweet Potatoes)

[YOGURT](#)

[YUZU FRUIT](#)

[Z](#)

[ZUCCHINI](#) (See also Summer Squash)

[ZUCCHINI BLOSSOMS](#) (See also Zucchini)

ACHIOTE SEEDS

beef

chicken

chiles

citrus (e.g., sour orange)

fish

game birds (e.g., duck, quail)

garlic

Mexican cuisine, esp. Yucatán oil

pork

shellfish, e.g., lobster, shrimp

shrimp

Flavor Affinities

achiote + pork + sour orange

ACIDITY
(See Sourness)

AFGHAN CUISINE

almonds

barley

breads

cardamom

chile pepper

cinnamon

cloves

coriander

cucumber

cumin

dill

fennel

fruits, esp. dried

ginger

grapes

kebabs

lamb

mint

mushrooms

nuts, e.g., almonds

pasta

rice, basmati

sesame

tomatoes and tomato sauce

turmeric

yogurt

Flavor Affinities

almonds + cardamom + sugar

cucumber + mint + yogurt

AFRICAN CUISINE

(See also Ethiopian and Moroccan Cuisines)

bananas

bell peppers

braised dishes

chicken

chile peppers, esp. West African

coconuts

corn

fish, esp. coastal

fruits, esp. tropical

garlic

goat

greens, esp. steamed or stewed

mangoes

melons

okra

onions

papayas

peanuts

peas, esp. black-eyed

plantains

soups

stews, esp. meat or vegetable

sweet potatoes

tomatoes

watermelon

yams, esp. West African

AFRICAN CUISINE (NORTH)

(See also Moroccan Cuisine)

bell peppers
braised dishes
chicken
chickpeas
couscous
cucumbers
cumin
eggplant
fish
garlic
lamb
mint
parsley
rice
stewed dishes
tomatoes
wheat

Flavor Affinities

cumin + garlic + mint, esp. Northeast Africa

AFRICAN CUISINE (SOUTH)

beans
carrots
chile peppers
cinnamon
cloves
fenugreek
garlic
ginger
lamb
onions
peas
pumpkin
stews
tomatoes
turmeric

Flavor Affinities

lamb + chile peppers + garlic + onions

AFRICAN CUISINE (WEST)

bananas
bell peppers
braised dishes
chicken
chile peppers
corn
goat
mangoes
okra
papayas
peanuts
plantains
rice
soups
stewed dishes
sweet potatoes
tomatoes
wheat
yams

Flavor Affinities

chile peppers + peanuts + tomatoes

ALLSPICE

Season: autumn–winter

Taste: sweet

Weight: medium

Volume: loud

Tips: Add early in cooking.

apples

baked goods

beans

BEEF, esp. braised, corned, grilled, ground, raw, roasted, or stewed

beets

bread, esp. breakfast

cabbage

cakes

Caribbean cuisine

carrots

chicken (e.g., Jamaican style)

chickpeas

chile peppers

cinnamon

cloves

cookies

coriander

currants, esp. black

curries and curry powder

Eastern Mediterranean cuisine

eggplant

English cuisine

fish, esp. grilled

fruits, fruit compotes, and jams

game and game birds (e.g., quail)

garlic

ginger

goat

grains

ham

herring, pickled

Indian cuisine

JAMAICAN CUISINE (e.g., jerk dishes)

ketchup

lamb

mace

MEATS, red, esp. braised, grilled, or roasted

Mexican cuisine

Middle Eastern cuisine

mushrooms

mustard

North American cuisine

nutmeg

nuts

onions

pepper, black

pies

pineapple

pork

PUMPKIN

rabbit

rice

rosemary

salsas and sauces

sauerkraut

sausages

soups

spiced cakes

spinach

squash, winter

stews

stocks and broths, chicken

sweet potatoes

thyme

tomatoes
turnips
vegetables, esp. root
West Indies cuisine

Flavor Affinities

allspice + beef + onions
allspice + garlic + pork

In Jamaica, **allspice** is their pepper. It's fruitier than black peppercorns. I think it's especially nice with braised and roasted meats.

—**BRADFORD THOMPSON**, MARY ELAINE'S AT THE PHOENICIAN (SCOTTSDALE, ARIZONA)

ALMOND OIL
(See Oil, Almond)

ALMONDS

Taste: sweet

Botanical relatives: peaches

Function: warming

Weight: medium

Volume: quiet

amaretto

anise, esp. green

apples

apricots

beans

blackberries

brandy

BUTTER, UNSALTED

butterscotch

caramel

cardamom

cayenne

cheese: goat, manchego, ricotta

cherries, esp. sour

chicken

CHOCOLATE: DARK, MILK

chocolate, white

cinnamon

coconut

coffee

cornmeal

corn syrup

crab

cranberries

CREAM

cream cheese

crème fraîche

crust: pastry, pie

currants

figs

fish

French pastries

fruits, most

garlic

grapes

Greek cuisine

greens, salad

hazelnuts

HONEY

ice cream

Indian cuisine

Italian sauces

lamb

lavender

lemon: juice, zest

liqueurs, fruit (including orange)

mascarpone

Mediterranean cuisine

Mexican beverages and mole sauces

milk, sweetened condensed

molasses

Moroccan cuisine

nectarines

oats

olive oil

olives

orange: juice, zest

paprika

passion fruit

peaches

pears

pecans

pepper, ground

pine nuts

plums
praline
prunes
quince
raisins, esp. white
raspberries
rhubarb
rice
rosemary
rum
salt: kosher, sea
shellfish
sherry
Spanish cuisine, esp. sauces
strawberries
sugar: brown, white
tea
Turkish cuisine
VANILLA
walnuts

Almonds are fairly versatile in that their flavor is not very specific. When they are manufactured, then they have a distinct flavor: think of Frangelico, almond oil, or marzipan in dessert. In these cases, the almond has a very distinct flavor.

—MARCEL DESAULNIERS, THE TRELLIS (WILLIAMSBURG, VIRGINIA)

If you have some beautiful **almonds**, there are so many things you can do. You can grind them and make a frangipane and put it in puff pastry. You can put them into biscotti, a cake, or almond ice cream.

—EMILY LUCHETTI, FARALLON (SAN FRANCISCO)

Flavor Affinities

almonds + chocolate + coconut
almonds + coffee + orange
almonds + green anise + figs

almonds + honey + orange zest + raisins

AMARETTO

(sweet almond liqueur)

almonds

apricots

butter

cherries

chocolate

coffee

cream

hazelnuts

Italian cuisine

peaches

pork

sugar

ANCHOVIES

Taste: salty

Weight: light

Volume: loud

almonds

basil

beans, green

bell peppers, esp. roasted

capers

carrots

cauliflower

celery

cheese: manchego, mozzarella, **Parmesan**

chives

eggs, hard-boiled

fennel

GARLIC

lemon, juice

lobster

mayonnaise

Mediterranean cuisine

mustard (e.g., Dijon)

nectarines

OLIVE OIL

olives (e.g., black, green, niçoise)

onions

orange, zest

parsley, flat-leaf

pasta

pepper: black, white

No country in the world has **anchovies** like Spain. They are sophisticated, and

the ones from the north of Spain are best because they are bigger. Spanish anchovies are not salty, either. Once you eat one, your life changes forever! I pay a lot for my anchovies—up to seventy-five cents per fillet—and will have to charge \$9 for a plate. My customers will say that is too much to pay, and I agree—but if you don't pay, you don't taste. Lately, I have been combining anchovies with nectarines, which I love. I will make a vinaigrette with Pedro Ximénez [i.e., PX sherry], sherry vinegar, and olive oil and it is the perfect dressing—and unique.

—JOSÉ ANDRÉS, CAFÉ ATLÁNTICO (WASHINGTON, DC)



peppers, piquillo

pizza

potatoes

puttanesca sauce (key ingredient)

red pepper flakes

romaine lettuce

rosemary

salads, esp. Caesar (key ingredient)

salmon

salt: kosher, sea

shallots

sherry, PX

tapenade (key ingredient)

thyme

tomatoes

tuna

vinegar: champagne, red wine, sherry

Flavor Affinities

anchovies + lemon + olive oil + rosemary

ANGELICA

Taste: bitter, sweet

Volume: loud

Tips: Add late in cooking; use in baking.

Use to balance high-acid fruit, to reduce the need for sweeteners.

almonds

anise

apricots

candy

cream and ice cream

custards

desserts

fish

fruits

ginger: fresh, candied

hazelnuts

juniper berries

lavender

lemon balm

liqueurs

mushrooms

Angelica pairs well with fresh or candied ginger. And angelica with rhubarb really intensifies the flavor of the rhubarb.

—JERRY TRAUNFELD, THE HERBFARM (WOODINVILLE, WASHINGTON)

nutmeg

oranges

pepper, black

plums

***RHUBARB**

salads

shellfish
strawberries

Flavor Affinities

angelica + cream + rhubarb

ANISE

(See also **Anise, Star, and Fennel**)

Function: warming

Weight: light–medium

Volume: moderate–loud

Tips: Add early in cooking.

allspice

almonds

apples

baked goods, esp. cakes, cookies

beets

breads, esp. rye

cabbage

cakes

cardamom

carrots

cauliflower

cheese, esp. goat and ricotta

chestnuts

Chinese cuisine

cinnamon

cloves

coffee

cookies

crab

cream

cumin

dates

desserts

duck

fennel seeds

figs

FISH

fruit
garlic
ginger
hazelnuts
lemon
lentils
mayonnaise
Mediterranean cuisine
melon
Middle Eastern cuisine
mole sauce
Moroccan cuisine
mussels
nutmeg
nuts
orange
parsnips
peaches
pears
pepper
pickles
pineapple
plums
pork
Portuguese cuisine
Provençal cuisine (French)
prunes
pumpkin
quince
raisins
rhubarb
salumi

Anise seeds and fennel are used for braising our pork belly. Fennel and pork is a natural, just like in Italian sausage.

—CARRIE NAHABEDIAN, NAHA (CHICAGO)

sauerkraut

Scandinavian cuisine

shellfish

soups, esp. fish

star anise

STEWES, ESP. FISH

strawberries

sugar

sweet potatoes

tea

vanilla

vegetables, root

Vietnamese cuisine

walnuts

ANISE HYSSOP

Season: late spring–summer

Taste: sweet

Weight: light–medium

Volume: quiet–moderate

apricots

basil

beans, green

beets

berries, esp. blueberries

beverages

carrots

cherries

chervil

chicken cream and ice cream

currants

custards

desserts

fennel bulb

fish

FRUITS, ESP. SUMMER

honey

lavender

lemon

lychees

marjoram

melons

mint

nectarines

oranges

parsley

parsnips

peaches

pears

plums

pork

raspberries

rice

salads: fruit, green

shellfish (e.g., shrimp)

shrimp

spinach

squash, winter

stone fruits (e.g., peaches)

sweet potatoes

tarragon

teas

tomatoes

vegetables, root

watermelon

zucchini

ANISE, STAR

Taste: sweet, bitter

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate–loud

Tips: Add at the beginning of the cooking process. Use in stir-fries.

allspice

baked goods (e.g., breads, pastries)

beef

beverages

cardamom

chestnuts

chicken

chile peppers

chili powder

CHINESE CUISINE

chocolate, esp. milk

cinnamon

citrus zest

cloves

coriander

cumin

curry powder (ingredient)

duck

eggs

fennel seeds

figs

fish

FIVE-SPICE POWDER

fruits, esp. tropical

garlic

ginger

Indian cuisine

kumquats

leeks
lemongrass
lime, zest
liqueurs
mace
Malaysian cuisine
mangoes
maple syrup
meats, esp. fatty
nutmeg
orange, zest
oxtails
pears, esp. poached

As a kid, I hated black jelly beans. But I have grown to like all the various forms of anise, and **star anise** is one of my favorites. My favorite application is when it is infused with milk chocolate. It then has an almost malty-caramely quality to it. It adds that little something that people can't quite identify. I also love pears with anise, which works well with roasted or poached pears.

—MICHAEL LAISKONIS, LE BERNARDIN (NEW YORK CITY)

I love using **star anise** in dishes from meats to desserts. I love how it can be kind of meaty in a stew, or kind of sweet, adding bright, warm notes to a pumpkin dessert.

—TONY LIU, AUGUST (NEW YORK CITY)

pepper: black, Szechuan
pineapple
plums, esp. poached
pork
poultry
pumpkin
raspberries
root vegetables
salmon

sauces

scallions

scallops

shellfish

shrimp

soups

soy sauce

stews

stocks: beef, chicken

sweet potatoes

tamarind

teas

tuna

turmeric

vanilla

vegetables, esp. root

Vietnamese cuisine (e.g., pho)

wine, rice

Flavor Affinities

star anise + cream + maple

star anise + milk + milk chocolate + orange zest + sugar

star anise + pork + soy sauce + sugar

APPETIZERS

Tips: Saltiness stimulates appetite.

Serve small portions so as not to satiate the appetite too early in a meal.

Accompany appetizers with light-bodied wines.

Dishes

Insalata A Voce: Green Apple, Marcona Almonds, Watercress, Pecorino

—Andrew Carmellini, A Voce (New York City)

Apple and Eggplant Croûte with Apple Butter, Cranberry Compote, and Lemon-Poached Apples

—Dominique and Cindy Duby, Wild Sweets (Vancouver)

Apple Softcake with Dark Chocolate and Cinnamon Soup

—Dominique and Cindy Duby, Wild Sweets (Vancouver)

Sautéed Apples, Olive Oil Sponge, Maple–Brown Butter Ice Cream

—Johnny Iuzzini, pastry chef, Jean Georges (New York City)

Poached Granny Smith Apples, Wildflower Honey, and Belgian Endive Leaves

—Thomas Keller, The French Laundry (Yountville, California)

Apple-Lychee Sorbet

—Michael Laiskonis, pastry chef, Le Bernardin (New York City)

Caramelized Apple Sundae with Butter Pecan Ice Cream

—Emily Luchetti, Farallon (San Francisco)

Warm Granny Smith Apple Tart with Buttermilk Ice Cream

—Patrick O’Connell, The Inn at Little Washington (Washington, Virginia)

APPLES

Season: autumn

Taste: sweet, astringent

Function: cooling

Weight: medium

Volume: quiet–moderate

Techniques: bake, caramelize, deep-fry (e.g., as fritters), grill, poach, raw, sauté, stew

allspice

almonds



The combination of **apple** and celery works. A tart green apple sorbet is not going to knock your socks off, because you are programmed to know it. When you add the flavor of celery, you get something new. I also love the flavors of apple and fennel together, especially in sorbet.

—MICHAEL LAISKONIS, LE BERNARDIN (NEW YORK CITY)

I make an **apple** confit of thinly sliced apples with cinnamon caramel powder layered between the apples and baked slowly. When the dish is served, next to the apples is a small pile of dates poached in syrup with vanilla. The other flavors on the plate are lemon confit, quince, raw apple with apple cider gelée,

and *ras el hanout* (a Moroccan spice blend).

For this dish you need a contrast for the sweetness, so the role of the lemon confit is to cleanse and refresh. If the confit was not there, you would have a bite of the sweet date and be done. The date and lemon is like a salad. The line drawing this together is the quince and dates that come from the Middle East and that was the line to *ras el hanout*.

—MICHAEL LAISKONIS, LE BERNARDIN (NEW YORK CITY)

If you cook **apples** on top of the stove, some varieties will have a lot of juice while others will have none at all. Fuji, Gala, and Golden Delicious apples tend to be juicy, while Granny Smith apples are often drier. With different types of apples, you often don't know exactly what they will do. So if I'm going to serve apples with gingerbread, I will sauté them in a little sugar and see what happens. If they are letting out a bunch of juice, I won't add much sugar. If they are dry, I'll add some apple juice or Calvados.

—EMILY LUCHETTI, FARALLON (SAN FRANCISCO)

When I make an **apple** pie, I won't use any fewer than three different kinds of apples for their different textures and sweetnesses, which ensures that every single bite is interesting. I'll use Galas or Golden Delicious apples for their sweetness in the middle of the pie, and soft Jonathans or McIntoshes on top for their ability to melt into the others, and Braeburns or Granny Smiths on the bottom for their ability to stay firm.... I can't imagine an apple pie without cinnamon, a splash of lemon juice, and a pinch of salt.

—SHARON HAGE, YORK STREET (DALLAS)

Apples and caramel are a wonderful combination and depending on what nut you add it will take the combination in very different directions. If you add pecans, it would make the combination a heavier winter dessert, versus adding almonds, which would keep it lighter. Both work; you just need to decide how heavy you want the dish.

—EMILY LUCHETTI, FARALLON (SAN FRANCISCO)

apple cider or juice

applejack

apricots: dried, jam, puree

Armagnac

bacon

bay leaf

beef

blackberries

bourbon

brandy, esp. apple

brioche

BUTTER, UNSALTED

butterscotch

cabbage, red

CALVADOS

CARAMEL

cardamom

celery

celery root

cheese: Camembert, cheddar, goat, Gruyère

cherries: dried, fresh

chestnuts

chicken

chives

cider

***CINNAMON**

cloves

cognac

Cointreau

coriander

cranberries

CREAM AND ICE CREAM

crème anglaise (sauce)

crème fraîche

crust: pastry, pie

cumin

currants, esp. black, and currant jelly

curry powder

custards

dates

duck

eggplant

fennel

French cuisine, esp. from Normandy

frisée

ginger

goose

hazelnuts

honey, esp. chestnut, wildflower

horseradish

ice cream

Kirsch

lavender

LEMON: JUICE, ZEST

lemon thyme

lychees

Madeira

maple syrup

mayonnaise

meringue

molasses

mustard

nutmeg

nuts

oatmeal and oats

oil: canola, hazelnut, walnut

olive oil

onions, esp. green, red

orange: juice, zest

parsley

peanuts and peanut butter

pears

pecans

pepper, black

pies

pineapple
pine nuts
pistachios
plums
pomegranates
pork
poultry
prunes
puff pastry
pumpkin
quince
raisins, esp. seedless, white
rhubarb
rice and rice pudding
rosemary
RUM: DARK, LIGHT
salads: fruit, green
salt, kosher
sauerkraut
sherry

Apple and shiso work well together. I especially like them together in a sorbet. I will use a Granny Smith apple that has a nice tartness combined with a little sugar, lemon, and then the shiso. The shiso has a cumin and cinnamon flavor that is a natural with apple.

—**JERRY TRAUNFELD**, THE HERBFARM (WOODINVILLE, WASHINGTON)

If you stay in the boundaries of what people think a dessert should be it gets very hard to do something new. We explain that they already eat carrot cake. We think parsnip will work instead of carrot and that kabocha squash will work instead of pumpkin in a pie.

When people see eggplant in a dessert they automatically think it will not work. You have to hide the unusual element and play up what people know already. The boundaries are limitless when you think of all the crossovers between sweet and savory. Duck à l'orange is a fruit and meat combined, so

why not use bacon in a dessert? A pancake with maple syrup and bacon on the plate is really sweet and savory. So people already eat these combinations unconsciously.

For our apple-eggplant dessert, we start with a *choux* dough piecrust. Then we layer an almond cream-like custard. Then we alternate **apple** and eggplant slices side by side. We use baby eggplant because it has a spongy texture and sucks up moisture from the cream that can otherwise make the crust soggy and absorb the juice and flavor from the apples that would normally just evaporate. So when you eat the eggplant and apples, the eggplant tastes like apples.

—DOMINIQUE AND CINDY DUBY, WILD SWEETS (VANCOUVER)

I have always been very fond of chef Fr dy Girardet [who earned three Michelin stars at his restaurant in Switzerland before retiring in 1996]. When I was young, I cooked almost every recipe from his book and visited his restaurant. One of his most interesting desserts was an **apple** dessert made of apples in the shape of little balls. The dessert broke away from cooking apples whole in the traditional way, which alone inspired me. He cooked them over a very high heat for two minutes and put them into a red wine reduction that had cinnamon, orange peel, and sugar. This was put onto a sheet tray that needed to be shaken for an hour so the apples would not dry out. The apples would absorb these flavors like a sponge and would then be served with vanilla ice cream.

In that spirit, we transformed this dessert. We transformed the wine by “espherication” so that it creates a bubble of liquid that explodes in your mouth. We cut apples with a melon baller, then vacuum-packed the apples with the wine but cooked it in such a way that the apples stayed hard and absorbed the wine flavor.

—JOS  ANDR S, CAF  ATL NTICO (WASHINGTON, DC)

We serve a dish of smoked oysters with **apples**. We smoke the oysters over applewood, and so it seemed logical to add apple to the dish. We serve it with a puree of apple with juniper that just plays beautifully off the oyster.

—KATSUYA FUKUSHIMA, MINIBAR (WASHINGTON, DC)

soups

sour cream

star anise

SUGAR: BROWN, WHITE

sweet potatoes

tarragon

tarts

thyme

vanilla

verjus

vermouth

vinegar: apple cider, raspberry

WALNUTS

wine: red, dry white

yogurt

Flavor Affinities

apples + almonds + caramel

apples + almonds + Armagnac + crème fraîche + raisins

apples + apricots + pine nuts + rosemary

apples + brown sugar + cream + walnuts

apples + Calvados + cranberries + maple syrup

apples + caramel + cinnamon

apples + caramel + cinnamon + dates + lemon confit + quince + *ras el hanout* +
vanilla

apples + caramel + peanuts

apples + caramel + pecans

apples + caramel + pistachios + vanilla

apples + celery + walnuts

apples + cinnamon + cranberries

apples + cinnamon + dark chocolate + yams

apples + cream + ginger

apples + ginger + hazelnuts

apples + ginger + lemon + quince + sugar

apples + honey + lemon thyme

apples + raisins + rum

apples + red cabbage + cinnamon

APRICOTS—IN GENERAL

Season: summer

Taste: sweet

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate

Techniques: bake, grill, poach, raw, stew
allspice

ALMONDS

amaretto

anise

apples

apricot

brandy

bananas

blackberries

blueberries

brandy

butter, unsalted

caramel

cardamom

cayenne

cheese (e.g., Brie, Reblochon, ricotta)

cheesecake

cherries

chicken

chocolate, white

cinnamon

coconut

coffee and espresso

cognac

coriander

cranberries

CREAM AND ICE CREAM

crème anglaise

custards (e.g., crème brûlée)

duck
foie gras
game
garlic
ginger
hazelnuts
honey
ice cream, esp. vanilla
Kirsch
lamb
LEMON: juice, zest
lemon verbena
liqueurs: apricot, nut
maple syrup
mascarpone
Mediterranean cuisine
meringue
Middle Eastern stews
mint (garnish)
Moroccan cuisine
nectarines
nutmeg
nuts
oats and oatmeal
onions, esp. yellow
orange: juice, zest
orange liqueur
peaches
pepper, black
pineapple
pine nuts
pistachios
plums
pork
poultry
praline
prunes

raisins
raspberries
rice pudding
rosemary
rum
saffron salads, esp. fruit, green
Sauternes
sour cream
strawberries
SUGAR: brown, white
tea: apple, apricot, Earl Grey
***VANILLA**
vinegar, red wine
walnuts
wine: sweet, white
yogurt

Flavor Affinities

apricots + almonds + cream + sugar
apricots + almonds + meringue + Moscato d'Asti
apricots + apples + pine nuts + rosemary
apricots + cranberries + white chocolate
apricots + oranges + sugar + vanilla + walnuts

APRICOTS, DRIED

Techniques: poach, stew

allspice
cherries, dried
cinnamon
currants
custard
French toast
ginger
hazelnuts
honey
ice cream
lemon: juice, zest
Madeira
Moroccan
cuisine
orange: juice, zest
pancakes/crepes
pistachios
pork
prunes
pumpkin seeds
raisins
rice pudding
sugar
tamarind paste
vanilla
wine, sweet white (e.g., Muscat)

Flavor Affinities

dried apricots + dried cherries + ginger + orange + pistachios

ARGENTINIAN CUISINE

(See also Latin American Cuisine)

beef

corn

peaches

pumpkin

sweet potatoes

AROMA

When looking to make a big impact with aroma, turn to:

chocolate

cinnamon

herbs

pineapple

sous-vide cooking

spices

star anise

truffles

vanilla

Apricots are much better cooked than raw. It is rare that you find a fruit that reaches its full potential as cooked rather than raw, but an apricot is one. A so-so apricot poached will turn into heaven. They are great with either chamomile or lavender.

—GINA DEPALMA, BABBO (NEW YORK CITY)

Apricot is a fruit you need to cook to help unleash its flavors. A bite of raw apricot is kind of bland and doesn't excite very much. If you throw that same apricot into the oven and heat it up a bit, it turns into a whole different fruit. Apricot with vanilla is a match made in heaven.

—EMILY LUCHETTI, FARALLON (SAN FRANCISCO)

We believe as much as 90 percent of flavor is due to **aroma** as opposed to taste.

—DOMINIQUE AND CINDY DUBY, WILD SWEETS (VANCOUVER)

ARTICHOKES

Season: spring–early autumn

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate–loud

Techniques: bake, boil, braise, broil, deep-fry, grill, raw, roast, sauté, steam, stew

aioli

anchovies

arugula

bacon

basil

bay leaf

beans, fava

beets

bell peppers, esp. roasted

bread crumbs

butter

capers

carrots

Dishes

Fettuccine with House-Made Pancetta, Artichokes, Lemon, and Hot Chiles

—Mario Batali, Babbo (New York City)

Spring Artichoke Fritto with Yogurt, Mint, and Lemon Aioli

—Andrew Carmellini, A Voce (New York City)

My mom made **artichokes** that we dipped in mayonnaise, so I tweaked that idea for the stuffed artichoke we serve here. *Panko* bread crumbs are mixed with chopped mint, salted, and stuffed into the artichoke cavity. The homemade mayonnaise I serve is made with eggs and just a little olive oil but mostly melted butter, which makes it richer and more flavorful—which is based on how it is made for the Chinese dish of shrimp and walnuts. The mayonnaise is then seasoned with anchovies, red pepper flakes, and onion confit.

—TONY LIU, AUGUST (NEW YORK CITY)

cashews

celery

cheese: Emmental, goat, Gruyère, Parmesan

chervil

chicken

chives

coriander

cream

crème fraîche

eggs: yolk, hard-boiled

French cuisine

GARLIC

grapefruit

ham (e.g., Serrano)

hazelnuts

hollandaise sauce

Italian cuisine

leeks

LEMON: confit, juice, zest

lobster

mayonnaise

Mediterranean cuisine

MINT

Moroccan cuisine

mushrooms

mustard, Dijon

nuts: cashews, hazelnuts, walnuts

oil: hazelnut, peanut

OLIVE OIL

olives: black, niçoise

ONIONS, ESP. SWEET AND YELLOW

orange

pancetta

PARSLEY, FLAT-LEAF PEPPER: BLACK, WHITE

pesto

piquillo peppers

potatoes

prosciutto

radicchio

Flavor Affinities

artichokes + butter + garlic + lemon + parsley

artichokes + cream + Parmesan cheese + thyme

artichokes + garlic + lemon

artichokes + garlic + lemon + mint

artichokes + garlic + lemon + olive oil

artichokes + garlic + lemon + olive oil + thyme

artichokes + garlic + mint

artichokes + garlic + Parmesan cheese + thyme

artichokes + garlic + sage
artichokes + lemon + mint + yogurt
artichokes + lemon + onions
artichokes + mushrooms + onions + sausage
artichokes + olive oil + Parmesan cheese + white truffles
red pepper flakes

rice

risotto

rosemary

saffron

sage

salads

SALT, KOSHER

savory

shallots

shellfish (e.g., crab)

sherry, dry

shrimp

soy sauce

Spanish cuisine

spinach

stock, chicken

sugar (pinch)

tapenade

tarragon, fresh

THYME, FRESH

TOMATOES

truffles, black

tuna

vinaigrette

vinegar: balsamic, rice, sherry, white wine

walnuts

WINE, DRYWHITE

yogurt

ARTICHOKES, JERUSALEM

Season: autumn–spring

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate

Techniques: bake, blanche, cream, fry, roast, sauté

anise

bacon

bay leaf

butter

celery

cheese, goat

chervil

chives

coriander

cream

cumin

dill

fennel leaves

fennel seeds

garlic

ginger

hazelnuts

leeks

lemon, juice

mace

meats, esp. roasted

morels

nutmeg

oil: nut, sunflower seed

olive oil

onions

parsley, flat-leaf

pepper, black

potatoes
rosemary
sage
salmon
salt, sea
shallots
stock, chicken
tarragon
thyme
vinegar
wine, dry white

Flavor Affinities

Jerusalem artichoke + goat cheese + hazelnuts
Jerusalem artichoke + lemon + morels

ARUGULA

(See also Lettuces—Bitter Greens and Chicories)

Season: spring–summer

Taste: bitter

Weight: light–medium

Volume: moderate–loud

Techniques: braise, raw (salads), sauté, soups, wilt

almonds

basil

beans, white

bell peppers, esp. red

cheese: Cabrales, feta, **goat**, mozzarella, **Parmesan**

chicken

cilantro

clams

corn

cucumbers

dill

eggs, esp. hard-boiled

endive

fennel

fish (e.g., salmon, tuna)

garlic

grapes

Italian cuisine

lemon juice

lettuces

lovage

Mediterranean cuisine

mesclun salad greens (key ingredient)

mint

mushrooms

mussels

nuts

olive oil

olives, black

oranges, esp. blood

pancetta

parsley

pasta

pears

pesto

pine nuts

potatoes

prosciutto

radicchio

radishes

risotto

salads and salad greens

Dishes

Jerusalem Artichoke Soup, Sweet Garlic Flan, “Sockeye” Salmon Tartare, Poached Quail Egg, and Crisp Sunchokes

—Carrie Nahabedian, Naha (Chicago)

Dishes

Arugula Risotto with Roquefort and Pignoli Nuts

—Gabriel Kreuther, The Modern (New York City)

Arugula Salad with Cucumber, Mt. Vikos Feta, Mint, Coriander Vinaigrette, and Niçoise Olives

—Judy Rodgers, Zuni Café (San Francisco)

Sautéed Arugula with Paneer Cheese and Roasted Cashews

—Vikram Vij and Meeru Dhalwala, Vij's (Vancouver)

salt, esp. sea

shallots

shellfish (e.g., shrimp)

tomatoes

tuna

vinaigrettes

vinegar: balsamic, champagne, red wine, sherry, white wine

watercress

Flavor Affinities

arugula + balsamic vinegar + lemon + olive oil + Parmesan cheese

arugula + Cabrales cheese + endive + grapes

arugula + cucumber + feta cheese + mint

arugula + endive + radicchio

arugula + fennel + pears

arugula + pears + prosciutto

ASIAN CUISINE

(See Chinese, Japanese, Vietnamese, etc. Cuisines)

ASPARAGUS

Season: spring

Weight: light–medium

Volume: moderate

Techniques: blanch, boil, deepfry, grill, pan roast, simmer, steam, stir-fry

almonds

anchovies

artichokes

basil

bay leaf

beets

bread crumbs

butter, brown

BUTTER, UNSALTED

capers

caraway seeds

carrots

cayenne

CHEESE: chèvre, Fontina, goat, Muenster, PARMESAN, PECORINO,
ricotta, Romano

chervil

chives

crab

cream, heavy

crème fraîche

dill

EGGS AND EGG DISHES (e.g., coddled, hard-boiled omelets)

fava beans

French cuisine

garlic

ginger

ham

hollandaise sauce

Italian cuisine

leeks

LEMON: JUICE, ZEST

lemon thyme

lime, juice

lobster

Marsala wine

mascarpone

mayonnaise

mushrooms, esp. cremini, **morels**, shiitakes

mustard, Dijon

oil: hazelnut, peanut, sesame, truffle

OLIVE OIL

onions, esp. spring, yellow

orange

oysters

pancetta

parsley, flat-leaf

pasta

peas

PEPPER: BLACK, WHITE

peppers, piquillo

Dishes

Ricotta Gnocchi with Asparagus, Morels, and Pine Nuts

—Dan Barber, Blue Hill at Stone Barns (Pocantico Hills, New York)

Asparagus and Ricotta “Mezzalune” with Spring Onion Butter

—Mario Batali, Babbo (New York City)

Salad of Sacramento Delta Green Asparagus, Spring Garlic, Marinated Sweet Peppers, with Young Arugula and Yellow Pepper Gastrique

—Thomas Keller, The French Laundry (Yountville, California)

Warm Salad of Sacramento Delta Green Asparagus, Melted Cipollini Onion Rings, Soft-Boiled Hen Egg, and Country Bread Croutons

—Thomas Keller, The French Laundry (Yountville, California)

Green Asparagus Soup with Gyromitre Mushrooms and Soft-Poached Farm Egg

—Gabriel Kreuther, The Modern (New York City)

Warm Salad of Grilled Asparagus and Prawns with a Sherry Vinaigrette

—Patrick O’Connell, The Inn at Little Washington (Washington, Virginia)

Vegetarian Sushi: Asparagus and Roasted Bell Pepper Roll

—Kaz Okochi, Kaz Sushi Bistro (Washington, DC)

Asparagus and Morel Mushroom Salad: Pancetta, Fiddlehead Ferns, Vermont Shepherd Cheese, and a Mushroom Reduction

—Alfred Portale, Gotham Bar and Grill (New York City)

Terrine of Green and White Asparagus, Roasted Beet Root Salad, Asparagus Juices
—Rick Tramonto, Tru (Chicago)

pistachios

potatoes

prosciutto

ramps

rice and risotto

saffron

sage

salmon

SALT: KOSHER, SEA

sauce: béchamel, brown butter, Mornay

savory

scallions

sesame seeds

shallots

shrimp

soups

sour cream

soy sauce

spinach

stocks: chicken, vegetable

tarragon

thyme, fresh

tomatoes

turnips

vermouth

vinaigrette: mustard, sherry

vinegar: champagne, **red wine**, sherry, **white wine**

wine, dry white (e.g., Muscat)

yogurt

Flavor Affinities

asparagus + capers + ham + shrimp

asparagus + cayenne + lime
asparagus + chervil + chives + garlic + morel mushrooms + shallots
asparagus + crab + morel mushrooms + ramps
asparagus + garlic + ginger + sesame
asparagus + garlic + leeks + onions + potatoes
asparagus + goat cheese + mascarpone + thyme
asparagus + ham + morel mushrooms + Parmesan cheese
asparagus + lemon + olive oil + black pepper
asparagus + morel mushrooms + ramps
asparagus + Parmesan cheese + eggs
asparagus + Parmesan cheese + pancetta + vinaigrette
asparagus + prosciutto + goat cheese + chervil

Daniel Humm of New York's Eleven Madison Park on Making Asparagus Soup

Making and seasoning soup is one of the best ways to learn about flavor. Let's make asparagus soup:

- You need a lot of asparagus flavor.
- You need acidity.
- You need sweetness that will come from the asparagus.
- You need the right amount of salt.
- You need just the right amount of spice, so that it doesn't actually taste spicy. We use a lot of cayenne, but you would never know it is there; it is just an accent.
- You need fresh lime juice to finish.

Soup is a play of balance when you have a lot of flavor. You can add a lot of salt and it won't taste salty. You can add a lot of acid and it won't taste acidic. But you still have a bold-flavored soup. It's like winemaking; at some point, there is a balance of all the flavors.

The first thing you need to do is get all the asparagus flavor into the soup at the start. We save our asparagus liquid from all the asparagus we cook to use for asparagus stock.

Making the soup: We sweat the asparagus [that is, cook it over low heat in a little fat, generally in a covered pot or pan] very slowly. When we add wine, we do it multiple times, adding a little at a time and reducing it, then repeating the process. What this does is concentrate the flavor at each step. It makes a big difference [before adding the asparagus liquid].

Finishing the soup: A soup may taste seasoned, but it still needs to be "woken up." You taste the asparagus, but maybe it doesn't blow you away at first. To do that, you need acid and cayenne. We season the soup with lime because it is a stronger acid and yet has less flavor than lemon. If I use lemon to get as much acid as I need for the soup, I will need to use so much that the soup will taste lemony instead.

ASPARAGUS, WHITE

Season: spring

Weight: light

Volume: quiet–moderate

Techniques: blanch, boil, sauté, steam

Tips: Covered to deprive it of sunlight while growing, white asparagus is lighter in flavor and texture than green asparagus.

butter

cheese, Parmesan

chicken

crab

eggs: whole, yolks

ham

hazelnuts

lemon

mushrooms (e.g., cepes, morels, porcini)

mustard

oil, truffle

olive oil

parsley

pepper, black

salt, sea

sauces: hollandaise, mayonnaise, romesco

shallots

shrimp

stock, chicken

sugar (pinch)

tarragon

vinaigrette

vinegar: champagne, white

wine, Riesling

Flavor Affinities

white asparagus + hazelnuts + Parmesan cheese + truffle oil

white asparagus + lemon + ceps mushrooms + parsley

white asparagus + mustard + olive oil + vinegar

ASTRINGENCY

Taste: astringent

Function: cooling

apples (astringent-sweet)
artichokes
asparagus
bananas, unripe (astringentsweet)
basil
beans
berries
broccoli
buckwheat
cashews
cauliflower
coffee
cranberries
figs (astringent-sweet)
fruits: dried, raw, unripe
grapes (astringent-sour-sweet)
hazelnuts
herbs
honey
legumes
lentils
lettuce
mace
marjoram
okra
parsley
peaches (astringent-sweet)
pears (astringent-sweet)
persimmons
plums (astringent-sweet)

pomegranates (astringent-soursweet)

quinoa

rhubarb

rye

saffron

sprouts

tea

turmeric

turnips

vegetables, raw

walnuts

AUSTRALIAN CUISINE

barbecued foods

beef

cheese

fish

fruits, fresh

lamb

nuts, macadamia

seafood

shellfish, esp. shrimp

vegetables, fresh

wines

yabbies

NOTE: Akin to the “New American” cuisine that incorporates ingredients and techniques from around the world, “Mod Oz” (modern Australian) cuisine combines its British heritage with influences from other parts of Europe as well as Asia.

AUSTRIAN CUISINE

beer

cinnamon

coffee

cream

desserts

dumplings

goulash

marjoram

meat, esp. beef or pork

paprika

parsley

pastries

potatoes

schnitzel

soups, esp. with dumplings or noodles

stews

strudel

wine

AUTUMN

Weather: typically cool

Techniques: braise, glaze, roast

almonds (peak: October)

apples (peak: September–November)

artichokes (peak: September–October)

basil (peak: September)

beans (peak: September)

bell peppers (peak: September)

broccoli

broccoli rabe (peak: July–December)

Brussels sprouts (peak: November–February)

cakes, esp. served warm

cantaloupe (peak: June–September)

caramel

cardoons (peak: October)

cauliflower

celery root (peak: October–November)

chard (peak: June–December)

chestnuts (peak: October–November)

chile peppers

coconut (peak: October–November)

corn (peak: September)

cranberries (peak: September–December)

cucumbers (peak: September)

dates

duck

eggplant (peak: August–November)

fennel

figs (peak: September–October)

foie gras

garlic (peak: September)

gooseberries (peak: June–September)

grains
grapes (peak: September)
heavier dishes
huckleberries (peak: August–September)
kale (peak: November–January)
kohlrabi (peak: September–November)
lentils
lovage (peak: September–October)
lychee nuts (peak: September–November)
mushrooms: chanterelles (peak: April–October), porcini (peak: September–October)
nectarines (peak: July–September)
nuts
okra (peak: July–September)
oranges, blood (peak: November–February)
oysters (peak: September–April)
partridge (peak: November–December)
passion fruit (peak: November–February)
pears (peak: July–October)
peas (peak: June–September)
persimmons (peak: October–January)
pheasant (peak: October–December)
pistachios (peak: September)
plums (peak: July–October)
polenta
pomegranates (peak: October–December)
pumpkins (peak: September–December)
quinces (peak: October–December)
salsify (peak: November–January)
scallops
seeds, sunflower
spices, warming (e.g., black peppercorns, cayenne, cinnamon, chili powder, clove, cumin, mustard, etc.)
squash, winter (peak: October–December)
stuffing
sweetbreads
sweet potatoes (peak: November–January)

tomatoes (peak: September)
turkey
vinegar, red wine
walnuts
watermelon (peak: July–September)
yams (peak: November)
zucchini (peak: June–October)

The earthy flavors of **autumn** come together in our chanterelle mushroom and lentil soup with sautéed foie gras.

—**HIRO SONE AND LISSA DOUMANI**, TERRA (ST. HELENA, CALIFORNIA)

In the **autumn**, I use walnut vinegar, which is red wine vinegar with macerated walnuts in it. It is great on a dish of sweetbreads and hazelnuts.

—**ANDREW CARMELLINI**, A VOCE (NEW YORK CITY)

When I think of autumn, I think of apples, pears, quince—which is so underrated—figs, and pumpkins.

I work with apples and pears, which you can start using in September, especially with the early apples like Gravenstein in the Bay Area. I try not to use pumpkin until close to Halloween, because no matter what you do with it, it will still taste like pumpkin. It's not like berries or apples that you can do a thousand things with. As a pastry chef, if I serve pumpkin too soon, people will get sick of it—and if I take it off the menu, there is nothing to replace it with. So I try to wait so I don't peak too early.

Figs are great for fall. The problem with figs is that there are not that many fig lovers out there. There are a lot more peach, chocolate, and apple lovers than there are fig lovers. When I make a fig dessert, I'll pair it with a raspberry or late summer fruit so it's more likely to meet with customer acceptance.

In the fall, I'll make more cakes. Fall also turns into caramel season, and fall fruits work so well with caramel. I keep a lighter hand with caramel in the fall because it is being combined with fruit versus chocolate.

—**EMILY LUCHETTI**, FARALLON (SAN FRANCISCO)

Dishes

Avocado and Grapefruit with Poppy Seed Dressing

—Ann Cashion, Cashion's Eat Place (Washington, DC)

Creamy Avocado Pudding with Pink Grapefruit Reduction and Candied Zest

—Dominique and Cindy Duby, Wild Sweets (Vancouver)

AVOCADO OIL
(See Oil, Avocado)

AVOCADOS

Season: spring–summer

Botanical relatives: allspice, bay leaf

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: quiet

Techniques: raw

Tips: Use to add richness to a dish.

arugula

bacon

basil and Thai basil

beans, black

bell peppers, esp. red

butter, unsalted

Central American cuisine

chayote

chervil

chicken

chile peppers: chipotle, jalapeño, serrano

chives

cilantro

corn and masa

crab

cream, heavy

crème fraîche

cucumbers

cumin

dashi

endive, esp. Belgian

fennel

fish

frisée

fruits, esp. tropical

garlic

grapefruit

guacamole (key ingredient)

jicama

lemon: juice, zest

LIME, JUICE

lobster

mangoes

mayonnaise

Mexican cuisine

oil, canola

olive oil

ONIONS, ESP. RED, spring, white

orange

parsley, flat-leaf

pepper: black, white

radishes

rocket

sake

salads, esp. green, seafood

salsa

SALT: KOSHER, SEA

sandwiches

scallions

shellfish (e.g., shrimp)

shrimp

smoked fish (e.g., trout)

soups

sour cream

Southwestern cuisine

soy sauce

spinach

stocks: chicken, vegetable

Tabasco sauce

tarragon

tequila

tomatillos

tomatoes

vinaigrette

VINEGAR: balsamic, cider, tarragon, white wine
walnuts, oil
yogurt

Flavor Affinities

avocado + bacon + scallions + tomatoes
avocado + basil + red onions + tomatoes + balsamic vinegar
avocado + chiles + cilantro + lime + black pepper + salt + scallions
avocado + cilantro + lime juice
avocado + crab + grapefruit + tomato
avocado + crème fraîche + grapefruit
avocado + endive + frisée + lemon juice + sea salt
avocado + jalapeño chiles + cilantro + cumin + garlic + lime + onion
avocado + lemon + smoked trout

Avocados are so rich that we always season them with a lot of *fleur de sel* and lemon juice, and toss them with frisée and endive. Avocados need something bitter for balance.

—**SHARON HAGE**, YORK STREET (DALLAS)

BACON

Taste: salty

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate

Techniques: broil, roast, sauté

aioli

avocados

beans (e.g., black, fava, green)

breakfast

butter, unsalted

celery

chervil

chicken

eggs

French cuisine

frisée

greens (e.g., arugula)

Italian cuisine

lentils

lettuce

maple syrup

mayonnaise

mushrooms, esp. chanterelles

olive oil

onions

parsnips

peas

pepper, black

potatoes

risotto

salads

salmon

salt

scallops
shallots
spinach
squash, winter
stews
stock, chicken
tomatoes
vinegar

Flavor Affinities

bacon + arugula + egg + pork belly
bacon + chanterelle mushrooms + chicken + potatoes
bacon + chanterelle mushrooms + salmon + shallots
bacon + hard-boiled eggs + spinach + balsamic vinegar
bacon + lettuce + tomatoes
bacon + onions + vinegar
bacon + shallots + vinegar
bacon + spinach + winter squash

Bacon can be salt, fat, and/or smoke, depending on the bacon you choose. You can also play with its texture, depending on whether you are using pork belly or crispy bacon. It is wonderful with vegetables. The fat is delicious, so if you are braising onions in bacon fat, reduce that down, and add a little onion *jus* and vinegar, you have a great sauce. Bacon just brings another layer of flavor to the vegetables. My dish of Berkshire pork chop with scarlet turnips, roasted rhubarb, and smoked bacon with cherry-almond salsa seca represents the relationship between fat, salt, sugar, and acid; they are all there. The bacon brings complexity to the pork; the cherry brings acid balance; and the almond brings a different kind of fat with crunch. The almonds in the dish are marcona, and every tenth one is extremely bitter, which adds another layer of complexity.

—**TRACI DES JARDINS**, JARDINIÈRE (SAN FRANCISCO)

Dishes

Braised Bacon with Spring Vegetables and White Horseradish Broth

—Dan Barber, Blue Hill at Stone Barns (Pocantico Hills, New York)

Smoked Bacon and Egg Ice Cream with Pain Perdu, Tea Jelly

—Heston Blumenthal, The Fat Duck (England)

Berkshire Pork Chop with Scarlet Turnips, Roasted Rhubarb, and Smoked Bacon with Cherry-Almond Salsa Seca

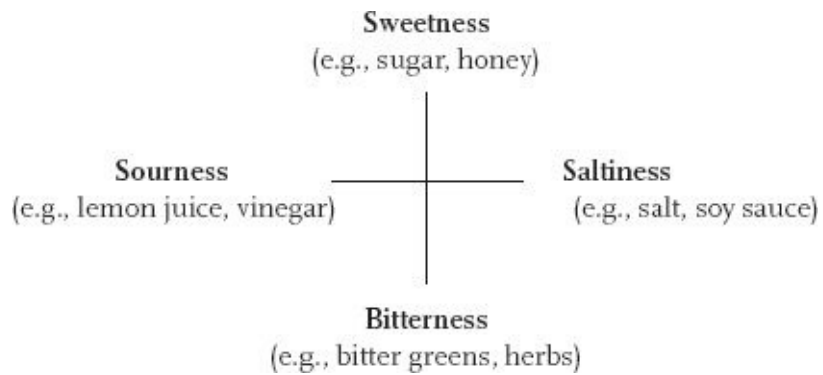
—Traci Des Jardins, Jardinière (San Francisco)

BALANCE

Tips: Seek balance in every dish you make:

- tastes (e.g., sourness vs. saltiness; sweetness vs. bitterness)
- richness (e.g., fat) vs. relief (e.g., acidity, bitterness)
- temperatures (e.g., hot vs. cold)
- textures (e.g., creamy vs. crunchy)

Balance taste by adding its opposite or its complement.



BALSAMIC VINEGAR

(See Vinegar, Balsamic)

Dishes

Chocolate-Banana Flan, Exotic Fruit Jelly, Spiced Fritters, Faux Foie Gras Emulsion, and Cumin Gel

—Dominique and Cindy Duby, Wild Sweets (Vancouver)

Sticky Toffee Pudding with Bananas, Medjool Dates, Oatmeal Ice Cream, Root Beer Reduction

—Gale Gand, pastry chef, Tru (Chicago)

Banana-Coconut Split with Vanilla Ice Cream, Candied Coconut, Dulce de Leche, Fudge Sauce

—Emily Luchetti, pastry chef, Farallon (San Francisco)

Caramelized Banana Tart with Coconut Ice Cream

—Patrick O’Connell, The Inn at Little Washington (Washington, Virginia)

Banana Tempura with Black Raspberry Ice Cream

—Kaz Okochi, Kaz Sushi Bistro (Washington, DC)

Macadamia Nut Tart with Banana-Rum Ice Cream

—Hiro Sone and Lissa Doumani, Terra (St. Helena, California)

Banana-Toffee Tart

—Sandy D’Amato, Sanford (Milwaukee)

Banana Tempura with Mango Ice Cream

—Sushi-Ko (Washington, DC)

Banana Crème Brûlée, Citrus-Pistachio Biscuit, Beurre Noisette Ice Cream, Peanut Caramel

—Michael Laiskonis, pastry chef, Le Bernardin (New York City)

Caramelized Banana, Smoked Chocolate Ice Cream, Stout

—Sam Mason, wd-50 (New York City)

Dover Sole with “Mostly Traditional Flavors” and Sliced Banana

—Grant Achatz, Alinea (Chicago)

BANANAS

Season: winter

Taste: sweet, astringent

Function: cooling

Weight: medium

Volume: quiet

Techniques: bake, broil, caramelize, deep-fry, grill, poach, raw, sauté

Tips: Sugar enhances the flavor of bananas.

allspice

almonds

apricots

Armagnac

baked goods (e.g., muffins, quick breads)

banana liqueur

blackberries

blueberries

brandy

breakfast

butter, unsalted

buttermilk

butterscotch

cakes

Calvados

CARAMEL

cardamom

cashews

cherries

chile peppers: habanero, jalapeño, serrano

CHOCOLATE: dark, white

cinnamon

cloves

COCONUT AND COCONUT MILK

coffee

cognac

CREAM AND ICE CREAM

cream cheese

crème anglaise

crème fraîche

curries

custard

dates

desserts

figs, dried

ginger

guava

hazelnuts

honey

Kirsch

LEMON, JUICE

lemongrass

lime, juice

macadamia

mangoes: green, ripe

maple syrup

meringue

nutmeg

oats and oatmeal

oil, vegetable

orange

pancakes

papaya

parsley

passion fruit

peanuts and peanut butter

pecans

pepper, black

pineapple

pistachios

pomegranate

puddings

raisins
raspberries: red, black
rice

RUM

salads, fruit
sesame seeds
smoothies and shakes
sour cream
strawberries

SUGAR: BROWN, WHITE

sweet potatoes
Tabasco sauce

vanilla

vinegar, white

walnuts

yogurt

A **banana** in a dessert is an instant sell. Everyone loves caramelized bananas!

—GINA DEPALMA, BABBO (NEW YORK CITY)

I hate overripe **bananas**. We'll actually freeze whole, unpeeled bananas, which will continue to ripen in the freezer and turn black. When we want bananas to use as a puree, we'll pull them out and let them thaw before pureeing, and then add them to a cake or mousse. The flavor is much better this way.

—DOMINIQUE DUBY, WILD SWEETS (VANCOUVER)

I serve a **banana** crème brûlée that is not made in ramekins (the usual individual serving cups) but cut out of a sheet pan and caramelized. I serve this set up in a grid with two squares of crème brûlée, one topped with a little citrus, the other with caramelized bananas—alternated with citrus biscuit, one topped with a brown butter ice cream, and the other with caramelized banana. So I have these three flavors—banana, citrus, and brown butter—tied together with a salted peanut–caramel sauce.

—MICHAEL LAISKONIS, LE BERNARDIN (NEW YORK CITY)

A **banana**'s ripeness will determine what you do with it. I like my bananas yellow and firm. If you are going to make a bananas Foster and your bananas are very yellow, you can cook them longer and they won't fall apart or turn to mush. If you start with a banana that is pretty brown, the second you add heat, it falls apart. A brown banana gives me shivers!

—EMILY LUCHETTI, FARALLON (SAN FRANCISCO)

Flavor Affinities

banana + blackberries + cream

banana + brown butter + caramel + citrus + peanuts

banana + caramel + chocolate

banana + caramel + crème fraîche + lemongrass

banana + coconut + cream

banana + cream + honey + macadamia nuts + vanilla

banana + cream + mango

banana + dates + oatmeal

banana + honey + sesame seeds

banana + macadamia nuts + rum

banana + oats + pecans

BARLEY

Taste: sweet, astringent

Function: cooling

Techniques: simmer

beef

butter

garlic

lemon thyme

mirepoix (carrots, celery, onions)

mushrooms: cultivated, wild (e.g., shiitakes)

olive oil

onions

oregano

parsley, flat-leaf

pepper, white

sage

salt, kosher

savory

scallions

soups

stocks: chicken, vegetable

thyme

tomatoes

vinegar, sherry

I use **basil** a lot. I will add it at the very end of cooking a dish, and it will totally change where the dish is going. Added at the last second, it gives a minty freshness that was not there before. Basil says “fresh” and “alive” to me. And although you can get it year-round, I associate it with summer.

I think particularly of fish and shellfish with basil. I cook a lobster with a sauce of sweet Muscat or Sauternes, curry, and lime. This is a dish that has been played with. The shells have been chopped up, added to mirepoix, and

turned into sauce. Then there's wine. So when the basil hits, you have this whole new thing going on. It opens up the dish and makes it light. It goes against the "worked-on" aspect of the dish.

In Thai cooking, you will find coconut milk-based curry that will have whole leaves of basil in it. Basil becomes something of a vegetable served this way.

—**DAVID WALTUCK**, CHANTERELLE (NEW YORK CITY)

I love **basil** in syrups. It works with strawberries and any citrus fruit. The trio I use the most for summer fruits like berries is basil, lemon, and vanilla. I have even macerated cherry tomatoes in this combination and made them into a fruit crisp.

—**MICHAEL LAISKONIS**, LE BERNARDIN (NEW YORK CITY)

I love **basil**. It is more familiar than cilantro, and more people like it. I use it in ceviche instead of cilantro because it is not as pungent. I combine hamachi tuna with tomato, watermelon, yuzu, and sesame seeds with fresh basil and basil oil.

—**KATSUYA FUKUSHIMA**, MINIBAR (WASHINGTON, DC)

BASIL

(See also Basil, Thai, and Lemon Basil)

Season: summer

Taste: sweet

Weight: light, soft-leaved

Volume: mild–moderate

Tips: Add just before serving. Use to add a note of freshness to a dish.

apricots

Asian cuisine

beans: green, white

bell peppers, esp. red, roasted

berries

blueberries

bread

broccoli

Cambodian cuisine

capers

carrots

**CHEESE: feta, goat, MOZZARELLA, PARMESAN, PECORINO,
RICOTTA**

chicken

chile peppers

chives

chocolate, white

cilantro

cinnamon

coconut milk

corn

crab

cream and ice cream

cucumber

custards

duck

eggplant

EGGS AND EGG DISHES (e.g., omelets)

fennel

fish, esp. grilled or poached

French cuisine

***GARLIC**

ginger, fresh

honey

ITALIAN CUISINE

lamb

lemon, juice

lemon verbena

lime, juice

liver

marjoram

meats

Mediterranean cuisine

mint

mussels

mustard: powder, seeds

nectarines

OLIVE OIL

olives

onions

orange

oregano

Parmesan cheese

parsley, flat-leaf

PASTA DISHES AND SAUCES

peaches

peas

pepper: black, white

PESTO (key ingredient)

pineapple

pine nuts

pizza

pork

potatoes
poultry
rabbit
raspberries
rice
rosemary
salads and salad dressings
salmon
salt: kosher, sea
sauces
scallops
sea bass
shellfish
shrimp
soups, esp. Asian, bean, chowder, vegetable
soy sauce
spinach
squash, summer
summer vegetables
Thai cuisine (e.g., green curries)
thyme
***TOMATOES and tomato sauces**
tuna
vanilla
veal
vegetables, esp. summer
Vietnamese cuisine
vinaigrettes
vinegar: balsamic, sherry
watermelon
ZUCCHINI

AVOID
tarragon

Flavor Affinities

basil + coconut + curry

basil + garlic + olive oil + salt

basil + garlic + olive oil + Parmesan cheese + pine nuts

basil + hamachi tuna + tomatoes + watermelon

basil + lemon + vanilla

basil + mozzarella cheese + tomatoes

basil + olive oil + Parmesan cheese

BASIL, LEMON
(See Lemon Basil)

BASIL, THAI

Taste: anise- or licorice-like

Asian cuisines

beef

coconut milk

curries

ginger

lemongrass

noodles and noodle dishes

oils, esp. pumpkin seed

salads

seafood

soups, esp. Asian

Thai cuisine

vegetarian dishes

venison

I use this in lots of vegetarian dishes because it gives them some oomph. It also works well with meat dishes, from beef to carpaccio to venison. I make a **Thai basil** pesto but make a few adjustments to the recipe or else it can look bruised and take on a funky color. We will add a little pumpkin seed oil to keep it a deep, rich green.

—BRAD FARMERIE, PUBLIC (NEW YORK CITY)

Flavor Affinities

Thai basil + beef + pumpkin seed oil

Thai basil + coconut milk + ginger

BASS

(See also Bass, Sea, and Bass, Striped)

Weight: light

Volume: quiet

Techniques: bake, broil, deepfry, poach, roast, sauté, steam

artichoke

bay leaf

carrots

cayenne

celery

chervil

fennel

garlic

lemon

olive oil

onions

orange: juice, zest

parsley, flat-leaf

pepper: black, white

saffron

salmon

salt, sea

shallots

sole

star anise

stock, fish

tarragon

tomatoes and tomato paste

vanilla

wine, white

Black bass is a fish that can go with the most exotic flavors. We serve black

bass with Peking duck, green papaya salad, and a very light, thin chutney sauce. I love Peking duck and find the flavor very soft and not “duck-y” or aggressive.

—**ERIC RIPERT**, LE BERNARDIN (NEW YORK CITY)

BASS, BLACK

Weight: medium

Volume: quiet

asparagus

basil

beets

butter

cabbage, savoy

carrots

celery

chestnuts

chile peppers, jalapeño

chives

chutney

cilantro

coriander

duck, Peking

endive

fennel

garlic

ginger

ham

honey

leeks

lemon

lemon, preserved

lime

marjoram

mint

mushrooms, porcini

mustard

olive oil

onions

orange, juice
oregano
papaya
parsley, flat-leaf
parsnips
peas
pepper, white
raisins
saffron
salt, sea
scallions
scallops
shallots
shrimp
squash: hubbard, yellow
stock, chicken
tarragon
thyme
tomatoes
tuna
turnips
vinegar: champagne, red wine
wine: red, white
zucchini

Flavor Affinities

black bass + chutney + papaya
black bass + new potatoes + shrimp

In my **black sea bass** in a tamarind-ginger sauce with minted baby onions dish, the tamarind is acidic, and ginger is a nice flavor bridge. I put mint in the onions to cut their sweetness.

—GABRIEL KREUTHER, THE MODERN (NEW YORK CITY)

Dishes

Paupiette of Black Sea Bass in a Crisp Potato Shell, with Tender Leeks and Syrah Sauce

—Daniel Boulud, Daniel (New York City)

Sesame-Crusted Chilean Sea Bass with Baby Shrimp, Clams, and Artichokes

—Patrick O’Connell, The Inn at Little Washington (Washington, Virginia)

Black Bass with Porcini Mushrooms, Braised Parsnips, and Chestnuts

—David Pasternak, Esca (New York City)

Grilled Pacific Sea Bass for Two with Marinated Blood Orange and Lime

—David Pasternak, Esca (New York City)

Crisp Black Sea Bass with Olive-Caper Emulsion

—Alfred Portale, Gotham Bar and Grill (New York City)

Spice-Crusted Black Sea Bass in Sweet and Sour Jus

—Jean-Georges Vongerichten, Jean Georges (New York City)

BASS, SEA

Season: winter–spring

Weight: medium

Volume: quiet

Techniques: bake, broil, ceviche, deep-fry, grill, pan roast, poach, roast, sauté, steam

almonds

anchovies

artichokes

bacon

basil

bay leaf

beans, esp. green or white

beets

bell peppers: red, green

bread crumbs

BUTTER: clarified, salted, unsalted

capers

cardamom

carrots

cayenne

celery

chervil

chives

cilantro

citrus

coriander

corn

cream

crème fraîche

fennel

garlic, fresh

ginger, fresh

hazelnuts

honey

leeks

lemon: juice, zest

lemon, preserved

lentils

lime, juice

marjoram

mayonnaise

mint

mirepoix (carrots, celery, onions)

mirin

MUSHROOMS, esp. button, porcini, or shiitake

mustard, Dijon

new potatoes

oil: canola, peanut, sesame

olive oil

olives, black

onions: pearl, yellow

oregano

parsley, flat-leaf

PEPPER: black, white

potatoes, esp. as a crust, mashed

radishes

rhubarb

saffron

sake

salmon roe

SALT, KOSHER

sauces: beurre blanc, brown butter

scallops

sesame seeds

shallots

shiso

shrimp

soy sauce

spearmint

spinach, esp. baby

star anise

stocks: chicken, fish, vegetable

sugar

tamarind

tarragon

thyme, fresh

TOMATOES: cherry, grape, juice, roasted

vanilla

vermouth

VINEGAR: champagne, red wine, rice, **sherry**, white wine

wine, dry white

yuzu juice

zucchini

Flavor Affinities

sea bass + artichokes + basil + chives + green beans + lemon + new potatoes

sea bass + bacon + corn + fava beans

sea bass + mushrooms + sesame seeds + shrimp

Striped bass is a hearty fish and is one of my favorites. I love roasting it with the skin on to a crisp, and finishing it with butter, garlic, and thyme. It's a fish that pairs well with meat, whether bacon, sweetbreads, or braised pork.

—**BRADFORD THOMPSON**, MARY ELAINE'S AT THE PHOENICIAN (SCOTTSDALE, ARIZONA)

Dishes

Wild Carolina Coast Striped Bass “Riviera” with a Salad of Shaved Fennel, Arugula, and Babaganoush, Cured Tomatoes, Spanish Olives, and Yellow Pepper Broth

—Carrie Nahabedian, Naha (Chicago)

Roasted Local Wild Striped Bass with Hubbard Squash, Caramelized Apple, and Wild Mushrooms

—David Pasternak, Esca (New York City)

Poached Atlantic Striped Bass, Pasilla Chili, Cocoa, Duck Consommé

—Rick Tramonto, Tru (Chicago)

BASS, STRIPED

Weight: medium

Volume: quiet

Techniques: bake, braise, broil, deep-fry, grill, pan roast, poach, raw, roast, sauté, sear, steam

artichokes

bacon

bay leaf

beets

bell peppers: red, yellow

bok choy

butter: clarified, unsalted

buttermilk

calamari

carrots

cauliflower

cayenne

celery

chanterelles

chervil

chile peppers: dried, fresh (e.g., jalapeño)

chives

cilantro

clams

corn

cream

cucumber

curries and curry powder

dill

fava beans

fennel

fish sauce

garlic

ginger
hollandaise sauce
horseradish
leeks
lemon: juice, zest
lemon verbena
lime, juice
mint
monkfish
mushrooms, shiitake
mustard, Dijon
OIL: canola, peanut, sesame, vegetable
olive oil
olives, picholine
onions: pearl, red
orange
paprika, sweet
parsley, flat-leaf
PEPPER: BLACK, GREEN, WHITE
potatoes
prosciutto
rosemary
sage
SALT: KOSHER, SEA
sauerkraut
scallions
sesame seeds
shallots
sour cream
soy sauce
squid
squid ink
stocks: fish, shellfish
Tabasco sauce
thyme, fresh
tomatoes
truffles, black

VINEGAR: champagne, red wine, sherry, white wine
walnuts
wine: port, dry white, Riesling
zucchini

Flavor Affinities

striped bass + bacon + sauerkraut
striped bass + bok choy + fish sauce
striped bass + clam broth + marjoram + spinach
striped bass + curry + sour cream
striped bass + fennel + olives + tomatoes
striped bass + garlic + lemon + thyme
striped bass + leeks + lemon juice + Dijon mustard
striped bass + leeks + shiitake mushrooms

I am a little too fond of **bay leaf**. I use it a lot. I probably have a fondness for it because I associate it with so many childhood flavors, like pot roast. It has a hearty quality to it and I associate it with stocks and big flavors. I will use fresh or dried bay leaf. Fresh bay leaf has fresher flavor and is surprisingly more intense than dried bay leaf, but it's still not as dramatic a difference as you can find with other herbs when it comes to fresh versus dried.

—**DAVID WALTUCK**, CHANTERELLE (NEW YORK CITY)

Inexperienced cooks will throw a handful of **bay leaves** into 40 gallons of veal stock. What happens next is they go to make a sauce and can't figure out what to do about the medicinal taste. It's the bay leaf! I'll explain they only need two or three at the most.

—**CARRIE NAHABEDIAN**, NAHA (CHICAGO)

BAY LEAF

Taste: sweet, bitter

Weight: light, tough-leaved

Volume: quiet–loud, depending on quantity used

Techniques: can stand up to cooking (e.g., simmer, stew)

allspice

apples

beans: dried, white

beef

braised dishes

caramel

cauliflower

celery leaf

cheese dishes

chestnuts

chicken

corn

cream and ice cream

custards

dates

desserts

duck

figs

fish

French cuisine

game

game birds

garlic

grains

juniper berries

lamb

lemon, juice

lentils

marinades

marjoram

meats

Mediterranean cuisine

mole sauce

Moroccan cuisine

onions

parsley

pâté

pears

pepper, black

polenta

pork

pot roast

potatoes

poultry

prunes

pumpkin

quail

rice (e.g., rice pudding) and risotto

rosemary

sage

salmon

saucers

sausage

savory

shellfish, shrimp

SOUPS

spinach

squash: summer, winter

STEWES

STOCKS AND BROTHS

strawberries

swordfish

thyme

tomatoes and tomato sauces

tuna

turkey
Turkish cuisine
vanilla
veal
venison
vinegar

BEANS—IN GENERAL

(See also specific beans below)

carrots

celery

garlic

lemon

marjoram

mint

onions

PARSLEY

rosemary

sage

salt

***SAVORY**

thyme

vinegar

BEANS, BLACK

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: moderate

Techniques: simmer

allspice

apples

avocado

bacon

bay leaf

beer

bell peppers: green, red

butter

Caribbean cuisine

carrots

cayenne

celery

celery root

Central American cuisine

cheese: cheddar, dry feta, farmer's, Parmesan, queso fresco, smoked

CHILE PEPPERS: ancho, cachuca, chipotle, jalapeño

chili powder, ancho

chives

CILANTRO

cream

crème fraîche

CUMIN

duck

egg, esp. hard-boiled

epazote

fennel seeds

GARLIC

ginger

ham and ham hocks

lemon

lime, juice

maple syrup

Mexican cuisine, esp. in the South

OIL: canola, **olive**, peanut, safflower, vegetable

olive oil

ONIONS: red, white, yellow

orange: fruit, juice, zest

oregano, dried

PARSLEY, FLAT-LEAF

pepper: black, white

red pepper flakes

rice

rosemary

salsa

SALT, ESP. KOSHER

salt pork

sausage

SAVORY

scallions

shallots

sherry

shrimp

soups

SOUR CREAM

South American cuisine

Southwestern cuisine

spinach

STOCKS: BEEF, CHICKEN, VEGETABLE

sugar: brown, white

Tabasco sauce

thyme

tomatoes and tomato paste

vinegar: cider, red wine, sherry, white wine

wine: Madeira, sherry

yogurt

Dishes

Black Bean Soup Flavored with Grilled Wild Ramps, Avocado Leaf, and Cilantro, Studded with Sweet Roasted Chayote and Corn, Topped with Green Chile Salsa and Crispy Tortilla Strips

—Rick Bayless, Frontera Grill (Chicago)

Black Bean Tamales Filled with Homemade Goat Cheese in “Guisado” of Wild and Woodland Mushrooms, Organic Roasted Tomatoes, Green Chile, and Mint; Watercress Salad

—Rick Bayless, Frontera Grill (Chicago)

Black Beans Fried with Garlic, Onion, and Epazote, Topped with Mexican Fresh Cheese

—Rick Bayless, Frontera Grill (Chicago)

Flavor Affinities

black beans + cumin + green bell peppers + oregano

black beans + lemon + sherry

BEANS, BROAD

(See Beans, Fava)

BEANS, BUTTER
(See Beans, Lima)

BEANS, CANNELLINI

(See also Beans, White)

Weight: medium

Volume: quiet–moderate

Techniques: braise, puree, simmer

bacon

carrots

celery

clams

garlic

Italian cuisine

lamb

lemon

olive oil

onions, esp. Spanish

paprika, sweet

PARSLEY, FLAT-LEAF

pepper, black

saffron

salads

salt, kosher

sausages (e.g., chorizo)

SAVORY

soups

stock, chicken

tarragon

thyme

tomatoes, esp. plum

Dishes

Cannellini Bean Soup with Smoked Trout Croquette and Pumpkin Seed Oil
—Gabriel Kreuther, The Modern (New York City)



BEANS, FAVA

(aka Broad Beans or Horse Beans)

Season: spring–summer

Taste: bitter

Weight: light–medium

Volume: moderate

Techniques: boil, puree, simmer

Asian cuisine

bacon

basil butter, unsalted

CHEESE: dry feta, manchego, Parmesan, pecorino, ricotta, sheep's milk

chile peppers

chives, fresh

cilantro

corn

cream

cumin

curry

dill

duck

falafel (key ingredient)

fennel

fish (e.g., salmon)

garlic

gnocchi

greens, bitter

ham

herbs

Italian cuisine

lamb

leeks

lemon, juice

lentils

lobster

Mediterranean cuisine

Mexican cuisine

Middle Eastern cuisine

mint (e.g., Italian cuisine)

Moroccan cuisine

OIL, walnut

OLIVE OIL

onions, esp. spring

orange, zest

oregano

PARSLEY, FLAT-LEAF

pasta

peas

pepper, black

poultry (e.g., turkey)

prosciutto

rabbit

radishes

rice and risotto

rosemary

sage, fresh

salads

salt: kosher, sea

SAVORY (e.g., as in French cuisine)

shellfish (e.g., lobster)

shallots

soups

spinach

steak

stir-fries

stock, chicken

thyme

tomatoes

vinaigrette

vinegar, cider

walnuts

yogurt

Fava beans have a great flavor. Cooks in the past would blanch them, and the flavor would be left in the water. Today, what I like to do with favas and other vegetables is to put them in a pan with a little water, olive oil, or butter, and to cover them while they cook. That way, all the flavor stays in the vegetables. If I could cook for my customers the way I like to cook and eat at home, I would sweat some spring onions in a pan with butter or oil, covered, to keep in the flavor. Then I'd add the shucked fava beans and let them cook with a little water. At the last second, I'd toss in some chopped parsley or basil, and there's your sauce. This would be great under some fish. If you added some thyme and maybe a little lamb *jus*, it would also work with lamb.

—**TRACI DES JARDINS**, JARDINIÈRE (SAN FRANCISCO)

Fava beans have a very delicate flavor, I like them raw and tender by themselves—or combined with sheep's milk cheese and olive oil. However, I wouldn't use an olive oil that's too peppery or spicy, because it would overwhelm them.

—**TONY LIU**, AUGUST (NEW YORK CITY)

Flavor Affinities

fava beans + basil + spring onions

fava beans + garlic + olive oil + rosemary

fava beans + lamb + thyme

fava beans + olive oil + pecorino cheese + prosciutto

fava beans + olive oil + thyme

fava beans + sheep's milk cheese + olive oil

BEANS, FLAGEOLET

Weight: light–medium

Volume: quiet

Techniques: simmer

apples

arugula

basil

bay leaf

butter

carrots

cassoulet

celery

cheese, esp. manchego or pecorino

chicken

cream

fines herbes

fish (e.g., cod)

French cuisine, esp. Provençal

garlic

***LAMB**

lemon, juice

lime

marjoram

olive oil

onions, esp. red, sweet, yellow

orange

PARSLEY

pasta

pepper, black

pork, esp. roasted

poultry

salads

salt

SAVORY

shallots

soups

stocks: chicken, vegetable

tarragon

thyme

tomatoes and tomato sauces

vinegar, red wine

wine, dry white

Flavor Affinities

flageolet beans + garlic + thyme

Dishes

Pasta with Basil Pesto, Green Beans, and Potatoes

—Lidia Bastianich, Felidia (New York City)

BEANS, GARBANZO

(See Chickpeas)

BEANS, GREEN

Season: summer–autumn

Weight: light–medium

Volume: moderate

Techniques: boil, grill, sauté, steam, stir-fry

almonds

anchovies

bacon

BASIL

bay leaf

beans, shell

bell pepper, red

bread crumbs

butter, unsalted

capers

carrots

cayenne

CHEESE: Asiago, blue, feta, goat, **PARMESAN**

chervil

chickpeas

chile peppers

chives

cilantro

coconut

corn

cream

crème fraîche

cumin

curry leaves

dill

eggs, esp. hard-boiled

fennel

French cuisine

garlic

ginger, fresh

ham (e.g., Serrano)

lemon, juice

lemon balm

lime, juice

lovage

marjoram

Mediterranean cuisine

mint

mushrooms

mustard, Dijon

mustard seeds, black

nuts

OIL: peanut, sesame

OLIVE OIL

olives: black, niçoise

ONIONS, esp. green, pearl, or red

oregano

pancetta

paprika: smoked, sweet

PARSLEY

peanuts

pepper: black, white

Pernod

pork

potatoes

prosciutto

red pepper flakes

rosemary

sage

salt, kosher

SAVORY, SUMMER

shallots

shrimp

soy sauce

stock, chicken

sugar

tamari

tarragon

thyme

TOMATOES

vinaigrettes

VINEGAR: red wine, rice wine, sherry, tarragon, white wine

walnuts

yogurt

Flavor Affinities

green beans + anchovies + garlic + Parmesan cheese + walnuts

green beans + mustard + prosciutto + vinaigrette + walnuts

BEANS, KIDNEY

Taste: sweet-astringent

Function: cooling

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate

Techniques: boil, simmer

bacon

bay leaf

bell pepper, esp. red

cardamom

carrots

cayenne

chile peppers: dried red, fresh green

chili

chorizo

cinnamon

cloves

coriander

cumin

curry leaves

garam masala

garlic

ginger

Indian cuisine

Italian cuisine, esp. Tuscan

olive oil

onions, esp. red, sweet, white

PARSLEY

pepper, black

pork

potatoes

saffron

salt

sauerkraut

SAVORY

thyme

tomatoes

turmeric

wine, red

BEANS, LIMA

Season: summer

Taste: bitter

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate

Techniques: simmer, steam

bacon

bay leaf

butter

Central American cuisine

chile peppers

cilantro

cream

cumin

curries

dill

fish

garlic

greens, bitter

ham and ham hocks

herbs

leeks

lemon, juice

mint

New England cuisine (e.g., succotash)

olive oil

onions

oregano

PARSLEY, FLAT-LEAF

pepper, ground

poultry, esp. chicken

rosemary

sage

salt, kosher
savory
shallots
shellfish (e.g., shrimp)
sorrel
soul food cuisine
Southern cuisine (American)
spinach
steak
succotash (key ingredient)
thyme
tomatoes and tomato sauce
tuna
vinegar

BEANS, NAVY

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate

Techniques: simmer

bacon

baked beans

basil

bay leaf

cayenne

cheese: Parmesan, ricotta

chili powder

garlic

ketchup

molasses

mustard: Dijon, yellow

olive oil

ONIONS, ESP. YELLOW

PARSLEY

pasta

pepper

salads

salt, kosher

SAVORY

soups

sugar, brown

thyme

tomatoes

vinegar, red wine

BEANS, PINTO

Season: winter

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate

Techniques: refry, simmer

bacon

cheese: feta, queso fresco

chile peppers: chipotle, jalapeño, poblano, serrano

chili

cilantro

cumin

epazote

garlic

Mexican cuisine, esp. northern

mint

oil: safflower, vegetable

onions, white

oregano, dried

paprika

PARSLEY

pork

refried beans (key ingredient)

SALT

SAVORY

scallions

sour cream

Southwestern cuisine

tequila

tomatoes

Flavor Affinities

pinto beans + bacon + poblano chiles + tomatoes

BEANS, RED

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate

Techniques: simmer

bell peppers, esp. green

chile peppers

chili (key ingredient)

chorizo

garlic

Mexican cuisine

olive oil

onions

PARSLEY

pork

sausage

SAVORY

Southwestern cuisine

stews

Dishes

A Latin Cassoulet of White Beans, Sausages, Smoked Bacon, and Kale Braised Slowly in the Wood-Burning Oven, with Spicy Sauce and Rice

—Maricel Presilla, Cucharamama (Hoboken, New Jersey)

Soup: White Bean Puree with Rosemary Oil

—Judy Rodgers, Zuni Café (San Francisco)

BEANS, WHITE

(e.g., Cannellini, Navy)

Season: winter

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate

ale or beer, dark

ancho chili powder

apricots, dried

arugula

bacon

basil

bay leaf

bouquet garni

bourbon

broccoli rabe

butter, unsalted

carrots

celery

cheese: manchego, **Parmesan**, Pecorino Romano

chile peppers, dried

chives

cloves

cream

fennel

GARLIC

ginger, ground

Italian cuisine

ham

lamb

lemon, juice

maple syrup

mirepoix (carrots, celery, onions)

molasses

mushrooms, wild

mustard, dry

OIL, peanut

OLIVE OIL

ONIONS (e.g., cipollini, red, sweet)

PARSLEY, FLAT-LEAF

pasta

PEPPER: black, white

pork

prosciutto

red pepper flakes

rosemary

rum, dark

sage

SALT: KOSHER, SEA

SAVORY

shallots

soups

squash, winter

stocks: chicken, vegetable

sugar, brown

tarragon

thyme

tomatoes and tomato paste

truffles

vinegar: balsamic, cider, red wine

wine, dry white

Flavor Affinities

white beans + olive oil + pecorino cheese

white beans + olive oil + rosemary + balsamic vinegar

white beans + broccoli rabe + wild mushrooms

Dishes

“Brasato al Barolo” Braised Beef with Porcini Mushrooms

—Mario Batali, Babbo (New York City)

Mochomos: Crispy, Crunchy Shredded Montana Natural Beef with Crispy White Onion Strings, Guacamole, Spicy Chile Salsa, and Warm Tortillas for Making Soft Tacos

—Rick Bayless, Topolobampo (Chicago)

Balsamic-Caramel Beef Cubes with Sticky Rice and Toasted Coconut

—Monica Pope, T’afia (Houston)

Chateaubriand, Wild Mushrooms, Porcini-Flavored Diced Yukon Gold Potatoes, Syrah Sauce

—Michel Richard, Citronelle (Washington, DC)

Ground Beef with Cream and Fenugreek on Yucca

—Vikram Vij and Meeru Dhalwala, Vij’s (Vancouver)

BEEF—IN GENERAL

Taste: sweet

Function: heating

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: moderate

Techniques: See also individual cuts of beef.

Tips: Clove adds richness to beef.

allspice

bacon

basil

bay leaf

beans, green

béarnaise sauce

beer

bouquet garni

brandy

butter, unsalted

capers

carrots

cayenne

celery

cheese, blue (e.g., Cabrales)

chiles, esp. dried and pasilla

chives

chocolate and cocoa powder

cilantro

cinnamon

cloves

coffee and espresso

cognac

coriander

corn

cornichons

cream

cumin

curry

fat: chicken, goose

foie gras

GARLIC

ginger

herbs

horseradish

hyssop

leeks

marrow, beef

mint

miso, red

mushrooms, esp. porcini or shiitake

mustard, Dijon

oil: canola, sesame

olive oil

ONIONS: green, red, Spanish, yellow

orange

oregano

parsley, flat-leaf

PEPPER: BLACK, white

potatoes

red pepper flakes

rosemary

saffron

salt: fleur de sel, kosher

shallots

soy sauce

spinach (accompaniment)

stocks: beef, chicken, veal

sugar (pinch)

tarragon

thyme

tomatoes and tomato paste

truffles

turnips

vinaigrette

vinegar: cider, red wine, rice wine, sherry, tarragon

wine: red (e.g., Cabernet Sauvignon, Merlot), Madeira

zucchini

Flavor Affinities

beef + beer + onions

beef + garlic + ginger

beef + garlic + tomatoes

beef + mushrooms + potatoes

beef + mushrooms + red wine

beef + porcini mushrooms + red wine

I love blue cheese with **beef**. We make a dish with blue cheese sauce that has chicken stock, Dijon mustard, truffle juice, and fresh truffle. This is a sauce that has many layers of flavor. The mustard is barely there but adds much more flavor to the sauce than vinegar or lemon would. The sauce is served on a [beef] filet that has been poached in spiced red wine. The poaching liquid is made with Cabernet Sauvignon that has been reduced for 25 minutes to concentrate its flavor, juniper berries, pepper, star anise, fennel seeds, and cloves. The cooked tannin in the wine really brings up the meaty flavor of the beef.

—**GABRIEL KREUTHER**, THE MODERN (NEW YORK CITY)

All cuts of **beef** have a different flavor profile: There is the big beefy flavor of the strip steak, the luxurious tenderness of filet mignon, and the juicy, fatty mouthfeel of a great rib eye. Skirt steak is a juicy cut that is great served as an open-faced sandwich. Hanger steak has an offal quality to it and is different from all the others. Braised short ribs pick up all of the flavors of what they are cooked with, developing layers of deep, dark beef flavor after being cooked on the bone for hours.

—**MICHAEL LOMONACO**, PORTER HOUSE NEW YORK (NEW YORK CITY)

We make a wood-grilled 18-ounce “prime” rib eye of **beef** with a gratin of macaroni and goat cheese, glazed shallots, oxtail red wine sauce, and *fleur de sel*. This dish is meat on meat on meat! We have the steak, oxtail sauce, and shallots braised in veal stock. This dish has so much flavor. You have the richness and fattiness of the rib eye, and we grill it over a wood fire that takes it to a whole other place. Top it with a drizzle of olive oil, the *fleur de sel*, cracked pepper, and then add rich oxtail sauce to it. People go crazy for it.

—**CARRIE NAHABEDIAN**, NAHA (CHICAGO)

You can braise **brisket** for hours, and it still tastes like brisket, making it ideal to prepare for large parties. Nothing is better than what the Texans do with brisket, and that is barbecue. I also noticed that Texans get the fattiest brisket I have ever seen, so the fat just melts away and the meat is self-basting. My favorite barbecued brisket is from Mueller’s outside of Austin. He cooks it about twenty hours and then wraps it in brown butcher paper to let it rest—which I think is the key to his barbecue.

—**MICHAEL LOMONACO**, PORTER HOUSE NEW YORK (NEW YORK CITY)

BEEF—BRISKET

Techniques: barbecue, braise, corn, roast, simmer, smoke

barbecue rub

barbecue sauce

bay leaf

beer

cabbage, with corned beef brisket

chili powder

cinnamon

cumin

fennel seeds

garlic

horseradish

maple syrup

mirepoix

mustard

olive oil

onions

pasilla peppers

pepper, black

potatoes

rosemary

salt

soups

star anise

stews

stock, beef

sugar, brown

thyme

tomatoes and tomato paste

vinegar: sherry, wine

wine, red

Dishes

Kobe Beef, Sautéed Foie Gras, Shaved Black Truffle, Madeira Sauce on an Onion Bun
—Hubert Keller, Burger Bar (Las Vegas)

Kobe Beef Carpaccio, Shaved Parmesan, Arugula, and Horseradish Sauce
—Frank Stitt, Highlands Bar and Grill (Birmingham, Alabama)

BEEF—CHEEKS

Techniques: braise

apples
bay leaf
butter, unsalted
carrots
celery
celery root
chives
cinnamon
cloves
garlic
horseradish
leeks
mustard
oil, peanut
onions
pasta (e.g., gnocchi, ravioli)
pepper, black
potatoes, esp. mashed and/or new
risotto
rosemary
salt, kosher
stock, chicken
tarragon
thyme, fresh
tomatoes
vegetables, root
vinegar, balsamic
wine, red (e.g., Burgundy)

BEEF—KOBE

arugula
cheese, Parmesan
chives
garlic
ginger
horseradish
Japanese cuisine
Madeira
mushrooms
oil, sesame
olive oil
onions
pepper, black
salt, sea
sesame seeds
soy sauce
truffles, black
yuzu juice

BEEF—LOIN

(aka shell, sirloin, tenderloin)

Techniques: pan roast, roast

butter, unsalted

five-spice powder

ginger

oil, peanut

paprika

pepper: black, white

rosemary, fresh

salt: kosher, sea

sauces

soy sauce

thyme, fresh

wasabi

BEEF—OXTAILS

Techniques: braise, stew

allspice

anise

basil

bay leaf

beans, esp. white

beer

bell peppers

cheese: Asiago, pecorino

garlic

ginger

gnocchi

leeks

Madeira

mushrooms

mustard

olive oil

ONIONS

orange

parsley, flat-leaf

parsnips

pasta (e.g., ravioli, tortellini)

pepper, black

potatoes, esp. mashed risotto

salt

scallops

shallots

soups

stews

stocks: beef, chicken

thyme

tomatoes and tomato sauce

WINE, RED
wine, white

Dishes

Cream of Sweet Onion, Braised Beef Oxtail, Aged Parmesan Tuile

—Jean Joho, Everest (Chicago)

Flavor Affinities

oxtails + parsnips + red wine

oxtails + red wine + thyme + tomatoes

BEEF—RIBS

Techniques: barbecue, braise, (dry) roast

barbecue sauce

spice rub

BEEF—ROAST

Techniques: roast

brandy

chocolate

coffee

garlic

horseradish

mushrooms, wild

rosemary

saucés: béarnaise, red wine (esp. Madeira or port)

soy sauce

thyme

wine, red

BEEF—ROUND

Techniques: grill, sauté, stir-fry

bell peppers: red, green

chili powder

cilantro

cumin

garlic

lime, juice

olive oil

onions, red

parsley

radishes

Tabasco sauce

BEEF—SHANK

Techniques: braise

garlic
ginger
lemon
onions, green
paprika
pepper, black
sesame oil
soy sauce
sugar

BEEF—SHORT LOIN

This is the T-bone steak. When it is cut double cut [that is, twice as thick], that is when it is a porterhouse. The story goes that it was first served in Lower Manhattan in 1815 at a porter house. The owner ran out of his usual cut of meat, and when a customer asked for something to go with his porter [beer], the owner cut him this huge piece of meat. It became known as a “porterhouse” steak. The porterhouse steak is part filet mignon and part strip steak. It is the perfect grilling steak. You get the tenderness of the filet, and the big beefy chewiness of the strip steak.

—**MICHAEL LOMONACO**, PORTER HOUSE NEW YORK (NEW YORK CITY)

Vikram Vij of Vancouver's Vij's on Beef Short Ribs in Cinnamon

For braising, I prefer to use cinnamon bark. Cinnamon stick is pretty, but it is steamed and rolled and a little too manipulated. In this dish, cinnamon bark is big and intense and not needed for presentation. At the end of the braise, you pull it out and throw it away. This dish is cooked for four hours and the cinnamon flavor does not cook out. In the end, the cinnamon imparts a delicate, sweet, aromatic flavor. It adds contrast to the chile flavor from the curry. If this dish ever has too much cinnamon flavor, you can counterbalance it with rice or yogurt that has a little salt and pepper in it.

—VIKRAM VIJ, VIJ'S (VANCOUVER)

BEEF—SHORT RIBS

Techniques: barbecue, braise, stew

bacon

basil

bay leaf

beer or ale

butter, unsalted

carrots

celery: stalk, leaves

celery root

chervil

chile peppers, esp. hot cherry

chives

cilantro

cinnamon

coriander

garam masala (Indian cuisine)

GARLIC

ginger

gremolata

grits

horseradish

leeks

lemon: juice, zest

lime

mirepoix

mushrooms: porcini, wild

mustard: Dijon, Meaux

molasses

OIL: canola, corn, grapeseed, hazelnut, peanut, sesame, vegetable, walnut

olive oil

ONIONS, esp. green, pearl, white, or yellow

orange: juice, zest

oregano

parsley, flat-leaf

parsnips

peas

PEPPER: black, Szechuan, white

potatoes, esp. mashed

prosciutto

rosemary

sage

salt, kosher

savory

shallots

sherry, dry

soy sauce

star anise

STOCK: BEEF, CHICKEN, VEAL

sugar: brown, white (pinch)

tamarind

tarragon

THYME, FRESH

tomatoes, tomato paste, and tomato sauce

turnips (accompaniment)

vinegar: balsamic, sherry

WINE, DRY RED (e.g., Barolo, Cabernet Sauvignon, Merlot, Zinfandel)

wine, white, esp. fruity

Worcestershire sauce



Dishes

Short Ribs with Braised Boston Lettuce, Peppered Shallot Confit

—Daniel Boulud, Daniel (New York City)

Braised Short Ribs with Parsnip Puree, Porcini Mushrooms, and Barolo

—Scott Bryan, Veritas (New York City)

Slow-Roasted Short Ribs with Stone-Ground Grits

—Cesare Casella, Maremma (New York City)

Garlic Braised Short Ribs with Parsnip Puree, Baby Round Carrots in Carrot Butter, Haricots Verts, and Cabernet Sauce

—Bob Kinkead, Colvin Run (Vienna, Virginia)

Braised Short Ribs of Beef with Soft Grits and Meaux Mustard Sauce

—Gray Kunz, Café Gray (New York City)

Braised Short Ribs of Beef, Wild Boar Bacon, and Cauliflower Puree with Roasted Winter Root Vegetables and Cipollini Onions, Smoked “Manuka” Sea Salt, and Herb Salad

—Carrie Nahabedian, Naha (Chicago)

Short Ribs Braised and Then Caramelized on the Grill with Ginger and Soy

—Kaz Okochi, Kaz Sushi Bistro (Washington, DC)

Braised Short Ribs in Red Wine Sauce, Brown Loaf Sugar and Mustard Crust, Stir-Fried Quinoa and Swiss Chard

—Maricel Presilla, Cucharamama (Hoboken, New Jersey)

Beef Short Ribs in Cinnamon and Red Wine Curry

—Vikram Vij and Meeru Dhalwala, Vij's (Vancouver)

Short ribs are a luxurious cut of meat, because they are braised for three to three and a half hours. We don't braise our ribs in red wine, but in Yuengling Porter, which has ethereal chocolate notes in the aroma. In the sauce with the beer is mirepoix, a sachet of herbs, lots of peppercorns, and chiles. I went to a charity event where they served short ribs for six hundred guests, and one reason it worked is because it is a cut that allows for a great margin of error. You cook it until it is well done and falling-off-the-bone tender. Falling-off-the-bone tender is one of the appeals of a braised dish. It is sensual. Get yourself a glass of good spicy Syrah with that short rib dish and think great thoughts!

—MICHAEL LOMONACO, PORTER HOUSE NEW YORK (NEW YORK CITY)

Flavor Affinities

short ribs + bay leaf + beer + mushrooms + mustard

short ribs + beer + garlic + horseradish + onions + potatoes + tomatoes

short ribs + carrots + mushrooms + parsnips

short ribs + celery root + horseradish

short ribs + cinnamon + tomatoes + red wine

short ribs + horseradish + lemon + parsley

short ribs + onions + potatoes + red wine

short ribs + potatoes + root vegetables

BEEF—STEAK: IN GENERAL

Techniques: broil, grill, sauté

aligot (French garlic-cheesy pureed potatoes)

allspice

arugula

basil

bay leaf

béarnaise sauce

brandy

butter, unsalted

capers

cayenne

celery root

chard

cheese, Parmesan

chile peppers

chives

cilantro

cloves

cognac

coriander

cream

cumin

five-spice powder

fish sauce, Thai

GARLIC

ginger, fresh

herbs, esp. *herbes de Provence*

honey

horseradish

juniper berries

lemon: juice, zest

lemongrass

lime, juice
marrow
mushrooms (e.g., chanterelles, cremini, shiitake)
mustard, Dijon
oil: canola, grapeseed, sesame, vegetable
olive oil
onions: red, white
parsley, flat-leaf
PEPPER: black, green, pink, Szechuan, white
port
potatoes, French fries
red pepper flakes
rice
rosemary
salt, kosher
scallions
shallots
sherry, dry
soy sauce
stocks: beef, veal
sugar (pinch)
tamarind
tarragon
thyme
vinegar: balsamic, champagne, Chinese black, cider, red wine, rice wine, sherry,
white wine
watercress
WINE, DRY RED (e.g., Beaujolais, Chianti)

I like to keep it simple and serve **steak** au poivre with a peppercorn crust and deglazed with bourbon or even good ole American rye, which has more flavor. I also like steak with a margarita sauce, which is a good, zingy sauce made with tequila, orange, and lemon zest, and finished with roasted chile peppers.

—MICHAEL LOMONACO, PORTER HOUSE NEW YORK (NEW YORK CITY)

Flavor Affinities

steak + arugula + Parmesan cheese + balsamic vinegar

steak + bacon + potatoes + red wine

steak + Chianti + lemon + salt steak + cremini mushrooms + watercress

steak + horseradish + mustard + potatoes

steak + shallots + red wine

BEEF—STEAK: CHUCK

Techniques: braise, grill, stew

This cut is really beefy, flavorful, and fatty, but tough. **Chuck steak** can be grilled, but it also works well for braising. A chuck also makes a good cut for stew because it has nice fat. When I was growing up, a “steak Episole” was chuck steak that had good fat, was seared well, and then cooked slowly with tomatoes, onions, and fresh oregano. You may not see chuck steak a lot on menus, but you see it a lot in burgers. In fact, this is my favorite meat for a burger. I like my mix to be 75 to 80 percent lean and 20 to 25 percent fat.

—**MICHAEL LOMONACO**, PORTER HOUSE NEW YORK (NEW YORK CITY)

BEEF—STEAK: FILET MIGNON

(aka Beef Tenderloin)

Techniques: broil, grill, sauté

bacon

butter, unsalted

cognac

cream

foie gras

garlic

leeks

mushrooms, esp. morels, porcini

oil, peanut

olive oil

onions

pepper: black, green

port

potatoes

rosemary

salt

shallots

sherry

stocks: beef, mushroom, veal

thyme

vinegar, balsamic

wine: dry red, Madeira

Dishes

Seared Rib Eye, Caramelized Yukon Gold Potatoes, and Chanterelles

—Daniel Boulud, Daniel (New York City)

Strip Loin Poached in Butter and Roasted with Sea Salt, Short Ribs Stuffed in Cremini Mushrooms with Potato Boulangère, Spinach Puree, and Foie Gras Hollandaise

—Jeffrey Buben, Vidalia (Washington, DC)

Dry-Aged New York Steak with Slow-Cooked Broccoli, Garlic, and Lemon, Fingerling Potatoes, Niçoise Olive Jus

—Traci Des Jardins, Jardinière (San Francisco)

Skirt Steak Marinated in Seville Oranges and Lime Juice

—Maricel Presilla, Zafra (Hoboken, New Jersey)

Strawberry Mountain New York Strip, Grilled Lettuce, Olive Oil–Poached Tomato, and Lemon Cream

—Cory Schreiber, Wildwood (Portland, Oregon)

Cast Iron–Seared Porcini-Crusted New York Sirloin Steak, Roasted Garlic Mash Potatoes, Black Trumpet Ragout, Braised Kale, Rum au Poivre

—Allen Susser, Chef Allen's (Aventura, Florida)

BEEF—STEAK: FLANK

Techniques: broil, grill, sauté, stir-fry

chile peppers, esp. chipotle or jalapeño

cilantro

cumin

garlic

hoisin sauce

honey

lime, juice

molasses

mustard, brown

oil: peanut, sesame

olive oil

oregano

salsa, esp. tomato

salt

soy sauce

sugar

thyme

vinegar, balsamic

Filet mignon gets no respect from many chefs because it doesn't have much beef flavor, but it is still the most popular cut in restaurants. I like to sear it and pan roast it with a little olive oil or an olive oil and butter combination. It is not a well-used muscle on the inside of the short loin, so filet is always tender. On the other side of the bone from the more worked side of the strip steak is the tail end of the filet. Béarnaise sauce [i.e., vinegar, shallots, egg yolks, butter, etc.] is a classic accompaniment to filet mignon.

—MICHAEL LOMONACO, PORTER HOUSE NEW YORK (NEW YORK CITY)

Dishes

Grilled Filet Mignon, Crisp Potatoes, Spinach, and Roasted Garlic Custard

—Alfred Portale, Gotham Bar and Grill (New York City)

Tournedos of Beef Tenderloin Worthy of a Splurge: Twin Filets of Beef Tenderloin Set on Brioche Toast, Slathered with Foie Gras Butter, and Served with Truffle Sauce, PortBraised Cipollini Onions, Fingerling Potatoes, Spring Mushrooms, and Leek Puree

—Janos Wilder, Janos (Tucson)

Dishes

Flank Steak with Marinated Mushrooms, Artichokes, Tomatoes, Summer Squash, Whipple Farm Greens, Yellow Taxi Tomato Vinaigrette, and Basil-Garlic Aioli

—Jeffrey Buben, Vidalia (Washington, DC)

Green Peppercorn Marinated Flank Steak with Balsamic Roasted Onions, Tomatoes, and Thai Barbecue Sauce

—Charlie Trotter, Trotter's to Go (Chicago)

Miso-marinated grilled **steak** will help to release the flavors of everything else you pair with it. Use red miso alone, or in combination with garlic, ginger, mirin [sweet rice wine], sesame oil, soy sauce, and/or sugar.

—**HIRO SONE**, TERRA (ST. HELENA, CALIFORNIA)

BEEF—STEAK: HANGER

Techniques: broil, grill, sauté

bell peppers
brandy
celery root
ginger
mushrooms
mustard
onions
parsnips
pepper, black
salsa verde
scallions
soy sauce
thyme
wine, red

Dishes

Hanger Steak Pizzaiola with Local Peppers, Salsa Verde, Natural Juices

—Andrew Carmellini, A Voce (New York City)

BEEF—STEAK: RIB EYE

Techniques: broil, grill, sauté, stir-fry

garlic

mushrooms, porcini (dried)

olive oil

oregano

pepper, black

red pepper flakes

rosemary

vinegar: balsamic, red wine

BEEF—STEAK: SKIRT

Techniques: broil, grill, sauté

allspice
anchovies
butter
capers
chile peppers, ancho
cinnamon
cumin
endive, Belgian
garlic
lime: juice, zest
mustard
oil, canola
olive oil
onions, red
oregano
paprika
parsley, flat-leaf
red pepper flakes
rosemary
salt: kosher, sea
scallions
soy sauce
thyme
vinegar, balsamic

BEEF—STEAK TARTARE

We make **tartare** from filet mignon and hand-chop it to order, which I like so that I don't feel like I'm just eating ground beef. I season our tartare with mustard, capers, and anchovies, which I am not shy about. You want the texture of the beef to be a counterpoint.

—MICHAEL LOMONACO, PORTER HOUSE NEW YORK (NEW YORK CITY)

Skirt steak comes in a long strip and looks like a belt—it's about two feet long and a couple of inches wide. This is an incredibly flavorful cut and delicious. It is very reasonably priced as well. It is very popular in the Latin community, especially with Argentinians. You often see it flattened with a mallet to tenderize it [by breaking the meat fibers] and used in fajitas. This, along with the hanger steak, is the beefiest flavored cut of beef. We serve it in a chimichurri sauce, which is a classic Argentinian sauce made of chopped garlic, onion, and parsley, plus white [we use champagne] vinegar, red pepper flakes, and a little olive oil. It grills really well.

—MICHAEL LOMONACO, PORTER HOUSE NEW YORK (NEW YORK CITY)

Michael Lomonaco of Porter House New York on Cooking Steak

Aging: Aging is important because it tenderizes the steak. The aging process breaks down the fibers and dehydrates the steak, concentrating its flavor. A dryaged steak has a more minerally and sharp edge to it, versus fresh meat that tastes sweeter. It is critical to the flavor and adds to the cost because it takes four weeks of aging to achieve it.

Seasoning: All our steaks are seasoned with coarse kosher salt and freshly ground black pepper just prior to cooking, which draws out the flavor while they cook. A squeeze of lemon makes a good Tuscan steak taste even better. If you are in Italy and eating “bistecca Fiorentina,” what you are having is an Italian porterhouse. The steak is grilled over dried grape vines and served with a drizzle of green olive oil from the first pressing of the new harvest and lemons on the side.

Cooking: A steak should be cooked rare to medium rare. “Rare” is a little cool inside and hot on the exterior. “Medium rare” is just a shade past, and only warm in the middle. Cooking a steak beyond that point, it starts to toughen up and the fat oozes out, making it increasingly dry and tough.

Saucing: Part of looking forward is looking back. Sauces provide the connection to historical French and Italian cooking. In the gastronomic world, the saucier was the top cook in the kitchen. It is all about building layer upon layer of complexity in a sauce. It is most often sweet and sour, to cut through the richness of the fat of the steak. Red wine sauce has the acidity to cut richness, with sweetness from caramelized shallots, and it enhances the beef flavor. We also make a homemade barbecue sauce as our steak sauce, which is sweet from light brown sugar and molasses, tart from red wine vinegar, and smoky from chipotle peppers.

Hanger steak is known as an *onglet* in French and is found on bistro menus. It is also a great value, which is why you see it on menus in smaller restaurants. A hanger steak is incredibly flavorful. There is only one per carcass, and it comes from the area close to the kidneys, so it has almost an offal flavor to the beef. It has become popular because it is different and not a typical-tasting steak. I like a hanger steak grilled and served rare to medium rare. Slicing is also important, because you have to cut it on the bias so that it is tender. I like a hanger steak served with a traditional sauce, such as a caramelized shallot and red wine sauce or a bourbon peppercorn sauce. It is important to caramelize the shallots so they get sweet and offset the gaminess of the steak. I use bourbon instead of cognac because it has more punch to it, and I’ll use four different peppercorns—white, black, pink, and green—with the last two modulating the flavor. Green peppercorns have the sharpness to cut through the richness.

—MICHAEL LOMONACO, PORTER HOUSE NEW YORK (NEW YORK CITY)

Rib steak is the most popular cut next to filet mignon. The cut comes from the rib roast, where one end meets the chuck at the fattier end and the other meets the short loin at the leaner end. The rib steak that meets the chuck end is the most popular and can even have a big knot of fat in it. This is one of my favorite steaks. A big, fatty, juicy rib steak can't be beat on the grill. I cook these bone-on because it gives more beef flavor. We do a Brandt Ranch cut that comes from California just north of Mexico. That area has lots of flavor influences, so I choose to do a chili rub on the steak. The cut is Holstein, which has a sweeter edge to its meat. We grill it so that fat melts away and bastes it as it cooks. At the end, we brush it with a blend of ancho chili, light brown sugar, toasted ground cumin seeds, chipotle chile, and a pinch of cayenne. Then we char it one more time, so that is like reseasoning the meat.

—**MICHAEL LOMONACO**, PORTER HOUSE NEW YORK (NEW YORK CITY)

The **sirloin** is a good, beefy-flavored high-quality cut. It is a cut toward the back of the animal that gets more work, so it is a little chewy, but it is a good-quality steak for barbecuing. If this cut is quickly cooked over high heat on a grill, not overcooked, and sliced correctly on the bias, you are going to get the most out of it.

—**MICHAEL LOMONACO**, PORTER HOUSE NEW YORK (NEW YORK CITY)

When you see rare roast beef, it is **top round**. It is a little tough, and that is why you see roast beef always sliced so thin. Nothing beats top round for a good old-fashioned roast beef sandwich because it doesn't have any gristle or fat—just good, beefy flavor.

—**MICHAEL LOMONACO**, PORTER HOUSE NEW YORK (NEW YORK CITY)

When I was in Ireland, I swilled Guinness [stout] and ate bangers and mash, which was essentially sausage with caramelized onions on top. It was so good that when I came back to the U.S., I started experimenting with Guinness. That's how I came up with a dish of braised short ribs that had been marinated in Guinness. The problem you often have cooking with **beer** is that sometimes the dish gets bitter. So, to counteract that naturally without using sugar, I choose to use onions. I marinate the ribs in the **beer**, then braise them, and finish the dish with a puree of roasted onions for balance.

—ANDREW CARMELLINI, A VOCE (NEW YORK CITY)

BEER

Taste: varies, from bitter to sweet

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: quiet–loud

beef

cheese, cheddar ham marinades meats

onions

pork

saucers sauerkraut sausages shrimp

stews

BEETS

Season: year-round

Taste: sweet

Function: heating

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate

Techniques: bake, boil, carpaccio, chips, roast, soup, steam

apples

arugula

avocado

basil

beans, green

beef

beet greens

BUTTER, UNSALTED

cabbage

capers

caraway seeds

carrots

caviar

celery

CHEESE: blue, cambozola, cheddar, **GOAT, PARMESAN, ROQUEFORT,**

SALTY chervil

chicory

chiles

chives

cilantro

citrus

coriander

cream

crème fraîche

cumin

curry

dill

eggs, hard-boiled

endive

escarole

fennel

fennel seeds

fish

French cuisine

frisée

garlic

ginger

herbs

honey

herring

horseradish

leeks

LEMON: juice, zest

lemon balm

lemon thyme

lemon verbena

lime

maple syrup

milk

mint

mushrooms (e.g., shiitake)

MUSTARD, DIJON

mustard oil

nutmeg

oil: canola, peanut, vegetable, **walnut**

OLIVE OIL

olives, esp. niçoise

onions: red, white, yellow **ORANGE:** JUICE, ZEST

parsley, flat-leaf

pasta

pears

PEPPER: BLACK, WHITE **pistachios**

potatoes

radishes
rosemary
Russian cuisine
salads, esp. green
SALT: kosher, sea
scallions
SHALLOTS
sherry
soups, esp. borscht
sour cream
spinach
stocks: chicken, veal, vegetable
sugar: brown, white
TARRAGON
thyme
vinaigrette, mustard
VINEGAR: balsamic, champagne, **cider**, raspberry, red wine, sherry, tarragon,
white wine
vodka
WALNUTS AND WALNUT OIL
wine, white
yogurt

Flavor Affinities

beets + chives + orange + tarragon
beets + citrus + goat cheese + olive oil + shallots
beets + crème fraîche + orange + tarragon
beets + dill + sour cream
beets + endive + goat cheese + pistachios
beets + endive + orange + walnuts
beets + goat cheese + walnuts
beets + Gorgonzola cheese + hazelnuts + vinegar beets + honey + tarragon
beets + mint + yogurt
beets + olive oil + Parmesan cheese + balsamic vinegar
beets + orange + walnuts
beets + potatoes + balsamic vinegar

beets + shallots + vinegar + walnuts

Beets are especially delicious when accented by a salty cheese, whether queso fresco or ricotta salata.

—**SHARON HAGE**, YORK STREET (DALLAS)

People love fresh **beets**. Now I won't lay claim to inventing beet salad with Gorgonzola and hazelnuts, but how our version is different from many others is that we marinate the beets. Overnight, we'll marinate peeled beets in Barolo vinegar, shallots, olive oil, salt, and pepper. Using Russian and Polish cooking principles, marinating the beets ensures that the vinegar is able to penetrate them so that they are sure to be tangy.

—**ANDREW CARMELLINI**, A VOCE (NEW YORK CITY)

I wanted to take **beets** that are associated with winter and make them into something summery, so I used them for a ceviche. We roasted and pureed them with lime and froze them into a sorbet. We served the beet sorbet flat in a bowl so it looked like soup. From there, we layered thinly sliced raw bay scallops with segments of lime, cilantro, and red onion oil. The dish is very fresh tasting. The other key to this dish was that we had all the flavors of ceviche but did not marinate the scallops in the acid, which makes them rubbery. The scallops treated this way are more delicate, like sushi.

—**KATSUYA FUKUSHIMA**, MINIBAR (WASHINGTON, DC)



Dishes

Roasted Beet Tartare with Chianti Vinegar and Ricotta Salata

—Mario Batali, Babbo (New York City)

Roasted Beet Salad: Cabrales Blue Cheese, Endive, and Walnuts

—Daniel Boulud/Bertrand Chemel, Café Boulud (New York City)

Roasted Beet Salad with Hazelnut, Gorgonzola, Barolo Vinegar

—Andrew Carmellini, A Voce (New York City)

Squab Borscht with Root Vegetable Pierogi

—Sandy D’Amato, Sanford (Milwaukee)

Roasted Beet Salad with a Warm Farm Egg, Caciocavallo Cheese, and Pickled Spring Onions

—Traci Des Jardins, Jardinière (San Francisco)

Roasted Beet Salad with Shaved Fennel and Chèvre

—Leslie Mackie, Macrina Bakery & Café (Seattle)

Salad of Organic Beets and Gala Apples, “Beauty Heart” Radishes and Upland Cress, Cracked Hazelnuts, Great Hill Blue Cheese, and Quince “Must” Syrup

—Carrie Nahabedian, Naha (Chicago)

Tartare of Yellow Beets with Sturgeon Caviar, and Dashi

—Kaz Okochi, Kaz Sushi Bistro (Washington, DC)

Beets, Frisée, Cambazola, Candied Walnuts, Orange Sauce

—Monica Pope, T'afia (Houston)

Beet, Apple, and Goat Cheese Tartlet with a Hazelnut-Champagne Dressing

—Thierry Rautureau, Rover's (Seattle)

We serve a salad that showcases the classic combination of **beets**, walnuts, and orange. We boil our beets, then slice them thinly on the plate. We add frisée to the salad and, since it is bitter, we mix in Cambozola cheese and candied walnuts. We dress the salad with a sherry-walnut-tarragon vinaigrette, and a mandarin orange sauce. People are surprised when they eat the dish—first, because they find out they like beets, and second, because the frisée is not bitter after being softened by the sweet touches.

—MONICA POPE, T'AFIA (HOUSTON)

I like to intensify the flavor of **beets** by serving them prepared in different ways on the same dish, such as accenting roasted beets with crunchy beet chips and a spiced beet coulis. And I love anything anise-flavored with beets, whether fennel or anise itself.

—BRAD THOMPSON, MARY ELAINE'S AT THE PHOENICIAN (SCOTTSDALE, ARIZONA)

The sweetness of red **bell peppers** and the acidity of sherry vinegar make for a perfect combination.

—JOSÉ ANDRÉS, CAFÉ ATLÁNTICO (WASHINGTON, DC)

A lot of people find the skin a turnoff on green **bell peppers**, so I'll peel them and cook them, which releases their juice. They're great cooked down with chorizo, garlic, and onions, which you can serve with shrimp over rice.

—TONY LIU, AUGUST (NEW YORK CITY)

I'll cook red **bell peppers** with onion and garlic on the stove over a low heat

for six hours or more, so that they become caramelized and intense. The bell peppers eventually turn into a concentrated red pepper paste. If you have a dish where something is missing, add

a little of this and it will fix it! It is superb. I add it to all sorts of things—even pasta.

—MICHEL RICHARD, CITRONELLE (WASHINGTON, DC)

Green **bell peppers** are used for the equivalent of Spanish mirepoix. In Spain you don't see much celery—but you'll see green pepper, onion, garlic, and leeks.

—ALEXANDRA RAIJ, TÍA POL (NEW YORK CITY)

BELGIAN CUISINE

almonds

beef

beer

Brussels sprouts

charcuterie

chocolate

endive, Belgian

game

meats

mussels, steamed

mustard

POTATOES: FRIED, mashed

shallots

soups

stews

vinegar

waffles

Flavor Affinities

beef + bay leaf + beer + thyme + vinegar

endive + béchamel sauce + nutmeg

endive + goat cheese + herbs

mussels + butter + garlic + parsley + shallots

BELL PEPPERS

Season: summer–autumn

Taste: bitter to sweet, from unripe (green) to ripe (yellow to red)

Weight: light–medium

Volume: moderate–loud

Techniques: bake, broil, grill, roast, sauté, steam, stew, stir-fry, stuff

anchovies

anise

arugula

bacon

BASIL

bay leaf

beef

bell peppers

butter

capers, esp. with roasted peppers

cardamom

carrots

cayenne

CHEESE, esp. feta, Fontina, **goat**, **mozzarella**, **Parmesan**

chile peppers (e.g., fresh green or poblano)

chives

cilantro

coriander

cream

cumin

curry

eggplant

fennel

fennel seeds

French cuisine

game

game birds

GARLIC

ginger, fresh

goulash

hazelnuts

honey

Indian cuisine

Italian cuisine

lamb

lemon, juice

lemongrass

lime, juice

lovage

marjoram

Mexican cuisine

mint

mirepoix

mushrooms (e.g., shiitake)

mustard

OIL, CANOLA

OLIVE OIL

olives (e.g., green) **ONIONS, ESP. RED OR**

YELLOW oregano paprika, smoked **parsley, flat-leaf** pasta

peas

pepper, black

peppers, piquillo

pine nuts

pizza

polenta

pork

potatoes (e.g., red)

quail

red pepper flakes

rice

rosemary

saffron

salads

salt: kosher, sea

sausages (e.g., chorizo, Italian)

savory

scallions

sea bass

sesame oil

shallots

squash, esp. summer

stews

stir-fried dishes

stocks: chicken, vegetable

sugar (pinch)

swordfish

Tabasco sauce

THYME

TOMATOES

tuna

VINEGAR: balsamic, champagne, cider, red wine, sherry, white wine

watercress

wine: dry white, sweet sherry

zucchini

Flavor Affinities

bell peppers + basil + currants + garlic + pine nuts + sherry vinegar

bell peppers + garlic + olive oil + onion + thyme + zucchini

Dishes

Berry Crème Fraîche Poppy Seed Cake

—Emily Luchetti, pastry chef, Farallon (San Francisco)

Fresh Fruit: Black Garnet Cherries, Strawberries, Pistachios, Marshall Farms Honey, Straus Organic Whole Milk Yogurt

—Emily Luchetti, pastry chef, Farallon (San Francisco)

Red Berry–White Chocolate Trifles

—Emily Luchetti, pastry chef, Farallon (San Francisco)

BERRIES—IN GENERAL

(See also Raspberries, Strawberries, etc.)

Season: spring–summer

Weight: light

Volume: quiet–moderate

Techniques: poach, raw

cheese, ricotta

chocolate: dark, milk, white

cream

crème de cassis

crème de menthe

crème fraîche

elderflower syrup

game

honey, wildflower

lemon: juice, zest

lime, juice

mint

pepper, black

poppy seeds

salads, fruit

sour cream

sugar: brown, white

yogurt

BITTER DISHES

(e.g., greens, barbecue food)

Tips: Salt suppresses bitterness.

BITTERNESS

Taste: bitter

Function: cooling; stimulates appetite; promotes other tastes

Tips: Bitterness relieves thirst.

When a bitter component is added to a dish, it creates a sense of lightness.

The hotter the food or drink, the less the perception of bitterness.

arugula

baking powder

baking soda

beans, lima

beer, esp. hoppy (e.g., bitter ales)

bell peppers, green

bitters

broccoli rabe

Brussels sprouts

cabbage, green

caffeine (e.g., as in coffee, tea)

chard (e.g., Swiss chard)

chicory

chocolate, dark

cocoa

coffee

cranberries

eggplant

endive

escarole

fenugreek

frisée

grapefruit (bitter-sour)

greens: bitter, dark leafy (e.g., beet, dandelion, mustard, turnip)

herbs, many

horseradish

kale

lettuce, romaine

So many Western cultures don't incorporate **bitterness** into their food. In India and Asia, it is a component of a balanced dish. If you give most of America rice with lime pickle, they will not be thrilled. It will be too sour, bitter, and spicy. To introduce the bitter flavor of lime pickle, we will puree it with yogurt and use it for a marinade for whole prawns. That way, it isn't overwhelming.

—**BRAD FARMERIE**, PUBLIC (NEW YORK CITY)

I used to love dishes that were rich on rich—but the older I get, the more I look forward to that **bitterness**, the cleansing bite that makes you want to go back for your next forkful of a dish. Almost every dish in our kitchen is finished with some kind of bitter leaf to serve as a balancing component. That's why I serve cress or watercress with a steak and potato dish, and arugula with our seared bluefin tuna on braised veal cheeks, and a bed of bitter greens like watercress, frisée, arugula, and shaved endive as the base for our foie gras dish—to cut the richness.

—**SHARON HAGE**, YORK STREET (DALLAS)

liver, calf's

melon, bitter

olives (bitter-salty) radicchio

rhubarb

spices, many

spinach

tea

tonic water

turmeric

walnuts, esp. black watercress

wine, red, esp. tannic zest: lemon, orange, etc. zucchini

BLACKBERRIES

Season: summer

Taste: sour

Weight: light–medium

Volume: moderate

Techniques: cooked, raw

almonds

apples

apricots

bananas

blueberries

brandy

butter, unsalted

buttermilk

caramel

cheese, goat

chocolate: dark, white

cinnamon

cloves

cobblers

Cointreau

cornmeal

CREAM AND ICE CREAM

cream cheese

crème de cassis

crème fraîche

custard

ginger

Grand Marnier

hazelnuts

honey

Kirsch

LEMON, JUICE

lime: juice, zest

liqueurs, berry

mango

mascarpone

melons

mint

nectarines

oats

oranges

peaches

pies

pork

raspberries

salads, fruit

salt (pinch)

sour cream

strawberries

SUGAR: BROWN, WHITE

vanilla

watermelon

wine (e.g., Merlot)

yogurt

Flavor Affinities

blackberries + crème de cassis + sugar

blackberries + ginger + peaches blackberries + honey + vanilla + yogurt

Blackberries are only okay raw, but they are really great *cooked*.

—GINA DEPALMA, BABBO (NEW YORK CITY)

Dishes

Blackberry-Almond Tart with Pineapple Carpaccio, Asian Pear, Ginger-Lime Caramel, and Beurre Noisette Ice Cream

—Michael Laiskonis, pastry chef, Le Bernardin (New York City)

Candied Ginger Shortbread Stacks with Peach-Blackberry Compote

—Emily Luchetti, pastry chef, Farallon (San Francisco)

Blackberry Sorbet-Filled Peaches

—Emily Luchetti, pastry chef, Farallon (San Francisco)

BLACK-EYED PEAS

Weight: light–medium

Volume: moderate–loud

Techniques: simmer

African cuisine

bay leaf

cardamom

carrots

cayenne

celery

chile peppers, dried red

cinnamon

cloves

coriander

cumin

garam masala

garlic

ginger, fresh

GREENS (e.g., collard)

HAM HOCKS

Indian cuisine

oil, peanut

onions: red, yellow

pepper, black

pork

red pepper flakes

rice

salt

savory

Southern cuisine (American)

tomatoes

turmeric

vinegar, white wine

yogurt

Flavor Affinities

black-eyed peas + collard greens + ham hocks

black-eyed peas + rice + savory

BLACK PEPPER
(See Pepper, Black)

BLUEBERRIES

Season: spring–summer

Taste: sour–sweet

Botanical relatives: huckleberries

Weight: light

Volume: quiet–moderate

Techniques: cooked, raw

Tips: Can substitute huckleberries.

allspice

almonds

apples

apricots

bananas

blackberries

butter, unsalted

buttermilk

chocolate, white

CINNAMON

cinnamon basil

cloves

cognac

cornmeal

cream and ice cream

cream cheese

crème fraîche

custard

ginger

honey

jams

Kirsch

LEMON: juice, zest

lemon thyme

lime: juice, zest

liqueurs: berry, orange

mace

mangoes

MAPLE SYRUP

MASCARPONE

melon

mint

molasses

muffins

nectarines

nutmeg

oats and oatmeal

orange

PEACHES

pears

pecans

Cinnamon with **blueberries** really intensifies the flavor of the blueberries.

—**JERRY TRAUNFELD**, THE HERBFARM (WOODINVILLE, WASHINGTON)

If I make a blueberry cobbler, I will macerate the **blueberries** first with maple and lemon zest.

—**MICHAEL LAISKONIS**, LE BERNARDIN (NEW YORK CITY)

Blueberries and lemon go really well together. **Blueberries** are a thick fruit with a lot of pectin in them, and intensely flavored. You need some lemon to cut through that.

—**EMILY LUCHETTI**, FARALLON (SAN FRANCISCO)

Dishes

Risotto Fritters with Gingered Blueberries

—Jimmy Bradley, The Red Cat (New York City)

Warm Blueberry Crostata with Crème Fraîche and Cinnamon

—Gina DePalma, pastry chef, Babbo (New York City)

Blueberry-Apple-Lavender Faux Gelato and Anise Tuile

—Dominique and Cindy Duby, Wild Sweets (Vancouver)

pepper, black

pies

pineapple

pine nuts

port

raspberries

rhubarb

ricotta cheese

rum

salads, fruit

sour cream

strawberries

SUGAR: BROWN, WHITE

tarts

Triple Sec

vanilla

walnuts

watermelon

yogurt

Flavor Affinities

blueberries + cinnamon + cream + sugar

blueberries + cream + lemon zest + mascarpone + sugar

blueberries + honey + port + vanilla

blueberries + lemon + lemon thyme

blueberries + lemon zest + maple syrup

blueberries + mascarpone + peaches

BLUEFISH

Season: spring–early autumn

Weight: medium

Volume: loud

Techniques: bake, blacken, braise, broil, grill, pan roast, poach, sauté

chile peppers, chipotle

cilantro

lemon

lime, juice

marjoram

mustard, brown

olive oil

onions, red

rosemary

sugar

thyme

tomatoes

vinegar, cider

wine

BOK CHOY

Season: year-round

Taste: bitter

Weight: light–medium

Volume: quiet

Techniques: boil, braise, raw, stir-fry

asparagus

beef

broccoli

butter

carrots

cashews

celery

chicken

chile peppers

chili powder

cilantro

coconut milk

coriander

duck

fennel

fish

garlic

ginger

hot sauce

lemon, juice

meats

mirin

mushrooms, esp. shiitake

noodles, rice

oil: peanut, sesame, vegetable

peanuts

pork

rice

rosemary

salads

salmon

scallions

sesame: oil, seeds

shallots

shellfish

snow peas

soy sauce

tamari

tarragon

tofu

vinegar, esp. rice

water chestnuts

zucchini

BONITO FLAKES, DRIED

(See also Tuna)

Taste: salty

Weight: light–medium

Volume: moderate–loud

Tips: Use large flakes to make fish stock and small flakes to season dishes.

anchovies

capers

garlic

Japanese cuisine

oil, vegetable

scallions

stock, fish

vinegar

BOUQUET GARNI

Tips: Bundle of herbs is removed after cooking.

French cuisine

soups

stews

stocks

Flavor Affinities

bay leaf + parsley + thyme

BOURBON

(See also Whiskey)

Weight: heavy

Volume: loud

apple

juice

apricot

brandy

barbecue

bitters

butter

butterscotch

cream

desserts

ginger

grapefruit juice

grenadine

honey

ice cream

LEMON JUICE

mint

orange juice

peaches

pecans

pineapple juice

Southern cuisine (American)

SUGAR: BROWN, WHITE

vermouth: dry, sweet

Flavor Affinities

bourbon + grapefruit + honey

bourbon + lemon + peaches

bourbon + lemon + sugar

bourbon + pineapple + sugar

BOYSENBERRIES

Season: summer

Taste: sour–sweet

Weight: light–medium

Volume: quiet–moderate

cream

Kirsch

lemon, juice

nectarines

peaches

sugar

vanilla

wine, esp. dry red

BRAISED DISHES

Season: winter

Tips: Check here for ideas of meats or vegetables to add to a braised dish.

artichokes
beans
beef: brisket, shanks, short ribs, shoulder
cabbage
carrots
celery
chicken: legs, thighs, wings
chili
cod
corned beef and cabbage
duck, legs
endive
fennel
ham hocks
lamb: shanks, shoulder
monkfish
octopus
onions
oxtails
pork: belly, butt, chops, loin, ribs, shank, shoulder
potatoes
pot roast
rabbit
ratatouille
short ribs
skate
stews
tripe
turkey, legs
turnips

veal: breast, rump, shank, shoulder, sirloin, sweetbreads
vegetables, root
venison, shoulder

BRAZILIAN CUISINE

(See also Latin American Cuisine)

beans, black
cardamom
chile peppers
cilantro
cloves
coconut milk
garlic
ginger
greens: collard, kale
grilled dishes
meats
nutmeg
onions
orange
parsley
pepper, black
peppers
pork
pumpkin
rice
saffron
sausages
thyme

Flavor Affinities

cream + egg yolks + sugar
pork + beans + greens + onions + oranges

BRINED DISHES

Taste: salty

Tips: Brining meats (i.e., in salt water) before cooking increases their moistness, juiciness, and flavor.

chicken
game birds
pork
poultry
turkey

I don't **brine** automatically. If I have a chicken that I know will cook up on the dry side, then I will brine it first. If it is a great chicken that will cook up naturally juicy and doesn't need help, then I won't. You can make a pretty strong brine for squab or even chicken—for instance, with thyme or even chile pepper—and the meat will pick up some flavors, but it's still very subtle.

—**TRACI DES JARDINS**, JARDINIÈRE (SAN FRANCISCO)

Our winter *pistou* features **broccoli**, and we're able to make the broccoli flavor very intense. We use not only broccoli stock, but also broccoli florets and even add broccoli puree. There's both clarity and lightness of flavor that we're able to achieve without butter or cream this way.

—**DAN BARBER**, BLUE HILL AT STONE BARN (POCANTICO HILLS, NEW YORK)

BROCCOLI

Season: autumn–winter

Botanical relatives: Brussels sprouts, cabbage, cauliflower, collard greens, kale, kohlrabi

Function: cooling

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate

Techniques: boil, deep-fry, sauté, steam, stir-fry

almonds

anchovies

basil

bread crumbs

butter, unsalted

caraway seeds

carrots

cauliflower

CHEESE: cheddar, feta, goat, mozzarella, Parmesan, Swiss

chicken

chile peppers (esp. green)

cilantro

coriander

cream

curry and curry leaf

eggs

garlic

ginger, esp. fresh

hollandaise sauce

lemon, juice

lemon balm

mint

mustard and mustard seeds

oil: peanut, sesame

olive oil

olives
onions, esp. green
oregano
parsley
pasta
pepper, ground
red pepper flakes
rice, basmati
salt
scallions
shallots
tarragon
thyme
vinaigrette
vinegar: balsamic, red wine
wine

Flavor Affinities

broccoli + anchovies + capers + red pepper flakes + garlic + olives
broccoli + anchovies + lemon
broccoli + garlic + lemon juice + olive oil
broccoli + garlic + tarragon

BROCCOLINI

Season: year-round

Weight: light–medium

Volume: quiet–moderate

Techniques: blanch, raw, sauté, steam, stir-fry

almonds

basil

cheese: feta, Parmesan

garlic

lemon, juice

olive oil

parsley, flat-leaf

pasta

red pepper flakes

salads

sesame oil

soups

tomatoes

BROCCOLI RABE

Season: late fall–spring

Taste: bitter

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: moderate–loud

Techniques: boil, sauté, steam, stir-fry

almonds

anchovies

basil

beans, white

butter, unsalted

cheese, Parmesan

chicken

chickpeas

chiles

chives

cream

fish

GARLIC

Italian cuisine

lemon, juice

meats

OLIVE OIL

oregano

parsley, flat-leaf

pasta, esp. orecchiette

pepper: white, black

piquillo peppers

poultry

prosciutto

red pepper flakes

salt

sausage

stock, chicken

tomatoes

vinegar: balsamic, red wine

Dishes

Orecchiette with Rapini and Sweet Sausage

—Mario Batali, Babbo (New York City)

Broccoli Rabe with Garlic and Oregano

—Andrew Carmellini, A Voce (New York City)

Flavor Affinities

broccoli rabe + anchovies + red pepper flakes + garlic + olive oil

broccoli rabe + garlic + oregano

broccoli rabe + red pepper flakes + oregano

BRUNCH

Customers are picky at **brunch**. They have all cooked what they think they like, they think they can do it slightly better than we can, and they want it twice as fast. So, we take the classics like pancakes or French toast, use them as building blocks, and push them a little further.

We will offer seasonal pancakes. In the winter, we'll make buckwheat pancakes with cinnamon and glazed oranges. Bridging spring into summer, we'll offer corn and saffron pancakes with a spicy poached pear and fresh ricotta. Saffron and corn work really well together because of the floral nature of the saffron and sweetness of the corn. We will use poached pears on the pancakes until switching to blueberries for the summer, which give a real pop. The pears are poached in a red wine syrup with *aleppo* chile that is a sundried chile with a rich, round, sweet spice to it. The chile is not noticeable, but it acts like an acid by lightening, plus cutting the sugar and richness of, the pancake.

When people eat pancakes, they naturally reach for butter. I don't serve butter with my pancakes and instead serve fresh ricotta. We use ricotta from Anne Saxelby, who supplies us with a fresh, rich, velvety ricotta, and this gives a richness to the dish.

—BRAD FARMERIE, PUBLIC (NEW YORKCITY)

BRUSSELS SPROUTS

Season: autumn–winter

Taste: bitter

Botanical relatives: broccoli, cabbage, cauliflower, collard greens, kale, kohlrabi

Weight: moderate–heavy

Volume: moderate–loud

Techniques: boil, braise, sauté, simmer, steam, stew, stir-fry

almonds

apple cider

apples and apple juice or cider

artichokes, Jerusalem

BACON

basil

bay leaf

bread crumbs

BUTTER, unsalted

celery

celery root

CHEESE: blue, cheddar, goat, Parmesan, provolone, ricotta, Swiss

chestnuts

chives

coriander

cream

crème fraîche

dill

eggs, hard-boiled

fennel seeds

garlic

hazelnuts

juniper berries

lemon, juice

marjoram

mustard, Dijon

nutmeg

oil, mustard

olive oil

onions

pancetta

paprika

parsley, flat-leaf

pepper: black, white

potatoes, esp. mashed

salt: kosher, sea

sauces, béchamel

shallots

stock, chicken

sugar

thyme, fresh

turnips

vermouth

vinaigrette

VINEGAR: cider, white wine

water chestnuts

wine, dry white

Flavor Affinities

Brussels sprouts + bacon + garlic + cider vinegar

Brussels sprouts + bacon + onions

Brussels sprouts + cream + nutmeg

Brussels sprouts + lemon juice + thyme

Brussels sprouts + pancetta + thyme

BULGUR WHEAT

Weight: light–medium

Volume: quiet–moderate

Techniques: steam

butter

chicken

chickpeas

dill

fish (e.g., branzino, pike, striped bass)

Dishes

Brussels Sprouts, Cranberry Polenta, and Braised Fennel with a Moroccan Olive Relish

—Thierry Rautureau, Rover's (Seattle)

I love **bulgur** [wheat] salad. In the summer, I'll serve it with greens and tomatoes, while in the fall it's paired with tangerines and pomegranates. I feel the same about it whether it is under branzino or pike or striped bass; it always makes sense.

—SHARON HAGE, YORK STREET (DALLAS)

greens

lamb

lentils

meats

Middle Eastern cuisine

oils, walnut

olive oil

orange

parsley

pilaf (key ingredient)

pine nuts

pomegranates

rice

salads

soups

tabbouleh (key ingredient)

tangerine

tarragon

tomatoes

vegetables

walnuts

BUTTER, BROWN

(aka Beurre Noisette)

bananas
fish, esp. white: halibut, skate
fruits, esp. richer ones
nuts
pears
scallops
soft-shell crabs
vinegar, esp. balsamic

Flavor Affinities

brown butter + balsamic vinegar + fish
brown butter + banana + nuts

BUTTERMILK

Taste: sour

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate–loud

bananas
blackberries
blueberries
cherries
cinnamon
dates
ginger
herbs
honey
lemon
lime
maple syrup
mayonnaise
mint
nectarines
nutmeg
oats
orange
peaches
plums
raisins
raspberries
rhubarb
sour cream
strawberries
sugar, brown
walnuts

BUTTERSCOTCH

almonds
chocolate
coffee
lemon
praline
rum
vanilla

Dishes

Butterscotch-Praline Ice Cream Parfait

—Rebecca Charles, Pearl Oyster Bar (New York City)

One of my favorite flavors in the world is **brown butter**. A *financier* cake made with brown butter is one of the best things ever. I have been making a brown butter vinaigrette for a jillion years! It is a super-easy pan sauce that I love as a warm sauce: I just brown my butter in a pan until it gets the *noisette* [brown] color, then add some balsamic vinegar. It doesn't even need to be expensive balsamic. You make an emulsification in the pan, and add a little salt and pepper and it's done. The flavor of brown butter, salt, and acid is one of my favorites. It works well on different fish like scallops or halibut or soft-shell crabs.

—TRACI DES JARDINS, JARDINIÈRE (SAN FRANCISCO)

Brown butter is one of my favorite flavors, and it pairs well with anything nutty, as well as richer fruits like bananas. A classic French *financier* is hands-down one of my favorite French pastries [a cookie made with brown butter, egg whites, flour, and powdered sugar].

Butter tastes great on its own, and in making brown butter you are not adding anything to it—just transforming it, so that it becomes more. The process is simple but a little tricky, as it keeps cooking even after it is off the stove. Something you can do to improve it is—halfway through the cooking process—start whisking the butter, because it intensifies the flavor if you keep the particles suspended.

—MICHAEL LAISKONIS, LE BERNARDIN (NEW YORK CITY)

Cabbage often has the connotation of being heavy, but in the fall, we'll make a fine chiffonade of cabbage that's very light. I like to cut cabbage thin and roast

it in a pan so that the edges just get brown because that tastes really good. We figured that out by mistake by putting cabbage into too hot a pan. After the chef raised his voice about how that is the wrong way to cook cabbage, we tasted it, and it was good! We now serve a green cabbage dish cooked this way with caraway seeds and walnuts, then deglazed with Calvados. We also add a little cider vinegar and olive oil to finish. It is a nice, easy marriage. It is not an unpredictable marriage; these things just all work together. We pair this with braised pork belly, but it would also work with a roasted breast of squab with its leg done in a confit.

—MICHAEL ANTHONY, GRAMERCY TAVERN (NEW YORK CITY)

CABBAGE—IN GENERAL

Season: autumn–winter

Botanical relatives: broccoli, Brussels sprouts, cauliflower, collard greens, kale, kohlrabi

Function: cooling

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate

Techniques: boil, braise, raw, sauté, steam, stir-fry

apples and apple cider

BACON

bay leaf

beef

bell peppers, red

butter, unsalted

CARAWAY SEEDS

carrots

celery: leaves, salt, seeds

Champagne

cheese: cheddar, feta, goat, Parmesan, Swiss, Taleggio, Teleme

chestnuts

chicken

chili sauce

chile peppers: dried red, fresh green (e.g., jalapeño)

cilantro

clove

coconut

coleslaw (key ingredient)

coriander

corned beef

cream

cumin

curry leaves

dill

duck
fat: rendered chicken, duck
fennel
fennel seeds
game birds
garlic
ginger
ham
horseradish
jicama
juniper berries
lemon, juice
lime, juice
marjoram
mayonnaise
meats
mushrooms
mustard, esp. Dijon, dry
mustard oil
mustard seeds, black
oil: peanut, sesame
olive oil
olives
ONIONS, ESP. RED
paprika
parsley
pasta
pecans
pepper: black, white
poppy seeds
pork
potatoes
poultry
prosciutto
red pepper flakes
rice
salmon

salt: kosher, sea

savory

shallots

sour cream

soy sauce

spinach

stock, chicken

sugar

tarragon

thyme

tomatoes

vinaigrettes

VINEGAR: champagne, cider, red wine, sherry, white wine
wine, white (e.g., Riesling)

CABBAGE, NAPA

(aka Chinese cabbage)

Season: year-round

Weight: light

Volume: quiet

Techniques: bake, braise, grill, marinate (e.g., kimchee), raw, sauté, stew, stir-fry

carrots

cashews

chicken

I like coming up with spins using Asian ingredients—such as soaking **napa cabbage** in ice water to crisp it and serving it with a blue cheese dressing as if it were iceberg lettuce.

—TONY LIU, AUGUST (NEW YORK CITY)



chile peppers, jalapeño
Chinese cuisine
cilantro
coleslaw, Asian-style
cucumber
duck
fish, salmon
garlic
ginger
mint
mushrooms (e.g., shiitakes)
oil, sesame
orange, juice
pork
scallions
seafood
sesame seeds

scallops
shellfish: shrimp
soups
soy sauce
stews
stir-fries
Thai basil
tofu
vinegar, rice
wine, rice

CABBAGE, RED

Season: autumn–winter

Techniques: braise, marinate, raw

APPLES: Golden Delicious, Rome, tart
bacon

bay leaf

butter, unsalted

caraway seeds

cheese: blue, goat, Gorgonzola, ricotta salata

Dishes

Pommery Grain Mustard Ice Cream, Red Cabbage Gazpacho
—Heston Blumenthal, The Fat Duck (England)

Dishes

Sautéed Strawberries in Black Pepper–Cabernet Sauvignon Sauce with Vanilla Bean Ice Cream and Sacristan Cookie

—Lissa Doumani and Hiro Sone, Terra (St. Helena, California)

chestnuts

cider, apple

cilantro

cream

cumin

fat: duck, goose

fruit, tart

game: rabbit, venison

game birds, pheasant

garlic

honey

lemon, juice

lime, juice

meats

mustard

nutmeg

oil, peanut

olive oil

onions: red, white

pancetta

parsley, flat-leaf

pepper, black

poultry

red pepper flakes

salt, kosher

scallions

stock, chicken

SUGAR: BROWN, WHITE

VINEGAR: balsamic, cider, red wine, rice wine, sherry, white wine
wine, dry red

Flavor Affinities

red cabbage + apples + cider vinegar

red cabbage + bacon + blue cheese + walnuts

red cabbage + balsamic vinegar + brown sugar

red cabbage + chestnuts + pork

red cabbage + duck fat + goat cheese + red wine vinegar

red cabbage + pancetta + ricotta salata cheese

CABBAGE, SAVOY

Season: autumn–winter

Techniques: boil, braise, raw, roast, steam

apples

bacon

butter, unsalted

carrots

cream

crème fraîche

garlic

leeks

lemon, juice

oil, peanut

olive oil

onions

parsley, flat-leaf

parsnips

pepper, black

potatoes

raisins, golden

salt, kosher

stock

thyme

turnips

vinegar, cider

walnuts

CABERNET SAUVIGNON

Weight: heavy red wine

Volume: loud

beef

cheese, esp. aged, blue, and/or stinky

game

game birds

lamb

meat, red

pepper, black

steak

strawberries

CAJUN CUISINE

cayenne

celery

chiles

crayfish

gumbo

jambalaya

onions

peppers

rice

seafood

tomatoes

CALAMARI

(See Squid)

CALF'S LIVER
(See Liver, Calf's)

CALVADOS

Season: winter

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: moderate–loud

Tips: Generally an after-dinner drink.

apples

bitters, orange

French cuisine

gin

lemon, juice

orange, juice

pears

rum

sugar

vermouth, sweet

CANADIAN CUISINE

bacon, back (aka Canadian bacon)

beer

berries, esp. wild

cheese

duck

fiddlehead ferns

foie gras

game

game birds

maple syrup

meats, esp. smoked

mushrooms, wild

oysters

rabbit

salmon

seafood

wild rice

wine: ice wine, Riesling

CANTALOUPE

Season: summer

Taste: sweet

Weight: light–medium

Volume: moderate

basil

cilantro

curry powder

ginger

grapefruit

lemon, juice

lemongrass

lime, juice

melon: honeydew, watermelon

mint

pepper: black, white

port

raspberries

star anise

tarragon

wine, esp. sweet

wine, Pinot Blanc (to accompany)

yogurt

CANTONESE CUISINE
(See Chinese Cuisine)

CAPERS

Taste: salty, sour, pungent

Weight: light

Volume: loud

almonds

anchovies

artichokes

arugula

basil

beans, green

butter sauces

celery

chicken

eggplant

eggs

fish

French cuisine, esp. southern

garlic

Italian cuisine, esp. southern

lamb

lemon, juice

lime

marjoram

meats, esp. richer ones, e.g., rib eye steaks

Mediterranean cuisine

mustard

olives

onions

oregano

parsley, flat-leaf

pasta

pork

potatoes

poultry
rabbit
salads
salmon
sauces, esp. Italian cuisine
shellfish, e.g., scallops, shrimp
tapenade (key ingredient)
tarragon
tomatoes
vinaigrettes
vinegar

Flavor Affinities

capers + lemon + marjoram

Dishes

Cantaloupe “Sashimi,” Raspberry Gel, and Star Anise Dust

—Dominique and Cindy Duby, Wild Sweets (Vancouver)

CARAMEL

Taste: sweet

almonds

APPLES

apricots

bananas

bourbon

cherries

chocolate

cinnamon

coffee and espresso

CREAM AND ICE CREAM

cream cheese

cumin

custard

fruits, tropical

lemon, juice

lime, juice

macadamia nuts

mangoes

nutmeg

passion fruit

peaches

peanuts

pears

pecans

plums

raisins

rhubarb

rum

sesame seeds

VANILLA

CARAWAY SEEDS

Taste: sweet, sour

Weight: light

Volume: medium–loud

Tips: Add late in the cooking process.

apples

Austrian cuisine

beef stew

BREADS, esp. pumpernickel, rye

British cuisine

cabbage

cakes

carrots

cheese (e.g., Liptauer, Muenster)

coleslaw

cookies

coriander

corned beef

cumin

desserts

duck

Eastern European cuisine

fruit

garlic

German cuisine

goose

goulash

Hungarian cuisine

juniper berries

lavender (can substitute for caraway)

marinades

meats

Moroccan cuisine

noodles

onions

parsley, flat-leaf

pork

potatoes

sauerkraut

sausages

soups

stews

thyme

tomatoes

turnips vegetables, esp. root

CARDAMOM

Taste: sweet, pungent

Function: heating

Weight: medium

Volume: loud

Tips: Add early when cooking.

anise

apples

apricots

Asian cuisine

baked goods (e.g., breads, cakes, cookies)

bananas

beef

beverages, esp. hot

caraway

carrots

chicken, esp. stewed

chickpeas

chile peppers

chocolate

cinnamon

citrus

cloves

coffee

coriander

cream and ice cream

crème anglaise

cumin

curries

custards

dates

desserts, esp. Indian

duck, esp. roasted

fish, e.g., salmon

garam masala, Indian (key ingredient)

ginger

gingerbread

grapefruit

honey

Indian cuisine

Indonesian cuisine

lamb

legumes

lemon: juice, zest

lentils

lime

meats

North African cuisine

orange: juice, zest

paprika

parsnips

pastries

pears

peas

pepper

pistachios

pork

rice and rice dishes

saffron

salmon

Scandinavian cuisine

squash

stews

sugar

sweet potatoes

tea

vanilla

vegetables, root

walnuts

wine (e.g., mulled)

yogurt

CARIBBEAN CUISINES

allspice
bay leaf chicken
chile peppers
cilantro
cinnamon
cloves
coconut milk
curry
dill
fish
fruits, tropical
garlic
ginger
hot sauce
jerked dishes
lime, juice



molasses
nutmeg
onions
orange
oregano
parsley
pineapple
plantains
rum, esp. dark

shellfish
sugar, brown
tamarind
thyme

Flavor Affinities

cilantro + garlic + onions (aka *sofrito*)
fish + allspice + oil + onions + vinegar (aka *escabèche*)

CARROTS

Season: autumn–spring

Botanical relatives: celery, chervil, dill, fennel, parsley, parsnips

Function: cooling

Weight: medium

Volume: quiet–moderate

Techniques: boil, braise, grill, raw, **roast**, sauté, simmer, steam, stir-fry

allspice

almonds

anise hyssop

apple juice

bacon

basil

bay leaf

beef

brandy

butter, brown

BUTTER, unsalted

carrot juice

celery

chervil

chicken

chile peppers: dried red, fresh green (e.g., jalapeño)

Thumbelina **carrots** are something I missed when I moved from working in the country [i.e., Pocantico Hills, New York, where Blue Hill at Stone Barns is located] into Manhattan. Luckily, I recently found these short, fat carrots at the green market. We sauté these carrots over an open fire so that they get a little smoky. When they are cooked, they become soft and creamy. Once cooked, we turn them into a puree with a shot of carrot juice at the last second. We pair this with farro that has been cooked like risotto, then add some pine nuts and more Thumbelina carrots that have been quartered. I don't know what is more

seductive: the smooth carrot farro with its light carrot flavor or the carrots themselves that are totally creamy. The dish has no butter or cream but that is not because we are trying to be healthy. The dish just doesn't need it.

—MICHAEL ANTHONY, GRAMERCY TAVERN (NEW YORK CITY)

Juices are a great way to freshen up a dish. If you cook a **carrot**, you lose the “carrotiness” of it. If you make a carrot soup with cooked carrots, it doesn't become bright. So now we do a carrot base with cooked organic carrots with tops, onions, garlic, and maybe some ginger and lemongrass. With that base we make a really thick soup and then add carrot juice to it. In the end you have fresh and cooked carrots for a better flavor profile.

—ANDREW CARMELLINI, A VOCE (NEW YORK CITY)

I had a salad at a restaurant with grated **carrots** and tarragon leaves with pistachios—and I knew the minute I tasted it that I could adapt this salad to be my own. Instead of grating the carrots, I cut them on the bias and roasted them with a little ginger and *juca* [an African mix made of almonds, pistachios, hazelnuts, and spices]. To finish the salad, I added the whole tarragon leaves, great pistachio oil, and a raita of yogurt and golden raisins. The dish has wonderful colors and texture and those beautiful whole leaves of tarragon which I had never thought to do myself.

—MONICA POPE, T'AFIA (HOUSTON)

Carrots—which pair well with allspice, cinnamon, cloves, and cumin—are one of the few vegetables that shine in desserts. When I first came to the U.S. I discovered carrot cake and that you could use carrots for dessert. I have since made carrot ice cream, cookies, and fruit paste. The problem is that most people trust carrot cake but little else. When I am using carrots for dessert, I like to cook them with orange.

—MICHEL RICHARD, CITRONELLE (WASHINGTON, DC)

Carrots and parsnips are similar, and I like the depth of flavor that comes from combining them.

—BRAD THOMPSON, MARY ELAINE'S AT THE PHOENICIAN (SCOTTSDALE, ARIZONA)

Dishes

Carrot Cake with Peach-Ginger Cream and Saskatoon Berry Compote

—Dominique and Cindy Duby, *Wild Sweets* (Vancouver)

Carrot Cake with Vanilla Chantilly, Pecan Praline

—Emily Luchetti, pastry chef, Farallon (San Francisco)

Roasted Carrots and Minted Pea Puree, and Moscato Vinegar

—Cory Schreiber, Wildwood (Portland, Oregon)

chives

cilantro

cinnamon

cloves

cod

coriander

crayfish

cream

crème fraîche

cumin (e.g., Indian cuisine)

curry

curry leaves

dill

fennel

fennel seeds

fish

garlic

GINGER

hazelnuts

honey

lamb

leeks

LEMON, juice

lemon balm

lemon verbena

lime, juice (e.g., Indian cuisine)

lovage

mace

MAPLE SYRUP

mint: spearmint, peppermint

mirepoix (key ingredient)

mustard

mustard seeds, black

nutmeg

oil: peanut, sesame

olive oil

onions, esp. green

ORANGE, juice

PARSLEY, FLAT-LEAF

parsnips

peas

pecans

pepper: black, white

pistachios

potatoes

raisins: black, white

meats, roasted

rosemary

rum

sage

salsify

salt: fleur de sel, kosher

savory

scallops

shallots

spinach

stocks: chicken, vegetable

SUGAR: brown, white (pinch)

tamarind

tarragon

thyme

turnips

veal

vegetables, root

vinaigrette

walnuts

wine, white

yogurt

Flavor Affinities

carrots + celery + onions (aka mirepoix)

carrots + cilantro + lime

carrots + cinnamon + raisins + sugar + walnuts

carrots + cumin + orange

carrots + dill + orange

carrots + lemon juice + olive oil + parsley

carrots + maple syrup + orange

carrots + olive oil + turnips

carrots + pistachios + tarragon

carrots + raisins + yogurt

CASHEWS

Taste: sweet, rich

Function: warming

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: loud

almonds

apricots

bananas

caramel

cheese

chicken (e.g., Indian cuisine)

chocolate, esp. white

cinnamon

coconut (e.g., Indian cuisine)

coffee / espresso

curries

dates

ginger

grapefruit

guava

honey

Indian cuisine

kiwi fruit

lemon

macadamia nuts

mango

mint

nutmeg

oil, vegetable

papaya

passion fruit

persimmon

pineapple

rice

rum

salads

salt

sauces

sugar: brown, white

vanilla

vegetables, esp. Indian

CATFISH

Weight: medium

Volume: quiet

Techniques: broil, deep-fry, grill, poach, sauté, steam, stir-fry

avocados

bacon

basil

butter, unsalted

cabbage (e.g., coleslaw)

capers

cayenne

chile peppers, chipotle

cilantro

cucumbers

garlic

greens, collard

ham

hush puppies

lemon, juice

oil: peanut, vegetable

olive oil

olives, esp. niçoise

parsley, flat-leaf

pepper: black, Szechuan

pine nuts

potatoes

salt, kosher

Southern cuisine (American)

soy sauce

stock, chicken

sugar

tomatillos

tomatoes

vinaigrette
vinegar, cider
wine, dry white

CAULIFLOWER

Season: autumn–winter

Taste: astringent

Botanical relatives: broccoli, Brussels sprouts, cabbage, collard greens, kale, kohlrabi

Function: cooling

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate

Techniques: boil, braise, deepfry, gratin, puree, raw, roast, sauté, simmer, steam

anchovies

apples

bay leaf

bell peppers, esp. green (e.g., Indian cuisine)

bread crumbs

broccoli

brown butter

butter, unsalted

capers

cardamom

caviar

celery seeds

CHEESE: blue, cheddar, Comté, Emmental, goat, Gruyère, Parmesan, pecorino

chervil

chile peppers, dried red

chili sauce

chives



Dishes

Variation of Cauliflower with Raisins, Grenobloise Butter, and Fried Pantelleria Capers

—Daniel Boulud, Daniel (New York City)

Cauliflower Panna Cotta Topped with American Paddlefish Caviar and Cockle Emulsion

—Gabriel Kreuther, The Modern (New York City)

Cauliflower Rice Pilaf with Raita

—Vikram Vij and Meeru Dhalwala, Vij's (Vancouver)

The first time I had the combination of **cauliflower** and curry was when I worked with Daniel Boulud, and he used them together in a soup. I didn't grow up liking cauliflower, but I do now when it's well roasted or pureed. It has good water content, which makes for a very smooth puree, and it has a subtle yet distinct flavor. Apple combines well with both, as it adds acidity and crunch while cutting the stronger flavors.

—**BRADFORD THOMPSON**, MARY ELAINE'S AT THE PHOENICIAN (SCOTTSDALE, ARIZONA)

Our dish of spicy roasted **cauliflower** with pine nuts and lime is cauliflower with lime supremes [skinless lime sections]. I love lime because it has more character than lemon.

—**HOLLY SMITH**, CAFÉ JUANITA (SEATTLE)

chocolate and cocoa, when cauliflower is caramelized
cilantro

coriander

CREAM AND MILK

cumin

currants, dried

curry powder

dill

Eastern Mediterranean cuisine

egg, hard-boiled, esp. yolk

French cuisine

garam masala

GARLIC

ginger

greens

hollandaise sauce

Indian cuisine

leeks

lemon: juice, zest

lime

Mediterranean cuisine

mint

mussels

mustard, esp. Dijon

mustard: oil, seeds

nutmeg

OIL: canola, grapeseed, vegetable

olive oil

olives: black, green

ONIONS: green, red

orange: juice, zest

paprika

parsley, flat-leaf

pasta

PEPPER: BLACK, WHITE

pine nuts

poppy seeds

potatoes, red (e.g., Indian cuisine)

raisins

red pepper flakes

saffron

SALT: KOSHER, SEA

saucers: béchamel, brown butter, cheese, cream, hollandaise, Mornay

scallions

scallops

shallots

soups

stock, chicken

tarragon

thyme

tomatoes (e.g., Indian cuisine)

truffles, white

turmeric

vinegar: red, white wine

watercress

yogurt (e.g., Indian cuisine)

Flavor Affinities

cauliflower + anchovies + red pepper flakes + garlic + olive oil

cauliflower + bread crumbs + brown butter + parsley

cauliflower + cilantro + cloves + cumin + turmeric

cauliflower + cream + sorrel

cauliflower + curry + apple

cauliflower + curry + vinegar

cauliflower + garlic + mint + pasta

cauliflower + pine nuts + lime

CAVIAR

Season: winter

Taste: salty

Weight: very light

Volume: quiet–loud

blini, esp. whole wheat

bread, esp. **toast points**

chives

crème fraîche

eggs

French cuisine

lemon

onion, esp. raw

pepper: black, white

potatoes

Russian cuisine

salt

shallots

sour cream

vodka

white chocolate

wine, Champagne

There is an obvious reason why you could argue that white chocolate and **caviar** go together and that is because of the fact that you are pairing fat and salt. The combination, however, runs a lot deeper than that. The amine [organic chemical compounds] levels in caviar and white chocolate are such that the two ingredients almost “melt” together.

—**HESTON BLUMENTHAL**, THE FAT DUCK (ENGLAND)

Dishes

Yellowtail Tuna with Spinach Puree, Potato Salad, and Osetra Caviar and Vodka Sauce

—David Bouley, Danube (New York City)

Scrambled Egg with Lime Crème Fraîche and Sturgeon Caviar

—Thierry Rautureau, Rover's (Seattle)

Royal Osetra Caviar Served with Warm Crepes, Toast, and Crème Fraîche

—Eric Ripert, Le Bernardin (New York City)

Caviar-Pasta: Osetra on a Nest of Tagliolini, Quail Egg, and Bacon Carbonara Sauce

—Eric Ripert, Le Bernardin (New York City)

CAYENNE, GROUND

Taste: piquant

Function: warming

Weight: light

Volume: loud

Tips: Cayenne tastes hotter the more it cooks.

basil

beans

bell peppers

Cajun cuisine

cheese and cheese sauces

chili

cilantro

coriander

corn

crab

Creole cuisine

cumin

eggplant

fish

garlic

Indian cuisine

Italian cuisine

lemon

lobster

meat

Mexican cuisine

oil

onions

potatoes

rice

sardines

sauc

shellfish
soups
stews
tomatoes

AVOID

caviar
delicate flavors
truffles

Flavor Affinities

cayenne + coriander + cumin + garlic

CELERY

Season: year-round

Taste: astringent

Botanical relatives: carrots

Function: cooling

Weight: light

Volume: moderate–loud

Techniques: boil, braise, cream, gratiné, raw, sauté, steam, stir-fry

basil

bay leaf

beets

butter

capers

carrots

cheese, esp. **blue**, feta, goat, Gruyère, Parmesan, Roquefort

chervil

chicken and other poultry

chickpeas and hummus

chives

cream

cream cheese

curry

dill

eggs, hard-boiled

fish

garlic

legumes

lemon, juice

lovage

mirepoix (key ingredient)

mushrooms, wild

mustard, esp. Dijon

Using a pinch of **cayenne** is like having a turbo versus a regular engine in your car. The cayenne goes into you so fast it is like creating an engine for your flavors. It will create a certain heat and speedy access to your flavors. I use cayenne in everything. However, it has to be done carefully. It has to be just a pinch at the last minute. If you are using basil, it will make the flavor even stronger.

—**ERIC RIPERT**, LE BERNARDIN (NEW YORK CITY)

Of all vegetables, **celery** has one of the strongest flavors. To me, it is almost like a truffle. In a mirepoix, you need all the vegetables—but if I could have only one, it would be celery. I love its earthy flavor. Celery and black truffles are my favorite combination. They work in part because they come out of the ground at the same time of year. Any root vegetable also works with celery. I enjoy celery root and celery separately as well as together.

—**DANIEL HUMM**, ELEVEN MADISON PARK (NEW YORK CITY)

olive oil
onions, esp. red
paprika
parsley
peanuts and peanut butter
pepper, white
potatoes
rice
salads: chicken, potato, shrimp, tuna
salt
scallions
shallots
shellfish
stir-fried dishes
stocks: chicken, vegetable
stuffings
tarragon
thyme
tomatoes and tomato juice

truffles, black

turnips

vinegar: tarragon, wine

Flavor Affinities

celery + carrots + onions (aka mirepoix)

celery + tarragon + vinegar

CELERY ROOT

Season: autumn–spring

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: moderate

Techniques: boil, deep-fry, raw, roast, steam

Tips: Always peel before using.

allspice

apples

basil

bay leaf

beef

beets

brown butter

butter

capers

carrots

celery

celery leaves

cheese: Gruyère, Parmesan, Swiss

chervil

chicken

chives

coriander

cream

crème fraîche

dill

fennel leaves

fennel seeds

garlic

leeks

LEMON, JUICE

lovage

game birds

garlic
hazelnuts
marjoram
MAYONNAISE
mushrooms
MUSTARD, DIJON
nutmeg
oil: peanut, sesame, walnut
olive oil
olives
onions
oregano
paprika
parsley
parsnips
pecans
pepper, black
POTATOES, ESP. MASHED
rice
rutabagas
sage
salads, esp. green, tuna
salt, kosher
seafood
soups
stews
stocks: chicken, vegetable
tarragon
thyme
truffles, esp. black
turnips
veal
vegetables, root
vinaigrette
vinegar: cider, wine
watercress
wild rice

Flavor Affinities

celery root + cream + potatoes + vinegar

celery root + lemon + mayonnaise + mustard

CELERY SALT

Bloody Marys
eggs, hard-boiled
Tabasco sauce

Dishes

Celery Root Soup with Spiced Pumpernickel Bread, Confit Shallot, and Parsley Emulsion

—Charlie Trotter, Charlie Trotter's (Chicago)

CELERY SEED

Taste: bitter, pungent

Function: heating

Weight: light

Volume: moderate

allspice
bay leaf
beef
breads
Cajun/Creole cuisines
cheese, e.g., blue
chervil
chicken
coriander
crab
dill
eggplant
eggs
fennel seeds
fish
German cuisine
ginger
Italian cuisine
mayonnaise
mushrooms
mustard
onions
paprika
peas
pepper
potatoes
Russian cuisine
salads and salad dressings

sauces

shellfish

soups

stews

stuffing

thyme

tomatoes

vegetables and vegetable juices

Worcestershire sauce

CHAMOMILE

Taste: sweet

Asian cuisine

chicken

chocolate, white

desserts

fish (e.g., halibut)

honey

lemon

rice

tea

veal

CHAMPAGNE

Weight: light–medium

Volume: quiet–moderate

blackberries

caviar

cherries

cranberries

lemon

lime

melon

mint

raspberries

strawberries

CHARD

(aka Swiss chard)

Season: year-round

Taste: bitter

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: moderate–loud

Techniques: boil, braise, parboil, sauté, steam, stir-fry

anchovies

bacon

basil

bay leaf

bread crumbs

butter, unsalted

capers

cheese: Fontina, Gruyère, Parmesan

chickpeas

chile peppers

cilantro

cumin

cured meats

egg dishes

eggs, hard-boiled

***GARLIC**

Italian cuisine, esp. pasta

lamb, esp. chops

leeks

lemon: juice, zest

mushrooms, chanterelle

oil, peanut

olive oil

olives

onions, esp. spring or yellow

orange, zest

oregano
pasta (including using to color green pasta)
pepper: black, white
pine nuts
polenta
potatoes
raisins
red pepper flakes
saffron
salt, kosher
shallots
spinach
stews
stocks: chicken, vegetable
thyme
tomatoes
vinegar: balsamic, red wine

Flavor Affinities

chard + bell peppers + pecorino cheese + eggplant
chard + red pepper flakes + lemon juice

CHARDONNAY

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: quiet–loud

butter and butter sauces

chicken

crab

cream and cream sauces

fish

lobster

salmon

scallops

shellfish

veal



CHEESE—IN GENERAL

(See also specific cheeses)

Taste: sweet–sour

Function: cooling

apples
breads, esp. neutral-flavored
celery, esp. with cheese sauces and dishes
cherries, esp. with soft cheeses
cured meats, esp. ham
dates, esp. Medjool
dried fruits, esp. dates, figs grapes
nuts, esp. hazelnuts, walnuts
pears

Since **cheese** is a near-perfect food, I sometimes look for the few nutrients missing in cheese that can be found in other foods. The two essential nutrients that cheese does not provide are vitamin C and fiber. This recommends fruits especially—and makes a great start to the day: cheese, some high-fiber vitamin C–rich fruit, some whole grain organic bread, and coffee. The breads I prefer with cheese are usually neutral flavored, though I fully appreciate the nutty or herbed or fruity breads as natural partners for cheeses. The main reason I prefer neutral flavors in my breads is because I don’t want to meddle with the flavors in the cheeses themselves. I’m kind of a purist on that! Usually, the softer the cheese, the harder the bread—to an extent. And high-pectin, high-fiber fruits [e.g., apples, pears, apricots, plums, nectarines, peaches, figs] make natural accompaniments for many, many cheeses.

Which cheeses? My faves with my espresso to which I add a little unfiltered raw honey would be the pressed sheep milk cheeses: Ossau Iraty, Roncal, Zamorano, Berkswell, Spenswood, Trade Lake Cedar, Vermont Shepherd, manchego, or Pecorino Fogle Noce. But I’m happy with whatever is looking good, and preferably the harder aged cheeses: sheep, goat, or cow.

—MAX McCALMAN, ARTISANAL CHEESE CENTER (NEW YORK CITY)

CHEESE, ASIAGO

almonds
bacon
figs
grapes
Italian cuisine
pasta
potatoes
salads

With aged or strong **cheese**, you need something fruity or sweet to contrast with the strong flavor. Pecorino is very strong, so you need something sweet with it. With an aged or hard cheese, I like to serve some chestnut honey, a fruit jam, or watermelon confiture. If I have some aged goat cheese, I like a *mostarda* [Italian mustard fruit]. With sharper cheese, I also like a nice sweet wine, especially an Italian Passito. With fresh young cheese, I simply like some good bread. Chestnut honey, while good with aged cheese, does not work with a young cheese.

—ODETTE FADA, SAN DOMENICO (NEW YORK CITY)

Honey, jam, and *mostarda* go great with **cheese**. Most honey works best with younger cheeses and soft-ripened cheeses, especially if they have a chalky quality to them. I love mountain Gorgonzola with chestnut honey; it is crazy! In Italy, we call jam a *confitura* or *marmalata*. I like it with saltier cheeses like Parmesan, or with more assertive cheeses. *Mostarda* is made of fruits cooked in a white wine mustard syrup until they are candied. So, you have a sweet candy effect with the spicy mustard. It goes with any savory firm cheese, and particularly well with pecorino and Taleggio.

—GINA DEPALMA, BABBO (NEW YORK CITY)

CHEESE, AZEITAO

foie gras

CHEESE, BLUE

(See also Gorgonzola, Roquefort, Stilton, etc.)

almonds

apples

beef

bread, esp. with nuts and/or raisins

celery

chestnuts, roasted

cream cheese

dill

figs, esp. with Gorgonzola

garlic

hazelnuts

HONEY, esp. chestnut or tupelo

mustard, Dijon

pasta

PEARS, esp. with Stilton

port

potatoes

salt, kosher

sour cream

steaks

vinegar, white wine

walnut bread

walnuts, esp. with Stilton

walnuts, candied

watercress

CHEESE, BRIE

almonds

apples

bread, esp. French

cherries

chicken

crudités (e.g., raw carrots, celery)

dates

fennel

figs

French cuisine

nuts

melon

onions

pears

pistachios

strawberries

white wine

CHEESE, BURRATA

beans, fava

bread

garlic

Italian cuisine

olive oil

peaches

pesto

plums

salt, esp. sea

tomatoes

vincotto (cooked wine)

CHEESE, CABRALES

figs

grapes, esp. red

ham, Serrano

honey

pears

salads

steak

Dishes

Baked Blue Cheesecake Mousse with Rhubarb Compote and Celery Confit

—Dominique and Cindy Duby, Wild Sweets (Vancouver)

Bruschetta with Burrata Cheese, Caponata, and Fava Bean Puree

—Hiro Sone, Terra (St. Helena, California)

CHEESE, CAMEMBERT

arugula
fruit, fresh
grapes
lettuces (e.g., baby greens)
melon
nuts
olive oil
pears
pecans
plums
salads
strawberries
vinegar: balsamic, sherry

A wonderful combination I discovered recently that surprised me was **Azeitao cheese** with foie gras.

—MAX McCALMAN, ARTISANAL CHEESE CENTER (NEW YORK CITY)

I like **blue cheese**, either Roquefort or Stilton, served simply with a walnut bread and a glass of port.

—GABRIEL KREUTHER, THE MODERN (NEW YORK CITY)

In general, the more intense a **blue cheese** is in its own right, the lighter and more delicate the honey you'll want to pair it with. I like Colorado star thistle honey [which is creamy, with cinnamon notes].

—ADRIAN MURCIA, CHANTERELLE (NEW YORK CITY)

CHEESE, CHEDDAR

APPLES

bacon

brandy, apple, e.g., Calvados

bread, esp. French, pumpernickel, or whole wheat

butter, unsalted

cayenne

chutney, Indian

cider

cream

dates

egg dishes

fennel

garlic

grapes

hamburgers

honey, esp. fruit (e.g., blueberry, raspberry)

mirepoix, esp. for soup

mostarda (mustard fruits)

nuts

oil, vegetable

paprika

pasta, esp. macaroni

pears and pear paste

pecans

pepper, black

potatoes

quince paste

stock, chicken

thyme

walnuts

CHEESE, COLBY

apples

bacon

beer

bread, rye

cider, apple

onions

pears

potatoes

CHEESE, COMTÉ

ham

hazelnut oil

greens, salad

CHEESE, COW'S MILK—IN GENERAL

cherries

fruits, stone (e.g., apricots, cherries, nectarines, peaches, plums, etc.)

melons

CHEESE, CREAM
(See Cream Cheese)

CHEESE, EMMENTAL

bacon

bread, rye, esp. lighter

potatoes

CHEESE, ÉPOISSES

cherries

marmalade, citrus

pears

CHEESE, EXPLORATEUR

pomegranate

Cheddar is a particularly friendly **cheese** to food pairing partners.

—ADRIAN MURCIA, CHANTERELLE (NEW YORK CITY)

CHEESE, FETA

bell peppers, red

bread: olive, pita

cheese, ricotta

chickpeas

dill

Eastern Mediterranean cuisine

eggplant

figs

garlic

grapes

Greek cuisine

honey

lamb

lemon

meats, grilled

mint

olive oil

olives: black, Greek

onions, red

pasta

pepper, black

sage

salads

sauces

shrimp

spinach

thyme

vinegar, red wine

walnuts

watermelon

zucchini

Flavor Affinities

feta cheese + chicken + mint

feta cheese + roasted red bell peppers + mint

feta cheese + salad greens + mint

CHEESE, FONTINA

chutney

endive

fondue

fruit, fresh

grapes

mostarda (mustard fruits)

pears

plums

salads

sandwiches

walnuts

CHEESE, FROMAGE BLANC

cranberries, sweetened

figs

CHEESE, GARROTXA

figs

CHEESE, GOAT'S MILK—IN GENERAL

almonds

honey

nuts

oil, walnut

olive oil

olives

pepper, black

pomegranate

thyme

I enjoy the combination of cherries with Lancashire [a premier English cow's milk **cheese**].

—MAX McCALMAN, ARTISANAL CHEESE CENTER (NEW YORK CITY)

Dishes

Goat Cheese Tortelloni with Dried Orange and Wild Fennel Pollen

—Mario Batali, Babbo (New York City)

Rich Goat's Milk Cheesecake with Blossom Honey Ice Cream, Fuyu Persimmons, and Huckleberries

—Elizabeth Dahl, pastry chef, Naha (Chicago)

Mixed Green Salad with Coach Farm's Triple Crème Goat Cheese, Toasted Pumpkin Seeds, and Apple Cider Vinegar

—Gabriel Kreuther, The Modern (New York City)

Goat Cheese Salad: Braised Fennel, Toasted Hazelnuts, Orange, and Extra-Virgin Olive Oil

—Alfred Portale, Gotham Bar and Grill (New York City)

CHEESE, GOAT—FRESH

(e.g., chèvre)

almonds

apples, esp. green

apricots, esp. dried

basil

beets

bell peppers: green, esp. **red**

blackberries

bread, esp. French or with nuts, olives, and/or raisins, whole wheat

broccoli

butter

cauliflower

cheese: Parmesan, ricotta

cherries, sour or sweet

chervil

chives

cinnamon

cranberries, esp. dried

cream

dates

eggs

fennel

fennel seeds

figs

garlic

grapes

greens, salad, esp. arugula

herbs

honey

I enjoy pomegranate with my Ibores [a Spanish goat's milk **cheese**].

—**MAX McCALMAN**, ARTISANAL CHEESE CENTER (NEW YORK CITY)

Dishes

Almond-Infused Goat's Milk Cheesecake

—Carrie Nahabedian, Naha (Chicago)

Mediterranean “Greek Salad” of Mt. Vikos Feta, Kalamata Olives, Plum Tomatoes, Cucumbers, Torn Mint and Oregano, Warm Feta Cheese “Turnover”

—Carrie Nahabedian, Naha (Chicago)

I will pair thyme with **goat cheese** and cherries.

—MICHAEL LAISKONIS, LE BERNARDIN (NEW YORK CITY)

If you are going to make a dessert with cheese, you want it to be a softer cheese. I make a **goat cheese** cake with berries and for that I use a milder goat cheese. Goat cheese and lemon work really well together, because the acidity of the lemon juice cuts the fat of the goat cheese.

—EMILY LUCHETTI, FARALLON (SAN FRANCISCO)

I like strawberries with my Loire Valley **chèvres**.

—MAX McCALMAN, ARTISANAL CHEESE CENTER (NEW YORK CITY)

LEMON, juice

milk

mint

nutmeg

nuts

oil, sesame

olive oil

olives

onions, esp. green, Spanish, or Vidalia

orange: juice, zest

parsley, flat-leaf

pasta

pears: dried, fresh

pecans

pepper: black, white

pesto

pine nuts

pistachios

port

potatoes

raspberries

red pepper flakes

rosemary

rum, esp. light

sage

salami

salt, sea

shallots

sour cream

star anise

strawberries

sugar: brown, white

thyme

vegetables, raw

vinegar, cider

tarragon

thyme

tomatoes and tomato jam

vanilla

vinegar: balsamic, sherry

walnuts



Flavor Affinities

goat cheese + almonds + honey + pears
goat cheese + cherries + thyme
goat cheese + fennel seeds + orange zest + pasta
goat cheese + honey + persimmons
goat cheese + pancetta + shallots

Some enjoy the combination of chocolate and cheese. If the idea intrigues you, I recommend trying a good dark chocolate with an aged Alpine cheese [a style native to the French and Swiss Alps, of which **Gruyère** is one of the most famous], such as Hoch Ybrig, Appenzeller, or Prattigauer.

—MAX McCALMAN, ARTISANAL CHEESE CENTER (NEW YORK CITY)

Swiss mountain cheeses [e.g., Appenzeller, Comté, **Gruyère**] are a cheese snob's Holy Grail of cheeses. Their “cooked milk” character makes them great with dark, cooked fruit preserves such as fig preserves. They also go well with

oloroso sherry, which has its own dark, cooked fruit flavors.

—**ADRIAN MURCIA**, CHANTERELLE (NEW YORK CITY)

CHEESE, GORGONZOLA

apples

brandy

cherries: sour, sweet

cognac

corn

cream

dulce de leche

figs

grapes

honey, esp. chestnut

Italian cuisine

mint

nuts

olive oil

pasta

PEARS

pistachios

pomegranate

prosciutto

salads (e.g., spinach)

sugar

thyme

WALNUTS

wine, sweet

Flavor Affinities

Gorgonzola + mint + walnuts

CHEESE, GOUDA

apples, esp. with aged and/or smoked cheese

apricots

cherries, esp. with young cheese

melon

mushrooms

peaches, esp. with young cheese

pears, esp. with aged or smoked cheese

spinach

CHEESE, GRUYÈRE

apples

arugula

bread

cherries

chicken

chocolate, dark, esp. with aged Gruyère

fondues

garlic

ham

hazelnuts

onions

soufflés

soups, esp. onion

spinach

Swiss cuisine

thyme

walnuts

I enjoy raspberries with my **Hoja Santa**, with a little mint thrown in.

—MAX McCALMAN, ARTISANAL CHEESECENTER (NEW YORK CITY)

CHEESE, HOJA SANTA

mint

raspberries

CHEESE, JACK

almonds

figs

pears

pecans

prunes

quince paste

walnuts

CHEESE, MAHON

(aged Spanish cheese)

quince paste

CHEESE, MANCHEGO

ALMONDS, esp. roasted Spanish

anchovies

bell peppers, roasted

bread, esp. crusty and fig or other fruit bread

figs and fig cake

ham, Serrano

olive oil

olives, green or black Spanish

onions, esp. caramelized

parsley

peppers, piquillo

plum paste

***QUINCE PASTE**

salads

Spanish cuisine

tomatoes

Flavor Affinities

manchego cheese + almonds + quince paste

CHEESE, MASCARPONE
(See Mascarpone)

CHEESE, MONTEREY JACK

chicken
enchiladas
fresh fruit

CHEESE, MOZZARELLA

anchovies

BASIL

bell peppers, roasted

garlic

Italian cuisine

meats, cured (e.g., salami)

olive oil

olives

oregano

pancetta

pasta

pepper, black

pizza

prosciutto

radicchio

rosemary

sage

salt: kosher, sea

sopressata

spinach

***TOMATOES**

tomatoes, sun-dried

truffles, black

vinegar: balsamic, red wine

Flavor Affinities

mozzarella cheese + basil + olive oil + tomatoes

mozzarella cheese + olives + prosciutto

Dishes

Mozzarella di Bufala, Eggplant Agrodolce, Artichoke con Pesto

—Andrew Carmellini, A Voce (New York City)



CHEESE, MUENSTER

apples

bread, crusty

caraway seeds

cherries

fennel

grapes

CHEESE, PARMESAN

basil

beans, fava

carpaccio

dates

fennel

figs

fruits, stone

garlic

grapes

honey, esp. chestnut

ITALIAN CUISINE

melon

mushrooms

olive oil

PASTA

pears

pizza

prosciutto

risottos

thyme

vinegar, balsamic, esp. aged

walnuts

CHEESE, PECORINO

bacon

bell peppers, roasted

duck confit

grapes

greens, salad

honey, chestnut

lemon, juice

mostarda (mustard fruits)

olive oil

pasta

pears

pepper, white

prosciutto

ricotta cheese

sopressata

vinegar, balsamic, esp. aged

walnuts

CHEESE, PIAVE

cured meats

CHEESE, PROVOLONE

figs

grapes

Italian cuisine

lime, juice

olive oil

olives

pasta (e.g., lasagna)

pears

pizza

prosciutto

Piave cheese works with an array of different cured meats.

—MAX McCALMAN, ARTISANAL CHEESECENTER (NEW YORK CITY)

If you open my refrigerator at home, you will always find a piece of cheese! I love many cheeses, but there will definitely be a piece of **Parmigiano-Reggiano**. It never goes bad and is so versatile. I can cut a piece off to go with a glass of Prosecco as an apéritif, serve it after dinner with red wine, slice a piece for a sandwich, or grate it over some pasta.

—ODETTE FADA, SAN DOMENICO (NEW YORK CITY)

I was in Parma, Italy, in a restaurant and out came my glass of Prosecco followed by the server cutting off hunks of **Parmigiano-Reggiano** to serve me. I thought it was a beautiful way to begin! It is a way to leave your world behind, and begin your meal.

—HOLLY SMITH, CAFÉ JUANITA (SEATTLE)

Dishes

Parmesan Broth with Prosciutto and Peas, Scallion Parmesan Flan

—Sanford D’Amato, Sanford (Milwaukee)

CHEESE, REBLOCHON

fennel

panforte (Italian fruit and nut cake)

pistachios

CHEESE, RICOTTA

almonds

apricots

bacon

basil

beans, fava

berries

blueberries

bread

cheese: mozzarella, Parmesan, pecorino

cheesecake

chestnuts

chives

chocolate, dark

cinnamon

coffee / espresso

cream

dates

egg dishes (e.g., frittatas, omelets)

figs, esp. dried

fruits, dried

garlic

hazelnuts

herbs

HONEY, esp. chestnut, eucalyptus, or lavender

Italian cuisine

lemon, esp. juice, zest

mace

mascarpone

nutmeg

olive oil

orange, esp. juice, zest

Gina DePalma of New York's Babbo on Babbo's Cheese Plate

At Babbo, I oversee the cheese selection, which has seven choices. The biggest challenge with Italian cheese is that there are so many “superstars” that you just can't *not* offer them. So, in the seven slots we have many standard choices but they are amazing:

- **Parmigiano-Reggiano:** This is the “undisputed king of all cheeses” according to Mario [Batali]!
- **Taleggio:** This washed-rind cheese is very wet, has the distinctive orange color, and is gooey. The interior is sweet and the rind is assertive.
- **Gorgonzola Piccante:** This is firmer, bluer, nutty, and just amazing!
- **Coach Farm Goat:** Though it is not from Italy, it is the goat cheese we choose. [Mario Batali's wife's family owns the Coach Farm Dairy.]
- **Robiola:** This is a soft-ripened cheese from Piedmont.
- **Pecorino:** This is a sheep's milk cheese that is nothing like the Pecorino-Romano that you get in your deli to grate over pasta. This is made in many areas around Italy. We may use one from the south or Tuscany or one that is rubbed with tomato or aged underground from another part of the country.
- **The Seventh Cheese:** I play around with the seventh cheese and change it often but a recent favorite is a **Piave**, which is like an English Cheddar. It is from the Veneto along the Piave River.

parsley, flat-leaf

pasta

pepper, black

pine nuts

prosciutto

Prosecco

prunes

raisins

raspberries

rum, esp. dark

salt, kosher

sorrel

spinach

strawberries

sugar

tapenade
tarragon
tomatoes
vanilla
vinegar, balsamic
walnuts, esp. candied or toasted
wine, red, sweet

Flavor Affinities

ricotta + bread + honey + Prosecco

On our brunch menu with our corn and saffron pancakes, we serve fresh **ricotta** to be used instead of butter.

—BRAD FARMERIE, PUBLIC (NEW YORK CITY)

CHEESE, ROQUEFORT

butter, unsalted

cognac

cream

figs

honey

leeks

oil, walnut

pears

pepper

potatoes, creamer

salt

vinaigrette

walnuts

wine: red, **SAUTERNES**

Flavor Affinities

Roquefort cheese + figs + pears

CHEESE, SHEEP'S MILK—IN GENERAL

almonds

apricots

bread, esp. olive

ham, esp. Serrano

honey

nuts

olive oil

olives

panforte

pepper, black

quince paste

Dishes

Bruschetta with Favas and New York State Ricotta

—Mario Batali, Babbo (New York City)

Sheep's Milk Ricotta Ravioli with Heirloom Tomato, Arugula, Vin Cotto

—Andrew Carmellini, A Voce (New York City)

Ricotta and Robiola Cheesecake with Figs and Raspberries

—Gina DePalma, pastry chef, Babbo (New York City)

Corn and Saffron Pancakes with a Spicy Poached Pear and Fresh Ricotta

—Brad Farmerie, Public (New York City)

Bellwether Farms Ricotta Fritters with Cara Cara and Blood Orange Compote, Vanilla Crème Anglaise

—Emily Luchetti, pastry chef, Farallon (San Francisco)

Ricotta Gnocchi with Fava Beans, Sage, and Lemon Oil

—Judy Rodgers, Zuni Café (San Francisco)

I'm a fan of apricot with Berkswell [an English **sheep's milk cheese**].

—MAX McCALMAN, ARTISANAL CHEESE CENTER (NEW YORK CITY)

CHEESE, SPANISH

(See Cheese: Cabrales, Manchego)

CHEESE, STILTON

apples

dates

honey

pears

pecans

port

salads

sauces

walnuts

CHEESE, SWISS

asparagus

bread, esp. pumpernickel

grapes

ham

pears

CHEESE, TALEGGIO

hazelnuts

mostarda (mustard fruits)

pears

CHEESE, TRIPLE CRÈME

cherries

figs

hazelnuts

herbs

honey

m0starda (mustard fruits)

nut bread

olives

pears

vegetables, roasted

walnuts

CHEESE, VACHERIN

cherries

hazelnuts

CHEESE, VALDEON

meats: cured, smoked
steak

CHEESE, VERMONT SHEPHERD

almonds

apples

fennel

CHERRIES—IN GENERAL

Season: late spring–late summer

Taste: sweet

Weight: light–medium

Volume: moderate

Techniques: flambé, poach, raw, stew

allspice

ALMONDS

amaretto

apricots

Armagnac

bourbon

brandy

butter, unsalted

buttermilk

cake

caramel

cassis

cheese: Brie, goat, ricotta

cherries, dried

CHOCOLATE, ESP. DARK, WHITE

cinnamon

cloves

coconut

coffee / espresso

cognac

coriander

CREAM AND ICE CREAM

cream cheese

crème fraîche

crust: pastry, pie

currants, red

custards (e.g., crème caramel, flan, etc.)

duck

fennel

figs

game birds

garlic

ginger

goose

Grand Marnier

hazelnuts

honey

ice cream, vanilla

***KIRSCH**

LEMON: juice, zest

lime, juice

liqueur: almond, orange

mascarpone

meats, fatty, esp. roasted

melon

meringue

nectarines

nuts

oats

orange: juice, zest

pâté

peaches

pecans

pepper: black, green

pistachios

plums

pork

port, esp. ruby

poultry, fatty, esp. roasted

quince

raspberries

rice pudding

rose hips

rum

sage, esp. with tart cherries

salads

salt

sour cream

stocks: chicken, duck, veal

SUGAR

VANILLA

vermouth, sweet

vinegar: balsamic, ice wine, red wine

vodka

walnuts

WINE: dry red (e.g., **Bordeaux, Merlot**), sparkling wine/Champagne

yogurt

Flavor Affinities

cherries + almonds + cream + kirsch + vanilla

cherries + chocolate + walnuts

cherries + coconut + custard

cherries + coffee + cream

cherries + goat cheese + ice wine vinegar + black pepper + thyme

cherries + honey + pistachios + yogurt

cherries + mint + vanilla

cherries + orange + sugar + dry red wine

cherries + sweet vermouth + vanilla

Cherries can stand up to a lot of flavors. They have more juice to them as well as complexity. Almonds go with cherries. Dark chocolate actually goes better with cherries than it does raspberries, and white chocolate works with cherries as well.

—EMILY LUCHETTI, FARALLON (SAN FRANCISCO)



If you have perfect ingredients in the summertime, you don't have to do much to them. With our perfect **cherries** [Michigan, while at Tribute restaurant], we halved them, sprinkled them with sugar, and heated them with a blowtorch so that they were just warmed through. The slightly caramelized sugar made a huge difference in the flavor. I used a goat cream cheese worked to a texture similar to mascarpone cheese, which I shaped into quenelles. Served alongside were some ice wine vinegar caramel sauce and a crispy crepe. Before serving, I added individual thyme leaves and a crack of black pepper. These are all really classic flavors, especially the cheese with black pepper and cherries.

—MICHAEL LAISKONIS, LE BERNARDIN (NEW YORK CITY)

I was reading an old Fannie Farmer cookbook from the late 1800s about making **cherry** jam. In the recipe, they would take the cherry pits and crush them. I thought it was crazy but tried it. When you take cherry pits and crush them, it gives you an almond flavor. I made some pickled sour cherries with the crushed pits in cheesecloth with the pickling liquid and I got this great almondy flavor that went deep inside the cherries.

—ANDREW CARMELLINI, A VOCE (NEW YORK CITY)

I like to let them shine on their own. But I do really like **cherries** and grappa. Mario [Batali] has a home in Michigan and he brought me back a case of cherries. They were so perfect I just macerated them in grappa and torn mint leaves. I served them in a bowl with a dollop of mascarpone. Cherries also work well with mint.

—GINA DEPALMA, BABBO (NEW YORK CITY)

I loved **cherries** so much growing up that I would climb up our cherry tree and eat as many as I could. Then I would realize I didn't know how to get back down and would cry until the neighbors would get me down. I still love cherries and especially in cherry pie or a *clafoutis*. Cherries work well with vanilla or poached in red wine, but I like to keep them as simple as possible.

—GABRIEL KREUTHER, THE MODERN (NEW YORK CITY)

Dishes

Cherry-Almond Blancmange over Frangipane and Crème Fraîche Soup

—Dominique and Cindy Duby, Wild Sweets (Vancouver)

Warm Black Garnet Cherry–Rhubarb Pie with Almond Butter Crunch Ice Cream

—Emily Luchetti, pastry chef, Farallon (San Francisco)

Black Garnet Cherries, Strawberries, Pistachios, Marshall Farms Honey, Straus Organic Whole Milk Yogurt

—Emily Luchetti, pastry chef, Farallon (San Francisco)

CHERVIL

Season: spring–autumn

Weight: delicate, soft-leaved

Volume: very quiet

Tips: Always use chervil fresh, not cooked.

asparagus

basil

beans, esp. fava, green

beets

bouquet garni (key ingredient)

carrots

cheese, ricotta

chicken

chives

crab

cream

cream cheese

dill

eggs and egg dishes

fennel

finest herbes (key ingredient, along with chives, parsley, tarragon)

fish

French cuisine

game birds

halibut

herbes de Provence (typical ingredient, along with basil, fennel, marjoram, rosemary, sage, summer savory, and thyme)

leeks

lemon, juice

lemon thyme

lettuce

lobster

marjoram

mint
mushrooms
mustard
parsley
peas
potatoes
poultry

One thing chervil has going for it is its looks. **Chervil** is so cute, it is adorable! You can very carefully make little tiny brushes of them and put them around the plate. Not only does it taste good, but it says to the people eating the dish that you are taking care of them.

—**DAVID WALTUCK**, CHANTERELLE (NEW YORK CITY)

Provençal cuisine
salads, esp. potato, and salad dressings
sauces, esp. creamy scallops
shallots
shellfish
sole
soups, esp. creamy
spinach
squash
tarragon
thyme
tomatoes and tomato sauces
veal
vegetables
venison
vinaigrettes
vinegar
watercress

Flavor Affinities

chervil + chives + fish + parsley

chervil + chives + parsley + tarragon (fines herbes)

CHESTNUTS

Season: autumn–winter

Taste: sweet

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: quiet–moderate

Techniques: boil, candy, grill, puree, raw, roast

APPLES: CIDER, FRUIT, JUICE

Armagnac

bacon

bay leaf

brandy

Brussels sprouts

butter, unsalted

caramel

cardamom

celery

celery root

celery seeds

cheese, ricotta

chicken (accompaniment)

chocolate, esp. dark or white

cinnamon

cloves

coffee

cognac

CREAM OR MILK

crème fraîche

desserts

duck

fennel

fennel seeds

figs

game (accompaniment)

ginger

ham

honey, esp. chestnut

Italian cuisine, esp. Tuscan

lemon, juice

lentils

maple syrup

mascarpone

meats

mushrooms: cepes/porcini

nutmeg

olive oil

onions

orange

pasta

pears

pepper: black, white

plums

pork (accompaniment)

poultry (e.g., chicken, turkey)

prosciutto

prunes

Dishes

Chestnut Spice Cake with Mascarpone Cream

—Gina DePalma, pastry chef, Babbo (New York City)

Chestnut Sugar Tart, Crème Fraîche

—Johnny Iuzzini, pastry chef, Jean Georges (New York City)

I like to take one ingredient and see how much I can do with it. I made a frozen chestnut semifreddo with bits of candied **chestnuts**. This was then set on an orange-soaked chestnut sponge cake, next to a chestnut wafer and chestnut paste. I needed a complementary flavor, and I have always liked the combination of pear and chestnut. They both have a richness but depending on how the pear is handled, it can add freshness and acidity. I roasted the pear in sugar, butter, and ice wine vinegar and finished it in the oven until soft. The pear was then diced tartare-like and had orange confit added. The juices from the pear were the only sauce.

—MICHAEL LAISKONIS, LE BERNARDIN (NEW YORK CITY)

Chestnuts have a bursty flavor and they work with chocolate and pears. You have to combine them with earthy flavors. If you paired chestnuts with berries, they would just get lost.

—EMILY LUCHETTI, FARALLON (SAN FRANCISCO)

raisins
raspberries
risotto
rum
sage
salt, sea

sauces

sausages

shallots

sherry

stews

STOCK, CHICKEN

stuffing (e.g., for poultry)

sugar: brown, white

sweet potatoes

thyme

vanilla

wine, esp. sweet Marsala or sherry

AVOID

berries

Flavor Affinities

chestnuts + apples + cream

chestnuts + bacon + fennel

chestnuts + crème fraîche + sugar

chestnuts + orange + pear

CHICKEN

Function: heating

Weight: medium

Volume: quiet

Techniques: bake, braise, broil, deep-fry, grill, poach, roast, sauté, steam, stew, stir-fry

allspice

almonds

anise

apples

apricots, dried

artichokes

avocadoes

bacon

bananas

BASIL: regular, cinnamon

BAY LEAF

beans: red, white

beer

bell peppers: red, green, yellow

bouquet garni

brandy, esp. apple (in sauce)

bread crumbs or *panko*

BUTTER, UNSALTED

buttermilk

Calvados

capers

cardamom

CARROTS

cashews (e.g., Indian cuisine, etc.)

cauliflower

cayenne

celery

celery root
celery seeds
chard

cheese: Asiago, blue, Comté, Emmental, Fontina, Parmesan

chervil

chicken livers

chickpeas

chile peppers: dried red (e.g., chipotle), fresh green (e.g., jalapeño)

chives

cider

cilantro

CINNAMON

cloves

coconut milk (e.g., Indian cuisine, etc.)

coriander

corn

cranberries: dried

cream (e.g., French, Indian cuisine, etc.)

crème fraîche

cumin

currants

curry leaves (e.g., Indian cuisine)

curry powder

curry sauce

daikon

dates

dill

dumplings

endive

escarole

fenugreek

figs

finest herbes (i.e., chervil, chives, parsley, tarragon)

fish sauce, Thai

five-spice powder

galangal

garam masala (e.g., Indian cuisine)

GARLIC**GINGER:** fresh, ground

Grand Marnier

grapefruit, juice

grapes and grape juice

greens

guava

ham

hazelnuts

hoisin sauce

Red beans and rice with andouille sausage is my favorite! When we opened up after the hurricane [Katrina] and were serving on paper plates, I made a roasted Tabasco **chicken** served with dirty rice, with the sausage stuffed in a bell pepper alongside red bean puree. For another dish, I was inspired by a diner down the street from us that had chicken and waffles on the menu, which is an old Southern dish. My take is to make a savory waffle and to add Boursin cheese with lots of herbs. Then I pair it with chicken thighs braised in a *coq au vin blanc* and serve it with spinach. The dish is simple, but I just love the flavors.

—**BOB IACOVONE**, CUVÉE (NEW ORLEANS)



Dishes

Taquitos de Pollo: Crispy Taquitos Filled with Chicken and Poblanos, with Homemade Sour Cream, Salsa Verde, Añejo Cheese, and Guacamole

—Rick Bayless, Frontera Grill (Chicago)

Chicken Braised in Black Pepper Gravy with Summer Root Vegetables, Hen o’ Woods Mushrooms, and Rosemary Cream Biscuits

—Jeffrey Bubben, Vidalia (Washington, DC)

Hoffman Ranch Breast of Chicken with Chanterelles and Thyme Jus

—Traci Des Jardins, Jardinière (San Francisco)

Chicken Tagine with Olives, Preserved Lemons, and Green Peas

—Lahsen Ksiyer, Casaville (New York City)

Half a Chicken Cut in Pieces and Braised in a Tequila–White Vinegar Sauce with Green Olives, Golden Raisins, and Almonds

—Zarela Martinez, Zarela (New York City)

“Southern Fried” Chicken Salad, Roasted Sweet Corn, Candied Pecans, Shaved Red Onions, and Buttermilk Ranch Dressing

—Carrie Nahabedian, Naha (Chicago)

Balsamic-Caramel Chicken with Broccoli and Walnuts

—Monica Pope, T’afia (Houston)

Roast Chicken Breast with Wild Mushrooms, Creamy Polenta, and White Truffle Oil

—Alfred Portale, Gotham Bar and Grill (New York City)

**Boneless Chicken Breast in Peruvian Adobo Roasted in Our Wood-Burning Oven,
Pumpkin and Mango Sauce, Ripe Plantain, and Eggplant Puree**

—Maricel Presilla, Cucharamama (Hoboken, New Jersey)

Apricot Curry Chicken Salad with Fennel, Cilantro, and Dried Fruit

—Charlie Trotter, Trotter's to Go (Chicago)

**Lemon-Ghee Marinated and Grilled Specialty Chicken Breast with Roasted Garlic and
Cashews**

—Vikram Vij and Meeru Dhalwala, Vij's (Vancouver)

Roasted Chicken with Green Olive, Coriander, and Ginger Sauce

—Jean-Georges Vongerichten, Jojo (New York City)

honey

kale

leeks

LEMON: juice, zest

lemongrass

lime, juice

mangoes

maple syrup

marjoram

mayonnaise

mint

mirepoix

molasses

MUSHROOMS: cultivated or wild (e.g., ceps, chanterelles, morels,
portobello, shiitake, white)

mustard: Dijon, dry, yellow mustard seeds

nutmeg

nuts: cashews, peanuts

OIL: canola, grapeseed, hazelnut, **peanut**, safflower, sesame, vegetable

OLIVE OIL

OLIVES: black, green, kalamata, niçoise

ONIONS: cipollini, pearl, red, Spanish, spring, sweet orange: juice, zest

oregano

pancetta

paprika

PARSLEY, FLAT-LEAF (garnish)

parsnips

peaches

peanuts

pears

peas: black-eyed, green

PEPPER: BLACK, PINK, WHITE

pesto

pine nuts

polenta (accompaniment)

pomegranates and pomegranate molasses

poppy seeds

potatoes (accompaniment)

prosciutto

prunes

raisins

red pepper flakes

rice

ROSEMARY, fresh

saffron

sage

SALT: *fleur de sel*, kosher, sea

sauces, Mornay

sausages, esp. spicy (e.g., andouille)

savory

scallions

sesame seeds

shallots

sherry, dry (e.g., manzanilla)

sour cream

soy sauce

spinach

star anise

STOCKS: chicken, veal

sugar: brown, white (pinch)

sweet potatoes

Tabasco sauce

TARRAGON

THYME, FRESH

TOMATOES AND TOMATO PASTE

truffles

turmeric

turnips

vanilla

vermouth

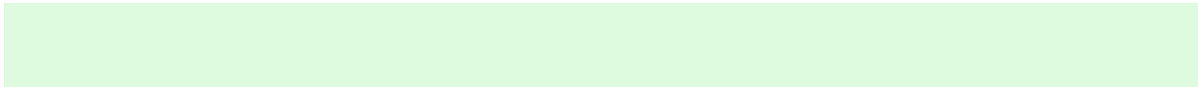
VINEGAR: balsamic, Chinese black, cider, red wine, sherry, tarragon, white wine

waffles

whiskey

WINE: dry to off-dry white (e.g., Riesling), dry red, rice, sweet wine, vermouth

yogurt



Andrew Carmellini of New York's A Voce on Cooking Chicken as a Two-Part Process— and Applying It to Chicken Cacciatore

1. *Brining*: Sometimes the older techniques inspire me for deeper flavors. Many of these techniques are overlooked. Take brining, for instance. Brining has been done forever with pork chops and chicken, and for the last five years you have heard about it with turkey. The success of brining is more about the salt and it getting in there and softening the protein strands. It is less about all the other flavoring agents.

If you want to get started in your kitchen, start with a skin- and bone-on chicken breast. Grab some kosher salt, sugar, or honey as I do, some water, and brine the breast for 30 minutes. When you pull it out of the brine, rinse it, dry it, and let it sit in the refrigerator for a couple of hours so the moisture comes out. You will notice the difference in the texture. The marinated chicken—even if you overcook it—will not be dry. It is the best.

2. *Marinating*: The chicken on my menu right now is brined and then marinated for 24 hours. It is crazy how good the chicken becomes. The marinade is made up of roasted garlic, Sicilian oregano, red pepper flakes, lots of lemon, thyme, and olive oil. We joke that it tastes like Zesty Italian Wish-Bone Dressing. It is so delicious.

The finished dish is served with poached and sautéed artichoke, roasted pepper grilled over wood, fennel, and roasted spring onions. These vegetables are all tossed with pesto, and the dish is finished with a tomato sauce made with foamy tomato water and thyme.

Chicken Cacciatore

We opened up A Voce with chicken cacciatore on our menu and when people heard the name of the dish, they'd just yawn. A lot of times, this dish is just chicken scaloppine with peppers and tomatoes. Ours is a whole different dish: the chicken is on the bone, and brined first, which makes it nice and moist. With it, we serve a homemade peperonata with roasted peppers, onions, garlic, red pepper flakes, rosemary, fresh bay leaf, fresh thyme, and *piment d'Espelette* [a pepper from France with a smoky flavor]. Here is a place where technique plays a role in the flavor: When you roast peppers, the best way to get the skin off is to put them in a bowl covered with plastic wrap and let them steam. When they are done, you are left with the pepper liquid. What we do is cook with that liquid.

To finish this dish, we put a big scoop of the pepper mixture, tomato sauce, garlic puree, onion, red wine vinegar, and fresh bay leaf on the chicken and put it in the oven to roast. The chicken cooks in its own juice then is served with roasted potatoes. It is delicious.

What we are doing is layering the flavors. You have the technique of brining the chicken, elevating the flavor profile of the peppers with the sweetness of the onions and herbs, adding a little heat from the *piment d'Espelette*, and giving body to the sauce from the pepper juice, which is distilled pepper brandy.

Flavor Affinities

chicken + andouille sausage + red beans + rice

chicken + apples + endive + walnuts
chicken + asparagus + ginger
chicken + avocado + bacon + garlic + mayonnaise + tarragon
chicken + basil + cinnamon
chicken + chanterelle mushrooms + rosemary
chicken + cloves + rosemary + yogurt
chicken + coconut + galangal + shiitake mushrooms
chicken + coriander + cumin + garlic
chicken + cream + grapefruit + pink peppercorns
chicken + cream + morels
chicken + cumin + garlic + lemon
chicken + figs + honey + thyme + dry white wine
chicken + fines herbes + mushrooms + spring onions
chicken + garlic + lemon
chicken + garlic + pancetta + sage + thyme
chicken + mustard + thyme

CHICKEN LIVERS

(See Liver, Chicken)

CHICKPEAS

(aka garbanzo beans)

Season: summer

Function: cooling

Techniques: simmer

apple cider or juice

basil

bay leaf

bell peppers, esp. red

bread

butter, unsalted

cardamom

carrots

cayenne

cheese, feta

chicken

chile peppers: dried red, fresh green (e.g., jalapeño)

chives

cilantro

cinnamon

cloves

coriander

couscous

cumin, esp. toasted (e.g., Indian cuisine, etc.)

curry leaves

curry powder

fennel

fennel seeds

garam masala (e.g., Indian cuisine)

GARLIC

ginger

greens (e.g., chard, spinach) ham, Serrano

hummus (key ingredient) Indian cuisine

Italian cuisine (as garbanzo beans)

leeks

LEMON: juice, zest

lemon, preserved

lemon thyme

Mediterranean cuisine

Mexican cuisine

Middle Eastern cuisine

mint

OLIVE OIL

olives, black

ONIONS: RED, YELLOW

paprika, esp. smoked or sweet

parsley, flat-leaf

pasta

pepper: black, white

pork

potatoes

prosciutto

raisins

red pepper flakes

rice, esp. basmati (accompaniment)

rosemary

saffron

sage

salads

SALT, KOSHER

scallions

sesame seeds

shrimp

soups

spinach

squash, winter

stews

stocks: chicken, vegetable

tabbouleh (key ingredient)

tahini

tamarind

thyme

tomatoes

turmeric

vinegar, esp. balsamic, red wine, sherry

walnuts and walnut oil

yogurt (e.g., Indian cuisine)

Flavor Affinities

chickpeas + cayenne + garlic + lemon juice + olive oil + salt + tahini

chickpeas + cilantro + cumin

chickpeas + garlic + lemon juice + olive oil + thyme

chickpeas + garlic + mint

chickpeas + garlic + olive oil + parsley

CHICORY

(See also Endive; Lettuces—Bitter Greens and Chicories; and Radicchio)

Season: autumn–spring

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate

Techniques: grill, raw

apples

bacon

capers

cheese, esp. Gruyère and/or fresh

cilantro

crème fraîche

cumin

figs

fish, smoked

garlic

ham, Serrano

lemon

lettuces

meats and poultry, richer

nuts

olive oil

paprika, smoked

parsley

prosciutto

salads

salmon, smoked

watercress

Dishes

Preserved Lemon Hummus; Roasted Red Pepper and Walnut Puree

—Monica Pope, T'afia (Houston)

Dishes

Chicory Salad with Fall Root Vegetables, Shaved Pear, and Rapeseed-Mustard Vinaigrette

—Daniel Boulud, Daniel (New York City)

CHILE PEPPERS—IN GENERAL

Season: summer

Taste: hot

Weight: light–medium (from fresh to dried)

Volume: moderate–very loud (from dried to fresh)

Techniques: raw, roast, sauté

Tips: Add at the end of the cooking process. The spiciness of chile peppers suggests “false heat.”

Asian cuisine

avocado

bananas

basil

bay leaf

BEANS, ESP. BLACK, PINTO

Cajun cuisine

Caribbean cuisine

cayenne

cheese: Fontina, goat, mozzarella, Parmesan

Chinese cuisine

chocolate

CILANTRO, esp. in Latin American cuisine

cinnamon

coconut and coconut milk, esp. in Asian cuisine

coriander

corn

cumin

CURRIES (key ingredient)

eggplant

fennel

fish sauce, esp. in Asian cuisine

fruit, esp. citrus

GARLIC

GINGER, esp. in Asian cuisine

Indian cuisine

ketchup

Latin American cuisine

lemon, juice

lemongrass

lentils

LIME, JUICE

mangoes

marjoram

***MEXICAN CUISINE**

mole sauces

mushrooms

mustard

olive oil

olives

onions

oregano

Pakistani cuisine

parsley, flat-leaf

peanuts, esp. in Asian cuisine

pineapple

rice

rosemary

saffron

salads, esp. bean

salsas and other sauces

seafood

sesame and sesame oil, esp. in Asian cuisine

shallots

Southwestern American cuisine soy sauce

stews

sweet vegetables (e.g., beets, carrots, corn)

***THAI CUISINE**

thyme

tomatoes and tomato sauces

verbena

vinegar: balsamic, red wine, sherry

yogurt

Flavor Affinities

chile peppers + cilantro + lime



CHILE PEPPERS, ANAHEIM

Taste: hot, sweet

Weight: medium

Volume: very quiet–loud

salads

salsas

stuffed peppers

CHILE PEPPERS, ANCHO

(dried poblanos)

Taste: hot, sweet

Weight: medium

Volume: quiet–loud

cashews

chili

saucés, esp. mole

soups

turkey

CHILE PEPPERS, CHIPOTLE

(dried, smoked jalapeño peppers)

Taste: very hot, smoky

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate–very loud

avocado

beans

Central American cuisine

chicken

chili

chocolate

cilantro

game

garlic

lemon, juice

lime, juice

mayonnaise

Mexican cuisine

molasses

olive oil

onions

orange, juice

paprika

pork

rice

salsas and sauces

salt, esp. kosher

soups

stews

sugar

Tex-Mex cuisine

tomatoes

vinegar, white

CHILE PEPPERS, GUAJILLO

Taste: hot

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate–loud

eggs

jicama

lime

pork

sauces

soups

stews

tomatoes

CHILE PEPPERS, HABANERO

Taste: very hot, sweet

Weight: medium

Volume: very loud+

fish (e.g., snapper)

lemon, juice

onions

pork

salsas and sauces

sugar

CHILE PEPPERS, JALAPEÑO

Taste: very hot

Weight: medium

Volume: very loud

cheese

cinnamon

lemon, juice

olive oil

onions, white

salsas and sauces

salt, sea

soups

CHILE PEPPERS, PASILLA

(dried chilacas) Taste: hot

Weight: medium

Volume: quiet–loud

mole

sauces

CHILE PEPPERS, PIMENTS D'ESPELETTE

Taste: hot

Weight: medium

Volume: quiet–moderate

cheese, French or Spanish

French Basque cuisine

olive oil

Spanish Basque cuisine

I have made a red-hot apple gelée that was a garnish to a *panna cotta*, taking apple cider and infusing it with cinnamon and **jalapeño chile**—which ended up tasting like red-hot candy. I like using fresh jalapeños in an infusion, or an *espelette* as a finishing note. I also love the idea of chipotle chile paired with chocolate ice cream.

—MICHAEL LAISKONIS, LE BERNARDIN (NEW YORK CITY)

CHILE PEPPERS, POBLANO

Taste: hot

Weight: medium

Volume: quiet–moderate

chile peppers, chipotle

chiles rellenos

cilantro

corn

garlic

onions

salads

salsas

tomatoes

vegetables, roasted

CHILE PEPPERS, SERRANO

Taste: very hot

Weight: medium

Volume: very loud+

Bloody Marys

chili powder

cilantro

coriander

cumin

garlic

molasses

oil, vegetable

olive oil

onions, yellow

orange, juice

salsas

stock, chicken

vinegar, white

CHILEAN CUISINE

(See also Latin American Cuisines)

chile peppers

corn

cumin

garlic

meats

olives

oregano

paprika

pepper, black

raisins

CHILI PASTE

Taste: hot

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: loud

Asian cuisine

beef

marinades

pork

saucers

CHILI POWDER

Taste: hot

Weight: light

Volume: quiet–loud

cumin

Tabasco sauce

tequila

CHINESE CUISINE

(See also Szechuan Cuisine)

Techniques: fry, stir-fry

cabbage
chicken
chile peppers
cinnamon
duck
fish
garlic
ginger
hoisin sauce
peanuts
pork

RICE

scallions
seafood
sesame: oil, seeds
shrimp: fresh, dried
snow peas

SOY SAUCE

star anise
steaming
stock, chicken
sugar
tofu
vegetables
vinegar, rice wine
wheat (e.g., noodles), esp. in northern China
wine, rice

In **Chinese cooking** they have a technique called “red cooking” that is a dish

braised or steamed with star anise, dark soy sauce, cinnamon, and rock sugar. I cook the oxtail for my timbale of oxtail and foie gras that way, and then clarify the broth and turn it into the aspic that holds the dish together. The foie gras is cooked separately and made into a terrine. The dish is then served with gingery pickled vegetables. It is not a Chinese dish in that it is not a dish that you would find in a Chinese restaurant, but it has Chinese influences. The idea of clarifying the broth is typically French. The use of foie gras is not very Chinese. The pickled vegetables are like something you might find in Chinese cooking, but they are done in perfect dice and served as a relish.

—**DAVID WALTUCK**, CHANTERELLE (NEW YORK CITY)



Flavor Affinities

cabbage + chicken stock

garlic + ginger + pork

ginger + rice wine + soy sauce

soy sauce + sugar

CHINESE FIVE-SPICE POWDER
(See Five-Spice Powder)

CHIVES

Season: spring–autumn

Botanical relatives: garlic, leeks, onions, shallots

Weight: light, soft-leaved

Volume: quiet–moderate

Tips: Always use fresh, not cooked. Use in stir-fries.

avocados

basil

beans, green

butter

CHEESE, esp. cheddar, ricotta, and cheese sauces

chervil

chicken

Chinese cuisine

cilantro

cream and cream sauces

cream cheese

crème fraîche

dill

EGGS, EGG DISHES, AND OMELETS

fennel

finest herbes (ingredient, along with chervil, parsley, tarragon)

fish

garlic

herbs, most other

marjoram

onions, esp. green

paprika

parsley

pasta

pork

POTATOES

salads and salad dressings

sauces, esp. cheese and cream based

shellfish

smoked salmon

sole

sorrel

SOUPS, esp. cream based and cold (e.g., vichyssoise)

sour cream

tarragon

thyme

vegetables and root vegetables

vinaigrettes

zucchini

You can't cook without onions, and **chives** are a delicate way to get that flavor into a dish. They are good in a soup or a sauce. A chive oil is great drizzled around a plate for flavor as well as appearance.

—**DAVID WALTUCK**, CHANTERELLE

My chocolate-corn dessert [of soft chocolate ganache and sweet corn in three textures: crunchy corn and hazelnut corn sorbet, and corn tuile] was inspired by freeze-dried corn. [The kernels] are whole with a vibrant sweetness. Corn dates back to the Aztecs, who also loved **chocolate**, so it's funny when people ask, "Where'd you get the inspiration?" This starts with a layer of milk chocolate hazelnut praline paste, then the corn, and then crushed wafers that give it that Kit Kat candy bar texture; on top of that is some chocolate ganache, then a layer of chocolate. To play off those flavors I serve some *espelette* [pepper] to give a little heat and some smoked salt from Wales. This dish is about the interplay of the chocolate and the corn. The *espelette* gives a heat that reminds me of roasted corn salsa. This is an ode to the origin of the inspiration.

—**MICHAEL LAISKONIS**, LE BERNARDIN (NEW YORK CITY)

It is hard to think of a fruit or nut that is not improved by combining it with **chocolate**.

—**MICHEL RICHARD**, CITRONELLE (WASHINGTON, DC)

I love **chocolate** with fruit or nuts or both. My favorite candy bar in the world is a Cadbury Fruit and Nut bar. On my menu I have a chocolate, hazelnut, and orange dessert, which is essentially a Cadbury!

—GINA DEPALMA, BABBO (NEW YORK CITY)

CHOCOLATE / COCOA—IN GENERAL

Taste: bitter–sweet (depending on sugar content)

achiote

allspice

ALMONDS

anise seeds

apricots

Armagnac

BANANAS

basil

beverages

boar

bourbon

brandy

brioche or challah

butter, unsalted

butterscotch

CARAMEL, esp. with dark chocolate

cardamom

cashews

cheese, ricotta

cherries: regular, sour, dried

chicken

chile peppers

chili powder

chocolate, white

CINNAMON

cloves

cocoa powder

coconut

***COFFEE / ESPRESSO**, esp. with dark chocolate

cognac

Cointreau

corn syrup, light

CREAM

cream cheese

crème anglaise

crème fraîche

crust: pastry, pie

currants

custard

dates

DESSERTS

duck

espelette figs, dried

fruit: dried, fresh



When it comes to **chocolate**, keep it simple. That's always good advice! For simplicity at its best, only two ingredients are necessary: heavy cream and chopped chocolate. Bring the cream to a boil, pour it over the chocolate, and it turns into ganache. Serve it warm with just a spoon. How can you do any better? In my new book, I feature a recipe called Cup O' Dark Chocolate, and

essentially it is ganache poured into a cup. Then you grab a cookie, and have at it!

If you want to dip fruit into chocolate, dried fruits such as figs, pear, and pineapple all work really well. People always ask what they can serve to impress their sweetheart on Valentine's Day, and fresh strawberries are really nice in February. Just make a warm ganache, grab the strawberries, and start dipping. Fresh grapes are fantastic with chocolate. Dip them into the melted chocolate, pop them in the freezer, and when they are frozen, put them into a two-quart container. That way, you will always have a little treat in the freezer. Be careful though—they are not M&Ms, so they *will* melt in your hands!

—MARCEL DESAULNIERS, THE TRELLIS (WILLIAMSBURG, VIRGINIA)

game (e.g., rabbit, venison)

game birds

ginger

graham crackers

Grand Marnier

HAZELNUTS

honey

Kirsch

lavender

lemon

liqueurs: berry, coffee (e.g., Kahlúa), nut (e.g., Frangelico), orange

macadamia nuts

malt (malted milk)

maple syrup

marshmallows

mascarpone

meats

Mexican cuisine (e.g., mole sauces)

MILK

MINT

nutmeg, esp. on hot chocolate

NUTS

oats

orange: juice, zest

orange blossom water

passion fruit

peanuts/peanut butter

pears

pecans

pepper: black, pink (pinch)

poultry

praline

prunes

raisins

RASPBERRIES, esp. with milk chocolate

Rice Krispies

RUM: DARK, LIGHT

salt

saucers: savory (e.g., mole), sweet (e.g., chocolate)

sour cream

strawberries

SUGAR: brown, confectioners', white

tea, esp. green or Earl Grey

turkey

VANILLA

Vin Santo

walnuts

Everybody is on the **chocolate** bandwagon now, and we are not far away from the proverbial “man on the street” knowing the difference between a 72 percent and a 66 percent chocolate. The boutique chocolate makers are now coming up with estate and varietal and vintage chocolates. I love that, but honestly, once you add enough sugar and cream to chocolate, those nuances are all gone.

—MICHAEL LAISKONIS, LE BERNARDIN (NEW YORK CITY)

People always ask why I use bittersweet versus semisweet **chocolate**.

Semisweet is chocolate that needs salt. When you add salt to it, it brings up the bitter flavor and makes it taste bittersweet. Semisweet chocolate to me tastes kind of flat. Milk chocolate can taste flat as well. Now that there is Scharffen

Berger and El Rey on the market, I find both those chocolates to be really, really great, with both flavor and kick to them. But if you want a killer chocolate dessert, don't use milk chocolate.

When I write a dessert menu, there will be a couple of chocolate desserts, with one being a killer chocolate and the other a lighter option, like chocolate with bananas. If you don't have something intensely chocolate, chocolate lovers are very, very unhappy. Banana soufflé with chocolate is not considered a chocolate dessert. You have to be careful with a killer chocolate dessert—you can't just put chocolate, chocolate, and chocolate together. There has to be balance so the dessert is not too rich. To achieve balance, turn to coffee or caramel because they pair so well and help to intensify the chocolate flavor.

For some desserts, I like to combine white and dark chocolate, or milk and dark chocolate, to give balance and cut intensity. It sounds crazy, but you can use one chocolate to mellow the flavor of another.

I'm not a fan of herbs with dessert, with the possible exception of chocolate. I love the combination of chocolate with mint.

—EMILY LUCHETTI, FARALLON (SAN FRANCISCO)

I don't have a big sweet tooth but I do like all kinds of **chocolate**, from dark to white. Each one is completely different. I like the bitterness and clean flavor of dark chocolate. I like milk chocolate with a piece of bread like when I was a kid. You have to select your white chocolate carefully because not all of it is good. White chocolate works well in a mousse; it has a more neutral flavor and does not dictate. Dark chocolate is all about being the star, versus white, that is better to play with.

—GABRIEL KREUTHER, THE MODERN (NEW YORK CITY)

Dark chocolate goes really well with coffee or caramel, but if I could only pick one it would be the caramel! Caramel and chocolate play so well together despite both being strong flavors.

—EMILY LUCHETTI, FARALLON (SAN FRANCISCO)

Flavor Affinities

chocolate + almonds + cinnamon + sugar

chocolate + almonds + cream

chocolate + banana + butterscotch + macadamia nuts
chocolate + banana + caramel + cream + vanilla
chocolate + butterscotch + caramel + coffee
chocolate + caramel + coffee + malt
chocolate + caramel + coffee + praline
chocolate + caramel + cream + hazelnuts + vanilla
chocolate + cherries + mint
chocolate + cinnamon + chiles + nuts + seeds
chocolate + coffee + hazelnuts
chocolate + coffee + walnuts
chocolate + cream + raspberries
chocolate + custard + pistachios
chocolate + ginger + orange
chocolate + graham crackers + marshmallows
chocolate + hazelnuts + orange
chocolate + lavender + vanilla
chocolate + rum + vanilla

Dishes

Hot Valrhona Chocolate Soufflé, Vermont Maple Ice Cream, Vanilla Ice Cream, and Chocolate Sorbet

—David Bouley, Bouley (New York City)

Austrian Chocolate-Hazelnut Soufflé with Italian Plum Ragoût and Caramel Balsamic Ice Cream

—David Bouley, Danube (New York City)

Chocolate-Hazelnut Cake with Orange Sauce and Hazelnut Gelato

—Gina DePalma, pastry chef, Babbo (New York City)

Almond and Chocolate Torte with Raspberries

—Jim Dodge, at the 2005 James Beard Awards gala reception

Crunchy Chocolate-Hazelnut Spring Roll with Mint and Mango Salad

—Dominique and Cindy Duby, Wild Sweets (Vancouver)

Milk Chocolate and Orange Parfait with Steamed Meringues and Orange and Black Truffle Brown Butter

—Dominique and Cindy Duby, Wild Sweets (Vancouver)

Chocolate-Hazelnut Mousse, Orange Sherbet, and Cardamom-Scented Oranges

—Gale Gand, pastry chef, Tru (Chicago)

Chocolate-Port Semifreddo with Chocolate-Port Bisque, Dark Chocolate Sponge Cake, and Orange-Cinnamon Truffle

—Gale Gand, pastry chef, Tru (Chicago)

Dark Chocolate, Cashew, and Caramel Tart, with Red Wine Reduction, Banana, and Malted Rum-Milk Chocolate Ice Cream

—Michael Laiskonis, pastry chef, Le Bernardin (New York City)

Flourless Chocolate Cake, Dark Chocolate Ganache, Toasted Bread, Maldon Sea Salt, Extra-Virgin Olive Oil

—Michael Laiskonis, pastry chef, Le Bernardin (New York City)

Warm El Rey Chocolate Pudding Cake with Salted Peanut Ice Cream and Peanut Brittle

—Emily Luchetti, pastry chef, Farallon (San Francisco)

Bittersweet Chocolate Pot de Crème with Coffee-Caramel Cream, Butterscotch, and Chocolate Toffee

—Emily Luchetti, pastry chef, Farallon (San Francisco)

Chocolate-Peanut Butter Crème Caramel with Strauss Family Farms Ice Milk

—Ellie Nelson, pastry chef, Jardinière (San Francisco)

Our Marjolaine Cake: A Classic Chocolate-Hazelnut Meringue Layer Cake with Raspberries

—Patrick O’Connell, The Inn at Little Washington (Washington, Virginia)

Our Perennially Popular, Molten-Centered Chocolate Cake with Roasted Banana Ice Cream

—Patrick O’Connell, The Inn at Little Washington (Washington, Virginia)

Chocolate Biscuit Soufflé with Dark Chocolate Mousse and Milk Chocolate–Ginger Parfait

—François Payard, Payard Patisserie and Bistro (New York City)

Milk Chocolate Mousse, Yuzu Citrus Cream, and Sacher Biscuit

—François Payard, Payard Patisserie and Bistro (New York City)

Trio of Desserts: Creamy Chocolate-Cheese Flan with Hibiscus Caramel, Chocolate Bread Pudding with Warm Café con Leche Sauce, Mayan Mediterranean Chocolate Rice Pudding with Cinnamon and Cacao Nib Dust

—Maricel Presilla, Zafra (Hoboken, New Jersey)

Trio of Dark, White, and Gianduja Chocolate Mousses with an Espresso Sauce

—Thierry Rautureau, Rover's (Seattle)

Dark Chocolate–Jalapeño Ice Cream Sundae

—Janos Wilder, Janos (Tucson)

I make a cake with dark **cocoa**, which makes for a bitter chocolate flavor, and then in the middle a milk chocolate cream. Many people don't realize how great the chocolate flavor of cocoa is. It adds bitterness and intensity without adding richness. That is invaluable because so many chocolate desserts are so rich. Often when I make a chocolate ice cream, I will combine melted chocolate and cocoa.

—**EMILY LUCHETTI**, FARALLON (SAN FRANCISCO)

My dessert of **milk chocolate** pot de crème, caramel foam, maple syrup, and Maldon sea salt served in an emptied-out eggshell symbolizes that a few ingredients can come together in a way that is greater than the sum of their parts. The key ingredient which ties it together is the Maldon sea salt. This combination elevates all the ingredients.

Starting with chocolate, caramel was the logical next step. At the time, I played with *fleur de sel*, red salt from Hawaii, and others, before ending up with the Maldon. I like the concept of using sugar as a seasoning, beyond its natural necessity in dessert. I also like natural sweetness from things and maple sugar brings a lot of flavor beyond sweetness. Once I hit upon this

combination, I have never changed it.

—MICHAEL LAISKONIS, LE BERNARDIN (NEW YORK CITY)

Dishes

Creamy White Chocolate and Cranberry Risotto with Roasted Apricots

—Dominique and Cindy Duby, Wild Sweets (Vancouver)

White Chocolate and Rice Milk Flan with Pistachio Emulsion

—Dominique and Cindy Duby, Wild Sweets (Vancouver)

Valrhona and El Rey are both good. When you are looking for a **white chocolate**, you want one that has some smoothness to it. It is not going to have the acidity that dark chocolate has. When you are making a dessert with white chocolate, it is going to be a softer, smoother dessert. I don't like dark chocolate and raspberries together, but I believe I am one of the few chefs who feel this way. What I don't like is that when you take a bite of the chocolate with the berry, the acidity of the two don't blend. The acids are too similar, so it doesn't feel like a single dessert in your mouth. Instead, it is a clash with both of them bouncing into each other in your mouth. They don't bridge, and even whipped cream doesn't bring them together. But if you use white chocolate, its softness works much better with berries. The white chocolate complements the berries and brings out their flavors. Citrus, especially anything in the orange family, also works well with white chocolate. Nuts, such as almonds, work well with white chocolate. Spices also work well with white chocolate.

—**EMILY LUCHETTI**, FARALLON (SAN FRANCISCO)

CHOCOLATE, WHITE

almonds

apricots

bananas

basil

BERRIES: blackberries, blueberries, cranberries

caramel

cashews

cassis

cherries

chocolate, esp. dark

citrus

coconut

cream

dates

figs

ginger

grapes

hazelnuts

lemon: juice, zest

lime

liqueurs: berry, crème de cacao

macadamia nuts

mango

mint

orange

papaya

passion fruit

persimmons

pistachios

pomegranate

prunes

***RASPBERRIES**

rum

strawberries

sugar
sweet potatoes
vanilla
yogurt

Flavor Affinities

white chocolate + basil + strawberries
white chocolate + cream + lemon + orange
white chocolate + dark chocolate + pistachios
white chocolate + ginger + pistachios + rice

CHORIZO

(See also Sausages) **Taste:** salty; spicy

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: moderate–loud

Techniques: sauté, stew

apples

bay leaf

beans

bell peppers, roasted

chicken

chili

clams

garlic

hard cider

herbs

kale

monkfish

olive oil

onions

paprika

potatoes

red pepper flakes

Spanish cuisine

stews

stock, chicken

sweet potatoes

thyme

tomatoes

AVOID

delicate fish (e.g., halibut, scallops)

oily fish (e.g., sardines)

Flavor Affinities

chorizo + clam broth + herbs + monkfish

CHRISTMAS

baked goods, esp. cookies
cinnamon
cloves
eggnog
fruitcake
ginger
peppermint

After a visit to Spain, I created a **chorizo** broth to go with monkfish. I love chorizo, with its paprika flavors and the fattiness of the pork. So I had to figure out how to make a sauce out of a dried piece of sausage. We melted the chorizo in a pan for a long time, and ended up with a flavorful grease that was not that appealing. However, we emulsified it in an herb-infused clam broth, and it became velvety. It wasn't greasy, and gave the sauce a little kick. I chose this sauce to go with monkfish because it is a meaty fish and can stand up to spice and to strong flavors really well. Chorizo would not destroy the soul of the fish.

—ERIC RIPERT, LE BERNARDIN (NEW YORK CITY)

Dishes

Pan-roasted Monkfish with Confit Peppers and Fiery “Patatas Bravas” with Chorizo-Albarino Emulsion

—Eric Ripert, Le Bernardin (New York City)

CILANTRO

Season: spring–summer

Taste: sweet, sour

Weight: light, soft-leaved

Volume: loud

Tips: Always use fresh, not cooked—or, if you must, add at the very last minute. Use cilantro to provide a cooling note to chile pepper–spiced dishes.

Asian cuisines

avocados

basil

beans

bell peppers

boar, wild

braised dishes

butter

cardamom

Caribbean cuisine

carrots

chicken

CHILE PEPPERS

chives

chutneys

coconut and coconut milk (e.g., Indian cuisine)

corn

cream and ice cream

cucumbers

cumin

curries, esp. Indian

dill

dips

figs

fish, white (e.g., cod, halibut) garam masala (e.g., Indian cuisine)

garlic

ginger

greens

INDIAN CUISINE

lamb

Latin American cuisines

legumes

lemon, juice

lemongrass

lemon verbena

lentils

lime, juice

mayonnaise

meats, esp. white

Mediterranean cuisine

MEXICAN CUISINE

Middle Eastern cuisine

mint (e.g., Indian cuisine)

North African cuisine

onions, red

orange, juice

parsley

pork

Portuguese cuisine

potatoes

rice, esp. Indian

salads, esp. Asian

SALSAS, MEXICAN

saucers

scallions

shellfish

soups

Southeast Asian cuisine

soy sauce

stews

stir-fried dishes

tamarind

Tex-Mex cuisine

Thai cuisine

tomatoes

vegetables, esp. root

Vietnamese cuisine

vinaigrettes, esp. red wine

vinegar, red wine

yogurt

AVOID

Japanese cuisine (say some)

Flavor Affinities

cilantro + chile peppers + coconut milk

cilantro + dill + mint

cilantro + garlic + ginger

I like the anise-seed quality to **cilantro**, which is really good with figs.

—MICHAEL LAISKONIS, LE BERNARDIN (NEW YORK CITY)

I really like using **cilantro** for its lemony and floral qualities, even though it's very non-European. I'll put cilantro stems [not the leaves] in the cavity when I'm roasting a chicken, and I find it lifts the flavor. Cilantro stems are also wonderful in Spanish-themed stews when there's a lot of depth of flavor from ingredients like chorizo, chickpeas, oxtails, or tripe, and it needs a high note.

—TONY LIU, AUGUST (NEW YORK CITY)

Love it or hate it, **cilantro** is in a lot of my dishes! I love its citrus flavor. Cilantro has long legs; we use it to make cilantro oil as well as purees. It lends itself well to white meats but I have even put it on hanger steak and wild boar. I also like it with coconut milk.

—BRAD FARMERIE, PUBLIC (NEW YORK CITY)

CINNAMON

Season: autumn–winter

Taste: sweet, bitter, pungent

Function: heating

Weight: light–medium

Volume: loud

Tips: Add early in cooking.

allspice

APPLES: CIDER, FRUIT, JUICE

apricots

baked dishes and goods

bananas

beef, esp. braised, raw, stewed

bell peppers

berries

beverages, esp. hot

blueberries

bread, sweet (e.g., gingerbread)

breakfast / brunch

butter

caramel

Calvados

cardamom

cherries

chicken

chile peppers

chili powder

Chinese cuisine

CHOCOLATE / COCOA

chutneys

cloves

coffee / espresso

cloves (compatible spice) cookies

coriander

couscous

cream and ice cream

cream cheese

cumin

curries, esp. Indian

CUSTARDS

DESSERTS

eggplant

fennel

five-spice powder (key ingredient)

French toast

fruits: fruit compotes, fruit desserts

game birds

garam masala, Indian (key ingredient)

garlic

ginger

holiday cooking

honey

Indian cuisine

Indonesian cuisine

lamb, esp. braised

lemon, juice

mace

malt

maple syrup

meats, red

Mediterranean cuisine

Mexican cuisine

Middle Eastern cuisine

mole sauces

Moroccan cuisine

nutmeg

nuts

onions

orange: juice, zest

pancakes

pastries
pears
pecans
pies
plums
pork
poultry
pumpkin
quail
quatre épices (key ingredient)
raisins
ras el hanout (key ingredient)
rice
saffron
sauces (e.g., barbecue)
South American cuisine
Southeast Asian cuisine (as cassia)
Spanish cuisine
squash, esp. winter
star anise
stews
stocks and broths
sugar: brown, white
tagines
tamarind
tea
tomatoes
turmeric
vanilla
veal
vegetables, esp. sweet
waffles
walnuts
wine, red, esp. mulled
yogurt
zucchini

Flavor Affinities

cinnamon + almonds + raisins

cinnamon + cardamom + cloves + coriander + black pepper (garam masala)

cinnamon + cardamom + rice

cinnamon + cloves + mace + nutmeg

I use Saigon **cinnamon** that is the most amazing cinnamon you will ever try. It comes in a chip [as opposed to a stick] and is like the cinnamon used to make red-hots [candy]. I use it in a ganache.

—JOHNNY IUZZINI, JEAN GEORGES (NEW YORK CITY)

CITRUS—IN GENERAL

(See also Lemons, Limes, Oranges, etc.)

Season: winter

Taste: sour

Weight: light–medium

Volume: medium–loud

fish

Greek cuisine

lemongrass

Mediterranean cuisine

salads: green, fruit

shellfish

Dishes

Lemongrass Sorbet, Dehydrated Grapefruit, Crispy Tangerine, Lime Curd

—Johnny Iuzzini, pastry chef, Jean Georges (New York City)

Orange is the leading lady of **citrus**—it brings a sunny, citric flavor to dishes. Lemon and lime are the men of citrus—very strong, so use them carefully!

—MICHEL RICHARD, CITRONELLE (WASHINGTON, DC)

I love candied **citrus** for savory dishes. I love candied kumquats, orange, or lemon. They are great with sweet or savory dishes, and amazing with cheese, such as a soft, non-ashed goat cheese.

—CARRIE NAHABEDIAN, NAHA (CHICAGO)

CLAMS

Season: summer

Taste: salty

Weight: light

Volume: quiet–moderate

Techniques: bake, broil, deep-fry, grill, roast, sauté, steam, stew

aioli

allspice

anchovy

artichokes

asparagus

BACON

basil

bay leaf

beans, white

bell peppers, esp. red

bread, esp. French

bread crumbs

BUTTER, UNSALTED

cabbage, esp. napa

capers

carrots

cauliflower

caviar

cayenne

celery

chervil

CHILE PEPPERS, esp. dried and red (e.g., habanero, jalapeño)

chili powder

chives

chorizo

cilantro

clam juice

cocktail sauce

cod

corn

cream

cumin

fennel

fermented black beans

fish, esp. striped bass

GARLIC

ginger, fresh

gingko nuts

ham, Serrano

hominy

horseradish

Italian cuisine

Japanese cuisine

Korean cuisine

leeks

lemon, juice

lemongrass

lime, juice

marjoram

Mediterranean cuisine

milk

mint, esp. spearmint

mirepoix

mushrooms

mussels

mustard greens

New England cuisine

oil, vegetable

OLIVE OIL

onions, esp. red or Spanish

oregano

oysters

pancetta

PARSLEY, FLAT-LEAF

pasta

PEPPER: BLACK, WHITE

Pernod

pork

POTATOES, esp. Idaho, red

prosciutto

red pepper flakes

rice, esp. Arborio or bomba

romesco sauce

rosemary

saffron

sake

salt, kosher

sausage, esp. spicy (e.g., chorizo)

scallions

scallops (compatible seafood)

shallots

sherry, dry (e.g., fino)

shiso leaf

shrimp (compatible seafood)

soy sauce

spinach

squid (compatible seafood)

stocks: chicken, clam, fish

Tabasco sauce

tapenade

tarragon

Thai basil

THYME

TOMATOES, esp. plum, roasted, sauce

vermouth

WINE, DRY WHITE (e.g., Champagne, Pinot Gris, Tocai Friulano, Sauvignon Blanc)

yuzu juice

Flavor Affinities

clams + aioli + capers + tarragon

clams + bacon + lemon + scallions

clams + basil + garlic + tomatoes

clams + butter + lemon + shallots

clams + cream + curry + fennel

clams + garlic + mussels + onion + thyme + white wine

clams + oysters + potatoes + thyme

Dishes

Linguine with Clams, Pancetta, and Hot Chiles

—Mario Batali, Babbo (New York City)

Clam Chowder with Smoked Bacon

—Rebecca Charles, Pearl Oyster Bar (New York City)

New New England Clam Chowder Served with Cream of Bacon, Onion Jam, and Chive Oil

—Katsuya Fukushima, Café Atlántico / minibar (Washington, DC)

Braised Manila Clams, Italian Sausage, and White Beans

—Rick Tramonto, Tru (Chicago)

CLOVES

Taste: sweet, pungent

Function: heating

Weight: medium

Volume: loud

Techniques: Add early in cooking.

allspice

almonds

apples: cider, fruit, juice

baked goods (e.g., breads, cakes, pastries, pies)

bay leaf

beef

beets

beverages

biryani

cabbage, esp. red

cardamom

carrots

chicken

chile peppers

Chinese cuisine

chocolate

cider, hot (i.e., mulled)

cinnamon

cookies

coriander

cumin

curries (e.g., Asian, Indian)

desserts

duck

English cuisine

fennel seeds

fruits, esp. cooked

game

garam masala (key ingredient)

garlic

German cuisine

ginger

ham, baked

honey

Indian cuisine, esp. northern

ketchup

kumquats

lamb

lemon

mace

meats

Mexican cuisine

nutmeg

onions

orange

pork

pumpkin

salad dressings

sausage

spice cakes

squash

Sri Lankan cuisine

star anise

stews

stock, esp. beef

stuffing

sweet potatoes

Szechuan pepper

tamarind

tea

tomatoes

turmeric

vegetables, sweet

walnuts

wine, red, hot (i.e., mulled)
Worcestershire sauce

Flavor Affinities

cloves + cardamom + cinnamon + tea
cloves + cinnamon + ginger + nutmeg
cloves + ginger + honey

My **coconut** rice pudding strudel was the result of Takashi's influence. [Takashi Yagihashi was his chef at Detroit's Tribute restaurant.] Dessert has to make sense in the context of the rest of the meal. Being a pastry chef is exciting because you have a lot of autonomy, but you are still working within the chef's framework. Takashi's food was very Asian-influenced. This dish was meant to bring in Asian ingredients in a new way yet be something familiar.

So we have rice pudding flavored with coconut, lemongrass, ginger, and vanilla, and diced apricot for texture. At the time I was introduced to *frie de brique*, which is a Moroccan dough that is like a cross between phyllo and a wonton wrapper. I would wrap these ingredients in this dough and then sauté them in clarified butter and slice them like a spring roll. Alongside I served green tea ice cream. This covered a lot of bases for me: the warm and cold temperatures, the Asian influence, and doing something with boring old rice pudding.

The coolest compliment I ever got was from Andrew Carmellini [chef of New York's A Voce] who was sitting down with us and asked about my background. When I said I used to be a line cook, he said, "I knew it—a pastry chef would never come up with that!" It was the combination of techniques and flavors as well as sautéing something to order.

—MICHAEL LAISKONIS, LE BERNARDIN (NEW YORK CITY)

COCONUT AND COCONUT MILK

Season: autumn–spring

Taste: sweet

Function: cooling

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: moderate–loud

Techniques: stir-fry

allspice

almonds

apricots

Asian cuisine

bananas

basil

beans, green (e.g., Indian cuisine)

beef

blackberries

Brazilian cuisine

candies

caramel

cardamom (e.g., Indian cuisine)

Caribbean cuisine

cashews (e.g., Indian cuisine)

cauliflower (e.g., Indian cuisine)

cherries, fresh or dried

chicken (e.g., Indian cuisine, etc.)

chile peppers, green or red

chili powder

chocolate, esp. dark or white

cilantro (e.g., Indian cuisine, etc.)

cinnamon

cloves

coriander

CREAM AND ICE CREAM

crème fraîche

cucumber

cumin

curries (e.g., Indian cuisine)

custard

dates

desserts

eggs

figs, dried

fish

fruit, esp. tropical

ginger

grapefruit

guava

honey

Indian cuisine

Indonesian cuisine

kiwi

kumquats

lamb (e.g., Indian cuisine)

lemon

lemongrass

lentils (e.g., Indian cuisine)

lime, juice

lychee

macadamia nuts

Malaysian cuisine

mangoes

maple

mascarpone

milk

mint (e.g., Indian cuisine, etc.)

nutmeg

oats

orange, juice

papaya

passion fruit

peanuts
pepper, black
pineapple
pistachios
rice
rose water
rum, esp. dark
salads, fruit
salmon (e.g., Indian cuisine)
salt, kosher
sesame seeds
shellfish: shrimp, lobster
soups
sour cream
Southeast Asian cuisine
stews
SUGAR: brown, white sweet
potatoes
tea, green
Thai cuisine
tropical fruits
VANILLA
Vietnamese cuisine
vinegar, white wine

Flavor Affinities

coconut + apricot + ginger + green tea + lemongrass + rice + vanilla
coconut + honey + lime
coconut + lemongrass + vanilla
coconut + orange + vanilla
coconut milk + beef + ginger

Dishes

Ice Wine–Lychee Gelée with Coconut Milk Sabayon and Pumpkin Seed Croquant
—Dominique and Cindy Duby, Wild Sweets (Vancouver)

Coconut Crème Brûlée with Lychee Sorbet and Sesame Tuile
—Brad Farmerie, Public (New York City)

Lemongrass and Coconut Panna Cotta
—Nora Pouillon, Asia Nora (Washington, DC)

COD

Weight: medium

Volume: quiet

Techniques: bake, boil, broil, cakes, deep-fry, fry, grill, poach, roast, sauté, steam

anchovies

bacon

basil

bay leaf

beans: cannellini, green, navy, white

bell peppers: red, green, yellow

bouquet garni

brandade

brandy

bread crumbs

BUTTER, unsalted

cabbage, savoy

capers

caraway seeds

carrots

cayenne

celery cheese: Emmental, Gruyère,

Swiss

chervil

chives

cilantro

coriander

cream

currants

daikon

eggplant, esp. Japanese

eggs, hard-boiled

endive

English cuisine, esp. fish and chips

fennel

French cuisine, esp. Provençal

garlic

ginger

ham: cured, Serrano

leeks

lemon, juice

mayonnaise

milk

miso

mushrooms, esp. ceps, portobello, shiitake

mustard, Dijon

New England cuisine

oils: canola, corn, grapeseed, peanut

olive oil

olives: black, green

onions

orange: juice, zest

paprika, sweet

PARSLEY, FLAT-LEAF

peas

pepper: black, white

pine nuts

POTATOES, esp. red, red bliss

prosciutto

radishes

risotto

rosemary

saffron

sage

salt: *fleur de sel*, kosher, sea

sauces: hollandaise, tartar, tomato

sausage, chorizo

scallions

shallots

shellfish: clams, shrimp

stocks: chicken, fish, mussels, veal, vegetable

sugar

tarragon

thyme

tomatoes

truffles, black

VINEGAR: balsamic, champagne, red wine, sherry, tarragon, white wine

wine: dry white, red

yuzu juice

Flavor Affinities

cod + capers + chives + lentils + potatoes

cod + cepes (mushrooms) + garlic + lemon + potatoes

Dishes

Ceviche Fronterizo: Lime-Marinated Alaskan True Cod with Vine-Ripe Tomatoes, Olives, Cilantro, and Green Chile, Served on Crispy Tostaditas

—Rick Bayless, Frontera Grill (Chicago)

Alaskan True Cod and Fresh-Shucked Oysters in Tamazula-Sparked Homemade Cocktail Sauce with Lime, Avocado, White Onion, and Cilantro

—Rick Bayless, Frontera Grill (Chicago)

Chatham Bay Codfish: Chanterelle Mushrooms, Sweet Peas, and Tarragon Sauce

—David Bouley, Upstairs (New York City)

Atlantic Cod “au Naturel” with Littleneck Clams; Roasted Artichokes, Swiss Chard, and Lemon Marmalade

—Daniel Boulud, Daniel (New York City)

Roast Cod on Edamame Risotto with Salt and Pepper Sepia and Carrot-Yuzu Sauce

—Brad Farmerie, Public (New York City)

Brioche-Crusted Cod with Baby Artichokes, Oven-Dried Tomatoes, Garlic Mashed Potatoes, and Artichoke Puree

—Bob Kinkead, Kinkead’s (Washington, DC)

Cod Baked in a Salt Crust Stuffed with Baby Artichokes, Romesco, Red Wine, Olive, and Preserved Tomato Stew

—Eric Ripert, Le Bernardin (New York City)

Cod is an undervalued fish. It's light, flaky, and delicate, and I especially like it served with broths or chowders. It's also great baked for ten minutes on salt on a sheet tray. Cod pairs well with clams and shellfish, and I love the combination of fresh cod with salted cod in a dish.

—**BRADFORD THOMPSON**, MARY ELAINE'S AT THE PHOENICIAN (SCOTTSDALE, ARIZONA)

Dishes

Black Cod with Miso Sauce

—Nobu Matsuhisa, Nobu (New York City)

Broiled Sake-Marinated Alaskan Black Cod and Shrimp Dumplings in Shiso Broth

—Hiro Sone, Terra (St. Helena, California)

COD, BLACK

bell peppers, red chile peppers, esp. red chives

garlic

ginger

leeks

miso

onions

shiso

shrimp

soy sauce

sugar, brown

COD, SALT

Taste: salty

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate–loud

artichoke hearts

bay leaf

beans, white

bell peppers: green, red

bread crumbs

capers

chile peppers

cilantro

cream

French cuisine, esp. Provençal **GARLIC** greens, salad

lemon, juice

marjoram

mint

Old Bay seasoning

OIL, canola

olive oil

olives, esp. black or kalamata

onions

paprika: hot, sweet

parsley, flat-leaf

pasta

pepper: black, white

potatoes

saffron

salt: kosher, sea

scallions

shallots

shrimp

sour cream

stock, fish

sugar

Tabasco sauce

thyme

tomatoes

vinegar: red wine, white wine

wine, dry

Worcestershire sauce

Flavor Affinities

salt cod + bay leaf + thyme + white wine vinegar

Dishes

Warm Salad of Poached Salt Cod, Porcini Mushrooms, and Yukon Golds

—David Pasternak, Esca (New York City)

COFFEE AND ESPRESSO

Taste: bitter

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate–loud

almonds

amaretto

anise

bananas

barbecue sauce

beverages

bourbon

brandy

caramel

cardamom

cheese, ricotta

cherries

chicken

chicory

CHOCOLATE, ESP. DARK, white

cinnamon

cloves

COCOA

coconut

cognac

CREAM

curry

custards

dates

fennel seeds

figs

game birds

gravy

ham (e.g., with red-eye gravy)

hazelnuts

honey

ice cream, vanilla

Irish whiskey

lamb

lemon

lime

liqueurs, coffee (e.g., Kahlúa, Tía Maria)

macadamia nuts

maple syrup

milk, including sweetened, condensed

nutmeg

NUTS

oats

orange

pears

pecans

persimmons

pork

prunes

raisins

rum

star anise

SUGAR: brown, white

VANILLA vinegar, balsamic

AVOID

lavender

Flavor Affinities

coffee + bourbon + cream

coffee + caramel + chocolate

coffee + cinnamon + cloves + orange

coffee + cinnamon + cream + lemon + sugar

coffee + mascarpone + rum + sugar + vanilla

Dishes

Espresso Cupcakes Filled with Milk Chocolate Ganache and White Chocolate Frosting

—Emily Luchetti, pastry chef, Farallon (San Francisco)

Bourbon Ice Cream on Coffee-Flavored Tapioca in a Martini Glass

—Kaz Okochi, Kaz Sushi Bistro (Washington, DC)

COGNAC

apples and apple cider
beef (e.g., filet mignon)
chicken
chocolate
cream
foie gras
mushrooms
mustard, esp. Dijon
pepper: black, green
pork
prunes
raisins
turkey
vanilla
vinegar, cider

In addition to seasonality, I always pay attention to temperature. I look at what I feel like eating now given that day's weather. If it is **cold** and raining, I make sure soup is on the menu.

—ANDREW CARMELLINI, A VOCE (NEW YORK CITY)

COLDNESS

(of indoor or outdoor temperature; See also Winter)

braised dishes

butter and butter-based sauces and dishes

cheese and cheese dishes

cream and cream-based sauces and dishes

grains, heavy

hot dishes and beverages

meats, esp. red

polenta

risotto

soups, hot and hearty

spices, warming

stews and stewed dishes

COLLARD GREENS

(See Greens, Collard)

COOLING

Function: Ingredients believed to have cooling properties; useful in hot weather.

asparagus
avocados
berries
buttermilk
cucumbers
figs, fresh
fruits, esp. sweet (e.g., cherries, grapes)
herbs, cooling (e.g., cilantro, honeysuckle, lavender, lemon balm, mint, peppermint)
lettuce
melon
salads
spices, cooling (e.g., cardamom, coriander, fennel)
water
watercress
watermelon
yogurt
zucchini

Flavor Affinities

cucumbers + mint + yogurt

My personal preference for the ratio of **coriander** to cumin is threequarters of a portion of coriander to one portion of cumin.

—MEERA DHALWALA, VIJ'S (VANCOUVER)

I'll use **coriander** with peppercorns in a sachet for soups, with the pepper providing the heat and the coriander more of a fruity note.

—BRADFORD THOMPSON, MARY ELAINE'S AT THE PHOENICIAN (SCOTTSDALE,

ARIZONA)

CORIANDER

Taste: sour, pungent, astringent

Function: cooling

Weight: light–medium

Volume: moderate–loud

Tips: Add near the end of cooking.

Toast coriander seeds to release their flavor.

allspice

anise

apples

baked goods (e.g., cakes, cookies, pies)

basil

beans

beef

cardamom

carrots

cayenne

chicken

chickpeas

chile peppers (e.g., fresh green)

chili

chutneys

cilantro

cinnamon

citrus and citrus zest

cloves

coconut and coconut milk corn

crab, esp. boiled

cumin

curries (e.g., Indian cuisine)

curry powder

desserts

eggs

fennel

fennel seeds

fish

fruits, esp. autumn and dried

garam masala (key ingredient)

garlic

ginger

gingerbread

grapefruit

ham

harissa (key ingredient)

hot dogs

Indian cuisine

lamb

Latin American cuisine

lentils

mace

meats

Mediterranean cuisine

Mexican cuisine

Middle Eastern cuisine

mint

Moroccan cuisine

mushrooms

North African cuisine

North American cuisine

nutmeg

nuts

olive oil

onions

orange: juice, zest

pastries

pears

pepper, black

pickles

plums

pork

potatoes
poultry
quince
rice (e.g., as pudding)
saffron
salmon
sausages
sesame seeds
shellfish
soups, esp. cream-based
Southeast Asian cuisine
Southwestern cuisine
spinach
stews (e.g., chicken)
stocks (e.g., fish)
stuffing
sugar
tomatoes and tomato sauces
turkey
turmeric
Vietnamese cuisine

Flavor Affinities

coriander + cardamom + cinnamon + clove
coriander + cayenne + cumin + garlic
coriander + chile peppers + mustard + black pepper
coriander + cumin + curry
coriander + fish + garlic + olive oil + tomatoes

CORN

Season: summer

Taste: sweet

Function: heating

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate

Techniques: boil, grill, roast, sauté, steam

bacon

BASIL: sweet, lemon

bay leaf

beans, esp. lima

béchamel sauce

beef

BELL PEPPERS: red, green

BUTTER, UNSALTED

buttermilk

caraway seed

carrots

cayenne

celery

cheese: **cheddar**, Colby, Cotija, feta, Monterey Jack

chervil

CHILE PEPPERS: chipotle, jalapeño, serrano

chili powder

chili sauce

Chinese cuisine

chives

cilantro

clams

cornmeal

crab

CREAM, esp. heavy

crème fraîche

cumin

curry powder

dill

eggs

fava beans

fennel

fish, salmon

GARLIC

ginger, fresh

ham

leeks

lemon, juice

lemon thyme

lime, juice

lobster

lovage

maple syrup

marjoram

mascarpone

Mexican cuisine

milk

mirepoix

MUSHROOMS, esp. chanterelle, oyster, shiitake, other wild mushroom

New England cuisine

nutmeg

OIL: canola, peanut, vegetable

OLIVE OIL

ONIONS: red, Spanish, yellow

oregano

pancetta

paprika

parsley

pasta

PEPPER: BLACK, WHITE

pesto

polenta

potatoes

poultry
risottos
rosemary
saffron
sage
salads, green
salmon
salsas
SALT: kosher, sea
scallions
scallops
shallots
sherry, dry
shiso
Southern cuisine
Southwestern cuisine
squash, esp. summer
star anise
STOCKS: chicken, vegetable
sugar
tarragon
thyme
tomatoes tortillas, corn
vermouth
vinaigrette
vinegar: cider, white wine
wine, dry white

We participate in an event called “Plate and Pitchfork” that is held on a farm with the food from the farm. The guests sit in the field among the **corn** and tomatoes, and we cook a meal for them on a couple of grills.

I made a corn soup for this event. We removed the husks, then cut the kernels off the cob. Then we used the husks, which produce a juice, to make a stock for the soup. If you were to use cobs, you wouldn’t get the same flavor. It is important to keep the corn flavor pure. Most cooks would throw in a bunch of vegetables in the stock, and what you’d get then is a vegetable stock with

corn. I want to have a corny flavor in the end. We made a stock using the corn husks cooked with a little onion, water, and salt, and let it cook for about 45 minutes. What came out was the most amazing sweet broth. We added the corn, pureed it, and served it chilled. It was so sweet and full of corn flavor you would have sworn there were cream and sugar in it.

We now make a corn husk broth to add to a corn, chanterelle, and Dungeness crab risotto with a touch of pesto. Basil pesto and corn really speaks to me. It is a wonderful combination.

—**VITALY PALEY**, PALEY'S PLACE (PORTLAND, OREGON)

To intensify the flavor of **corn** in a dish, add [corn] juice. I'll make a corn ravioli with pureed corn and cooked corn. I add corn juice to the filling to add a fresh corn flavor to the ravioli.

—**ANDREW CARMELLINI**, A VOCE (NEW YORK CITY)



Dishes

Homemade Corn and Leek Ravioli with Maine Lobster and Silver Queen Local Corn

—Lidia Bastianich, Felidia (New York City)

Baby Corn on the Cob, Brown Butter Powder, Cilantro Emulsion

—Brad Farmerie, Public (New York City)

Arepas de Choclo: Corn Cakes Topped with Crème Fraîche and Salmon Roe

—Maricel Presilla, Zafra (Hoboken, New Jersey)

Red Bliss Potato and Corn Pizza, Parsley Pesto, and Smoked Cow's Milk Cheese

—Cory Schreiber, Wildwood (Portland, Oregon)

Flavor Affinities

corn + bell pepper + jalapeño chile + cilantro + tarragon

corn + butter + salt

corn + cayenne + lime + salt

corn + cilantro + shrimp

CORNED BEEF
(See Beef—Brisket)

CORNISH GAME HENS

cardamom

cayenne

cinnamon

cloves

cumin, esp. toasted

garam masala

garlic

ginger

lemon

oil, canola

onions

paprika

pepper, black

salt

tomatoes and tomato paste

turmeric

yogurt

COUSCOUS

Weight: light

Volume: quiet–moderate

Techniques: steep

African (North) cuisine

apricots, dried

basil

bell peppers, esp. red

butter

cabbage

carrots

cayenne

chervil

chicken

chickpeas

cilantro

cumin fish (e.g., snapper)

ginger

lemon: juice, preserved, zest

Middle Eastern cuisine

mint

Moroccan cuisine

olive oil

olives

onions

parsley, flat-leaf

pepper, black

raisins

saffron

salt: kosher, sea

sausage, *merguez*

scallions

stocks: chicken, fish, vegetable,

tomatoes and tomato juice

turnips

zucchini

COUSCOUS, ISRAELI

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: light–moderate

olive oil

pepper, white

pesto

shallots

stock, chicken

CRAB

Season: summer

Taste: sweet

Weight: light

Volume: quiet

Techniques: bake, boil, broil, grill, steam

aioli

apples

artichokes

asparagus

***AVOCADOS**

bacon

basil

bay leaf

bell peppers, esp. green, red, yellow

bread crumbs / panko

butter, unsalted

carrots and carrot juice

cauliflower

caviar

cayenne

celery

celery root

celery salt

chervil

chile peppers: jalapeño, Scotch bonnet pepper, Thai

chili sauce

Chinese cuisine

CHIVES

cilantro

coconut and coconut milk

coriander

corn

crab roe

cream

crème fraîche

cucumber

cumin

Dishes

Jumbo Lump Crab Salad with Asparagus, Mustard Seed Dressing

—Daniel Boulud/Olivier Muller, DB Bistro (New York City)

Crab Salad with White Asparagus, Ginger, Lime, Pistachio Oil

—Daniel Boulud/Bertrand Chemel, Café Boulud (New York City)

Marinated Jumbo Lump Crabmeat with Horseradish, Coriander, Tomato, Seaweed Salad, and Ginger Vinaigrette

—Jeffrey Bubben, Vidalia (Washington, DC)

Red and Yellow Tomato Gazpacho with Avocado Puree and Lump Crabmeat, with Microgreen Salad

—Bob Iacovone, Cuvée (New Orleans)

A Mélange of Jumbo Lump Crab, Mango, and Avocado in a Tropical Fruit Coulis

—Patrick O’Connell, The Inn at Little Washington (Washington, Virginia)

Signature Sushi: Blue Crab with Celery and Red Bell Pepper

—Kaz Okoshi, Kaz Sushi Bistro (Washington, DC)

Potato Gnocchi with Oregon Dungeness Crab and Preserved Lemon

—Vitaly Paley, Paley’s Place (Portland, Oregon)

Spicy Crab and Peanut Soup with Okra

—Monica Pope, T’afia (Houston)

Crab Cake with Saffron-Sherry Aioli

—Monica Pope, T'afia (Houston)

Dungeness Crab and Potato Cakes, Green Beans, Cucumbers, Almonds, and Shaved Fennel

—Cory Schreiber, Wildwood (Portland, Oregon)

Michael Dean's Squash Blossom, Crabmeat, and Squash with Green Tomato Relish

—Frank Stitt, Highlands Bar and Grill (Birmingham, Alabama)

I'll never forget tasting the combination of **crab**, avocado, and almonds at chef Pascal Barbot's Paris restaurant L'Astrance.

—MICHAEL ANTHONY, GRAMERCY TAVERN (NEW YORK CITY)

Crab is something that you typically see steamed and served with butter. King crab is intensely flavorful, meaty, and salty. When it is caught at sea, it is cooked on the boat with heavily salted water. The first thing I did was soak the crab multiple times in ice water to draw out all the salt. I saw and created a vision of this red crabmeat within a *barigoule* with perfectly cut vegetables, artichokes, French green beans, Valencia oranges, sweet garlic, and finished with olive oil.

—CARRIE NAHABEDIAN, NAHA (CHICAGO)

curry

custard

dill

eggplant

eggs

endive, Belgian

fennel

fish: pike, sole

fish sauce, Thai

garlic

ginger

grapefruit

honey

LEMON: juice, zest

lemongrass

lemon thyme

lime: juice, zest

lobster

mango

mascarpone

MAYONNAISE

melon: cantaloupe, honeydew

mint

mushrooms (e.g., button, cremini, shiitakes)

mustard, Dijon

mustard powder

nutmeg

OIL: canola, grapeseed, peanut, sesame, vegetable

olive oil

Old Bay seasoning

ONIONS: green, red, spring, sweet, white

orange: juice, zest

paprika, esp. sweet

PARSLEY, FLAT-LEAF

peas, green

PEPPER: black, white

pineapple

pine nuts

ponzu sauce

potatoes

radishes

saffron

SALT: kosher, sea

scallions

sesame seeds

shallots

sherry, dry

shiso

SHRIMP

snow peas

sour cream

soy sauce

spinach

stocks: chicken, vegetable

sugar (pinch)

Tabasco sauce

tamarind

tarragon

tartar sauce

thyme

TOMATOES: fresh, sun-dried

vinaigrette, esp. citrus

vinegar: balsamic, champagne, red wine, sherry

watercress

yogurt

Flavor Affinities

crab + aioli + cilantro + jalapeño chile

crab + almonds + avocado

crab + avocado + cilantro + mango

crab + avocado + grapefruit

crab + corn + green tomatoes

crab + cucumber + lime + mint

crab + ginger + lime

crab + lime + mint

crab + mango + raspberry vinegar

crab + black pepper + snow peas

crab + saffron + shallots

When making **crab** cakes, I'll use whole shrimp—the meat in the cakes, and the shrimp heads in the sauce—to intensify the shellfish flavor.

—MICHEL RICHARD, CITRONELLE (WASHINGTON, DC)

Dishes

Black and White Fettuccini with Oven-Dried Tomatoes, Almond Pesto, Calamari, and Crisp Soft-Shell Crab

—Lidia Bastianich, Felidia (New York City)

Crispy Thai-Style Soft-Shell Crab with Green Papaya Salad and Lime Dipping Sauce

—Bob Kinhead, Kinhead's (Washington, DC)

Pecan-Crusted Soft-Shell Crab Tempura with Italian Mustard Fruit

—Patrick O'Connell, The Inn at Little Washington (Washington, Virginia)

Soft-Shell Crab: Sweet Corn, Potatoes, Leeks, Spring Onions, Caper–White Wine Emulsion

—Alfred Portale, Gotham Bar and Grill (New York City)

Chesapeake Bay Soft-Shell Crabs with Young Ginger and Chinese Chive Coulis

—David Waltuck, Chanterelle (New York City)

CRAB, SOFT-SHELL

Season: spring–summer

Taste: sweet

Weight: light–medium

Volume: quiet–moderate

Techniques: deep-fry, grill, pan roast, sauté, tempura

almonds

arrowroot

arugula

asparagus

avocado

bacon

basil

bell peppers, red

broccoli rabe

brown butter sauce

butter: clarified, unsalted capers

cayenne

chervil

chile peppers, jalapeño

chili powder

chives

coleslaw

couscous, Israeli

cream

crème fraîche

cucumbers

daikon

dill

fennel

garlic

ginger (e.g., pickled)

grapefruit

leeks

LEMON, JUICE

lime: juice, zest

mayonnaise

mushrooms (e.g., shiitakes)

mustard, Dijon

nori

OIL: canola, peanut, vegetable

olive oil

onions, red

orange, juice

paprika

parsley, flat-leaf

peas, sugar

PEPPER: black, white

pesto

potatoes, esp. new

rémoulade sauce

sake

SALT: kosher, sea

scallions

scallops

shallots

shiso leaf

shrimp

sorrel

soy sauce

stock, fish

Tabasco sauce

tarragon, fresh

tartar sauce

thyme

tomatoes

vinaigrette

vinegar: balsamic, champagne, white wine

wine, dry white

zucchini

Flavor Affinities

soft-shell crab + arugula + tartar sauce

soft-shell crab + asparagus + capers + garlic + lemon + potatoes

soft-shell crab + broccoli rabe + brown butter

soft-shell crab + cabbage + mustard

soft-shell crab + lemon + parsley

soft-shell crab + orange + parsley

CRANBERRIES

Season: autumn–midwinter

Taste: sour

Weight: light–medium

Volume: loud

Techniques: boil

allspice

almonds

apples

apricots

baked goods

cheese, goat

chicken

chile peppers, jalapeño

chocolate: dark, white

cinnamon

cloves

cognac

cream

cream cheese

currants

ginger

hazelnuts

honey

LEMON: JUICE, ZEST

lime, zest

liqueur, orange (e.g., Grand Marnier)

maple syrup

nuts

oats

ORANGE: juice, zest

peaches

pears

pepper
pistachios
pork
poultry
pumpkin
raisins
quince
salt
star anise
SUGAR: brown, white
sweet potatoes
tangerines
thyme
turkey
vanilla
walnuts
wine, white

CRAYFISH

(aka crawfish)

Season: spring

Weight: light–medium

Volume: moderate

Techniques: boil, broil, steam

asparagus

avocados

bacon

basil

bay leaf

butter

Cajun cuisine

carrots and carrot juice

cayenne

celery

chervil

chives

cloves

coriander

cream / milk

Creole cuisine

dill

egg yolks

endive

fennel seeds

garlic

hazelnuts

leeks

mango

mayonnaise

mirepoix

mushrooms, morels

mustard
oil, grapeseed
olive oil
onions
orange, juice
parsley, flat-leaf
pepper, black
radishes
rice
rosemary
salt
shallots
sorrel
Tabasco sauce
tarragon
thyme
tomatoes
vinegar: tarragon, white wine
wine, dry white (e.g., white Burgundy)
zucchini

Flavor Affinities

crayfish + asparagus + morel mushrooms
crayfish + carrot juice + orange juice

Dishes

Crayfish, Beet, Leek, and Bacon Salad with Mustard Vinaigrette

—Daniel Boulud, at the 2003 James Beard Awards gala reception

CREAM

When you eat a piece of pumpkin pie, the whipped **cream** is the first thing you go for! You can take this for granted in desserts, or you can dig deeper: You can think of cream as its own flavor. When I was in Japan, the cream was miles better than here in the U.S. You also need to think about your dairy choice in relation to the country. In India, everything is centered around reduced milk. The counterpart would be *dolce de leche* in Latin cuisine. I love yogurt because it is simple and complex; it can be in the forefront or in the background.

—MICHAEL LAISKONIS, LE BERNARDIN (NEW YORK CITY)

CREAM CHEESE

Taste: sour

Weight: heavy

Volume: loud

berries

blueberries

bread, esp. fruit

breakfast / brunch

cheese: fresh goat, ricotta

cherries

cloves

cream

crème fraîche

desserts

eggs

fruit, dried

ginger

graham cracker crumbs

honey

kiwi fruit

LEMON: JUICE, ZEST

liqueur, orange (e.g., Grand Marnier)

maple syrup

mascarpone

nutmeg

orange, juice

quince paste

raisins

raspberries

rum

salt (pinch)

sour cream

strawberries

sugar
vanilla
yogurt

Flavor Affinities

cream cheese + crème fraîche + orange + sugar + vanilla
cream cheese + maple syrup + mascarpone

CREAM, SOUR
(See Sour Cream)

CRÈME FRAÎCHE

Taste: sour

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: loud

apples

caramel

French cuisine

fruit, fresh

potatoes

raspberries

sauces

strawberries

sugar, brown

CREOLE CUISINE

bouillabaisse

cayenne

crawfish

okra

onions

oysters

paprika

pepper: black, white

salt

seafood

shrimp rémoulade

CRESS

(See Watercress)

CUBAN CUISINE

allspice
avocado
bay leaf
beans
beef
bell peppers
chicken
chocolate
citrus (e.g., lime, orange)
cumin
garlic
lime
olive oil
onions, esp. white
orange, juice
oregano
pineapple
plantains
pork
rice
seafood (crab, fish, lobster, shrimp)
sugar, white
watercress

Your choice of sugar suggests a country of origin. For example, **Cuban cuisine** relies on white sugar, while Mexican cuisine relies on brown sugar.

—MARICEL PRESILLA, ZAFRA (HOBOKEN, NEW JERSEY)

Flavor Affinities

allspice + cumin + garlic + orange juice + pork
avocado + onions + pineapple + watercress
bay leaf + green bell peppers + garlic + onions + oregano (aka *safrito*)

chocolate + garlic + olive oil

citrus juice + garlic + olive oil (aka *adobo*)

CUCUMBERS

Season: spring–summer

Taste: sweet, astringent

Function: cooling

Weight: light

Volume: quiet

Techniques: pickle, raw, salads, sauté, soups

allspice

bell peppers, esp. green

basil

butter

buttermilk

caraway seeds

cayenne

celery and celery seeds

cheese: blue, feta

chervil

chile peppers: fresh green, jalapeño

chives

cilantro

coconut milk

coriander

cream

cream cheese

crème fraîche

cumin

DILL

fish

fish sauce, Thai or other Asian

frisée

garam masala

GARLIC

gin

Greek cuisine
horseradish
Japanese cuisine
jicama
lemon balm
lemon, juice
lime, juice
melon, esp. honeydew
MINT (e.g., Indian cuisine)
mustard, Dijon
oil: sesame, vegetable
olive oil
ONIONS, esp. green or red
oregano
parsley, flat-leaf
peanuts
pepper: black, white
pineapple
romaine
red pepper flakes
salads
salmon
salt: kosher, sea
scallions
scallops
sesame seeds
shallots
shrimp
smoked salmon
soups, chilled (e.g., gazpacho)
sour cream
soy sauce
sprouts
sugar (pinch)
Tabasco sauce
tamari
tarragon

tea sandwiches

thyme

tomatoes

Vietnamese cuisine

vinaigrettes

VINEGAR: balsamic, champagne, cider, red wine, rice wine, sherry, tarragon,
white wine

vodka

watercress

wine, white

YOGURT (e.g., Indian cuisine)

CUMIN

Taste: bitter, sweet

Function: heating

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate–loud

Tips: Add early in the cooking process.

Toast cumin seeds in a dry pan to evaporate their moisture and increase their flavor.

allspice

anise

apples

baked goods (e.g., breads)

bay leaf

beans, esp. black or kidney

beef

beets

bread (e.g., rye)

cabbage

caramel

cardamom

carrots

cayenne

Flavor Affinities

cucumber + chervil + salt + vinegar

cucumber + chile peppers + mint + yogurt

cucumber + cilantro + ginger + sugar + rice vinegar

cucumber + dill + red onion + sour cream + vinegar

cucumber + dill + salmon

cucumber + dill + yogurt

cucumber + feta cheese + garlic + mint + olive oil + oregano + red wine vinegar

cucumber + garlic + mint + yogurt

cucumber + lemon + sesame oil + vinegar
cucumber + jalapeño chile + dill + onion
cucumber + mint + yogurt

With lighter dishes like rice pilaf or lentils, I use **cumin seeds** for their gentler flavor. With heavier dishes like chickpeas, kidney beans, or red meat, I'll use the stronger-flavored **cumin powder**.

—MEERU DHALWALA, VIJ'S (VANCOUVER)

cheese: esp. aged, feta, Muenster

chicken

chickpeas

chile peppers

chili

chili powder

cinnamon

cloves

coriander

couscous

curries

curry leaves

eggplant

eggs

fennel

fennel seeds

fenugreek seeds

fish

fruits, dried

garam masala (key ingredient)

garlic

ginger

harissa

honey

hummus (key ingredient)

Indian cuisine

Indonesian cuisine

lamb, esp. grilled

LENTILS

mace

meats, esp. stronger-flavored, and esp. grilled

MEXICAN CUISINE

mint, dried

Moroccan cuisine

mustard and mustard seeds (e.g., Indian cuisine)

nutmeg

onions

orange

oregano

paprika

peas

pepper

pork

Portuguese cuisine

potatoes

rice

saffron

salads, esp. pasta, tomato

salmon

saucers (e.g., mole)

sauerkraut

sausages

shellfish

soups (e.g., black bean)

Spanish cuisine

squash

stews

sugar, palm

Tabasco sauce

tahini

tamarind

tequila

Tex-Mex cuisine

Thai cuisine

thyme

tomatoes

tuna

turmeric

vegetables, esp. summer

Vietnamese cuisine

yogurt

Flavor Affinities

cumin + cayenne + coriander + garlic

cumin + chickpeas + yogurt

cumin + cinnamon + saffron

cumin + palm sugar + tamarind

cumin + tomatoes + turmeric

CURRY LEAVES

Taste: sour, bitter

Weight: light

Volume: quiet–moderately loud

Tips: Add later in cooking, or to finish a dish.

allspice

Asian cuisines

bread, esp. Indian (e.g., naan)

cardamom

chile peppers

cilantro

cinnamon

cloves

coconut

coriander

cumin

curries, esp. Indian

fennel seeds

fenugreek seeds

fish

garlic

ginger

Indian cuisine

lamb

lentils

mustard seeds

paprika

peas

pepper

rice

shellfish

soups

stir-fried dishes

stocks
tamarind
turmeric
vegetables

CURRY POWDER AND SAUCES

Taste: bittersweet, pungent

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: moderate–loud

Tips: Add early in cooking process.

beef

butter

cardamom

cashews

cayenne

cheese

chicken

chile peppers, red

cilantro

cinnamon

cloves

coconut

coriander

cream

crème fraîche

cumin

dill

eggs and egg salad

fennel

fish

garlic

ginger

Indian cuisine

lemon, zest

lemongrass

lime, juice

mace

mayonnaise

mushrooms
nutmeg
oil, vegetable
onions
paprika
pepper: black, red
potatoes
saffron
salads (e.g., chicken, egg, potato)
salt, kosher
sauces
shellfish
soups, esp. fish, pea
star anise
stews, meat
stocks: chicken, fish
tamarind
Thai cuisine
tomatoes
tuna
turmeric
vegetables
zucchini

CUSTARDS

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: quiet

almonds

apples

apricots

bananas

berries

caramel

chai

cherries

chocolate, esp. dark or white

cinnamon

coconut

coffee

ginger

hazelnuts

lemon

liqueurs: nut, orange

mango

maple syrup

nutmeg

orange

passion fruit

pears

persimmons

pineapple

plums

prunes

pumpkin

quince

raisins

raspberries

rhubarb
strawberries
sweet potatoes
thyme
vanilla
walnuts
wine, sweet

Torrijas, which means “soaked,” are a [**custardy**] dessert in the Basque country that are like French toast or *pain perdu*. We soak the bread until it is saturated in milk, then let it sit [in the refrigerator] overnight. The next morning before serving, we coat it in egg and then fry it. We serve our version of *torrijas* with poached apples and instead of serving it with maple syrup, we serve it with Pedro Ximenez [a rich, sweet, Spanish sherry] syrup that has a raisin-like quality to it. The PX is just warmed and has a little glucose added to thicken it into a syrup. I don’t cook it or reduce it because I want to keep the alcohol in the syrup so it doesn’t become overly cloying.

—ALEXANDRA RAIJ, TÍA POL (NEW YORK CITY)

DAIKON

Season: autumn–winter

Taste: sweet

Weight: light

Volume: quiet–moderate

Techniques: braise, marinate, raw (e.g., julienned), stew, stir-fry

basil

beef

beets

butter

cabbage

carrots

celery root

cheese, feta

chives

cream

cream cheese

cucumbers

curry powder

dill

duck

fish

ginger

honey

lemon, juice

lovage

marjoram

mint

miso

oil, sesame

onions, esp. green

orange, juice

oregano

parsley
pork
salmon
scallions
soups
sour cream
soy sauce
sugar
sugar snap peas
tamari
thyme
tuna
vinegar

Daikon is great in stews and is milder, sweeter, and more absorbent than turnips or radishes. Duck and turnips is a classic, but I like duck with daikon even better. It pairs well with other heavier flavors, such as pork or beef.

—TONY LIU, AUGUST (NEW YORK CITY)

Dishes

Chocolate and Date Pudding Cake

—Gina DePalma, pastry chef, Babbo (New York City)

Baked-to-Order Date Pudding with a Caramelized Rum Sauce and a Dollop of Freshly Whipped Cream

—Toshi Sakihara, Etats-Unis (New York City)

Medjool Dates Stuffed with Chorizo, Wrapped in Bacon

—Monica Pope, T'afia (Houston)

Medjool Dates with Maple Mascarpone, Pistachios, and Orange Blossom Water

—Monica Pope, T'afia (Houston)

Someone told me about a savory **date** dish they had but could only remember that it was stuffed and wrapped in bacon. This led me into the kitchen to stuff a date with chorizo, wrap it in bacon, and then add charmoula [typically made of paprika, cayenne pepper, cumin, garlic, lemon juice, parsley, cilantro, and olive oil]. The dish just hits the mark. I also serve a sweet date dish that I stole from Judy Rodgers of Zuni Café. My version is made with Medjool dates that have maple mascarpone smeared in, pistachios crumbled on top, and orange blossom water. The orange blossom water gives people a visceral reaction because you don't see it, but you taste it. When people have the dish, they lick their fingers trying to figure it out!

—MONICA POPE, T'AFIA (HOUSTON)

DANDELION GREENS

(See Greens, Dandelion)

DATES

Season: autumn–winter

Taste: sweet

Function: cooling

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: moderate

almonds

apples

apricots

Armagnac

bacon

bananas

brandy

butter, unsalted

buttermilk

cakes

caramel

CHEESE, esp. Brie, Explorateur, **Parmesan**, pecorino, ricotta, Roquefort

cherries, dried

chicken

chives

chocolate, esp. dark or white

cinnamon

coconut

coffee

couscous

cranberries, dried

cream and ice cream

cream cheese

crème fraîche

currants

desserts

figs

ginger
hazelnuts
honey
lamb
lemon
lime
macadamia nuts
maple syrup
mascarpone
Middle Eastern cuisine
Moroccan cuisine
nuts
oats
orange blossom water
ORANGE: juice, zest
pecans
pepper, black
pistachios
prunes
quince
raisins
rosemary
rum
sugar: brown, white
thyme
vanilla
walnuts
wine: red, sweet

Flavor Affinities

dates + caramel + vanilla + walnuts
dates + chocolate + walnuts
dates + cream + rum
dates + maple syrup + mascarpone + pistachios
dates + orange + walnuts

Emily Luchetti of Farallon in San Francisco on When and How to Serve Dessert

The older I get, the more I like my dessert at 3:00 in the afternoon. I like it all by itself, it has no competition and you are usually hungry. Your taste buds are wide awake and you can appreciate what it is. Of course if we have people over for dinner I can't get away with not serving dessert!

When you serve a dessert after a meal you are already full, not in a bad way, but if you had a first course and main course your palate has gone through many flavor components. At home I always take a little break and give people a breather between dinner and dessert. I'll have my guests help with the dishes or, if it's a formal party, I'll let them talk for a half hour and finish off the red wine. It is not just for their stomachs but for the palate as well.

I hate when it comes to slicing a dessert and someone says, "No, no, that is too big!" I used to fight it and take it personally, so now I just ask in advance. The guest appreciates it, has a small piece, and then has seconds. It is recognizing that everyone has their own choice regarding how much they want to eat. If I am serving a shortcake, I will put the fruit with a little cream on the cake, then pass a bowl of whipped cream, so whether they want to pile it or keep it light, they can.

DESSERTS

Tips: Sweetness satiates the appetite, so generally end a meal on a sweet note. Even sweet desserts should be in balance (their acidity, saltiness, etc.). Dessert wine should always be sweeter than the dessert it accompanies.

Dill adds a certain freshness and cleanness to a dish. During the winter, most of my fish dishes have dill—as well as dishes like goulash with noodles, which is served with both chives and dill for their herbal freshness.

—TONY LIU, AUGUST (NEW YORK CITY)

DILL

Season: spring–autumn

Taste: sour, sweet

Weight: light, soft-leaved

Volume: moderately loud

Tips: Always use dill fresh, not cooked.

asparagus

avocados

basil

beans, esp. fava or green

beef

beets

breads, esp. rye

broccoli

cabbage

capers

carrots

cauliflower

celery root

cheese: cheddar, cottage, goat, soft

chicken

chives

cilantro

coriander

corn

crayfish

cream cheese

cream sauces

crème fraîche

CUCUMBERS

eggplant

EGGS AND EGG DISHES (e.g., omelets)

European cuisines

FISH, esp. whole

garlic

German cuisine

Greek cuisine

green beans

halibut

horseradish

lemon balm

lemon thyme

lovage

meats, e.g., lamb

Mediterranean cuisine

Middle Eastern cuisine

mint

mushrooms

mustard

North American cuisine

onions

paprika

parsley

parsnips

peas

PICKLES (key ingredient)

POTATOES AND POTATO SALAD

poultry

rice, esp. pilaf

Russian cuisine

salads and salad dressings

salmon

salmon, cured (key ingredient)

salmon, smoked

sauces

scallops

Scandinavian cuisine

shellfish

shrimp

sole

soups, esp. potato

sour cream and sour cream sauces

spinach

squash

TOMATOES AND TOMATO JUICES

trout

Turkish cuisine

veal

vegetables

YOGURT AND YOGURT SAUCES

zucchini

Flavor Affinities

dill + cilantro + mint

dill + cucumber + salmon

Dishes

Duck, Butternut Squash, and Banana with Thai Flavors

—Grant Achatz, Alinea (Chicago)

Liberty Farms Duck Breast with Smoked Bacon, Savoy Spinach, and Pickled Mulberries, Ginger Consommé

—Traci Des Jardins, Jardinière (San Francisco)

Roast Duck Breast, Bok Choy, and Cassava Chips with Sesame Soy Dressing and Pickled Chiles

—Brad Farmerie, Public (New York City)

Duck with Tomato, Red Chile, and Dried Mixed Fruits

—Zarela Martinez, Zarela (New York City)

Blossom Honey “Lacquered” Aged Moulard Duck Breast, Caramelized Quince and Fennel, Broccoli Rabe, Sicilian Pistachios, and Port

—Carrie Nahabedian, Naha (Chicago)

Grilled Duck Breast with Creamy Farro, Spring Onion, and Sour Cherry Jus

—Peter Nowakoski, Rat’s (Hamilton, New Jersey)

Braised Duck Legs on Wilted Watercress in an Aromatic Asian Broth

—Patrick O’Connell, The Inn at Little Washington (Washington, Virginia)

Cured Duck Meat with a Salad of Licorice-Scented Fennel Shavings and Blood Orange

—Monica Pope, T’afia (Houston)

Drake Duck “Sirloin” with Roasted Sweet Potatoes and Port Wine Sauce

—Monica Pope, T’afia (Houston)

Duck Breast with Fava Beans and Roasted Plums

—Alfred Portale, Gotham Bar and Grill (New York City)

Grilled Duck Breast over Aromatic Tamarillo Sauce, Creamy Quinoa, and Sweet Potato Puree

—Maricel Presilla, Cucharamama (Hoboken, New Jersey)

Moultard Duck Breast with Parsnips, Wild Mushrooms, and a Rosemary Sauce

—Thierry Rautureau, Rover’s (Seattle)

Muscovy Duck Breast with Rainier Cherries, Pecans, and Garden Lettuces

—Judy Rodgers, Zuni Café (San Francisco)

Charcoaled Duck with Walnuts, Confit Leg, and Apricots Baked in Brown Sugar Brioche

—Lydia Shire, Locke-Ober (Boston)

Grilled Liberty Farm Duck with Duck-Liver Wontons in Wild Mushroom Sauce

—Hiro Sone, Terra (St. Helena, California)

Grilled Duck Breast in Lime Leaf Curry with Ginger, Jalapeño Basmati Rice

—Vikram Vij and Meeru Dhalwala, Vij’s (Vancouver)

Spit-Roasted Duck with Quince Sauce

—Alice Waters, Chez Panisse (Berkeley, California)

DUCK

Season: autumn

Weight: heavy

Volume: moderate–loud

Techniques: braise (esp. legs), grill (esp. breast), roast, sauté, stir-fry

allspice

APPLES, esp. Granny Smith

apricots (sauce)

artichokes

arugula

bacon

basil

bay leaf

beans, fava

blueberries

bok choy

butter, unsalted

cabbage: green, red

caraway seeds

cardamom

carrots

celery

celery root

cheese: Asiago, Parmesan, pecorino, ricotta

Our paella made with **duck** confit, foie gras, and morels is in honor of [the late chef] Jean-Louis Palladin. We made a paella with the fat from the duck and morels, and to finish it we topped it with thin slices of raw foie gras. The foie gras would get warm from the hot rice and melt into the rice. It is an amazing paella!

—**JOSÉ ANDRÉS**, CAFÉ ATLÁNTICO (WASHINGTON, DC)

Duck is great with fruit. We serve a duck with Seville oranges that are a little bitter. We made a puree of the pulp and a little peel that had nice acidity and bitterness. We then added fennel that had been cooked with butter and a little star anise.

—**DANIEL HUMM**, ELEVEN MADISON PARK (NEW YORK CITY)

For my dish of lacquered **duck** and peppercress, I make a duck cooked with honey served with a brown butter–honey that gives the duck a sweet, nutty flavor. To cut the sweetness, I added a reduction of pomegranate juice and oil emulsion to give the dish a tart contrast.

—**BOB IACOVONE**, CUVÉE (NEW ORLEANS)

CHERRIES: regular, sun-dried

chervil

chestnuts

chicory

chile peppers: ancho, jalapeño

chili paste

Chinese cuisine

chives

chocolate / cocoa

cilantro

cinnamon

citrus fruit

cloves

coconut milk

coriander

cucumbers

cumin

currants, black or red: fruit, preserves

curry paste, esp. Thai green, or curry powder, esp. Madras

dates

duck fat

farro

fennel

fennel seeds

figs

fish sauce, Thai

five-spice powder

foie gras

GARLIC

GINGER

hoisin sauce

honey, esp. lavender

horseradish

huckleberries

juniper berries

kaffir lime leaves

kumquats

lavender

leeks

LEMON, JUICE, preserved

lemongrass

lentils

lime, juice

liqueur, orange (e.g., Grand Marnier), peach

mangoes

marjoram

Mediterranean cuisine

mint

mirepoix

morels

MUSHROOMS, ESP. WILD (esp. porcini or shiitake)

mustard, Dijon

nutmeg

nuts, macadamia

OIL: canola, grapeseed, peanut, sesame, vegetable

olive oil

olives, esp. green

ONIONS, esp. green, sweet

ORANGE: juice, zest

pancetta

parsley, flat-leaf

pasta

peaches

pears

peas

PEPPER: black, green, pink, white

plums: fruit, sauce

pomegranates

poppy seeds

port

potatoes

prunes

raspberries

red pepper flakes

rice, esp. basmati, wild

risotto

rosemary

sage

sake

SALT: *fleur de sel*, kosher, sea

sauerkraut

scallions

sesame seeds: black, white

shallots

sherry

SOY SAUCE

spinach

squash, butternut

star anise

STOCKS: chicken, duck, game, meat, turkey

stuffing

SUGAR: brown, white

sweet potatoes

Tabasco sauce

tamarind

tarragon, fresh

teriyaki sauce

Thai cuisine

thyme, fresh

tomatoes: paste, puree, raw

turmeric

TURNIPS

vegetables, root

verjus

vermouth

VINEGAR: balsamic, champagne, raspberry, red wine, rice wine, sherry, white

water chestnuts

watercress

WINE, dry red (e.g., Cabernet Sauvignon, Merlot), dry white (e.g., Riesling),
port, rice, sweet (Madeira, Muscat)

Flavor Affinities

duck + almonds + apricots

duck + almonds + honey

duck + apples + celery root + hazelnuts

duck + apples + parsnips (and/or other root vegetables)

duck + apricots + cherries + basmati rice

duck + arugula + lentils

duck + arugula + vinaigrette + walnuts

duck + bacon + ginger + spinach

duck + blackberries + ginger + Pinot Noir

duck + cabbage + mushrooms

duck + cherries + vinegar

duck + cinnamon + honey + orange + star anise

duck + cloves + garlic + orange + prunes + red wine

duck + dates + turnips

duck + fava beans + pecorino cheese

duck + garlic + ginger + mint

duck + ginger + honey + soy sauce

duck + ginger + kumquats + black pepper + star anise

duck + green peppercorns + sweet potatoes

duck + honey + lavender

duck + lemon + plums

duck + lentils + onions + balsamic vinegar

duck + orange + scallions

duck + parsnips + turnips

We serve a sixteen-ounce **duck** breast with a Pinot Noir, blackberry, and ginger sauce. The sauce is made from frozen Oregon blackberries, which I am not shy to admit I use, because eleven months out of the year, there is nothing better. At home, I make a version of this sauce with currant preserves: I sauté the duck, then add lots of fresh ginger and shallots, a few tablespoons of currant preserves, and some champagne vinegar to cut the sweetness.

—MICHAEL LOMONACO, CHEF, PORTER HOUSE NEW YORK (NEW YORK CITY)

Dishes

Duck Confit: Wild Mushrooms, Red Swiss Chard, Sweet and Sour Duck Jus
—Olivier Muller, DB Bistro Moderne (New York City)

DUCK CONFIT

beets
cheese, Roquefort
frisée
garlic
lentils, green
mushrooms, wild
mustard, Dijon
oil: hazelnut, walnut
onions
parsley, flat-leaf
pepper, white
salt
shallots
stock, chicken
vinegar, red wine
watercress

EASTERN EUROPEAN CUISINES

allspice, esp. in desserts

bacon

beef

beets

bell peppers, green

cabbage

caraway seeds

carrots

celery

celery root

chicken

cinnamon, esp. in desserts

cloves, esp. in desserts

cream

dill

game

garlic

ginger, esp. in desserts

juniper berries

lamb

marjoram

meats

mushrooms

mustard

noodles

offal

onions

paprika

pepper, black

potatoes

rice

sour cream

sugar

tomatoes

veal
vegetables, root
vinegar

Flavor Affinities

beef + cabbage + rice
beets + dill + sour cream
cabbage + caraway + vinegar
chicken + cream + paprika
noodles + caraway seeds + sour cream

EGGPLANT

Season: summer

Taste: bitter

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: moderate

Techniques: bake, boil, braise, broil, deep-fry, grill, roast, sauté, steam, stir-fry, stuff

allspice

anchovies

artichokes

basil

bell peppers, esp. green, red

bouquet garni

bread, pita

bread crumbs

cabbage, green

capers

cashews

cayenne

CHEESE: Emmental, feta, goat, Gruyère, mozzarella, **Parmesan**, **ricotta**, **ricotta salata**, Romano, Swiss

chickpeas

chile peppers, esp. fresh green

chili powder

Dishes

Grilled Eggplant Terrine with Red Bell Pepper and Italian Parsley Sauce

—David Bouley, Bouley (New York City)

Eggplant Ravioli with Medallions of Maine Lobster and Tomato-Basil Butter

—Patrick O’Connell, The Inn at Little Washington (Washington, Virginia)

Baba Ghanoush Soup, Made with Eggplant, Tahini, Tomato Water, Garlic, and Cumin

—Michel Richard, Citronelle (Washington, DC)

Eggplant, Peas, and Paneer in Pomegranate-Cinnamon Masala with Raita and Chapati

—Vikram Vij and Meeru Dhalwala, Vij’s (Vancouver)



Chinese cuisine

chives

cilantro

cinnamon

coconut milk

coriander

cumin

curry

dips

Eastern Mediterranean cuisine

fennel

fennel seeds

French cuisine, esp. Provençal

garam masala

GARLIC

ginger

honey

Indian cuisine

Italian cuisine

Japanese cuisine

Korean cuisine

lamb

LEMON, juice

lentils

Middle Eastern cuisine

mint

miso

mushrooms, esp. button, shiitake

mustard, Dijon

oil: peanut, sesame

OLIVE OIL

olives: black, green

ONIONS, esp. red, Spanish, yellow

oregano

paprika (garnish)

PARSLEY, FLAT-LEAF

pasta

PEPPER: BLACK, WHITE

peppers, piquillo (e.g., Spanish cuisine)

pine nuts

pomegranate

prosciutto

red pepper flakes

rice

rosemary

saffron

sage

SALT: kosher, sea

sausage

savory

scallions

sesame: oil, seeds

shallots

soy sauce

squash, yellow or other summer

stock, chicken

sugar

tahini

tamari

thyme

TOMATOES, tomato juice, tomato sauce

VINEGAR: balsamic, champagne, red wine, rice wine, sherry

walnuts

yogurt

zucchini

Flavor Affinities

eggplant + basil + bell peppers + garlic + tomatoes

eggplant + basil + mozzarella cheese

eggplant + basil + olive oil + balsamic vinegar

eggplant + basil + ricotta salata cheese + tomatoes

eggplant + bell peppers + garlic + mustard

eggplant + garlic + lemon juice + olive oil + parsley + tahini

eggplant + garlic + onions + parsley
eggplant + lentils + yogurt

Eggplant is funny. It is a subtle vegetable that can work with strong herbs like rosemary or marjoram.

—**JERRY TRAUNFELD**, THE HERBFARM (WOODINVILLE, WASHINGTON)

Eggplant can take on an even richer, meatier flavor when it's enhanced with miso or tahini.

—**BRAD FARMERIE**, PUBLIC (NEW YORK CITY)

My **eggplant** gazpacho really tastes like a baba ghanoush soup. We start the soup by roasting eggplant and onions. Then we blend this together with tahini, tomato water, buttermilk for acidity, lemon, and garlic. The soup is garnished with three gels made of eggplant, lemon, and onion—all flavors from the soup. I love texture—people joke with me and call me “Captain Crunch”—so at the last second, we top the soup with Rice Krispies.

—**MICHEL RICHARD**, CITRONELLE (WASHINGTON, DC)

Dishes

Frittata with Zucchini and Parmesan Cheese, with Arugula Salad

—Andrew Carmellini, A Voce (New York City)

Poached Eggs with Crispy Polenta and Tomato Hollandaise

—Andrew Carmellini, A Voce (New York City)

Warm Salad of Greens with Pancetta and Scrambled Eggs

—Cesare Casella, Maremma (New York City)

Organic Egg Frittata with Mushrooms, Zucchini, and Gruyère

—Daniel Humm, Eleven Madison Park (New York City)

Organic Farm Egg Omelet with Capriole Farms Goat Cheese, Oranges, and Citrus Hollandaise, Toasted Ciabatta, and Apple Butter

—Carrie Nahabedian, Naha (Chicago)

Organic Farm Egg and Wood-Grilled Spanish Sausage with a Salad of Italian Frisée Smoked Red Thumb Potatoes, French Breakfast Radishes, Sweet Garlic, and Herbs

—Carrie Nahabedian, Naha (Chicago)

Organic Scrambled Egg with a Lime Crème Fraîche and White Sturgeon Caviar

—Thierry Rautureau, Rover's (Seattle)

Traditional Eggs Benedict, Shaved Canadian Bacon, Lemon-Thyme Hollandaise, and Truffle Pesto

—Nori Sugie, Asiate (New York City)

Smoked Chicken, Roasted Bell Pepper, Artichoke, and Fontina Cheese Omelet

—Nori Sugie, Asiate (New York City)

I like **frittata** as a main course at lunch or dinner. You can simply have frittata with a soup, and it's a meal. Frittata is like a risotto in its versatility; you can go crazy with it and add almost anything to them. I love my frittata with vegetables; asparagus, artichokes, mushrooms, onions, zucchini all work. With any variety of vegetables I would add some fresh herbs and cheese. Since the eggs are the protein, the only thing I don't personally care for in my frittata is meat, or maybe pickled vegetables.

—ODETTE FADA, SAN DOMENICO (NEW YORK CITY)

We will serve the combination of poached **egg** and spring asparagus differently at brunch versus dinner. At brunch, we will serve sliced asparagus mixed with other sliced vegetables in the bottom of a *cazuela* [clay pot] with the poached egg on top. For dinner, it will be green market asparagus topped with a poached egg and anchovy butter.

—ALEXANDRA RAIJ, TÍA POL (NEW YORK CITY)

EGGS AND EGGBASED DISHES—IN GENERAL

Taste: sweet, astringent

Function: heating

Weight: light–medium

Volume: quiet

Techniques: bake (frittata, quiche, etc.), boil (soft or hard), fry, poach, scramble

asparagus

bacon and pancetta

basil

bell peppers, esp. green

bread

butter

capers

caviar

cheeses: Comté, Emmental, **feta**, **Gruyère**, **Havarti**, **mozzarella**, **Parmesan**,
Roquefort

chervil

chives

chorizo

cream

cream cheese

crème fraîche

dill

garlic

ginkgo nuts

ham: Serrano, Virginia

herbs, esp. fines herbes (i.e., chervil, chives, parsley, tarragon)

leeks

marjoram

mushrooms

olive oil

onions

parsley, flat-leaf

pepper: black, white

potatoes

salmon, smoked

salt: kosher, sea

sausage

scallions

shallots

sorrel

spinach

tarragon

thyme

tomatoes

truffles



AVOID

cranberries

Flavor Affinities

eggs + bacon + cheese + onions

eggs + bacon + crème fraîche + onions (Alsatian)

eggs + beets + smoked whitefish (Yiddish)

eggs + cheese + mushrooms + thyme

eggs + kale + pinkelwurst (oatmeal sausage) (Berliner)

eggs + mozzarella cheese + tomatoes (Roman)

eggs + mushrooms + red wine (Bordelaise)

eggs + potato + sausage

EGGS, FRITTATA

anchovies

artichokes

arugula

asparagus

bacon and pancetta

basil

bell peppers

cheese: feta, Gruyère, Havarti, mozzarella, Parmesan

chives

herbs

Italian cuisine

mushrooms

olives

onions

pepper, black

salt, esp. kosher

sausage

shallots

thyme

tomatoes

zucchini

EGGS, HARD-BOILED

Techniques: chop, devil, halve, sieve, slice

almonds

basil

butter, unsalted

cayenne

chile peppers,

jalapeño

chives

cilantro

cream

curry

dill

garlic

ginger, pickled

leeks

mayonnaise

mint

mustard: Dijon, dry

olive oil

paprika

parsley, flat-leaf

pepper, black

salmon

salt, kosher

sauce, béchamel

scallions

shallots

sour cream

Tabasco sauce

tarragon

tomatoes

ENDIVE

Season: winter–spring

Taste: bitter, sweet

Weight: light

Volume: quiet–moderate

Techniques: braise, glaze, grill, raw, roast

almonds

anchovies

apples

arugula

avocado

bacon and pancetta

basil

bay leaf

beets

butter, unsalted

capers

cardamom, green

celery

CHEESE: Asiago, **blue**, goat, **Gorgonzola**, **Gruyère**, herb, **Parmesan**,

Roquefort

chervil

chicken

chives

cinnamon

coriander

crab

cream

cream cheese

crème fraîche

cumin

fennel seeds

fenugreek

French cuisine

frisée

game

garlic

ginger

grapefruit

honey

horseradish

leeks

lemon, juice

mayonnaise

mushrooms

mustard: Dijon, dry, whole grain

mustard seeds

OIL: grapeseed, peanut, safflower, vegetable

OLIVE OIL

olives, black

orange: fruit, juice

parsley, flat-leaf

peanuts

pears

pecans

pepper: black, white

nuts

pistachios

pomegranate

radicchio

red pepper flakes

rosemary

salads

salt: kosher, sea

seafood

shallots

shrimp

smoked fish, esp. salmon or trout

sour cream

stocks: chicken, fish, veal

sugar: brown, white

tarragon

thyme

tomatoes

vinaigrette, mustard

VINEGAR: balsamic, raspberry, **red wine**, sherry

WALNUTS

watercress

Dishes

Cabbageless Sauerkraut: Pickled Onions, Fennel, Endive, and Green Apple

—Christopher Lee, Gilt (New York City)

Endive Tips with Red Pepper Puree, Maple Molasses, and Candied Walnuts

—Monica Pope, T'afia (Houston)

Endive and Grapefruit Salad with Honey Dressing and Toasted Pecans

—Monica Pope, T'afia (Houston)

Belgian Endive Salad, Shredded Carrot and Apple Salad, Concord Grapes, Sonoma Verjus Vinaigrette

—Nori Sugie, Asiate (New York City)

People shy away from **endive** because of its bitterness. But a good chef will pair it with a sweet dressing.

—CARRIE NAHABEDIAN, NAHA (CHICAGO)

Flavor Affinities

endive + argula + radicchio

endive + cheese + mushrooms

ENDIVE, CURLY
(See Frisée)

ENGLISH CUISINE

cheese: Cheddar, Stilton

cream

fish (and chips)

game

jams and preserves

lamb

mutton

oats

peas

puddings (e.g., Yorkshire)

roast beef

scones

tea

tea sandwiches

Worcestershire sauce

EPAZOTE

Taste: bitter

Weight: light–medium

Volume: moderate–loud

beans, esp. black

bell peppers

Caribbean cuisine

Central American cuisine

chile peppers

chorizo

cilantro

cloves

corn

cumin

fish

garlic

goat

Latin American cuisines

legumes

lime

Mexican cuisine

mole sauces

mushrooms

onions

oregano

paprika

pepper

pork

rice

salsas

shellfish

soups

squash

tomatillos
vegetables, green

I have always loved to mix meat and fish in a very delicate way. I went to Cut [Wolfgang Puck's steak restaurant] and had my first true Kobe beef steak. I begged Lee [Heft, the chef] for his source! Surf and turf is not as much about having a piece of meat and fish on the plate as about the ideas they create for flavor combinations. The Kobe beef triggered everything. I can't serve steak at a fish restaurant, but the Kobe was so good I had to find a way to justify it on the menu. I came up with Kobe beef and **escalar**, with a brown butter that is classic with the fish. The final dish was inspired by having Korean barbecue at a friend's house, which is when I realized how to bring it together.

I wanted another element in the dish because the Kobe, escalar, and brown butter are all rich and all soft. The dish also has squash, Japanese pears, and napa cabbage marinated like Korean kimchee for just a moment. These elements add contrast, chewiness, and crunchiness.

—**ERIC RIPERT**, LE BERNARDIN (NEW YORK CITY)

ESCALAR

brown butter

Kobe beef

Flavor Affinities

escalar + Kobe beef + brown butter

ESCAROLE

Season: year-round

Taste: bitter

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate–loud

Techniques: braise, grill, roast

almonds

anchovies

beans

beef

butter

cheese: Fontina, Gruyère, mozzarella, Parmesan, Roquefort

chile peppers, dried red

cream

cumin

fish

garlic

hazelnuts

lemon

olive oil

olives,

black

onions

paprika, sweet

parsley

pepper: black, white

pork

poultry

red pepper flakes

salt, kosher

shallots

soups, esp. bean

stock, chicken

tomatoes (e.g., cherry)
vinegar, red or white wine

Flavor Affinities

escarole + apples + Cheddar cheese
escarole + olive oil + shallots

Escarole is a bitter but sturdy leaf, and in a salad dressed with olive oil and red wine vinegar, I like to add Cheddar for its sharpness and creaminess plus some crisp and refreshing apples.

—TONY LIU, AUGUST (NEW YORK CITY)

ETHIOPIAN CUISINE

beef, raw or stewed injera

spices

stewed dishes

vegetables, stewed

wine, honey

EUROPEAN, EASTERN CUISINES
(See Eastern European Cuisines)

FALL
(See Autumn)

FENNEL

Season: year-round

Taste: sweet

Weight: light

Volume: quiet

Techniques: boil, braise, fry, grill, raw, roast, sauté, steam

almonds

anise

apples

arugula

asparagus

basil

bay leaf

beets: vegetable, juice

bell peppers

BUTTER, UNSALTED

carrots

CHEESE: blue, goat, Gorgonzola, Gruyère, **Parmesan**, pecorino

chicken

chives

coriander

crab

cream

crème fraîche

cucumbers

eggplant

eggs

endive

fennel pollen

fennel seeds

FISH, esp. grilled and/or whole salmon, sea bass, snapper

frisée

garlic

ginger, fresh
Italian cuisine
herbs
honey
lamb
leeks
LEMON: juice, zest
lemon balm
lettuce: Bibb, butter
lime: juice, leaf (kaffir)
lobster
lovage
meats
Mediterranean cuisine
mint
mussels
nutmeg
OIL: canola
olive oil
olives: black, green
onions, esp. red
ORANGE: JUICE, segments
pancetta
paprika
parsley, flat-leaf
pasta
pears
pecans
PEPPER: BLACK, WHITE
Pernod
pickles
pork
potatoes
prosciutto
rice
rosemary
salads (e.g., green or tuna) and salad dressings

salmon
salt: kosher, sea
sambuca
sauces
scallions
shallots
shellfish
shrimp
soups, esp. vegetable
spinach
star anise
stews, esp. fish
stocks: chicken, veal, vegetable
stuffing
sugar (pinch)
swordfish
tarragon
thyme
tomatoes and tomato sauce
tuna
veal
vegetables, esp. summer
vermouth
vinaigrettes
vinegar: champagne, cider, raspberry
walnuts
watercress
wine: dry white, vermouth
zucchini

Dishes

Wild Fennel and Ramp Soup with Broken Capellini and Alaskan King Crab

—Lidia Bastianich, Felidia (New York City)

Braised Fennel Salad with Pears and Gorgonzola

—Mario Batali, Babbo (New York City)

Puree of Fennel Soup with Apples, Almonds, and Madras Curry

—Traci Des Jardins, Jardinière (San Francisco)

I like **fennel** shaved raw, with just some lemon juice, olive oil, and fennel seeds. Fennel goes well with dried meats like prosciutto. It also pairs nicely with shellfish like langoustines, lobster, or crab. Fennel can work with fish as well as with meat. It goes really well with cold poached salmon or white, light meats like chicken or veal.

—GABRIEL KREUTHER, THE MODERN (NEW YORK CITY)

Fennel is a flavor I like so much that I have to show restraint with it. You can add anything to it because other flavors really adhere to it. You can braise it in olive oil and veal stock to get one flavor. Or you can braise it in olive oil, white wine, and water and get a whole other flavor. Or you can quarter it, caramelize it, and roast it in the oven—now you have a sugar flavor and it can become a dessert. I love fennel every way including braised, caramelized, dried, candied, and pureed. In the fall, I served raw shaved fennel with arugula, and shaved Honeycrisp apple with a dressing made of apple cider, honey, and mustard. Fennel puts the salad over the top with its crunch. In summer, we serve a fennel and fig tarte tatin with duck. You get a Fig Newton flavor from the fig and Pernod flavor from the fennel; they match really well.

—CARRIE NAHABEDIAN, NAHA (CHICAGO)

Flavor Affinities

fennel + almond + fennel seeds + honey + lemon

fennel + apple + pecorino cheese + watercress

fennel + asparagus + fennel seeds + garlic + olive oil

fennel + garlic + onions + tomatoes

fennel + lemon + mint + olive oil + olives + orange

fennel + lemon + olive oil + Parmesan cheese + parsley

fennel + onions + potatoes + chicken stock

fennel + orange + sambuca

FENNEL POLLEN

Taste: sweet

Weight: light

Volume: quiet

Tips: Use to finish a dish.

apricots
beef
boar
chicken
cream
fennel seeds
fish, esp. flakier white, poached or steamed
garlic
lamb
lemon
nuts, esp. almonds, pistachios
pasta
pork
potatoes
poultry
rabbit
rice or risotto
salads
salmon
sea trout
shellfish
vegetables
yogurt

Flavor Affinities

fennel pollen + lemon + yogurt

Fennel pollen has a light, fennel-anise flavor with a floral component. It is delicate, so you don't cook with it—you just finish a dish with it. It is great on lighter things like salads, poached or steamed flaky white fish, poultry, or pork. When a dish has fennel pollen, even before the food hits your mouth you will notice a floral smell that gets you thinking of summer, lighter foods, and freshness. I use it with my sea trout dish, which is served with a simple salad of green apple, fennel, jicama, pistachios, and dried gooseberries. The dish is topped with the pollen blended with some yogurt, lemon juice, and preserved lemon, which we drape over the fish. This dish just screams “summer.” With a glass of Sauvignon Blanc on the terrace in the early evening, you're set!

—**BRAD FARMERIE**, PUBLIC (NEW YORK CITY)

I really like **fennel pollen**. The majority of the time, we use it in a marinade for meats like pork, boar, chicken, and lamb. It adds an interesting herbaceous, aromatic note and a mysterious flavor.

—**SHARON HAGE**, YORK STREET (DALLAS)

FENNEL SEEDS

Taste: sweet

Weight: light

Volume: quiet–medium

Tips: Add near end of cooking process.

apples

baked goods (e.g., breads)

basil

beans

beets

bouillabaisse

cabbage

chicken

Chinese cuisine

cinnamon

cloves

cucumber

cumin

curries

duck

fennel

figs

FISH, ESP. STEAMED

five-spice powder (key ingredient)

garam masala (key ingredient)

garlic

herbes de Provence (key ingredient)

Italian cuisine

leeks

lentils

meats, braised

Mediterranean cuisine

olives

orange
paprika
parsley
pasta
pepper, black
pickles
pork
potatoes
ras el hanout (key ingredient)
rice
saffron
salads
sauces
sauerkraut
***SAUSAGES, esp. Italian**
Scandinavian cuisine
shellfish
soups, esp. fish
star anise
stews, esp. fish
stocks and broths
tarragon
tomatoes and tomato sauces
vegetables, esp. green

Flavor Affinities

fennel seeds + cinnamon + cloves + peppercorns + star anise (five-spice powder)

FENUGREEK

Season: autumn

Taste: bitter, sweet

Function: heating

Weight: light–medium

Volume: quiet–moderate

cardamom

cauliflower

cheeses, esp. creamy

chicken

cinnamon

cloves

coriander

cream, esp. sour

cumin

CURRIES AND CURRY POWDERS

Ethiopian cuisine

fennel seeds

fish

garlic

Indian cuisine lamb

legumes

lentils

maple syrup, artificial (key ingredient)

mayonnaise

mint

peas

pepper

potatoes

rabbit

rice

saucers, esp. creamy

shellfish, shrimp

soups
spinach
stews, esp. tomato-based
tomatoes
turmeric
vegetables, esp. green and root
yogurt

I love **fenugreek**, and its incredible aromatics. It goes well with everything from lamb to chicken to vegetables.

—**VIKRAM VIJ**, VIJ'S (VANCOUVER)

FETA CHEESE
(See Cheese, Feta)

FIDDLEHEAD FERNS

Season: spring

Taste: bitter

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate–loud

Techniques/Tips: Always serve cooked: blanch, boil, sauté, steam.

American cuisine, esp. New England

asparagus

bacon

basil

beans, fava

beef

brown butter

butter, sweet

cayenne

cheese: Comté, goat, Parmesan

chicken

fennel

fish (e.g., halibut, salmon)

garlic

hollandaise sauce

horseradish

lamb

lemon, juice

MUSHROOMS, WILD, e.g., chanterelles, morels

mustard

oil: sesame, walnut

olive oil

onions, esp. cipollini, red, spring

parsley, flat-leaf

pasta, esp. gnocchi

pepper

polenta

potatoes, esp. Yukon gold

poultry

prosciutto

ramps

salads

salt

sesame seeds

shallots

soy sauce

spinach

tarragon

thyme

veal

vinaigrettes

vinegar: balsamic, sherry

walnuts

yogurt

Dishes

Bresaola with Fiddleheads and Pecorino

—Mario Batali, Babbo (New York City)

Flavor Affinities

fiddlehead ferns + butter + herbs + morel mushrooms + ramps

fiddlehead ferns + garlic + morel mushrooms + salmon

fiddlehead ferns + sesame oil and/or seeds + soy sauce

FIGS, DRIED

Taste: sweet

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate

Techniques: stew

almonds

anise seeds

apples

apricots, dried

bananas

bay leaf

brandy

caramel

cheese: goat, manchego, Parmesan, ricotta

cherries, dried

chestnuts

chocolate, esp. dark, white

cinnamon

cloves

coconut

coffee

cognac

cream

dates

game

ginger

HONEY

lemon: juice, zest

macadamia nuts

maple syrup

mascarpone

nutmeg

oats

ORANGE: fruit, juice

pastries

pears

pecans

pineapple

pistachios

prunes

quince

raisins, yellow

sugar, brown

sweet potatoes

vanilla

WALNUTS

WINE, RED, sweet

Flavor Affinities

dried figs + anise + oranges + walnuts



FIGS, FRESH

Season: summer–autumn

Taste: sweet, astringent

Function: cooling

Weight: medium

Volume: quiet–moderate

Techniques: bake, broil, caramelize, deep-fry, grill, raw, roast

ALMONDS

anchovies

anise, esp. green

apples

arugula

bacon

butter, unsalted

caramel

CHEESE: blue, fromage blanc, **goat**, **Gorgonzola**, dry Jack, manchego, provolone, **ricotta**, Roquefort

cherries

chicken

chocolate: dark, white

cilantro

cinnamon

cloves

coffee / espresso

cognac

CREAM AND ICE CREAM

cream cheese

crème anglaise

crème fraîche

duck

fish (e.g., bass)

five-spice powder

French cuisine, esp. southern

game birds

garlic

ginger

grapes

ham, esp. Serrano

hazelnuts

HONEY

Italian cuisine, esp. southern

Kirsch

lamb

lavender

lemon: juice, zest

lime, juice

liqueurs, esp. raspberry

mango

mascarpone

meats, cured and smoked

Mediterranean cuisine

Middle Eastern cuisine

mint

Moroccan cuisine

oil, grapeseed

olive oil

onions

ORANGE: juice, zest

pancetta

pears

pecans

pepper, black

pine nuts

pistachios

pork

port

prosciutto

quail

radicchio

RASPBERRIES

rice

rosemary

rum, esp. dark

sorbets

star anise

SUGAR: brown, white

thyme

VANILLA

Vin Santo

VINEGAR: BALSAMIC, red wine, sherry

WALNUTS

wine: dry red, Marsala, port

Dishes

Fresh Fig Tart with a Dollop of Mascarpone

—Gina DePalma, pastry chef, Babbo (New York City)

Fig and Ricotta Gelato

—Gina DePalma, pastry chef, Babbo (New York City)

Honey-Baked Figs Stuffed with Walnuts

—Gina DePalma, pastry chef, Babbo (New York City)

Black Mission Figs with Goat Cheese Mousse, Honey Ice Cream, and Port Sabayon

—Gary Danko, Gary Danko (San Francisco)

Rogue River Oregonzola, Black Mission Figs, Lavender Honey, Toasted Hazelnuts

—Monica Pope, T'afia (Houston)

Flavor Affinities

figs + almonds + green anise

figs + black pepper + ricotta cheese

figs + caramel + vanilla + balsamic vinegar

figs + cilantro + lime

figs + cinnamon + honey + orange

figs + cream + goat cheese + honey

figs + cream + honey + raspberries

figs + goat cheese + pine nuts

figs + honey + mascarpone

figs + lemon + rosemary

figs + olive oil + rosemary

figs + Pernod + walnuts

FILET MIGNON

(See Beef—Steak: Filet Mignon)

FINES HERBES

Tips: Use late in the cooking process.

French cuisine

Flavor Affinities

chervil + chives + parsley + tarragon

Think of white **fish**—dorade, Dover sole, pompano, skate, snapper—as white meat, and red fish—salmon, tuna—as red meat. Salmon is like pork, and tuna like beef, and both combine better with stronger flavors. Tuna even pairs with some of the same flavors as beef, including black pepper, red wine, and wasabi.

—MICHEL RICHARD, CITRONELLE (WASHINGTON, DC)

I like my **fish** simply grilled or steamed. I choose fish that have a lot of flavor so very little has to be done to them. I don't believe you need 10,000 things for a great piece of fish. Dover sole doesn't need anything. Turbot has a wonderful flavor with no help. We get our baby octopus from Sicily and they have plenty of flavor.

—ODETTE FADA, SAN DOMENICO (NEW YORK CITY)



FISH—IN GENERAL

(See individual fish; Seafood)

Taste: sweet

Function: heating

Weight: light–medium

Volume: quiet–moderate

anise

basil

broths

butter

cream

dill

fennel

finest herbes (i.e., chervil, chives, parsley, tarragon)

garlic

ginger

grapefruit

leeks

lemon: juice, zest

lemongrass

lemon verbena

lime: juice, zest

parsley

peas (accompaniment)

peppercorns

rhubarb

salt

tomatoes

wine, esp. white

Dishes

Onion-Crusted White Fish with Tomato-Water Sauce

—Michel Richard, Citronelle (Washington, DC)

Flavor Affinities

fish + ginger + lemongrass

fish + herbs + white wine

fish + onions + tomatoes

FISH SAUCE

Taste: salty

Weight: light

Volume: loud

lime, juice

sauces, dipping

shrimp

Southeast Asian cuisines

spring rolls

sugar

Thai cuisine

Vietnamese cuisine

vegetables

FIVE-SPICE POWDER

Taste: sweet

Weight: light

Volume: quiet–moderate

beef

chicken

Chinese cuisine

duck

pork

stews

stir-fries

Flavor Affinities

cinnamon + cloves + fennel seeds + star anise + Szechuan peppercorns

Dishes

Flounder Wrapped in Spring Roll Paper Served with House-Made Egg Noodles, Thai Green Curry–Coconut Milk Broth with Snow Peas, Yuzu Lime, and Honey Mushrooms

—Bob Kinkead, Colvin Run (Vienna, Virginia)

Sesame-Flavored Flounder and Wakame Seaweed Soup

—Kaz Okochi, Kaz Sushi Bistro (Washington, DC)

FLOUNDER

Season: summer

Weight: light

Volume: quiet

Techniques: bake, broil, deepfry, fry, poach, sauté, steam, stir-fry

almonds

basil

bread crumbs or cracker crumbs

butter

capers

chili sauce

chives

coconut milk

corn

cornmeal (e.g., as a crust)

crab

curry, green

dill

lemon

lime

Mediterranean cuisine

miso

noodles

olive oil

onions, Vidalia

pasta

peas

pepper, black

ramps

salt

seaweed, esp. konbu

shiso

ume (Japanese plum)

wine, white

yuzu

zucchini

Flavor Affinities

flounder + capers + lemon

flounder + shiso + ume

flounder + konbu seaweed + shiso

FOIE GRAS

Season: autumn

Weight: heavy

Volume: moderate

Techniques: braise, sauté, terrine

allspice

APPLES

apricots

Armagnac

bacon

brandy

cabbage

cherries

chives

chocolate

cognac

endive

figs: dried, fresh

French cuisine

ginger

grapes

leeks

lemon

mangoes

miso

nutmeg

oil, grapeseed

olive oil

onions

peaches

pears

pepper, black

pistachios

plums

port

raisins

rhubarb

salt, kosher

Sauternes

shallots

stock, chicken

strawberries

sugar (dash)

tomatoes

truffles and truffle oil, esp. white

vinegar: balsamic, cider

Flavor Affinities

foie gras + cherries + balsamic vinegar

foie gras + cherries + pistachios

foie gras + strawberries + black pepper

Dishes

Foie Gras with Roasted Plums

—Carrie Nahabedian, Naha (Chicago)

Foie Gras Sushi with Plum-Wine Jelly

—Kaz Okochi, Kaz Sushi Bistro (Washington, DC)

Seared Hudson Valley Foie Gras with Caramelized Three-Pear Salad

—Jimmy Schmidt, at the 2003 James Beard Awards gala reception

I found a recipe for olive oil cake at the same time that I was perfecting making a **foie gras** mousse that was pliable to the point that it could be made into an icing. So, I created a savory cake topped with the icing. Then one day while I was online I heard someone mention Twinkies, and the next thing I knew I was ordering real Twinkie pans online. Three days later, Twinkies stuffed with foie gras was born. I serve it with fresh strawberries and black pepper. It seems like everything has been done already, but I like to think I am the only person working with Twinkies.

—**BOB IACOVONE**, CUVÉE (NEW ORLEANS)

FRENCH CUISINE—IN GENERAL

beef

cheese

CREAM

eggs

herbs

mustards

onions

parsley

pastries

pork

potatoes

poultry

roasted meats

SAUCES

sausages

sautéed dishes

seafood

shallots

spirits

STOCK

tarragon

thyme

truffles, black

veal

vinegars

wheat, esp. as flour

WINE

Flavor Affinities

butter + cheese + stock

butter + cheese + wine

butter + herbs

cream + herbs

herbs + stock
herbs + wine

Tarte flambée is a dish that is 200 years old and was originally made by farmers in Alsace in the village's wood-burning oven used for baking bread. The *tarte flambée* developed from what was on hand on the farm: cheese and cream from the cow, pork from the pig, and onions from the field, which they added to some dough. Since we don't have a wood-burning oven [in the middle of Manhattan], we have to tweak the recipe from the classic. We have to tweak the cream because if we don't, it breaks and just becomes grease. Instead, I use a mix of fromage blanc, cream, and sour cream so I can get the same result as cream in the original. And to compensate for not having a fire, I use an applewood-smoked bacon.

—GABRIEL KREUTHER, THE MODERN (NEW YORK CITY)

FRENCH CUISINE, NORTHERN

apples: cider, fruit, juice buckwheat (key ingredient in crepes)

BUTTER

cabbage

Calvados

charcuterie

cheese: Camembert

CREAM

fish, freshwater

game

lobster

oysters

pork: bacon, ham

sausages

shellfish

veal

Flavor Affinities

bacon + cheese + cream

FRENCH CUISINE, SOUTHERN

(aka Provençal Cuisine)

anchovies

anise

basil

beef, esp. stewed

bell peppers

chicken, esp. grilled

fish, esp. grilled

garlic

grilled dishes

herbes de Provence

lamb, esp. roasted

lavender

marjoram

meats

mustard

OLIVE OIL

olives

pâtés

pork

rosemary

sage

shellfish

soups

tomatoes

vegetables

wine

Flavor Affinities

basil + garlic + olive oil + Parmesan cheese

basil + olive oil + tomatoes

bell peppers + eggplant + garlic + onions + tomatoes + zucchini

chicken + garlic + olives + onions + tomatoes

garlic + egg yolk + lemon + olive oil + saffron

marjoram + rosemary + sage + thyme (aka *herbes de Provence*)

olives + basil + capers + garlic + olive oil (aka tapenade)

pork + anise + marjoram + thyme

seafood + garlic + olive oil + tomatoes

FRESHNESS

Season: spring–summer

Tips: Listed herbs are always used fresh (with little or no cooking), and add a note of freshness to a dish. Other listed flavors add a bright note to a dish. For the opposite, see listing for **Slow-Cooked**.

basil

chives

cilantro

citrus

dill

fennel pollen

mint

tarragon

FRISÉE

(a fine-leaved variety of curly endive)

Season: year-round

Taste: sweet, bitter

Weight: light

Volume: quiet

Techniques: raw, wilt

almonds

anchovies

avocado

bacon / lardons

basil

bell peppers: red, yellow

beets

CHEESE: BLUE, GOAT, PARMESAN, ROQUEFORT

cherries, dried

chervil

chives

cilantro

croutons (accent)

cucumbers

eggs, esp. poached

endive

fat: bacon, duck

garlic

ginger

grapefruit

lemon, juice

lettuces: red oak leaf, red leaf

lime, juice

maple syrup

mushrooms, white

mustard, Dijon

oil: canola, grapeseed, hazelnut, walnut

olive oil

olives

onions, red

orange, juice

parsley, flat-leaf

pepper: black, white

salads, esp. warm

salt: kosher, sea

scallops

seafood

shallots

tangerines and tangerine juice

tarragon

tomatoes

vinaigrette

vinegar: sherry, white wine

walnuts (accent)

watercress

Dishes

**Salad “Lyonnaise”: Italian Frisée, Applewood Slab Bacon, and Warm Poached Egg,
Sherry Wine–Dijon Mustard Vinaigrette**

—Carrie Nahabedian, Naha (Chicago)

Warm Frisée and Bacon Salad with Beet Carpaccio and Toasted Walnuts

—Lydia Shire, Locke-Ober Café (Boston)

**Frisée and Spinach Salad with Dried Cherries, Blue Cheese, Walnuts, and Maple-
Sherry Vinaigrette**

—Charlie Trotter, Trotter’s to Go (Chicago)

Flavor Affinities

frisée + anchovies + garlic + Parmesan cheese

frisée + bacon + poached egg

frisée + bacon + Roquefort cheese + garlic + shallots + sherry vinegar

FRUIT, DRIED

(See also Dates, Figs, Raisins, etc.)

Taste: sweet

Tips: If the fruit is hard, steam before using.

apple juice

chocolate

cinnamon

ginger

lemon

nuts

pistachios

vanilla

walnuts

FRUIT, FRESH

(See also specific fruits)

Taste: sweet

Tips: Sugar enhances the natural flavor of fruit.

almonds

ginger, fresh

lemon: juice, zest

sabayon sauce

SUGAR

vanilla

FRUIT, TROPICAL

(See also specific fruits, e.g., Mangoes, Papayas, Pineapples, etc.)

Taste: sweet, sour

bananas
bourbon
caramel
chile peppers
chocolate
chocolate, white
cloves
coconut
coriander
cream and ice cream
five-spice powder
ginger
guava
honey
lemon: juice, zest
lemongrass

LIME: JUICE, ZEST

mangoes
melon, honeydew
mint
orange: juice, zest
pineapple
pomegranates

RUM

spirits, white: gin, vodka
strawberries

sugar: brown, white

vanilla

yogurt

Tropical fruits are strong flavored, and stand up to chocolate better. At the same time, tropical fruits like bananas or mangoes are not overly sweet fruits, so caramel can stand up to them. With tropical fruits, I will use a little lime juice and often rum as well to help give them a little kick. With mangoes, I use a little light brown sugar—or I'll even blend light brown and white sugar together because I'll want the flavor but not want it to be too harsh.

—**EMILY LUCHETTI**, FARALLON (SAN FRANCISCO)

Dishes

Exotic Fruit Salad with Guava Sauce and Phyllo Galettes

—Dominique and Cindy Duby, Wild Sweets (Vancouver)

Chocolate Custard Cake with Exotic Fruit Gelée and Caramelized Bananas

—Dominique and Cindy Duby, Wild Sweets (Vancouver)

Tropical Fruit Salad with Rosewater and Sweet Tahini Yogurt

—Brad Farmerie, Public (New York City)

Flavor Affinities

tropical fruit + coconut + honey + lime

tropical fruit + ginger + mint + orange + sugar

GAME—IN GENERAL

(See also **Rabbit, Venison**)

Season: autumn

Weight: heavy

Volume: moderate–loud

Techniques: braise, roast

Tips: The flavor of cloves adds richness to game.

allspice

cabbage, red

cayenne

cherries

chestnuts

cloves

cranberries, dried

garlic

gin

greens

Italian cuisine

juniper berries

lentils

Madeira

maple syrup

mushrooms, wild

mustard, Dijon

onions

parsley, flat-leaf

pepper, black

salt, sea

stock, beef

sugar, brown

vinegar

wine, red

GARAM MASALA

Function: warming

Tips: Add near the end of the cooking process or before serving.

Indian cuisine

Flavor Affinities

cardamom + black pepper + cinnamon + cloves + coriander + cumin + dried chiles + fennel + mace + nutmeg



GARLIC

Season: year-round

Botanical relatives: chives, leeks, onions, shallots

Function: heating

Weight: light–medium

Volume: moderate (esp. cooked)–loud (esp. raw)

Techniques: grill, raw, roast, sauté

almonds

anchovies

bacon

barbecue

basil

bay leaf

beans

beef

beets

bread

broccoli

cabbage

Cajun cuisine

caraway seeds

cayenne

cheese, Parmesan

chicken

chile peppers

Chinese cuisine

chives

cilantro

coriander

cream, half-and-half

Creole cuisine

cumin

curries

eggplant

eggs

fennel

fennel seeds

fish

French cuisine

ginger

Indian cuisine

Italian cuisine

Korean cuisine

lamb

leeks

LEMON: juice, zest

lemongrass

lentils

lime, juice

mayonnaise

meats

Mediterranean cuisine

Mexican cuisine

Middle Eastern cuisine

Moroccan cuisine

mushrooms

mustard

oil: canola, peanut

OLIVE OIL

onions

oregano

paprika, esp. sweet

parsley, flat-leaf

pasta and pasta sauces

pepper: black, white

pesto (key ingredient)

pork

potatoes

rice

rosemary

saffron
sage
salads (e.g., Caesar)
salt
sauces
shallots
shellfish
shrimp
soups
soy sauce
spinach
steak
stocks: chicken, vegetable
sugar
tarragon
Thai cuisine
thyme
TOMATOES AND TOMATO SAUCE
vegetables
Vietnamese cuisine
VINEGAR, esp. balsamic, red wine
wine, white
zucchini

When **garlic** needs to be there, it needs to be there. That includes a lot of dishes, such as lamb. Garlic is also called for with all kinds of vegetables, sauces, pastas, and salads.

—**DAVID WALTUCK**, CHANTERELLE (NEW YORK CITY)

I use **garlic** primarily in two ways: infused into olive oil, or served crispy as a garnish. I'll use the garlic oil for cooking—and even if a dish will have garlic added later, I will start with this oil. For crispy brown garlic, you start by slicing it thinly like a chip. The garlic is then put into cold olive oil and cooked until it is just brown. Then, you add parsley, red pepper flakes, and an acid like lemon juice or vinegar to make a vinaigrette. You can even add some stock like

a fumet, which is wonderful, too—served hot, it is great with almost any kind of fish, from something light all the way to oily blue fish.

—ALEXANDRA RAIJ, TÍA POL (NEW YORK CITY)

GEORGIAN CUISINE (RUSSIAN)

fish

garlic

meats

pepper, red ground pickles

pomegranates

vinegar

walnuts

Flavor Affinities

coriander + dill + fenugreek (blue) + garlic + red peppers

garlic + walnuts

GERMAN CUISINE

allspice
anise
bay leaf
beer
bread, rye
caraway seeds
chives
cinnamon
dill: seeds, weed
fish
ginger
horseradish
juniper berries
mace
meats, esp. with fruits
nutmeg
paprika, sweet
parsley
pepper, white
poppy seeds
pork
potatoes
sauerbraten
sauerkraut
sausages
sour cream
sugar
veal
vinegar

Flavor Affinities

caraway + paprika + sour cream
caraway + sauerkraut

cream + horseradish + fish or meat

cream + paprika + poppy seeds

dill + cucumbers

ginger + sauerbraten

juniper berries + game

mace + chicken

nutmeg + potatoes

sugar + vinegar

GIN

Weight: light–medium

Volume: quiet–loud

apple brandy
apricot brandy
basil
blackberries
celery
Champagne
cilantro
Cointreau
cola
cranberry juice
cucumber
Curaçao
Earl Grey tea
ginger

HERBS

honey
lemon juice
lime juice
mint

orange juice

oysters
pomegranate
pomegranate molasses
rose geranium
rosemary
sage
sugar

TONIC

Cucumber and mint is a fashionable combination in cocktails, [especially] those with Hendrick's **gin**, which has a cucumber flavor. Cucumber is a flavor that's distinct yet delicate, and very refreshing. It goes beautifully with a range of foods, from Asian cuisine to smoked salmon.

—**JERRI BANKS**, COCKTAIL CONSULTANT (NEW YORK CITY)

With **gin**, or even Martini & Rossi Bianco, I love the combination of blackberries and sage. Blackberries have an indescribable flavor to begin with, and the sage gives them a brooding quality.

—**JERRI BANKS**, COCKTAIL CONSULTANT (NEW YORK CITY)

Flavor Affinities

gin + apple brandy + lemon juice + orange juice

gin + basil + lemon

gin + blackberries + sage

gin + cilantro + lime

gin + Cointreau + lime + rosemary

gin + cucumber + mint

gin + Earl Grey tea + lemon + sugar

gin + lime + mint

gin + lime + mint + pomegranate

gin + lime + orange

Gin Flavors

Beefeater: pear

Hendrick's: cucumber, rose petals

Old Raj: saffron

Zuidam Dry: orange peel

Dishes

Ginger-Honey Gelato

—Gina DePalma, pastry chef, Babbo (New York City)

Ginger-Lemon Drink: Ginger, Lemon, Sugar, Salt, and Pepper

—Vikram Vij and Meeru Dhalwala, Vij's (Vancouver)

GINGER

Season: year-round

Taste: sour, hot

Weight: light–medium

Volume: loud

Techniques: bake, stir-fry

allspice

almonds

anise

apples

apricots

Arabic cuisine

ASIAN CUISINES

bananas

basil

bay leaf

beef

bell peppers, red

beverages

butter

caramel

cardamom

carrots

cashews

celery

cheese, ricotta

chicken

chile peppers, esp. jalapeño

CHINESE CUISINE

chocolate, esp. dark, white

cilantro

cinnamon

citrus

cloves
coconut
coriander
crab
cranberries

CREAM AND ICE CREAM

cumin

CURRIES

custards
duck
eggplant
European cuisines
fennel
figs

FISH

fish sauce
five-spice powder (key ingredient)

garlic

grapefruit
guava
hazelnuts

HONEY

Indian cuisine, esp. curries
Indonesian cuisine

JAPANESE CUISINE

kaffir lime leaves
Korean cuisine
kumquats
lamb
lavender
leeks

lemon

lemongrass

lemon herbs (e.g., balm, thyme, verbena)

LIME, JUICE

lobster
lychees

mangoes
maple syrup
marinades
mascarpone
meats
melon
Middle Eastern cuisine
mint
molasses
Moroccan cuisine
mushrooms
mussels
noodles and noodle dishes
North African cuisine
nutmeg
oats
oil: canola, grapeseed
olive oil
onions, esp. red
orange
papaya
passion fruit
peaches
peanuts
pears
pepper, white
persimmons
pineapple
plums
pork
prunes
pumpkin
quince
raisins
raspberries
rhubarb
rice

rum, esp. dark

saffron

salad dressings

salads, esp. Asian

salt, kosher

sauces

SCALLIONS

scallops

sesame oil

shallots

shellfish

shrimp

soups

SOY SAUCE

star anise

steak

stews

stocks: beef, chicken

strawberries

SUGAR: white, brown

sushi and sashimi

sweet potatoes

Tabasco sauce

tamarind

tarragon

tea

Thai cuisine

tomatoes

turmeric

vanilla

vegetables

verbena

Vietnamese cuisine

VINEGAR: champagne, cider, rice wine

walnuts

wasabi (e.g., with seafood)

wine, sweet

yogurt
yuzu

Flavor Affinities

ginger + carrot + celery + garlic
ginger + chile peppers + garlic
ginger + chocolate + cream + rum
ginger + cider vinegar + sugar
ginger + cilantro + garlic + scallions
ginger + cream + honey
ginger + lemon + mint
ginger + lemon + pepper + salt + sugar

Ginger and honey is one of my favorite flavor combinations.

—GINA DEPALMA, BABBO (NEW YORK CITY)

I'll use **ginger** more for its heat than its sweetness. For example, I'll juice it to add to a carrot or squash puree, which gives it heat and backbone.

—BRADFORD THOMPSON, MARY ELAINE'S AT THE PHOENICIAN (SCOTTSDALE, ARIZONA)

GINGER, GROUND

Taste: pungent

Function: heating

Weight: light–medium

Volume: moderate–loud

Asian cuisine

baked goods (e.g., breads, cakes, cookies)

bananas

beverages

cardamom

carrots

chicken

chocolate

chutneys

cinnamon

cloves

couscous

cream and ice cream

desserts

fruits

gingerbread (key ingredient)

ham

honey

lemon

meats, esp. braised or stewed

melon

Moroccan cuisine

nutmeg

nuts

onions

oranges

paprika

peaches

pears

pepper

pineapple

pork

pumpkin

rice

saffron

squash, winter

stewed dishes

sweet potatoes

tea

tomatoes

Dishes

Gingersnap-Lemon Ice Cream Sandwiches

—Emily Luchetti, pastry chef, Farallon (San Francisco)

Ginger is great on its own, but also works great with other flavors. It's one of those “wake up” flavors that you can hide beneath all sorts of other flavors. I think it works especially well with citrus. It works with yuzu, passion fruit, coconut, banana, and other tropical flavors.

—MICHAEL LAISKONIS, LE BERNARDIN (NEW YORK CITY)

My mom always had **candied ginger** in the spice cupboard when I was growing up. Today at the restaurant, we take candied ginger and combine it with whatever fruit is in season—from nectarines, to cherries, to quince—and then add Vin Santo to make a sauce for our foie gras. Vin Santo brings nuttiness and candied ginger brings spice that both cut through the fat of the foie gras. I think nectarines and candied ginger are a perfect flavor combination.

—HOLLY SMITH, CAFÉ JUANITA (SEATTLE)

GOAT CHEESE
(See Cheese, Goat)

GRAPEFRUIT

Season: year-round

Taste: sour

Weight: light

Volume: loud

Techniques: bake, broil, raw

arugula

asparagus

avocado

bananas

butter, unsalted

Campari

caramel

cashews

ceviche

Champagne

chicken

coconut

crab

crème fraîche

fish, esp. grilled

fromage blanc

gin

ginger, fresh

Grand Marnier

grenadine syrup

hazelnuts

honey

lemon

lime

macadamia nuts

melons

meringue

mint, fresh

miso

olive oil

onions, esp. spring

orange

papaya

pecans

pineapple

pomegranate

poppy seeds

port

raspberries

rum

salads, esp. fruit

salmon

seafood

seaweed

shrimp

sorbet

star anise

strawberries

SUGAR: brown, white

tarragon

tequila

tomatoes

vanilla

vinaigrette

vinegar, champagne

vodka

walnuts

watercress

wine, sparkling, white

yogurt

Dishes

Yuzu Cream, Caramelized Rice, Grapefruit, Green Tea Ice Cream, Crisp Meringue, Malted Rum Milk Chocolate Ice Cream

—Michael Laiskonis, pastry chef, Le Bernardin (New York City)

We serve a dish of **grapefruit**, crab salad, and mint. Grapefruit is sweet and a little bitter, which makes it fun to play with. I like mint in the dish because it refreshes and wakes your palate up. When you get a little taste of mint it brings up the other flavors of the dish.

—GABRIEL KREUTHER, THE MODERN (NEW YORK CITY)

I love tarragon with **grapefruit**. It is a classic.

—MICHAEL LAISKONIS, LE BERNARDIN (NEW YORK CITY)

I have served a **grapefruit** and seaweed crab salad with miso dressing. I also like grapefruit with asparagus.

—BRAD FARMERIE, PUBLIC (NEW YORK CITY)

I never mess with the flavor of **Concord grapes**; I always just make them into a sorbet. I was upstate in my cabin when the first Concord grapes came into season. I wanted sorbet so badly that I cut one of my T-shirts in half to use as a strainer, and then used my broom handle with the shirt to squeeze every last bit of juice from the grapes. The sorbet was awesome!

—JOHNNY IUZZINI, JEAN GEORGES (NEW YORK CITY)

Flavor Affinities

grapefruit + avocado + crème fraîche

grapefruit + caramel + meringue

grapefruit + crab + miso + seaweed

grapefruit + *fromage blanc* + pomegranate

grapefruit + mint + sugar

grapefruit + star anise + yogurt

GRAPES

Season: summer–autumn

Taste: sweet

Weight: light–medium

Volume: quiet–moderate

almonds

apples

arugula

brandy

cayenne

CHEESE, esp. blue, cow's milk, goat's milk

chicken

chocolate, white

cognac

cream

cumin

curry

curry leaf

duck

endive

fennel seeds

fish

game, esp. roasted

garlic

hazelnuts

honey

lemon

mint

mustard seeds

olive oil

paprika

pears

pecans

pistachios
pork, esp. roasted
poultry, esp. roasted
raspberries
rice
rosemary
rum
salads, esp. chicken, fruit, tuna, Waldorf
salt
sour cream
strawberries
sugar
vinegar, sherry
walnuts
wine: red, white
yogurt

GREEK CUISINE

(See also Mediterranean Cuisines)

allspice

anise

basil

bay leaf

beef

bell peppers

CHEESE: FETA, goat, sheep

chicken

cinnamon

cloves

custard

dill

eggplant

eggs

fennel

figs

fish, esp. grilled

GARLIC

grape leaves

honey

kebabs

LAMB

LEMON

meats, esp. grilled, roasted

mint

nutmeg

nuts

octopus

OLIVE OIL

olives

onions

oregano

parsley

phyllo dough

pine nuts

pita bread

pork

raisins

rice

salads, esp. with mint

shellfish

spinach

thyme

tomatoes

yogurt

zucchini

Dishes

Mediterranean “Greek Salad” of Mt. Vikos Feta, Kalamata Olives, Plum Tomatoes, Cucumbers, Torn Mint, and Oregano with Warm Feta Cheese “Turnover”

—Carrie Nahabedian, Naha (Chicago)

Flavor Affinities

cucumber + dill + garlic + yogurt

dill + lemon

dill + lemon + olive oil

dill + yogurt

eggplant + custard + garlic + meat

eggplant + garlic + olive oil

eggs + lemon

lamb + garlic + lemon + oregano

lemon + olive oil

lemon + olive oil + oregano

lemon + oregano

phyllo dough + honey + nuts

rice + grape leaves

rice + nuts

spinach + feta cheese

tomatoes + cinnamon

yogurt + cinnamon

GREEN BEANS
(See Beans, Green)

GREENS—IN GENERAL

(See also specific greens)

Season: year-round

Taste: bitter

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: moderate–loud

Techniques: blanch, raw, sauté, steam

allspice

arugula

bacon

basil

butter

caraway seeds

celery or celery seeds

CHEESE, esp. grated (e.g., Asiago, Jack, Parmesan)

chicory

chili sauce

coriander

corn

curry

dill

eggs, esp. hard-boiled

fennel

GARLIC

ginger

ham

horseradish

leeks

legumes

lemon, juice

mushrooms

mustard, Dijon

nutmeg

nuts, toasted

oil: mustard, nut, peanut, sesame

OLIVE OIL

onions, green

oregano

paprika

parsley

pasta

peaches

pears

pomegranates

potatoes, esp. new and/or red

red pepper flakes

rice

sage

salads

salt, kosher

savory

sesame seeds

shellfish: oysters, esp. fried, shrimp

sweet potatoes

Tabasco sauce

tarragon

thyme

tomatoes

VINEGAR: balsamic, red wine

Dishes

A Simple Salad of Beautiful Greens, Forelli Pears, Pomegranate, and Saba Balsamic
—Carrie Nahabedian, Naha (Chicago)

GREENS, COLLARD

Season: winter–spring

Taste: bitter

Botanical relatives: broccoli, Brussels sprouts, cabbage, cauliflower, kale, kohlrabi

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: moderate–loud

Techniques: boil, braise, steam, stir-fry

bacon

black-eyed peas

brown butter

cheese, Parmesan

garlic

ham hocks

mustard seeds

oil: peanut, vegetable

onions, yellow

oregano

pepper, black

red pepper flakes

salt

salt pork

soul food cuisine

Southern cuisine (American)

tomatoes

vinegar, cider

GREENS, DANDELION

Season: late spring–early autumn

Taste: bitter

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate

Techniques: raw, sauté, steam

anchovies

bacon

garlic

mustard, Dijon

oil, peanut

onions

pepper, ground

salads

salt

vinegar

GREENS, KALE

(See Kale)

GREENS, MUSTARD

Season: winter–spring

Taste: bitter

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: moderate–loud

Techniques: boil, braise, grill, stew, wilt

It's hard to even think about **bitter greens** without thinking about toasted nuts. You can get the flavor from the nuts themselves, or from toasted nut oils, which are balanced by the bright fruitiness of cider vinegar.

—MICHAEL ANTHONY, GRAMERCY TAVERN (NEW YORK CITY)

Asian cuisine

bacon

black-eyed peas

Chinese cuisine

ham hocks

oil, sesame

olive oil

onions

prosciutto

salads

Southern cuisine (American)

soy sauce

Flavor Affinities

mustard greens + bacon + onions

mustard greens + garlic + olive oil + prosciutto

mustard greens + sesame oil + soy sauce

GREENS, SALAD

(See also Lettuce, Sorrel, Watercress, etc.)

Season: late spring

bacon

cheese

croutons

fruit: apples, pears

garlic

olive oil

pepper, black

salt

vinegar: red wine, sherry

GREENS, TURNIP

Season: fall–winter

Techniques: boil, braise

bacon

black-eyed peas

eggs

ham hocks

onions

Dishes

Turnip Green and Onion Soup with Poached Egg

—Judy Rodgers, Zuni Café (San Francisco)

A salad is a tricky thing to season. If you put the salt on too early, it will wilt the **greens**. You have to be careful not to leach it of its life!

—TRACI DES JARDINS, JARDINIÈRE (SAN FRANCISCO)

Dishes

Wild Dandelion Greens with Anchovy Vinaigrette

—David Pasternak, Esca (New York City)

GRILLED DISHES

artichokes
asparagus
bell peppers
chicken
corn, esp. on the cob
eggplant
endive
fennel
fish, whole
garlic
hamburgers
hot dogs
lamb: butterflied, chops
lobster
mushrooms
onions
pineapple
pork: chops, loin
salmon
sausages
shrimp, esp. skewered
squash, summer
steaks
swordfish
tomatoes
tuna
turkey: breasts
veal: chops, steaks
zucchini

GRITS

Techniques: simmer

cheese: cheddar, Parmesan

corn

cream

garlic

mascarpone

nutmeg

pepper, black

salt

sausage, andouille

shrimp (to accompany)

Southern cuisine (American)

GROUPER

Season: spring

Weight: medium

Volume: quiet

Techniques: bake, braise, broil, deep-fry, grill, poach, roast, sauté, steam, stir-fry

almonds

anchovies

artichokes

bacon

bay leaf

bell peppers, red

bok choy

butter

capers

carrots

cayenne

celery

cheese, Asiago

chervil

chile peppers, Anaheim

chili sauce

cucumber

endive

garlic

ginger

lemon, juice

lime, juice

Mediterranean cuisine

mushrooms, porcini

oil: corn, sesame, vegetable

olive oil

olives, picholine

onions, white

oyster sauce

parsley, flat-leaf

pepper: black, white

port

rosemary

sage

salt, sea

sesame, seeds

shallots

soy sauce

stocks: chicken, fish, pork

tarragon

thyme

tomatoes

vermouth, dry

vinegar: balsamic, sherry

wine: red, white

zucchini

Dishes

Grilled American Red Grouper on Crab Hash, Pancetta–Red Onion Vinaigrette
—Sanford D’Amato, Sanford (Milwaukee)

GUAVAS

Season: summer–autumn

Taste: sweet

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate

Techniques: bake, juice, poach

BANANAS

cashews

cheese

chocolate, white

coconut

cream

cream cheese

curry powder

ginger

ham

honey

lemon

lime, juice

macadamia nuts

mascarpone

oil, vegetable

onions, yellow

orange

passion fruit

pineapple

pork

poultry

raisins

rum

salads, fruit

sauces

strawberries

sugar: brown, white

vanilla

vinegar, white

HADDOCK

(See Cod)

HALIBUT

Season: spring–summer

Weight: medium

Volume: quiet

Techniques: bake, braise, broil, grill, pan roast, poach, roast, sauté, steam

aioli (sauce)

almonds

anchovies

apples: cider, fruit, juice

artichokes

arugula

asparagus

bacon

basil

beans: black, fava, haricots verts

bell peppers: red, yellow

bok choy

butter, unsalted

capers

cardamom

carrots and carrot juice

cayenne

celery

celery root

chamomile

chard

chervil

chicory

chile peppers: dried red, fresh green

chives

cilantro

clams

coriander

cornichons
couscous
cream
cucumber
cumin
curry powder
dill
endive
fennel
fennel seeds
fenugreek seeds
frisée
garam masala
GARLIC
ginger, ground
grapefruit
hazelnuts
horseradish
kohlrabi
leeks
LEMON: juice, preserved
lemon balm
lime, juice
lovage
mint
mushrooms, esp. oyster, porcini, portobello, shiitake
mussels
mustard: Dijon, dry, grainy
OIL: canola, grapeseed
olive oil
olives: black, niçoise
onions, esp. pearl, red, spring
paprika
PARSLEY, flat-leaf
parsnips
pepper: black, white
potatoes, esp. new (e.g., fried, mashed)

pumpkin seeds
red pepper flakes
rhubarb

rosemary

saffron

salt: kosher, sea

savory

scallions

sesame seeds: black, white

SHALLOTS

sorrel

spearmint

spinach

stocks: chicken, fish

sugar (pinch)

tamarind

tapanade

tarragon

thyme

tomatoes and tomato sauce

turmeric

vinaigrette

vinegar: balsamic, sherry

walnuts

watercress

WINE: dry red, dry white (e.g., Chardonnay, Sauvignon Blanc), vermouth

yogurt

zucchini

Halibut from the East Coast is the most delicate and silky fish. It is different than Alaskan halibut, which is drier, meatier, and more robust. East Coast halibut is so delicate that anything can kill it. That is why we steam and poach so much here: Even searing it too strongly in the pan will hurt a piece of halibut.

We'll poach halibut, then serve it with a blood orange vinaigrette made with extra-virgin olive oil, which gives it a round and full flavor. The fish is then

served atop a carpaccio of golden beets that have been cooked in sherry vinegar. The beets have a sweet-and-sour flavor to them. They are also very crunchy, which I like with the creamy texture of the halibut. The vinaigrette brings the right degree of acidity to the dish to make it exciting.

—**ERIC RIPERT**, LE BERNARDIN (NEW YORK CITY)

Halibut is a gentle-tasting fish, which leads to gentle herbs like cilantro, chives, or chervil.

—**JERRY TRAUNFELD**, THE HERBFARM (WOODINVILLE, WASHINGTON)

Dishes

Wellfleet Line-Caught Halibut, Sweet Corn, Shiitake Mushrooms, and Lemon Thyme Sauce

—David Bouley, Upstairs (New York City)

Almond-Crusted Halibut with Parsnip Puree, Fava Beans, Haricots Verts, and Wild Mushrooms

—David Bouley, Danube (New York City)

Halibut: Braised Tomato, Olives, Escarole, and Spring Salad

—Daniel Boulud/Bertrand Chemel, Café Boulud (New York City)

Olive Oil–Poached Halibut with Star Route Farm’s Fava Beans, Fennel Salad, and Niçoise Olives

—Traci Des Jardins, Jardinière (San Francisco)

Alaskan Halibut, Potato, and Black Pepper Crust

—Hubert Keller, Fleur de Lys (San Francisco)

Alaskan Halibut on a Bed of Creamy Leeks with Asparagus Puree, Fines Herbe, Spring Ramps, Favas, and English Peas

—Bob Kinkead, Kinkead’s (Washington, DC)

Chermoula Halibut with Red Quinoa, Edamame, and Shell Bean Salad with Preserved Lemon Vinaigrette

—Monica Pope, T’afia (Houston)

Halibut with Morel Mushrooms, English Peas, and Fingerling Potatoes

—Alfred Portale, Gotham Bar and Grill (New York City)

Halibut, Kohlrabi, Celery, Verbena-Lime Emulsion

—Michel Richard, Citronelle (Washington, DC)

Halibut Poached with Sweet-and-Sour Golden and Red Beets, Citrus and Extra-Virgin Olive Oil Emulsion

—Eric Ripert, Le Bernardin (New York City)

Alaskan Halibut Braised in the Brick Oven with Marble Potatoes, Baby Carrots, English Peas, Butter, and Cilantro

—Judy Rodgers, Zuni Café (San Francisco)

Line-Caught Seal Rock Halibut, Leek Emulsion, Reduced Chardonnay, Bacon Vinaigrette

—Rick Tramonto, Tru (Chicago)

Flavor Affinities

halibut + anchovies + black olives

halibut + anchovies + garlic + lemon + sorrel

halibut + apples + celery root + parsnips

halibut + beets + blood orange + olive oil + sherry vinegar

halibut + bok choy + sesame seeds

halibut + chicory + grapefruit

halibut + coriander + fennel + lemon

halibut + garlic + lemon + sorrel

halibut + scallions + white wine

HAM

Taste: salty

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate–loud (depending on smokiness)

Techniques: bake, sauté

allspice

apples and applesauce

arugula

bacon

bay leaf

breakfast / brunch

butter, unsalted

buttermilk

cayenne

CHEESE: cheddar, Emmental, Fontina, Gruyère, Jack, manchego, mozzarella, Parmesan, Swiss

chestnuts

chives

cinnamon

cloves

corn

cornmeal

French cuisine

eggs

garlic

greens

honey

Italian cuisine, esp. with prosciutto di Parma

macaroni

maple syrup

mushrooms

mustard, Dijon

nutmeg

olive oil
onions, red
orange, juice
parsley
pears
peas
pepper, black
pine nuts
potatoes
sage
sauce, Mornay
scallions
Southern cuisine (American)
soy sauce
spinach
stock, chicken
sugar: brown, white
sweet potatoes
tarragon
thyme
vinegar, balsamic
wine: dry sherry, Madeira **red, white**

Flavor Affinities

ham + cheese + mustard
ham + honey + soy sauce
ham + Jack cheese + greens + mushrooms
ham + mozzarella cheese + red onion

Dishes

Raviolis of Virginia Country Ham and Fontina Cheese

—Patrick O’Connell, The Inn at Little Washington (Washington, Virginia)

Serrano Ham with Roasted Onions, Manchego Cheese, and Watercress

—Charlie Trotter, Trotter’s to Go (Chicago)

Virtually all vegetables—from asparagus to green beans—pair well with **ham** because of its natural saltiness.

—**JOSÉ ANDRÉS**, CAFÉ ATLÁNTICO (WASHINGTON, DC)

One of the happiest trios in the flavor world is **Ibérico ham**, manchego cheese, and manzanilla sherry.

—**ADRIAN MURCIA**, CHANTERELLE (NEW YORK CITY)

If you are a first timer, the only thing you should combine with **Ibérico ham** is the warmth of your tongue. Just let it rest on your tongue and let your 37 degrees Celsius do the rest! You can use just the fat of Ibérico ham melted in a pan and make scrambled eggs or a tortilla, and it will add amazing flavor and aroma.

—**JOSÉ ANDRÉS**, CAFÉ ATLÁNTICO (WASHINGTON, DC)

HAM, IBÉRICO

cheese, pressed sheep's milk (e.g., manchego)

HAM, SERRANO

asparagus

beans, green

cheese, manchego

olive oil

peppers, piquillo

Spanish cuisine

tomatoes

HAZELNUT OIL
(See Oil, Hazelnut)

HAZELNUTS

Taste: sweet, salty

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate–loud

almonds

apples

apricots

asparagus

bananas

beets

berries

butter, unsalted

buttermilk

caramel

carrots

cheese: feta, goat, Gruyère, ricotta, Taleggio

cherries

chestnuts

CHOCOLATE, esp. dark or white

cinnamon

cocoa powder

coffee / espresso

cognac

cranberries

cream and ice cream

cream cheese

custard

dates

figs

garlic

ginger

grapefruit

grapes

hazelnut oil

honey

Kirsch

kiwi

lemon

liqueur: **almond** (e.g., amaretto), hazelnut (e.g., Frangelico), orange

mango

maple syrup

mascarpone

mint

nectarines

nutmeg

oats

orange: juice, zest

pastries

peaches

pears

pecans

persimmons

plums

prunes

pumpkin

quail

raisins

raspberries

rum

sauces

soups

strawberries

sugar: brown, confectioner's, granulated

sweet potatoes

tea

VANILLA

vegetables

walnuts

wine: red, sweet, white

HERBES DE PROVENCE

French cuisine, southern

meats

stews, esp. vegetable

vegetables

Flavor Affinities

basil + fennel seeds + lavender + marjoram + rosemary + sage + summer savory
+ thyme

Dishes

Chocolate-Hazelnut Cake with Orange Sauce and Hazelnut Gelato

—Gina DePalma, Babbo (New York City)

Hazelnut and Chocolate Soufflé

—Odette Fada, San Domenico (New York City)

Gianduja Napoleon with Chocolate-Hazelnut Ganache, Frozen Caramel Mousse, Crispy Hazelnut Nougatine

—Gale Gand, pastry chef, Tru (Chicago)

Hazelnuts have a complicated flavor, though not as complicated as walnuts.

—MARCEL DESAULNIERS, THE TRELIS (WILLIAMSBURG, VIRGINIA)

Hazelnuts are from the north and are used in Piedmontese cooking. Hazelnuts are very rich and round and buttery, so I will use them to achieve a rich, fatty quality in my dessert. Hazelnuts with chocolate are a natural. Hazelnut with grapes are great; it's like peanut butter and jelly!

—GINA DEPALMA, BABBO (NEW YORK CITY)

I am more of an **herb** guy than a spice guy. It comes back to a certain conservatism I have regarding food. The French are not big on spices; they use more herbs. I know the spices used in European cooking and use them in moderation. I am not going to serve a dish that is wildly nutmegged!

—DAVID WALTUCK, CHANTERELLE (NEW YORK CITY)



HERBS

(See specific herbs)

Herbs 101

with Jerry Traunfeld of The Herbfarm, Woodinville, Washington

Working with herbs is very different from working with spices. With herbs, you can really only work with a few at a time. With spices, you can throw so many more together. An Indian dish may have more than a dozen spices in it. Here are some guidelines:

- *Know your herb.* Herbs range in intensity, so you need to know the profile of the herb you are choosing at the start. You need to be careful; for example, if you add rosemary to chervil it will overpower the chervil.
- *You want to pair delicate with delicate or strong with strong.* Chervil is possibly the most delicate herb. Lemon basil and lemon thyme would be in the middle. Lemon verbena or tarragon I would consider loud. Then you have bay leaf which is light, until you add twenty together and it becomes strong.
- *Not all herbs are created equal, and they can vary within their categories or season.* Oregano can be mild, or hot and spicy. With mint, apple mint is mild while peppermint is strong. The season also has an effect on rosemary: in the winter, rosemary is mild and in the summer, it is strong.
- *Herbs have regional affinities.* Mediterranean herbs marry well together. Rosemary and marjoram or thyme and savory are naturals together. Among Asian herbs, lemongrass goes with mint and cilantro or mint and chives. In France, you have lots of combinations: chervil, tarragon, chives, and parsley. The one exception to France's herbs is tarragon, which is probably best on its own.
- *Herbs also have seasonal affinities.* Summer vegetables work with summer herbs, as do winter vegetables with winter herbs. In summer, it is basil or marjoram with tomatoes. Basil with zucchini is one of my favorite combinations. In winter, sage and rosemary work with potatoes and root vegetables. Also in winter, one of my favorite combinations is butternut squash with bay leaf and nutmeg. Pumpkin and bay leaf together make the pumpkin taste even more pumpkin-like.
- *How to use the chosen herb.* Soft-leaved herbs—such as basil, chervil, chives, cilantro, dill, lovage, and sorrel—shouldn't be cooked because they will lose their flavor. Tough-leaved herbs—such as bay leaf, savory, and rosemary—can go into dishes and stand up to heat and cooking.
- *Choose an herb that is the same intensity as your protein.* Halibut is a gentle-tasting fish, which leads to gentle herbs like cilantro, chives, or chervil. Smelt is a local fish that is oily, so here we look to stronger herbs like oregano, savory, or rosemary.
- *Herbs aren't exclusive to savory dishes.* Anise hyssop works with most stone fruits like peaches. Cinnamon basil works with blue huckleberries. Cinnamon with blueberries really intensifies the flavor of the blueberry. Lavender works with plums or peaches. Lemony herbs like basil or anise hyssop work with watermelon. Rosemary works with apples or pears. Sage works with tart cherries. Tarragon works with muskmelon.

We grow forty different tomatoes and eight different basil. Our farmer planted

the tomatoes surrounded by the basil, and I thought he did it because they taste good together. It turns out that doing so attracts beneficial insects to each. Our farmer believes that tomato and basil work so well on the plate because they work so well in the field. He also explained that if you plant certain basil next to tomatoes, you can taste it in the tomato.

All our cooks take care of their own section of the **herb** garden. The garde-manger cooks [who prepare appetizers] look after the chives and chervil. The fish cooks care for the lemon herbs like lemon thyme and lemongrass, and the meat cooks for the rosemary, sage, and thyme. Our pastry cooks tend the edible flowers that can be candied, and mint and lemon verbena, which they use in sorbets.

—**DAN BARBER**, BLUE HILL AT STONE BARN (POCANTICO HILLS, NEW YORK)

I am a big fan of roasting and resting meat on **herbs**. If you roast a rib eye, prime rib, or filet mignon, most people would put it on a sheet tray with a roasting rack. One day, I didn't have a roasting rack but I had a lot of thyme and savory and rosemary, so I threw the meat on top and roasted it. The technique did the trick by keeping the meat from the juices and it also enhanced the flavor that much more. Since then, we have stopped using roasting racks for our meats and switched to herbs. During the roasting process, I like to turn the meat so that the flavor of the herbs penetrates even more. Since you are roasting in a closed oven, the air circulates the herb flavor.

For a lamb shoulder, if you can't get hay, I would recommend using savory, thyme, sage, and rosemary. This technique is great for a whole chicken: slice some truffles to put under the chicken skin, brush it with butter, and put it on a bed of savory and thyme. It will be pretty incredible.

—**VITALY PALEY**, PALEY'S PLACE (PORTLAND, OREGON)

I might grab **honey** when I am working with nutty flavors or to macerate some fruit. You can also scorch honey to create a whole new flavor; one of my favorite dishes is a burnt honey caramelized pistachio ice cream.

—**MICHAEL LAISKONIS**, LE BERNARDIN (NEW YORK CITY)

I use **honey** as a flavor, not as a sweetener like sugar. In my honey *panna cotta*, I add some sugar to make it sweet enough. If I used only honey as a

sweetener, the flavor of honey would be too strong and the *panna cotta* would taste a little flat.

—**EMILY LUCHETTI**, FARALLON (SAN FRANCISCO)

I like the combination of fresh pineapple topped with warm **honey**. I will glaze my raspberry tart with flower honey, and my apple tart with chestnut honey. Chestnut honey gives a rustic flavor that goes well with the apple.

—**MICHEL RICHARD**, CITRONELLE (WASHINGTON, DC)

Dishes

Lavender Honey-Roasted Pig with Spiced Banana Puree

—Sandy D’Amato, Sanford (Milwaukee)

Honey Semifreddo with Tropical Consommé, Fresh Coconut, and Bloomed Basil Seeds

—Celina Tio, American Restaurant (Kansas City)

HONEY

Taste: sweet, astringent

Function: heating

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: moderate–loud

almonds

apples

apricots

baked goods (e.g., biscuits, breads)

bananas

brandy

butter

buttermilk

carrots

cheese: goat, ricotta, soft

chestnuts

chicken

Chinese cuisine

chocolate: dark, white

cinnamon

coconut

coffee

cognac

CREAM AND ICE CREAM

currants, red

dates

desserts

duck

figs, esp. dried

fruit

ginger

grapefruit

grapes

Greek cuisine

guava

ham

hazelnuts

kiwi fruit

kumquats

lamb

lavender

LEMON: juice, zest

LIME, juice

liqueur, orange (e.g., Grand Marnier)

lychees

mascarpone

melon

Middle Eastern cuisines mint

Moroccan cuisine

mustard

nutmeg

NUTS

oats

ORANGE: juice, zest

papaya

pastries

peaches

peanuts

pears

pecans

persimmons

pineapple

pine nuts

pistachios

plums

pomegranate

pork

prunes

pumpkin

quince

raisins

raspberries

red pepper flakes

rhubarb

rum

sage

sauces

Southern cuisine

soy sauce

SUGAR: brown, white

sweet potatoes

tea

tequila

thyme

Turkish cuisine

VANILLA

walnuts

whiskey

wine: red, white

Flavor Affinities

honey + almonds + chicken + pomegranate

honey + bananas + lavender + pork

honey + cream + pistachios

honey + fruit + yogurt

HONEY, BLUEBERRY

cheese, esp. cheddar

HONEY, CHESTNUT

Taste: sweet-bitter

cheese, esp. goat, ricotta, triple crème

HONEY, RASPBERRY

cheese, esp. cheddar

HONEYDEW

Season: midsummer

Taste: sweet

Weight: light–medium

Volume: moderate

basil

blackberries

cardamom

Champagne

chiles

coconut milk

coriander

cream

cumin

figs

ginger

grapefruit

honey

lemon, juice

lemon basil

lime

melon, cantaloupe

milk

mint

nectarines

peaches

red pepper flakes

pepper: black, white

prosciutto

ricotta cheese

salt (pinch)

scallions

strawberries

sugar
tarragon
wine, sweet
yogurt

Flavor Affinities

honeydew melon + figs + mint + prosciutto

Dishes

Honeydew-Mint Sorbet with Fresh Blackberries

—Gina DePalma, pastry chef, Babbo (New York City)

Honeydew Melon Salad with Oven-Roasted Tomatoes, Goat Cheese, and Pistachios

—Gabriel Kreuther, The Modern (New York City)

HORSERADISH

Season: spring–autumn

Taste: pungent, hot

Weight: light–medium **Volume:** very loud

Tips: Use horseradish raw or add at end of cooking process. Heat diminishes the pungency of horseradish.

apples, esp. Golden Delicious

apricots

Austrian cuisine

avocados

BEEF, ESP. CORNED OR ROAST

beets

celery

chicken

chives

cinnamon

cloves

corn

CREAM

cream cheese

crème fraîche

dill

Eastern European cuisine

eggs

fennel

fish, esp. oily, smoked

garlic

German cuisine

ham

ketchup

lemon, juice

lime, juice

lobster

mascarpone
mayonnaise
meats, esp. cold
mustard
olive oil
oxtails
oysters
parsley
pears
pepper, black
pork
potatoes
Russian cuisine
salads
salmon
salmon, smoked
salt: kosher, sea
sauces
sausage
shellfish
sour cream
steak
sugar
Tabasco sauce
tomatoes and tomato paste
trout
vinegar
walnuts
Worcestershire sauce
yogurt

Heating grated horseradish changes the **horseradish** completely. It makes it more mellow and takes away the bite while keeping its yummy flavor. Horseradish prepared this way works well with Nantucket Bay scallops that are naturally sweet and work with the sweetness of the horseradish. We will also use it in a lemony vinaigrette and dress a smoked trout with it.

First, grate horseradish on a microplane [a fine grater]. Coat a ten-inch skillet with some Ligurian olive oil, and heat the horseradish over medium heat. Watch it very closely, because the minute it starts to turn from its blond color, it is done. From there, transfer it into cold pans to cool it quickly. When it is totally cool and has its crunch, add some lemon zest and kosher salt.

—**HOLLY SMITH**, CAFÉ JUANITA (SEATTLE)

Flavor Affinities

horseradish + apples + pork + sour cream

horseradish + beef + beets

horseradish + beets + cream cheese

horseradish + garlic + olive oil

horseradish + salt + vinegar

horseradish + seafood + tomatoes

HOTNESS

(of indoor or outdoor temperature; see also Summer)

chilled dishes and beverages

fish

grilled dishes

herbs, esp. cooling

olive oil–based dishes

raw dishes

salads, esp. fruit, vegetable

salsas, fresh

seafood

soups, cold

vegetables, esp. green leafy

If it is **hot** outside, I make sure there are lots of salads on the menu.

—ANDREW CARMELLINI, A VOCE (NEW YORK CITY)

HUNGARIAN CUISINE

bacon

beef

bell peppers, green

caraway seeds

chile peppers

garlic

ham

lard

mushrooms

ONIONS

PAPRIKA

pork

pork fat

potatoes

sausage

SOUR CREAM

tomatoes

wheat

wine, esp. Tokaji Aszu

Flavor Affinities

onions + paprika

onions + paprika + pork fat

onions + paprika + sour cream

In Eastern European or **Hungarian cooking**, you will see a stewed or braised dish flavored with paprika that is cut with sour cream either in it or served on top so that it mixes together as you eat it. I serve rare roasted venison in venison stock with hot and sweet paprika that is essentially a goulash.

Alongside, I serve creamed sauerkraut that bleeds into the sauce and gives the same effect as a goulash. Even though the sauerkraut has an intense flavor, it is still mild because it has been cooked in cream. It is not a Hungarian dish but

rather a play on a Hungarian dish, and it works in the context of the subtler intensity of flavors I like.

—**DAVID WALTUCK**, CHANTERELLE (NEW YORK CITY)

HYSSOP

Taste: bitter

Weight: medium

Volume: strong

beans, green

beef

beets

cabbage

carrots

chicken

cranberries

eggs

fruits

lamb

meats

parsley

pork

rice

rosemary

salads: fruit, green

soups, esp. chicken

stews

thyme

tomatoes

turkey, esp. stuffed and roasted

vegetables

venison

INDIAN CUISINE

allspice

almonds, esp. in desserts

anise

bread, in the north

cardamom

cauliflower

chicken

chile peppers

cilantro, esp. in the south

cinnamon

cloves

coconut, esp. in the south and/or in desserts

coriander

cumin, esp. in the north

CURRIES

curry leaf

eggplant

fenugreek

garlic, esp. in the north

ghee (clarified butter)

ginger, esp. in the north

herbs

lamb

lentils

mint

mustard seeds, esp. in the south

nutmeg

oil: canola, grapeseed

paprika

peas

pepper: black, white

pistachios, esp. in desserts

poppy seeds

potatoes

rice, basmati, esp. in the south

saffron

sage

SPICES

spinach

tamarind, esp. in the south

TOMATOES

turmeric

vegetables, esp. in the south

wheat, esp. in the north

yogurt

Tomatoes are as important to making **Indian cuisine** as they are to making Italian cuisine. In fact, making an Indian curry is a lot like making an Italian tomato sauce.

—**MEERU DHALWALA**, VIJ'S (VANCOUVER)

If my mind is in **India**, tamarind will be sneaking its way into the dish. When thinking of India, my inspirations are the flavors of clove, cardamom, and coriander seed. They are aromatic spices that really cut the fat of the dish, so it is not big, fat, and flabby on the palate.

—**BRAD FARMERIE**, PUBLIC (NEW YORK CITY)

I worked in an **Indian** restaurant as a waiter for four years. I love cooking with Indian ingredients. Everything I learned at the CIA was thrown out the window when I learned Indian cooking, which is where I picked up many techniques and philosophies. I now roast my own spices and create spice blends. I love creating my own flavor combinations. I came to love a garam masala made with fennel, cinnamon, clove, cumin, and coriander. Each of these five spices has a distinctive flavor, but combined they create one single flavor that is amazing. I will use my garam masala mixture in soups and sauces. When people ask about the dish, they always ask, “What was that flavor?”

—**BOB IACOVONE**, CUVÉE (NEW ORLEANS)

AVOID

beef, for religious reasons, say some
pork, for religious reasons, say some

Flavor Affinities

cinnamon + cloves + mace + nutmeg
coriander + cumin + turmeric
coriander + cumin + yogurt
cumin + garlic + ginger
cumin + garlic + yogurt
garlic + ginger
garlic + ginger + onion
potatoes + chili powder + turmeric
yogurt + fruit

INDONESIAN CUISINE

chicken

chile peppers

coconut

coriander

fish

garlic

grilled dishes

lemongrass

molasses

noodles

peanuts

pepper

rice

shellfish

shrimp paste

soy sauce

spices, esp. clove, nutmeg, pepper

stir-fried dishes

sugar, brown

vegetables

Flavor Affinities

chile peppers + peanuts + soy sauce

garlic + peanuts + soy sauce

garlic + soy sauce + brown sugar

IRANIAN CUISINE

(aka Persian Cuisine)

apricots
basil
beans
chicken
cinnamon
dates
dill
duck
fish
garlic
herbs
kebabs
lamb
lime
meats
mint
nuts
onions
parsley
plums
pomegranates
prunes
raisins
rice
saffron
stews

Flavor Affinities

cardamom + cinnamon + cloves + cumin + ginger + rose
duck + pomegranates + walnuts

ITALIAN CUISINE—IN GENERAL

anchovies

artichokes

basil

beef

bell peppers

capers

cheese: mozzarella, Parmesan, pecorino, ricotta

chicken

eggplant

fennel

fish

garlic

grappa

greens

honey, esp. in desserts

lemon, esp. in desserts

Marsala

mascarpone, esp. in desserts

mushrooms

nuts

olive oil

olives

orange and orange zest, esp. in desserts

oregano

pancetta

parsley

pasta

pork

prosciutto

red pepper flakes

rosemary

rum, esp. in desserts

saffron

sage

sausage

shellfish

spinach

thyme

tomatoes and tomato sauces

veal

vinegar: balsamic, red wine

wine

zucchini

Flavor Affinities

anchovies + capers + lemon juice

anchovies + garlic + wine vinegar

basil + garlic + olive oil

basil + garlic + tomatoes

bell peppers + olive oil + tomatoes

capers + garlic + wine vinegar

garlic + olive oil + parsley

garlic + oregano + tomatoes

garlic + saffron + shellfish

red pepper flakes + fennel + sausage

ITALIAN CUISINE, NORTHERN

asparagus

basil

beans

butter

cheeses, creamy and rich

cream and cream-based sauces

cured meats

fish

goat

hazelnuts

lemon, juice

Marsala

nuts

pasta, esp. richer egg-based and/or ribbon-shaped, often combined with other
starches such as beans

pine nuts

polenta

potatoes

rice and risotto

truffles, white

vinegar, esp. wine

wine

ITALIAN CUISINE, SOUTHERN

bell peppers

chile peppers

cinnamon

eggplant

fennel

garlic

marjoram

nutmeg

olive oil, heavy

oregano

pasta, esp. tube-shaped and with tomato sauce

pizza

pork

raisins

red pepper flakes

sardines

sausage

tomatoes and tomato sauces



I only half joke that if you add rum or orange zest to a dessert, it will taste **Italian**. They are very common flavors in Italy.

—GINA DEPALMA, BABBO (NEW YORK CITY)

There are five ingredients that any **Italian** cook must use: 1) real Italian pasta; 2) extra-virgin olive oil; 3) real balsamic vinegar; 4) Italian prosciutto; and 5) Parmigiano-Reggiano cheese.

—MARIO BATALI, BABBO (NEW YORK CITY)

Holly Smith of Café Juanita in Seattle on Five Flavors that Will Take You to Northern Italy

White Truffles. The perfect vehicle for white truffles is hand-cut pasta that is egg rich. Eggs that taste like real eggs make a great pasta. Our pasta is egg rich and has 35 egg yolks to a kilo (2.2 pounds) of flour. You can get them in there, it is crazy! The pasta looks like a sunset. On the pasta, I would first put butter barely scented with sage, before shaving the truffles on top.

Nebbiolo. Beef cheeks braised in Nebbiolo [wine]. To keep it simple, we serve roasted turnips and the reduced sauce with pomegranate seeds and that's it. We braise our cheeks for seven and a half hours. Most braised dishes go four hours, but not beef cheeks—anything less, and they are [still tough].

Anchovies. I love a really acidic anchovy vinaigrette for a bread salad. Anchovies with roasted garlic are like butter at this restaurant; they go in lots of dishes. We put them in lamb, we put them in between potatoes with chicken stock for a gratin. We love them. I like anchovies with sage on each side deep fried for an appetizer. We cook anchovies in olive oil with a little butter until they get toasty, throw in onions to caramelize, and serve this with fish.

Hazelnuts. Chocolate and hazelnut is the perfect combination so we make *gianduja* and put it inside crepes and warm them and put chestnut honey on top. Most of the time hazelnuts end up in salad or ground for a final dusting for a pasta. Beet pasta that looks like candy wrappers is served on top of a warm plate that has just been smeared with Gorgonzola Piccante, then topped with ground hazelnuts just before it is served. Blue cheese and hazelnuts is it for me.

Goat Meat. I just had spit-roasted goat at Da Cesare. If I knew I was going to die, I would get myself there [to the Piedmont region of Italy]. Roasted goat basted with garlic, olive oil, marjoram, mint, or rosemary is it.

JAMAICAN CUISINE

(See also Caribbean Cuisines)

jerked dishes (e.g., chicken)

JAPANESE CUISINE

bonito: dried, flakes

broiled dishes

chile peppers

daikon

dashi (kelp-based stock)

fish, cooked and raw

ginger

kelp

mirin (sweet rice wine)

noodles

pickles

poached dishes

ponzu sauce

rice

sake

scallions

sesame: oil, seeds

shellfish

***SOY SAUCE**

steamed dishes

tea

vinegar, rice wine

wasabi

wine, rice

yuzu

Flavor Affinities

bonito flakes + kelp

garlic + ginger + soy sauce

ginger + scallions + soy sauce

sake + soy sauce + sugar

soy sauce + wasabi

Japanese cuisine is very simple. We don't mix too many ingredients together. One of the main ingredients we use in Japanese cooking is soy sauce, for both its saltiness and umami. Soy sauce is very complex: It takes months and months to make it. Same for the dried bonito used to make *dashi*, our Japanese broth. So Japanese chefs find that much of the hardest work has already been done for us!

—**KAZ OKOCHI**, KAZ SUSHI BISTRO (WASHINGTON, DC)



JICAMA

Season: winter–spring

Taste: sweet

Weight: light–medium

Volume: quiet

Techniques: cooked (e.g., stir-fry), raw

avocado

cabbage, green

carrots

chicken

***CHILE PEPPERS**

chili powder

cilantro

cloves

cucumbers

cumin

fish

ginger

grapefruit

ketchup

lemon

***LIME, juice**

Malaysian cuisine

mangoes

melon

Mexican cuisine

mustard, yellow

oil: canola, sesame

onions, red

orange

papaya

peanuts, crushed

pepper, black

pineapple
pumpkin seeds
radishes
salads (e.g., fruit)
salsa
salt, kosher
sesame oil
shrimp
soy sauce
spinach
sugar
vinegar, white

Flavor Affinities

jicama + avocado + grapefruit + pumpkin seeds
jicama + chili powder + lime juice

Dishes

Jicama Callejera: Crunchy Jicama with Oranges, Grapefruit, and Pineapple; Orange-Lime Vinaigrette and Fresh Limes to Squeeze On

—Rick Bayless, Frontera Grill (Chicago)

Ensalada de Jicama y Aguacate: Jicama, Grapefruit, and Avocado Salad with Pumpkin Seeds

—Traci Des Jardins, Mijita (San Francisco)

Seaweed and Jicama Salad with Ginger Dressing

—Kaz Okochi, Kaz Sushi Bistro (Washington, DC)

I love the gentle, mellow tanginess **kaffir lime leaf** adds to curries.

—MEERU DHALWALA, VIJ'S (VANCOUVER)

JUNIPER BERRIES

Season: summer–autumn

Character: refreshing

Taste: bitter

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate–loud

allspice

Alsatian cuisine

apples

bay leaf

beef

cabbage

caraway

celery

chicken

choucroute

duck

fennel

fish

GAME

game birds

garlic

German cuisine

gin

goose

ham

kidneys

lamb

liver

marinades

marjoram

Mediterranean cuisine

onions

oregano
parsley
pâtés
pepper
pork
rosemary
sage
salmon
sauces
sauerkraut
savory
Scandinavian cuisine
stuffings, esp. bread
thyme
veal
VENISON
wine, red

Flavor Affinities

juniper berries + game + garlic + rosemary

KAFFIR LIMES AND KAFFIR LIME LEAF

(See also Lemons, Limes, etc.)

Season: year-round

Taste: sour

Weight: light

Volume: moderate–loud

Techniques: stir-fry

basil, Thai

beef

cardamom

chicken

chile peppers

cilantro

coconut and coconut milk

coriander

cumin

curry pastes and curries

fish

ginger

Indian cuisine

Indonesian cuisine

lemongrass

lime, juice

marinades

mushrooms

noodles

pork

poultry

rice

salads

sesame

shellfish

soups, esp. Thai

star anise

sugar

tamarind

THAI CUISINE

turmeric

vegetables, esp. green

Flavor Affinities

kaffir lime + saffron + seafood

kaffir lime leaf + duck + ginger

kaffir lime leaf + rice + turmeric

KALE

Season: autumn–spring

Taste: bitter, sweet

Botanical relatives: broccoli, Brussels sprouts, cabbage, cauliflower, collard greens, kohlrabi

Weight: heavy

Volume: moderate

Techniques: blanch, boil, braise, sauté, steam, stir-fry

bay leaf

bell peppers, red

butter

cheese: cheddar, Parmesan

chicken, roasted

cream

GARLIC

ginger

lemon

meats, roasted

nutmeg

OIL: grapeseed, vegetable

olive oil

onions, esp. yellow

oregano

pancetta

pasta

pepper: black, white

pork

potatoes

red pepper flakes

salt, kosher

sausage, chorizo

shallots

sour cream

soy sauce
stock, chicken
sugar
sweet potatoes
thyme
tomatoes
vinegar, red wine

Flavor Affinities

kale + garlic + olive oil + red wine vinegar
kale + onions + salt + smoked sausage

I like **kale** blanched then sautéed with some onions, a pinch of salt, and some smoked sausage.

—**GABRIEL KREUTHER**, THE MODERN (NEW YORK CITY)

KIWI FRUIT

Season: late autumn–spring

Taste: sour

Weight: medium

Volume: quiet–moderate

Techniques: raw

bananas

berries

cherries

chocolate: dark, white

coconut

cream and ice cream

crust: pastry or pie

custard

grapefruit

hazelnuts

honey

Kirsch

lemon: juice, zest

lime

lychee

macadamia nuts

mangoes

oranges

papaya

passion fruit

pineapple

rum

salad, esp. chicken or fruit

strawberries

sugar

wine: Champagne, ice wine

KOHLRABI

(See also Rutabagas, Turnips)

Season: summer–autumn

Botanical relatives: broccoli, Brussels sprouts, cabbage, cauliflower, collard greens, kale

Weight: medium (esp. when younger)–heavy (esp. when older)

Volume: moderate (esp. when younger)–loud (esp. when older)

Techniques: boil, steam, stir-fry

allspice

basil

butter, unsalted

cabbage

carrots

celery

celery leaves or seeds

celery root

cheese, esp. Parmesan, Swiss

chervil

cilantro

coriander

cream

dill

fennel leaves or seeds

garlic

horseradish

leeks

lemon, juice

lovage

mace

mustard (e.g., Dijon)

mustard seeds

onions

parsley, flat-leaf

pepper, black
potatoes
rosemary
salt, esp. sea
sesame oil, seeds
soups
sour cream
soy sauce
stews
tamari
turmeric
vinegar, red wine

Kohlrabi is an underrated vegetable. I admit it has not always been one of my favorites, but it has grown on me over the years. Now, I love it. I can't precisely place its flavor, which is somewhere between a turnip, radish, and cauliflower. But it tastes great and is really versatile. You can grill it, roast it, glaze it like a carrot, or make a gratin out of it with potatoes. We have even grated it and made a rémoulade out of it like you would with a celery root. But the best way to enjoy kohlrabi is grilled, roasted, and drizzled with olive oil and sea salt. That is my favorite!

—**VITALY PALEY**, PALEY'S PLACE (PORTLAND, OREGON)

KOREAN CUISINE

chile peppers

fish

garlic

noodles, esp. buckwheat

rice

sesame seeds

shellfish

soy sauce

sugar

vegetables, pickled (e.g., kimchi)

Flavor Affinities

chile peppers + garlic + soy sauce

chile peppers + sesame seeds + soy sauce

chile peppers + soy sauce

garlic + sesame seeds + soy sauce

garlic + soy sauce

KUMQUATS

Season: autumn–winter

Taste: sour, bitter

Weight: light–medium

Volume: moderate–loud

Techniques: raw, stew

Asian cuisines

beef

berries: **cranberries**, strawberries

brandy

caramel

cayenne

chicken

chocolate: dark, white

chutney

cinnamon

citrus

coconut

cranberries

cream

custard

dates

duck

East Asian cuisine

endive (Belgian)

fish, esp. cod, halibut, red snapper, salmon, tuna, esp. grilled

ginger

hazelnuts

honey

lemon, juice

lime

mace

mango

marinades
meats
mint
nutmeg
olive oil
onions, spring

orange

papaya

pecans
persimmons
pineapple
pistachios
pomegranates
poppy seeds
pork
pumpkin
quince

rum

SALADS: FRUIT, GREEN

salt
strawberries
sugar
vanilla
walnuts
wine, white

LAMB—IN GENERAL

Season: spring

Taste: sweet, astringent

Function: heating

Weight: heavy

Volume: moderate–loud

Techniques: braise (esp. shanks), grill (esp. leg), roast (esp. leg), stew (esp. shoulder)

Tips: Cloves add richness to the flavor of lamb.

Our signature wine-marinated **lamb** popsicles in fenugreek cream curry on spinach potatoes dish is bare rugged simplicity. You have rack of lamb that has been cooked just a few minutes. Then you have a simple sauce that is essentially just cream and garlic—and you can taste all three. We add some green fenugreek that gives an earthiness to the dish and takes it to a whole new level. It is incredibly simple. It is a dish about technique because if the garlic is cooked too long, it gets bitter. Or if you add too much fenugreek, it gets bitter and overpowers the cream. But in the right proportions, it is perfect.

—MEERU DHALWALA, VIJ'S (VANCOUVER)



Dishes

Lamb, Fig, Pernod, and a Pillow of Sassafras Air

—Grant Achatz, Alinea (Chicago)

Lamb with Stew of Chickpeas, Root Vegetables, and Braised Lettuces

—Dan Barber, Blue Hill at Stone Barns (Pocantico Hills, New York)

Mint Love Letters with Spicy Lamb Sausage

—Mario Batali, Babbo (New York City)

Grilled Lamb Sirloin in a Roasted Garlic Sauce with Potato–Celery Root Gratin and Sautéed Escarole

—Ann Cashion, Cashion’s Eat Place (Washington, DC)

Colorado Rack of Lamb with Roasted Fennel, Glazed Baby Carrots, Fresh Garbanzo Beans, and Cardoon Puree, Niçoise Olive–Kumquat Tapenade

—Traci Des Jardins, Jardinière (San Francisco)

Colorado Lamb Loin with Creamy Polenta, Morel Mushrooms, and Star Route Fava Beans, Perigord Truffle Jus

—Traci Des Jardins, Jardinière (San Francisco)

Roast Lamb Sirloin on Crispy Goat Cheese Polenta with Saffron-Braised Baby Vegetables and Minted Yogurt

—Brad Farmerie, Public (New York City)

“Armenian Style” Lamb Skewers, Mediterranean Chickpea Salad, “Panisses,” and Minted Sheep’s Milk Yogurt

—Carrie Nahabedian, Naha (Chicago)

Poached Spring Lamb with Artichoke Tart and Pine Nut–Morel Gremolata

—Bradley Ogden, at the 2003 James Beard Awards gala reception

Moroccan Spiced Rack of Lamb with Couscous Salad, Roasted Eggplant, Lemon–Black Pepper Jus

—Alfred Portale, Gotham Bar and Grill (New York City)

Pan-Roasted Lamb Rack and Eighteen-Hours-Braised Leg of Lamb; Goat Cheese Mashed Potatoes; Wild Mushroom–Red Wine Sauce

—Eric Ripert, Le Bernardin (New York City)

Lamb Black Truffle Tagliatelle with Preserved Lemon and Aged Parmesan

—Eric Ripert, Le Bernardin (New York City)

Truffle and Almond-Crusted Rack of Lamb

—Brad Thompson, Mary Elaine’s at the Phoenician (Scottsdale, Arizona)

Wine-Marinated Lamb Popsicles in Fenugreek Cream Curry on Spinach Potatoes

—Vikram Vij and Meeru Dhalwala, Vij’s (Vancouver)

aioli

almonds

anchovies

apples

apricots, dried

artichokes

asparagus

bacon

basil

bay leaf

beans: cranberry, **fava**, **FLAGEOLETS**, green, **WHITE**

beer

bell peppers

brandy

bread crumbs

bulgur wheat

butter: clarified, unsalted

capers

cardamom

carrots

cayenne

celery

celery root

chard

cheese: blue, feta, **Parmesan**, ricotta

chickpeas

chiles: jalapeño, red

chili powder

chives

chocolate, dark

cilantro

cinnamon

cloves

coconut

cognac

coriander

couscous

cream

cumin

curry powder

dates

dill

Eastern Mediterranean (e.g., Greek, Turkish) cuisine

eggplant

endive

escarole

fennel

fennel seeds

fenugreek, esp. green

figs, dried black

five-spice powder

FLAGEOLETS

garam masala

***GARLIC and garlic paste**

ginger

Greek cuisine

herbs

honey

Indian cuisine

Irish cuisine (e.g., stews)

Italian cuisine, esp. southern

lavender

leeks

LEMON: juice, zest

lemon, preserved

lentils

lime, juice

mace

marjoram

Middle Eastern cuisine

***MINT**, esp. spearmint, mint jelly

mirepoix

Moroccan cuisine

mushrooms

MUSTARD, Dijon

nutmeg

OIL: canola, peanut, vegetable

olive oil

olives, esp. black, kalamata, niçoise

ONIONS: pearl, red, white, yellow

orange: juice, zest

oregano

paprika

PARSLEY, flat-leaf

pasta, esp. pappardelle

peas, esp. sweet

PEPPER: black, white

pesto

pine nuts

pistachios

polenta

pomegranates and pomegranate molasses

porcini mushrooms

potatoes, esp. new or red prunes

raisins

red pepper flakes

rice: basmati, white, wild

risotto

***ROSEMARY**

rutabaga

saffron

sage, fresh

SALT: *fleur de sel*, kosher, sea

savory

scallions

shallots

sherry, oloroso

spinach

stocks: beef, chicken, lamb, veal

sugar: brown, white

tabbouleh

tamarind

tarragon

THYME, FRESH

TOMATOES and tomato sauces

truffles, black, and truffle oil

turmeric

turnips

vanilla

vegetables, root

vermouth

vinaigrette

vinegar: balsamic, red wine, rice wine, sherry, white

watercress

WINE: dry white, red (e.g., Petite Syrah)

Worcestershire sauce

yogurt

zucchini

I work with a local **lamb** farmer in the Willamette Valley who has true spring lamb in the spring. We have a spit and every Friday night we roast a whole lamb. I am a big fan of lamb shoulder. It can take a beating and in the end come out glorious tasting! There is an old French technique where they cook ham in hay. The hay is submerged in water; then they put the ham on it to cook. It is amazing. We adapted this technique to the lamb. We had our farmer collect the hay and grass in the field where the lamb grazed with the thinking that this is what the lamb actually ate. We then dry the hay by letting it sit out overnight on a tray, so it becomes really butterscotchy and barnyardy. You can use any hay for this technique but I'm just a purist.

We brine a boneless shoulder of lamb for 24 hours in a brining solution of 1 cup of salt and ¼ cup of sugar in a gallon of water, [adding] some peppercorns, bay leaf, a couple of cardamom pods, a cinnamon stick, and cumin. The brine is brought to a boil, cooled down, and the lamb goes in. After the brining we rub the lamb with garlic and summer savory and tie it up into a log and put it on the bed of hay, drizzle it with white wine, cover it, and put it in the oven. It is nature going back on itself. The lamb ate the hay, the hay makes the lamb taste better. When it's cooked, the flavors are intense but pleasant and it becomes something else. When lavender is in season, I'll throw some in the hay as well and it is delicious.

With the lamb I like to serve a stuffed tomato Provençal [typically a combination of basil, bread crumbs, garlic, olive oil]. You want to serve something simple. You could also serve a crushed potato with savory and olive oil or a medley of vegetables.

—**VITALY PALEY**, PALEY'S PLACE (PORTLAND, OREGON)

Flavor Affinities

lamb + broccoli rabe + Parmesan cheese
lamb + cardamom + yogurt
lamb + carrots + ginger + pistachios
lamb + carrots + lentils + parsley
lamb + chickpeas + garlic
lamb + chocolate + cinnamon + cloves
lamb + cilantro + dill + garlic + mint
lamb + cinnamon + dried apricots + preserved lemons + walnuts
lamb + cinnamon + garlic + lemon + mint + onion + oregano
lamb + cinnamon + prunes
lamb + clove + red wine
lamb + cream + fenugreek + garlic
lamb + cucumber + mint + tomatoes
lamb + escarole + lemon
lamb + fava beans + thyme
lamb + fennel + onions + turnips
lamb + flageolet beans + thyme
lamb + garlic + flageolet beans
lamb + garlic + olives
lamb + garlic + rosemary
lamb + mint + mustard
lamb + mint + olives
lamb + mint + parsley
lamb + mint + peas + risotto
lamb + mint + ricotta cheese
lamb + mint + tomatoes

LAMB, CHOPS

Techniques: broil, grill, sauté

anchovies

beans (e.g., fava)

bell peppers, red

broccoli, rabe

butter, unsalted

capers

carrots

cayenne

chard

cheese, feta

cilantro

cumin

curry

fennel

garam masala

garlic

ginger

honey

leeks

lemon

lime

mace

mint

miso

mushrooms

mustard, Dijon

nutmeg

oil: canola, peanut

olive oil

olives, black

onions, esp. pearl oregano

paprika
parsley, flat-leaf
pepper: black, white
pomegranates
potatoes
rosemary
salad
salt: kosher, sea
savory
shallots
stock, chicken
sugar
tarragon
thyme
tomatoes
truffles
vinegar: balsamic, malt
wine, dry red
yogurt

Flavor Affinities

lamb chop + lemon + mint

Latin American cuisine is very Mediterranean. It's based on what was brought over from Spain and Italy. You'll see the combination of garlic, onions, and peppers like you'll see in Spain and Italy, not to mention the same pantry of herbs and spices: cilantro, cinnamon, cloves, cumin, oregano, rosemary, thyme.

—**MARICEL PRESILLA**, ZAFRA (HOBOKEN, NEW JERSEY)

LATIN AMERICAN CUISINE

beans, black

beef

café con leche

chile peppers

cilantro

cinnamon

cloves

corn

cumin

fruits

garlic

greens

lime, juice

meats

mixed grilled meats

onions

orange

oregano

peppers

pork

potatoes

rice

rosemary

sausages

seafood

tarragon

thyme

vegetables

Flavor Affinities

beef + corn + sweet potatoes

garlic + onions + peppers

meats + black beans + greens + orange + rice

seafood + chile peppers + cilantro + garlic + lime

LAVENDER

Taste: sweet, sour

Weight: light

Volume: loud

Tips: Caraway seeds can substitute for lavender.

almonds

apples

baked goods: cakes, cookies, scones, shortbread

berries

blackberries

blueberries

cheese, ricotta

cherries

CHICKEN

CREAM AND ICE CREAM

crème fraîche

currants, black

custards

desserts

duck

figs

French cuisine

fruit and fruit preserves

game birds

ginger

herbes de Provence (occasional ingredient)

HONEY

LAMB

lemon

lemonade

marjoram

mascarpone

meats (e.g., beef, lamb, steak)

milk
mint
onions
orange
oregano
parsley
peaches
pistachios
plums
pork
potatoes
Provençal cuisine
quail
rabbit
ras el hanout (key ingredient)
raspberries
rhubarb
rice
rosemary
savory
spearmint
stews
strawberries
sugar
tea, esp. black
thyme
vanilla
vinegar, balsamic
walnuts

Flavor Affinities

lavender + cream + sugar
lavender + meat + salt

Lavender works with plums or peaches.

—JERRY TRAUNFELD, THE HERBFARM (WOODINVILLE, WASHINGTON)

Lavender and rosemary work in butter cakes, cookies, and other baked goods.

—**JERRY TRAUNFELD**, THE HERBFARM (WOODINVILLE, WASHINGTON)

I like very little **lavender** with quail for its savory aroma, but the key phrase is “very little”—or else it’s like eating a piece of soap!

—**SHARON HAGE**, YORK STREET (DALLAS)

LEEEKS

Season: autumn–spring

Taste: sweet

Botanical relatives: chives, garlic, onions, shallots

Weight: light–medium

Volume: quiet

Techniques: boil, braise, fry, grill, roast, steam

Tips: Add early in cooking process.

anchovies

bacon

barley

bay leaf

beef

bouillabaisse

butter, unsalted

capers

caraway

carrot

cauliflower

celery

cheese: cheddar, goat, Gruyère, Parmesan

chervil

chicken

chile peppers

chives

coriander

cream

crème fraîche

dill

eggs (including hard-boiled) and egg dishes

fennel

fish

French cuisine

garlic

Greek cuisine

lemon, juice

lovage

meats, white

mushrooms, esp. oyster mussels

mustard

nutmeg

oil: corn, grapeseed, hazelnut, peanut, vegetable

olive oil

onions

oregano

paprika

parsley

pasta

pepper: black, white

potatoes

rice

sage

salads

salt, kosher

saucés, romesco

scallions

sea bass

soups

soy sauce

stews

stocks: chicken, vegetable

tamari

tarragon

thyme

tomatoes and tomato sauce

truffles, black

vinaigrette

vinegar, balsamic

wine: dry white, red

Flavor Affinities

leeks + anchovies + garlic + olive oil

leeks + bacon + cream

leeks + cream + thyme

leeks + mustard + vinaigrette

Dishes

Salade de Poireaux Frais: Chilled Leeks with Fingerling Potatoes and Piquillo Peppers

—Thomas Keller, Bouchon (Yountville, California)

Leek and Asparagus Pasta with Lemon, Parmesan, and Poached Egg

—Peter Nowakoski, Rat's (Hamilton, New Jersey)

We have **lemon juice** right next to the salt when we cook. Acid is the most important aspect of how a dish tastes—whether it is there as subtle punctuation or an exclamation point!

—SHARON HAGE, YORK STREET (DALLAS)

Lemon zest adds a totally different dynamic than lemon juice. If you are making an apple crisp, if you added a teaspoon of zest it would taste very different than if you added lemon juice. The juice would make it taste tart, whereas the zest would actually add a lemon flavor component to it. For ice cream, custards, and tarts, use lemon juice. But if you are going to combine lemon with other flavors, that's when you use zest.

—EMILY LUCHETTI, FARALLON (SAN FRANCISCO)

Use **lemon juice** when you want the acid and lemony flavor of the juice. If you want the perfume of the lemon, use the zest because the skin is where you get the essential oils. I use more lemon and orange than vanilla in my cooking because they are more prevalent in Italy and in Italian cooking, and a flavor profile that people recognize as Italian.

—GINA DEPALMA, BABBO (NEW YORK CITY)

Lemon can be used by itself or with other ingredients because it enhances so

many flavors. An orange can be a little too mellow, but lemon makes flavors much brighter. Lemon is an underlying flavor as much as the star. If there is one fruit you had to always have on hand as a basic staple, it is lemon.

—**EMILY LUCHETTI**, FARALLON (SAN FRANCISCO)

LEGUMES

(See Beans, Lentils, Peas, etc.)

LEMONS

Season: year-round

Taste: sour

Weight: light

Volume: loud



almonds

anise
apples
apricots
artichokes
bananas
basil
bay leaf
beef
berries
beverages
blackberries
blueberries
butter, unsalted
buttermilk
capers
caramel
cardamom
cayenne
cheese: goat, ricotta
cherries
chervil
chestnuts
chicken
chives
chocolate: dark, white
cinnamon
coconut
coffee
crab
cranberries
cream / milk
cream cheese
crème fraîche
custard
dates
desserts
duck

figs: fresh, dried

FISH

GARLIC

gin

ginger

gooseberries

grapefruit

grapes

Greek cuisine

guava

hazelnuts

HONEY

kiwi fruit

lamb

lemongrass

lemon verbena

lime

liqueurs: nut, orange (e.g., Cointreau, curaçao, Grand Marnier)

mango

maple syrup

mascarpone

Mediterranean cuisines

Middle Eastern cuisines

mint (garnish)

Moroccan cuisine

mustard, Dijon

nectarines

nuts, esp. hazelnuts

oats

olive oil

orange: juice, zest

oregano

oysters

papaya

parsley, flat-leaf

passion fruit

pasta and pasta sauces peaches

pears
pecans
pepper, black
persimmons
pine nuts
pistachios
plums
poppy seeds
pork and pork chops
poultry
prunes
quince
raisins
raspberries
rhubarb
rice
rosemary
rum
sage
salads and salad dressings
salt, kosher
sauces: brown butter, parsley
sesame oil
shallots
SHELLFISH
sour cream
stock, chicken
SUGAR: brown, white
tangerine
thyme
vanilla
veal
violets
vodka
walnuts
wine: red, sweet (e.g., Muscat), white
yogurt

Flavor Affinities

lemon + berries + crème fraîche

lemon + blackberries + honey + ricotta cheese

Dishes

Ricotta-Lemon Pancakes with Blackberries and Honeycomb Butter

—Andrew Carmellini, A Voce (New York City)

LEMONS, MEYER

Season: autumn–spring

Taste: sour–sweet

Weight: light

Volume: moderate–loud

cream

grapefruit

honey

lemon

lime

orange

sugar

vanilla

LEMONS, PRESERVED

Taste: sour

Weight: light–medium

Volume: moderate–loud

cinnamon

cloves

lamb

MOROCCAN CUISINE

nigella seeds

saffron

We churn through **preserved lemons**! In the middle of the summer, we buy cases so that we can age them eight months before we use them. After six months, they are great. After eight months or a year, you see God. They become incredible just by waiting those extra few months. I make preserved lemons by feel. I primarily use salt and will add some cinnamon, clove, nigella, a tiny, tiny bit of saffron, and then just tuck them away in the refrigerator. If I wasn't so greedy, I would give them away, but we are talking a year of my life here!

—BRAD FARMERIE, PUBLIC (NEW YORK CITY)

When you are using different kinds of lemons, you need to treat them as different things. A **Meyer lemon** is different from a regular lemon. If you are using a Meyer lemon, you may want the perfume, aroma, and subtlety of it. Yet when you taste it, you may want to add a touch of regular lemon to give it a little more acidity and a little kick.

—EMILY LUCHETTI, FARALLON (SAN FRANCISCO)

We get a lot of **Meyer lemons** in during the season, and they have a lovely sweet-orangey lemon flavor. But there are times that they are simply too sweet and we have to either add regular lemon or some lime to balance the Meyer

lemon.

—**MONICA POPE**, T'AFIA (HOUSTON)

Dishes

Meyer Lemon Cream Pie with Roasted Strawberries, Candied Coconut, Vanilla Chantilly

—Emily Luchetti, pastry chef, Farallon (San Francisco)

LEMON BALM

Season: spring–autumn

Taste: sour

Weight: light–medium

Volume: quiet–moderate

apricots
asparagus
berries
carrots
chicken
chives
dill
fennel bulb
fish
fruit
ginger
melon
mint
nectarines
parsley, flat-leaf
peaches
peas
salads, esp. fruit and green
teas

LEMON BASIL

Taste: sour

Weight: light

Volume: moderate

apricots
berries
cinnamon
desserts
fish
peaches
seafood
shellfish
soups
vegetables

LEMONGRASS

Taste: sour

Weight: light

Volume: moderate–loud

Tips: Add near end of cooking process; use in stir-fries.

basil

beef

chicken

chile peppers: red, green

chives

cilantro

cinnamon

cloves

coconut and coconut milk

coriander

crab

cream

curries

FISH

fruits

galangal

garlic

ginger

honey

Indonesian cuisine

lime, juice

lobster

Malaysian cuisine

meats

mint

noodles, rice

offal

onions

parsley

peanuts

pork

poultry

sage

salads and salad dressings

scallions

shallots

SHELLFISH

shrimp

soups, esp. chicken or turkey

Southeast Asian cuisines

spring rolls

stews

teas

THAI CUISINE

turmeric

vanilla

vegetables

Vietnamese cuisine

vinaigrettes

Flavor Affinities

lemongrass + chives + mint

lemongrass + cilantro + mint

lemongrass + cream + vanilla

LEMON THYME

Taste: sour

Weight: light

Volume: moderate–loud

asparagus

basil

bay leaf

beets

beverages (e.g., herbal teas) bouillabaisse

carrots

chicken, esp. roasted chives

eggs

fennel

figs

fish

fruits

ginger

halibut

lamb

marjoram

meats

mint

orange

parsley

potatoes

poultry

rabbit

rosemary

sage

salads: fruit, green

seafood

shellfish

sole

spinach

stews

stocks and broths: fish, seafood

stuffings

veal

vegetables, esp. spring

LEMON VERBENA

Taste: sour

Weight: light

Volume: loud

anise hyssop

apricots

baked goods (e.g., cakes, shortbread)

basil

beets

berries

beverages

blueberries

butter, unsalted

carrots

cherries

chicken

chile peppers

chives

cilantro

cinnamon

cream and ice cream

crème fraîche

currants, red

custards

desserts

fish

fruits

garlic

ginger

grapes

honey

lamb

lavender

lemon, juice
lemonade
lemongrass
lemon thyme
lime, juice
melon
milk
mint
mushrooms
nectarines
peaches
peas
plums
raspberries
rice
salads, fruit and green
salt
sour cream
strawberries
sugar
tamarind
tea, green
zucchini

Flavor Affinities

lemon verbena + apricots + sugar

Lemon verbena is amazing. I love to make a lemon verbena syrup and then poach apricots in it. It is so refreshing! We also make our own soda here, and lemon verbena is great in soda.

—JOHNNY IUZZINI, JEAN GEORGES (NEW YORK CITY)

Dishes

Green Lentil Soup with Black Truffle, Smoked Quail, Crispy Shallots

—Daniel Boulud, Daniel (New York City)

Lentil Stew with Blood Sausage, Chorizo, or Ham with a Poached Egg on Top

—Alexandra Raij, Tía Pol (New York City)

A drizzle of sherry vinegar just before you serve **lentils** elevates them to another level.

—JOSÉ ANDRÉS, CAFÉ ATLÁNTICO (WASHINGTON, DC)

I like **lentils** for soup with a smoked ham hock. For seasoning the soup, I recommend thyme, bay leaf, and a pinch of cumin. You can add bacon or sausage, or serve it with potato galettes on the side.

—GABRIEL KREUTHER, THE MODERN (NEW YORK CITY)

LENTILS

Season: winter

Taste: sweet–stringent

Function: cooling

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate

Techniques: simmer

Tips: Green lentils are more flavorful than brown or red.

apples: cider, juice

bacon

BAY LEAF

bell peppers, esp. red

bouquet garni

bread and croutons

butter, unsalted

cardamom

CARROTS

cayenne

CELERY

celery root

cheese, goat

chervil

chile peppers: dried red, fresh green

chives (garnish)

cilantro

cinnamon

cloves

coconut

cornichons

cream

cumin, esp. seeds

curry: leaves, powder, sauces

dill

eggplant

French cuisine

game birds, roasted (e.g., quail)

GARLIC

ginger

ham and ham hocks

honey

Indian cuisine

lamb

leeks

lemon, juice

lime, juice

meats

Mediterranean cuisine

mint, esp. spearmint

mirepoix (esp. for soups)

mustard, Dijon

mustard seeds, black

OIL: hazelnut, peanut, vegetable, walnut

olive oil

ONIONS, esp. red, white, yellow

oregano

PARSLEY, flat-leaf

PEPPER: black, white

pineapple

pork

poultry, roasted (e.g., chicken)

prosciutto

SALMON

SALT: kosher

sausage, esp. smoked

scallions

shallots

sorrel, esp. with green lentils

soups

soy sauce

spinach

squash, winter (e.g., butternut)

STOCKS: chicken, vegetable

thyme

tomatoes

turmeric

turnips

VINEGAR: balsamic, red wine, **sherry**

walnuts

wine, red

zucchini

Flavor Affinities

lentils + bacon + bell pepper + cumin + garlic

lentils + bacon + garlic + sherry vinegar

lentils + bay leaf + onions + thyme

lentils + cumin + turmeric

lentils + olive oil + parsley + sorrel

LETTUCES—IN GENERAL

Season: spring–autumn

Function: cooling

Weight: light–medium

Volume: quiet–loud

apples

bacon

basil

bread, breadsticks, croutons, etc.

capers

cheese (e.g., feta)

chicories, aka bitter greens

dill

eggs, esp. hard-boiled

fennel leaves

garlic

lemon, juice

mint

mushrooms

mustard, Dijon

nuts

oil: hazelnut, peanut, walnut

olive oil

olives

orange

parsley

peaches

pears

pepper, black

raisins

salt

shallots

sprouts

tarragon
vegetables, esp. raw
vinaigrette
vinegar: balsamic, cider, red wine
watercress

Bibb lettuce is a light, delicate, and almost creamy lettuce, so I serve it with a creamy dressing to mimic that creaminess. Because of its delicacy, to make the mayonnaise I'll use a neutral oil that's a blend of 80 percent canola and 20 percent olive. It finds a counterpoint in lemon and fines herbes, and gets a note of freshness, crunch, and spicy heat from radishes.

—**TONY LIU**, AUGUST (NEW YORK CITY)

LETTUCE, BIBB

(aka Boston or butter lettuce)

Season: spring

Taste: sweet

Weight: light–medium

Volume: quiet

arugula

avocados

basil

chervil

chives

cucumbers

fines herbes

lemon

orange

parsley

pepper, black

radishes

salt

sesame seeds

shallots

tarragon

vinaigrette

watercress

yogurt



LETTUCES—BITTER GREENS AND CHICORIES

(See Arugula, Escarole, Frisée, Radicchio)

Season: spring

Taste: bitter

Weight: light–medium

Volume: medium–loud

bacon

basil

beans, esp. “fresh shell”

butter

cheese: Asiago, Gruyère, Parmesan

cilantro

cream

eggs, hard-boiled

garlic

lemon, juice

lemon balm

nuts

olives

olive oil

onions, yellow

pancetta

parsley

pasta

red pepper flakes

rices

salt, kosher

scallions

shallots

sugar

thyme

vinegar: balsamic, red wine, white

walnuts

LETTUCES—MESCLUN GREENS

(i.e., mixed baby lettuces) (See also Lettuces—Bitter Greens and Chicories)

Season: spring

Taste: bitter

Weight: light

Volume: moderate

Dishes

Hearts of Romaine and Treviso Radicchio with Spanish Serrano Ham, Manchego Cheese, White Anchovies, Fire-Roasted Peppers, and Crisp Capers

—Carrie Nahabedian, Naha (Chicago)

Caesar Salad Soup

—Nobiyuki Sugie, Asiate (New York City)

Leaves of Romaine, Creamy Garlic Dressing, Red Onions, Capers, and Parmesan

—Cory Schreiber, Wildwood (Portland, Oregon)

basil
cheese, goat
chervil
chives
confit (e.g., duck)
French cuisine
hazelnuts
lemon, juice
mushrooms, wild (e.g., morels)
olive oil
parsley, flat-leaf
pecan
pepper, black
salt
shallots
tarragon
vinaigrettes

Flavor Affinities

mesclun greens + goat cheese + hazelnuts

LETTUCE, ROMAINE

Season: spring–autumn

Taste: sweet, bitter

Weight: light

Volume: quiet

anchovies

avocados

bell peppers: green, red

butter

Caesar salad

capers

cayenne

CHEESE: feta, dry Jack, Monterey Jack, **Parmesan**, Stilton

chervil

chile peppers: jalapeño, serrano

chives

cilantro

cream

crème fraîche

croutons

cucumbers

eggs, yolk

GARLIC

grapefruit

ham

leeks

lemon, juice

lime: juice, zest

lovage

mayonnaise

mustard, Dijon

OIL: canola, vegetable

OLIVE OIL

olives, kalamata

onions, esp. red

parsley, flat-leaf

pepper: black, white

salt: kosher, sea

shallots

sour cream

stocks: chicken, vegetable

tarragon

tomatoes

vinaigrette

VINEGAR: balsamic, cider, raspberry, red wine, sherry, white wine

walnuts

Worcestershire sauce

Flavor Affinities

romaine + anchovies + Parmesan cheese

romaine + capers + garlic + Parmesan cheese + red onions

Acidity awakens flavors. I love **lime**, and just a squeeze of lime on seafood soup or Thai soup awakens it.

—**KATSUYA FUKUSHIMA**, MINIBAR (WASHINGTON, DC)

Dishes

Key Lime Cheesecake with Macadamia Nut Crust, Lime Caramel, Key Lime Curd

—Emily Luchetti, pastry chef, Farallon (San Francisco)

**Grilled Lime Pound Cake with Crème Fraîche–Tapioca Pudding, Blueberry Gelée, and
Burnt Honey Ice Cream**

—Celina Tio, American Restaurant (Kansas City)

LIMES

Season: year-round

Taste: sour

Weight: light

Volume: moderate

apricots

avocados

berries: blueberries, gooseberries, raspberries, **strawberries**

butter

buttermilk

capers

caramel

ceviche

chicken

chile peppers, esp. jalapeño or serrano

chocolate, white

cilantro

coconut and coconut milk

cream

cream cheese

crème fraîche

dates

duck

figs, dried

fish, esp. grilled

fruits, esp. tropical

gin

ginger

gooseberries

grapefruit

green tea

guacamole

guava

hazelnuts

honey: raw, burnt

jicama

kiwi fruit

Latin American cuisine lemon

lemongrass

lime: juice, zest

lobster

macadamia nuts

mangoes

maple syrup

margaritas

mascarpone

meats, esp. grilled

melon, esp. honeydew

Mexican cuisine

mint

orange, juice

papayas

passion fruit

peanuts

pecans

pie, esp. with Key limes

raspberries

rum

salt

scallops

sea bass

shellfish

shrimp

Southwestern cuisine

strawberries

sugar: brown, white

sweet potatoes

tequila

Thai cuisine

tomatoes

tuna

vanilla

Vietnamese cuisine

vodka

yogurt

Flavor Affinities

lime + blueberries + burnt honey + crème fraîche

lime + caramel + cream cheese + macadamia nuts

lime + strawberries + tequila

LIMES AND LIME LEAF, KAFFIR
(See Kaffir Limes and Kaffir Lime Leaf)

LIVER, CALF'S

Taste: bitter

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: moderate–loud

Techniques: braise, broil, grill, sauté

Tips: Cook briefly, one minute per side.

apples

arugula

avocado

bacon

bay leaf

bouquet garni

butter, unsalted

carrots

celery

cheese, Parmesan

chervil

chives

cream

figs

French cuisine

garlic

jasmine

lemon, juice

milk

mushrooms

mustard, Dijon

oil, canola

olive oil

olives, green

ONIONS: fried, red, Vidalia, white

orange, zest

pancetta

parsley, flat-leaf
pears
pepper: black, white
polenta
potatoes, mashed
prunes
rhubarb
sage
salt, kosher
sauce, brown butter
sausages
shallots
spinach
stock, chicken
sugar, brown
thyme
tomatoes
turnips
VINEGAR: balsamic, cider, red wine, sherry
wine: dry red or white

Flavor Affinities

calf's liver + arugula + onions + pancetta
calf's liver + figs + onions + red wine vinegar

LIVER, CHICKEN

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate–loud

Techniques: grill, sauté

anchovies

apples

bacon

bay leaf

butter, unsalted

capers

chicken fat

chives

cilantro

eggs, hard-boiled

garlic

kale

lemon, juice

lime, juice

oil, peanut

olive oil

ONIONS: fried, red, sweet (e.g., Vidalia)

parsley, flat-leaf

peanuts

pepper: black, white

radishes

red pepper flakes rosemary

sage

salt, kosher

shallots

sherry, dry (e.g., fino) soy sauce

sugar

thyme

vinegar: balsamic, sherry wine, dry red

Flavor Affinities

chicken livers + apples + sage

chicken livers + bacon + balsamic vinegar + onions + rosemary

chicken livers + kale + lemon

I love **lobster**: poached, roasted, or grilled. I like mayonnaise or a vinaigrette with my lobster much more than butter with lobster. In the summertime, I like it with small potatoes and corn. I really like it with cilantro.

For my dish Roasted Maine Lobster in “Folly of Herbs” with Baby Fennel and Salsify, I wanted to do something different with lobster besides a lobster sauce. I make a “tea” of dried herbs: thyme, rosemary, fennel seeds, oregano, sage, mint, and tarragon. This is boiled and strained, then gets a dash of Ricard [also known as Pernod, an anise-flavored liquor]. The lobster gets finished with fresh parsley, mint, and fresh oregano. I chose these two vegetables because salsify is underused and underappreciated. I don’t blanch my salsify in water because when you do, the flavor stays in the water. I roast them and caramelize them a little bit, then deglaze with just a little water with a sprig of thyme and a bay leaf. Baby fennel is good because it plays off the Ricard and fennel. I quickly blanch the fennel and then caramelize it.

—GABRIEL KREUTHER, THE MODERN (NEW YORK CITY)

Cooked **lobster** meat blends well with mayonnaise, but I don’t think I’d use it with raw lobster—I’d use soy sauce instead.

—KAZ OKOCHI, KAZ SUSHI BISTRO (WASHINGTON, DC)

LIVER, DUCK OR GOOSE
(See Foie Gras)

LOBSTER

Season: summer–autumn

Taste: sweet

Weight: light–medium

Volume: quiet–medium

Techniques: bake, boil, broil, grill, pan roast, poach, roast, sauté, steam

anchovies

apples

artichokes

asparagus

avocado

bacon

basil

bay leaf

beans: green, flageolets, white

beets

bell peppers, esp. red, yellow, and/or roasted

brandy

BUTTER, unsalted

cabbage, esp. savoy

capers

carrots

caviar

cayenne

celery

celery root

Champagne

cheese: Gruyère, Parmesan

chervil

chile peppers, jalapeño

chili paste

Chinese cuisine

chives

cilantro

cinnamon

clams

clove

coconut and coconut milk

cognac

coriander

corn

crab

cream

crème fraîche

cucumbers

cumin

curry: paste (red), powder

curry leaf

daikon

dill

eggs and egg yolks

endive

fennel

fennel seeds

fenugreek seeds

figs

fish sauce, Thai

foie gras

frisée

GARLIC

ginger, fresh

grapefruit

grapes

guacamole

haricots verts

honey

horseradish

kiwi fruit

kumquats

leeks

LEMON: juice, zest
lemon, Meyer

Dishes

Spaghettini with Spicy Budding Chives, Sweet Garlic, and a One-Pound Lobster

—Mario Batali, Babbo (New York City)

Chatham Bay Day Boat Lobster with Red Wine Sauce and Parsnip-Rosemary-Apple Puree

—David Bouley, Upstairs (New York City)

Chilled Maine Lobster: Mango, Fresh Artichoke, and Serrano Ham with a Passion Fruit and Fresh Coconut Tamarind Dressing

—David Bouley, Bouley (New York City)

Potato Gnocchi with Maine Lobster, Wild Asparagus, Meyer Lemon, and Tarragon

—Traci Des Jardins, Jardinière (San Francisco)

Lobster and Morel Ravioli in Basil Broth, Hazelnuts, and Lobster Oil

—Sandy D’Amato, Sanford (Milwaukee)

Nova Scotia Lobster Poached with Florence Fennel and Chamomile

—Daniel Humm, Eleven Madison Park (New York City)

Warm Lobster Salad, Cauliflower and Watercress Coulis

—Jean Joho, Everest (Chicago)

Butter-Poached Lobster with Sweet Carrot Emulsion

—Thomas Keller, The French Laundry (Yountville, California)

Briny Lobster with Wasabi Mayo

—Kaz Okochi, Kaz Sushi Bistro (Washington, DC)

Maine Lobster Tails Roasted with Fingerling Potatoes, Pea Greens, Whole Garlic, and Fava Beans

—Alfred Portale, Gotham Bar and Grill (New York City)

Martini of Maine Lobster, Cucumber Salad, Belvedere Vodka, and White Sturgeon Caviar

—Thierry Rautureau, Rover's (Seattle)

Lobster Poached in a Lemon Miso Broth with Shiso and Hon Shimeji Mushrooms

—Eric Ripert, Le Bernardin (New York City)

Baked Lobster; Braised Endives, with Enoki and Black Trumpet Mushroom with Bourbon–Black Pepper Sauce

—Eric Ripert, Le Bernardin (New York City)

lemongrass

lentils

lime: leaf (kaffir), juice

lobster roe

macaroni and cheese

mace

mâche

mangoes

mascarpone

mayonnaise

Mediterranean cuisine

mint

mirepoix

miso, white

mushrooms: button, cepes, chanterelles, cremini, porcini, shiitake, white, wild

mussels

mustard: dry, seeds

New England cuisine

nutmeg

OIL: canola, corn, grapeseed, hazelnut, peanut, sesame, vegetable, walnut

olive oil

onions, esp. pearl, red, Spanish

orange (juice, zest) and clementine

oyster sauce

papaya

paprika, sweet

parsley, flat-leaf

parsnips

pasta (e.g., macaroni)

passion fruit

peanuts

peas

peas, snow

pepper: black, white

Pernod

pineapple

port

potatoes, esp. fingerling or new

pumpkin

radicchio

red pepper flakes

rhubarb

rice, esp. sticky, and risotto

rosemary

saffron

SALT: kosher, sea, *sel gris*

sauces, béchamel

scallions

scallops

sea urchin

shallots

shrimp

snow peas

Southern cuisine

soy sauce

spinach

squid

star anise

stocks: chicken, fish, lobster, shellfish, veal, vegetable

Tabasco sauce

tamarind, puree

tarragon

thyme

TOMATOES: juice, paste, pulp

truffles: black, juice

vanilla

vermouth, dry

vinaigrette, esp. citrus

VINEGAR: red wine, rice wine, **sherry**, white wine

vodka

wasabi

water chestnuts

watermelon

whiskey

WINE: dry to off-dry white (e.g., Gewürztraminer or Riesling), dry red (e.g., Syrah), port

Worcestershire sauce

yuzu juice

Flavor Affinities

lobster + artichokes + garlic

lobster + avocado + mayonnaise + tarragon + white wine vinegar

lobster + bacon + porcini mushrooms

lobster + basil + hazelnuts + morel mushrooms

lobster + basil + tomatoes

lobster + brandy + cream + rosemary

lobster + brown butter + orange + vanilla

lobster + butter + garlic + tarragon

lobster + celery + mayonnaise + black truffles
lobster + chanterelle mushrooms + parsley + Pernod
lobster + chanterelle mushrooms + tarragon
lobster + chive + lemon
lobster + cilantro + cumin
lobster + corn + garlic + lemon + potatoes + tarragon
lobster + fennel + lemon
lobster + mango + spinach
lobster + mayonnaise + wasabi
lobster + orange + soy sauce
lobster + pasta + peas
lobster + saffron + vanilla

Stinging nettles and **lovage** is a wonderful combination. Stinging nettles are peppery with a green flavor and lovage is celery-like. It's funny: I find nettles without lovage are kind of flat tasting. I will use this combination in a ravioli filling or with local Dungeness crab as a sauce for a soufflé.

—**JERRY TRAUNFELD**, THE HERBFARM (WOODINVILLE, WASHINGTON)

LOTUS ROOT

Season: summer–winter

Taste: sweet

Weight: light–medium

Volume: quiet

Techniques: fry, raw, simmer, stir-fry

ginger

lemon

lime

oil, vegetable

salads

soups

soy sauce

stir-fried dishes

tempura

vinegar, rice

wine, rice

LOVAGE

Season: spring, autumn

Taste: sour

Weight: light–medium, soft-leaved

Volume: quiet–loud

Tips: Always use fresh, not cooked.

apples

bay leaf

beans, green

bell peppers

caraway

carrots

chard

cheese

chervil

chicken

chile peppers

chives

clams

corn

crab, Dungeness

cream cheese

dill

eggs and egg dishes

fennel

fish, e.g., halibut, skate, smoked, tuna

garlic

greens

ham

juniper berries

lamb

marjoram

mint

mushrooms
mussels
mustard
nettles, stinging
onions
oregano
parsley
pork
potatoes
rabbit
rice
salads, green
sauces
shellfish
sorrel
soups, esp. fish
spinach
stews
tarragon
thyme
tomatoes and tomato juice
veal
vegetables, esp. root
zucchini

Flavor Affinities

lovage + Dungeness crab + stinging nettles
lovage + salmon + tomatoes

LUXURIOUS

caviar, esp. Beluga

Champagne

foie gras

Ibérico ham

Kobe beef

saffron

smoked fish

vanilla

truffles: black, white

wine

LYCHEES

Season: summer

Taste: sweet

Weight: light–medium

Volume: quiet–moderate

Techniques: raw

anise hyssop

berries

blackberries

chicken

chile peppers

cilantro

coconut and coconut milk

cream

cream cheese

curry

duck

foie gras

ginger

honey

kiwi fruit

lemon, juice

lemongrass

lime, juice

mangoes

melon, esp. honeydew

nuts

orange, tangerine

passion fruit

pears

pineapple

plums

pork

raspberries

rice

rose (French cuisine)

rum

sake

salads, fruit

shellfish: scallops, shrimp

strawberries

sugar, esp. palm

vodka

wine: plum, sparkling

yogurt

Flavor Affinities

lychees + ginger + lime

lychees + raspberries + rose

Dishes

Summer Raspberry-Lychee Macaroon with Lemon Sorbet

—Eric Bertoia, Cafe Boulud (New York City)

Our **macadamia nut** tart, which we serve with banana-rum ice cream, is our take on pecan pie.

—LISSA DOUMANI, TERRA (ST. HELENA, CALIFORNIA)

Macadamia nuts are buttery, rich nuts. I will even pair them with sea scallops, which also have a richness to them. The macadamia nuts don't overwhelm the scallops and I put them in the dish slightly chopped—otherwise, the texture of the nut would be too chewy. We use macadamia nuts on one of the simplest yet most popular dishes on our menu—our jumbo lump crab cake with grilled asparagus and toasted macadamia nuts. Our crab cake is the only recipe we won't give out. It contains no herbs or spices. The only thing that goes in our crab cake is crab, salt, pepper, *panko* [Japanese bread crumbs], and a little mayonnaise to hold them together. You are the first people to get this recipe!

—MARCEL DESAULNIERS, THE TRELIS (WILLIAMSBURG, VIRGINIA)

MACADAMIA NUT OIL

(See Oil, Macadamia Nut)

MACADAMIA NUTS

Weight: light–medium

Volume: moderate

apricots

bananas

beets

bourbon

brandy

caramel

cashews

chicken

chocolate, esp. dark or white

coconut

coffee

crab

cream

dates

desserts

figs, dried

fish (e.g., cod, halibut, mahi mahi)

ginger

goat cheese

grapefruit

guava

Hawaiian cuisine

honey

kumquats

lamb

lemon

lime

mango

maple syrup

mint

orange
papaya
passion fruit
peaches
pineapple
prunes
raspberries
rum
scallops
sugar, brown
vanilla

Flavor Affinities

macadamia nuts + bananas + caramel + cream
macadamia nuts + beets + goat cheese
macadamia nuts + coconut + lime

MACE

Season: summer–autumn

Taste: pungent, sweet

Botanical relatives: nutmeg

Weight: light–medium

Volume: loud

allspice

Asian cuisine

baked goods (e.g., doughnuts)

beans

broccoli

butter

cabbage

cardamom

carrots

cheese and cheese dishes, esp. creamy

cherry pie

chicken

chocolate

chowders (e.g., fish)

cinnamon

cloves

coriander

cream / milk

cumin

curry (ingredient)

eggs

English cuisine

fish

French cuisine

garam masala (ingredient)

ginger

hazelnuts

Indian cuisine

ketchup (ingredient)

lamb

meats

New England cuisine

NUTMEG

onions

paprika

pastries

pepper

potatoes

pound cake

puddings

pumpkin

salads, fruit

saucés: béchamel, cream, onion

sausages

shellfish, shrimp

soups and consommés

spinach

stuffing

sweet potatoes

thyme

veal

vegetables

West Indian cuisine

MÂCHE

Season: autumn–spring

Weight: very light

Volume: very quiet

Techniques: raw, steam

apples

bacon

beets

butter

cheese, goat

cream

eggs, quail

endive

lemon, juice

mustard, Dijon

nuts: pistachios, **walnuts**

oil: grapeseed, nut

olive oil

orange

pomegranates

potatoes

scallops

shallots

vinegar: champagne, sherry

Flavor Affinities

mâche + apples + bacon

mâche + apples + bacon + vinegar

mâche + apples + beets + endive + sherry vinaigrette + walnuts

mâche + oranges + pistachios + pomegranates

MACKEREL

Season: summer–autumn

Weight: light

Volume: loud

Techniques: braise, broil, grill, marinate, poach, sauté, sear

If you go to Japan, you'll find that virtually all the sushi restaurants put a little ginger and scallion on their **mackerel** sushi. It cuts its “fishiness” while adding flavor.

—KAZ OKOCHI, KAZ SUSHI BISTRO (WASHINGTON, DC)

apples

artichokes

bay leaf

beets

bell peppers: red, yellow

butter

capers

caraway seeds

caviar

ceviche

chile peppers

chives

cilantro

cinnamon

cloves

coriander

cornichons

cream

crème fraîche

cucumber

cumin

dill

fennel

French cuisine

garlic

ginger

gooseberries

horseradish

LEMON, juice

lemon thyme

lentils

lime, juice

mint (garnish)

miso

mushrooms

mustard, Dijon

mustard seeds

OIL: canola, corn, peanut, sesame, vegetable

olive oil

onions

orange, juice

pancetta

parsley, flat-leaf

PEPPER: black, green, white

red pepper flakes

rosemary

saffron

sake

salmon caviar

salt, sea

scallions

sesame seeds

shallots

sorrel

soy sauce

stocks: chicken, fish

sugar

thyme

VINEGAR: champagne, red wine, sherry, white wine

wine, dry white

Flavor Affinities

mackerel + arugula + chickpeas + lemon + rosemary

mackerel + chives + Dijon mustard + lemon juice + shallots + vinegar

mackerel + ginger + scallions

mackerel + onions + thyme

MAHI MAHI

Taste: sweet

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: quiet

Techniques: bake, broil, deepfry, grill, poach, sauté, steam, stirfry

avocado

cabbage

cilantro

coriander

dill

fruits, esp. tropical

gin

juniper berries

lemon: juice, zest

orange: juice, zest

pepper, white

salt, sea

sugar

Flavor Affinities

mahi mahi + avocado + cabbage + cilantro

Dishes

**Taco de Pescado “Baja”: Battered and Deep-Fried Mahi Mahi in Soft Corn Tortillas
with Cabbage and Avocado-Cilantro Cream**

—Traci Des Jardins, Mijita (San Francisco)

MALT

Taste: sweet

Weight: light

Volume: moderate

bananas

caramel

chocolate

cinnamon

coffee

cream and ice cream

nuts

sugar

vanilla

Dishes

Naha Sundae of Vanilla Malt Ice Cream, Hickory Nut Waffle, Bananas, and Bourbon-Pecan Syrup, Shortbread Cookies

—Elizabeth Dahl, pastry chef, Naha (Chicago)

Double-Malted Euphoria with Malted Chocolate, Vanilla Mousse, and Marcona Almond Brittle

—Celina Tio, American Restaurant (Kansas City)

I love **malt**. It has a sweetness, breadiness, and graininess to its flavor. It works with the classics like chocolate, vanilla, and caramel.

—MICHAEL LAISKONIS, LE BERNARDIN (NEW YORK CITY)

Dishes

Mango Mousse, Pineapple Soufflé, Roasted Pineapple, Swiss Meringue

—François Payard, Payard Patisserie and Bistro (New York City)

Organic Strawberry and Grapefruit Granitas, Mango “Salad,” Mascarpone

—Monica Pope, T’afia (Houston)

Mango, Pistachio, and Banana Strudel with Coconut-Curry Sauce

—Allen Susser, at the 2003 James Beard Awards gala reception

Raspberry-Mango Soufflé with Fresh Fruit and Bittersweet Chocolate Ice Cream

—Celina Tio, American Restaurant (Kansas City)

MANGOES

Season: late spring–late summer

Taste: sweet

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate

Techniques: raw

almonds

amaretto

anise

avocados

BANANAS (compatible fruit)

basil

bell peppers, esp. red and green

beverages (e.g., cocktails, smoothies)

blackberries

blueberries

buttermilk

butterscotch

cabbage, green

caramel

cashews

cayenne

ceviche

Champagne

cheese, esp. mixed-milk cheeses (e.g., Robiola Rocchetta and Amarelo da Beira Baixa)

CHILE PEPPERS, esp. jalapeño, serrano, red, green

chocolate, white

chutneys

cilantro

cinnamon

cloves

COCONUT AND COCONUT MILK

coffee
cream (e.g., heavy, whipped)
crème fraîche
curry powder
custard
fish
game
garlic
ginger, fresh
grapefruit
honey
Indian cuisine
Kirsch
kiwi fruit
kumquats
lemon, juice
LIME, juice
macadamia nuts
mascarpone
Mexican cuisine
milk (e.g., evaporated)
mint
nutmeg
oil, vegetable
olive oil
ONIONS: red, sweet
ORANGE: juice, zest
orange liqueur
papaya
passion fruit
pepper, white
pineapple
pork, esp. roasted
poultry: chicken, duck
prosciutto
raspberries
rice

RUM

sake

salads, fruit

salmon

salt**Sauternes**

scallions

sesame seeds

shellfish, shrimp

sorbet

squab

star anise

strawberries

SUGAR: LIGHT BROWN, WHITE

Tabasco sauce

Thai cuisine

tuna, esp. grilled

vanilla

vinegar: balsamic, red wine

violets

vodka

wine: Chardonnay, sweet (e.g., ice wine)

yogurt

AVOID

soy sauce

wasabi

Flavor Affinities

mango + almonds + lime

mango + basil + Champagne

mango + black pepper + lemon + mint + passion fruit

mango + coconut + rice

mango + ginger + mint + papaya

mango + salmon + sushi rice

Mangoes pair well with some of the mixed-milk cheeses such as Robiola

Rocchetta and Amarelo da Beira Baixa.

—**MAX MCCALMAN**, ARTISANAL CHEESE CENTER (NEW YORK CITY)

MAPLE SYRUP

Taste: sweet, bitter

Function: cooling

Weight: medium-heavy

Volume: moderate-loud



almonds
anise
apples
apricots
bacon
baked goods, e.g., gingerbread

BANANAS

BLUEBERRIES

breakfast / brunch
butter
buttermilk
Canadian cuisine
caramel
carrots
chestnuts
chocolate, esp. dark, white
cinnamon
coffee
corn syrup
cream
cream cheese
custard
dates
desserts
duck
figs, esp. dried
foie gras
French toast
fruit
ginger
ham
hazelnuts
ice cream: coffee, vanilla
lemon, juice
lime, juice
macadamia nuts
mascarpone

nectarines

New England cuisine

nutmeg

nuts

oats

onions

orange

pancakes

peaches

PEARS

PECANS

persimmons

pineapple

plums

pork ribs

prunes

pumpkin

quince

raisins

raspberries

rhubarb

rum: dark, light

star anise

strawberries

sweet potatoes

sugar: light brown, raw, white

tea

turkey

vanilla

waffles

WALNUTS

whiskey

yogurt

AVOID

sugar, dark brown, as it is too intense with maple syrup

Flavor Affinities

maple syrup + blueberries + lemon

maple syrup + butter + chocolate + cream

maple syrup + caramel + pecans

maple syrup + mascarpone + pistachios

I typically use **maple syrup** with nuts, like in a pecan pie. I will replace the dark corn syrup in the recipe with maple syrup instead. It is always important to use a very good quality [e.g., Vermont or Canadian] maple syrup. If you are working with syrup and sugar, you need to be careful because the combination of dark brown sugar with maple syrup can become very intense.

—**EMILY LUCHETTI**, FARALLON (SAN FRANCISCO)

BLiS **maple syrup** is aged in bourbon barrels, and is good enough to drink on its own! I'll use it with everything from duck breast to foie gras.

—**BRADFORD THOMPSON**, MARY ELAINE'S AT THE PHOENICIAN (SCOTTSDALE, ARIZONA)

Dishes

Maple and Anise French Toast with Lavender Custard

—Dominique and Cindy Duby, Wild Sweets (Vancouver)

Milk Chocolate and Maple Caramel Cake

—Dominique and Cindy Duby, Wild Sweets (Vancouver)

Milk Chocolate and Maple Caramel Ice Cream, Caramelized Bananas, and Ginger Tuile

—Dominique and Cindy Duby, Wild Sweets (Vancouver)

MARJORAM

Season: summer–winter

Taste: sweet, spicy

Botanical relatives: oregano (which is stronger in flavor than marjoram)

Weight: light

Volume: quiet–moderate

Tips: Add at the end of the cooking process.

artichokes asparagus

basil

bay leaf

beans, esp. green

beef

beets

bouquet garni (ingredient)

bread

butter

carrots

chard

cheese: fresh goat, mozzarella

chicken

chives

chowders

clams

corn

cucumber

delicate-flavored foods (e.g., those “quiet” in Volume)

duck

eggs and egg dishes (e.g., omelets)

fish

French cuisine

fines herbes (ingredient)

garlic

halibut

Italian cuisine

lamb

lemon, juice

lima beans

meats, esp. grilled

Mediterranean cuisine

Middle Eastern cuisine

mint

mushrooms, esp. wild

North African cuisine

North American cuisine

oil, peanut

olive oil

olives

onions

oregano

parsley

pasta, esp. macaroni or ravioli

peas

pizza

pork

potatoes

poultry

rabbit

risotto

rosemary

sage

SALADS, esp. green, and salad dressings

saucers

sausages

savory

shellfish

soups, esp. bean, onion

spinach

squash, summer

stews

stuffing

thyme

tomatoes and tomato sauce

tuna

veal

vegetables, esp. summer

vinaigrettes

wine, red

zucchini

Flavor Affinities

marjoram + chicken + lemon

marjoram + fresh goat cheese + prosciutto

marjoram + tomato sauce + zucchini

Mediterranean herbs marry well. Rosemary and **marjoram**, or thyme and savory, are naturals together.

—**JERRY TRAUNFELD**, THE HERBFARM (WOODINVILLE, WASHINGTON)

MASCARPONE

Taste: sweet

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: quiet

almonds

anchovies

apricots

arugula

berries

biscotti

blackberries

blueberries

brandy

butter

caramel

cheese, ricotta

cherries

chives

chocolate, esp. dark

cinnamon

cloves

coffee/espresso

cream

cream cheese

crème fraîche

currants, red

dates

figs

fruits, tropical

ginger

guava

hazelnuts

honey

Italian cuisine

Kirsch

ladyfingers

lemon: juice, zest

lime

maple syrup

mushrooms

mustard

nectarines

nutmeg

oats

orange

pasta

peaches

pears

pepper, black

pesto

pine nuts

pistachios

prosciutto

pumpkin

quince

raisins

raspberries

rhubarb

rum

strawberries

sugar: raw, white

truffle oil

vanilla

vinegar, balsamic

walnuts

wine: red, sweet

Flavor Affinities

mascarpone + arugula + truffle oil

mascarpone + berries + figs

mascarpone + chocolate + strawberries

mascarpone + cinnamon + pumpkin

mascarpone + espresso + ladyfingers (cookies) + sugar

mascarpone + figs + prosciutto

mascarpone + maple syrup + pistachios

Dishes

Black Mission Figs with Mascarpone Foam and Prosciutto di Parma

—Rick Tramonto, Tru (Chicago)

MEATS

Tips: Enhance the flavor of meat *before* (e.g., via brining and marinating), *during* (e.g., via selecting the best cooking technique), and *after* cooking (e.g., via condiments and sauces).

MEDITERRANEAN CUISINES

(See also French [southern], Italian, Middle Eastern, Moroccan, and Spanish Cuisines)

basil

citrus

garlic

herbs

lemon, juice

marjoram

olive oil

oregano

parsley

rosemary

sage

savory

thyme

tomatoes

vinegar: balsamic, red wine

Flavor Affinities

marjoram + rosemary

savory + thyme

MELON/MUSKMELONS—IN GENERAL

(See also Cantaloupe, Honeydew, etc.)

Season: summer

Taste: sweet

Function: cooling

Weight: light–medium

Volume: moderate

Techniques: raw

almonds

anise seeds and anise hyssop

apricots

basil

beverages, esp. smoothies

blackberries

blueberries

Champagne

cherries

chile peppers, esp. serrano chili powder

chili sauce

cilantro

cognac, esp. in cocktails

Cointreau

cream / milk

crème fraîche

cucumbers

curaçao, esp. in cocktails

cured meats (e.g., prosciutto, sopressata)

curry

fennel

ginger

Grand Marnier, esp. in cocktails grapefruit

grapes

hazelnuts

honey
ices and ice creams
Italian cuisine
Kirsch
kiwi fruit
LEMON, juice
lemon balm
LIME, juice
lychees
macadamia nuts
Madeira
mangoes
Midori liqueur
MINT, esp. spearmint
olive oil
orange
orange-flower water
pears
pecans
pepper: black, white
port
PROSCIUTTO
raspberries
rum
sake
salads, esp. fruit
salsas, fruit
salt, kosher
sambuca
soups, esp. chilled
strawberries: fruit, puree
tarragon
tequila, esp. in cocktails
vanilla
vinegar, rice
wines, sweet, esp. Gewürztraminer, late harvest wines, **Muscat Beaumes-**
deVenise Riesling, Sauternes

yogurt
yuzu juice

Tarragon works with **muskmelons**.

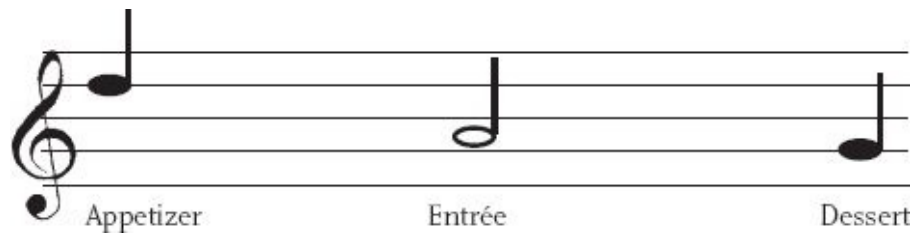
—**JERRY TRAUNFELD**, THE HERBFARM (WOODINVILLE, WASHINGTON)



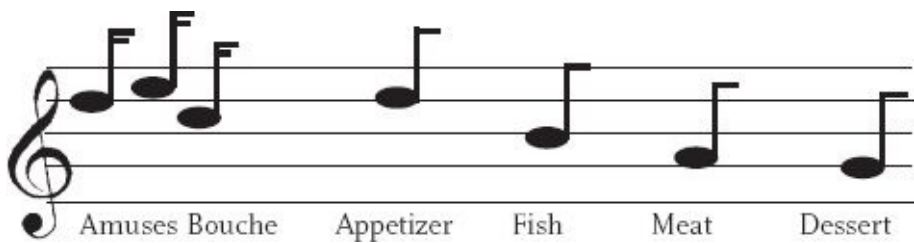
MENU

Tips: Strive for balance over an entire menu, i.e., appetizer, entrée, and dessert. Envision the course of a menu as a piece of music having a melody, rhythm, and tempo.

Three-course menu:



Tasting menu:



When planning a **menu**, pick the dessert or the entrée first and have the other one match it, in terms of style and preparation. If you are doing an entrée that requires last-minute time in the kitchen, don't serve a dessert that requires last-minute time as well. If you have a main course that takes last-minute work, serve a dessert that can be made a day ahead—or if your dessert is what needs last-minute attention, serve it after a stew or lasagna. When deciding what to make, remember: The heavier the main course, the lighter the dessert should be, or vice versa. I was recently going through some of my earlier books and was shocked when I looked at the recipes. One recipe for a chocolate cake that we served at Stars was served in big wedges. I was amazed we used to serve such a huge portion! People can't eat like that anymore. At the same time, the cake is so good I still want to serve it so I work backward. I will serve a chicken or something else light for the main course, not a prime rib of beef.

—EMILY LUCHETTI, FARALLON (SAN FRANCISCO)

MERLOT

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate

beef

cheese, esp. blue and other fullflavored

chicken

duck

lamb

meat, red

mushrooms

pork

steak

turkey

veal

MEXICAN CUISINE

avocados

beans

beef

chicken

***CHILE PEPPERS**

chili powder

chocolate

cilantro

cinnamon

corn

cumin

epazote

fried dishes

garlic

lemon

lime, juice

nuts

onions

orange

oregano

pork

rice

saffron

salsas

scallions

seeds

squash

tomatoes

tortillas

turkey

vanilla

wheat

Flavor Affinities

beans + rice

chile peppers + lime

chile peppers + tomatoes

cilantro + lime



Creating new dishes has to be more than simply intensifying flavors for dishes. In terms of visual presentation, we are shifting into a new direction where the food looks like one thing, but is really something else. That adds an extra element of challenge for us. An example of this would be a [**Mexican-inspired**] nacho dish we just created. You get something that looks like chips, sour cream, *salsa verde*, and grated cheese. The cheese is actually grated from saffron ice cream that we have thrown into liquid nitrogen, that is put into a food processor grater. The *salsa verde* is made from kiwi, mint puree, and epozote to give it a little twist. The sour cream is a yuzu crème fraîche. The chips are made from pureed corn tortilla chips that have been sweetened with powdered sugar, then pasted into triangles and deep fried. So you get something that looks like nachos, but tastes completely different. So we are taking a visual aspect of something you are comfortable with and serving it at the end of a twenty-course meal.

—HOMARO CANTU, MOTO (CHICAGO)

MIDDLE EASTERN CUISINE

almonds
beans, fava
cheese, feta
chicken
chickpeas
cinnamon
cloves
coriander
cumin
dill
eggplant
fish
fruits, dried
garlic
ginger
goat
honey
lamb
lemons
lemons, preserved
lentils
meats, esp. roasted
mint
nutmeg
nuts
olive oil
olives
onions
oregano
parsley
pepper, black
pine nuts
pistachios
pomegranates

poppy seeds
raisins
ras el hanout (spice blend)
rice
roasted dishes
sesame: oil, seeds
sumac
tahini
tomatoes
walnuts
yogurt

Flavor Affinities

cilantro + cumin + ginger + red pepper
cinnamon + cloves + ginger + nutmeg
cinnamon + lemons + tomatoes
cinnamon + tomatoes
coriander + cumin + garlic
coriander + cumin + garlic + onions + parsley
coriander + cumin + garlic + pepper
eggplant + onions + tomatoes
garlic + coriander
garlic + lemon + mint
garlic + lemon + oregano
garlic + lemon + parsley
lemon + parsley
meat + cinnamon
salads + goat cheese + pomegranate seeds
yogurt + garlic + mint
yogurt + mint
yogurt + parsley

With **mint**, applemint is mild, while peppermint is strong.

—JERRY TRAUNFELD, THE HERBFARM (WOODINVILLE, WASHINGTON)

I was actually brought up in the school of thought that put a sprig of **mint** on every dessert. I am not that guy anymore. I have a saying—“NFG”—which stands for two things at once: “nonfunctional garnishes” are “no fucking good.” If something doesn’t make sense to the dish, it won’t be there. I hate ordering lamb and seeing a huge bunch of rosemary alongside it. Put it in the dish—let me taste it!

—**JOHNNY IUZZINI**, JEAN GEORGES (NEW YORK CITY)

I love **mint** flavor, but some cooks started throwing mint on desserts just because they liked the color of it. If you have a gorgeous strawberry shortcake and add some mint to it, one of two things will happen: 1) Either you don’t eat it, so what’s the point of putting it on the plate in the first place, or 2) If you do eat it, that one mint leaf will completely change the balance of the dessert. If you have a lemon tart that is mostly perfectly balanced lemon curd with a little whipped cream and you add a mint leaf to the dessert, the leaf will play havoc with that balance. So don’t throw mint on a plate haphazardly, or you’ll throw off the balance of the entire dessert.

—**EMILY LUCHETTI**, FARALLON (SAN FRANCISCO)

The first place I think of with **mint** is Morocco. From there, it is the Middle East. Mint and lamb is such a natural combination, as is mint and yogurt.

—**BRAD FARMERIE**, PUBLIC (NEW YORK CITY)

I don’t use **mint** very much, but I have a serious thing for black peppermint! You will see it in one form or another on my menu. I go to the farmers’ market twice a week and use it all summer. It is great with berries. It works best with something light like an infusion or granita. Last summer, we made a tangy lychee gelée that was served under oven-roasted Tristar strawberries tossed lightly with balsamic vinegar. On top of the strawberries, we scooped the black peppermint sorbet.

—**JOHNNY IUZZINI**, JEAN GEORGES (NEW YORK CITY)

MINT—IN GENERAL

Season: spring–autumn

Taste: sweet

Function: cooling

Weight: light

Volume: quiet–moderate

Tips: Mint generally refers to spearmint.

Mint suggests “false coolness” and adds a note of freshness to dishes.

Afghan cuisine

apples

Asian cuisines

asparagus

basil

BEANS: black, fresh, white

beef

beets

bell peppers

berries

beverages

blackberries

bourbon

buttermilk

cardamom

carrots, esp. baby

cashews

Champagne

cheese: feta, ricotta

chicken

chile peppers (e.g., jalapeño)

chives

CHOCOLATE, ESP. DARK, white

chutneys

cilantro

cinnamon

citrus

cloves

coconut

cocktails: mint julep (ingredient), Pimms No. 1 Cup (ingredient)

CREAM AND ICE CREAM

crème fraîche

CUCUMBERS

cumin

curries

desserts

dill

duck

eggplant

Egyptian cuisine

endive

fenugreek

fish

FRUITS

fruits, tropical

garlic

ginger

grapefruit

grapes

Greek cuisine

halibut

honey

Indian cuisine

jellies

kumquats

***LAMB**

lavender

lemon

lemongrass

lemon verbena

lentils

lettuce

lime

mango

marinades

marjoram

meats

Mediterranean cuisine

melon

Mexican cuisine

Middle Eastern cuisine

milk

Moroccan cuisine

mushrooms

mussels

nectarines

olives, black

onions, esp. red

orange

oregano (say some)

papaya

paprika

parsley

pasta

peaches, esp. cooked

pears

peas, esp. young

pepper

pineapple

plums, esp. cooked

pork

potatoes, esp. new

poultry

pumpkin

punches, fruit

radishes

raitas

raspberries

rice and rice dishes

rosemary

sage

SALADS: bean, fruit, green, vegetable

salsas

sea bass

shellfish

shrimp

skate

soups, esp. bean, cold, and/or fish

soy sauce

spinach

spring rolls, esp. Vietnamese

squash, summer

stews, esp. seafood

strawberries

SUGAR

sumac

tabbouleh (key ingredient)

tea, esp. Earl Grey, green

Thai cuisine (e.g., green curries)

thyme

tomatoes

trout

tuna

Turkish cuisine

vanilla

veal

vegetables

Vietnamese cuisine

vinegar: cider, rice wine

watermelon

YOGURT

zucchini

AVOID

oregano (say some)

Flavor Affinities

mint + chocolate + cream

mint + cilantro + dill

mint + cucumber + lime

mint + cucumber + vinegar

mint + cucumber + yogurt

mint + lamb + yogurt

MINT, DRIED

Taste: sweet

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate–loud

beef
bell peppers
bold-flavored foods
cheese, feta
chicken
cucumbers
duck
Eastern Mediterranean cuisine
garlic
Greek cuisine
hummus
kebabs
lamb
leeks
lemon
lentils
meats, esp. grilled
olive oil
olives
onions, red
oregano
pasta
pork
rice
soups: chicken, vegetable
tomatoes
Turkish cuisine
yogurt
zucchini



MINT, PEPPERMINT

Taste: sweet

Weight: light–medium

Volume: very loud

Tips: Mint suggests “false coolness.”

apples

berries

beverages

candies

carrots

chocolate

citrus

cream and ice cream

DESSERTS

iced desserts (e.g., granita, sorbet)

mangoes

Mediterranean cuisine

milk

strawberries

teas

AVOID

savory foods

MIREPOIX

Tips: Use as the base of stocks and soups.

French cuisine

Flavor Affinities

carrots + celery + onions

I like to add **miso** to purees because it adds a rich, buttery flavor and a rich texture. I will serve broiled oysters topped with a puree of miso, pineapple, and serrano chile. I am working on miso-avocado puree as well. It is delicious, but I just haven't found the right dish for it yet. I am also working with miso-huitlacoche soup with tofu, mushrooms, or corn.

—KATSUYA FUKUSHIMA, MINIBAR (WASHINGTON, DC)

I love **miso**. I went to a Japanese restaurant and loved the miso soup. I realized that it would give more flavor than chicken broth to my onion soup. So now I make a miso broth the night before, let it sit and separate, and use the broth for my onion soup.

—MICHEL RICHARD, CITRONELLE (WASHINGTON, DC)

I will use several different **misos**, depending on the purpose. I might use *saikyo*, a light, yellow, sweet miso, in marinades or with lighter fish like sweet shrimp and scallops that would be overwhelmed by dark miso. Barley miso is a distinctive strong, sweet miso that I'll use with nigiri with baby squid and shiso. I'll use wheat miso with foie gras. Sometimes I'll even mix misos.

—KAZ OKOCHI, KAZ SUSHI BISTRO (WASHINGTON, DC)

MISO AND MISO SOUP

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: quiet–moderate (depending on light or dark miso)

Techniques: marinades, sauces, soups

beef
chicken
duck
fish: cod, salmon
garlic
ginger
honey
Japanese cuisine
legumes
lemongrass
marinades
mirin
mushrooms
mustard
oysters
pineapple
rice, brown
sake
salad dressings
sauces
sesame oil
soups
soy sauce
steak
stews
stock, chicken
sugar
tofu
vinegar, rice

walnuts

Dishes

Roasted Duck Breast with a Red Wine–Miso Sauce

—Gabriel Kreuther, The Modern (New York City)

Alaskan Black Cod with Chinese Broccoli, Homemade Tofu, Black Seaweed, Asian Pear, Miso Broth

—Christopher Lee, Gilt (New York City)

MOLASSES

Taste: sweet, bitter

Weight: heavy

Volume: loud

apples

baked goods (e.g., cookies, pies)

barbecue sauce

beans, baked

bread, esp. brown

butter, unsalted

cinnamon

cream

ginger

gingerbread

Grand Marnier

lemon, juice

marinades

New England cuisine (e.g., Indian pudding)

orange

pancakes

plums

popcorn

raspberries

sugar, brown

vanilla

walnuts

Monkfish is great with garlic!

—ERIC RIPERT, LE BERNARDIN (NEW YORK CITY)

Dishes

Line-Caught Monkfish Loin and “Fresh Bacon” Kurobuta Pork Belly with Golden Chanterelles, Wood-Grilled Leeks, and Herb-Crusted Salsifies, Lobster Red Wine Jus

—Carrie Nahabedian, Naha (Chicago)

Sautéed Monkfish with Broccoli Rabe, Pine Nuts, and Raisins

—David Pasternak, Esca (New York City)

Roasted Monkfish with Spinach, Oyster Ravioli, Watercress Sauce

—Michel Richard, Citronelle (Washington, DC)

MONKFISH

(See also Fish—In General)

Season: autumn–winter

Weight: medium

Volume: quiet–moderate

Techniques: braise, broil, grill, poach, roast, sauté, stew

aioli

apples

apricots, dried

artichokes, Jerusalem

arugula

asparagus

bacon

basil

bay leaf

beans, white

beer, wheat

brandy

bread crumbs

butter: clarified, unsalted

cabbage: green, red, savoy

caperberries

capers

cardamom

carrots

cayenne

celery

chard

chervil

chile peppers

chili powder

chives

cider, hard

cilantro
cinnamon
clams
coriander
couscous
cream
cumin
curry powder
fennel
fennel seeds
GARLIC
ginger, fresh
leeks
LEMON: juice, zest
lemon, preserved
lemongrass
lemon thyme
lobster
Mediterranean cuisine
mushrooms, esp. chanterelles, portobello
mussels
OIL: canola, corn, peanut, vegetable
olive oil
olives, esp. green
onions, esp. yellow
orange, zest
oregano
pancetta
paprika, sweet
Parmesan cheese
parsley, flat-leaf
pesto
pepper: black, green, white
Pernod
pine nuts
pork: bacon, pork belly
potatoes, esp. new

red pepper flakes

romesco sauce

rosemary

saffron

sage

salmon

salmon, smoked

salt: kosher, sea

sausage

shallots

sherry, dry (e.g., fino)

soy sauce

spinach

squid

star anise

STOCKS AND BROTHS: chicken, clam, fish, shellfish, veal

striped bass

Swiss chard

tarragon

thyme

tomatoes

turmeric

vinaigrette

vinegar, white wine

walnuts

watercress

WINE: dry white (e.g., Gewürztraminer), or full-bodied red, dry sherry

Flavor Affinities

monkfish + aioli + new potatoes

monkfish + apples + sausage

monkfish + bacon + cabbage + potatoes

monkfish + basil + Swiss chard + thyme

monkfish + curry + mussels + saffron

monkfish + leeks + mussels

monkfish + red cabbage + pancetta

monkfish + white beans + fennel + garlic + saffron + tomatoes

MORELS

(See Mushrooms, Morels)

MOROCCAN CUISINE

almonds
apricots
bell peppers, green
chile peppers
cilantro
cinnamon
couscous
coriander
cucumbers
cumin
dates
figs
fruits
ginger
lamb
lemon, juice

LEMONS, PRESERVED

nuts
olive oil
olives
onions
paprika
pepper
pine nuts
pistachios
raisins
ras el hanout
saffron
salads
stews, aka *tagines*
sumac
tomatoes
turmeric

Flavor Affinities

chile peppers + garlic + olive oil + salt (aka harissa)

cinnamon + coriander + cumin

eggplant + cinnamon + mint

green tea + dried spearmint + sugar

lamb + cinnamon + honey + prunes

oranges + cinnamon + honey

parsley + lemon juice + olive oil

phyllo dough + almonds + cinnamon + honey

phyllo dough + honey + sesame seeds



I don't know the first thing about **Moroccan cooking** other than eating Moroccan food and owning Paula Wolfert's book [*Couscous*], but I serve a lamb dish in Moroccan spices. I braise lamb shanks in cumin, saffron, and preserved lemon, with the juice being turned into a sauce. The lamb shanks are then boned and put into a cake with eggplant and molded onto a plate. This is not Moroccan cooking per se, but it suggests the flavors of Morocco.

—**DAVID WALTUCK**, CHANTERELLE (NEW YORK CITY)

MUSHROOMS—IN GENERAL

(See also specific mushrooms)

Season: late spring–autumn

Weight: light–medium

Volume: quiet–moderate

Techniques: bake, broil, deepfry, grill, pan roast, raw (e.g., in salads), roast, sauté, soup, steam, stew

almonds

asparagus

bacon

barley

basil

bay leaf

beans: green, lima

beef

bell peppers, esp. red

bread crumbs

BUTTER, unsalted

capers

carrots

cayenne

celery

cheese: Comté, Emmental, Gruyère, Parmesan, Swiss

chervil

chestnuts

chicken

chile peppers: dried red, fresh green

chives

cilantro

cloves

cognac

coriander

crab

CREAM

crème fraîche

cumin

dill

eggs

fennel

fish

French cuisine

frisée lettuce

game

garam masala

***GARLIC**

garlic chives

ginger

grappa

ham

herbs

juniper berries

leeks

lemon: juice, zest

Madeira

marjoram

meats

milk

mirepoix

mustard, Dijon

nutmeg

OIL: canola, grapeseed, peanut, vegetable

OLIVE OIL

onions: green, pearl, red, yellow

oregano

paprika, esp. sweet

Parmesan cheese

PARSLEY, flat-leaf

pasta

peas

PEPPER: black, white

pine nuts
pork
potatoes
poultry
prosciutto
radicchio
rice
risotto
rosemary
sage
sake
SALT: fleur de sel, kosher, sea
scallions
seafood
sesame oil
SHALLOTS
sherry, dry (e.g., manzanilla)
sour cream
soy sauce
spinach
stocks: chicken, dashi, mushroom, veal
sugar
tarragon
thyme, fresh
tomatoes
truffle oil
veal
vinegar, esp. **balsamic**, red wine, **sherry**
walnuts
WINE: dry red, white, vermouth
yogurt

Flavor Affinities

mushrooms + garlic + lemon + olive oil
mushrooms + garlic + parsley
mushrooms + garlic + shallots

Dishes

Vegetarian Texas Chili: Ancho Chile Braise of Grilled Woodland Mushrooms, White Runner Beans, Green Beans, Calabacitas, Cumin, and Beer, topped with Mexican Queso Anejo and Red Onion

—Rick Bayless, Frontera Grill (Chicago)

Wild Mushroom Soup with Ramps and Croutons

—Daniel Boulud / Bertrand Chemel, Café Boulud (New York City)

Roasted Garlic Gnocchi with Wild Mushrooms, Sage, and Crispy Sweetbreads

—Gabriel Kreuther, The Modern (New York City)

Warm Mushroom Salad: Frisée, Bacon, Goat Cheese, and Sherry Vinaigrette

—Alfred Portale, Gotham Bar and Grill (New York City)

Mushroom Tart: Thin-Crust Tart Filled with Sautéed Wild Mushrooms, Celeriac Puree, and Aged Port Reduction

—Eric Ripert, Le Bernardin (New York City)

Risotto with Wild Rice, Squash, and Wild Mushrooms

—Judy Rodgers, Zuni Café (San Francisco)

Warm Wild Mushroom Spinach Salad with Chickpeas, Olives, and Preserved Lemon

—Allen Susser, Chef Allen's (Miami)

Mushroom and Asparagus Risotto with Lemon Thyme

—Jerry Traunfeld, The Herbfarm (Woodinville, Washington)

Marjoram brings up the **mushroom** flavor.

—**JERRY TRAUNFELD**, THE HERBFARM (WOODINVILLE, WASHINGTON)

Dishes

Pappardelle with Chanterelles and Thyme

—Mario Batali, Babbo (New York City)

MUSHROOMS—CHANTERELLES

Season: spring–autumn

Weight: light–medium

Volume: quiet–moderate

Techniques: bake, sauté

bay leaf

butter, unsalted

chard

cheese, Parmesan

chives (garnish)

cream

eggs and egg dishes (e.g., omelets)

game

garlic

lentils

mussels

oil, peanut

olive oil

onions, esp. green

parsley

pasta

pepper: black, white

poultry

radicchio

salt, kosher

saucés

shallots

soups

STOCKS: BEEF, CHICKEN

sweet potatoes

thyme, fresh

vinegar, sherry

wine, dry white

Flavor Affinities

chanterelles + butter + cream + garlic + parsley

chanterelles + cream + garlic + thyme

MUSHROOMS—CREMINI

Season: year-round

Weight: light–medium

Volume: quiet–moderate

arugula

butter

cheese: goat, Parmesan

chives

garlic

mascarpone

olive oil

parsley, flat-leaf

pepper, white

salt

shallots

stock, chicken

thyme

truffle oil

MUSHROOMS—MATSUTAKE

Season: autumn

Weight: medium

Volume: loud

Techniques: braise, fry, grill, sauté, simmer, steam, stir-fry

butter

cabbage, savoy

chicken

cod, black

cream

custard

dashi

fish

herbs: chervil, chives, flat-leaf parsley, tarragon

Japanese cuisine

lemon, juice

mirin

mushrooms, wild

olive oil

pepper, black

rice

sake

salt

shallots

shrimp

soup

soy sauce

stock, chicken

tempura

tofu

vinegar, rice wine

Matsutake mushrooms have a cinnamon and pine quality to them. This is a fall mushroom and works well with savoy cabbage. I like pairing luxurious ingredients with cabbage. We will roast black cod and serve it with cabbage, cream, and the matsutake.

—**JERRY TRAUNFELD**, THE HERBFARM (WOODINVILLE, WASHINGTON)

MUSHROOMS—MORELS

Season: spring (May–June)

Weight: light–medium

Volume: quiet–moderate

Techniques/Tips: Always serve cooked: boil, stew

ASPARAGUS: green, white

bacon

basil

bay leaf

BUTTER, unsalted

caraway seeds

cheese: Fontina, goat, Parmesan

chervil

chicken mousse

chives

CREAM, heavy

crème fraîche

eggs, yolks

faro

fava beans

Dishes

Organic Carnaroli Risotto with Wild Spring Morels, Wood-Grilled Ramps, Confit of Green Garlic and Spinach, Parmigiano-Reggiano, and Umbrian Olive Oil

—Carrie Nahabedian, Naha (Chicago)

Our Local Morel Pizza with Fontina Cheese, Virginia Country Ham, and Frizzled Ramps. A Warm Salad of Grilled Asparagus and Freshwater Blue Prawns with Sherry Vinaigrette

—Patrick O’Connell, The Inn at Little Washington (Washington, Virginia)

Caraway seeds bring up the flavor in **morel mushrooms**.

—JERRY TRAUNFELD, THE HERBFARM (WOODINVILLE, WASHINGTON)

fiddlehead ferns

GARLIC: regular, spring

ham: Virginia, Serrano herbs

lamb

leeks

lemon

Madeira

marjoram

mirepoix

oil, peanut

olive oil

onions, esp. spring

pancetta

paprika, sweet

parsley, flat-leaf

pasta

peas

PEPPER: black, white

pork

port

potatoes, esp. new

ramps

rosemary

SALT, kosher

sauces

savory

shallots

soufflés (e.g., goat cheese)

soy sauce

stocks: chicken, mushroom, vegetable

sweetbreads

tarragon

thyme

truffles, black

vinaigrette

vinegar, sherry

wine, Champagne

Flavor Affinities

morels + asparagus + ramps

morels + garlic + lemon + olive oil + parsley

MUSHROOMS—PORCINI / CEPES / KING BOLETE

Season: late spring–early autumn

Weight: light–medium

Volume: quiet–moderate

Techniques: grill, parboil, roast, sauté, stew

almonds

arugula

bacon

brandy

bread crumbs

butter, unsalted

carrots

cheese: Fontina, Garrotxa, **Parmesan**

chervil

chicken, esp. roasted

chives

coffee

cream / milk

crème fraîche

eggs

fennel

fish: grilled, white

French cuisine

garlic

hazelnuts

Italian cuisine

lemon, juice

Madeira

marjoram

mascarpone

mint

mushrooms, button or cremini

OIL, PORCINI

OLIVE OIL

onions

parsley, flat-leaf

pasta

Dishes

Raw Porcini with Arugula, Parmigiano, and Aceto Manadori

—Mario Batali, Babbo (New York City)

Salad of Porcini Mushrooms, Green Apple, and Garrotxa Cheese, with Hazelnut Vinaigrette

—Traci Des Jardins, Jardinière (San Francisco)

King Bolete—or **porcini**, as they are also known—are pretty sweet. I like them with a carrot puree in ravioli. The sauce for the dish will be the braising liquid from the ravioli as well as some carrot juice. The ravioli is then topped with fried sage and black currants.

—JERRY TRAUNFELD, THE HERBFARM (WOODINVILLE, WASHINGTON)

pepper, black

polenta

potatoes

prosciutto

radicchio

rice, arborio

sage

sake

salt: kosher, sea

shallots

spinach

steak

stocks: chicken, mushroom, vegetable

tamari

tarragon

thyme

tomatoes

truffles, esp. white

veal

vinegar, esp. balsamic walnuts

wine, dry white

Flavor Affinities

porcini + almonds + balsamic vinegar

porcini + arugula + lemon + Parmesan cheese

porcini + balsamic vinegar + radicchio

porcini + carrots + sage

porcini + coffee + veal

porcini + lemon juice + olive oil

porcini + parsley + tomatoes

porcini + prosciutto + spinach

MUSHROOMS—PORTOBELLO

Season: year-round

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: moderate

Techniques: broil, grill, roast, sauté, stuff

Tips: Gets firmer with longer cooking.

cheese: manchego, Parmesan, ricotta

crème fraîche garlic

lemon

mint

olive oil

pasta

polenta

spinach

thyme

tomatoes, sun-dried

Flavor Affinities

portobello mushrooms + lemon + mint + olive oil

portobello mushrooms + polenta + spinach

Dishes

Grilled Portobello with Manchego Cheese, Garlic, and Thyme Oil

—Ann Cashion, Cashion’s Eat Place (Washington, DC)

Vegetarian Sushi: Sun-Dried Tomato and Portobello Roll

—Kaz Okochi, Kaz Sushi Bistro (Washington, DC)

Gonzales Portobello Mushroom “Steak,” Texas Brown Rice and Nut Cake, Coconut-Chile Sauce

—Monica Pope, T’afia (Houston)

Pasta Salad with Sun-Dried Tomato Pesto, Portobello Mushrooms, and Grilled Squash

—Charlie Trotter, Trotter’s to Go (Chicago)

Portobello Mushrooms in Porcini Cream Curry

—Vikram Vij and Meeru Dhalwala, Vij’s (Vancouver)

Portobello Mushroom and Red Bell Pepper Curry on Paneer with Beet-Daikon Salad

—Vikram Vij and Meeru Dhalwala, Vij’s (Vancouver)

MUSHROOMS—SHIITAKE

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate

Techniques: grill, sauté, simmer, stir-fry

anchovies

asparagus

bacon

basil

bell peppers, roasted

brandy

butter: clarified, unsalted

cabbage, savoy

celery root

chicken

chile peppers

chives

cod

coriander

cream

cream cheese

eggplant

eggs, esp. hard-boiled

fish sauce

GARLIC

Japanese cuisine

leeks

lemon, juice

lemongrass

lime

mushrooms, oyster

OIL: canola, hazelnut, vegetable

olive oil

ONIONS, esp. red, white

parsley, flat-leaf

Vitaly Paley of Paley's Place in Portland, Oregon, on Cooking with Mushrooms

Mushrooms Year-Round

Spring. This is the start of the morel season. One of the reasons I came to work in Oregon was one day I was working in a kitchen in France and a box of morels arrived with a tag on it that said "Oregon."

Summer. The morels dwindle away, and we get a brief stint of porcini/cepes. Late summer is golden and white chanterelle season.

Fall. The porcini come back and we also get in matsutake mushrooms as well. We have [Pacific Northwest] black and white truffles here and the season starts in November. They are pretty flavorful but it is important to realize they are different from European truffles—not to mention a lot less expensive.

I'm not a big fan of cultivated mushrooms but I do like a few. King oyster or trumpet royal are the same mushroom and it is one of my favorites. Portobellos are also good, though they are a little '70s.

I am suspicious of some dried mushrooms you find in the supermarket only because you don't know how old they are and how much flavor they will have.

Buying and Cleaning Mushrooms

When it comes to mushrooms, every kind needs to be well cleaned because there is nothing worse than getting a mouthful of grit. I wash them all by soaking them in a bowl of water and pulling them out. The key to remember is that you want to use mushrooms soon after washing them. Don't wash them a day ahead.

For morel mushrooms, you need to know how to cook them, and slicing them up fresh and throwing them in a pan is not it. It is very important to clean them and I recommend blanching them. Fill a pot with cold water, toss in a handful of salt and then the mushrooms. Bring the pot to a boil, scoop out the mushrooms, spread them out, and lightly squeeze them dry. As you dry them, take a good look at them to make sure they are free of twigs and such.

Seasoning Mushrooms

When it comes to seasoning mushrooms, savory works across the board. The seasoning combination that I've used in my kitchen from day one is a raw parsley and garlic combination that in French is called *persillade*. After the mushrooms have been sautéed in butter or olive oil, at the last second you toss in this combination with a pinch of salt. That is all a mushroom needs most of the time!

If you are roasting porcini or king oyster mushrooms, roast them on a bed of savory or thyme for extra flavor.

pepper, black
pizza
polenta

pork
potatoes
rice, basmati
rosemary
sage
salt, kosher
shallots
soups
sorrel
soy sauce
spinach
stews
stock, chicken
tarragon
thyme
vinegar, balsamic
walnuts
wine, dry white

Flavor Affinities

shiitake mushrooms + basil + onions

MUSSELS

Season: autumn–winter

Weight: light

Volume: quiet–moderate

Techniques: bake, boil, grill, steam

bacon

basil

bass

bay leaf

beans: green, navy

bell peppers, esp. red and/or roasted

bread crumbs

butter, unsalted

capers

carrots

cayenne

celery

celery seeds

chanterelles

chervil

chile peppers, esp. jalapeño

Chinese cuisine

chives

cilantro

CLAMS and clam juice

cod

cognac

CREAM

curry powder

egg yolks

fennel

fennel seeds

French cuisine

GARLIC

ginger

ham

Italian cuisine

leeks

LEMON, juice

lemon thyme

lovage

Dishes

Mussel Soup with Cilantro and Serrano Chile Cream

—Robert Del Grande, Café Annie (Houston)

Mussels in a Spicy Sauce of Panca Peppers, Garlic, Cilantro, and Peruvian Dark Beer

—Maricel Presilla, Cucharamama (Hoboken, New Jersey)

Our Version of the Classic Portuguese Surf and Turf Braise: Pork Belly, Mussels, Potatoes, and Black Olives in a Savory Ají Panca and Dark Beer Sauce

—Maricel Presilla, Cucharamama (Hoboken, New Jersey)

Spaghetti with Mussels, Pine Nuts, Nutmeg, and Parsley

—Barton Seaver, Hook (Washington, DC)

Steamed Black Mussels, Coconut Broth, Red Curry Oil

—Rick Tramonto, Tru (Chicago)

marjoram

mayonnaise, garlic

Mediterranean cuisine

mint

monkfish

mushrooms

mustard, Dijon

nutmeg

OLIVE OIL

olives, black

ONIONS, esp. red, spring, white

orange: juice, zest

oregano

oysters

paella (key ingredient)

paprika: smoked, sweet

Parmesan cheese

PARSLEY: flat-leaf, curly

pasta

PEPPER: black, white

Pernod

pesto

pine nuts

potatoes

radicchio

red pepper flakes

rice and risotto

rosemary

SAFFRON

SALT: kosher, sea

scallions

SHALLOTS

shrimp

snapper

sole

squid

stews

stocks: chicken, clam, fish

tarragon

THYME

TOMATOES

vermouth

vinaigrette

vinegar: red wine, sherry

watercress

wild rice

WINE: dry white (e.g., Chardonnay, Pinot Blanc, Riesling, Sauvignon Blanc)

zucchini

Flavor Affinities

mussels + clams + garlic + onion + thyme + white wine

mussels + cream + curry + saffron

mussels + fennel + saffron + white wine

mussels + garlic + saffron + tomatoes

mussels + Dijon mustard + saffron

mussels + mustard + tarragon

mussels + olives + oranges

mussels + saffron + tarragon + tomatoes

MUSTARD

Taste: bitter

Function: heating

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: moderate–very loud

Tips: Add at the end of the cooking process.

Use cucumbers to cut the taste of mustard.

apples: fruit, juice

avocados

bay leaf

beef, esp. corned, grilled, or roasted

beets

cabbage

capers

cheeses (e.g., blue, cheddar, Gruyère, and other hard) and cheese dishes (e.g.,
macaroni and cheese, soufflé)

chicken

chile peppers

cold cuts

coriander

crab

cream and sour cream

cucumbers

cumin

cured meats

curries

curry leaves

dill

egg dishes

fennel

fenugreek

fish

French cuisine, esp. southern

fruits

garlic

German cuisine

gingerbread

green beans

ham

herbs

honey

Indian cuisine, as mustard seeds

Irish cuisine

Italian cuisine, esp. southern

lamb

leeks

lemon, juice

mayonnaise

meats, cold or hot

Mediterranean cuisine

mint, esp. peppermint

mostarda (mustard fruits)

mussels

oil, canola

olive oil

onions

oregano

paprika

parsley

pastrami

pepper: black, green, white

pork**potatoes**

poultry

rabbit

salads and salad dressings**salmon**

salt: kosher

saucés

sauerkraut

sausages

Scandinavian cuisine

seafood

smoked fish

soy sauce

steaks

sumac

tarragon

tomatoes

turmeric

vegetable-based dishes

vinaigrettes

vinegar: balsamic, red wine, white wine

walnuts: nuts, oil

Good cooking transcends all cultures. You can take inspiration from all around the world and apply it to what you are cooking without making it “fusion.” In some cases, you can even take a classic and make it taste better. I worked with Floyd Cardoz [chef of the Indian restaurant Tabla in New York City] and learned a lot about Indian spicing and technique from him. One technique was *turka*, which is where you fry spices in oil or ghee [Indian clarified butter] until they pop. It really opens up the flavor of the spices.

I use this cross-cultural technique when making a veal dish with a great **mustard** sauce, which is a classic French dish, and the result is not a fusion dish: Take black, yellow, and red mustard seeds and toast them in butter or olive oil until they pop; then add some shallots and vermouth and reduce it. Then, add veal stock with a splash of cream and Dijon mustard. The result is a very complex sauce with a much deeper flavor, versus simply combining some cream and mustard together in the pan.

—ANDREW CARMELLINI, A VOCE (NEW YORK CITY)

Flavor Affinities

mustard + curry leaves + cumin

mustard + garlic + oil + shallots + vinegar

mustard + garlic + oil + vinegar

mustard + oil + shallots + vinegar

MUSTARD GREENS

(See Greens, Mustard)

Tarragon leads me to **mustard** which leads me to shellfish—which leads me to mussels. The combination of the three is delicious.

—MICHAEL ANTHONY, GRAMERCY TAVERN (NEW YORK CITY)



NECTARINES

(See also Peaches)

Season: late spring–early autumn

Taste: sweet

Weight: light–medium

Volume: moderate

Techniques: bake, broil, grill, poach, raw, sauté

allspice

almonds, esp. toasted

apricots

beverages, esp. cocktails

blackberries

blueberries

brandy

butter, unsalted

buttermilk

caramel

Champagne

cherries

chicken

chocolate

cinnamon

cranberries

cream and ice cream

custard

desserts and dessert sauces

figs

ginger, esp. fresh

hazelnuts

honey

Kirsch

lemon: juice, zest

maple syrup

mascarpone
milk, sweetened condensed
mint (garnish)
nutmeg
oatmeal
onions
orange, juice
orange liqueur
peaches
peach liqueur (e.g., schnapps)
pecans
pepper, black
pistachios
plums (compatible fruit)
pork
raspberries
salads, fruit
salsas, fruit
soups, esp. chilled
sour cream
strawberries
SUGAR: brown, white
vanilla
vinegar, cider
WINE: red, fruity, sweet, or white: Merlot, Moscato d'Asti, Muscat, Rosé,
Sauternes, Vin Santo, Zinfandel
yogurt

NORTH AFRICAN CUISINE

(See also Moroccan Cuisine)

allspice

cinnamon

coriander

couscous

cumin

garlic, esp. in Egypt

ginger

lemons, preserved

meats, esp. grilled

onions

paprika

pepper, black

saffron

salads

spices, esp. in Morocco

turmeric

vegetables

Dishes

Roasted Nectarine Custard Cake with Ice Wine Sorbet and Warm Berry Compote

—Dominique and Cindy Duby, Wild Sweets (Vancouver)

**New Orleans Nectar Soda “Snow Cone” with Stewed Nectarines and Fresh Raspberries
—and Drizzle of Sweetened Condensed Milk**

—Bob Iacovone, Cuvée (New Orleans)

NUTMEG

Season: autumn–winter

Taste: sweet

Botanical relative: mace

Weight: light–medium

Volume: loud

Tips: Use in moderation.

allspice

apples

baked dishes (e.g., biscuits, cakes, pies)

beef: braised, raw

berries

beverages (e.g., chocolate, eggnog)

broccoli

butter

cabbage

cakes

cardamom

Caribbean cuisine

carrots

cauliflower

CHEESE (ESP. RICOTTA) AND CHEESE DISHES

chicken

chickpeas

Chinese cuisine

chocolate

chowders (e.g., fish)

cinnamon

cloves

cookies

coriander

CREAM / MILK

cumin

custards

DESSERTS

EGGNOG

eggs

fish

French cuisine

fruits: dried, fresh

German cuisine

ginger

goat

Greek cuisine

green beans

hazelnuts

honey

Indian cuisine

Italian cuisine, esp. sauces

jerk pastes, e.g., Caribbean

lamb, esp. braised

Latin American cuisine

lemon, juice

MACE

meats (e.g., meatballs)

Middle Eastern cuisine

milk-based dishes

mushrooms

nuts

onions

oranges

parsnips

pasta and pasta sauces

pastries

pâtés

pears

pepper

pork

potatoes

puddings

pumpkin

quatre épices (ingredient, with cloves, ginger, and white pepper)

raisins

RICE

saucers: béchamel, white

sausages

Scandinavian cuisine

seafood

shellfish, shrimp

soufflés

soups

sour cream

Southeast Asian cuisine

SPINACH**squash, winter**

stuffing

succotash

sugar, esp. brown

sweet potatoes

thyme

tomatoes and tomato sauces

vanilla

veal

wine (e.g., mulled)

yogurt

Flavor Affinities

nutmeg + allspice + cinnamon

nutmeg + cloves + cream

nutmeg + cloves + ginger + white pepper (*quatre épices*)

nutmeg + cream + spinach

NUTS—IN GENERAL

(See also Pecans, Walnuts, etc.)

Weight: heavy

Volume: moderate (varies by nut)

Tips: Always toast nuts before using to enhance flavor and texture.

Marcel Desaulniers of The Trellis in Williamsburg, Virginia, on Nuts

We use a great deal of nuts at the restaurant. On our fall menu, we have nuts in six out of ten entrées. Using nuts has always been one of my hallmarks in terms of adding texture to everything from a salad or soup to entrées and desserts. This philosophy hasn't changed much since 1987 when I opened. I can't think of a nut that doesn't, in essence, work in both sweet and savory dishes.

Dishes from The Trellis in Williamsburg Featuring Nuts

Jumbo Lump Crab Cakes with Grilled Jumbo Asparagus and Toasted Macadamia Nuts

Grilled Chicken Breast with StoneGround Grits Cake, Toasted Peanuts, and Spicy Peanut Sauce

Chicken Salad: Diced Fresh Chicken Breast, Granny Smith Apples, Pecans, Celery, Raisins, and Mayonnaise on Toasted Buttermilk Bread, Served with Mesclun Greens

Pan-Seared Sea Scallops and Sautéed Shrimp with Country Ham, Shiitakes, Roasted Shallots, and Pecan-Studded Basmati Rice

Spinach Fettuccine with Smoked Tomatoes, Artichokes, Melted Sweet Onions, Fresh Herbs, Toasted Pine Nuts, and Black Pepper Butter

Chunk Light Tuna with Seedless Grapes, Chopped Walnuts, and Mayonnaise on Toasted Whole Wheat Bread Garnished with Watercress, Grapes, and Walnuts

I love **nuts**, and put them in everything. I find that almost all nuts pair well with a lot of different things. When I am creating a dessert, I will choose my nuts geographically. For example, if I am making a Sicilian dessert, I'll use pistachios because that is the nut they would use [in Sicily].

—GINA DEPALMA, BABBO (NEW YORK CITY)

The quality of chopped **nuts** can never compare with the quality of whole nuts. In 26 years, we have never bought chopped pecans because the quality is so

different, despite the fact that it would be a lot less expensive.

I recommend simply chopping by hand or, in the case of something like a pecan, breaking it with your fingers. Pecans have so much moisture that if you chop them, you lose what is special about their texture. People tend to put nuts into the food processor and the next thing you know, you have powder and not pieces.

We always toast our **nuts**, 100 percent of the time. Nuts absorb a lot of moisture, so by toasting them you dry them out and heighten the flavor. You do need to be careful, because they burn so easily. Slower roasting is better. With a nut like a cashew, you want to roast them at 325 degrees to get them to be a nice, golden brown.

—**MARCEL DESAULNIERS**, THE TRELLIS (WILLIAMSBURG, VIRGINIA)

Always toast **nuts** to bring up the flavor. If you don't toast the nuts before adding them to a dish, they tend to come out soggy when the dish is done. The one exception would be if they are going on top of a tart going into the oven, because then they would be overtoasted.

Nuts work great in adding texture, especially to creamy and/or moussey desserts. The other way to balance out richness is with some phyllo dough.

—**EMILY LUCHETTI**, FARALLON (SAN FRANCISCO)

Juicing **nuts** is the new thing we are doing. We'll juice almonds, hazelnuts, and —best of all—pine nuts, which comes out like pine nut butter. Juicing pine nuts is better than grinding them, because it pulverizes their fat. We put that on some local green beans with preserved lemon zest, to serve with spring onions with lamb.

—**ANDREW CARMELLINI**, A VOCE (NEW YORK CITY)

Lavender works well with all sorts of **nuts**, including almonds, hazelnuts, pistachios, and walnuts. The one nut it doesn't work well with is chestnuts.

—**JERRY TRAUNFELD**, THE HERBFARM (WOODINVILLE, WASHINGTON)

OATMEAL / OATS

Taste: sweet

Function: heating

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: quiet

Techniques: simmer

almonds

apples

apricots

bananas

blueberries

brandy

breakfast

butter, unsalted

buttermilk

caramel

cherries

chocolate, esp. dark, white

cider

cinnamon

coconut

coffee

cranberries

cream

currants

dates

figs, dried

ginger

hazelnuts

honey

lemon

maple syrup

mascarpone

milk
nectarines
orange
peaches
peanuts
pears
pecans
persimmons
pine nuts
plums
prunes
pumpkin
raisins
raspberries
rhubarb
rum, dark
salt (pinch)
strawberries
SUGAR: brown, white
sweet potatoes
vanilla
walnuts
yogurt

Flavor Affinities

oatmeal + currants + maple syrup
oatmeal + pears + vanilla + yogurt

Dishes

Cherry-Almond Granola with Greek Yogurt and Vanilla Honey

—Daniel Humm, Eleven Madison Park (New York City)

Steel-Cut Oats, Devon Cream, Cinnamon Toast, and Cider-Roasted Apples

—Daniel Humm, Eleven Madison Park (New York City)

Grown-Up Oatmeal Soufflé Served with Maple Syrup and Rum-Soaked Currants

—Patrick O’Connell, The Inn at Little Washington (Washington, Virginia)

OCTOPUS

Weight: medium

Volume: quiet–moderate

Techniques: grill, simmer, stew

chile peppers, jalapeño

chives

chorizo

dashi

garlic

ginger

lemon, juice

mint

olive oil

onions, red

orange, juice

pepper, black

potatoes

red pepper flakes

sake

salt, sea

soy sauce

tamarind

tangerine

tomatoes and tomato sauce

vinegar: champagne, red wine

wine, red

Flavor Affinities

octopus + chorizo + lemon

octopus + jalapeño peppers + mint

octopus + orange + potatoes

octopus + sake + sea salt

OIL, ALMOND

Weight: light

Volume: quiet

Techniques: bake, raw

almonds

asparagus

baked goods

chicken

Chinese cuisine

duck

fish

Indian cuisine

mustard

pasta

romaine

salads

sauces

smoked salmon

vegetables

vinaigrettes

vinegar, champagne

I like **almond oil** with asparagus salad.

—**DANIEL HUMM**, ELEVEN MADISON PARK (NEW YORK CITY)

I'll poach everything from saddle of rabbit to guinea fowl to fish—from sturgeon, which holds up nicely, to New Zealand snapper to John Dory—in **avocado oil**. It gives an incredible texture and depth of flavor. I also like it with vegetarian dishes. I use it in dressings, and it seems to hold an emulsion really well. It has a nice affinity with tomato; I have made tomato water with chardonnay vinegar and avocado oil, and it makes beautiful light dressing. It also goes well with citrus like lemon, lime, or orange. Just like you like to

squeeze some citrus over avocado, avocado oil works the same way in reverse.

—**BRAD FARMERIE**, PUBLIC (NEW YORK CITY)

OIL, AVOCADO

Weight: light

Volume: quiet

Techniques: emulsify, fry, grill, raw, roast, salads, sauté, stir-fry

arugula

asparagus

avocados

basil

chile peppers

corn

cucumber

emulsions

fish

garlic

grapefruit

guinea fowl

lemon, juice

lime, juice

melon

orange, juice

pasta

rabbit

salads and salad dressings

salmon

scallops

seafood

shrimp

squid

thyme

tomatoes and tomato water

tuna

vegetables

vegetarian dishes

vinegar: balsamic, chardonnay, white wine
zucchini

Flavor Affinities

avocado oil + chardonnay vinegar + tomato water

OIL, CANOLA

Taste: neutral

Weight: light

Volume: quiet

Techniques: bake, sauté

salads and salad dressings

AVOID

deep-fry

OIL, GRAPESEED

Taste: neutral

Weight: light

Volume: quiet

Techniques: fry, raw, sauté

coconut

marinades

salads and salad dressings

sautéed dishes

vinegar

OIL, HAZELNUT

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: moderate–loud

Techniques: raw

Tips: Avoid cooking, as it burns easily.

apples

artichokes

broccoli

cheese, fresh

desserts (e.g., candy, cookies)

figs

fish

greens, bitter

hazelnuts

lemon, juice

pastries

pears

persimmons

salads and salad dressings

sauces

spinach

squab

vinaigrettes

vinegars, esp. balsamic, cider, fruity

wild rice

Hazelnut oil gets mixed with cider vinegar; that is a great natural marriage. This gets tossed in our baby winter spinach with mixed herbs and frisée salad. The toasted nut quality mixes well with bitter greens.

—MICHAEL ANTHONY, GRAMERCY TAVERN (NEW YORK CITY)

Hazelnut oil is a wonderful autumn oil. We will use it in a dark balsamic

vinaigrette served with squab. It is also very good with broccoli. If you make a broccoli soup, use this along with toasted hazelnuts. It is a delicious combination.

—**DANIEL HUMM**, ELEVEN MADISON PARK (NEW YORK CITY)

OIL, MACADAMIA NUT

Weight: light–medium

Volume: moderate–loud

Techniques: bake, roast

fruit salads, esp. with tropical fruits

Hawaiian cuisine

macadamia nuts

rice salads

sauces

OIL, OLIVE
(See Olive Oil)

OIL, PEANUT

Weight: light

Volume: quiet–moderate

Techniques: fry, raw, salads, stir-fry

Asian cuisines

Chinese cuisine

cooking

fruits and fruit salads

garlic

ginger

lentils

meats

peanuts

salad dressings, esp. Asian, fruit

soy sauce

vinegars, esp. balsamic, malt

OIL, PECAN

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: moderate–loud

Techniques: bake, marinade

bread

fish

meat

pasta

rice

salads and salad dressings

vegetables

OIL, PISTACHIO

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate

Techniques: bake

asparagus

avocado

beets

bread

fish

mayonnaise

meat

pasta

salads and salad dressings

tuna

Pistachio oil beautifully complements tuna and asparagus in our dish Big Eye Tuna Thinly Sliced with Provence White Asparagus and Montegotterro Pistachio Oil.

—**DANIEL HUMM**, ELEVEN MADISON PARK (NEW YORK CITY)

OIL, PORCINI

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate

Techniques: raw

bread

cheese

mushrooms, esp. porcini

pasta

risotto

salads and salad dressings

sauces

stews

OIL, PUMPKIN SEED

Weight: light

Volume: quiet

Tips: Use to finish a dish, not to cook.

beef, rare

citrus

corn

desserts

ice cream

maple syrup

mustard, Dijon

pastries

pumpkin seeds

rice

soups

squash, winter

vinegar: balsamic, cider, rice wine

OIL, SESAME

Function: heating

Weight: light–medium

Volume: moderate–loud (light to dark versions)

Techniques: raw

Tips: Add as a flavoring to raw or cooked dishes.

Asian cuisine

beef

cabbage, napa

chicken

chili powder

Chinese cuisine

fish

fruit salads

garlic

ginger

greens, esp. Asian

honey

Japanese cuisine

Korean cuisine

lemon, juice

lemongrass

lime, juice

marinades

meats

miso soup

mustard

noodles

oil, vegetable (compatible oil)

orange

pepper, black

salads and salad dressings, esp. Asian

salt

sauces
scallions
sesame seeds
shallots
shiso
soy sauce
stir-fried dishes
tahini
tuna
vegetables
vinegar: cider, rice wine

Flavor Affinities

sesame oil + ginger + mustard + rice wine vinegar

[Pumpkin seed oil] is good for finishing dishes with just a little drizzle. We have even poured it over ice cream that is served with a pumpkin seed brittle.

—**BRAD FARMERIE**, PUBLIC (NEW YORK CITY)

Truffle oil is one of those ingredients that really gets overused, so one day I decided that I wanted to do truffle oil right. We make a dressing of truffle oil, white balsamic vinegar, and whole grain mustard. We toss it over endive, crumbled blue cheese, spicy pecans, and raw cremini mushrooms. You just can't stop eating it!

—**MONICA POPE**, T'AFIA (HOUSTON)

OIL, TRUFFLE

Weight: light

Volume: moderate–loud

Techniques: raw

cheese

eggs

fish

mushrooms

pasta

risotto

salads and salad dressings

Dishes

Endive and Mushroom Salad, Blue Cheese, Spicy Pecans, White Balsamic–White Truffle Vinaigrette

—Monica Pope, T’afia (Houston)

OIL, WALNUT

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate

Techniques: raw

Tips: Avoid cooking as it burns easily.

apples

baked goods

beets

bread

cheese, fresh

chicory

figs

fish, esp. grilled

frisée

greens, bitter

meats, esp. grilled

pasta

pears

persimmons

potatoes

SALADS AND SALAD DRESSINGS

sauces

steaks

vinaigrettes

vinegar: balsamic, fruit, **red wine**, sherry, tarragon

walnuts

OKRA

Season: summer–autumn

Function: cooling

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: moderate

Techniques: boil, braise, deepfry, fry, grill, sauté, steam, stew

bell peppers, esp. red

butter

cayenne

chicken

chile peppers, fresh green

cilantro

coriander

corn and cornmeal

Creole cuisine

cumin

curry powder

fennel seeds

garlic

ginger, fresh

gumbo

ham

Indian cuisine

LEMON, juice

lime, juice

Mediterranean cuisine

Moroccan cuisine

mustard seeds

oil: peanut, vegetable

onions, esp. red

parsley, flat-leaf

peas, black-eyed

rice

salt, kosher

seafood

shrimp

soups

Southern cuisine (American)

TOMATOES

turmeric

vinegar

yogurt

OLIVE OIL

Weight: medium

Volume: quiet–loud

Techniques: cook, fry, raw, salads, sauces

almonds

anchovies

On Selecting the Right Oil

Your choice of olive oil always depends on what you are using it for. In general, you don't want an oil that is super-assertive, green, or peppery. You want a good olive flavor. I use a 100 percent Italian blend. It is silly to cook with 100 percent extra-virgin olive oil if you are just sautéing something. If the oil is going to stay in what you are making, like a sauce, then start with extra-virgin olive oil. When I make a tomato sauce, that is what I am starting with.

If you are finishing a dish, that is also when you would use an assertive, more full-flavored **oil**. I also like to use nut oils, especially those made by Jean Leblanc. They are insane; his oils are so good that after you taste them, nothing else will do! I especially like to use nut oils in the fall. I use walnut oil dressing on salads, especially those salads that accompany meat. If you make a foie gras dish with apples and endive, an addition of walnut oil would be great.

—ANDREW CARMELLINI, A VOCE (NEW YORK CITY)

Olive oil comes in a wide variety of flavors and strengths even from the same region, much like wine:

- I use a heavier (e.g., Puglian, Umbrian, Sicilian) olive oil on biggerflavored dishes. A strong olive oil goes well on bean puree or a strong vegetable like dandelion greens. In the United States, you would put a barbecue sauce on a grilled meat; in Italy, you would use a strong olive oil.
- I use a lighter (e.g., Ligurian, Tuscan) olive oil on lighter meats like veal or fish dishes and pastas. A Ligurian olive is full and bright and is great on a lighter dish.

—ODETTE FADA, SAN DOMENICO (NEW YORK CITY)

- I like to use single varietal **olive oil** from Australia and New Zealand. Australian olive oils can be like their wines: big, pungent, and spicy. New Zealand oils have a little more depth of flavor and green grassiness.

—BRAD FARMERIE, PUBLIC (NEW YORK CITY)



I like Greek black **olives** the best. I like them by themselves, but they also work great in a chicken, duck, or lamb dish.

—**GABRIEL KREUTHER**, THE MODERN (NEW YORK CITY)

Olives have such a strong flavor that they can overwhelm other ingredients, but salmon will stand right up to it.

—**MICHEL RICHARD**, CITRONELLE (WASHINGTON, DC)

beans, white

chickpeas

fish

French cuisine, southern

garlic

herbs

hummus

Italian cuisine

meats

Mediterranean cuisine

Middle Eastern cuisine

Moroccan cuisine

olives

Parmesan cheese

pasta

pepper, black

salads and salad dressings

salt

soups

Spanish cuisine

thyme

vegetables

vinegar

OLIVES

Taste: salty

Weight: light–medium

Volume: quiet–loud (depending on type)

almonds

anchovies

basil

bass

bay leaf

bell peppers, esp. red

brandy

bread

butter

capers

cayenne

cheese: feta, goat's milk

chicken

cognac

cream cheese

cumin

fish

French cuisine, esp. Provençal

GARLIC

Italian cuisine

lamb

LEMON: juice, zest

meats

Mediterranean cuisines

Moroccan cuisine

olive oil

onions, esp. red

orange: juice, zest

oregano

parsley, flat-leaf

pasta

pepper: black, white

peppers, piquillo

Pernod

pine nuts

red pepper flakes

rosemary

sage

salads and salad dressings

salmon

salt: kosher, sea

sambuca

scallions

scallops

shallots

Spanish cuisine

thyme

tomatoes: regular, sun-dried

tuna

veal

vinegar: red wine, sherry

wine, dry white

Dishes

Olive and Anchovy Tapenade with Sage Crackers

—Monica Pope, T'afia (Houston)

OMELETS

(See Eggs and Eggbased Dishes)

ONIONS—IN GENERAL

Season: year-round

Taste: pungent (+ sweet with cooking via caramelization)

Botanical relatives: chives, garlic, leeks, shallots

Function: heating

Weight: light–medium

Volume: moderate–loud

Techniques: bake, boil, braise, deep-fry, fry, grill, roast, sauté, stir-fry

Tips: Onions increase appetite, and go with virtually all savory foods.

anchovies

apples

bacon

basil

bay leaf

beans

beef, ground, e.g., hamburgers, meat loaf

beer

beets

bell peppers

brandy

bread: croutons, crumbs BUTTER, UNSALTED

caraway seeds

cardamom

carrots

cayenne

cheese: cheddar, Comté, Emmental, *fromage blanc*, goat, Gruyère, Parmesan, Swiss

The **onion** family is the basis for every cuisine I can think of. Of course, Asian cuisines use more green onions and garlic, while the French use more shallots and garlic, but it's the onion family providing the foundation.

—TONY LIU, AUGUST (NEW YORK CITY)

You can't cook without **onions**. There is not a single thing you can do without onions. There are so many things made with onions that when people come in to our restaurant and say that they are allergic to onions, I say, "No, you are not—it is impossible. You just don't like onions." People eat onions all the time and just don't know it. I remember having a conversation with [the artist] Jasper Johns, with him saying, "If truffles and onions cost the same amount of money, you would obviously choose an onion. You don't need truffles; you do need onions."

—**DAVID WALTUCK**, CHANTERELLE (NEW YORK CITY)

I roast **onions** a long, long time and use them to add a meaty flavor to soups.

—**MICHEL RICHARD**, CITRONELLE (WASHINGTON, DC)

Your cooking technique alters your flavors a great deal. If you put a lot of **onions** in your curry but don't sauté them enough first, you will get a sweet flavor. If you sauté the onions until they are almost burnt but not quite, your curry will have more of a roasted-toasted flavor.

—**VIKRAM VIJ**, VIJ'S (VANCOUVER)

chile peppers, esp. jalapeño

chili

cilantro

cinnamon

cloves

coriander

cream / milk

crème fraîche

cucumbers

cumin seeds

curry

dill

dips

eggs, e.g., omelets

garlic

greens, bitter

hamburgers
honey
lemon, juice
lime, juice
liver
mace
mangoes, esp. with red onions
marjoram

meats

milk
mint (e.g., Indian)
mirepoix (key ingredient)
mushrooms
mustard, Dijon

NUTMEG

OIL: canola, peanut, sesame, vegetable

olive oil
olives, black
orange, juice
oregano
paprika
Parmesan cheese
parsley, flat-leaf
peas

pepper: black, white

ponzu sauce
pork
potatoes
poultry
raisins, esp. golden
rice

rosemary

saffron

sage

salads

SALT: *fleur de sel*, kosher, sea
sandwiches

sauces and gravies

savory

soups

sour cream

stews

stocks: beef, chicken, veal

sugar (pinch)

Tabasco sauce

THYME, lemon

tomatoes

vegetables

vinegar: balsamic, champagne, red wine, sherry, white wine

wine: dry red, white, port

Dishes

Roasted Vidalia Onion Stuffed with Walnuts, Wild Rice, and Roquefort Served with Wilted Arugula, Fava Beans, and Vegetable Demi-Glace

—Peter Nowakoski, Rat's (Hamilton, New Jersey)

Flavor Affinities

onions + balsamic vinegar + brown sugar

onions + beer + cheese + nutmeg

onions + garlic + thyme

ONIONS, SWEET

(e.g., Vidalia)

Season: late spring–early summer

Taste: sweet

Weight: light–medium

Volume: quiet–moderate

basil

cayenne

chard

cheese: blue (e.g., Cabrales, Maytag), goat, Parmesan

chives

cilantro

ginger, fresh

herbs

lettuces

mint

nutmeg

olive oil

pine nuts

salads

salt

sandwiches

Tabasco sauce

tomatoes

vinegar: rice, sherry

yogurt

Flavor Affinities

Vidalia onions + goat cheese + tomatoes + sherry vinegar

ORANGES—IN GENERAL

Season: year-round

Taste: sour, sweet

Function: heating

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate–loud

Techniques: poach, raw

Tips: Lemon brightens the flavor of orange.

almonds

anise seeds

Dishes

Baked Chocolate Mousse with Mandarin Oranges and Anise Seed Croustillant

—Dominique and Cindy Duby, Wild Sweets (Vancouver)

Orange and Basil Soup, Alpine Strawberry Compote, and Mascarpone Mousse

—Dominique and Cindy Duby, Wild Sweets (Vancouver)

Candied Orange Sponge with Poached Rhubarb and Cream Cheese Mousse

—François Payard, Payard Patisserie and Bistro (New York City)

Orange Tart with Carrot Cake and Mandarin

—François Payard, Payard Patisserie and Bistro (New York City)



I like **orange zest** with crab and shrimp because it gives them a sunny flavor. Lemon and lime are too strong. Orange is feminine—the lady of citrus—while lemon and lime are the men!

—MICHEL RICHARD, CITRONELLE (WASHINGTON, DC)

I use liqueurs such as [**orange-flavored**] Grand Marnier to bring out the flavors of other ingredients. When it's done right, you don't even know it is there.

—EMILY LUCHETTI, FARALLON (SAN FRANCISCO)

Orange and pomegranate season overlap in the fall, making these two fruits a natural pairing.

—**JOSÉ ANDRÉS**, CAFÉ ATLÁNTICO (WASHINGTON, DC)

apples

apricots

Armagnac

arugula

avocados

bananas

basil

beets

blackberries

blueberries

brandy

buttermilk

caramel

cardamom

carrots

ceviche

cheese: goat, ricotta

cherries

chestnuts

chicken

chile peppers, esp. serrano

chives

CHOCOLATE: dark, white cilantro

cinnamon

cloves

coconut

coffee

cognac

crabs

cranberries

cream and ice cream

crust: pastry, pie

cumin

custard

dates

desserts

fennel

figs: dried, fresh

fish

game

garlic

ginger

grapefruit

greens

grenadine syrup

guava

hazelnuts

honey

ices

juniper berries

Italian cuisine

Kirsch

kumquats

LEMON: juice, zest

lemongrass

lettuce, romaine

lime

lime leaf, kaffir

liqueurs, almond

macadamia nuts

mangoes

maple syrup

mascarpone

meats

melon

meringue

MINT

nectarines

oats

olive oil

olives, black

ONIONS, esp. green, red

orange, zest

orange liqueurs: Cointreau, Grand Marnier

papaya

paprika

parsley, flat-leaf

passion fruit

peaches

pears

pecans

pepper, black

persimmons

pineapple

pine nuts

pistachios

plums

pomegranates

poppy seeds

pork, roast

port

prunes

pumpkin

quince

raisins

raspberries

rhubarb

rice

rosemary

rum

saffron

salads, fruit and green

salt

saucers

scallops

shrimp

squash, winter (e.g., butternut)

star anise

strawberries

SUGAR: brown, white

sweet potatoes

tea

thyme

tomatoes

vanilla

veal

vinegar, esp. rice wine, sherry

walnuts

watercress

wine: red, sweet, white

yogurt

Flavor Affinities

orange + anise + chocolate

orange + anise + dried figs + walnuts

orange + basil + sugar

orange + chocolate + pistachios

orange + cinnamon + honey + saffron

orange + seafood + tarragon

ORANGES, BLOOD

Season: winter–late spring

Taste: sour–sweet

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate

caramel
Champagne
chocolate, white
cinnamon
cloves
cream
grapefruit
honey
kumquats
lemon
mint
pomegranates
salads
sugar, brown
tarts
vanilla

ORANGES, CLEMENTINE
(See Oranges, Mandarin)

Dishes

Blood Orange–Vanilla Creamsicle

—Emily Luchetti, pastry chef, Farallon (San Francisco)

Dishes

Chocolate and Tangerine Semifreddo Garnished with Chopped Pistachios

—Gina DePalma, pastry chef, Babbo (New York City)

ORANGES, MANDARIN

(includes Clementines and Tangerines)

Season: autumn–spring

Taste: sweet, sour

Weight: light–medium

Volume: moderate

almonds

apricots

bananas

Campari

caramel

chicken

Chinese cuisine (e.g., as dessert)

chives

chocolate, esp. dark

cream and ice cream

crème anglaise

cumin

custard

dates

desserts

duck

fish

garlic

ginger

grapefruit

hazelnuts and hazelnut oil

honey

kumquats

lavender

LEMON JUICE

lemongrass

lemon verbena

lettuces
lime
lime leaf, kaffir
liqueurs, orange
mascarpone
melon
mint
olive oil
onions, green
oranges and blood oranges
passion fruit
pistachios
pomegranates
raspberries
rosemary
rum, esp. dark
salads
salt
scallops
seafood
sesame oil
shellfish (e.g., crab)
shrimp
sugar
vinegar: champagne, rice, white wine
yogurt

Avoid **oregano** with desserts. Oregano firmly belongs in savory cuisine; one taste, and it immediately calls to mind pizza sauce!

—GINA DEPALMA, BABBO (NEW YORK CITY)

OREGANO

Season: late autumn–late spring

Botanical relative: marjoram (milder in flavor than oregano)

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: moderate–loud

Tips: Oregano can have great variability, i.e., from mild to hot and spicy (e.g., Italian oregano is “quieter” than Greek oregano).

anchovies

artichokes

arugula

basil

beans, esp. dried and/or white

beef

BELL PEPPERS

broccoli

broths

capers

cheese and cheese dishes: feta, mozzarella, Parmesan

chicken

chile peppers, esp. piquillo

chili con carne, esp. Mexican oregano

chili powder

chives

cucumbers

cumin

duck

eggs and egg dishes

eggplant

FISH, esp. oilier, and esp. baked or grilled

garlic

Greek cuisine

greens, bitter

grilled dishes

hamburgers

Italian cuisine

lamb

***LEMON**

marjoram

MEATS, esp. red and/or grilled, and meat-based dishes

Mediterranean cuisine

Mexican cuisine

mint (say some)

mole sauces, esp. with Mexican oregano

mushrooms

olive oil

olives

onions

paprika

parsley

PASTA AND PASTA SAUCES

pepper, black

PIZZA

pork

potatoes

poultry

quail

rabbit

roasts

rosemary

sage

salads and salad dressings, esp. Greek

sauces

sausages

seafood

shellfish

shrimp

soups, esp. chicken, fish, vegetable

Spanish cuisine

squash, summer

squid

stews

stuffing

swordfish

Tex-Mex cuisine

thyme

***TOMATOES AND TOMATO SAUCES**

veal

vegetables, esp. summer

vinaigrettes

vinegar

zucchini

AVOID

cilantro

desserts

dill

mint (say some)

tarragon

Flavor Affinities

oregano + basil + tomato

oregano + lemon juice + marjoram

If you come to Chanterelle during November and December, you will see **oysters** with white truffles when they are both in season and they are classics for this restaurant.

—**DAVID WALTUCK**, CHANTERELLE (NEW YORK CITY)

Dishes

Oysters Served with Tomatillo-Habanero “Miñoneta,” Smoky Chipotle-Garlic Salsa and Fresh-Cut Limes

—Rick Bayless, Frontera Grill (Chicago)

Oysters on the Half Shell with Champagne Mignonette and Fresh Horseradish

—Traci Des Jardins, Jardinière (San Francisco)

OXTAILS

(See Beef)

OYSTERS

Season: autumn–spring (aka “months containing the letter *r*”)

Taste: salty

Weight: light–heavy (e.g., light Kumamotos to heavy Gulf Coast oysters)

Volume: quiet–moderate

Techniques: bake, broil, deep-fry, grill, poach, raw, roast, sauté, steam

aioli

apples

asparagus

bacon

basil

bay leaf

beer / ale

beets

bread, esp. dark

bread crumbs, *panko*

butter, unsalted

Cajun cuisine

capers

caviar

cayenne

celery

Champagne

chervil

chili sauce

chives

cilantro

clams

cocktail sauce

cornmeal (for crust)

CREAM

crème fraîche

Creole cuisine

cucumbers
daikon
fennel
flour (for dredging)
French cuisine
garlic
gazpacho
ginger
hollandaise sauce
horseradish
lavender
LEEKS
LEMON: juice, zest
lemon verbena
lime, juice
mint
mushrooms, wild
OIL: canola, peanut, vegetable
olive oil
olives
onions, Spanish
orange
oyster juice
paprika
parsley, flat-leaf
passion fruit
PEPPER: black, white
ponzu sauce
potatoes
risotto
saffron
sake
salmon, smoked
SALT: kosher, sea
sauces: cocktail, mignonette
scallions
sea urchin

seaweed

SHALLOTS

shiso leaf

shrimp

sorrel

sour cream

Southern cuisine

soy sauce

spinach

stocks: chicken, clam, fish, vegetable

sugar (pinch)

Tabasco sauce

tapioca

thyme

tomatoes: flesh, juice

truffles: black, white

vermouth

VINEGAR: balsamic, **champagne**, red wine, rice, sherry

WINE, dry white

yuzu juice

AVOID

tarragon

Flavor Affinities

oysters + caviar + leeks

oysters + caviar + tapioca

oysters + clams + potatoes + thyme

oysters + cream + horseradish + onions

oysters + ginger + horseradish + sherry vinegar

oysters + horseradish + champagne vinegar

oysters + Muscadet + shallots + vinegar

oysters + shallots + vinegar

PANCETTA

Taste: salty

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate

Techniques: fry

arugula

beans

butter

cheese: fontina, **Parmesan**

garlic

Italian cuisine

lentils

meats

olive oil

onions

parsley

parsnips

PASTA

peas

pepper, black

pistachios

poultry

SAUCES

tomatoes

vegetables

PAPAYAS

Season: summer–autumn

Taste: sweet

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate

Techniques: bake, grill, raw, sauté

bananas

beverages (e.g., smoothies) caramel

cashews

carrots, esp. with green

chile peppers: jalapeño, serrano

chocolate, white

cilantro

cinnamon

citrus fruits

coconut: meat, milk

cream and ice cream

curries

fish sauce

garlic, esp. with green papayas

ginger

grapefruit

honey

kiwi fruit

kumquats

lemon, juice

LIME, juice

macadamia nuts

mango

marinades

melon

mint

nectarines

orange

passion fruit

peaches

peanuts

pepper, black

pineapple

port

prosciutto

raspberries

salads, fruit

salsa

salt, esp. with green

shrimp, esp. dried with green papaya

sorbet

soups

sour cream

strawberries

sugar

vanilla

vinegar: rice, white wine

yogurt

PAPRIKA—IN GENERAL

Taste: sweet–hot, depending on variety (e.g., hot, sweet, smoked, etc.)

Weight: light

Volume: quiet–loud

Tips: Add at the beginning of the cooking process.

allspice

barbecue

beef

bell peppers

butter, unsalted

Cajun cuisine

caraway seeds

cardamom

cauliflower

cheese

CHICKEN, esp. baked or

paprikash

chili

crabs

cream

crème fraîche

curries

duck

eggs, esp. hard-boiled and egg dishes (e.g., omelets)

European cuisines

fish, esp. baked

garlic

ginger

goulash (key ingredient)

hummus

Hungarian cuisine

Indian cuisine

lamb

legumes
lemon, juice
marjoram
meats
Middle Eastern cuisine
Moroccan cuisine
mushrooms
octopus
olive oil
onions
oregano
paprikash
parsley
pepper, white
pork
potatoes
rice
rosemary
saffron
salads: pasta, potato
salt, sea
sauces, esp. cream
sausage, esp. chorizo
seafood
shellfish
soups
sour cream
Spanish cuisine
stews, esp. fish
stock, chicken
tagines
thyme
Turkish cuisine
turmeric
veal
vegetables
yogurt

Flavor Affinities

paprika + beef + sour cream

We use lots of **smoked paprika**, but need to be careful because it can be really strong. I like to finish our fried chickpeas with this because it makes them taste like they just jumped out of the fire! We also like to mix our paprikas together, typically in equal proportions of sweet, hot, and smoked. Smoked paprika is primarily smoky and doesn't have a lot of other flavors. So if you combine it with a vibrant sweet paprika, you'll get a more rounded pepper flavor. Paprika is also very regional. In the south [of Spain] where it gets sunshine and heat, you see more smoked paprika, but in the north where it is colder and rainy, they are not into the heat.

—ALEXANDRA RAIJ, TÍA POL (NEW YORK CITY)

PAPRIKA, SMOKED

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate–loud

bacon

beans, esp. white

cheese

chicken

chickpeas

chorizo

clams

eggs, hard-boiled

fish (e.g., skate)

garlic

lamb

marjoram

mayonnaise

meats, esp. grilled or roasted

Mediterranean cuisine

octopus

olive oil

onions

paella

pepper, black

peppers, piquillo

pork, esp. ribs

potatoes

sage

scallions

seafood

soups

steaks

stews

tomatoes

turkey, esp. roasted
vegetables
vegetarian meals

Flavor Affinities

smoked paprika + mayonnaise + seafood

PARSLEY

Season: year-round

Weight: light

Volume: quiet

Tips: Use fresh. Parsley generally refers to flat-leaf parsley. Parsley is great for blending, as it is compatible with virtually all other herbs.

avocados

basil

bay leaf

beans, esp. dried

beef

bouquet garni (ingredient, along with bay leaf, marjoram, thyme)

braised dishes

bulgur wheat

butter

capers

carrots

cauliflower

cheese, esp. Parmesan, ricotta

chervil

chicken

chile peppers

chives

cinnamon

clams

cream

cream cheese

crème fraîche

dill

eggs and egg dishes

eggplant

fennel

finest herbes (ingredient)

FISH

French cuisine, esp. southern

game

GARLIC

halibut

ham

herbs (as a flavor enhancer)

Italian cuisine, esp. southern

lemon: juice, zest

lemon balm

lentils

lovage

marjoram

meats

Mediterranean cuisine

Middle Eastern cuisine

mint

Moroccan cuisine

mushrooms

mussels

oils: hazelnut, walnut

olive oil

onions

oregano

oysters

parsnips

pasta and pasta sauces

peas

pepper: black, white

pesto (ingredient)

pizza

pork

potatoes

poultry

rice

rosemary

sage

salads, esp. egg, green, pasta, potato, or rice

salsa verde (ingredient)

sauces

sausages

savory

scallions

seafood

shallots

shrimp

skate

snails

sorrel

SOUPS

Spanish cuisine, esp. southern

spinach

stews

stocks

stuffings

sumac

tabbouleh (key ingredient) tarragon

thyme

tomatoes and tomato sauces

veal

vegetables

vinaigrette

vinegar, balsamic

zucchini

AVOID

desserts

The Spanish use **parsley** stems for cooking, and fresh as a garnish before serving. When you make rice or beans, you would put a stem in. To me, parsley added to fish or shellfish makes the dish tastes more “marine,” as opposed to earthy. I love *salsa verde*, which is a sauce made with basically a

ton of parsley, garlic, and some kind of juice like clam juice. It's wonderful served with fish.

—ALEXANDRA RAIJ, TÍA POL (NEW YORK CITY)

People do not understand **parsley**; they think it is green specks. But it is wonderful with fish. If you make a straight-up linguini with clam sauce, you want a big handful of chopped parsley in there—not for the appearance, but for the taste. It is an important component in a lot of dishes and needs to be there. It can also be used as a sauce all on its own. If you sprinkle it on a steak, it will not have the impact that it would on fish. On the other hand, if you make a Maître d'hôtel butter [butter flavored with lemon juice and parsley] and put it on the steak, the parsley has a role there. On vegetables, if you make glazed carrots or pearl onions or a stew with lots of vegetables, parsley stirred in at the last moment is good stuff. As for my choice of parsley, I always use flat Italian-style parsley.

—DAVID WALTUCK, CHANTERELLE (NEW YORK CITY)

Salsa verde is my favorite all-purpose condiment at home. I like it on fish, lamb, and steak. It is made with anchovy, garlic, shallots, olive oil, and herbs—primarily **parsley**, but also chervil, chives, tarragon, a little bit of marjoram, and sometimes a little mint if I am in the mood. I add the acid at the last moment so it won't change the color of the herbs, and will choose between Banyuls or red wine vinegar, or lemon juice. If I am serving meat, I will use vinegar; if I am serving fish, I will use lemon. Even though it changes color once the acid is added, it lasts a few days. It is really good on a piece of bread or with some fresh farmer's cheese as a snack.

—TRACI DES JARDINS, JARDINIÈRE (SAN FRANCISCO)

Flavor Affinities

parsley + bulgur wheat + garlic + lemon + mint + olive oil + scallions

parsley + butter + garlic

parsley + capers + garlic + lemon zest + olive oil

parsley + garlic

parsley + garlic + lemon zest

parsley + garlic + olive oil + Parmesan cheese + vinegar

parsley + lemon juice + olive oil + Parmesan cheese

PARSNIPS

Season: autumn–winter

Taste: sweet

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: moderate

Techniques/Tips: Always use cooked (never raw): bake, boil, braise, deep-fry, grill, mash, puree, roast, steam

allspice

anise

apples

bacon

basil

bay leaf

beans, black, green

BUTTER, brown and/or unsalted

carrots

cheese, esp. creamy

chervil

chicken

chile peppers

chives

cinnamon

coriander

cream

cumin

curry

dill

duck

fennel: leaves, seeds

fish

game

game birds

garlic

ginger, esp. ground
greens, bitter / winter

honey

leeks

lemon, juice

lentils

lovage

mace

maple syrup

meats

mint

mirepoix

mirin

mushrooms, porcini

mustard

NUTMEG

oil: peanut, sesame

olive oil

onions

orange

pancetta

parsley

Parmesan cheese

pears

pepper: black, white

potatoes

rosemary

sage

salt

shallots

soups

soy sauce

stews

stocks: chicken, vegetable

sugar, brown

tarragon

thyme

vegetables, root

vinegar, balsamic

wine, dry white

yogurt

Flavor Affinities

parsnips + butter + cream + potatoes

parsnips + carrots + nutmeg + potatoes

parsnips + cream + nutmeg

parsnips + honey + mustard

parsnips + pancetta + Parmesan cheese + pasta

Dishes

Passion Fruit and Bonito Caramel

—Dominique and Cindy Duby, Wild Sweets (Vancouver)

Passion Fruit Flip: Passion Fruit + Honey + Lime + Raspberries + Yogurt

—Gale Gand, pastry chef, Tru (Chicago)

Passion Fruit Cream Enrobed in White Chocolate, Ginger Caramel, and Mandarin Sorbet

—Michael Laiskonis, Le Bernardin (New York City)

PASSION FRUIT

Season: year-round

Taste: sweet

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate

Techniques: puree, raw

almonds

bananas

beverages

caramel

cashews

Champagne

chicken

chives

chocolate, esp. dark, white

cilantro

citrus fruit

coconut and coconut milk

Cointreau

CREAM AND ICE CREAM

cream cheese

custard

egg whites

fish

fruits, tropical

ginger

kiwi fruit

lemon, juice

lime, juice

macadamia nuts

mangoes

orange, juice

papayas

peaches

pears

pineapples

rum, esp. dark

salads, fruit

salad dressings

soups, fruit

strawberries SUGAR

tapioca

tequila

vanilla

wine, ice

yogurt

Flavor Affinities

passion fruit + banana + orange

passion fruit + caramel + coconut

passion fruit + caramel + ginger + white chocolate

passion fruit + cream + ice wine

passion fruit + dark chocolate + ginger + raspberries

PASTA

Weight: medium–heavy (depending on the cut)

Volume: quiet

anchovies

artichokes

asparagus

bacon

basil

beans, e.g., fava, white

beef

bottarga (tuna roe)

bread crumbs

broccoli

broths, esp. chicken, esp. with small pasta

butter

capers

cauliflower

CHEESE: cheddar, Comté, Emmental, Fontina, goat, Gorgonzola, Gouda,

Gruyère, **mozzarella**, **PARMESAN**, **pecorino**, **ricotta**, ricotta salata

chicken

chickpeas

Dishes

Goat Cheese Tortelloni with Dried Orange and Fennel Pollen

—Mario Batali, Babbo (New York City)

Mint Tagliatelle with Lamb and Olives

—Mario Batali, Babbo (New York City)

Spaghettini with Spicy Artichokes, Sweet Garlic, and Lobster

—Mario Batali, Babbo (New York City)

Spaghetti Primavera with Prosciutto, Spring Garlic, Sugar Snap Peas, and Parmigiano

—Andrew Carmellini, A Voce (New York City)

Homemade Pappardelle with Lamb Bolognese and Sheep's Milk Ricotta

—Andrew Carmellini, A Voce (New York City)

Homemade Soft Egg Yolk-Filled Raviolo with Truffled Butter

—Odette Fada, San Domenico (New York City)

Homemade Straccetti with Pesto and Clams

—Odette Fada, San Domenico (New York City)

Linguini with Clams, Pancetta, and Spicy Fresno Chile Pesto

—Matt Molina, Osteria Mozza (Los Angeles)

Farfalle with Stridoli, Walnuts, and Chanterelles

—Matt Molina, Osteria Mozza (Los Angeles)

Tagliatelle with Chanterelles and Parmigiano Reggiano

—Holly Smith, Café Juanita (Seattle)

Butternut Squash Ravioli with Oxtail Ragout and Sage Cream

—David Waltuck, Chanterelle (New York City)



chile peppers

chives

clams

cream, esp. with fettuccine, festonate, gnocchi, or pappardelle

cured meats: bacon, ham, pancetta, prosciutto

duck confit

eggplant

eggs

fennel

figs

fish (e.g., cod, salmon, swordfish, tuna)

game, esp. with fettuccine or pappardelle

garlic

greens (e.g., arugula, radicchio, stridoli)

ITALIAN CUISINE

lamb

leeks

lemon, juice

lobster

mascarpone

meat, esp. beef, lamb, oxtail, pork, venison

meat, ground, esp. with penne and rigatoni

mint

mushrooms, esp. wild

mussels

mustard, Dijon

nutmeg

octopus

OLIVE OIL, esp. with linguini and spaghetti

olives

onions

pancetta

parsley, flat-leaf

parsnips

peas, esp. with penne and rigatoni

pecans

Pairing Pastas with Sauces

Which sauces pair best with which pastas? We asked chef Odette Fada of New York City's San Domenico restaurant.

- **Angel hair:** In Italy, angel hair pasta is served to old people who can't chew. It's for grandparents, or for others to eat when they are sick. The problem with angel hair pasta is it's so thin it's hard to cook al dente, and I like my pasta a little chewy.

- **Bow tie:** Fresh bow tie is great when made by hand, because it stays folded and doesn't open into a square. I like to serve it with vegetables and tomato-based sauces.

- **Fettuccine:** This is a flavorful pasta and is good with a Bolognese sauce.

- **Fusilli:** I like their [corkscrew] shape, but they tend to break easily so they are not that attractive when you cook them in a restaurant setting. I like them at home in a salad or with some pesto because the pesto sticks to it.

- **Hollow pasta** [e.g., macaroni, penne, rigatoni]: Good with sauces that have big chunks in them so that the sauce pieces go inside whole. I like to do penne with fresh peas because the peas will slip inside, so you'll sometimes get a little surprise when you're chewing.

- **Pappardelle:** This is a strong, rustic pasta. I like it with rabbit sauce, a ragoût, or a fish sauce that has some character.

- **Small pasta** [e.g., rice-, shell-, or star-shaped]: These are good for soups and brothy dishes. For example, you would use them with a brothy fish dish.

- **Spaghetti:** Everything goes with spaghetti! It is a pasta that sauce sticks to. Everything from tomato sauce to pesto to pecorino with black pepper is great with spaghetti.

Or, if you're starting with the sauce:

- **Carbonara:** Spaghetti or bucatini, you want a pasta that the sauce will stick to.

- **Cream:** Fettuccine, pappardelle, or gnocchi, since cream is so rich you want a strongflavored pasta or, in the last case, gnocchi—one that is made with some egg in it.

- **Game:** Pappardelle or fettuccine; you want an egg-rich pasta with some flavor.

- **Olive oil and garlic:** Spaghetti.

- **Pesto:** Fusilli.

- **Tomato:** This works with almost all pasta shapes, from small to large.

I have played with lots of flavored pasta doughs. One of my favorites is

olive because it holds its flavor. Other flavors that hold up well are squid ink and saffron. I have also made a pappardelle with cocoa powder that I paired with game sauce that worked great. If you wanted to achieve a particular color, you could create red pasta with beets, green pasta with spinach, and black pasta with squid ink.



pepper: black, white
pine nuts
pork

potatoes
prosciutto
pumpkin
rabbit, braised, esp. with pappardelle
raisins
red pepper flakes
rosemary
saffron
sage
salt, esp. kosher
sardines

SAUCES: Bolognese (esp. with fettuccine), carbonara (esp. with bucatini or spaghetti), Mornay (esp. with macaroni), pesto (esp. with fusilli), rabbit (esp. with pappardelle), sardines (esp. with bucatini), tomato

sausage
scallops
seafood: clams, crab, lobster, mussels, octopus, scallops, shrimp, squid
shallots
shrimp
spinach
squash: summer, winter
squid
sweet potato
thyme
tomatoes
tomatoes, sun-dried
truffles: black, white
veal
vegetables
venison
vinegar, esp. balsamic
walnuts
zucchini

Flavor Affinities

pasta + anchovies + bread crumbs + capers + red pepper flakes + garlic + olives
pasta + anchovies + mozzarella cheese

pasta + artichokes + garlic + lobster
pasta + bacon + black pepper + eggs + olive oil + pecorino cheese
pasta + basil + garlic + tomato
pasta + basil + peas + shrimp
pasta + basil + scallops + tomato
pasta + bread crumbs + greens + shrimp + white beans
pasta + bread crumbs + raisins + sardines
pasta + chickpeas + garlic + sage
pasta + chile peppers + lobster + mint
pasta + clams + pancetta
pasta + cream + peas + prosciutto
pasta + duck confit + wild mushrooms
pasta + fennel + sausage + tomato + white beans
pasta + figs + pancetta
pasta + Gorgonzola cheese + spinach + walnuts
pasta + Gruyère cheese + nutmeg + ricotta cheese
pasta + lamb + lemon + rosemary
pasta + lamb + mint + olives
pasta + lobster + peas
pasta + mushrooms + pumpkin + sage
pasta + pancetta + stridoli
pasta + Parmesan cheese + sage + tomato
pasta + pesto + white beans
pasta + pumpkin + pecans + ricotta cheese + sage
pasta + red pepper flakes + fennel + sardines + tomatoes
pasta + red pepper flakes + garlic + olive oil
pasta + ricotta cheese + veal shanks
pasta + rosemary + venison
pasta + spinach + ricotta cheese
pasta + tomatoes + ricotta cheese

Chef Odette Fada of New York's San Domenico on Making Ravioli

I love ravioli! Anything and everything goes in my ravioli—I have used everything from chestnuts to cheese to fish, meat, and vegetables. You can vary the ravioli dough as well as the stuffing. For example, I serve ravioli stuffed with sea urchin and the dough is light and made with just flour and water. For a stronger filling like lamb, I will use some egg in the dough which makes it bigger flavored. One of my favorite ravioli stuffings is black truffle and pancetta. The truffle provides a crunchiness when you bite into it.

One of the greatest ravioli we do dates back to the chef for the last king of Italy at the beginning of the twentieth century. It is stuffed with spinach, truffle, Parmesan cheese, and an egg yolk, and served with butter, truffle, and Parmesan cheese. When the ravioli is cooked, it is served with the yolk warm but not cooked. It is truly an amazing dish.

In Italy during the winter, you would typically have some slices of sausage on top of a plate of lentils. I decided to combine the two into a ravioli dish. Now, one of my other favorite dishes is our ravioli stuffed with *cotechino* [sausage] and lentils. The lentils are cooked with rosemary, garlic, extra-virgin olive oil, and prosciutto skin, and go into the ravioli with the sausage, parsley, and Parmesan cheese. The dish is finished with some strong extra-virgin olive oil, parsley, and a crack of pepper.

PEACHES

Season: late spring–early autumn

Taste: sweet

Function: heating

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate

Techniques: bake, broil, grill, poach, raw, roast, sauté

allspice

ALMONDS, esp. toasted

anise hyssop

apples

apricots, puree

arugula

basil

bay leaf

beverages, esp. cocktails

blackberries

BLUEBERRIES

bourbon

brandy

butter, unsalted

buttermilk

Calvados

caramel

Champagne

cherries

chile peppers, green (e.g., jalapeño)

chocolate: dark, white

CINNAMON

cloves

coconut

cognac

Cointreau

***CREAM AND ICE CREAM**

crème fraîche

currants, red: fruit, jelly

custards

desserts and dessert sauces

figs

fruit crisp

ginger

Grand Marnier

grenadine

hazelnuts

honey

ice, esp. pistachio

ice cream, esp. vanilla

Kirsch

lavender

LEMON: juice, zest

lemon thyme

lemon verbena

lime, juice

liqueurs: nut, orange, peach (e.g., schnapps)

mace

Madeira

maple syrup

Marsala

mascarpone

mint

molasses

nectarines

nutmeg

oatmeal



Dishes

Jim Core's Peaches Upside-Down Cake with Blueberry Sorbet

—John Besh, August (New Orleans)

Saffron Panna Cotta with Peaches, Peach Sorbetto, and Lemon Balm

—Gina DePalma, Babbo (New York City)

White Peach Melba with Raspberry Granita

—Emily Luchetti, pastry chef, Farallon (San Francisco)

Warm Ginger Cake Sabayon with Spiced Peaches

—Chuck Subra, La Côte Brasserie (New Orleans)

When I think of the essence of **peaches**, it's their smell—so I think of echoing that with the floralness of Moscato d'Asti. I'll add acidity, sweetness, and a little fat, such as through crème fraîche.

—TONY LIU, AUGUST (NEW YORK CITY)

I try not to cook **peaches**, or if I do, only for a short amount of time. A peach pie never tastes as good to me as a blueberry pie, because it tastes too cooked by the time you get it thick enough. So if I get peaches, I'll chop them up and put them on a tart shell that is already cooked instead.

—EMILY LUCHETTI, FARALLON (SAN FRANCISCO)

I like **peaches** with rich, round flavors like vanilla and honey.

—GINA DEPALMA, BABBO (NEW YORK CITY)

Japanese baby **peaches** are tiny peaches about the size of olives. We wanted to showcase the peaches and thought, What do peaches go with? Cream. We took that one step further and used yogurt instead. So we chose Greek yogurt, paired it with the peaches, then garnished the dish with Hawaiian pink sea salt, Greek olive oil, reduced balsamic vinegar, and micro mint. We turned the water strained from the yogurt into “air” [foam]. This is a dish that we serve as a pre-dessert and it works well because it is sweet and savory.

—**KATSUYA FUKUSHIMA**, MINIBAR (WASHINGTON, DC)

oil, vegetable

olive oil

onions, yellow

ORANGE: juice, zest

papaya

passion fruit

pecans

pepper: black, white

pineapple

PISTACHIOS

plums

port

raisins

RASPBERRIES: fruit, puree

rum

saffron

salads, fruit

salsas, fruit

salt

soups, esp. cold

sour cream

star anise

STRAWBERRIES (e.g., fruit, puree)

SUGAR: BROWN, confectioners', white

tarragon

tea

thyme

VANILLA

vinegar: balsamic, champagne, cider, red wine, rice, white

Vin Santo

violets, esp. candied

walnuts

watercress

whiskey

WINE: dry or fruity red or white or sweet (e.g., Asti, **Burgundy**, Merlot, sweet Muscat, Riesling, Rosé, Zinfandel)

yogurt

zabaglione

Flavor Affinities

peaches + apples + vanilla

peaches + blueberries + mascarpone

peaches + cream + honey + vanilla

peaches + figs + maple syrup

peaches + ginger + sugar

peaches + orange liqueur + vanilla

peaches + sugar + yogurt

PEANUT OIL
(See Oil, Peanut)

PEANUTS AND PEANUT BUTTER

(See also Nuts—In General)

Taste: sweet, astringent

Function: heating

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: moderate–loud

African cuisine

apples

BANANAS

basil

beef

bell peppers

Burmese cuisine

butter

caramel

cayenne

chicken

chile peppers (e.g., jalapeño)

Chinese cuisine

CHOCOLATE, ESP. DARK, MILK

cilantro

coconut and coconut milk

coffee

curries

curry paste, Thai red

curry powder

desserts

fish sauce, Thai

garlic

grape jelly

honey

Indonesian cuisine

lemon, juice

lime, juice
mole sauces
noodles
oatmeal
oil: peanut, vegetable
olive oil
onions
parsley
pears
pork
raisins
raspberries
Rice Krispies
salads
salt
sauc
shrimp
Southern cuisine (American)
soy sauce
stir-fried dishes
strawberries
sugar: brown, white
tarragon
Thai cuisine
tomatoes
turmeric
vanilla
Vietnamese cuisine
vinegar, red wine

Anything we put **peanuts** on sells! Peanuts are associated with the South, so there is a regional appeal. We had a chicken breast with sugar snap peas, white radishes, toasted peanuts, basmati rice, and spicy peanut sauce.

—MARCEL DESAULNIERS, THE TRELIS (WILLIAMSBURG, VIRGINIA)

Peanuts are not as versatile as other nuts. They have a great flavor and are pretty generic so you can use them on a lot of things and they pair well. Milk chocolate and peanuts work really well together. Peanuts pair great with bananas, especially if you cover the banana in chocolate and then roll it in peanuts and freeze it.

—**EMILY LUCHETTI**, FARALLON (SAN FRANCISCO)

PEARS

Season: autumn–winter

Taste: sweet

Weight: medium

Volume: quiet–moderate

Techniques: bake, deep-fry (e.g., as chips), grill, poach, raw, roast, sauté, stew

allspice

ALMONDS and almond paste

anise

apples: fruit, juice

apricots, esp. dried or pureed

arugula

bacon

basil

beets

blackberries

blueberries

borage

bourbon

brandy, esp. pear

butter, brown

BUTTER, unsalted

butterscotch

Calvados

CARAMEL

cardamom

cassis

celery

Champagne

CHEESE: BLUE, Brie, Cabrales, Cambozola, Camembert, Cantal, cheddar,

feta, **goat**, **Gorgonzola**, Monterey Jack, **Parmesan**, **pecorino**, ricotta,

Romano, **ROQUEFORT**, **Stilton**

cherries: dried, fresh

chestnuts

Chinese cuisine, esp. featuring Asian pears

CHOCOLATE, esp. dark, white

cider

CINNAMON

CLOVES

cranberries

cream and ice cream

cream cheese

crème anglaise

crème fraîche

custards

dates

dill

duck and duck confit

endive

fennel

figs

French cuisine

game

ginger

Grand Marnier

hazelnuts

HONEY

ice cream, vanilla

Italian cuisine

Kirsch

LEMON: JUICE, ZEST

liqueurs: almond, hazelnut, orange

macadamia nuts

mace

maple syrup

Marsala

MASCARPONE

meats, esp. fatty, grilled, and/or roasted

Mediterranean cuisine

mint (garnish)

mustard
nutmeg
nuts
oats
oil, canola
olive oil
onions, green
ORANGE: fruit, juice, zest
parsley, flat-leaf
passion fruit
peanuts
pear brandy
pear cider
pecans
pepper: black, white
pine nuts
pistachios
Poire William
pork
port: red, white
poultry
praline
prosciutto
prunes
quinces
radicchio
raisins
raspberries: fruit, puree
rhubarb
rice (e.g., pudding)
rosemary
rum



This salad has roasted **pear**, Roquefort cheese, lemon, and olive oil and is garnished with borage flowers. The sauce is burnt caramel with pepper deglazed with Coteaux du Layon, which is sweet but higher in acid than Sauternes. The caramel sauce keeps you awake!

Cheese and fruit: Blue cheese is sharp and hits your palate, then the pear calms it down.

Salad greens: We use herbs in our salad and this one has fennel, thyme, tarragon, parsley, and anise hyssop.

Borage flowers: Eating a borage flower is like eating an oyster! It is briny. In the summer when they are in season, if you taste a couple it is reminiscent of a mild oyster.

—GABRIEL KREUTHER, THE MODERN (NEW YORK CITY)

Apples are more popular than **pears** because when you go to the store, pears are all hard. You buy them, bring them home, and wait forever for them to ripen. You have to have a premeditated use for pears.

—EMILY LUCHETTI, FARALLON (SAN FRANCISCO)

I like **pears** poached because I'm not fond of their texture. I also make a pear tart with pears poached in lemon zest and vanilla, and then combined with custard, honey, lemon, and vanilla. It is paired with a honey grappa zabaglione and topped with grated Pecorino Toscano cheese grated over it as if it were pasta. The dish sounds a little crazy but all these flavors are classic combinations found in Italy. Pears are often infused with grappa in the north of Italy. Pears, honey, and pecorino is a classic combination in Tuscany. Pecorino goes with every flavor. Honey carries all the flavors forward.

—GINA DEPALMA, BABBO (NEW YORK CITY)

sabayon

salads: fruit, green

salt (pinch)

sour cream

squab

squash: butternut, winter

star anise

strawberries, esp. sauce

SUGAR: brown, white

sweet potatoes

toffee

VANILLA

VINEGAR: balsamic, champagne, sherry, white, white wine

WALNUTS

watercress

whiskey

WINE: red (e.g., Burgundy), strong red (e.g., Cabernet Sauvignon, Zinfandel), dry white (e.g., Riesling), sparkling (e.g., Champagne), sweet (e.g., ice wine)

Flavor Affinities

pears + amaretto + hazelnuts

pears + arugula + Parmesan cheese + vinaigrette + walnuts

pears + bacon + bitter greens + goat cheese

pears + blue cheese + olive oil + red wine vinegar + watercress

pears + caramel + balsamic vinegar

pears + caramel + chestnuts + crème fraîche

pears + caramel + chocolate
pears + cinnamon + ginger + honey
pears + fennel + Parmesan cheese + balsamic vinegar + walnuts
pears + ginger + honey + vanilla
pears + Gorgonzola cheese + vinaigrette + walnuts
pears + honey + lime + vanilla
pears + honey + rosemary
pears + maple syrup + walnuts
pears + mascarpone + pistachios + red wine
pears + pecorino cheese + balsamic vinegar
pears + Roquefort cheese + sugar + vanilla + red wine
pears + Roquefort cheese + walnuts
pears + Stilton cheese + hazelnuts + balsamic vinegar

Dishes

Pear and Fresh Pecorino–Filled Ravioli with Aged Pecorino and Crushed Black Pepper

—Lidia Bastianich, Felidia (New York City)

Grilled Pear and Roquefort Tart with Caramelized Onions and Walnuts

—Sandy D’Amato, Sanford (Milwaukee)

Grilled Pear Steak with Polenta Frites and Orange-Tarragon Sauce

—Dominique and Cindy Duby, Wild Edibles (Vancouver)

Salad of Spicy Poached Pear, Fresh Ricotta, Smoked Almonds, and Edamame with Verjus Dressing

—Brad Farmerie, Monday Room (New York City)

Sticky Toffee Pudding with Cinnamon-Sautéed Pears

—Gale Gand, at the 2005 James Beard Awards gala reception

Warm Semolina Pancake, Poached Pears, Cumin

—Johnny Iuzzini, pastry chef, Jean Georges (New York City)

Honey-Roasted Pear Napoleon

—Kate Zuckerman, pastry chef, Chanterelle (New York City)

PEAS—IN GENERAL

(See also Snap Peas)

Season: late spring–summer

Taste: sweet

Weight: light–medium

Volume: quiet–moderate

Techniques: boil, braise, sauté, steam

arugula

asparagus

bacon

BASIL

bay leaf

bouquet garni

BUTTER, unsalted

cardamom

CARROTS and carrot juice

cayenne

celery

cheese, esp. Parmesan, ricotta

chervil



chicken

chile peppers: dried red, fresh green

chives

cilantro, (e.g., as Indian cuisine) cinnamon

cloves

coriander

crab

CREAM, HEAVY

crème fraîche

cumin

curry powder

dill
fava beans
fish
French cuisine
garam masala
garlic
ginger
ham and ham hocks
honey
Italian cuisine
leeks
lemon, juice
lettuce, Boston
lime, juice
lobster
marjoram
mascarpone
MINT
mushrooms, esp. morels
oil, peanut
olive oil
onions: pearl, red, spring, white
pancetta
parsley, flat-leaf
pasta
pepper: black, white
pork
potatoes
poultry
prosciutto
risotto
rosemary
sage
salt: kosher, sea
savory, winter
scallions
scallops

shallots

shrimp

snap peas

sorrel

Spanish cuisine, esp. southern

spinach

stocks: chicken, vegetable

sugar

tarragon

thyme

tomatoes

turmeric

vinaigrette

vinegar, champagne

watercress

wine, dry white

yogurt

Flavor Affinities

peas + bacon + cream + shallots

peas + basil + potatoes

peas + celery + olive oil + onions + chicken stock + sugar

peas + custard + Parmesan cheese

peas + lobster + pasta

peas + marjoram + mascarpone + Parmesan cheese

peas + mint + morel mushrooms

peas + mushrooms + ricotta cheese

peas + onions + pancetta + sage

Bronze fennel grows all over Seattle. One day I walked outside eating **peas** while going out to get mint for my pea salad. I ate a bite of fennel and thought, “By Jove, I’ve got a dish!” Bronze fennel is a non-bulb fennel that has an amazing fennel and earthy flavor.

—**HOLLY SMITH**, CAFÉ JUANITA (SEATTLE)

Dishes

Spring Pea Fricassée with Morels and Butter Lettuce

—Daniel Boulud, at the 2003 James Beard Awards gala reception

Chilled Sweet Pea Soup “à la Française” Thumbelina Carrot Salad with Cilantro and Lobster

—Daniel Boulud, Daniel (New York City)

Pea Velouté with Apple-Smoked Bacon, Louisiana Crayfish, Savory Cream

—Daniel Boulud, Daniel (New York City)

Garden Pea Soup with Morel Cream

—Daniel Humm, Eleven Madison Park (New York City)

Sweet Pea Soup with Caramelized Vidalia Onion, Apple-Smoked Bacon, and Mint

—Alfred Portale, Gotham Bar and Grill (New York City)

Sweet Pea Sorbet with Preserved Green Almond and Marcona Almond Milk, Fuji Apple with Butterscotch, Rye, and Thyme

—Charlie Trotter, Charlie Trotter’s (Chicago)

Fresh Pea Ravioli with Sweet Onions Sauce and Smoked Pork Reduction

—David Waltuck, Chanterelle (New York City)

PECAN OIL
(See Oil, Pecan)

PECANS

(See also Nuts—In General)

Season: autumn

Taste: bitter–sweet

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: quiet–moderate

almonds

apples

apricots

baked goods (e.g., breads, cookies, pies)

bananas

blackberries

blueberries

bourbon

brandy

breakfast (e.g., pancakes, waffles)

butter, unsalted

butterscotch

CARAMEL

cheese, goat

cherries

chicken

chocolate: dark, white **cinnamon**

coffee

cognac

corn syrup: light, dark cranberries

cream

dates

ginger

grapefruit

grapes

hazelnuts

honey

ice cream

kumquats

lemon, juice

liqueurs, orange

MAPLE SYRUP

mascarpone

Mexican sauces

nectarines

nutmeg

oats and oatmeal

orange

peaches

pears

persimmons

plums

pork

prunes

pumpkin

quince

raisins

raspberries

rice, wild

rum

salads

salt

sour cream

Southern cuisine (American)

squash, butternut

stir-fried dishes

Dishes

Pecan Praline Cheesecake

—Terrance Brennan, Artisanal (New York City)

Pecan Praline Pancakes with Brown Butter Bananas and Rum Raisins

—Daniel Humm, Eleven Madison Park (New York City)

Southern Butter Pecan Ice Cream with Hot Caramel Sauce

—Patrick O’Connell, The Inn at Little Washington (Washington, Virginia)

Phyllo Spirals with Garden Herbs, Rio Grande Organic Pecans, and Pure Luck Feta

—Monica Pope, T’afia (Houston)

We are using **pecans** on a savory dish of scallops and shrimp, ham, shiitake mushrooms, shallots, and pecan-studded basmati rice.

—MARCEL DESAULNIERS, THE TRELLIS (WILLIAMSBURG, VIRGINIA)

strawberries

stuffing

SUGAR: BROWN, white

sweet potatoes

tea

vanilla

walnuts

whiskey

wine: red, sweet

PEPPER, BLACK

Taste: pungent, hot

Function: warming

Weight: light–medium

Volume: moderate–loud

Tips: Pepper suggests “false heat” and also stimulates the appetite. Add at the end of the cooking process.

apricots

basil

BEEF, esp. roasted

berries cardamom cheese

cherries cinnamon

cloves

coconut milk coriander

cumin

eggs

fruit, fresh

game

garlic

ginger

Indian cuisine

lamb

lemon, juice

lentils

lime, juice

meats, red

nutmeg

nuts

olive oil

olives

parsley

pineapple

pork

poultry

pumpkin (e.g., pie)

rosemary

salads

SALT

sauces

sausages

seafood, heartier soups

spice cake

STEAKS, esp. grilled strawberries

thyme

tomatoes

turmeric

veal

PEPPER, GREEN

(as peppercorns)

Taste: hot

Weight: light–medium

Volume: moderate

Tips: Add at the end of the cooking process. The flavor is less sharp than black pepper.

avocados

bay leaf

beef

brandy

butter

chicken

cream

curries

duck

game

garlic

ham

meats, esp. grilled and/or red

mustard

parsley

pâtés

pork

sage

salads and salad dressings

salmon

saucés: creamy, white seafood

shrimp

stock, veal

turkey

veal

vegetables

venison
wine, white

PEPPER, PINK

Taste: hot

Weight: light–medium

Volume: moderate–loud

Tips: Add at the end of the cooking process.

butter

chervil

chicken

chocolate

desserts

duck

eggs

fennel

fruit

game

lemongrass

lime leaves, kaffir

lobster

meats, esp. richer and/or stronger

mint

olive oil

parsley

pâtés

pears

pepper: black, green pineapple

pork

poultry

salad dressings

saucés: fruit, white scallops

seafood

shrimp

steak

veal

vinegar, esp. balsamic
Worcestershire sauce

PEPPER, RED

(See also Cayenne, Ground)

Taste: hot

Weight: light

Volume: loud

Tips: Add at the end of the cooking process.

Caribbean cuisine

chili powder (ingredient)

Indian cuisine

Italian cuisine

jerk seasoning (ingredient)

meats

Mexican cuisine

mole negro (ingredient)

seafood

PEPPER, WHITE

Taste: hot

Weight: light–medium

Volume: moderate (Note: White pepper is “quieter,” i.e., milder, than black pepper.)

Tips: Add at the end of the cooking process.

Asian cuisines

charcuterie

cloves

European cuisines

fish, esp. white

ginger

halibut

Japanese cuisine

lemongrass

nutmeg

potatoes

quatre épices (key ingredient)

saucés, esp. light-colored or white

soups, esp. light-colored or white

Thai cuisine

white and other light-colored foods

PEPPERS, BELL
(See Bell Peppers)

PEPPERS, CHILE
(See Chile Peppers)

PEPPERS, PEPPADEW

Peppadew peppers, which are from South Africa, started coming to the U.S. just a few years ago. I stuff them with goat cheese and wrap them in Serrano ham before frying them. You get sweetness and spice from the peppers, saltiness from the ham, creaminess from the cheese, and crunchiness from the frying. Doing so gives them so much flavor, I don't need to add anything else.

—**BOB IACOVONE**, CUVÉE (NEW ORLEANS)

I like **white pepper** with most white fish, and **black pepper** with tuna and red meat. White pepper works with halibut because it does not overwhelm the fish. Black pepper has a complex flavor and is spicy, which can be distracting. The problem with many peppers like cayenne or chipotle is that they are so strong they can burn. That is not a problem for me, but it is for our clientele. We use *piment d'Espelette*, which is spicy but sweet.

—**ERIC RIPERT**, LE BERNARDIN (NEW YORK CITY)

You have to be careful with **black pepper** because it can be a vehicle to add flavor—but if misused, it will mask flavor. I might add the tiniest little pinch before a dessert gets served to punch it up. I use black pepper with fresh fruit, especially cherries.

—**MICHAEL LAISKONIS**, LE BERNARDIN (NEW YORK CITY)

To me, tuna doesn't even taste like tuna anymore unless it's seared with my **pepper** mix of toasted and ground black and pink peppercorns, coriander, and star anise. The same mix is also great on beef, buffalo, and venison.

—**SHARON HAGE**, YORK STREET (DALLAS)

We don't have sixteen types of **pepper** here; we use a basic black Tellicherry peppercorn and a little bit of red pepper flakes. I will occasionally go to an Asian market to get a pepper that has a sweet element to it, as these also tend to have a fruitiness to them that works well in braised dishes.

—**SHARON HAGE**, YORK STREET (DALLAS)

PEPPERS, PIQUILLO

(Spanish peppers)

Taste: hot

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate–loud

Techniques: roast

aioli

almonds

anchovies

artichokes

asparagus

beef

bread

calamari

CHEESE: goat, manchego

chicken

chickpeas

chocolate, bitter

chorizo

clams

crab

eggs

fish, esp. cod, redfish, white

garlic

lamb

lemon

meat

mushrooms

OLIVE OIL

olives

onions

orange paprika, smoked pork

potatoes

salads

salmon

salt

seafood

shrimp

soups

Spanish cuisine stews

sugar

tomatoes

tuna

PEPPERS, SPANISH

Guindilla peppers are used to give heat in Spanish cooking. If you were cooking beans, you would add your parsley sprig, half an onion, garlic, carrot, and one guindilla pepper. **Nora peppers** are smoked, bell-shaped peppers from Catalonia used for romesco sauce. They are similar to Mexican guajillo peppers. **Chorizero peppers** are bittersweet. Their pulp is used in *salsa vizcaina*, which is a red sauce made with a lot of onions cooked down sweet, the chorizero pepper pulp, and either fish or bean stock. It's great served on fish or tripe.

—ALEXANDRA RAIJ, TÍA POL (NEW YORK CITY)

Dishes

Green Olives Stuffed with Piquillo Peppers and Anchovies

—José Andrés, Café Atlántico (Washington, DC)

**Piquillo Peppers Filled with Manchego Cheese, Avocado Leaf—and Hoja Santa—
Seasoned Refried Beans and Vanilla—Bitter Chocolate Sauce**

—Maricel Presilla, Zafra (Hoboken, New Jersey)

PERSIMMONS

Season: autumn–winter

Taste: sweet–sour

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: moderate–loud

Techniques: bake, broil, raw

almonds

apples

avocados

bourbon

brandy

caramel

cashews

cheese, esp. creamy, goat

chile peppers, serrano

chocolate, white

cinnamon

cloves

coffee

cognac

cream and ice cream

custard

endive

frisée

ginger

grapes, esp. red

hazelnuts

honey

Kirsch

kiwi

kumquats

lemon: juice, zest

liqueurs, esp. orange

mace
maple syrup
nutmeg
oatmeal
oil, hazelnut
olive oil
orange
pears
pecans
pepper, black
pomegranates
pork
poultry
prosciutto

Because of the texture and unique flavor of a **persimmon**, no matter what you do it will always taste like persimmon pudding. I decided two years ago to stop trying to do anything else with persimmons. Why try and reinvent the wheel? To work with persimmons, you first put them in the freezer overnight to ripen, then peel and puree them. Persimmons are pretty astringent, so you need to add a lot of spices and sugar to them. The combination of allspice, cinnamon, and ginger that you see in traditional recipes is nice with persimmons, and adds an interesting complexity to the flavor.

—EMILY LUCHETTI, FARALLON (SAN FRANCISCO)

puddings
radicchio
raisins
rum, esp. dark
salads: fruit, green
salt
seafood
sorbet
sugar: brown, white
sweet potatoes

vanilla

vinegar: champagne, red wine, sherry, white wine

walnuts

watercress

wine, sweet (e.g., Sauternes)

yogurt

Flavor Affinities

persimmons + allspice + cinnamon + ginger

PHEASANT

Season: autumn

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate

Techniques: grill, roast

Tips: Wrap with bacon to keep from drying out when roasting.

apples

bacon

basil

bay leaf

butter

buttermilk

cabbage, esp. savoy

Calvados

chestnuts

cider

cinnamon

cream: heavy, sour

foie gras

French cuisine, esp. southern

GARLIC

Italian cuisine, esp. southern

lemon, juice

mushrooms, esp. wild nutmeg

olive oil

onions

orange

parsley, flat-leaf

port

POTATOES

raisins

sage

sauerkraut

shallots
Spanish cuisine, esp. southern
squash, winter
tarragon
THYME
truffles
wild rice
wine

Flavor Affinities

pheasant + apples + potatoes

PICKLES

I lived in Japan for two years where I fell in love with **pickles** and pickling. For pickling, I use the proportions that are common for seasoning Japanese sushi rice, though I'll admit that there might be a sushi chef out there who might disagree with me: 9 parts vinegar to 5 parts sugar, 1 part salt, and 1 part water. Pickles are one of those things I love to have in my pantry because they are so fun to use and make so many things yummy. It is definitely one of my tricks that I keep stashed away. I like to pickle Swiss chard stems with raw beets and star anise. They are great together and work as a garnish on our Nantucket Bay scallop dish.

—MICHAEL ANTHONY, GRAMERCY TAVERN (NEW YORK CITY)

PIMENTON

(See also Paprika)

I don't even like to use the word "paprika" when referring to **pimenton**. It is not the same as Hungarian paprika, which is just dried pepper and doesn't taste like anything else. The Spanish were the first to plant peppers. Our *pimenton* has the right touch of sweetness, bitterness, and smoke. Used in a dish it makes the dish a whole new thing. Sprinkled on octopus, it is astonishing.

—JOSÉ ANDRÉS, CAFÉ ATLÁNTICO (WASHINGTON, DC)

Dishes

Pheasant: Cider, Shallot, and Burning Leaves

—Grant Achatz, Alinea (Chicago)

Cinnamon-Roasted Pheasant with Applewood-Smoked Bacon and Red Chile Pecan Sauce

—Robert Del Grande, Café Annie (Houston)

Dishes

Pineapple-Vanilla Vacherin with Coconut Gelée

—Daniel Boulud, Restaurant Daniel, New York City

Warm Pineapple Cake “Sottosopra” with Rum Zabaione

—Gina DePalma, pastry chef, Babbo (New York City)

Exotic Fruit and Mint Salad, Star Anise Tuile

—Dominique and Cindy Duby, Wild Sweets (Vancouver)

Pineapple Rum Soup with Passion Fruit and Mango Gelée, Coconut Tapioca, Pink Peppercorn–Pineapple Sorbet

—Gale Gand, pastry chef, Tru (Chicago)

Pineapple Sorbet, Candied Pine Nut Tart, and Pineapple Chip

—Thomas Keller, The French Laundry (Yountville, California)

Fermented Pineapple Peel Drink

—Maricel Presilla, Zafra (Hoboken, New Jersey)

Grilled Pineapple, Avocado, and Watercress

—Maricel Presilla, Zafra (Hoboken, New Jersey)

Roasted Pineapple with Pistachio Ice Cream

—Eric Ripert, Le Bernardin (New York City)



PINEAPPLES

Season: winter–summer

Taste: sweet

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate

Techniques: bake, broil, grill, poach, raw, roast, sauté

allspice

apricots

avocado

baked goods **BANANAS**

basil

brandy

butter, unsalted caramel cardamom cashews

cayenne

cheese: blue (some)

chicken

Pineapple is 80 to 90 percent water. We'll freeze the pineapple, then pull it out and put it in a colander, and let the juice run out of it—which has all the flavor of the pineapple. After pressing out all the juice, we'll throw out the now-flavorless pulp, and use just the juice. You can do the same with strawberries or other fruits to obtain a clear juice, which you can use in drinks or, frozen and scraped, as fruit crystals to serve with a dessert.

—DOMINIQUE AND CINDY DUBY, WILD SWEETS (VANCOUVER)

I like the combination of rosemary with **pineapple**.

—MICHAEL LAISKONIS, LE BERNARDIN (NEW YORK CITY)

Pineapple benefits from a touch of vanilla.

—GINA DEPALMA, BABBO (NEW YORK CITY)

chile peppers: fresh, dried, red, green (e.g., jalapeño)

chocolate

cilantro

cinnamon

cloves

COCONUT: meat, milk

cognac

Cointreau

cream and ice cream

cream, Bavarian style

curry

fennel seeds

fruits, tropical

ginger

Grand Marnier

grapefruit

ham

honey

Kirsch

kiwi fruit

kumquats

lemon: juice, zest

lemongrass

LIME: juice, zest

macadamia nuts

MANGOES

maple syrup

marinades

meat

mint

olive oil

onion, red

oranges: fruit, marmalade

papaya

passion fruit

pepper, black

pistachios

pomegranate

poultry

raspberries

rice/rice pudding

rosemary

RUM

saffron

salads, fruit

salt, esp. *fleur de sel*, kosher

seafood (e.g., shrimp)

shallots

spinach

star anise

strawberries

SUGAR: brown, white

sweet potatoes

Szechuan pepper

tamarind

tapioca

VANILLA

vinegar, rice

walnuts

watercress

wine, sweet (e.g., Vin Santo)

yogurt

Flavor Affinities

pineapple + avocado + watercress

pineapple + banana + ginger + rum + sugar + vanilla

pineapple + berries + citrus + mangoes + star anise

pineapple + coconut + honey + oranges

pineapple + ice cream + brown sugar + vanilla

pineapple + lime + sugar

pineapple + Madeira + brown sugar + vanilla

pineapple + rum + sugar

pineapple + rum + vanilla + walnuts

You have to be careful with **pine nuts** because they are so strong that they will dominate a dessert. If I use even a small amount in an apple dessert, it turns it into a pine nut dessert.

—EMILY LUCHETTI, FARALLON (SAN FRANCISCO)

Pine nuts are really fatty and luxurious, so I like to use salt with them for balance. Even in a pesto, you notice the flavor of pine nuts versus using walnuts or no nuts.

—GINA DEPALMA, BABBO (NEW YORK CITY)

PINE NUTS

Weight: light

Volume: moderate

Techniques: toast

apples

apricots

basil

bell peppers

Central American cuisine

cheese: feta, goat, Parmesan, ricotta

cookies

Eastern Mediterranean cuisine

French cuisine, esp. southern

garlic

honey

Italian cuisine, esp. southern

lemon

liqueurs, orange

mascarpone

Mexican sauces

Middle Eastern cuisine

Moroccan cuisine

olive oil

onions

orange

pears

PESTO (key ingredient)

prunes

raisins

raspberries

rice

rum

sauc

Spanish cuisine, esp. southern

sugar

vanilla

vegetables, esp. roasted

walnuts

wine: red, sweet

Flavor Affinities

pine nuts + apples + apricots + rosemary

pine nuts + basil + garlic + olive oil + Parmesan cheese (pesto)

PINOT NOIR

Weight: light–medium

Volume: quiet–moderate

beef

chicken

duck

lamb

mushrooms

pork

salmon

tuna

veal

PIQUANCY

Taste: hot

Volume: loud

Function: warming

Tips: Stimulates appetite; enhances other flavors (e.g., salty, sour).

cayenne

chile peppers

garlic

ginger

horseradish

mustard, hot

onions, esp. raw

pepper, black

red pepper flakes

spices, many

wasabi

PISTACHIO OIL
(See Oil, Pistachio)

PISTACHIOS

(See also Nuts—In General)

Season: year-round

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate

Techniques: raw, roast, salt

anchovies

apples

apricots

artichokes

arugula

asparagus

bananas

basil

beets

cardamom

cauliflower

cheese: goat, Parmesan, ricotta, Taleggio

cherries

chicken

chocolate: dark, white

coconut

cranberries

cream and ice cream

Heat [aka **piquancy**] can come from a grind of black pepper when you are cooking, or at the last second on top of a salad before it goes out. Heat can also come from some jalapeño in steamed cockles with ginger and lemongrass. In either case, heat adds a brightness to the dish.

—SHARON HAGE, YORK STREET (DALLAS)

Dishes

Pistachio and Chocolate Semifreddo

—Gina DePalma, pastry chef, Babbo (New York City)

A Checkerboard Terrine of Pistachio and White Chocolate Ice Cream with Blackberry Sauce

—Patrick O’Connell, The Inn at Little Washington (Washington, Virginia)

Pistachios are a distinctively flavored nut. You need to be sure that what you pair with them will stand up. They go well with raspberries but not strawberries because the latter are softer in flavor.

—EMILY LUCHETTI, FARALLON (SAN FRANCISCO)

Pistachios look great with other nuts because you get green and brown alongside each other. They can be pretty mild so they are less about flavor and more about color and texture. Since pistachios are so mild I like to feature them solo or in a large quantity so they don’t get lost. I make a chocolate semifreddo and there is pistachio in the semifreddo, there is pistachio paste, they are on the plate, and they are in the sauce. They are front and center.

—GINA DEPALMA, BABBO (NEW YORK CITY)

dates

duck

Eastern Mediterranean cuisine

endive

figs: dried, fresh

foie gras

ginger

gooseberries

honey

Italian cuisine

kumquats

lavender

leeks

lemon

mangoes

mascarpone

Moroccan cuisine

nectarines

orange

parsley

pasta and pasta sauces

pastries

pâtés

PEACHES

poultry

prunes

quince

raisins, esp. golden

raspberries

rice

rosemary

rose water sausages

sugar

vanilla

watermelon

yogurt

AVOID

strawberries, which pistachios can easily overpower

PLANTAINS, GREEN

Botanical relatives: bananas

Weight: medium

Volume: quiet–moderate

Techniques: bake, boil, deep-fry, mash, sauté

Tips: Look for green plantains without any yellow.

African cuisine

bacon

butter

cardamom

Central American cuisine

chicken

chile peppers

cilantro

cinnamon

cloves

coriander

cumin

curry

fruits, tropical

garam masala

garlic

ginger

lime, juice

Mexican cuisine

molasses

oil: canola, vegetable

onions, esp. red

pepper, esp. black

pork

rice

salsa

salt, esp. kosher

soups

stews
yogurt

PLANTAINS, SWEET

Taste: sweet

Botanical relatives: bananas

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate

Techniques: bake, boil, deep-fry, sauté

Tip: Look for yellow to black plantains that ripen to black.

African cuisine

allspice

butter

Central American cuisine

chicken

chocolate

cinnamon

cloves

coconut

cranberries

cream and ice cream

fruits, tropical

ginger

honey

lemon, juice

lime, juice

Mexican cuisine

molasses

oil: canola, vegetable

orange: fruit, juice, zest

pepper, black

rice

rum, esp. dark

salt

star anise

sugar, esp. brown

toffee

PLUMS

Season: late spring–early autumn

Taste: sweet, astringent

Weight: light

Volume: moderate

Techniques: bake, poach, raw, stew

allspice

almonds

anise

anise hyssop

apricots, pureed

arugula

bay leaf

brandy, esp. plum

butter, unsalted

buttermilk

caramel

cardamom

cherries

cider

CINNAMON

cloves

coriander

cornmeal

cream and ice cream

crème fraîche custard

French cuisine

gin

ginger

Dishes

Plum and Bay Leaf Soup with Vanilla Yogurt Sorbetto

—Gina DePalma, pastry chef, Babbo (New York City)

Plum Cornmeal Cake with Plum Sorbet

—Emily Luchetti, pastry chef, Farallon (San Francisco)

hazelnuts

honey

juniper berries

Kirsch

lavender

LEMON: juice, zest

liqueurs: almond, orange, plum

mace

maple syrup

mint

nectarines

nutmeg

oatmeal

olive oil

onions, red

ORANGE: juice, zest

peaches

pecans

pepper, black

pies

prosciutto

raisins

raspberries

rum, dark

sage

salads

sour cream

strawberries

SUGAR: brown, confectioners', white

thyme

VANILLA

vinegar: balsamic, cider

walnuts

whiskey

wine, dry red or white or dessert

wine: port or sweet (e.g., plum)

yogurt

Flavor Affinities

plums + arugula + prosciutto

plums + bay leaf + vanilla

plums + cinnamon + cloves + red wine + sugar

plums + cinnamon + orange

plums + cream + sugar + vanilla

plums + ginger + raspberries

plums + ginger + yogurt

PLUMS, DRIED

(aka prunes)

Season: year-round

Taste: sweet

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: moderate

Techniques: raw, stew

allspice

almonds

anise

apples

apricots, dried

***ARMAGNAC**

bacon

baked goods

bay leaf

brandy, esp. apple, pear

caramel

cheese, esp. blue, goat, ricotta chestnuts

chocolate: dark, white

cinnamon

cloves

coffee

cognac

cream and ice cream

crème fraîche

I like **plums** with anise hyssop. That is a classic flavor combination and I serve it every year. They also work well with sage, and I have made sage ice cream to serve with plums.

—GINA DEPALMA, BABBO (NEW YORK CITY)

cumin
currants
custard
dates
figs, esp. dried
French cuisine
game
game birds
ginger
hazelnuts
honey, wildflower
lemon, zest
liqueurs: almond, other nut
macadamia nuts
maple syrup
Moroccan cuisine
oatmeal
orange, zest
pâté
pears
pecans
pepper, black
pine nuts
pistachios
pork
port, esp. tawny
quince
rabbit
raisins
rice pudding
rum
Southern Comfort
star anise
stews
sugar: brown, white
teas, esp. black or Earl Grey
thyme

turkey

vanilla

vinegar: champagne, white wine

WALNUTS

whiskey

WINE: dry red (e.g., Bordeaux, Cabernet Sauvignon), **Sauternes**, sweet white (e.g., Muscat)

Flavor Affinities

prunes + allspice + bay leaf + cinnamon + black pepper

prunes + apples + brandy + vanilla + yogurt

prunes + Armagnac + chocolate

prunes + Armagnac + crème fraîche

prunes + brandy + cream + vanilla

prunes + cheese + cumin + walnuts

prunes + cognac + honey + Sauternes

POLENTA

Weight: medium

Volume: quiet

Techniques: simmer

Tips: Grill or sauté cooked polenta.

bay leaf

beef

bell peppers, esp. red

butter, unsalted

CHEESE: Fontina, Gorgonzola, Gruyère, mozzarella, Parmesan, Taleggio

chervil

chicken

chives

cream / milk

egg, yolks

game birds

garlic

herbs

honey

Italian cuisine, esp. northern

marjoram

mascarpone

mushrooms, esp. chanterelles, porcini, shiitakes

oil: truffle, walnut

olive oil

parsley, flat-leaf

pepper: black, white

pork

red pepper flakes

rosemary salt: kosher,

sea

sausages

scallions

stocks: chicken, vegetable

thyme

tomatoes and tomato sauce

truffles, white

walnuts

Flavor Affinities

polenta + chanterelle mushrooms + white truffle oil

polenta + Gorgonzola cheese + mascarpone + walnuts

polenta + Parmesan cheese + rosemary

POMEGRANATES

Season: autumn

Taste: sour, sweet

Function: cooling

Weight: light–medium

Volume: moderate

Techniques: raw, ice/sorbet

allspice

almonds

arugula

avocados

Dishes

Cornish Game Hens with Pomegranate Sauce and Toasted Almonds

—Rafih Benjelloun, Imperial Fez (Atlanta)

Pomegranate Glazed Specialty Chicken Breast with Coconut-Onion Curry

—Vikram Vij and Meeru Dhalwala, Vij's (Vancouver)

bananas

beets

cardamom

chicken

chile peppers

chocolate, white

cinnamon

cloves

coconut

coriander

couscous

cream

cucumbers

cumin

curry

desserts

fish

garlic

ginger, esp. fresh

grapefruit

hazelnuts

honey

hummus

kumquat

lamb

legumes

lemon, juice

lime, juice

meats, roasted

Middle Eastern cuisine

nutmeg

olive oil

onions

orange, juice

parsley

pine nuts

pomegranate molasses (key ingredient)

pork

poultry (e.g., turkey)

SALADS, esp. cucumber, fruit, green

sesame seeds

sorbets

stewed dishes

sugar

tequila

turmeric

vinegar: balsamic, red wine

walnuts

wine: port, red, white

Flavor Affinities

pomegranates + almonds + cinnamon + cloves + garlic + ginger + honey

pomegranates + chicken + coconut + curry + onions

pomegranates + lemon + sugar

What is nice about **pomegranates** is that they are very flavorful but don't have a lot of sugar in them. They also have a unique flavor that is not like anything else. It is one of the few flavors that have come around in popularity because they have made it easier to use [via pomegranate juice, molasses, etc.].

Cleaning them to use just the seeds can be a pain in the neck. However, I use the juice because it makes a great sorbet.

—**EMILY LUCHETTI**, FARALLON (SAN FRANCISCO)

POMEGRANATE MOLASSES

Taste: sweet, sour

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: moderate–loud

allspice

beef

chicken

chile peppers cinnamon

cloves

duck

game

game birds

ginger

lamb

marinades

meats

Middle Eastern cuisine

mustard

mustard seeds

olive oil

pepper

pork

poultry

salad dressings

vinegar, balsamic

walnuts

POMELOS

(See also Grapefruit)

Taste: sour, sweet

Weight: light

Volume: loud

Techniques: broil, raw

avocado

chicken

chili powder

coconut

crab

fish

fish sauce

ginger, pickled

lemongrass

maple

onions

peanuts

pomegranate

salads

salt

scallops

shrimp

spinach

Flavor Affinities

pomelo + pickled ginger + fish

pomelo + salt + chili powder

Pomelo is good in salads. During the summer, we will mix it with pickled ginger and a couple of other ingredients and serve it on chicken or fish.

—BRAD FARMERIE, PUBLIC (NEW YORK CITY)

PONZU SAUCE

Taste: sour

Weight: light–medium

Volume: moderate–loud

beef

dashi

fish, esp. grilled or raw

Japanese cuisine

meat, esp. grilled

sashimi

shellfish

soy sauce

ume (Japanese plum)

POPPY SEEDS

Taste: sweet

Weight: light

Volume: quiet

apples

Asian cuisine

BAKED GOODS (e.g., breads, cakes, cookies, pastries)

beans, green

butter, unsalted

buttermilk

cabbage

carrots

cauliflower

cheese, ricotta

cinnamon

cloves

cream

curry powder

desserts

eggplant

eggs and egg dishes

fish

fruits

ginger

honey

Indian cuisine

lemon

Mediterranean cuisine

noodles

nutmeg

onions, esp. sweet

pasta

pastries

potatoes

rice

salads and salad dressings, esp. creamy

sauces, esp. creamy

sesame seeds

sour cream

spinach

strawberries

sugar

Turkish cuisine

vanilla

vegetables

walnuts

zucchini

PORK—IN GENERAL

Season: autumn

Taste: sweet–astringent

Function: heating

Techniques: Use dry-heat cooking (e.g., broil, grill, roast) for tender cuts of pork, and moist-heat cooking (e.g., braise, stew) for tougher cuts of pork.

aioli

almonds

anchovies

anise

APPLES: cider, fruit, juice

apricots

asparagus

bacon

barbecue dishes

basil

bay leaf

beans: green, navy, white bean

bell peppers: green, red, yellow

brandy

bread crumbs

butter, unsalted

cabbage: green, red

Calvados

capers

caraway seeds

cardamom

carrots

cayenne

celery

cheese: Gruyère, Jack

chile peppers, esp. ancho, dried red, jalapeño

chili powder

Chinese cuisine

chives

cider

cilantro

cinnamon

cloves

coconut milk

coriander

cornichons

corn

cranberries

cream

cumin

curry powder

fennel

fennel seeds

figs

fish sauce, Thai

French cuisine, esp. southern

fruit: dried, fresh

GARLIC

ginger: fresh, ground dried

ham, Serrano

honey

horseradish

Italian cuisine, esp. southern

ketchup

Korean cuisine, esp. northern

LEMON: juice, zest

lemongrass

lemon verbena

lentils

lime, juice

mace

mangoes: green, ripe

marjoram

Mexican cuisine

mint, esp. spearmint

Dishes

Rack of Pork, Marinated in Oranges, Thyme, and Garlic, Served with Fennel and Black Olive Ouzo and Orange Sauce

—Ann Cashion, Cashion’s Eat Place (Washington, DC)

Suckling Pig with Quince Paste and Romesco Sauce

—Suzanne Goin, at the 2003 James Beard Awards gala reception

Roasted Rack of Pork with Apple Butter Glaze, Country Ham Spoon Bread, Roasted Apples, Mustard Greens, and Bourbon Glaze

—Bob Kinkead, Colvin Run (Vienna, Virginia)

Beer-Braised Pork Belly with Sauerkraut and Ginger Jus

—Gabriel Kreuther, The Modern (New York City)

Organic Berkshire Pork Tenderloin Marinated in Wheat Beer with Barley Risotto, Turnips, and Chicory Emulsion

—Gabriel Kreuther, The Modern (New York City)

Pork with Fig Maple Jus and Dutch Cabbage

—Monica Pope, T’afia (Houston)

Cuban Roast Pork Marinated in an Allspice-Cumin Adobo with Ripe Plantains, Rich Oaxacan Six-Chile Mole Sauce, and “Moors and Christians” Rice

—Maricel Presilla, Zafra (Hoboken, New Jersey)

Trio of Pan-Seared Pork Tenderloin with House-Made Sausage and Potato Pierogis

—Celina Tio, American Restaurant (Kansas City)

Marinated Pork Medallions with Garlic-Yogurt Curry and Naan Bread

—Vikram Vij and Meeru Dhalwala, Vij's (Vancouver)

You'll often see what is essentially clam chowder [without the clams] used as a sauce: the combination of **pork**—whether it's bacon, chorizo, or whatever—and thyme, served with potatoes and cream. It could be served with something poached or sautéed. It is a cute reworking of something that is classic.

—**DAVID WALTUCK**, CHANTERELLE (NEW YORK CITY)

I like the combination of **pork** with fruit. With a pork chop, fresh and dried figs or strawberries would all work.

—**MARCEL DESAULNIERS**, THE TRELLIS (WILLIAMSBURG, VIRGINIA)

Sauces often don't do justice to the meat they're saucing. For that reason, we don't use veal stock with **pork**, which hides the flavor of the meat. Instead, we want to do everything we can to emphasize the flavor of the pork itself. So, we'll roast the pork scraps and bones and make a pork stock instead. In the summertime, to keep it light, we won't even add wine.

—**DAN BARBER**, BLUE HILL AT STONE BARN (POCANTICO HILLS, NEW YORK)

mirepoix

molasses

mushrooms, esp. shiitake **mustard, Dijon**

mustard seeds

noodles/pasta

nutmeg

OIL: canola, grapeseed, sesame, vegetable

olive oil

olives

ONIONS, esp. green, pearl, red, sweet, white, yellow

ORANGE: juice, zest

oregano

paprika: smoked, sweet

parsley, flat-leaf

peanuts and peanut sauce

pears

peas, black-eyed

pecans

***PEPPER: black, white**

pineapple

pine nuts

piquillo peppers

plums

port

potatoes, mashed or roasted

prosciutto

prunes

quince

radicchio

red pepper flakes

rice or risotto

ROSEMARY

saffron

sage

salt: kosher, sea

sauerkraut

shallots

sherry, cream

sour cream

soy sauce

spaetzle

Spanish cuisine, esp. southern

squash: acorn, butternut

star anise

stock, chicken

Pork can handle all the sweet spices, including allspice, cinnamon, and clove.

—BRADFORD THOMPSON, MARY ELAINE'S AT THE PHOENICIAN (SCOTTSDALE, ARIZONA)

sugar (pinch)

sweet potatoes

Tabasco sauce

tangerine, juice

tea, black (e.g., Lapsang Souchong)

THYME

tomatoes and tomato paste

turmeric

turnips

vanilla

verjus

vermouth, dry

Vietnamese cuisine

VINEGAR: balsamic, red wine, rice wine, sherry, white wine

walnuts

watercress

wine: dry red, white

Worcestershire sauce

yogurt

Flavor Affinities

pork + allspice + mace

pork + apples + mustard

pork + bacon + mustard + sauerkraut

pork + chile peppers + cilantro + garlic + lime + peanuts

pork + cinnamon + star anise

pork + coriander + honey + soy sauce

pork + clove + garlic + orange

pork + cream + potatoes + thyme

pork + curry + garlic + yogurt

pork + fennel + garlic

pork + garlic + ginger + molasses

pork + ginger + honey + soy sauce

pork + mustard + sauerkraut

pork + port + rosemary

PORK—BACON

(See Bacon)

PORK—BELLY

Techniques: braise, double-cook, pan-fry

apples

bacon

bay leaf

beets

caraway

carrots

celery

cilantro

cinnamon

citrus

cumin

eggs

fennel

garlic

leeks

mushrooms

oil, peanut

olive oil

onions

paprika

parsley, flat-leaf

parsnips

pepper, black

potatoes

rosemary

sake

salt: kosher, sea shallots

soy sauce

star anise

stocks: chicken, veal

thyme

vegetables, root
vinegar, champagne
zucchini

PORK—CHOPS

Techniques: dry-heat cooking (e.g., broil, grill, roast, sauté)

APPLES: cider, fruit, sauce

arugula

beans

bread crumbs

broccoli rabe

butter

cabbage, red

coriander

corn

fennel

fennel pollen

I'm sometimes inspired by looking back to my childhood and the combinations of flavors I liked. I was a pretty picky eater growing up, but I loved my macaroni and cheese, and bacon and eggs. I came up with a take on bacon and eggs substituting **pork belly** for the bacon. I love pork belly—it is a poor man's foie gras, the way it just melts in your mouth. I make the eggs in a double boiler that gives them a creamy texture, and finish them with fresh herbs. For the belly, we grill it and then braise it in citrus, champagne vinegar, and veal stock for six hours. Then at serving, we grill it again and top it with a "sweet heat" sauce which is like a barbecue sauce with layers and layers of flavor.

—**BOB IACOVONE**, CUVÉE (NEW ORLEANS)

Dishes

Grilled Pork Chop with Artichokes, Cipollini, and Aceto Manodori

—Mario Batali, Babbo (New York City)

Pork Chop, Creamed Sweet Corn, Pan-Fried Summer Squash, and Crushed Blackberries

—Cory Schreiber, Wildwood (Portland, Oregon)

garlic

ginger

greens

honey

lemon, juice

lentils

molasses

mustard (esp. Dijon) and mustard seeds

olive oil

onions

peaches

pepper, black

polenta

potatoes: mashed, steamed

prosciutto

rosemary

SAGE

sauerkraut

spinach

stock, chicken

sugar: brown, white

tomatoes

vanilla

vinegar: balsamic, cider

Flavor Affinities

pork chop + apples + ginger + sage

pork chop + arugula + tomatoes

pork chop + greens + sweet potatoes

pork chop + peaches + balsamic vinegar

PORK—HAM

(See Ham)

PORK—LOIN

Techniques: dry-heat cooking (e.g., bake, braise, grill, roast, sauté)

bay leaf
brandy
cabbage, red
chile peppers, ancho
cilantro
cinnamon
figs
garlic
ginger
lemongrass
lime, juice
maple syrup
mustard
mustard seeds
onions
oregano
port
potatoes
rosemary
sage
sake
soy sauce
stock, chicken
thyme
vinegar, white
wine, white

Flavor Affinities

pork loin + figs + onions
pork loin + red cabbage + port wine

PORK—RIBS

Techniques: bake, barbecue, braise, broil, grill, roast, sauté

allspice

bay leaf

beer

bourbon

butter

cabbage

chile peppers, guajillo

chili powder

cider

coffee

coriander

cumin

garlic

ginger

hoisin sauce

honey

hot sauce

ketchup

lemongrass

liquid smoke

mirepoix

molasses

mustard, Dijon

olive oil

onions, esp. white

oregano

paprika: hot, smoked

parsley, flat-leaf

pepper, black

potatoes

salt: kosher, sea

sesame oil

soy sauce

sugar, brown

Tabasco sauce

thyme

tomatoes and tomato puree

vinegar: apple cider, balsamic, red wine, sherry, white wine

Worcestershire sauce

PORK—SAUSAGE

(See Sausages)

PORK—SHOULDER

Techniques: moist-heat cooking (e.g., barbecue, braise, stew)

achiote

allspice

andouille sausage (key ingredient)

apples

barbecue sauce

bay leaf

cayenne

chile peppers

cinnamon

coriander

cornmeal (e.g., grits, polenta)

couscous

cumin

five-spice powder

GARLIC

ginger

honey

lemon

lime

maple syrup

milk

mushrooms

orange

oregano

paprika

port

quince

rice

rum

sage

soy sauce

sugar, brown

thyme

tomatoes

vinegar

wine, red

Flavor Affinities

pork shoulder + bay leaves + wild mushrooms

pork shoulder + chipotle peppers + cumin + tomatoes

pork shoulder + plantains + rice + rum

PORK—TENDERLOIN

Techniques: dry-heat cooking (e.g., broil, grill, roast, sauté)

artichokes, Jerusalem

bacon

beans, green

cardamom

cilantro

cinnamon

corn

fennel

ginger

lime

maple syrup

marjoram

mushrooms, porcini, dried

mustard

olive oil

onions: cipollini, yellow

orange

oregano

pancetta

parsley

pepper, black

polenta

potatoes

red pepper flakes

rosemary

rum, esp. dark

sage

savory

sherry

sour cream

sugar, brown

tarragon

turmeric

vinegar, balsamic

yogurt

PORTUGUESE CUISINE

anise
bread
chile peppers, piri piri
cilantro
cinnamon
clams
cod
custards
eggs
fish
garlic
kale
olive oil
onions
paprika
parsley
pork, esp. cured
port
potatoes
rice
saffron
shellfish
tomatoes
turkey
vanilla

Flavor Affinities

clams + garlic + paprika + pork
cod + eggs + onions + potatoes
garlic + kale + onions + potatoes
piri piri peppers + garlic + lemon juice + olive oil + salt

We make a **potato** stew with bacon, olives, mushrooms, and onions, which is perfect for cold winter Sunday suppers. We add two strong flavors—bacon and olives—to the potato. Onions and porcini mushrooms add another layer of flavor.

—MICHEL RICHARD, CITRONELLE (WASHINGTON, DC)

POTATOES

Season: year-round

Function: cooling

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: quiet

Techniques: bake, boil, deep-fry, gratin, grill, mash (use older, starchier potatoes), puree, roast, sauté, steam

arugula

bacon

basil

BAY LEAF

BEEF

bell peppers, green, esp. roasted

BUTTER, unsalted

buttermilk

caraway seeds

cardamom

carrots

cauliflower (e.g., Indian cuisine)

caviar

cayenne

celery

celery root

CHEESE: Brin d'Amour, Cantal, cheddar, Comté, Dry Jack, Emmental, Fontina, goat, Gouda, Gruyère, manchego, Parmesan, pecorino, raclette, Roquefort, Torta del Casar

chervil

chicken

chickpeas (e.g., Indian cuisine)

chicory

chile peppers (e.g., Indian, Thai cuisine)

chili oil

CHIVES

cilantro

cinnamon

cloves

coriander

CREAM / MILK

crème fraîche

cumin

curry

dill

eggs

French cuisine

garam masala

GARLIC

ginger

greens, winter

herbs

kale

lamb

lavender

LEEKS

lemon, juice

lovage

marjoram

mayonnaise

morels

mushrooms, esp. wild

mussels

mustard: Dijon, dry

nutmeg

OIL: canola, peanut, vegetable

olive oil

olives, e.g., black

ONIONS: green, red, Spanish, Vidalia

oysters

paprika

parsley, flat-leaf

parsnips

peas

PEPPER: black, white

pork and pork belly

ramps

ROSEMARY

rutabagas

saffron

sage

salads

SALT: kosher, sea

salt cod

sausages: chorizo, Italian

savory

scallions

shallots

sorrel

sour cream

spinach (e.g., Indian cuisine)

squash, winter (e.g., butternut)

STEAK

STOCKS: chicken, vegetable

sweet potatoes

THYME

tomatoes

truffles, black



turmeric

turnips

vegetables, root vinaigrettes

vinegar: champagne, sherry, white wine

wine, dry white

yogurt

Flavor Affinities

potatoes + bacon + cheese + onions

potatoes + chives + sour cream

potatoes + cream + garlic + Parmesan cheese + rosemary

potatoes + cream + leeks + oysters

potatoes + Gruyère cheese + winter squash

potatoes + leeks + nutmeg

POTATOES, NEW

Season: spring–summer

Weight: medium

Volume: quiet

Techniques: boil, roast, steam

Tips: New potatoes are best not baked or fried.

chives

cream

garlic

mint

olive oil

paprika

parsley

pepper, black

rosemary

salt

savory

shallots

tarragon

thyme

vinegar

Flavor Affinities

new potatoes + garlic + shallots + tarragon + vinegar

POULTRY

(See Chicken, Turkey, etc.)

PROSCIUTTO

Taste: salty

Weight: light–medium (depending on thinness of slicing)

Volume: moderate

almonds

apples

arugula

asparagus

basil

cheese: Fontina, Gruyère, Parmesan, provolone

chestnuts

chicken

chicory

cilantro

fennel

FIGS

grapes

hazelnuts

honey

Italian cuisine

lemon, juice

lime, juice

***MELON**, esp. cantaloupe, honeydew

mushrooms

mustard, esp. Dijon

mustard seeds

nectarines

olive oil

pasta

pears

pepper: black, white

pine nuts

pomegranate molasses

sage

spinach

tomatoes

walnuts

PRUNES

(See Plums, Dried)

PUMPKIN

(See also Squashes, Winter)

Season: autumn

Taste: sweet

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: moderate

Techniques: bake, braise, grill, puree, roast

allspice

amaretti cookie crumbs

apples

bay leaf

brandy, esp. apple

BUTTER, unsalted

caramel

carrots

cayenne

CHEESE: feta, Gruyère, Parmesan

chile peppers

chocolate, white

cilantro

CINNAMON

CLOVES

coconut

cognac

cranberries

CREAM

cream cheese

crème anglaise

crème fraîche

Dishes

Prosciutto San Daniele with Black Pepper Fettunta and Figs

—Mario Batali, Babbo (New York City)

Fig and Prosciutto Pizza

—Todd English, Figs (Charlestown, Massachusetts)



Dishes

Pumpkin, Brown Sugar, and Tempura with Cinnamon Fragrance

—Grant Achatz, Alinea (Chicago)

Pumpkin “Lune” with Butter, Sage, and Amaretti

—Mario Batali, Babbo (New York City)

Creamy Pumpkin and Cream Cheese Custard with Orange-Rum Raisins

—Gina DePalma, pastry chef, Babbo (New York City)

Grilled Pineapple and Caribbean Pumpkin Salad with Pumpkin Seeds and Cacao Nib Vinaigrette

—Maricel Presilla, Zafra (Hoboken, New Jersey)

cumin

curry

custard

duck

garlic

GINGER: fresh, ground

hazelnuts

honey

Italian cuisine

kumquats

lemon, juice

lime, juice

lobster

mace

maple syrup

marjoram
molasses
mushrooms
NUTMEG
nuts
oatmeal
oil: sesame, vegetable
olive oil
onions: red, white
orange: juice, zest
orange liqueur (e.g., Grand Marnier)
oysters
pasta (e.g., ravioli, tortelli)
pecans
pepper: black, white
pine nuts
pork
potatoes
pumpkin: oil, seeds
radicchio
raisins
risotto
rosemary
rum, esp. dark
SAGE
salt, kosher
scallops
shrimp
soups
sour cream

With **pumpkin** or even sweet potatoes, the combination of allspice, cinnamon, ginger, and clove works great. If you buy canned pumpkin that has spices already added, it tastes a little off and artificial. Depending on how you like your spices, you typically add equal amounts of ginger and cinnamon and less allspice and clove because the last two are very strong.

—EMILY LUCHETTI, FARALLON (SAN FRANCISCO)

Pumpkin and butternut squash juices are great in dishes featuring [each respective vegetable]. What the juice does is intensify their flavor, making the dishes taste more natural.

—ANDREW CARMELLINI, A VOCE (NEW YORK CITY)

I had to come up with a recipe for a vegan cookbook, and ended up making a **pumpkin** and coconut milk custard thickened with agar-agar that was so delicious, I put it on the menu!

—BRADFORD THOMPSON, MARY ELAINE'S AT THE PHOENICIAN (SCOTTSDALE, ARIZONA)

Pumpkin and bay leaf together make the pumpkin taste even more pumpkin-like.

—JERRY TRAUNFELD, THE HERBFARM (WOODINVILLE, WASHINGTON)

My **pumpkin** pie soup dish was inspired by walking through Whole Foods and seeing pumpkins. I thought, How do I like my pumpkin? I like pumpkin pie, and thought it would actually make an interesting soup. I made a pumpkin soup and found the soup to be very savory with its spicing, and added smoked duck to it. I wanted a contrasting flavor, so I added some sweet meringue as a garnish. Then I needed a contrast to the creaminess, so I put in a piece of pie crust a second before serving as well as toasted pecans for even more crunch.

—BOB IACOVONE, CUVÉE (NEW ORLEANS)

stews

stock, chicken

SUGAR: brown, white

sweet potatoes

Thanksgiving

thyme

turnips

vanilla

vinegar, balsamic
walnuts
wine, dry white
wine, sweet
yogurt

PUMPKIN SEED OIL
(See Oil, Pumpkin Seed)

PUMPKIN SEEDS

Season: autumn

Weight: light

Volume: quiet

Techniques: bake, roast

caramel

chile peppers, jalapeño

cilantro

coriander

cumin

Mexican cuisine

salt

PURSLANE

Season: summer

Taste: sour

Weight: light

Volume: moderate

Techniques: raw, sauté

beans, green

cucumber

garlic

Wild **purslane** has a lemony flavor and waxy leaves. It makes me think of a salad of very young green beans that are three inches long and tossed with the purslane and a splash of white wine vinegar and Ligurian olive oil.

—MICHAEL ANTHONY, GRAMERCY TAVERN (NEW YORK CITY)

Flavor Affinities

pumpkin + allspice + bay leaf + cinnamon + salt

pumpkin + allspice + cinnamon + ginger

pumpkin + amaretti cookie crumbs + butter + pasta + sage

pumpkin + apples + curry

pumpkin + brown sugar + pine nuts

pumpkin + butter + garlic + chicken stock + thyme

pumpkin + chile peppers + garlic

pumpkin + cream cheese + orange + rum

pumpkin + cream cheese + pumpkin seeds + sugar

pumpkin + custard + garlic

pumpkin + honey + balsamic vinegar

pumpkin + olive oil + rosemary

Dishes

Pepitas: Toasted Pumpkin Seeds Seasoned with Cumin, Coriander, and Jalapeño

—Traci Des Jardins, Mijita (San Francisco)

Cilantro and Pumpkin Seed Pesto

—Jerry Traunfeld, The Herbfarm (Woodinville, Washington)

herbs: chervil, cilantro, mint

olive oil

smoked trout

tomatoes

vinegar, white wine

yogurt

QUAIL

Season: late spring–autumn

Weight: light–medium

Volume: quiet–moderate

Techniques: braise, broil, grill, pan roast, roast, sauté

almonds

anchovies

anisettes

apples

arugula

bacon

bay leaf

bell peppers, esp. red bourbon

brandy

butter, unsalted

capers

cardamom

carrots

chard

chestnuts

chicken livers

chile peppers, esp. green

chili powder

cinnamon

cloves

coconut

cognac

coriander

cream

cumin

currants

curries

dandelion greens

fennel

figs

foie gras

frisée

garlic

ginger, fresh or ground

grapes, esp. seedless

ham

honey

Italian cuisine

leeks

lemon, juice

lentils

maple syrup

marjoram

mint

molasses

mushrooms, wild

mustard, Dijon

OIL: canola, peanut, sesame, vegetable

olive oil

onions, spring

orange: juice, zest

oysters

pancetta

parsley, flat-leaf

pears

peas

pepper, black, pink

pine nuts

pistachios

polenta

pomegranates and pomegranate molasses

potatoes, esp. creamer

prosciutto

rosemary

saffron

sage

salsify

salt

sausage

scallions

shallots

sherry

soy sauce

stocks: chicken, vegetable

stuffing

sugar, brown

sumac

Tabasco sauce

tamarind

tarragon

THYME

tomato paste

truffles, white

vinaigrette

VINEGAR: balsamic, red wine, sherry

walnuts

wine: red, white

Flavor Affinities

quail + arugula + pomegranate

quail + bacon + Brussels sprouts

quail + bacon + garlic + lemon

quail + bourbon + molasses + pears

quail + chanterelle mushrooms + tarragon + tomato

quail + cinnamon + sumac

quail + figs + vinaigrette

quail + marjoram + olive oil + rosemary + sage + thyme

QUATRE ÉPICES

beef, esp. braised

charcuterie

duck

foie gras

French cuisine

game

pâté

sausages

soups

stews

vegetables

venison, esp. braised

Quail is too delicate for rosemary, so I like it with a little lavender, pink peppercorns, and *fleur de sel*.

—SHARON HAGE, YORK STREET (DALLAS)

Dishes

Quail Corn Bread and Pecan Stuffed Breast, Leg Confit, Sweet Corn Pudding, and Chanterelle Mushrooms

—Jeffrey Bubben, Vidalia (Washington, DC)

Glazed Quail with Caramelized Fennel Bulb and Tangerine Marmalade

—Thomas Keller, The French Laundry (Yountville, California)

Walnut-Glazed Quail with a Ragout of Organic Shell Beans, Shiitake Mushrooms, and Applewood-Smoked Bacon

—Gabriel Kreuther, The Modern (New York City)

Roast “Brace” of Quail and La Quercia “Americano” Prosciutto with a “Fondant” of Austrian Crescent Potatoes, Roasted Acorn Squash, Red Pearl Onions, Swiss Chard, and Tarragon

—Carrie Nahabedian, Naha (Chicago)

Two Texas Cross Quail and Braised Cabbage with Apple and Hazelnuts

—Monica Pope, T’afia (Houston)

Roasted Quail with Smoked Bacon, Brussels Sprouts, and a Quail Jus

—Thierry Rautureau, Rover’s (Seattle)

Pan-Fried Coriander Quail Cakes with Coconut Curried Vegetables

—Vikram Vij and Meeru Dhalwala, Vij’s (Vancouver)

Flavor Affinities

cloves (allspice or cinnamon) + ginger + nutmeg + black and/or white pepper

QUINCE

Season: autumn

Taste: sour

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate

Techniques: bake, poach, stew

almonds

***APPLES: fruit, juice**

Armagnac

bay leaf

beef

brandy

butter, unsalted Calvados

caramel

cardamom

CHEESE, ESP. GOAT, MANCHEGO, RICOTTA, and esp. with quince paste

cherries

chicken

cinnamon

cloves

cranberries

cream and ice cream

custards

dates

figs, esp. dried

fruits, dried, esp. apricots, cherries, plums

ginger

hazelnuts

honey

jams and jellies

kumquats

lamb

lemon, juice

liqueurs, nut

maple syrup

mascarpone

meats

nutmeg

orange

***PEARS**

pecans

pepper, black

pies (e.g., apple)

pistachios

poultry

raisins

raspberries

Spanish cuisine (quince paste)

star anise

sugar: brown, white

vanilla

walnuts

whiskey

wine: red, sweet

wine, white, e.g., Riesling

yogurt

Dishes

Roasted Quince, Foie Gras, and Candied Fennel with Sweet Spices

—Grant Achatz, Alinea (Chicago)

Quince and Marcona Almond “Crisp,” Mascarpone Sorbet, and Pedro Ximenez Sherry Caramel

—Elizabeth Dahl, pastry chef, Naha (Chicago)

Quince-Filled Maple-Whiskey Cake with Goat Cheese Ice Cream

—Dominique and Cindy Duby, Wild Sweets (Vancouver)

Granny Smith Apple Sorbet, Quince, Quinoa, Pecans

—Johnny Iuzzini, pastry chef, Jean Georges (New York City)

Quince is something that will never be mainstream because of its unique flavor and the fact that you just can’t peel it and eat it. But if you peel quince and cook it forever and show it some love, it is so much better than an apple or a pear.

—EMILY LUCHETTI, FARALLON (SAN FRANCISCO)

RABBIT

(See also Game—In General)

Season: autumn–winter

Taste: sweet–astringent

Function: heating

Weight: medium

Volume: quiet–moderate

Techniques: barbecue, braise (esp. legs, thighs), broil, grill, roast, sauté, stew

almonds

apples

artichokes

arugula

asparagus, white

BACON, esp. smoked

barbecue sauce

basil

bay leaf

beans: fava, green, white

beer

bell peppers

brandy

bread crumbs

butter, unsalted

cabbage, esp. red

carrots

cayenne

celery root

cherries

chervil

chiles, esp. Thai

chives

chocolate, esp. dark

cider

cilantro
cinnamon
cloves
coconut milk

Dishes

Rabbit Enchiladas with Red Chile Mole and Pumpkin Seeds

—Robert Del Grande, at the 2003 James Beard Awards gala reception

Braised Rabbit with Winter Vegetables, Abita Beer Bread, Truffled Parsnips

—Bob Iacovone, Cuvée (New Orleans)

Roast Loin of Rabbit with a “Ragoût” of Braised Rabbit, Confit Garlic Crushed Potatoes, Applewood Slab Bacon, “Hen of the Woods” Mushrooms, Glazed Young Carrots, and Turnips

—Carrie Nahabedian, Naha (Chicago)

Roasted Rabbit Saddle with Root Vegetables, Green Lentils, and a Game Jus

—Thierry Rautureau, Rover’s (Seattle)

Rabbit Braised in Arneis with Chickpea Crepe and Pancetta

—Holly Smith, Café Juanita (Seattle)

Rabbit Consommé, Morels, Pea, and Lavender Emulsion

—Rick Tramonto, Tru (Chicago)

coriander

corn

cream

cumin

currants (e.g., currant jelly)

curry paste, Thai yellow

fennel leaves
fennel seeds
fish sauce, Thai
French cuisine

GARLIC

ginger
hazelnuts
Italian cuisine
leeks
lemon: juice, zest
lemongrass
lime: juice, leaves
Marsala
Mediterranean cuisine
mint
mirepoix

mushrooms

MUSTARD: Dijon, dry

OIL: canola, grapeseed, hazelnut, peanut, vegetable, walnut

olive oil

olives, esp. green, black, kalamata

ONIONS, esp. pearl, Spanish, yellow

orange, zest

oregano

pancetta

paprika: smoked, sweet

parsley, flat-leaf

pasta/noodles, egg

PEPPER: black, pink, white

pine nuts

plums

port

potatoes

prunes

rice and risotto

rosemary

saffron

sage

salt: kosher, sea

sesame seeds

shallots

soy sauce

spinach

star anise

STOCKS: chicken, rabbit, veal

sugar (pinch)

Tabasco sauce

tarragon

THYME

tomatoes and tomato paste

vegetable puree

VINEGAR: balsamic, cider, red wine, sherry, white wine

WINE: dry red, dry white (e.g., Riesling), Champagne

Flavor Affinities

rabbit + bacon + rosemary

rabbit + garlic + potatoes + rosemary + shallots

rabbit + mushrooms + noodles

rabbit + mushrooms + tarragon

rabbit + mustard + red wine

rabbit + vinegar + red wine

rabbit + rosemary + tomato

rabbit + shallots + white beans

A dish I am really proud of is our saddle of **rabbit** served with green olives, shallots, marjoram, and fennel jam. This is a light and beautifully balanced dish that reminds me of Liguria [in Italy]. The olives are salty, the marjoram is strong, and the fennel is sweet. This has been on our menu for over a year but it took me a few tries to get right. I tried black olives, but they were too strong. I tried rosemary, but it was too earthy. I tried Brussels sprouts, but they were a little too bitter and didn't complement the same way sweet fennel did. So though the combination didn't work for the saddle, the black olives and rosemary led me to add some rabbit liver and stuff a whole boned rabbit. That

dish did work. The two dishes were different in the sense that the saddle with the green olives was a little more sophisticated while the whole rabbit was more of a peasant dish. Customers like both!

—**ODETTE FADA**, SAN DOMENICO (NEW YORK CITY)

RADICCHIO

Season: year-round

Taste: bitter

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: moderate–loud

Techniques: braise, grill, roast, sear

anchovies

apples

arugula

bacon

beans, esp. shell, white

beef

butter

capers

CHEESE, esp. pungent and/or Asiago, blue, dry Jack, feta, **Gorgonzola**,

Gruyère, **PARMESAN**

chicken, esp. roasted

chives

duck

eggs, esp. hard-boiled

endive

fennel

figs

fish

garlic

horseradish

ITALIAN CUISINE

lamb

lemon: juice, zest

lime, juice

lobster

mushrooms, wild

mustard, Dijon

oil, corn

OLIVE OIL

onions, red

orange: juice, zest

pancetta

parsley, flat-leaf

pasta

pears

pecans

pepper: black, white

pine nuts

pizza

pork

poultry

prosciutto

pumpkin and pumpkin oil

red pepper flakes

risotto

rosemary

salads and salad dressings

salami

SALT

seafood, esp. grilled or roasted

shallots

shrimp

squab

VINEGAR: BALSAMIC, red wine, sherry

walnuts

wine, dry white

Flavor Affinities

radicchio + arugula + endive

radicchio + Asiago cheese + olive oil + balsamic vinegar

radicchio + duck + risotto + reduced balsamic vinegar

radicchio + fennel + prosciutto

radicchio + Gorgonzola cheese + pears

radicchio + hard-boiled eggs + olive oil + prosciutto + sherry vinegar + walnuts
radicchio + mushrooms + risotto + balsamic vinegar

RADISHES

Season: spring–autumn

Taste: pungent

Function: heating

Weight: light

Volume: moderate–loud

Techniques: braise, raw

anchovies

avocados

basil

bread: French, rye

BUTTER, esp. sweet

celery

cheese, esp. blue, feta chervil

chives

cilantro

crab

cream

It's vital that you taste your ingredients to determine the best way to serve them. We got a new **radicchio** in that is so bitter it just won't work as a salad. Instead, we will turn it into a pesto or a tiny garnish.

—MONICA POPE, T'AFIA (HOUSTON)

Dishes

Grilled Radicchio Trevisano with Asiago and Horseradish

—Mario Batali, Babbo (New York City)

Radicchio Salad with Parmesan Balsamic Vinaigrette

—Hiro Sone and Lissa Doumani, Terra (St. Helena, California)

There is a time of year when all there seems to be in the green market is **radishes**. You get sick of seeing them and they are there for months. I needed to create something new and all there was were radishes. So, I came up with a radish salad served with lobster. We blanch turnip rounds and fold in a little baby ginger to get this wonderfully peppery salad. The sauce with the lobster is a pistachio vinaigrette that is bound by onion puree and brightened by the juice that pickled the ginger. We finish the dish with toasted pistachios and add a pistachio oil. The pistachio nut and oil add an earthy quality and depth of flavor to the dish.

—MICHAEL ANTHONY, GRAMERCY TAVERN (NEW YORK CITY)

cream cheese

cucumbers

curry powder

dill

fennel

fish, esp. white

lemon, juice

lettuces

lobster

lovage

marjoram

mint

olive oil
onions
orange: fruit, juice
oregano
parsley, flat-leaf
pears
pecans
pepper
rosemary
salads
SALT, esp. SEA
scallions
sesame oil
shallots
shrimp
soy sauce
tamari
thyme
vinaigrettes
VINEGAR: cider, white wine

Flavor Affinities

radishes + bread + butter + salt

RAISINS

Taste: sweet

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate

Techniques: bake, raw, stew

allspice

almonds

anise

apples

apricots, dried

baked goods (e.g., cookies)

bananas

brandy

breakfast (e.g., cereals, oatmeal)

butter, unsalted

buttermilk

caramel

carrots

cheese: goat, ricotta

chestnuts

chocolate: dark, white

cinnamon

cloves

cognac

crème fraîche

currants

custard

dates

desserts

figs, dried

ginger

hazelnuts

honey

ice cream

Indian cuisine

Italian cuisine, esp. Venetian

lemon: juice, zest

liqueurs, nut

maple syrup

mascarpone

mole sauces

Moroccan cuisine

nutmeg

nuts

oatmeal

orange: juice, zest

peanuts

pears

pecans

pine nuts

pistachios



prunes

pumpkin

quince

raisins

rice (e.g., pudding) **RUM**

salads

sour cream

Southern Comfort stuffings

sugar: brown, white sweet potatoes

vanilla

walnuts

whiskey

wine: red, sweet, white

yogurt

Flavor Affinities

raisins + orange + rum

RAMPS

(aka wild leeks; see also Leeks, Onions, and Scallions)

Season: spring–summer

Weight: light

Volume: quiet–moderate

Techniques: cook, raw

asparagus

bacon

butter

carrots

cheese, Parmesan

chicken

chives

cream

cured meats (e.g., speck)

fish (e.g., halibut, salmon, trout)

ham

lentils, green

mushrooms, wild (e.g., morels)

olive oil

onions

pasta

pepper, black pork

potatoes, esp. new

prosciutto

risotto

shallots

stock, chicken

wine, white

Flavor Affinities

ramps + asparagus + morels

ramps + lentils + pork

ramps + Parmesan cheese + risotto

ramps + pasta + speck

RASPBERRIES

Season: summer

Taste: sweet

Weight: light

Volume: quiet–moderate

almonds

apricots

beverages

blackberries

blueberries

brandy, esp. berry-flavored

buttermilk

caramel

Champagne

cheese: goat, ricotta

CHOCOLATE, ESP. DARK (say some)

***CHOCOLATE, WHITE**

cinnamon

cloves

cognac

Cointreau

corn syrup, light

CREAM

crème anglaise

crème fraîche

currants, esp. red

custard

desserts

figs, esp. fresh

Framboise

ginger

graham crackers

Grand Marnier

grapefruit
grapes
hazelnuts
honey
ICE CREAM, vanilla
jams
Kirsch
LEMON: juice, zest
lemon verbena
lime: juice, zest
liqueurs, esp. berry, nut
macadamia nuts
mangoes
maple syrup
mascarpone
melon
meringue
milk, sweetened condensed
mint (garnish)
nectarines
oatmeal
orange: juice, zest
peaches
peanuts
pears
pecans
pineapple
pine nuts
pistachios
plums
quince
raspberry preserves rhubarb
rum, dark
salads: fruit, green

Dishes

Spaghetti with Local Ramps, American Speck, and Parmesan

—Andrew Carmellini, A Voce (New York City)

Roasted Pork Chop with Spiced Pulled Pork, Green Lentils, and Ramps

—Gray Kunz, Café Gray (New York City)

Dishes

Flambéed Peaches with Crepes and Raspberry-Lemon Ice Cream

—Gary Danko, Gary Danko (San Francisco)

Raspberry Mousse and Star Anise Tuile

—Dominique and Cindy Duby, Wild Sweets (Vancouver)

Almond Tart Shell Filled with Rose Cream and Raspberries with Lychee Granité, and Pistachio Crème Anglaise

—Michael Laiskonis, pastry chef, Le Bernardin (New York City)

When working with **raspberries**, I will try not to cook them too much. The problem is that often fresh raspberries are not that great. If I am making a sauce, even in the middle of summer I will use frozen raspberries. You can use frozen fruit as long as it doesn't have sugar or anything else added. The fruit is picked in the field when it is ripe and frozen right away. So, the frozen raspberries will have better flavor than those that have been put in a little carton and shipped across the country. Of course, local farmers' market raspberries are a different story. If I am making a sauce in the summer, the frozen raspberries will taste great. On the other hand, you would not use frozen raspberries on top of a tart.

—EMILY LUCHETTI, FARALLON (SAN FRANCISCO)

salt, sea

sauces

sour cream

star anise

strawberries

SUGAR: brown, white

tequila

wine: red, sweet (e.g., Riesling)

VANILLA

yogurt

AVOID

chocolate, dark (say some)

Flavor Affinities

raspberries + almonds + lemon

raspberries + almonds + vanilla

raspberries + cream + star anise

raspberries + crème fraîche + lemon

raspberries + custard + mint

raspberries + lemon + peaches

raspberries + sugar + vanilla + white chocolate

RED SNAPPER

(See Snapper)

RHUBARB

Season: late spring–summer

Taste: sour

Weight: medium

Volume: loud

Techniques: bake, puree, sauté, stew

almonds

ANGELICA

apples

bay leaf

berries

blood orange

brandy

butter, unsalted

buttermilk

caramel

cardamom

cheese: blue, Stilton

chives

chocolate, white

cinnamon

citrus fruits

cloves

CREAM AND ICE CREAM

cream cheese

crème fraîche

crust: pastry, pie

custard

duck

eggs

fennel

fish, mild

foie gras

fruit

game birds

garlic

GINGER: fresh, crystallized, powdered

Grand Marnier

grapefruit

grenadine

hazelnuts

honey

Kirsch

lemon: juice, zest

lime: juice, zest

liver

maple syrup

mascarpone

mint, esp. spearmint

nutmeg

oatmeal

oil, peanut

onions

orange, juice

pecans

pepper, black

pies

plums

pork

port

raspberries

salt: kosher, sea

sour cream

***STRAWBERRIES**

SUGAR: BROWN, CONFECTIONERS', WHITE

trout

VANILLA

verbena

vinaigrette

vinegar: cider, raspberry

wild rice

wine, sweet white (e.g., Riesling)

yogurt

Dishes

Cool Rhubarb Soup with Orange and Mint Fior Di Latte

—Gina DePalma, pastry chef, Babbo (New York City)

Ricotta Cheesecake with Rhubarb and Sweet Vanilla Cream

—Gina DePalma, pastry chef, Babbo (New York City)

Rhubarb Stilton and Port Wine Reduction Chocolate

—Dominique and Cindy Duby, Wild Sweets (Vancouver)

Rhubarb Consommé, Vanilla-Poached Rhubarb, Strawberry Crisp

—Gale Gand, pastry chef, Tru (Chicago)

Vanilla Yogurt Mousse, Rhubarb-Citrus Compote, Blood Orange Sorbet, and Coulis

—Michael Laiskonis, pastry chef, Le Bernardin (New York City)

Warm Apple and Rhubarb Turnovers with Rhubarb-Gewürztraminer Jam and Candied Ginger–Crème Fraîche Ice Cream

—Emily Luchetti, pastry chef, Farallon (San Francisco)

Rhubarb Napoleon with Mascarpone Cream and Fennel Compote

—Ellie Nelson, pastry chef, Jardinière (San Francisco)

Old-Fashioned Rhubarb Crisp with Cinnamon-Walnut Ice Cream

—Michael Romano, Union Square Café (New York City)

Rhubarb and Angelica Pie

—Jerry Traunfeld, The Herbfarm (Woodinville, Washington)

Rhubarb-Mint Cobbler

—Jerry Traunfeld, The Herbfarm (Woodinville, Washington)

I like to pair **rhubarb**, caramelized sugar, and blood orange juice—which has more character than orange juice—because their seasons barely overlap. I am not a fan of rhubarb desserts because they always tend to be one note—either very tart, or very sweet to make up for the tartness. Caramel works well with rhubarb because it makes the rhubarb not too sweet.

—MICHAEL LAISKONIS, LE BERNARDIN (NEW YORK CITY)

There is not a lot of fruit available in the spring, so that pretty much leaves you with **rhubarb**. The good news is that rhubarb works well in custards and ice creams.

—JERRY TRAUNFELD, THE HERBFARM (WOODINVILLE, WASHINGTON)

Flavor Affinities

rhubarb + blood orange + caramelized sugar

rhubarb + caramel + orange

rhubarb + cardamom + orange

rhubarb + cardamom + sugar + vanilla

rhubarb + cinnamon + cream + walnuts

rhubarb + cream cheese + lime + vanilla

rhubarb + fennel + mascarpone

rhubarb + honey + lemon + vanilla

rhubarb + lemon + yogurt

rhubarb + mint + orange

rhubarb + mint + sugar + vanilla

rhubarb + Stilton cheese + port wine

rhubarb + strawberry + vanilla

RICE, WHITE—IN GENERAL

Function: cooling

Weight: light–medium

Volume: quiet

Techniques: boil, steam

anise

bacon

beans

butter, unsalted

chicken

cinnamon

coconut and coconut milk

cream / milk

curry powder

fish

fish sauce, Thai

garlic

ginger, fresh

lemon, zest

meats

nuts: almonds, pecans, pistachios, walnuts

onions

peas

raisins

rhubarb

SAFFRON

salt

shellfish

shrimp

stocks: chicken, vegetable

sugar

tomatoes

vegetables

RICE, ARBORIO OR CARNAROLI

(aka risotto)

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: quiet

Techniques: sauté, then simmer

arugula

asparagus

bacon

basil

butter, unsalted celery

cheese, Parmesan

chicken

chile peppers, red

chives

crab

fennel

garlic

Italian cuisine

lemon

lemon thyme

lime, zest

mushrooms (e.g., chanterelles, morels, shiitake)

mussels

mustard seeds

onions

parsley, flat-leaf

peas

pepper, black

prosciutto

saffron

scallions

shallots

shellfish

shrimp

sorrel

squid

stocks: chicken, fish, vegetable

tarragon

thyme

tomatoes

truffles

veal

vermouth

wine: dry red or white

zucchini blossoms



Flavor Affinities

risotto + artichokes + lemon + prosciutto

risotto + asparagus + chervil + morel mushrooms

risotto + asparagus + saffron + scallops

risotto + bacon + butternut squash + maple syrup + sage

risotto + chanterelle mushrooms + zucchini blossoms

risotto + chorizo + clams + saffron
risotto + corn + Parmesan cheese + scallions
risotto + corn + Parmesan cheese + shrimp
risotto + mussels + parsley + peas
risotto + pancetta + Parmesan cheese + pumpkin
risotto + peas + prosciutto
risotto + sweet onions + Parmesan cheese
risotto + veal + black truffles

RICE, BASMATI

Function: cooling

Weight: light

Volume: quiet–moderate

Techniques: boil, simmer

almonds

basil

bay leaves

bell peppers

butter

buttermilk

cardamom

chicken

chile peppers, esp. dried red

cinnamon

coconut

coriander

cream / milk

cumin

currants

curry leaves

fennel seeds

garam masala

garlic

ginger

Indian cuisine

lamb

lemon

lime, juice

milk

mint

nuts

oil: canola, macadamia

onions, esp. green, red

orange

peas

pepper: black, white

pistachios

potatoes

raisins, yellow

saffron

salt, kosher

spinach

sugar

thyme

tomatoes and tomato paste

Odette Fada of New York's San Domenico on Risotto

I am from Northern Italy and grew up eating risotto. Back then, we mainly ate risotto Milanese [i.e., saffron risotto, traditionally served with osso buco or with a mild pork sausage crumbled in with some rosemary]. We would also put it in soup—or even just eat it simply with some grated cheese.

I love it because it only takes one pan, and it is ready in 20 minutes! People think it takes a long time but if you were to cook a piece of fish, wash greens, and make a salad dressing, that would take just as long.

You can make risotto with almost anything. I love it with fruit, vegetables, or fish. One of my favorite fruit risottos is a seasonal one with pears and Gorgonzola. The pears give a nice, sweet crunch to the dish. I also like making risotto with Prosecco, strawberries, and nettles.

A classic combination in Italy in fall is game with blueberry jam and mushrooms. I have adapted this and for over twenty years have been serving risotto with porcini mushrooms and blueberries tossed in at the last second.

I also like to make a risotto with fresh herbs like rosemary, thyme, or oregano—and then at the end I'll cover it with an extra-thin slice of lard [pork jowl] that has a mild flavor. It just melts into the risotto and is out of this world.

Each ingredient you add to your risotto will dictate when it should be added. If it is something delicate like a berry, it gets added very late so it will not break up. If you are making a seafood risotto—say, with octopus—it should be added early so it has time to cook all the way through.

RICE, CARNAROLI
(See Rice, Arborio)

RICE, JASMINE
(See Thai Cuisine)

RICE, WILD

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate

Techniques: simmer

butter, unsalted

celery

game

game birds

lemon, zest

Midwestern American cuisine

oil: hazelnut, vegetable, walnut

olive oil

onions

pepper, ground

pine nuts

salt

sausage, smoked

scallions

stock, chicken

tarragon walnuts

wine, dry white

RIESLING

Weight: light

Volume: quiet–moderate

apples
cheese, esp. blue, soft, triple crème
chicken
curries, esp. milder
duck
fish
fruit, esp. summer
ham, esp. baked
pork
salads
salmon
salmon, smoked
scallops
seafood
shellfish
trout, esp. sautéed



Dishes

Rose and Almond Panna Cotta

—Gina DePalma, pastry chef, Babbo (New York City)

Tropical Fruit Salad with Rosewater and Sweet Tahini Yogurt

—Brad Farmerie, Public (New York City)

Floral flavors, when done well, can be really amazing. This is also special because it is something that I never grew up with. Someone from India may not find it a big deal.

I tend to think in threes. I'll pair two classic ingredients, and add a third to elevate the combination. I make my own **rose**-flavored dessert that was inspired by [French pastry chef] Pierre Hermé and his rose macaroon with raspberry and lychee, which is one of the greatest things I have tasted in my life. I coat a standard tart shell with a layer of liquid raspberry; on top of that I place a rose parfait, which I pair with lemon and pistachio. To make the rose flavor not so overbearing, I use it in three different forms. I infuse rosebuds [used to make rosewater] in the milk for the parfait, and I also use rose syrup, which adds color and sweetness, and finally rosewater as well. You have to be careful with rose because it can be like eating perfume. That is why I take a lot of care using three layers to make it one flavor.

—MICHAEL LAISKONIS, LE BERNARDIN (NEW YORK CITY)

ROASTED DISHES

artichokes, Jerusalem

beef

beets

carrots

celery root

chicken

fennel

ham

lamb

onions

parsnips

pork

potatoes

rutabagas

shallots

squash, winter (e.g., butternut)

turkey

turnips

veal: loin, rib

vegetables, root

venison

yams

ROMAINE

(See Lettuce, Romaine)

ROSE

(Hips, Petals, Water)

Taste: sweet

Weight: light

Volume: moderate–loud

almonds
baked goods (e.g., cakes)
cream / milk
desserts
fruit
honey
ice cream
Indian cuisine desserts
lemon
lychee
pistachios
raspberries
rice and rice pudding
vanilla
yogurt

Flavor Affinities

rose + almonds + cream/milk
rose + honey + yogurt
rose + lemon + pistachios
rose + lychee + raspberries

Rosemary has a strong flavor, so it's always going to be the star. It works with strong, assertive fish like swordfish or tuna—and, of course, it is a classic with lamb.

—DAVID WALTUCK, CHANTERELLE (NEW YORK CITY)

Rosemary works with apples or pears.

—**JERRY TRAUNFELD**, THE HERBFARM (WOODINVILLE, WASHINGTON)

When I think of **rosemary**, I think of octopus. It works so well in a ceviche with octopus, black olives, and potato.

—**KATSUYA FUKUSHIMA**, MINIBAR (WASHINGTON, DC)

Rosemary can be strong with seafood unless it is a full-flavored seafood. We will skewer mussels with rosemary and panfry them because they work with the piney flavor of the mussels.

—**JERRY TRAUNFELD**, THE HERBFARM (WOODINVILLE, WASHINGTON)

Rosemary works well with citrus and honey.

—**GINA DEPALMA**, BABBO (NEW YORK CITY)

ROSEMARY

Season: year-round

Taste: pungent

Weight: heavy, tough-leaved

Volume: loud

Tips: Add early in the cooking process.

In winter, rosemary is milder; in summer, it is stronger.

anchovies

apples

apricots

asparagus

bacon

baked goods (e.g., breads, cakes, cookies)

bay leaf

BEANS, esp. dried, fava, white, green

beef

bell peppers

bouquet garni (key ingredient)

braised dishes

breads

Brussels sprouts

butter

cabbage

carrots

cauliflower

celery

chicken, esp. grilled

chives

cream

cream cheese

duck

eggs and egg dishes

eggplant

fennel

figs

FISH, esp. grilled

focaccia

French cuisine, esp. Provençal

fruit

game: rabbit, venison

***GARLIC**

gin

grains

grapefruit: juice, zest

grapes

grilled dishes, esp. meats, vegetables

herbes de Provence (key ingredient)

honey

Italian cuisine

***LAMB**

lavender

lemon: juice, zest

lemon verbena

lentils

lime: juice, zest

liver

lovage

mackerel

marinades

marjoram

MEATS, esp. grilled, roasted

Mediterranean cuisine

milk

mint

mushrooms

mussels

octopus

OLIVE OIL

ONIONS

orange: juice

oregano

parsley

parsnips

pasta

pears

peas

pepper, black

pizza

polenta

PORK

POTATOES

poultry

radicchio

rice

risotto

roasted meats

sage

salmon

sardines

saucers

savory

scallops, esp. grilled

shellfish

sherry

shrimp

soups

spinach

squash: summer, **winter**

steaks

stews

strawberries

strongly flavored foods

sweet potatoes

swordfish

thyme

TOMATOES, tomato juice, tomato sauce

tuna

veal
vegetables, esp. grilled, roasted
vinegar, balsamic
wine
zucchini (say some)

AVOID

corn
Middle Eastern cuisine
salads
zucchini (say some)

Flavor Affinities

rosemary + anchovies + garlic
rosemary + butter + lemon
rosemary + garlic + lamb
rosemary + garlic + lemon
rosemary + garlic + wine
rosemary + onions + potatoes
rosemary + Parmesan cheese + polenta
rosemary + pork + sherry

The Martinique **rums** tend to be drier, while Haitian rums tend to be spicier. I use more spices with rum in general, and herbs with spirits such as gin.

—**JERRI BANKS**, COCKTAIL CONSULTANT (NEW YORK CITY)

I love the combination of **rum** with carrots. Carrot juice provides a bright color that sends a message, especially to women. It has its own natural sweetness, and a little goes a long way. Carrots go beautifully with lemon thyme and orange, but I especially love the combination of carrots and ginger. In the autumn months, I'll combine gold rum with carrot and apple juices and autumn spices. I'll infuse allspice, cinnamon, and nutmeg into a tea or tisane, and add that to the cocktail.

—**JERRI BANKS**, COCKTAIL CONSULTANT (NEW YORK CITY)

RUM

Weight: light–heavy (light to dark rum)

Volume: moderate–loud

apples: fruit, juice

bananas: fruit, liqueur

butter

butterscotch

Caribbean cuisine

carrot: juice

chestnuts

chocolate

cinnamon

Coca-Cola

coconut: fruit, milk, water

cream and ice cream

fruit juice

ginger

grapefruit

grenadine

LEMON: JUICE

LIME: JUICE

maple syrup

maraschino liqueur

mint

nutmeg

nuts

ORANGE: JUICE

passion fruit

pineapple

pumpkin

punch (key ingredient)

raisins

SPICES: allspice, cinnamon, nutmeg, star anise

SUGAR, ESP. BROWN

tropical fruits

vanilla

vermouth: dry, sweet

Flavor Affinities

rum + apples + butter + nuts + vanilla

rum + apples + carrot juice + spices

rum + apples + cinnamon + pumpkin

rum + coconut water + tropical fruits

rum + lime + banana + sugar

rum + lime + mint + sugar

rum + lime + pineapple + sugar

RUSSIAN CUISINE

beets

cabbage

caraway seeds

caviar

cilantro

cinnamon

cloves

cumin

dill

fish: pickled, smoked

fruits and fruit sauces

garlic

ginger

herring

lamb, grilled

meats, skewered and grilled

mint

mushrooms

nutmeg

onions

paprika

parsley

pepper, black

poppy seeds

potatoes

saffron

sausages

sour cream

tarragon

vinegar

vodka

yogurt

Flavor Affinities

mushrooms + cloves + pepper + vinegar

RUTABAGAS

Season: autumn–spring

Taste: sweet

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: moderate–loud

Techniques: boil, braise, deepfry, puree, roast, steam

allspice

apples

basil

bay leaf

beets

broccoli

butter, clarified

caraway seeds

cardamom

carrots

cayenne

celery

celery root

cheese: blue, **Gruyère**, Parmesan

chives

cinnamon

cream

cream cheese

cumin

dill

duck

garlic, esp. roasted

ginger

greens, bitter

honey

lamb

leeks

lemon, juice

mace

maple

syrup

marjoram

mustard

nutmeg

olive oil

onions

orange, zest

oregano

parsley

parsnips

pears

pepper: black, white

pork

potatoes

rabbit

raisins

rosemary

saffron

sage

salt

savory

scallions

soups

squash, butternut

star anise

stock, chicken

sweet

potatoes

tarragon

thyme

tomatoes

tuna

turnips

vanilla

vinaigrette / vinegar
watercress

Dishes

Apple-Rutabaga Soup

—Patrick O’Connell, The Inn at Little Washington (Washington, Virginia)

Flavor Affinities

rutabagas + apples + maple syrup

rutabagas + cheese + potatoes

rutabagas + potatoes + rosemary

SAFFRON

Taste: sour–sweet–bitter

Function: cooling

Weight: very light

Volume: very loud

Tips: Add later in the cooking process; saffron is activated by the heat of cooking.

This bright yellow/orange-hued spice is used for its color as well as its flavor. A little saffron goes a very long way—never add more than necessary.

anise

artichokes asparagus

basil

beef

BOUILLABAISSE

bread

cardamom

carrots

cheese

chicken

cinnamon

citrus

cloves

coriander

corn

couscous

cream and ice cream cumin

curries

custards

eggplant

eggs

fennel

FISH

fruit

game birds

garlic

ginger

halibut

ice cream

Indian cuisine

Italian cuisine

lamb

leeks

mayonnaise

meats

Mediterranean cuisine

Middle Eastern cuisine

Moroccan cuisine

mushrooms

mussels

North African cuisine

nutmeg

onions, esp. Spanish, Vidalia

orange

paella

paprika

pepper

potatoes

rabbit

ras el hanout (ingredient)

***RICE**

***RISOTTO**

sauces

scallops

SHELLFISH

shrimp

soups, esp. chicken, fish

Spanish cuisine

spinach

squash, winter

stews, esp. fish

tomatoes

turbot

vanilla

veal

vegetables

yogurt

Flavor Affinities

saffron + fish + rice

saffron + ginger + vanilla

saffron + monkfish + rice

Dishes

Saffron Panna Cotta with “Agrumi Misti” and Blood Orange Sorbetto

—Gina DePalma, pastry chef, Babbo (New York City)

I would definitely have **saffron** on hand for Spanish cooking. It lends itself to rice, seafood, meat, and poultry. You can combine saffron and salt together for a saffron salt that is incredibly aromatic. Saffron also works very well on a salad. People forget that saffron is a flower and, sprinkled on a salad, it aromatizes the greens.

—JOSÉ ANDRÉS, CAFÉ ATLÁNTICO (WASHINGTON, DC)

Saffron has a sweet power. It is a classic flavor to add to shellfish, but the minute you taste the saffron in a dish, there is too much.

—MICHEL RICHARD, CITRONELLE (WASHINGTON, DC)

I wanted to come up with a *panna cotta* that was unlike anyone else's. I was walking down the street thinking of Italian dishes and risotto Milanese [which is made with **saffron**] came to mind. This led me to think about saffron, and the idea of adding saffron to my *panna cotta*. After Ruth Reichl mentioned it in the *New York Times* review of Babbo, Mario [Batali] told me I could never take it off the menu!

Saffron has a bright metallic flavor, and with quince—which is floral, delicate, and perfumed—it is wonderful. Over the years, I have found that saffron unexpectedly changes its flavor depending on what fruit is paired with it. Each fruit I work with either turns up its floral component or its metallic flavor. Saffron is great with stone fruits like apples, peaches, pears, plums, and figs. It also works with citrus like blood oranges, kumquats, and grapefruit. On the other hand, it doesn't work with many berries. It makes strawberries a little flat, and is downright awful with cranberries.

—GINA DEPALMA, BABBO (NEW YORK CITY)

SAGE

Season: late spring–early summer

Taste: sweet, bitter, sour

Weight: moderate–heavy

Volume: loud

Tips: Always use cooked (never raw); add near the end of the cooking process.

apples

asparagus

bay leaf

BEANS, esp. dried, green

beef

blueberries

bread

butter

cabbage

caraway

carrots

CHEESE, esp. Brie, feta, Fontina, Gruyère, Parmesan, ricotta

cherries, esp. tart

CHICKEN, esp. roasted

chickpeas

citrus

corn

cream

cream cheese

duck

eggplant

eggs

European cuisine

fattier foods, esp. meats

fennel

fish, esp. oilier

French cuisine

game

game birds

garlic

ginger, dried

goose

Greek cuisine

honey

Italian cuisine

lamb

lemon

lemon herbs (balm, thyme, verbena)

liver

lovage

marjoram

meats, fattier, richer, and/or roasted

Mediterranean cuisine

mint

mushrooms

offal

olive oil

ONIONS

orange

oregano

oysters (e.g., stuffing)

pancetta

paprika

parsley, flat-leaf

PASTA, esp. gnocchi, ravioli

pears

peas

pepper, black

***PORK**

potatoes

poultry

prosciutto

pumpkin

rice

rich dishes
rosemary
salads: pasta, potato
sausages
savory
shellfish
shrimp
skate
slow-cooked dishes
soups, esp. legumes
Spanish cuisine
squash, winter
steak
stews
stocks
STUFFING
swordfish
thyme
tomatoes
tuna
turkey
veal
vegetables, esp. root
walnuts
wine, esp. white

Flavor Affinities

sage + marjoram + thyme
sage + parsley + rosemary + thyme
sage + pasta + walnuts
sage + stuffing + turkey + walnuts

Sage has a much better flavor when it is cooked first. We will cook it in butter, olive oil, or bacon fat.

—**JERRY TRAUNFELD**, THE HERBFARM (WOODINVILLE, WASHINGTON)

Every **salad** should have elements of bitter, salt, heat, and texture. For us, the bitter component is often the greens. We use a lot of frisée, radicchio, and endive. But there always needs to be some crunch in a salad. Even if it is a delicate salad, you need to find a way to get a crunch in there. For a delicate salad, you can get crunch using fried shallot rings or crispy sage leaves. We often use nuts for crunch. Our leaf salad has a cashew brittle, which is made by caramelizing sugar then seasoning it with salt, black pepper, a hint of madras curry, a pinch of our Moroccan spice blend (eighteen ingredients), and a pinch of pepper mix (four ingredients) before tossing the nuts in. The other components of the salad are pomegranate seeds, bacon, and a South American blue cheese.

—**SHARON HAGE**, YORK STREET (DALLAS)

SAKE

Weight: light

Volume: quiet

cucumber

fish

gin

JAPANESE CUISINE

lemon juice

lime juice

salads

sashimi and sushi

shellfish

sugar (simple syrup)

vodka

Flavor Affinities

sake + cucumber + lime

SALADS

(See also **Lettuces and other vegetables**)

When you are eating a **salad**, the greens are the main ingredient, so whatever you add has to elevate them. Lettuce is boring by itself, so you elevate it with the vinaigrette. We will use herbs in our salads, but they must not overpower the greens; they have to be very subtle and used in small amounts. We will use chives or fresh parsley leaves or a combination of the two. We may also add some mint to the mix because it pushes the flavors of the greens.

—ERIC RIPERT, LE BERNARDIN (NEW YORK CITY)

King White Salmon by Gabriel Kreuther of New York City's The Modern



The **salmon** is roasted, and served with warm, slightly charred cucumbers, which I like because they are rarely used cooked. We use market vegetables that right now are bok choy and peas. I have added some trout caviar for a briny flavor because salmon is on the sweet side. The dish is then finished with a hickory broth.

For the hickory broth, we smoke some hickory chips, wrap them in cheesecloth with juniper berries and peppercorns, and then submerge them in water to make a broth. This creates a smoked sauce that is light and tasty. What we have here is a “wood stock” that makes perfect sense with the salmon because so often salmon is smoked. After the wood comes out, you taste the broth to adjust it. It may need some more water to cut the wood and smoke flavor, or it might need to be reduced to intensify it. We finish the sauce with a little half-and-half, and foam it with a handheld mixer.

SALMON

(See also Fish—In General)

Season: spring–early autumn

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate

Techniques: bake, braise, broil, grill, marinate, panfry, poach, raw (e.g., sashimi, tartare), roast, sauté, sear, steam

anchovies

apples, esp. Golden Delicious or Granny Smith, and apple cider artichoke hearts

arugula

asparagus (accompaniment)

bacon

barbecue sauce

basil: leaf, oil

bass

bay leaf

beans: fava, flageolets, white

beets

beurre blanc

bread crumbs: regular, *panko*

Brussels sprouts

BUTTER, unsalted

cabbage, esp. green, savoy

capers

cardamom

carrots

caviar

cayenne

celery

Champagne

chervil

chile peppers: dried, fresh, green, jalapeño, red, Thai

CHIVES (garnish)

cilantro
cinnamon
citrus
cloves
coconut: shredded, milk
cognac
coriander
corn
cornichons
crab
CREAM, HEAVY
cream cheese
crème fraîche
cucumbers
cumin
curry: leaves, powder, sauce
(esp. red)
daikon
dill
eggs: hard-boiled, scrambled
fennel
fennel seeds
fenugreek seeds
GARLIC
ginger: fresh
grapefruit: juice, zest
greens, bitter
horseradish
juniper berries
kelp
leeks
LEMON: juice, zest
lemon, preserved
lemongrass
LENTILS
lettuces (e.g., frisée)
licorice

LIME: juice, leaves, zest

lovage

Madeira

mangoes

marjoram

mayonnaise

mint, esp. spearmint

mirepoix

mirin

miso, white

Vitaly Paley of Portland's Paley's Place on Cooking Salmon on a Plank

Salmon is a big part of cooking in the Northwest. We get ours anywhere from Oregon up to Alaska.

The first cooking process that comes to mind in this part of the country is called cedar planking, which is a Native American technique. You see planking in all the best cooking catalogs, but the problem is that you cook the fish, throw it out, and keep the plank because the plank is inevitably more expensive than the fish! So here is one tip: Instead, do what we do and go to a lumber yard and pick up untreated cedar shingles. They come in a huge bundle for \$16.

To get the most out of plank cooking, the salmon needs to be brined or marinated. I have two favorite marinades—one that is wet, and one that is dry. The wet marinade is a 60/40 mixture of soy sauce and cream sherry, lots of sliced ginger, heads of garlic cut in half, and chopped scallions. The sherry adds just a touch of sweetness to the fish, which I like. Let the fish sit in that marinade for a couple of hours and then it is ready to take on the smoke.

The dry marinade is a more traditional marinade of a 60/40 ratio of brown sugar and salt with orange zest [grated] on a microplane [fine grater]. I mix this all together and lavishly rub it over a salmon with the skin on, which protects it from getting too salty or sweet. The sugar in this rub balances out the salt and adds another dimension to the fish with caramelization happening a lot quicker. The sweetness is almost hidden; it is that “What’s-that-flavor?” aspect to the fish. Marinate for a couple of hours, then wipe off the rub slightly, and it is ready to go. The 60/40 ratio of sugar to salt is good because it is pretty forgiving if you leave the fish in the marinade a half hour too long.

I recommend brushing the plank lightly with some olive oil, throwing it on a hot grill, putting the fish on, and letting it catch on fire, because when the plank is on fire, that is the flavor you are looking for. When the burning plank gets close to the fish, cover the grill to smother the fire and let the smoke do the rest of the work.

Salmon has been my favorite fish since I learned to cook it correctly. It is so versatile: you can smoke it, marinate it, or even serve it raw. Because it is rich and fatty, it pairs well with everything from a red wine sauce to a simple vinaigrette.

—MICHEL RICHARD, CITRONELLE (WASHINGTON, DC)

Tomato and pineapple with **salmon**: This dish goes back to 1975 when someone gave me a salad of tomato and pineapple. I didn’t know what to do with it, so I stored the idea away. Today, I will cook the tomato, pineapple, a dash of white wine for acid, miso, and the salmon head, which bridges and brings the flavors together. Tomato gets fruitier when cooked with pineapple.

The end result doesn't taste like either tomato or pineapple; it is a new flavor.
This sauce is perfect with salmon.

—**MICHEL RICHARD**, CITRONELLE (WASHINGTON, DC)

Dishes

Salmon Gravlax with Chickpea Pancake, Caviar, and Mustard

—Tom Valenti, Ovest (New York City)

Dishes

Seared Salmon with Potatoes, Leeks, and Mustard-Chive Sauce

—Lidia Bastianich, Felidia (New York City)

Pistachio-Crusted Salmon Medallions with Garlic Mashed Potatoes, Crispy Fennel, Arugula, Olives, Roasted Peppers, and Savory Tomato Butter

—Bob Kinhead, Kinhead's (Washington, DC)

Wild Salmon with Horseradish Crust, Cabbage, and Riesling

—Gabriel Kreuther, The Modern (New York City)

House-Made Graviac with Scrambled Eggs, Pumpernickel, Herb Crème Fraîche, and Red Onions

—Tony Liu, August (New York City)

Salmon Rubbed with Ground Red Chile and Lime and Pan Seared. Served with a Tangy, Spicy Tomatillo, Jalapeño, and Lime Juice Sauce

—Zarela Martinez, Zarela (New York City)

Wild Alaskan Troll Red King Salmon, Yukon Potato Gnocchi, Braised Artichokes and Leeks, Enriched Chicken Jus with Chives and Chervil

—Carrie Nahabedian, Naha (Chicago)

Signature Sushi: Salmon with Mango Puree; Seared Salmon Belly with Lemon Soy

—Kaz Okochi, Kaz Sushi Bistro (Washington, DC)

Pistachio-Crusted Salmon with Curried Spinach Salad, Mandarin Orange Vinaigrette

—Monica Pope, T'afia (Houston)

Salmon with Grilled Vegetables, Baby Artichokes, Israeli Couscous, Warm Vegetable Vinaigrette

—Alfred Portale, Gotham Bar and Grill (New York City)

Wild Salmon: Barely Cooked Wild Alaskan Salmon; Morels and Spring Vegetables in a Wild Mushroom Pot au Feu

—Eric Ripert, Le Bernardin (New York City)

Slow-Roasted Scottish Salmon, Caramelized Fennel, Red Wine–Fennel Emulsion

—Rick Tramonto, Tru (Chicago)

Darjeeling Tea–Cured Salmon with English Cucumber and Crème Fraîche

—Charlie Trotter, Trotter’s to Go (Chicago)

Roasted Salmon with Sweet Corn Flan, Chanterelles, Prosciutto, Zucchini, Corn-Chive Butter, and Shrimp Oil

—Tom Valenti, Ovest (New York City)

mushrooms, esp. black trumpet, button, chanterelles, cremini, morels, oysters
mussels

MUSTARD: Dijon, whole grain

mustard seeds

nutmeg

OIL: canola, corn, grapeseed, peanut (for cooking), sesame, vegetable (for
cooking)

OLIVE OIL

olives, esp. black, niçoise, picholine, Provençal

ONIONS, esp. pearl, red, Vidalia, white

orange: juice, zest

oysters

pancetta

paprika

PARSLEY, flat-leaf

peas

PEPPER: black, green, pink, red, white

Pernod

pike

pineapple and pineapple juice

pistachios

polenta

ponzu sauce

port

POTATOES

radishes

ramps

rice (e.g., basmati, sushi)

roe: flying fish, **salmon** rosemary

saffron

sake

SALT: kosher, sea

sauces: béarnaise, beurre blanc, brown butter hollandaise

scallions

scallops

sesame seeds

SHALLOTS

shiso leaves

smoked salmon

sole

sorrel

sour cream

soy sauce

spinach

STOCKS: chicken, fish, mussels, veal, vegetable

sugar: brown, white

Tabasco sauce

tamarind

tarragon

THYME

tilefish

TOMATOES

tomatoes, sun-dried

truffles: oil, shaved, white

turmeric

vanilla

vermouth

vinaigrette

VINEGAR, e.g., balsamic, champagne, cider, red wine, rice, sherry, white wine

watercress

WINE: dry white or red (Cabernet Sauvignon, Pinot Noir)

zucchini

Flavor Affinities

salmon + apple + horseradish + rosemary

salmon + avocado + chile peppers + grapefruit

salmon + bacon + cabbage + chestnuts

salmon + bacon + lentils + sherry vinegar

salmon + basil + white beans

salmon + beets + crème fraîche + cucumber + horseradish

salmon + caviar + vermouth

salmon + chervil + chives + leeks + lemon + morels + peas + potatoes

salmon + cucumber + balsamic vinegar

salmon + cucumber + dill

salmon + cucumber + dill + horseradish

salmon + cucumber + tomato

salmon + lemon juice + Dijon mustard

salmon + marjoram + peas

salmon + miso + pineapple + tomato + white wine

salmon + mustard + scallions

salmon + orange + tomato

salmon + peas + potatoes

salmon + pineapple + tomatoes

salmon + potato + watercress



SALMON, CURED

Taste: salty

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate–loud

aquavit

avocados

basil

beans, white

bell peppers, red

bread: pumpernickel, rye

caviar

cayenne

Champagne

chives

cream

cream cheese

crème fraîche

dill

honey

horseradish

lemon: juice, zest

lentils, green

lime: juice, zest

mustard: Dijon, dry olive oil

orange, zest

pepper: black, white

potatoes

salt: kosher, sea

shallots

sour cream

sugar

tarragon

tomatoes

SALMON, SMOKED

Taste: salty

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate–loud

artichokes

avocados

bell peppers, roasted

blini

bread: bagels, pumpernickel, rye, white

breakfast / brunch

butter: clarified, unsalted

capers

caviar

celery

celery root

Champagne

chervil

chicory

CHIVES

cilantro

cream

CREAM CHEESE

crème fraîche

cucumbers

cumin

daikon

DILL

eggs, esp. hard-boiled, and egg salad

frisée

garlic

ginger, fresh

horseradish

juniper

leeks

LEMON: juice, zest

lime: juice, zest

mascarpone

monkfish

mussels, smoked

mustard, Dijon

oil, canola

olive oil

onions, esp. red, sweet

orange

oysters

parsley

pasta

PEPPER: black, white

Pernod

potatoes and potato salad

radishes

salmon

salmon roe

salt: kosher, sea

scallions

scallops

shallots

shiso leaf

sorrel

sour cream

soy sauce

spinach

stocks: clam, fish

Tabasco sauce

tarragon

tea sandwiches

tomatoes

vinaigrette

vinegar: red wine, rice wine, sherry, white wine

Worcestershire sauce

yogurt (say some)

AVOID

mayonnaise

yogurt (say some)

My signature sushi roll pairs **salmon** with mango puree and sushi rice. However, I wouldn't serve salmon with mango puree as sashimi. The balance would be lost. Also, mango doesn't pair well with either soy sauce or wasabi.

—**KAZ OKOCHI**, KAZ SUSHI BISTRO (WASHINGTON, DC)

We roast **salmon** wrapped in squash blossom and it imparts a slight zucchini flavor to the salmon. The blossom is mild and makes a perfect package for the salmon by steaming it as it cooks. With the salmon we serve a [zucchini] squash cut into spaghetti seasoned with lemon thyme and basil. The herbs work with both the zucchini and the salmon.

—**JERRY TRAUNFELD**, THE HERBFARM (WOODINVILLE, WASHINGTON)

I love combining fruit and proteins. I am one-half Hawaiian, and in Hawaiian cooking a classic dish is Spam cooked with fresh pineapple. I grew up with my father making it for us, and it is delicious. You'll also see a lot of sushi chefs combine kiwi and scallops, as fruit adds a nice cleansing note to the protein you are working with. Our take on this combination is pineapple **salmon** with avocado and quinoa. We cut pineapple very thin, then wrap it around salmon belly, which is very rich. When we cook it, the pineapple gets caramelized and helps cut the fat of the salmon. On the dish is a sweet-hot sauce of avocado, honey, scallions, and serrano chiles. To garnish the dish and add some crunch we add quinoa that is cooked then dried for three days before cooking it in olive oil, which makes it puff like Rice Krispies.

—**KATSUYA FUKUSHIMA**, MINIBAR (WASHINGTON, DC)

Dishes

Smoked Salmon with Crispy Potatoes and Horseradish Cream

—Jean Joho, Brasserie Jo (Chicago)

Rosti Potato Cake with Herb Mascarpone and Fresh-Smoked Salmon

—Monica Pope, T'afia (Houston)

Leek Tart with Smoked Salmon and Crème Fraîche

—Michel Richard, Citronelle (Washington, DC)

Flavor Affinities

smoked salmon + chives + crème fraîche + dill + pumpernickel-rye blini

smoked salmon + chives + dill + scrambled eggs + potatoes

smoked salmon + cream cheese + lemon juice + shallots + sour cream

smoked salmon + cucumber + horseradish + mint

smoked salmon + dill + horseradish + lemon juice + sour cream

SALSIFY

Season: autumn–winter

Taste: sweet

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate

Techniques: bake, braise, pan roast, stew

anchovies

butter

cheese, Parmesan

chives

cream

duck prosciutto

fish (e.g., halibut)

hollandaise sauce

LEMON, JUICE

maple syrup

mascarpone

mayonnaise

mushrooms

nutmeg

oil, peanut

onions

orange

parsley

pepper, black

polenta

prosciutto

rice

sage

salmon, smoked

salt, kosher

scallions

shallots

sorrel

soups

stock, chicken

thyme, fresh

truffles, black

vinaigrettes

Flavor Affinities

salsify + Parmesan cheese + prosciutto

SALT—IN GENERAL

Taste: salty

Function: warming

SALT, FLEUR DE SEL

chicken

cold dishes

meats

radishes

salads

steak

SALT, HAWAIIAN

ceviche

chicken

lamb

meat, esp. barbecued pork

seafood

steak

vegetables, esp. tomatoes

I like to use **Hawaiian salt** on a dish where I want a little crunch. This holds up better than other salts that will dissolve more quickly. I will use it on ceviche, which has a little broth.

—**DANIEL HUMM**, ELEVEN MADISON PARK (NEW YORK CITY)

We use **fleur de sel** on cold dishes, such as salads. We also use it on meats like beef, buffalo rib eye, or roast chicken after they are sliced and a moment before serving.

—**SHARON HAGE**, YORK STREET (DALLAS)

SALT, JAPANESE

fish

foie gras

salmon

sashimi

squid

Japanese salt has ground seaweed in it and works on sashimi. I use this in Japanese dishes.

—**DANIEL HUMM**, ELEVEN MADISON PARK (NEW YORK CITY)

SALT, KOSHER

bread

brine

charcuterie

cocktails, esp. rims

cooking

cure

meat

potatoes

pretzels

toast

water for blanching or for pasta

We use **kosher salt** primarily for meats.

—SHARON HAGE, YORK STREET (DALLAS)

SALT, MALDON

fish, esp. raw
finishing dishes
lobster

[Maldon] is the finest of all **salts** in regard to both flavor and texture. I appreciate its delicacy on fish, especially lobster.

—**DANIEL HUMM**, ELEVEN MADISON PARK (NEW YORK CITY)

SALT, SEA—COARSE

meats

seafood

seasoning

vegetables, hearty

SALT, SEA—FINE

baking

fish

seasoning

vegetables, delicate

For delicate foods like vegetables or fish, we use ground **sea salt** right before it goes into the pan.

—**SHARON HAGE**, YORK STREET (DALLAS)

SALT, SMOKED

brines, esp. for pork
chicken
fish, esp. raw
meats: barbecued, red
pork
potatoes, baked
seafood
salmon
sardines
steak
tuna
vegetarian dishes

The **Danish smoked salt** we use is smoked over Chardonnay vines. For us, using smoked salt provides the flavor of cooking over grape vines as they do in Spain. Smoked salt is also great if you don't have a grill, because even a gas grill can't provide a smoky flavor. I like smoked salt sprinkled on sardines, which in Spain will be cooked over a fire on the beach where they get really smoky. I can give that sense of place by using this salt on my sardines.

—ALEXANDRA RAIJ, TÍA POL (NEW YORK CITY)

SALT, TRUFFLE

egg dishes

pastas

popcorn

potatoes

risotto

salads and salad dressing

SALT, VANILLA

chicken
chocolate, esp. dark
lamb
meats
mussels
nuts
pork
pumpkin
shellfish, esp. lobster or scallops
squash, winter
sweet potatoes



SALTINESS

Taste: salty

Function: heating; stimulates salivation; enhances the flavors of ingredients

Tips: Adding salt to a dish diminishes the effects of bitter, sour, and sweet.

anchovies

bacon

capers

caperberries

caviar and other fish roe

cheeses, salty (e.g., feta, manchego, Parmesan, pecorino)

clams and clam juice

cured meats

dashi (e.g., Japanese stock)

finnan haddie

fish sauce, Asian

gravlax

ham

ingredients with added salt (e.g., chips, nuts)

kelp

lemons, preserved

lox

nuts, salted

olives

oysters

oyster sauce

pancetta

pickles (salty-sour)

prosciutto

salmon, smoked

salt

salt cod

salt pork

sardines

sausages, salty (e.g., chorizo)
sea urchin
sea vegetables
seaweed
seeds, salted
shrimp paste
smoked foods, esp. fish, meats
smoked salmon and trout
soy sauce
tamari
Worcestershire sauce

If you have a piece of Ibérico or Serrano ham in your refrigerator, you'll eventually end up with this little end of dried-out salt-cured meat. While some might just throw it away, we know there's a lot of flavor left—so we grind it up in a coffee grinder and use it as meat-flavored salt. We call this **“ham salt,”** and will use this on a salad to emphasize the aroma and flavor of pork.... In Spain we have *mojama*, which is tuna loin cured like ham. We'll grind it up in a coffee grinder and it becomes tuna salt. When I sear tuna, I will sprinkle this on and emphasize the tuna with its own tuna flavor. It is simple and dramatic. I even showed this technique to the owner of the best tuna restaurant in the world—called El Campero in Barbate, Spain—where he serves tuna a hundred ways. He loved it!

—**JOSÉ ANDRÉS**, CAFÉ ATLÁNTICO (WASHINGTON, DC)

We use three different kinds of salt—but we also use **capers, anchovies, olives, preserved lemons**, and even **prosciutto** for adding another dimension of saltiness. Even when using these other salty components, 99 percent of the time we'll use them in addition to salt, not instead of it.

—**SHARON HAGE**, YORK STREET (DALLAS)

Chefs on Selecting and Using Salt

***Kosher salt** has larger, harder crystals and won't break down too fast. I use this for pasta water, brining, curing meat, and charcuterie. I use **French sea salt** (esp. Baleine) for general seasoning. I like Maldon salt a lot. This is what I use for finishing dishes. It has a really fine crystal and the flavor is great. It even gives some crunch and melts like snowflakes. It is great sprinkled on raw fish.*

—**ANDREW CARMELLINI**, A VOCE (NEW YORK CITY)

***Salt** is now used very often in desserts and unfortunately it doesn't always make sense. I was served a green apple sorbet with salt and it didn't work. Salt does work on sweet oranges, though. If you cut a Cara Cara orange into wedges and sprinkle sea salt on them, they are delicious. Salt also makes sense with caramel and butterscotch. The salt is a contrast to the super sweet, which is why we like PayDay candy bars.*

—**GINA DEPALMA**, BABBO (NEW YORK CITY)

*I use **Maldon salt** flakes as a salt for finishing dishes, and kosher salt for blanching water or when I roast on salt. I'll sometimes use **smoked salt** with raw fish or in a brine for pork, but it's really strong so you have to be careful with it.*

—**BRADFORD THOMPSON**, MARY ELAINE'S AT THE PHOENICIAN (SCOTTSDALE, ARIZONA)

*There is salt in almost all of my desserts. However, you would not know it was there until I took it out—which is how it should be. You don't need to taste the salt, but it helps open the palate and stimulates your taste buds. With something fatty like chocolate, you need some salt to brighten it up. I use all sorts of salts with my desserts. We are making a peanut butter and jelly bonbon that I pair with **smoked Brittany sea salt**. **Maldon salt** is shaved and more about texture, because it is not as strong; I would use it on a pancake or something creamy. *Fleur de sel* is a salt with texture and ocean floral notes, and would go well on our panini which have cheese, arugula, and vinaigrette.*

—**JOHNNY IUZZINI**, JEAN GEORGES (NEW YORK CITY)

*Salt goes into almost every dough we make and is something that makes flavors pop. Some chefs can go a little overboard, but desserts should still be sweet. Salt works well with caramel and chocolate, obviously. I also use a **vanilla salt** with a classic sweet potato tart that is cut into four slices with a few grains on each slice. The salt reinforces the savoriness of the sweet potato and plays off the brightness of the preserved lemon on the plate.*

—**MICHAEL LAISKONIS**, LE BERNARDIN (NEW YORK CITY)

*To counteract **oversalting** a dish, you need to increase the volume of whatever you are making. That can be tricky, because you don't want to end up with something too watery. Whenever there is a puree involved, whether it is mashed potatoes or butternut squash soup, I encourage my cooks to make it thick. You can always add, but not take away.*

—ANDREW CARMELLINI, A VOCE (NEW YORK CITY)

SARDINES

Season: spring–summer

Taste: salty

Weight: light

Volume: loud

Techniques: braise, broil, fry, grill, marinate, poach, sauté

anchovies

basil

bay leaf

bell peppers, red

bread crumbs

capers

carrots

cayenne

chives

coriander seeds

currants

eggplant

fennel

fennel pollen

fennel seeds

French cuisine

garlic

ham

Italian cuisine, esp. southern

lemon: juice, zest

mirin

oil, peanut

OLIVE OIL

onions: red, white

orange: juice, zest

parsley, flat-leaf

pasta

pepper: black, white

peppers, piquillo

pine nuts

raisins, esp. yellow

red pepper flakes

rosemary

saffron

sage

sake

salt, sea

sour cream

soy sauce

thyme

tomatoes and tomato sauce

verjus

vinaigrette

vinegar, e.g., balsamic, red wine, sherry, white wine

walnuts

wine, dry white (e.g., Chenin Blanc, Grenache, Viognier)

zucchini

SAUERKRAUT

Taste: sour

Weight: medium

Volume: loud

Tips: Sauerkraut is shredded cabbage that is fermented in salt and spices.

apples

bacon

bay leaf

beans, esp. kidney and/or red

caraway seeds

carrots

cider

cloves

duck

Eastern European cuisine

fat: duck, goose

French cuisine, esp. Alsatian

garlic

German cuisine

gin

ham: hocks, meat

JUNIPER BERRIES

Kirsch

olive oil

onions

pepper, black

pork, esp. loin

potatoes

rhubarb

salt, kosher

SAUSAGES, esp. blood, bratwurst, frankfurter, kielbasa

stock, chicken

vinegar: champagne, white wine

wine: dry to off-dry white (e.g., Alsatian, Riesling)

Dishes

Marinated Fresh Sardines with Caramelized Fennel and Lobster Oil

—Mario Batali, Babbo (New York City)

Whole Wheat Spaghetti with Fresh Sardines and Walnuts

—David Pasternak, Esca (New York City)

SAUSAGES

(See also Chorizo)

Weight: light–heavy

Volume: quiet–loud

Techniques: bake, grill, poach, sauté, stew

apples

basil

bay leaf

beans, white

beer

bell peppers: green, red

breakfast

broccoli rabe

butter, unsalted

carrots

celery root

celery seeds

fennel

garlic

leeks

lemon, juice

lentils

Mediterranean cuisine

mustard, Dijon

oil, canola

olive oil

ONIONS: white, yellow

oregano

parsley, flat-leaf

pasta

pepper, black

potatoes, esp. boiled, mashed, pureed

radicchio

rosemary
salt, kosher
sauerkraut
scallops
shallots
thyme
tomatoes
vinegar, balsamic
wine, dry white

Flavor Affinities

sausages + mustard + sauerkraut
sausages + onions + potatoes + tomatoes
sausages + radicchio + white beans

Dishes

Homemade Alsatian Country Sausage with Turnip Choucroute and Whole Grain Mustard Sauce

—Gabriel Kreuther, *The Modern* (New York City)

SAUVIGNON BLANC

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate

asparagus

chicken

cilantro

fish

garlic

herbs

oysters, esp. raw

peppers

pork

salads

shellfish

tomatoes

turkey

vegetables

SAVORY

Weight: medium, tough-leaved

Volume: moderate–loud (Summer savory is quieter, winter savory is louder.)

Tips: Can stand up to cooking. Use summer savory with summer vegetables, and winter savory with winter vegetables.

basil

bay leaf

***BEANS, esp. dried, summer (e.g., fava, green, lima)**

beef

beets

bell peppers

bouquet garni

braised dishes

Brussels sprouts

cabbage

cheese (e.g., goat) and cheese dishes

chicken

chicken livers

chives

cumin

eggs and egg dishes

fennel

finest herbes (ingredient)

fish, esp. baked or grilled

garlic

herbes de Provence (ingredient)

herbs, other (as a blending herb)

kale

lamb

lavender

legumes

lentils

mackerel

marjoram

meats, esp. grilled, roasted, stewed

Mediterranean cuisine

mint

mushrooms

nutmeg

olives

onions

oregano

paprika

parsley

peas

polenta

pork

potatoes

poultry, esp. grilled

rabbit

rice

rosemary

sage

salads and salad dressings

saucers and gravies

soups, esp. tomato-based

squash, summer

stews, esp. meat

stuffings (e.g., poultry)

tarragon

thyme

tomatoes and tomato sauces

veal

vegetables, esp. root

vinegar

wine, red

zucchini

Flavor Affinities

savory + garlic + tomatoes

Savory in any form—whether summer or winter savory—is my favorite herb. It is not as woody as thyme, not as piney as rosemary, and not as pungent as sage. It also has the ability to stay flavorful throughout the cooking process. I like it with potatoes, with polenta, and with mushrooms. Savory and mushrooms are great. I especially like grilled porcini mushrooms with savory. I'll grill the mushrooms then put them on a bed of savory to finish roasting them. Savory also works in a sherry or red wine vinaigrette with shallots, and is great on salads.

—**VITALY PALEY**, PALEY'S PLACE (PORTLAND, OREGON)

Savory is an herb that is very compatible in the same way fresh thyme is. You could use savory in dishes that call for thyme.

—**MARCEL DESAULNIERS**, THE TRELLIS (WILLIAMSBURG, VIRGINIA)

SCALLIONS

Season: summer

Weight: light

Volume: moderate

Techniques: braise, grill, raw, sauté, stir-fry

anise

basil

bay leaf

bell peppers

butter, unsalted

carrots

cheese: goat, Parmesan

chile peppers

cilantro

cinnamon

cloves

cream

cream cheese

curry

dill

egg dishes

garlic

greens, bitter

honey

Japanese cuisine

Korean cuisine

lemon, juice

mushrooms

mustard, Dijon

nutmeg

olive oil

oregano

paprika

parsley
pepper, white
potatoes
rice
rosemary
sage
salt, kosher
sesame oil
sugar
Thai cuisine
thyme
tomatoes
vinegar

Dishes

Callos de Hacha en Adobo: Chipotle-Glazed, Grilled “Dry Pack” New England Sea Scallops in Classic Adobo Sauce (Anchos, Garlic, Orange) with Plantain-Studded Black Bean Rice, Wood-Grilled Green Beans, and Crispy Onions

—Rick Bayless, Frontera Grill (Chicago)

Fresh-Grilled Sea Scallops Baked Over Rosemary Salt, with Creamy Polenta and Tomato-Citrus Vinaigrette

—Daniel Boulud, Daniel (New York City)

Diver Sea Scallops: Fennel Ravioli, Fricassee of Chanterelles, Artichoke, and Arugula

—Daniel Boulud/Olivier Muller, DB Bistro Moderne (New York City)

Maine Diver Scallops with English Peas, Smoked Bacon, Pickled Ramps, and Perigord Truffle Nage

—Traci Des Jardins, Jardinière (San Francisco)

Maine Diver Scallops Grilled with Ruby Grapefruit, Spring Potatoes, and Basil

—Daniel Humm, Eleven Madison Park (New York City)

Sea of Cortez “Mano de Leon” Scallops Scented with Citrus, Spices, and Vanilla Bean, Caramelized Belgian Endive, Ruby Red Grapefruit, Mâche, and Mint

—Carrie Nahabedian, Naha (Chicago)

Bay Scallops with Mushrooms, Peppers, and Grilled Italian Sausage

—Patrick O’Connell, The Inn at Little Washington (Washington, Virginia)

Delicate Sake-Poached Sea Scallops with Lemon and Cilantro

—Kaz Okochi, Kaz Sushi Bistro (Washington, DC)

Linguine with Taylor Bay Scallops, Maine Mussels, Hot Red Pepper, and Pancetta

—David Pasternak, Esca (New York City)

Scallops with Roasted Brussels Sprouts and Pancetta

—David Pasternak, Esca (New York City)

SCALLOPS

Season: summer–autumn

Taste: sweet, esp. bay scallops

Weight: light–medium

Volume: quiet

Techniques: broil, deep-fry, gratin, grill, marinate, pan sear, poach, raw, roast, sauté, sear, steam, stir-fry, tartare

almonds

apples, esp. Granny Smith

artichokes

arugula

asparagus

avocado

bacon and other cured meats (e.g., Serrano ham)

basil

bay leaf

beans: cannellini, fava, green, haricots verts, lima

bell peppers: red, green, yellow

bread crumbs

Brussels sprouts

BUTTER: brown, clarified, unsalted

capers

carrots and carrot juice

cauliflower, esp. pureed

caviar

cayenne

celery

Champagne

cheese: Asiago, Parmesan

chervil

chile peppers: jalapeño, poblano

Chinese cuisine

chives (garnish)

cilantro

citron

citrus

clams

cloves

coconut and coconut milk

corn

coriander

crab

cream

cream cheese

crème fraîche

cucumbers

curry powder

dashi

dill

duck fat

edamame

eggs, hard-boiled

fennel

fennel seeds

fish sauce, Thai

French cuisine

GARLIC**ginger**

grapefruit: juice, zest

gremolata

ham

haricots verts

honey

horseradish

kaffir lime

kiwi fruit

leeks

LEMON: juice, zest

lemongrass

lemon thyme

lentils

LIME: juice, zest

lobster

mango

marjoram

mascarpone

mint

morels

mushrooms: button, chanterelle, cremini, Japanese, porcini, portobello, shiitake

mussels

mustard, Dijon

OIL: canola, corn, grapeseed, peanut, vegetable

oil: almond, hazelnut

olive oil

onions, esp. red, white, yellow

orange: juice, zest

pancetta

PARSLEY, flat-leaf

passion fruit

pasta

peas

PEPPER: black, white

Pernod

pineapple

pomegranates and pomegranate juice

potatoes, esp. mashed

red pepper flakes

rice

rosemary

saffron

sake

salmon roe

salsify

SALT: kosher, sea

sauce, béchamel

sausages, chorizo

scallions

sea urchin

sesame: seeds, oil

SHALLOTS

shrimp

sole

soy sauce

spinach

squash, butternut

squid

stocks: chicken, clam, fish, shrimp, veal, vegetable

sugar

Tabasco sauce

tarragon, fresh

THYME, FRESH

tomatoes: canned, fresh, paste

truffles, esp. black, white

tuna

turnips

vanilla

vermouth

vinaigrette

VINEGAR: balsamic, champagne, cider, red wine, rice wine, sherry, tarragon,
white wine

watercress

**WINE, DRY WHITE (e.g., Chablis, Chardonnay, Meursault, Riesling,
Sauvignon Blanc)**

Vermouth

yuzu juice

zucchini

We have served cinnamon-dusted sea **scallops**, and they were very tasty.

—MARCEL DESAULNIERS, THE TRELLIS (WILLIAMSBURG, VIRGINIA)

You'll find sushi chefs combining **scallops** with kiwi.

—KATSUYA FUKUSHIMA, MINIBAR (WASHINGTON, DC)

We offer Gulf of Maine sea **scallops** scented with citrus, spices, and vanilla bean, caramelized Belgian endive, ruby red grapefruit, mâche, and mint. The dish came about because I love vanilla and grapefruit. I came up with the idea that I would use dry citrus to powder my scallops. Then I realized that was just one note, so I added some spice which led to star anise, fennel, and anise seed. I sauce the dish with a beurre blanc and grapefruit syrup made of fresh grapefruit, candied peel, and fresh vanilla bean. Since the sauce has butter and cream, I had to be careful not to turn this into vanilla crème brûlée! I love caramelized endive because you have a bitter vegetable that you make sweet. We cook it in whole butter and just as it starts to brown we sprinkle in sugar. This balances the tart and sweet of the grapefruit and the sweetness of the scallops.

—**CARRIE NAHABEDIAN**, NAHA (CHICAGO)

Sear **scallops** on one side only, or else they'll be overcooked. Accent them with coconut milk, garlic, ginger, or lemongrass. Or, puree sea scallops with cream and cook them slowly in a double boiler, which gives them the appearance of white scrambled eggs. This pairs beautifully with caviar, chopped raw onion, or truffles.

—**MICHEL RICHARD**, CITRONELLE (WASHINGTON, DC)

Scallops with chanterelles and green parsley sauce is as beautiful on the plate as it is on the palate.

—**HIRO SONE**, TERRA (ST. HELENA, CALIFORNIA)

Nantucket bay **scallops** are magically delicious, and pairing them with duck fat is an unusual combination that works. It is essentially scallops Provençal, but instead of using olive oil you use duck fat that gives you a silky quality. It is an enormously fun dish to cook and you use your eyes and nose to cook it. You heat up duck fat, getting it really hot, then sauté the scallops really fast. After taking them out, add chopped garlic and tomato *concasse*. It moves along quickly; hit it with chicken stock, adjust it with some lemon juice, and let it reduce and emulsify. You add your scallops back in with some chiffonade of basil and it's done.

The dish smells so good while you're cooking it, between the garlic, the

scallops, and the duck fat. The whole thing is done in one shot. No resting, no slicing, no elaborate plating. It's fun, and it's delicious.

—DAVID WALTUCK, CHANTERELLE (NEW YORK CITY)

Flavor Affinities

scallops + almonds + cauliflower

scallops + apples + bacon + watercress

scallops + apples + tarragon

scallops + asparagus + butter + lemongrass

scallops + avocado + lemon + lobster

scallops + bacon + chives

scallops + bacon + garlic + chanterelle mushrooms

scallops + bacon + leeks

scallops + basil + caviar + chives + tomatoes

scallops + basil + chicken stock + duck fat + garlic + lemon juice + tomatoes

scallops + basil + grapefruit

scallops + bay leaf + vanilla

scallops + Brussels sprouts + pancetta

scallops + carrot juice + pomegranate juice

scallops + cauliflower + cream

scallops + cilantro + lemon + sake

scallops + coriander + crab + lemon + thyme

scallops + dashi + Japanese mushrooms

scallops + edamame + mint

scallops + fennel + lemon + parsley

scallops + fennel + orange + rosemary

scallops + garlic + mushrooms

scallops + ginger + mint

scallops + ginger + scallions

scallops + ham + pineapple

scallops + kaffir lime + lemongrass + peanuts

scallops + parsley + salmon roe

SCANDINAVIAN CUISINE

aquavit

cardamom, esp. in baked goods

cinnamon

cucumbers

dill

fruits, esp. stewed

ginger

herring, pickled

juniper berries

nutmeg

onions

salmon, cured (aka gravlax)

soups, fruit

sour cream

Flavor Affinities

apples + cinnamon + sugar

cardamom + ginger + cinnamon + nutmeg + cloves

cucumbers + dill + onions + sugar + vinegar

SCOTCH

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: moderate–loud

bitters

Earl Grey tea

gin

ginger

lemon, juice

lime, juice

orange, juice

soda

tamarind syrup

vermouth

Flavor Affinities

scotch + Earl Grey tea + tamarind syrup

scotch + ginger + lemon juice

During the winter months, I'll turn to bourbon and brown spirits to make cocktails. But non–scotch drinkers might turn their noses up at a cocktail with **scotch** in the name, so I created the Scotty and Tammy—an Earl Grey tea–based scotch drink made with tamarind syrup that goes especially well with Indian food.

—JERRI BANKS, COCKTAIL CONSULTANT (NEW YORK CITY)

The combination of ginger and **scotch** is explosive! I think the combination of ginger and lemon is such a welcoming flavor and can take on almost any spirit. Ginger itself is one of the most compelling scents and flavors in the world. Nothing else comes close.

—JERRI BANKS, COCKTAIL CONSULTANT (NEW YORK CITY)

I love citrus and fruit in general with savory food because they add acidity. Fruit works really well with **seafood** because seafood is also sweet. During the winter, we served a seafood consommé with green apple and ginger. We added a little green apple juice in the end for the acid balance.

—**DANIEL HUMM**, ELEVEN MADISON PARK (NEW YORK CITY)

We use the **Seafood** Watch guide from the Monterey Bay Aquarium to help select the fish we serve.

—**MONICA POPE**, T'AFIA (HOUSTON)

Our Seafood Watch regional guides contain the latest information on sustainable **seafood** choices available in different regions of the United States. Our Best Choices are abundant, well managed, and fished or farmed in environmentally friendly ways. **Seafood** to avoid are overfished and/or fished or farmed in ways that harm other marine life or the environment. You can view the guides online or download a pocket-size version.

—**MONTEREY BAY AQUARIUM SEAFOOD WATCH**

We work to inspire a closer relationship with the sea through science, art, and literature [including its Guide to Ocean Friendly Seafood].

—**BLUE OCEAN INSTITUTE**

SEAFOOD—IN GENERAL

(See also specific fish and Shellfish)

Tips: Tap these ideas when cooking a medley of assorted seafood.

apples, esp. green

avocados

brandy, dry

capers

citrus

fennel

fruit

garlic

ginger

LEMON JUICE

mint

Old Bay seasoning

olive oil

olives

onions

parsley, flat-leaf

pepper: white, black

red pepper flakes

rosemary

saffron

salt

shallots

sherry

vinaigrettes

vinegars

wine: dry white (e.g., Sancerre, Soave)

Flavor Affinities

seafood + brandy + sherry

seafood + fennel + lemon + mint

seafood + green apple + ginger

Dishes

Spicy Gazpacho with Chilled Seafood Salad and Sweet Herbs

—Vitaly Paley, Paley's Place (Portland, Oregon)

Seafood Salad: Scallops, Squid, Japanese Octopus, Lobster, Avocado, Lemon Vinaigrette

—Alfred Portale, Gotham Bar and Grill (New York City)

The Cure Crudo: Tuna Bresaola, Citrus Sardine, and Smoked Scallop with Blood Orange

—Barton Seaver, Hook (Washington, DC)

Seafood Salad with Chickpeas, Celery, and Black Olives

—Hiro Sone, Terra (St. Helena, California)



SESAME OIL
(See Oil, Sesame)

SESAME SEEDS, BLACK

Taste: bitter

Weight: light

Volume: quiet

Tips: Use whole seeds.

apples

Asian cuisine

bananas

Chinese cuisine

fish

Japanese cuisine

lemon, juice

meats

mirin

rice

salt

seafood

sesame seeds, white

soy sauce

vegetables

vinegar, rice wine

SESAME SEEDS, WHITE

Taste: sweet

Function: heating

Weight: light

Volume: quiet

Tips: Toast before using; use ground or whole.

allspice

apples

Asian cuisines

baked goods (e.g., bagels, breads, cakes, cookies)

bananas

beef

beets

bread and breadsticks

cardamom

chicken

chickpeas

chile peppers

Chinese cuisine (e.g., dim sum)

cilantro

cinnamon

cloves

coriander

duck

eggplant

fish

garlic

ginger

honey

hummus

ice cream

Indian cuisine

Japanese cuisine

lamb

Lebanese cuisine

legumes

lemon

meats

mole sauces

Middle Eastern cuisine

noodles

nutmeg

orange

oregano

paprika

pepper

rice

SALADS (green, pasta) and salad dressings

scallions

scallops

sesame oil

shellfish

shrimp

soy sauce

spinach

stir-fried dishes

sugar

sumac

tahini paste (key ingredient)

thyme

Turkish cuisine

vanilla

vegetables, esp. cold, green

zucchini

Flavor Affinities

sesame seeds + honey + tahini paste + vanilla

sesame seeds + garlic + soy sauce + spinach

SHALLOTS

Season: summer

Taste: sweet

Botanical relatives: chives, garlic, leeks, onions

Weight: light–medium

Volume: moderate

Techniques: blanch, braise, deep-fry, fry, roast, sauté, stir-fry

Tips: Shallots are milder than garlic or onions.

beef

butter

capers

chicken

chives

cod

cognac

cream

fish, esp. baked, grilled

French cuisine, esp. sauces

garlic

halibut

lemon, juice

meats, esp. grilled, roasted

mustard, Dijon

nutmeg

olive oil

oysters

parsley, flat-leaf

pasta

pepper, white

port

salads and salad dressings

salt

saucés (e.g., béarnaise, bordelaise, red wine)

sherry

squash, butternut

steak

stock, chicken

sugar (pinch)

tarragon

thyme

tomatoes

veal

vinaigrettes

vinegar: balsamic, champagne, cider, red wine, sherry, white wine
wine

SHELLFISH

(See also Crab, Lobster, Scallops, Shrimp, etc.)

Season: summer

almonds
bacon
basil
celery
chives
cilantro
coconut
cream
curry
fennel
fines herbes (i.e., chervil, chives, parsley, tarragon)
fruit
garlic
ginger
grapefruit
hoisin sauce
LEMON
lemongrass
Old Bay seasoning
orange
saffron
tarragon
tomatoes
vanilla
vinegar
watermelon
wines, dry white (e.g., Sauvignon Blanc)

Flavor Affinities

shellfish + almonds + vanilla
shellfish + curry + lemongrass
shellfish + saffron + cream

Fruit works easily with **shellfish**. You need to be careful, though, and counteract some of the sweetness of the fruit with vinegar or a citrus juice like lemon. Watermelon works well with shellfish, and I particularly like it with lobster, shrimp, and crab.

—**GABRIEL KREUTHER**, THE MODERN (NEW YORK CITY)

I love Provençal-style **shellfish** cooked with saffron and cream.

—**HIRO SONE**, TERRA (ST. HELENA, CALIFORNIA)

I love vanilla with **shellfish** because it brings out the sweetness. It works with scallops, lobster, or shrimp. I make a lobster-vanilla bisque that is one of my favorite soups. I also serve a scallop dish with vanilla, almonds, and orange. The vanilla brings up the sweet, the almonds add crispness to the creamy rich scallops, and the orange adds some acid. The dish also works really well with grapefruit instead of orange and gives it a tart flavor as well.

—**BOB IACOVONE**, CUVÉE (NEW ORLEANS)

SHIITAKE MUSHROOMS

(See Mushrooms—Shiitakes)

SHISO LEAF

Weight: light

Volume: moderate–loud

Techniques: raw

apples

avocados

basil

beef

cabbage

chicken

chives

clams

crab

cucumbers

fish, esp. fried or oily

fried foods

ginger

Japanese cuisine

Korean cuisine

lemon

lemongrass

lime

meat

melon

mint

miso

noodles

onions

orange

parsley

pears

pickles

prawns

radishes
rice
salads: green, fruit
sea urchin
seafood
shrimp
soups
soy sauce
sushi and sashimi
tempura
turnips
vinegar
wasabi
yellowtail

Flavor Affinities

shiso leaf + avocado + crab
shiso leaf + clams + onions

Visually you can't beat **shiso**; it is a big, beautiful leaf. It is great with fried foods, oily fish, and sea urchin, and pairs with big, robust flavors. Instead of grabbing lemon or soy sauce, you can use shiso to liven up a dish.

—**BRAD FARMERIE**, PUBLIC (NEW YORK CITY)

Shiso is a very versatile herb and works with a lot of things. It can work with pears as well as apples, not to mention a variety of seafood like Dungeness crab and spot prawns.

—**JERRY TRAUNFELD**, THE HERBFARM (WOODINVILLE, WASHINGTON)

SHORT RIBS

(See Beef—Short Ribs)

SHRIMP

(See also Shellfish)

Season: year-round

Weight: light-medium (depending on size)

Volume: quiet

Techniques: bake, barbecue, boil, broil, deep-fry, grill, poach, roast, sauté, steam, stir-fry

allspice

almonds

apples and apple cider

artichokes

arugula

asparagus

avocado

bacon

basil

bay leaf

beans: black, cranberry, fava, green, white

beer

bell peppers, red

bonito flakes (e.g., Japanese)

brandy

bread crumbs, *panko*

brown butter sauce

butter, unsalted

cabbage: green, red

Cajun cuisine

capers

carrots and carrot juice

caviar

cayenne

celery

celery root

chervil

chicory

CHILE PEPPERS, e.g., ancho, chipotle, dried red, jalapeño, serrano

chili oil

chili paste

chili powder

chili sauce

Chinese cuisine

chives

cilantro (garnish)

cinnamon

clams

cloves

coconut: milk, shredded

cognac

coriander

corn

CRAB

cream

Creole cuisine

cucumbers

cumin

curry leaf

curry powder or sauce

dill

eggs

endive

fennel

fennel seeds

fish, white

fish sauce, Thai

***GARLIC**

ginger

greens, esp. beet, dandelion, collard, mustard, turnip

grits

hazelnut oil

honey

horseradish
Japanese cuisine
kaffir lime leaf
ketchup
Korean cuisine
leeks
LEMON: juice, zest
lemongrass
lettuce
lime: leaves, juice, whole, zest
lobster
mango
marjoram
mayonnaise
Mediterranean cuisine
melon, cantaloupe
Mexican cuisine
mint
mirin
monkfish
mushrooms, (e.g., chanterelles, shiitakes)
mussels
mustard: country, Dijon, dry (sauce)
mustard seeds
nutmeg
OIL: canola, corn, grapeseed, peanut, vegetable
oil: peanut, sesame (for drizzling)
Old Bay seasoning
olive oil
olives, black
ONIONS, esp. red, Spanish, white
orange: juice, zest
oregano
oysters
paprika
parsley, flat-leaf
pasta

peanuts

PEPPER: black, white

pesto

pike

pineapple and pineapple juice

pine nuts

pistachios

pumpkin

radishes

red pepper flakes

rice (e.g., Arborio, bomba)

risotto

rosemary

rum, dark

saffron

sage

sake

salsa

SALT: kosher, sea

sauce, romesco

sausages (e.g., andouille)

scallions

scallops

sesame: oil, seeds

shallots

shiso leaf

snow peas

sour cream

Southern cuisine

soy sauce

spinach

squid

squid ink

star anise

stocks: chicken, clam, fish, shrimp

sugar: brown, white

sweet potatoes

Tabasco sauce

tarragon

tea sandwiches

tempura

Thai cuisine

thyme, lemon

TOMATOES and tomato paste, sun-dried

turmeric

vanilla

vermouth

Vietnamese cuisine

vinaigrette

vinegar: balsamic, rice wine, sherry, tarragon, wine

wasabi

watercress

WINE: dry white, rice, Sauternes

Worcestershire sauce

yogurt

yuzu juice

zucchini

Dishes

Black Spaghetti with Rock Shrimp, Spicy Salami Calabrese, and Green Chiles

—Mario Batali, Babbo (New York City)

Ceviche Yucateco: Steamed Organic Shrimp and Calamari Tossed with Lime, Orange, Habanero, Avocado, and Cilantro

—Rick Bayless, Frontera Grill (Chicago)

Phyllo-Crusted Shrimp with Crabmeat in an Ocean Herbal Broth

—David Bouley, Bouley (New York City)

Shrimp Sautéed in a Spicy Sauce with Jalapeño, Mint, and Garlic, Topped with Shredded Fresh Coconut

—Zarela Martinez, Zarela (New York City)

Chipotle Shrimp Corn Cakes

—Mark Miller, Coyote Café (Santa Fe)

Shrimp with White Bean Salad and Italian Sausage

—Patrick O’Connell, The Inn at Little Washington (Washington, Virginia)

Sweet Shrimp Risotto: Roma Tomatoes, Wilted Arugula, and Crisp Bacon

—Alfred Portale, Gotham Bar and Grill (New York City)

Shrimp in Light Three-Pepper Red Mole Sauce (Coloradito) over Cuban-Style Fresh Corn Polenta and Sautéed Kale

—Maricel Presilla, Zafra (Hoboken, New Jersey)

Fricassee of Rock Shrimp, Mango, Leeks, and Coconut Rum

—Allen Susser, Chef Allen's (Aventura, Florida)

Shrimp and Avocado Ceviche, Kaffir Lime, Coconut Milk, Scallions, and Pappadam

—Allen Susser, Chef Allen's (Aventura, Florida)

Shrimp shells are a base for a great sauce. They are really sweet, and you want to be sure to brown all the shrimp shell surfaces to get the maximum sweetness. This sauce came about by smelling the shells while they were cooking, and working with the flavors that came to mind. I added vanilla and whiskey, and something magical happened.

—CARRIE NAHABEDIAN, NAHA (CHICAGO)



Flavor Affinities

shrimp + bacon + chives
shrimp + basil + garlic + jalapeño chile
shrimp + black beans + coriander
shrimp + cayenne + cinnamon + orange
shrimp + cepes mushrooms + curry powder + Dijon mustard
shrimp + chiles + lime juice + brown sugar
shrimp + coriander + tarragon
shrimp + crab + Old Bay seasoning
shrimp + crab + pistachio nuts + watercress
shrimp + garlic + grits + mascarpone + tomato
shrimp + garlic + lime
shrimp + garlic + mustard + tarragon
shrimp + ginger + green apple + saffron
shrimp + horseradish + ketchup + lemon
shrimp + white beans + bell pepper + orange + sausage

SKATE

Season: summer

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: quiet–moderate

Techniques: broil, grill, poach, roast, sauté, steam

almonds

anchovies

arugula

bay leaf

butter and butter sauces (e.g., brown butter)

CAPERS

carrots

cayenne

celery and celery leaves

chives

cilantro

clams

cloves

dill

eggplant

fennel

garlic

leeks

LEMON, juice

lemon balm

lovage

mustard, Dijon

OIL: canola, peanut, sesame, vegetable

OLIVE OIL

onions

orange, juice

parsley, flat-leaf

parsnips

pasta

pepper: black, green, white

pistachios

polenta

ponzu sauce

potatoes

pumpkin seeds

rosemary

saffron

sage

sake

salt: kosher, sea

shallots

shrimp

spinach

squid

star anise

tapenade

tarragon

thyme

tomatoes and tomato paste

vinaigrette

VINEGAR: balsamic, red wine, rice wine, sherry

walnuts

wine: dry white, red

Dishes

Skate with Hen-of-the-Woods (Mushrooms) and Butternut Squash

—Mario Batali, Babbo (New York City)

Chanterelle-Stuffed Skate, Creamy Spinach, “Carotte Fondante,” and Bordelaise Sauce

—Daniel Boulud, Daniel (New York City)

Sautéed Skate Wing with Caper Brown Butter

—Jean Joho, Brasserie Jo (Chicago)

Skate Wing and a Cannelloni of “Sunchoke” with Butter-Poached Chesapeake Bay Lump Crab, Jerusalem Artichokes, and Oyster Mushrooms

—Carrie Nahabedian, Naha (Chicago)

Sage goes really well with **skate**—it gives the skate a masculine touch.

—ERIC RIPERT, LE BERNARDIN (NEW YORK CITY)

I make a sautéed **skate** dish that is basically a version of linguini with white clam sauce. The sauce with the skate is made from the juice from the clams, garlic, anchovy, and olive oil and it is finished with a parsley puree. With the fish I also serve angel hair pasta. All these flavors are what you will find in white clam sauce, but are just served in a different form.

—DAVID WALTUCK, CHANTERELLE (NEW YORK CITY)

We still have the same philosophy as when we opened: The fish is still the star of the plate. We have not budged from there, but every dish has a sauce that completes the dish, and brings together all the elements on the plate and

creates harmony. We pay homage to seafood and are dedicated to it, but use a wide palette from rich sauces to broths and a variety of spices and emulsions.

What makes a dish work is the way we make and treat our sauce. We don't make a sauce in the morning and use it for the day. Can you imagine if you made coffee in the morning and came back at noon to taste it? It would be disgusting. The same for tea: if you left a tea bag in your tea all day, at night it would be awful.

We used to make a garlic sage broth and I found it to be very volatile. I realized that the sauce is really only good for three minutes. After that, the sage kills the garlic or vice versa and the sauce loses its balance. What we ended up doing is making a base with chicken stock, then using a tea bag with ingredients in it to infuse the sauce, and we serve it right away. This sauce is paired with **skate** roasted in goose fat with green peppercorns. On the side we serve artichokes with pistachios and Parmesan cheese.

—**ERIC RIPERT**, LE BERNARDIN (NEW YORK CITY)

Flavor Affinities

skate + butter + pistachios

skate + capers + garlic + lemon juice

skate + capers + sherry vinegar

skate + fennel + onions

skate + garlic + sage

SLOW-COOKED

Season: autumn–winter

Tips: These herbs and flavorings taste better with longer cooking. For the opposite of slow-cooked, see **Freshness**.

cumin
garlic
ginger
horseradish
onions
oregano
rosemary
shallots
thyme

SMOKED SALMON
(See Salmon, Smoked)

SMOKINESS

Tips: Add a smoky component to provide a “meaty” flavor to a dish or to counteract the richness of certain meats and seafoods.

bacon
barbecued foods
beer, smoked
cheese, smoked
chile peppers, chipotle
duck, smoked
fish, smoked (e.g., salmon, trout)
grilled foods
ham, smoked
liquid smoke
paprika, smoked
salmon, smoked
salt, smoked
sausage, smoked
tea, Lapsang Souchong
whiskey, scotch

SNAP PEAS

(aka sugar snap peas)

Season: spring

Taste: sweet

Weight: light

Volume: quiet

Techniques: blanch, raw, steam, stir-fry

almonds

basil

brown butter sauce

butter

carrots

celery

chervil

chives

cilantro

cream

curry

dill

garlic

ginger

halibut

leeks

lemon, juice

marjoram

mint

mushrooms

nutmeg

olive oil

onions

oregano

parsley

pepper, white

potatoes
rice
rosemary
saffron
sage
salmon
scallions
sesame oil
sesame seeds
shrimp
stock, vegetable
tarragon
thyme
yogurt

Flavor Affinities

snap peas + brown butter + sage

Dishes

Alaskan King Salmon with Sugar Snap Peas

—David Pasternak, Esca (New York City)

SNAPPER

(aka red snapper)

Season: late spring–early autumn

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate

Techniques: bake, braise, broil, deep-fry, grill, poach, roast, sauté, steam, stir-fry

almonds

apricots, esp. dried

artichokes

basil (garnish)

bay leaf

bell peppers: green, red, yellow

butter, unsalted

cabbage

capers

carrots

cayenne

celery and celery leaves

chile peppers: chipotle, jalapeño

chives

cilantro

clams

coconut

coriander

couscous

crab

cream

cumin

dill

fennel

fennel seeds

five-spice powder

GARLIC

ginger

grapefruit

hazelnuts

leeks

LEMON: fruit, juice, zest

lemon thyme

lime, juice

mint

miso: dried, white

mushrooms: ceps, chanterelles

mustard, Dijon

OIL: canola, corn, grapeseed, vegetable

OLIVE OIL

olives: black, kalamata

onions: red, white

orange: juice, zest

papaya

paprika

parsley, flat-leaf

peas, sugar snap

pepper: black, white

pesto

pistachios, esp. as crust

port

potatoes

red pepper flakes

rice

rosemary

saffron

SALT: kosher, sea

sauces: brown butter, hollandaise, romesco

sausage, esp. spicy

scallions

seaweed (for presentation)

sesame

shallots

shrimp

spinach

star anise

stocks: chicken, fish

sugar

sweet potatoes

tarragon

thyme

TOMATOES: canned, fresh, paste

turnips

vinegar: red wine, sherry, white

wine, dry white

Dishes

Marinated Thai Snapper with Wasabi Cream; Shaved Radishes and Poppy Seed Tuile
—Daniel Boulud, Daniel (New York City)



Flavor Affinities

snapper + clams + romesco sauce + sausage
snapper + fennel + olives + orange + saffron
snapper + coconut + crab + papaya
snapper + garlic + potatoes + rosemary
snapper + lemon + thyme + tomatoes

SOLE

Weight: light

Volume: quiet

Techniques: pan sear, poach, sauté, steam

artichokes

asparagus

basil: sweet, lemon

bass

bay leaf

beans, fava

bread crumbs

BUTTER, unsalted

buttermilk

capers

carrots

cayenne

celery and celery leaves

chervil

CHIVES

coriander

cornmeal

couscous

cream

dill

endive

French cuisine

garlic

ginger

greens, collard

LEMON: juice, slices

lobster

mayonnaise

Mediterranean cuisine

milk
mint, esp. spearmint
mushrooms: button, morels
mussels
noodles
oil: canola, corn, grapeseed, olive, peanut, vegetable
olive oil
onions, esp. white
oysters
paprika
PARSLEY, flat-leaf
peas
PEPPER: black, pink, white
potatoes
quince
ramps
salmon
SALT: kosher, sea
sauces: brown butter, hollandaise
SHALLOTS
shrimp
spinach
star anise
stock, fish
TARRAGON
thyme
tomatoes
truffles
vinegar, balsamic
watercress
WINE, DRY WHITE (e.g., Chablis)

Flavor Affinities

sole + butter + lemon + parsley
sole + paprika + potatoes

SORREL

Season: spring–autumn

Taste: sour

Weight: medium, soft-leaved

Volume: moderate–loud

Tips: Always use fresh; as a softleaved herb, it will lose flavor in sauces, soups.

almonds

apples

avocados

bacon

basil

BUTTER, UNSALTED

carrots

caviar

chard

CHEESE: Emmental, goat, **Gruyère**, **Parmesan**, pecorino, **ricotta**, Swiss

chervil

chicken

chives

cilantro

collard greens

CREAM

crème fraîche

cucumbers

dandelion greens

dill

EGGS: egg-based dishes, omelets

escarole

FISH

French cuisine

garlic

grapes

greens

leeks
lemon, juice
lemon verbena
lentils, esp. green
lettuce
lovage
marinades
meats
mint
mushrooms
mussels
mustard
nutmeg
olive oil
onions
paprika
parsley, flat-leaf
parsnip
pepper: black, white
pork
potatoes, esp. new, russet
poultry
rice
salads (say some)
salmon
salmon, smoked
salt
saucers, cream
seafood
shad
shallots
shellfish
SOUPS, esp. creamy vegetable
sour cream
SPINACH
STOCKS: chicken, veal, vegetable
stuffings

tarragon
tea sandwiches
thyme, lemon
tomatoes
trout
veal
vegetarian dishes
vinegar, red wine
watercress
wine, dry white

AVOID

salads (say some)

Flavor Affinities

sorrel + butter + chicken stock
sorrel + garlic + spinach
sorrel + leeks + potatoes
sorrel + nutmeg + ricotta cheese

Dishes

Puree of Sorrel Soup with Toasted Marcona Almonds and Poached Sultanas

—Thomas Keller, The French Laundry (Yountville, California)

Sorrel has a green vegetal quality and is tangy. It is a little like tasting fish sauce: on its own it is nasty, but with food it is great! Sorrel also works with eggs as well as seafood. One of the seafood dishes we make is roasted oysters with bacon and sorrel sauce.

—**JERRY TRAUNFELD**, THE HERBFARM (WOODINVILLE, WASHINGTON)

SOUR CREAM

Taste: sour

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: moderate–loud

Tips: Use fresh, or cook at low temperatures only.

baked goods (e.g., cakes, cookies)

borscht

caviar

desserts

dill

dips

European cuisine, esp. eastern and northern

fruit

horseradish

Hungarian cuisine

lemon, juice

mustard

paprika

pepper

potatoes, esp. baked

Russian cuisine

salads and salad dressings

sauces

Scandinavian cuisine

soups

I like galangal, lemongrass, and ginger. They all have natural **acidity** and zingy spice that will perk anything up. Even if you are not adding [a liquid] acid to coconut milk but add aromatics instead, your dish won't taste heavy.

—BRAD FARMERIE, PUBLIC (NEW YORK CITY)

SOURNESS

Taste: sour

Function: heating; stimulates appetite; increases thirst

Tips: Sourness tends to sharpen other flavors.

In small doses, sour notes enhance bitterness, while in large doses, they suppress bitterness.

apples, tart (e.g., Granny Smith, Winesap)

blackberries

buttermilk

caraway seeds

cheese, sour (e.g., chèvre, other goat cheese)

cherries, sour

citrus

cloves

coriander

cornichons

cranberries

cream cheese

cream of tartar

crème fraîche

currants

fermented foods

fruits: sour, unripened

galangal

ginger

grapefruit

grapes, green

kaffir lime

kiwi fruit

kumquats

lemon: juice, zest

lemon, preserved

lemongrass

lime: juice, zest

milk, goat's

miso

mushrooms, enoki

orange: juice, zest

pickled foods

plums, esp. unripe

ponzu

quince

rhubarb

rose hips

sauces, reduced-wine

sauerkraut

sorrel

sour cream

soy sauce

sumac

tamarind

tomatoes, esp. green

verjus

vinegars

whey

wine, dry

yogurt

yuzu

A defining factor for American cooks is hitting high notes with **acidic** tones. Using acidity to create brightness in dishes stands out from the cooking I did in France. French cooking is all about harmony, while American cooking is about hitting the high notes. In American fine dining, you have to have some boundaries with your acidity because you are working with wine. It is important to hit the high notes but you have to do it without destroying the wine pairing.

—MICHAEL ANTHONY, GRAMERCY TAVERN (NEW YORK CITY)

Almost every dish has to have some sort of **acid**, or else it will taste flat. It is a question of taste—some chefs like sour, some like sweet—and there is no right or wrong. Lemon juice is used in small amounts to bring out other flavors. I use all kinds of vinegars—banyuls, red wine, rice wine, and sherry, just to name a few.

—**DAVID WALTUCK**, CHANTERELLE (NEW YORK CITY)

I have a cupboard full of acids! Every culture is doing the same thing when it comes to using **acid** in its food: it is all about enhancing flavor without adding salt. We use a lot of citrus, whether it is lemon, lime, or something else. When I lived in England, they joked with me because I would add orange juice to almost everything, especially vinaigrettes. I really like its acidity and the light, fruity flavor it adds. On a totally different end of the spectrum is tamarind. We always have tamarind water in our refrigerator and use it to finish sauces. Depending on the country of inspiration, I will use a different acid: for India, tamarind; Japan, ponzu, yuzu; Middle East, sumac, preserved lemon, and yogurt; and for Southeast Asia, lemon, lime, and tamarind.

—**BRAD FARMERIE**, PUBLIC (NEW YORK CITY)

I select my **acids** as carefully as I select my sweeteners. I could use lemon juice for everything, but in some cases, *verjus* will add a brightness that balsamic or sherry vinegar won't. I love *verjus* and have served it alone as a sorbet. I have also served it with apple and pears. I like ice wine vinegar with roasting fruits. Aged balsamic vinegar isn't shocking anymore—it is great straight over fruit or added to an ice cream.

—**MICHAEL LAISKONIS**, LE BERNARDIN (NEW YORK CITY)

When you add **acid** to a sauce, it lifts everything up. Lemon is my favorite; I use lemon and orange the way a chef uses salt and pepper. Whether I add the juice, zest, or confit depends on the cooking application:

- **Juice:** If a recipe calls for water, why use that? Why not add flavor and use orange juice?
- **Zest:** If I make *panna cotta*, it will have orange zest in it but it will not taste

orangey. If I make a cake, I also use zest.

- **Confit:** I use this most often as a garnish.

—MICHAEL LAISKONIS, LE BERNARDIN (NEW YORK CITY)

SOUS-VIDE COOKING

What **sous-vide** [“under vacuum”] cooking does is give you a long, very controlled cooking time. I like to use it on vegetables because no air hits the vegetable. All the white vegetables come out really white. It also keeps the whiteness in fruits like apples and pears.

—**DANIEL HUMM**, ELEVEN MADISON PARK (NEW YORK CITY)

Instead of **sous-vide**, with poultry I’ll use a poaching technique I learned from my grandmother: I’ll cover a whole chicken or turkey or pheasant with cold liquid, mirepoix, garlic, and herbs; cover the pot with a tight-fitting lid; bring it to a boil; drop it to a simmer; and then turn it off. This technique creates a vacuum seal that transfers all the flavor into the chicken. It’s ten times better than straight poaching, because you don’t lose any moisture. I’ll serve the chicken cold with a hot ginger sauce that’s two parts fresh ginger to one part each garlic, scallions, and cilantro. I heat oil to smoking, pour it over the herbs, and serve the hot ginger-herb sauce over the cold poached chicken. It’s delicious.

—**TONY LIU**, AUGUST (NEW YORK CITY)

SOUTHEAST ASIAN CUISINES

Tips: Balance hot + sour + salty + sweet tastes.

chile peppers

coconut milk

curries

fish sauce

galangal

ginger

lemongrass

lime

mint

soy sauce

sugar

tamarind

vegetables: fresh, fermented

Flavor Affinities

chile peppers + fish sauce + lime + sugar

fish sauce + lime + tamarind

SOUTHERN CUISINE (AMERICAN)

baked goods, e.g., biscuits

barbecue

black-eyed peas

chicken, esp. fried

gravy

greens, esp. collard

grits

ham

pies

pork

potatoes

rice

sweet potatoes

tea: iced, sweet

SOUTHWESTERN CUISINE (AMERICAN)

avocados

beans

beef

cheese

chicken

chiles

chocolate

cilantro

cinnamon

corn

limes

nuts

onions

pork

rice

squash

tomatoes

tortillas

SOY SAUCE

Taste: salty

Weight: light

Volume: moderate–loud

Tips: Add at the end of the cooking process, or to finish a dish. Use in stir-fries.

basil

beef

broccoli

chicken

Chinese cuisine

coriander

fish: cooked, raw

garlic

ginger

honey

Japanese cuisine

Korean cuisine

lime juice

lobster, raw

marinades

meats

mirin

molasses

orange zest

peanuts

red pepper flakes

salt

scallions

seafood

sesame oil

sugar

wasabi

Flavor Affinities

soy sauce + coriander + honey

soy sauce + garlic + ginger

soy sauce + molasses + sugar

I add **soy sauce** to my onion soup because it gives it a meaty flavor. I use so much soy sauce at home my kid is starting to look Asian!

—MICHEL RICHARD, CITRONELLE (WASHINGTON, DC)

White soy sauce is something I fell in love with while cooking in Japan for two years. It is like liquid smoke. It is not really soy sauce, but more of a brewed wheat product. It has a smoky quality, too, but it is still so light you can use it on hamachi with sesame seeds and olive oil.

—MICHAEL ANTHONY, GRAMERCY TAVERN (NEW YORK CITY)

White soy sauce is lighter on the palate and has a cleaner, more direct flavor than regular soy sauce. Regular soy sauce has a touch of caramel for color, flavor, and body, which makes it more a part of the dish rather than simply enhancing the ingredient. White soy sauce will let the ingredient sing. It is very pale, and if you make a ponzu sauce with mirin and rice wine vinegar, you'll get something almost clear.

—BRAD FARMERIE, PUBLIC (NEW YORK CITY)

SPANISH CUISINE

almonds

anchovies

bay leaf

bread

chorizo

custards

eggs

fish

fruits

garlic

ham, Serrano

hazelnuts

lemon

meats, esp. roasted

olive oil

olives

onion

orange

paprika, sweet

parsley

peppers, esp. guindilla or piquillo, esp. roasted

pine nuts

pomegranates

pork

rice

roasts

saffron

shellfish

sherry

soups

stews

thyme

tomatoes

vanilla

vegetables

vinegar, sherry

walnuts

Flavor Affinities

almonds + garlic + olive oil

almonds + olive oil

garlic + olive oil

garlic + onions + paprika + rice + saffron

garlic + onions + parsley

red peppers + onions + tomatoes

tomatoes + almonds + olive oil + roasted red peppers

Dishes

Hearts of Romaine and Treviso Radicchio with Spanish Serrano Ham, Manchego Cheese, and White Anchovies, Fire-Roasted Peppers, and Crisp Capers

—Carrie Nahabedian, Naha (Chicago)

Petite Red Oak Lettuce Salad with Manchego Cheese, Cinnamon Almonds, and Aged Sherry Vinaigrette

—Celina Tio, American Restaurant (Kansas City)

Spain in the New World: How American Chefs Are Influenced by Spain

Sweet Potato, Feta, and Smoked Paprika Tortilla with Minted Lemon Raita: We looked at Spain and the tortilla as the starting point for this dish. A traditional tortilla is made all together in one pan, but we played with that a little. We roast our sweet potatoes first with spicy-smoky paprika that tempers the sweetness with the heat and aromatic smokiness. We add feta cheese for the salt factor and caramelized onion for another layer of flavor. We then mix up a bunch of eggs, combine everything together, and cook it tortilla-style in a hot pan with a lot of olive oil on the stove and then in the oven to finish cooking. When we serve it, we cut it tortilla-style in a wedge and serve it at room temperature. The idea of eggs and potatoes always feels a bit heavy, which is why there is a zesty yogurt on the plate along with a crunchy watercress salad.

—**BRAD FARMERIE**, PUBLIC (NEW YORK CITY)

Hearts of Romaine and Treviso Radicchio with Spanish Serrano Ham, Manchego Cheese and White Anchovies, Fire-Roasted Peppers and Crisp Capers: This dish is an homage to Guillermo, who supplies our Spanish products. His anchovies are so good that if someone asks for them on the side, the waiter just replies, “Trust me....” The reason there is radicchio on the salad is because I like to change people’s opinions of ingredients that have been wronged. When it is added to this salad, it is so good you can’t believe it. It adds a wonderful crunch and balances the romaine and other flavors. I add the fried capers to add some acidity and crunch.

—**CARRIE NAHABEDIAN**, NAHA (CHICAGO)

In Spain, eggs aren’t eaten for breakfast; they are more for dinner. The Spanish also don’t eat brunch, but at Tía Pol, brunch is a way to celebrate the Spanish egg cookery that is a huge part of their diet. The Spanish cook eggs beautifully and in a huge variety. In the Basque country, they really value a soft scrambled egg with a great ingredient in it—whether tiny mushrooms, asparagus, or baby pink shrimp. The Spanish also cook eggs in olive oil. When we serve a fried egg, we cook it in so much oil it is almost deep-fried; instead of using a spatula, we use a spider [a weblike wire mesh strainer] to remove the egg from the pan.

—**ALEXANDRA RAIJ**, TÍA POL (NEW YORK CITY)

We use olive oil as a condiment. In Spain it is not uncommon to see something swimming in olive oil. Anchovies will be covered in oil, and after you eat the anchovies you just dip your bread in the oil. Even a dish that is cooked in olive oil will get a drizzle of raw oil on top for finishing. In Spanish cooking it is hard for me to name a dish that doesn’t get olive oil. We will cook mushrooms in olive oil and serve them with oil on top.

Sautéed vegetables in Spain may get cooked in a little pork fat and then served with diced ham on top. The Spanish also like to braise vegetables, and will add a ham end similar to a trotter [pig’s foot] during the cooking. Any pot of stew or beans, such as garbanzos, will

get ham added to it as well. What the ham end adds to what is being cooked is a little funky flavor but in a good way—like the flavor mold adds to a cheese.

—**ALEXANDRA RAIJ**, TÍA POL (NEW YORK CITY)

SPICES

(See also individual spices)

Just a pinch of **spices** such as fennel, coriander, cumin, and cayenne is great for finishing a sauce. Cayenne is great if you want to raise the heat level. You want to use only a pinch so that you don't even know it is there. If you are making a French lemon sauce with *beurre blanc*, lemon puree, and diced lemon zest, adding a pinch of cayenne will bring up the flavor without making it spicy.

—ANDREW CARMELLINI, A VOCE (NEW YORK CITY)

I am sure every kitchen has its own **pepper mix** that is not just pepper. We have a mix that is specific for meat and occasionally for pork or tuna. It is a combination of black peppercorns, pink peppercorns, coriander seeds, and toasted ground star anise. The other thing I always have next to me is a tray we call “the four seasons”: *fleur de sel*; red pepper flakes—the ultimate marriage of heat and fruit; dry mustard, which I use all the time; and sumac, for an acidic component.

—SHARON HAGE, YORK STREET (DALLAS)

To counteract **overspicing**, you need to increase the quantity of whatever you are making. This is a case where you might want to add a puree of something, or add some sweetness because sweetness balances spice. With an Indian curry that is too powerful, you could puree some dried apricot into it. The apricot puree adds sweetness, binds the sauce, and increases the overall quantity.

—ANDREW CARMELLINI, A VOCE (NEW YORK CITY)

SPINACH

(See also Greens—In General)

Season: year-round

Taste: bitter

Function: cooling

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate

Techniques: boil, raw, sauté, steam, stir-fry, wilt

almonds

anchovies

apples

bacon

basil

***BUTTER, unsalted**

cayenne

chard

CHEESE: aged, Comté, Emmental, feta, goat, Parmesan, ricotta

chicken, esp. grilled

chickpeas

chives

crab

CREAM / MILK

cream cheese

crème fraîche

cumin

curry

dill

eggs, esp. hard-boiled

fennel

fish (e.g., striped bass)

French cuisine

GARLIC

ginger

greens, collard

Indian cuisine

Italian cuisine

Japanese cuisine

lamb, esp. grilled

lemon, juice

lentils

lovage

marjoram

mascarpone

mint, esp. spearmint

mushrooms, esp. shiitake

mustard, Dijon

mustard seeds

NUTMEG

OIL: canola, peanut, sesame, vegetable, **walnut**

olive oil

onions, esp. sweet

pancetta

paprika, sweet

parsley

pasta

pecans

PEPPER: black, white

pesto

pine nuts

potatoes

prosciutto

quince

raisins

red pepper flakes

saffron

SALT: kosher, sea

salt cod

sauces: béchamel, Mornay

scallions

SESAME SEEDS

shallots

shrimp

smoked salmon

sorrel

sour cream

soy sauce

stocks: chicken, vegetable

sugar (pinch)

Tabasco sauce

thyme, fresh

tomatoes

tuna

vinaigrette, esp. sherry

VINEGAR: balsamic, cider, red wine, rice wine, sherry

walnuts

yogurt

Dishes

Warm Mushroom and Baby Spinach Salad with Black Bean Sauce

—Kaz Okochi, Kaz Sushi Bistro (Washington, DC)

Spinach and Walnut Cannelloni in the Style of the River Plate Region, Creamy Manchego and Parmigiano-Reggiano White Sauce, and Tomato Sauce

—Maricel Presilla, Cucharamama (Hoboken, New Jersey)

I love **spinach**. It is best sautéed in a little oil, because if you blanch it, it tends to lose its flavor [to the blanching water]. I like to add some garlic to it, and from there you can go almost anywhere. Sautéed spinach is delicious with a poached egg.

—GABRIEL KREUTHER, THE MODERN (NEW YORK CITY)

Spinach and bacon is simply a great combination. The key to our creamed spinach is that we steam our fresh-leaf spinach just until it wilts, then drain it and chop it slightly. [In a pan,] we start with a little butter and flour to thicken, then add cream, nutmeg, and an *onion piqué* [an onion spiked with cloves], and reduce the cream by half. Then we add the barely cooked spinach to the cream and heat them together briefly so just a little juice infiltrates the cream. You end up with velvety spinach, which we top with [chunks of] Nueske's bacon, which is an applewood-smoked bacon from the Midwest.

—MICHAEL LOMONACO, PORTER HOUSE NEW YORK (NEW YORK CITY)

Our warm mushroom and baby **spinach** salad with black bean sauce works so well because of the garlic, which is the last thing added to the dish. Too often, garlic is overpowering. You want to add just enough.

—KAZ OKOCHI, KAZ SUSHI BISTRO (WASHINGTON, DC)

Flavor Affinities

spinach + bacon + garlic + onions + cider vinegar

spinach + bacon + walnuts

spinach + chives + goat cheese + mascarpone

spinach + cumin + garlic + lemon + yogurt

spinach + fennel + Parmesan cheese + portobello mushrooms + balsamic
vinegar

spinach + feta cheese + lemon juice + oregano

spinach + garlic + mushrooms

spinach + garlic + sorrel

SPRING

Weather: typically warm

Techniques: pan roast and other stove-top methods

artichokes (peak: March–April)

asparagus: green, purple, white (peak: April)

beans, fava (peak: April–June)

cauliflower (peak: March)

crayfish

dandelion greens (peak: May–June)

fiddlehead ferns

garlic, green (peak: March)

greens: salad, spring

lamb, spring

leeks

lemons, Meyer

lettuces

lighter dishes

limes, key

loquats

mushrooms, morel (peak: April)

onions: spring, Vidalia (peak: May)

oranges, navel (peak: March)

peas (peak: May)

ramps (peak: May)

rhubarb (peak: April)

soft-shell crabs

sorrel (peak: May)

soufflés

spices, cooling (e.g., white peppercorns)

strawberries

tomatoes, heirloom

watercress

zucchini blossoms

Spring is when people are looking for all the young salads that they have been missing all winter. I really look forward to asparagus that I will serve simply with mayonnaise or a mousseline.

—**GABRIEL KREUTHER**, THE MODERN (NEW YORK CITY)

Spring is when everyone's moods start to lighten. It may be cold, but people are looking for lighter things. This is rhubarb and strawberry season. Citrus plays a bigger role; in the winter, it is an alternative to chocolate, but in the spring, it is the lighter and more aromatic option.

—**EMILY LUCHETTI**, FARALLON (SAN FRANCISCO)

Spring lamb is one of the quintessential dishes of **spring**.

—**MICHEL RICHARD**, CITRONELLE (WASHINGTON, DC)

You may be thinking about licorice but don't want a licorice sauce. So you may simply just grate some fennel over **squab** and you get this great aroma and when you take a bite you'll taste this root beer–Pernod flavor that is not overbearing that will still work with squab, foie gras, medjool dates, and green peppercorns. Some flavors are meant to be just a soft accent on a dish. I like to think of them as “eye shadow”!

—**CARRIE NAHABEDIAN**, NAHA (CHICAGO)

Dishes

Squab, Watermelon, Foie Gras, and Black Licorice

—Grant Achatz, Alinea (Chicago)

Barbecued Squab with Roasted Beet “Farrotto” and Porcini Mustard

—Mario Batali, Babbo (New York City)

SPROUTS

Season: year-round

Function: cooling

Weight: light

Volume: quiet

Techniques: sauté, steam, stir-fry

Tips: Cook for less than 30 seconds, or they'll wilt.

cucumbers

egg salad

salads, esp. more delicate sprouts

sandwiches

stir-fried dishes, esp. heartier sprouts

SQUAB

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate

Techniques: braise, broil, grill, roast, sauté

bacon

beans, fava

beets

cabbage

cherries

fennel

figs

foie gras

garlic

juniper berries

lentils

mushrooms, wild, esp. porcini

mustard

olive oil

olives

onions

pancetta

pears

peas

pepper, black

prunes

rice and risotto

rosemary

sage

salt

vinegar, balsamic

wine, esp. red

SQUASH, ACORN

(See also Pumpkin; Squash, Butternut; and Squash, Winter)

Season: autumn–winter

Taste: sweet

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: moderate

Techniques: bake, mash

allspice

bay leaf

butter, esp. brown

cheese, Parmesan

cinnamon

cream

eggs, custard

garlic

ginger, fresh

maple syrup

mascarpone

mushrooms, esp. shiitake

nutmeg

nuts

olive oil

onions, esp. cipollini

parsley

pork

SAGE

salt, kosher

sugar, brown

thyme

vanilla

vinegar, sherry

Flavor Affinities

acorn squash + custard + sage

acorn squash + ginger + maple syrup

Dishes

Heirloom Autumn Squash Salad with Local Pears, Currants, Roasted Chestnuts, Sankow Farm Feta Cheese, and Brown Butter Dressing

—Michael Nischan, Dressing Room (Westport, Connecticut)

Butternut Squash Soup with Honey-Glazed Parsnips, Spaghetti Squash, and Smoked Duck, Maple Syrup, Styrian Pumpkin Seed Oil, and Crisp Garnett Yams

—Carrie Nahabedian, Naha (Chicago)

I find **butternut** to be the best **squash**. It is nutty, sweet, and has a balanced flavor to it.

—DANIEL HUMM, ELEVEN MADISON PARK (NEW YORK CITY)

In winter, one of my favorite combinations is **butternut squash** with bay leaf and nutmeg.

—JERRY TRAUNFELD, THE HERBFARM (WOODINVILLE, WASHINGTON)

SQUASH, BUTTERNUT

(See also **Pumpkin; Squash, Acorn; and Squash, Winter**)

Season: early autumn

Taste: sweet

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: moderate

Techniques: bake, braise, mash, roast, steam, tempura-fry

allspice

anchovies

apples, esp. green

artichokes, Jerusalem

bacon

basil

bay leaf

bourbon

bread crumbs

brown butter

BUTTER, UNSALTED

carrots

cayenne

celery

celery root

CHEESE: Fontina, **goat**, Gruyère, **PARMESAN**, pecorino, **ricotta**, ricotta

salata

chervil

chestnuts

chickpeas

chile peppers, esp. fresh green, jalapeño

chili sauce

chives

cilantro

cinnamon

cloves

coconut milk

coriander

couscous

cream

crème fraîche

cumin

curry: paste (yellow), powder

duck

fenugreek

fish sauce, Thai

garlic

ginger: fresh, ground

honey

Japanese cuisine (e.g., tempura)

leeks

lemon, juice

lemongrass

lime, juice

maple syrup

marjoram

mascarpone

mint

Moroccan cuisine

mushrooms, esp. porcini

nutmeg

nuts

OIL: canola, grapeseed, peanut, **pumpkin seed**, vegetable

olive oil

ONIONS, esp. red

orange, juice

pancetta

parsley, flat-leaf

parsnips

pears

PEPPER: black, white

pork

potatoes

pumpkin seeds
red pepper flakes
risotto
rosemary
SAGE
salsify
SALT: kosher, sea
shallots
shrimp
soups
sour cream
spinach
STOCKS: chicken, vegetable
sugar: brown, white
tarragon
thyme
truffle oil
vanilla
vinegar: balsamic, champagne, sherry
walnuts
watercress
wine: dry white, Vin Santo
yams
yogurt

Flavor Affinities

butternut squash + anchovies + bread crumbs + onions + pasta
butternut squash + bacon + maple syrup + sage
butternut squash + bay leaf + nutmeg
butternut squash + cilantro + coconut + ginger
butternut squash + crème fraîche + nutmeg + sage
butternut squash + ricotta cheese + rosemary
butternut squash + risotto + sage

SQUASH, KABOCHA

(See also Squash, Winter)

Flavor Affinities

kabocha squash + coconut + sweet curry

—DOMINIQUE AND CINDY DUBY, WILD SWEETS (VANCOUVER)

SQUASH, SPAGHETTI

(See also **Squash, Winter**)

Season: early autumn–winter

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate

Techniques: bake, boil, or steam; then sauté

bacon

basil

bell peppers

cheese: feta, Gorgonzola, Parmesan

chicken

chives

duck

garlic

ginger

honey, chestnut

olive oil

olives, black

oregano

parsley, flat-leaf

pasta

pepper, ground

salt

seafood: fish, scallops

tomatoes

vinaigrette

SQUASH, SUMMER

(See also Zucchini)

Season: summer

Weight: light–medium

Volume: quiet–moderate

Techniques: bake, blanch, boil, braise, deep-fry, grill, sauté, steam, stir-fry

basil

bell peppers

butter

cheese: goat, Gruyère, mozzarella, Parmesan

chile peppers: dried red, fresh green

chives

cinnamon

coconut

coriander

corn

cream

cumin

curry leaves

dill

eggplant

garlic

lemon, juice

marjoram

mint

mustard seeds, black

olive oil

onions

oregano

parsley, flat-leaf

pecans

pepper, black

rosemary

sage

salt

sausage, Italian

thyme

tomatoes

turmeric

walnuts

yogurt

SQUASH, WINTER

(See also Pumpkin; Squash, Acorn; and Squash, Butternut)

Season: autumn–winter

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: moderate

Techniques: bake, braise, grill, mash, puree, roast, sauté, steam

allspice

APPLES: cider, fruit, juice

bacon

BUTTER

caraway seeds

cayenne

celery, leaves

cheese: Fontina, Gruyère, Parmesan, pecorino, Romano

chili powder

cinnamon

cloves

coconut milk

coriander

cream

cumin

curry

GARLIC

ginger

honey

lamb

leeks

lemongrass

lime, juice

maple syrup

marjoram

mushrooms

mustard

NUTMEG

nuts

olive oil

ONIONS

orange: juice, zest oregano

paprika, sweet

parsley, flat-leaf

pasta, esp. ravioli

pears

pecans

pork

pumpkin

pumpkin seeds

quince

radicchio

red pepper flakes

risotto

rosemary

SAGE

savory

soups

stocks: chicken, vegetable

SUGAR, BROWN THYME

truffles, white

vinegar, sherry

walnuts

wild rice

Dishes

Red Curry Squash Flan, Orange Jelly, Coconut Emulsion, Sweet Gnocchi, and Curry Gel

—Dominique and Cindy Duby, Wild Sweets (Vancouver)

Roasted Squash Ice Cream, Crispy Pumpkin Seeds, Sage

—Johnny Iuzzini, pastry chef, Jean Georges (New York City)

When **winter squash** is at its peak, it is already sweet, and yet the tendency is to want to reach for the cinnamon or maple syrup to season it. To keep it a savory dish, I'll reach for fresh ginger, which adds a sweet heat.

—**BRADFORD THOMPSON**, MARY ELAINE'S AT THE PHOENICIAN (SCOTTSDALE, ARIZONA)

Flavor Affinities

winter squash + butter + garlic + sage

winter squash + garlic + olive oil + parsley

winter squash + onions + Parmesan cheese + chicken stock

SQUASH BLOSSOMS

(See Zucchini Blossoms)

SQUID

(aka calamari)

Weight: light–medium

Volume: quiet

Techniques: deep-fry, grill, marinate, roast, salad, sauté, stew

aioli

almonds

anchovies

arugula

basil

bay leaf

beans, white

bell peppers: green, red, yellow

butter, unsalted

cabbage: green, red

caperberries

capers

carrots

cayenne

celery

chard

chile peppers, esp. piquillo

chives

chorizo

cilantro

cloves

cornichons

cornmeal (for breading)

couscous, esp. Israeli

currants

GARLIC

ginger

hoisin sauce

honey

ketchup

Italian cuisine

leeks

LEMON, JUICE

lime, juice

lobster

marjoram

mayonnaise

Mediterranean cuisine

melon, esp. cantaloupe, watermelon

oil: grapeseed, peanut (for frying), walnut

OLIVE OIL

olives, esp. black, kalamata

onions, esp. sweet, white

orange, zest

oregano

PARSLEY, FLAT-LEAF

pasta

PEPPER: black, white

pine nuts

polenta

potatoes, new

red pepper flakes

rice: Arborio, bomba

risotto

saffron

salads

SALT: kosher, sea

scallions

scallops

sesame seeds

shallots

shiso

shrimp

soy sauce

squid ink

stock, fish

sugar

Tabasco sauce

tarragon

thyme

tomatoes

VINEGAR: balsamic, red wine, rice wine, sherry, white wine

walnuts

wine, dry white

yuzu juice

zucchini

Dishes

Grilled Squid with Tapioca and Meyer Lemon

—Charlie Trotter, Charlie Trotter's (Chicago)

Flavor Affinities

squid + aioli + anchovies

squid + basil + bell peppers + chiles + garlic + orange + tomatoes + red wine

squid + garlic + lemon + parsley

STAR ANISE
(See Anise, Star)

STEAK
(See Beef)

STRAWBERRIES

Season: late spring–summer

Taste: sweet–sour

Weight: light

Volume: moderate

Techniques: raw, sauté

Tips: Adding sugar enhances strawberry flavor, as does adding an acid such as citrus juice or vinegar.

Dishes

Strawberries in Chianti with Black Pepper Ricotta Cream

—Gina DePalma, pastry chef, Babbo (New York City)

Fresh Strawberry Tart with Orange Curd and Moscato Gelée

—Lissa Doumani, Terra (St. Helena, California)

Citrus-Strawberry Salad, Honey Parfait, and Charentais Melon Puree

—Michael Laiskonis, Le Bernardin (New York City)

Strawberry, Mango, and Basil “Ice Cream Sandwich” and Organic Strawberry Juice

—Michael Laiskonis, Le Bernardin (New York City)

Strawberry-Rhubarb Shortcake with Crème Fraîche Ice Cream

—Patrick O’Connell, The Inn at Little Washington (Washington, Virginia)

I remember asking myself, How can I make a salad into a dessert? The result of my experimentation bore no resemblance to a salad: I used olive oil to make an almond *financier*; because a *financier* is not a *financier* without the brown butter, I substituted olive oil for half the brown butter. I served this with a balsamic vinegar ice cream, and a basil-infused **strawberry** consommé.

A note about the strawberries is that I cooked them on very low heat. It comes from the idea of gentleness, slowness, care, respect for the ingredients, and, in the end, a better-tasting fresh ingredient. I could have extracted more juice from the strawberries by bringing them up to a boil with a bunch of sugar, but that results in cooked strawberries and not the fresh strawberry flavor you’re after.

—MICHAEL LAISKONIS, LE BERNARDIN (NEW YORK CITY)

A tiny bit of vanilla makes **strawberries** yummy! It has to be just a little because you don't want a vanilla-strawberry dessert; you want a strawberry dessert that has a little vanilla on the palate that people have to search for.

—GINA DEPALMA, BABBO (NEW YORK CITY)

You still can't go wrong with a classic. For years I tried to come up with the end-all be-all **strawberry** dessert. Four years ago, I said forget it—the strawberries I get from my purveyor in the farmers' market are perfect. Now, I serve strawberry gelato with lots of strawberries and 25-year-old balsamic vinegar. It became an injustice to try to do anything else with the perfect strawberries I was getting.

—GINA DEPALMA, BABBO (NEW YORK CITY)

almonds

amaretto

apricots, pureed

bananas

berries

biscuit

blackberries

blueberries

boysenberries

brandy

buttermilk

caramel

cardamom

Champagne

Chartreuse

cheese: Queso de los Beyos, ricotta

chocolate: dark, white

cinnamon

cloves

cognac

coriander

***CREAM AND ICE CREAM**

cream cheese

crème de cassis

crème fraîche

crust: pastry, pie

custard

elderflower syrup

gelatin (for texture)

ginger

gooseberries

grapefruit

grapes

grappa

guava

hazelnuts

honey

KIRSCH

kumquats

LEMON: juice, zest

lemon verbena

lime: juice, zest

liqueurs, berry or orange (e.g., Cointreau, **curaçao**, Framboise, **GRAND**

MARNIER

loquats

mangoes

maple syrup

mascarpone

melon

mint (for garnish)

nutmeg

oatmeal

ORANGE: juice, zest

papaya

passion fruit

peaches

peanuts

pecans

pepper, black

pies

pineapple

pine nuts

pistachios

plums

pomegranates

port

RASPBERRIES

***RHUBARB**

rum

sake

sherry

shortcake

SOUR CREAM

***SUGAR:** brown, white

tarts

VANILLA

***VINEGAR, BALSAMIC, ESP. AGED**

walnuts

WINE: RED OR ROSÉ (e.g., **Beaujolais**, Cabernet Sauvignon), **sweet white**
(e.g., Moscato d'Asti, Muscat, Riesling, Sauternes, Vin Santo)

yogurt

zabaglione

Strawberries pair beautifully with Cabernet Sauvignon, and black pepper takes the combination even further.

—LISSA DOUMANI, TERRA (ST. HELENA, CALIFORNIA)

When I taste **strawberries** at the store I close my eyes and ask, Is this a [perfect] strawberry or does this need a little help? If they are a little dry, to help them, you cook them on top of the stove a little and that will release their perfume and juice. You can add Grand Marnier or Kirsch, which will help their flavor as well. If you follow these steps, though, this will lead you to wanting

to serve them warm. If you chill them down, they will not look great. So I would serve a warm berry compote over vanilla ice cream. If you have some berries that aren't perfect, with a little love and attention they'll adapt. In spring, when the strawberries are early and not that good, I'll roast them in the oven with red wine, balsamic vinegar, sugar, corn syrup, and water, and they turn wonderfully jammy.

—EMILY LUCHETTI, FARALLON (SAN FRANCISCO)

I love fresh **strawberries** with dense and dry cow's milk cheeses, such as Queso de los Beyos from Spain. It hits your tongue like dry plaster, then melts, releasing its slightly sour fresh milk flavor. Both also go very well with rosé Champagne.

—ADRIAN MURCIA, CHANTERELLE (NEW YORK CITY)

Strawberries have a rose note to them so I find rose geraniums bring that out. The two have similar flavors.

—JERRY TRAUNFELD, THE HERBFARM (WOODINVILLE, WASHINGTON)



AVOID
salt

Flavor Affinities

strawberries + almonds + cream

strawberries + almonds + olive oil + balsamic vinegar

strawberries + almonds + rhubarb

strawberries + balsamic vinegar + black pepper

strawberries + black pepper + ricotta cheese + red wine

strawberries + Champagne + Grand Marnier

strawberries + rhubarb + sugar

STRIPED BASS
(See Bass, Striped)

STUFFING

Season: autumn–winter

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: quiet–moderate

apples
bread crumbs
butter, unsalted
celery
chestnuts
chicken fat
chicken livers
corn bread
garlic
mushrooms (e.g., shiitakes)
olive oil
onions
parsley, flat-leaf
pecans
pepper: black, white
prosciutto
rosemary
sage
salt, kosher
sausage, esp. chicken, pork
stocks: chicken, turkey
thyme
walnuts

SUGAR

Taste: sweet

Function: cooling

Tips: Balance sweetness with acid (e.g., vinegar) and salt. Avoid dark brown sugar with maple syrup, as the combination is too intense.

SUGAR, PALM

Taste: sweet

Tips: Avoid with lighter dishes, which would be overwhelmed.

coconut

curries

custards

desserts

Indian cuisine

tamarind

Thai cuisine

SUGAR SNAP PEAS

(See Snap Peas)

SUMAC

Taste: sour

Weight: light–medium

Volume: moderate

allspice

avocados

beets

cheese, feta

CHICKEN, ESP. ROASTED

chickpeas

chile peppers

chili powder

coriander

cucumbers

cumin

eggplant

fennel

FISH, ESP. GRILLED

garlic

ginger

kebabs

lamb

Lebanese cuisine

lemon, juice

lentils

lime

meats, esp. grilled

Middle Eastern cuisine mint

Moroccan cuisine

onions

orange

oregano

paprika

parsley
pepper, black
pine nuts
pomegranates
rosemary
salads and salad dressings
salt
seafood
sesame seeds
shellfish
stewed dishes
thyme
tomatoes
Turkish cuisine
vegetables
walnuts
yogurt

Flavor Affinities

sumac + lamb + black pepper
sumac + salt + sesame seeds + thyme (aka Middle Eastern *za'atar*)

We rely a lot on **sumac**, which I love because it is a good way to add another layer of tartness and acidity to a dish without having to add liquid. I could not imagine our beet salad without it. Sumac works well with chicken, vegetables, and salads, as well as in a vinaigrette or with cheeses you might marinate like feta. I avoid it with red meat or steak; I think it is the wrong kind of tartness for them.

—SHARON HAGE, YORK STREET (DALLAS)

Sumac's distinctly sour flavor and reddish-purple color can both lift a dish.

—LISSA DOUMANI, TERRA (ST. HELENA, CALIFORNIA)

If my mind is in the Middle East, I will be reaching for **sumac** or preserved

lemon or yogurt. I use sumac at the very end of the cooking process to enhance the acid already being used in the dish.

—**BRAD FARMERIE**, PUBLIC (NEW YORK CITY)

My favorite fruit to work with is a toss-up between all of the stone fruits [i.e., cherries, plums, apricots, nectarines, and peaches]. Late July, August, and September is my favorite time of year!

—**GINA DEPALMA**, BABBO (NEW YORK CITY)

When I compose a dish, I work with the season—but like to play with that as well. People will ask how we can have braised short ribs on the menu in **summer**. I can, because I play with the other elements of the dish. For example, I pair seared watermelon with my short ribs for a refreshing note. From this base, I add other elements to lighten the dish further. The dish also has watermelon radishes that are bright green on the outside and red on the inside so you get another take on “watermelon on watermelon.” The radish also adds a little heat and freshness to cut the richness of the short ribs. The last note in the dish is feta cheese, which adds overall creaminess and goes back to the combination of watermelon and feta that you see in Greek restaurants.

—**KATSUYA FUKUSHIMA**, MINIBAR (WASHINGTON, DC)

What I like about working with the seasons is that everything that is in season at the same time works together. During the **summer** when you have tomatoes, melon, and basil, you can make a dish with them and it will work. [His menu includes a salad of grilled watermelon with tomatoes, basil, and aged balsamic.] I don’t try to create new combinations of ingredients. I saw the combination of tomatoes and basil everywhere I ever worked. Should I do something different with tomatoes? No—why? The reason everyone serves this combination is because it is amazing! My approach is to find a new way to serve the tomatoes or the basil. I may make a tomato gazpacho and serve it with basil sorbet, or I could serve different preparations of tomatoes on the plate—fresh, a confit, a juice—and then do the same with the basil, serving it as an oil or a puree.

—**DANIEL HUMM**, ELEVEN MADISON PARK (NEW YORK CITY)

Look at the weather and the occasion. You want your dessert to match the style and appropriateness of the meal. If it is a barbecue in the **summer**, I would serve a fruit crisp or pie, summer pudding, or ice cream, and that is pretty much it. People always talk about using fresh and local ingredients, which is very important. But, if you are using chocolate, which is available year-round, and if it is 85 degrees out with 85 percent humidity, the last thing you want is a hot chocolate soufflé. You want chocolate ice cream instead.

—**EMILY LUCHETTI**, FARALLON (SAN FRANCISCO)

Summer vegetables work with summer herbs. In the Northwest, you will see the same set of ingredients in season in the same week every year. So, you just put them together. For example, sockeye salmon comes into season [during the summer] when squash does, and so do the herbs used in a fines herbes mixture. There's your dish!

—**JERRY TRAUNFELD**, THE HERBFARM (WOODINVILLE, WASHINGTON)



SUMMER

Weather: typically hot

Techniques: barbecue, grill, marinate, panfry, pan roast, raw

apricots (peak: June)

basil

beans, fava

beans, green (peak: August)

blackberries (peak: June)

blueberries (peak: July)

boysenberries (peak: June)

cherries

chilled dishes and beverages

corn (peak: July/August)

cucumbers (peak: August)

eggplant

figs (peak: August)

fish

flowers, edible

garlic (peak: August)

grapes

grilled dishes

herbs, cooling (e.g., basil, cilantro, dill, fennel, licorice, marjoram, mint)

ice cream

ices

limes (peak: June)

mangoes

melons (peak: August)

nectarines (peak: July)

okra (peak: August)

onions (peak: August)

onions, red (peak: July)

peaches (peak: July/August)

pears, Bartlett (peak: August)

peppers

picnics

plums (peak: August)

puddings, summer

raspberries (peak: June, August)

raw foods (e.g., salads)

salads: fruit, green, pasta

salsas, fresh

shellfish

sorbets

soups, cold

spices, cooling (e.g., peppercorns, white; turmeric, etc.)

squash, summer

steaming

strawberries

tomatillos (peak: August)

tomatoes

vegetables, green leafy

Vidalia onions (peak: June)

watermelon

zucchini (peak: July)

SUNCHOKES

(See Artichokes, Jerusalem)

SWEDISH CUISINE

allspice
bay leaf
cardamom
cinnamon
cloves

DILL

fish
ginger
herring, pickled
meatballs
mushrooms
mustard
nutmeg
onions
peas
pepper
pickled dishes (e.g., fish, meat, vegetables)
potatoes
shellfish
soups, esp. fruit
sugar

AVOID

garlic
piquancy

Flavor Affinities

beef + bay leaf + dill + nutmeg + onions
herring + sour cream + vinegar
red wine + allspice + cinnamon + cloves + raisins + sugar
veal + allspice + onions

SWEETBREADS

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate

Techniques: braise, deep-fry, grill, pan roast, sauté

artichokes, Jerusalem

asparagus

BACON

butter, unsalted

cabbage

capers

celery

celery root

cream

fennel

fennel seeds

flour (for dredging)

French cuisine

garlic

greens

ham

hazelnuts

honey

Italian cuisine

lemon, juice

liver, esp. duck

Madeira

mushrooms, esp. wild (e.g., chanterelles, morels)

mustard

oil, peanut

olive oil

onions: red, white

parsley, flat-leaf

peas

pecans

PEPPER: black, white

port

raisins

salt: kosher, sea

scallions

shallots

soy sauce

spinach

stock, chicken

sugar

thyme, fresh

truffles, black

vermouth

VINEGAR: balsamic, red, rice, sherry, white

wine, white

In the fall, I use walnut vinegar which is red wine vinegar with macerated walnuts in it. It is great on a **sweetbread** and hazelnut dish.

—ANDREW CARMELLINI, A VOCE (NEW YORK CITY)

Dishes

Sweetbreads, Cauliflower, Burnt Bread, and Toasted Hay

—Grant Achatz, Alinea (Chicago)

Flavor Affinities

sweetbreads + asparagus + morels

sweetbreads + bacon + capers

sweetbreads + bacon + garlic

sweetbreads + bacon + onions + sherry vinegar

sweetbreads + capers + lemon

sweetbreads + celery + truffles, black

sweetbreads + hazelnuts + red wine vinegar + walnuts

sweetbreads + Madeira

sweetbreads + mustard + raisins

SWEETNESS

Taste: sweet

Function: cooling; sweetness satiates the appetite

Tips: The colder the food or drink, the less the perception of sweetness. Sweetness tends to round out flavors, while acidity sharpens them.

At dessert time, you don't have the same philosophy as you do at the beginning of the meal. You don't want people coming back for more—you want to finish them off! Dessert is the easy course, because **sweetness** is easy and obvious. I don't want big structure; the work is done. As long as the apple tastes like apple, you are there! A dessert is about manipulating the sugar in some way to bring out the best of the apple, chocolate, lemon, pecans, or whatever you are working with. From there, you want to balance the sugar with the fat to bring out the best of the star ingredient. I am not a pastry chef, so I try to stick to simple things, like chocolate *pot de crème* and lemon pudding. The key is that, though they may be simple, I always use very good ingredients.

—SHARON HAGE, YORK STREET (DALLAS)

I'm not such a fan of white sugar because it only adds **sweetness** and little sophistication. Maple, honey, or brown sugar add so much more. When making a baba in France, you use only sugar and water. I use molasses because it gives texture and sweetness. In France you use a lot of simple syrup. I like to use orange juice instead of water, and instead of using white sugar, I'll use brown.

—MICHEL RICHARD, CITRONELLE (WASHINGTON, DC)

I love jaggery [the unrefined sugar used in India, also known as palm sugar] because it has a fermented flavor and provides more complexity. Dates can be a primary source of **sweetness** in a dessert instead of sugar, as can vegetables such as beets, carrots, parsnips, and corn, which all have an earthy sweetness. However, I don't want to pound people over the head with a beet sorbet.

—MICHAEL LAISKONIS, LE BERNARDIN (NEW YORK CITY)

apple: cider, fruit, juice
apricots
bananas
barley
basil, sweet
beans
beets
bell peppers: red, yellow
brandies, fruit (e.g., Calvados)
butter
caramel
carrots
cherries, sweet
chestnuts
chocolate: dark, milk, white
clementines
cloves
cocoa, sweetened
coconut and coconut milk
corn
corn syrup
crab
cream
currants
daikon
dates
figs
fruits: dried, ripe
fruit juices
garlic, roasted
ginger, candied
grapes
guava
hoisin sauce
honey
jicama
ketchup

lentils
licorice
liqueurs, sweet
lobster
lotus root
lychee nuts
Madeira
mangoes
maple syrup
melons (e.g., cantaloupe, honeydew)
milk
mirin (Japanese sweetener)
molasses
nectarines
onions: cooked, sweet (e.g., Vidalia)
oranges, sweet (e.g., navel)
papaya
parsnips
passion fruits
peaches
pears
peas and sugar snap peas
persimmons
pimentos
pineapple
plantains, esp. ripe
plums, sweet
plum sauce
pomegranates
potatoes
prunes
pumpkin
raisins
raspberries
rice
roasted foods
sake

scallops, esp. bay

sherry, sweet (e.g., cream, oloroso)

shrimp

squash, winter (e.g., acorn, butternut)

strawberries

sugar: brown, palm, white

sweet potatoes

tangerines

tomatoes

vermouth, sweet

vinegar, balsamic

watermelon

wheat

wines, sweet

Dishes

Sweet Potato, Feta, and Smoked Paprika Tortilla with Minted Lemon Raita

—Brad Farmerie, Public (New York City)

Warm Sweet Potato Cake with Cranberries and Dates

—Johnny Iuzzini, pastry chef, Jean Georges (New York City)

Szechuan Peppercorn and Salt-Roasted Sweet Potato Skewers with Sweet-Hot Mustard Sauce

—Monica Pope, T'afia (Houston)

SWEET POTATOES

Season: autumn–winter

Taste: sweet

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: moderate–loud

Techniques: bake, boil, deep-fry, fry, grill, mash, roast, sauté, steam

allspice

anise

apples and apple juice

bacon

bananas

basil

bay leaf

beans

bell peppers: green, red

bourbon

brandy

BUTTER, unsalted

caramel

cheeses

chestnuts

chile peppers

chives

chocolate, white

cilantro

CINNAMON

cloves

coconut

coriander

cranberries

cream

crème fraîche

cumin

curry powder
custards
dates
dill
duck
figs, dried
fruits and fruit juices
garlic
ginger
greens, bitter
ham
hazelnuts
honey
kale
ketchup
leeks
lemon: juice, zest
lime, juice
liqueurs: nut, orange
maple syrup
meats, esp. roasted
molasses
mushrooms, chanterelle
mustard, esp. Dijon
NUTMEG
oatmeal
oil: nut, peanut, sesame
olive oil
onions, esp. red
ORANGE: juice, zest
paprika, smoked
parsley, flat-leaf
peanuts
pears
pecans
pepper: black, white
persimmons

pineapple
pork
potatoes: new, red
poultry, esp. roasted
prosciutto
pumpkin
pumpkin seeds
raisins
red pepper flakes
rosemary
rum
sage
salt, kosher
sausage: andouille, chorizo
sesame seeds
sour cream
stock, chicken
SUGAR, BROWN
tarragon
thyme
tomatoes
vanilla
vinegar: balsamic, cider
walnuts
whiskey
wine, sweet
Worcestershire sauce
yogurt

Flavor Affinities

sweet potatoes + allspice + cinnamon + ginger
sweet potatoes + apples + sage
sweet potatoes + bacon + onions + rosemary
sweet potatoes + chile peppers + lemon zest
sweet potatoes + chorizo sausage + orange
sweet potatoes + cilantro + lime juice

sweet potatoes + kale + prosciutto

sweet potatoes + maple syrup + pecans

SWISS CHARD
(See Chard)

SWORDFISH

Season: early summer–early autumn

Weight: heavy

Volume: quiet–moderate

Techniques: braise, broil, grill, poach, sauté, sear, steam, stir-fry

apples, esp. Granny Smith

bacon

basil

bay leaf

beans, white

bread crumbs

butter

capers

caponata

carrots

cayenne

celery

chili powder

cilantro

coconut milk

coriander

cream

cumin

currants

curry

fennel

garlic

lemon: juice, zest

lemon, preserved

lemongrass

lime: juice, leaf (kaffir), zest

mint

OIL, corn

olive oil

olives, esp. black

onions, esp. pearl

orange, juice

oregano

parsley, flat-leaf

pepper: black, red

pineapple

pine nuts

pistou

potatoes

red pepper flakes

rosemary

saffron

salt: kosher, sea

scallions

shallots

star anise

stocks: chicken, fish, shrimp

Tabasco sauce

tomatoes and tomato sauce

vinegar, balsamic

wine, dry white

Dishes

Seared Swordfish with Lemon and Caper Shallot Dressing

—David Bouley, Bouley (New York City)

Swordfish with Eggplant Caviar and Teardrop Tomato Salad

—Gabriel Kreuther, The Modern (New York City)

SZECHUAN CUISINE

(See also Chinese Cuisine)

Volume: loud

Techniques: braise, pickle, roast, simmer, steam, stir-fry

bamboo shoots

beef

cabbage, Chinese

chicken

chile peppers

chili paste

duck

garlic

ginger

meats, smoked

peanuts

PORK

soy sauce

***SZECHUAN PEPPER**

tangerine peel, dried

wine, rice

SZECHUAN PEPPER

Taste: sour, hot, pungent

Weight: light–medium

Volume: loud

Tips: Add at the end of the cooking process.

Asian cuisines

beans, black

chicken

chile peppers

Chinese cuisine

curry powder

duck

five-spice powder (key ingredient)

fried dishes

fruits, citrus

game

game birds

garlic

ginger

grilled dishes

honey

lemon

lime

meats, esp. fattier

mushrooms

onions

orange

peppercorns: black, green, white

pork

quail

salt

scallions

sesame: oil, seeds

soy sauce

squid

star anise

stir-fried dishes

Tibetan cuisine

Flavor Affinities

Szechuan pepper + ginger + star anise

TAMARIND

Season: spring–early summer

Taste: sour

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate–loud

Tips: Add at the beginning of the cooking process.

African cuisine

allspice

almonds

Asian cuisines

bananas

beans

beverages, esp. fruit

cabbage

cardamom

Central American cuisine

chicken

chickpeas

chile peppers, esp. Thai

chili powder

Chinese cuisine

chutneys

cilantro

cinnamon

cloves

coconut and coconut milk

coriander

cumin

curries, curry paste, curry powder

dates

duck

fennel seeds

fenugreek

fish

fish sauce

fruits

game

garlic

ginger

greens

honey

INDIAN CUISINE

Indonesian cuisine

Jamaican cuisine

lamb

Latin American cuisine

lentils

lime, juice

mangoes

marinades

meats

Middle Eastern cuisine

mint

mushrooms

mustard

oil, grapeseed

onions, red

orange

paprika

peaches

peanuts

pears

pepper, black

pineapple

pork

potatoes

poultry

rice

sauces

scallops

sea bass
shellfish
shrimp
soups
Southeast Asian cuisine
soy sauce
star anise
stews
sugar: brown, palm, white
Thai basil
Thai cuisine
turmeric
vegetables
vinaigrette
Worcestershire sauce (key ingredient)
yogurt

Flavor Affinities

tamarind + chicken + yogurt

TANGERINES

(see Oranges, Mandarin)

TARRAGON

Season: late spring–summer

Taste: sweet

Weight: light

Volume: loud

Tips: Add at the end of the cooking process.

acidic foods and flavors (e.g., citrus)

anise

apples

apricots

artichokes

asparagus

basil (say some)

bass

bay leaf

beans, green

beef

beets

broccoli

capers

carrots

cauliflower

celery seeds

cheese, esp. goat, ricotta

chervil

***CHICKEN**

chives

chocolate

corn

crab and crab cakes

cream

crème fraîche

dill

EGGS AND EGG DISHES (e.g., omelets), egg salad

fennel bulb

fennel seeds

fines herbes (key ingredient)

FISH

French cuisine

game

game birds

garlic

grapefruit

greens, bitter

halibut

leeks

LEMON, JUICE

lemon herbs (balm, thyme, verbena)

lentils

lettuces (e.g., frisée)

lime

lobster

lovage

marjoram

mayonnaise

meats, white

melon

mint

mushrooms

mussels

mustard: Dijon, Chinese (ingredient and complement)

olive oil

onions

orange, juice

oysters

paprika

PARSLEY

pasta

peaches

peas

pepper, black

Pernod

pork

potatoes

poultry

rabbit

radishes

rice

salads (e.g., fruit, green) and salad dressings

salmon

salsify

saucers, e.g., **BÉARNAISE** (key ingredient), creamy, hollandaise, tartar

savory

scallops

shallots

SHELLFISH

shrimp

sole

soups

sorrel

soy sauce

spinach

squash, summer

steaks

stock, vegetable

stuffings

TOMATOES

veal

vegetables

vinaigrette

VINEGAR, esp. champagne, sherry, white wine

wine, red

zucchini

AVOID

basil (say some)

desserts
oregano
rosemary
sage
savory
sweet dishes

The flavor of **tarragon** is fabulous. You get the flavor of Provence and of fennel... it is wonderful. I use it a lot, but you have to be careful. Most people chop tarragon too thin and it oxidizes before it goes into the dish. You want to just cut it into three pieces, and that's it. Chop, chop, chop—that's it. Otherwise, between the knife and the cutting board, it will oxidize and give the herb a bad taste.

—MICHEL RICHARD, CITRONELLE (WASHINGTON, DC)

I like **tarragon** when it is used in moderation. It is a fairly particular and strong herb, and for that reason it doesn't have the same applications as other herbs. It is good in a lot of things, such as with fish and chicken—and you can't make béarnaise without it!

—DAVID WALTUCK, CHANTERELLE (NEW YORK CITY)

Tarragon is my all-time favorite herb. I like the licorice flavor and the light perfume of the herb. This is an herb that marries well with other flavors. We serve a dish right now of flounder, white corn, and sugar snap peas with tarragon butter that is delicious.

—MARCEL DESAULNIERS, THE TRELLIS (WILLIAMSBURG, VIRGINIA)

Tarragon is best on its own [as opposed to combined with other herbs],... Tarragon works with muskmelon.

—JERRY TRAUNFELD, THE HERBFARM (WOODINVILLE, WASHINGTON)

Flavor Affinities

tarragon + anise + celery seeds

tarragon + chicken + lemon
tarragon + orange + seafood

TECHNIQUES

We believe that food preparation is 60 percent ingredients and 40 percent **technique**.

—DOMINIQUE AND CINDY DUBY, WILD SWEETS (VANCOUVER)

I find it a bit of a nightmare to find quality fruit and vegetables in this country. I think that for this reason **technique** began to be the primary driving force for a new dish.

—HESTON BLUMENTHAL, THE FAT DUCK (ENGLAND)

TEQUILA

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate

chile peppers

cilantro

Cointreau

fruit juice

ginger

grenadine

lemon, juice

LIME, JUICE

MEXICAN CUISINE

orange, juice

pomegranate, juice

sage

salt

sugar

vermouth: dry, sweet

Flavor Affinities

tequila + cilantro + lime

tequila + Cointreau + lime juice + pomegranate juice

tequila + Cointreau + lime juice + sage

tequila + lime juice + salt

TEX-MEX CUISINE

(See Mexican Cuisine, Southwestern Cuisine)

THAI CUISINE

Tips: Authentic Thai cuisine strives for a balance of hot + sour + salty + sweet.

basil, Thai

bell peppers

CHILE PEPPERS

cilantro

coconut

coriander

cumin

curries

fish

fish sauce

garlic

ginger

herbs, fresh

lemongrass

lime

mint

noodles, as in Pad Thai

peanuts

rice

shrimp paste

sugar

turmeric

vegetables

Flavor Affinities

chile peppers + cilantro + coconut milk

chile peppers + curry

chile peppers + curry + fish sauce

chile peppers + curry + peanuts

chile peppers + fish sauce

chile peppers + garlic
chile peppers + peanuts



THYME

Season: early summer

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate–loud

Tips: Add at the beginning of the cooking process; use dried or fresh.

allspice

apples

bacon

basil

BAY LEAF

beans, esp. dried, green

beef

beer

bell peppers

bouquet garni (key ingredient, along with bay leaf, marjoram, parsley)

braised dishes

bread and other baked goods

broccoli

Brussels sprouts

cabbage

caramel

carrots

casseroles

celery

CHEESE: FRESH, GOAT

CHICKEN, esp. roasted

chile peppers

chives

chowders, clam

cloves

cod

coriander

corn

cranberries

curries

dates

dill

eggplant

eggs and egg dishes

fennel

figs

FISH

French cuisine

fruits, dried

game

garlic

Greek cuisine

gumbos

herbes de Provence (ingredient)

honey

Italian cuisine

Jamaican cuisine

jerk seasoning

lamb, esp. grilled, roasted

lavender

leeks

legumes

lemon

lemon verbena

lentils

lovage

marinades

marjoram

MEATS and meat loaf

Mediterranean cuisine

Middle Eastern cuisine

mint

mole sauce

MUSHROOMS

mustard

nutmeg

olive oil

ONIONS

orange

oregano

oysters, esp. stewed

paprika

parsley

parsnips

pasta and pasta sauces

pâtés

pears

peas

pepper

pork, esp. roasted

POTATOES

poultry

rabbit

rice

roasts

ROSEMARY

sage

salads and salad dressings

saucés, esp. rich and/or tomato sauces, red wine

sausages

SAVORY

seafood

SOUPS, esp. vegetable

Spanish cuisine

spinach

STEWES

stocks

stuffings

tarragon

TOMATOES

vegetables, esp. winter

venison

vinaigrettes
wine, red, and red wine sauces
zucchini

Flavor Affinities

thyme + goat cheese + olive oil
thyme + savory

Thyme works well with so many things, especially soups and stews. I can't think of anything that it wouldn't work with if used properly. It is often a supporting-role herb and not the star; it is not an herb that bangs you over the head.

—**DAVID WALTUCK**, CHANTERELLE (NEW YORK CITY)

This is one of those cases where I remember the first time I ever tasted **thyme**. I'd ordered a cup of real clam chowder in Newport, Rhode Island, and found out that fresh thyme was the secret to it being the best I had tasted at the time. I still use thyme in my chowder to this day, though now I use dried thyme. You would have to use a considerable amount of fresh thyme to get the flavor of the dried.

—**MARCEL DESAULNIERS**, THE TRELIS (WILLIAMSBURG, VIRGINIA)

Thyme works well with citrus and honey.

—**GINA DEPALMA**, BABBO (NEW YORK CITY)

In Spanish cooking, **thyme** is used very lightly. You will just toss a sprig in something. You don't want it to be **strong**; it is just a note. I use it when making *escabeche* [marinated poached or fried fish] or when cooking beans.

—**ALEXANDRA RAIJ**, TÍA POL (NEW YORK CITY)

THYME, LEMON
(See Lemon Thyme)

TOFU

Weight: light

Volume: quiet

Techniques: grill, sauté, stir-fry, tempura-fry

asparagus

cabbage, esp. napa

garlic

ginger

Japanese cuisine

miso

mushrooms

noodles, esp. soba, udon

rice, esp. fried

salads and salad dressings

scallions

sesame: oil, seeds

soups

soy sauce

tamari

teriyaki

TOMATILLOS

Season: year-round

Taste: sour

Weight: light–medium

Volume: moderate

avocado

chicken

chile peppers, fresh (e.g., jalapeño, serrano)

cilantro

cucumber

fish

garlic

grilled dishes

guacamole

lime

Mexican cuisine

onions

pork

salsas, esp. green

salt: kosher, sea

scallions

shellfish

shrimp

sour cream

stews

tequila

tomatoes

TOMATOES

Season: summer–early autumn

Taste: sour, sweet

Function: heating

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate

Techniques: bake, broil, confit, fry, grill, raw, roast, sauté, stew

Dishes

Warm Goat Cheese Salad: Vine-Ripe Tomatoes, Frisée, Watercress, and Almond Dressing

—David Bouley, Upstairs (New York City)

Heirloom Tomato Salad, Warm Brin d’Amore (Corsican Sheep’s Milk Cheese), Teammate Coulis, Raspberry Vinegar, Globe Basil

—David Bouley, Upstairs (New York City)

Cherry Tomatoes with Milk-Poached Buffalo Mozzarella, Country Ham, Jalapeño, Purple Basil, and Tomato Water

—Jeffrey Bubben, Vidalia (Washington, DC)

Chilled Gazpacho with Cucumber Relish and Parsley Cream

—Sanford D’Amato, Sanford (Milwaukee)

Chilled Tomato Soup with Watermelon, Ginger Oil, Coconut Cream, and Basil

—Katsuya Fukushima, minibar (Washington, DC)

Summer Vegetable Bread Pudding with Warm Tomato Vinaigrette and Tomato-Basil Salad

—Vitaly Paley, Paley’s Place (Portland, Oregon)

Heirloom Tomato Salad with Crème Fraîche and Herbs

—Alice Waters, Chez Panisse (Berkeley, California)



Tomatoes with watermelon is a simple, refreshing, and perfectly balanced combination. The acidity of the tomatoes is a counterpoint to the sweetness of the watermelon.

—**JOSÉ ANDRÉS**, CAFÉ ATLÁNTICO (WASHINGTON, DC)

A romesco sauce combines some of Spain’s best-loved ingredients: **tomatoes**, peppers, onions, bread, and almonds.

—**JOSÉ ANDRÉS**, CAFÉ ATLÁNTICO (WASHINGTON, DC)

Strattu is a Sicilian **tomato** paste that I’m finishing many dishes with now. It is delicious and very sweet. It looks like red Silly Putty and comes in jars, and doesn’t taste anything like canned tomato paste. I recently used it in a garlic aioli that we served with calamari. It gave the mayonnaise a wonderful color, sweetness, and depth of flavor.

—**ANDREW CARMELLINI**, A VOCE (NEW YORK CITY)

Gazpacho is awesome. As a restaurant chef, I can’t just make gazpacho. I have to do something that you can’t do at home, but that is interesting—and not in a

weird way. We use the ingredients that you would find in gazpacho but instead of using only **tomatoes**, we will use 80 percent strawberries and 20 percent tomatoes. My gazpacho is made up of toasted country bread, cucumber, bell pepper, a little garlic, strawberries, tomatoes, olive oil, and white balsamic vinegar. The dish is then garnished with Hawaiian blue prawns, diced strawberries, and slices of *guanciale* (cured pork jowl), olive oil, basil, and black pepper.

—**DANIEL HUMM**, ELEVEN MADISON PARK (NEW YORK CITY)

My parents had a large garden with almost 120 **tomato** plants. I would go out in the garden and pick a tomato and eat it like an apple. I love heirloom tomato season. I like to serve them with a little salt and pepper, a drizzle of lemon juice or cider vinegar, and a piece of mozzarella cheese. You need to taste your tomatoes before you season them. Yellow tomatoes are pretty sweet, which is why I like to add a little vinegar.

—**GABRIEL KREUTHER**, THE MODERN (NEW YORK CITY)

aioli

allspice

almonds

anchovies

arugula

avocados

***BASIL: lemon, purple**

bay leaf

beans: fava, green

beets

BELL PEPPERS: red, green, yellow

bread, bread crumbs

broccoli

butter, unsalted

capers

carrots

cauliflower

cayenne

celery and celery salt

CHEESE: blue, Cabrales, cheddar, feta, **goat**, **Gorgonzola**, **mozzarella**,
Parmesan, **pecorino**, ricotta, ricotta salata, sheep's milk

chervil

chicken

chickpeas

chile peppers: chipotle, habanero, jalapeño, serrano, and/or dried sweet

chili

chili sauce

chives

cilantro

cinnamon

coconut milk

coriander

corn

crab

cream

cream cheese

cucumbers

cumin

curry

dill

eggplant

eggs

fennel

fennel seeds

fish, esp. poached, grilled

French cuisine

GARLIC

garlic chives

ginger

ham

hazelnuts

honey

horseradish

Italian cuisine

lamb

lavender

leeks

legumes

LEMON: juice, zest

lemon balm

lime, juice

lovage

Madeira

mango

marjoram

mayonnaise

meats

Mediterranean cuisine

melon, esp. cantaloupe, honeydew

Mexican cuisine

mint, esp. spearmint

mushrooms

mustard, esp. whole grain

oil: grapeseed, vegetable

okra

OLIVE OIL

olives: black, niçoise

ONIONS, esp. pearl, red, Spanish, sweet, Vidalia, white, yellow

orange, juice

oregano

paprika, esp. sweet

parsley, flat-leaf

pasta and pasta sauces

peas

PEPPER: black, white

pineapple

pizza

port

raspberries

red pepper flakes

rice

rosemary

saffron

sage

salads, green

SALT: fleur de sel, kosher, sea

sandwiches

saucers

shallots

shellfish

soups

Spanish cuisine

squash

stews

stocks / broths: beef, chicken, vegetable

strawberries

sugar (pinch)

Tabasco sauce

tarragon

THYME

tomato paste

veal

vinaigrettes

VINEGAR: balsamic, raspberry, red wine, rice, sherry, tarragon, white, wine

watermelon

wine: red, rosé, vermouth, white

yogurt

zucchini

Flavor Affinities

tomatoes + avocado + basil + crab

tomatoes + avocado + lemon

tomatoes + basil + chervil + garlic + tarragon

tomatoes + basil + goat cheese

tomatoes + basil + mozzarella cheese + garlic + olive oil + balsamic vinegar

tomatoes + basil + olive oil + orange juice + prosciutto + watermelon

tomatoes + basil + oregano + thyme

tomatoes + basil + ricotta cheese
tomatoes + chile peppers + garlic + onions
tomatoes + fennel + Gorgonzola cheese
tomatoes + garlic chives + lemon basil
tomatoes + horseradish + lemon
tomatoes + olive oil + balsamic vinegar



TROUT

Season: midsummer

Weight: medium

Volume: moderate–loud

Techniques: bake, broil, grill, panfry, pan roast, poach, roast, sauté, steam

almonds

anchovies

apples: cider, fruit

bacon

bay leaf

beans, green

bell peppers, esp. red

bread crumbs

brown butter sauce

butter, unsalted

capers

carrots

cayenne

celery

cheese: manchego, Parmesan

chili powder

corn

crayfish

cream

escarole

fines herbes

garlic

ham, esp. Serrano

leeks

lemon, juice

lentils

mint

mushrooms

oil: canola, peanut
olive oil
onions
oregano
parsley
pine nuts
parsley, flat-leaf
pepper: black, white
potatoes
sage
salt, kosher
sauces, béarnaise
shallots
stock, mushroom
thyme
tomatoes
vinegar, esp. sherry, wine
wine: dry red, white

Flavor Affinities

trout + bacon + lentils + sherry vinegar
trout + capers + lemon

Dishes

Pan-Roasted Trout with Almonds, Brown Butter, and Haricots Verts

—Thomas Keller, Bouchon (Yountville, California)

Smoked Trout with Purslane Salad

—Mario Batali, Babbo (New York City)

TROUT, SMOKED

Taste: salty

Weight: medium

Volume: loud

apples

beans, green

bell pepper, roasted **red**

cayenne

chives

corn

cream

crème fraîche

dill

greens, baby

horseradish

lemon, juice

marjoram

nutmeg

olive oil

pepper: black, white

purslane

radishes

salt, sea

sour cream

walnut oil

wine, white (e.g., Riesling)

Flavor Affinities

smoked trout + apples + horseradish

smoked trout + crème fraîche + dill

smoked trout + horseradish + lemon juice + olive oil + purslane

TRUFFLES, BLACK

Season: winter

Weight: light

Volume: loud (in a subtle way!)

Techniques: shave

bacon

beef

cauliflower

chicken

cod

eggs: chicken, quail

foie gras

French cuisine

langoustines

lemon, juice

mushrooms (e.g., cepes, morels)

olive oil

pears

potatoes

rabbit

scallops

shellfish

stock, chicken

tarragon

vinegar, balsamic

TRUFFLES, PACIFIC NORTHWEST

Season: autumn

Weight: light

Volume: moderate–loud (in a subtle way!)

beef, esp. with black truffles

butter

celery root

crab, esp. with white truffles

eggs

game birds, esp. with black truffles

leeks, melted, esp. with black truffles

meats, red, esp. with black truffles

pasta, esp. with white truffles

potatoes, esp. with white truffles

salads, esp. with white truffles

seafood, esp. with white truffles

shellfish, esp. with white truffles

vegetables, root, esp. with white truffles

Jerry Traunfeld of Woodinville, Washington's The Herbfarm on Pacific Northwest Truffles

Northwest truffles are very good for what they are. What they are *not* is French or Italian truffles, which are stronger. Northwest truffles pair really well with celery root puree. We serve a ravioli filled with celery root and an egg yolk. The egg yolk is raw when the ravioli is cooked; when it is served, the dish is topped with butter and shaved truffle.

The white truffles are milder than the black. I especially like the white truffles with seafood such as shellfish, especially crab. They also work with root vegetables and potatoes.

The black truffles are a little funkier, and work with red meats and game birds.

We like to prepare melted leeks, which are leeks cooked in water until they are incredibly soft, which then get a shaving of black truffle and are served with wagu beef.

TRUFFLES, WHITE

(and White Truffle Oil) (See also Oil, Truffle)

Season: autumn

Weight: light

Volume: loud (in a subtle way!)

Techniques: shave

Tips: Shave over dishes at the last minute.

Dishes

Pappardelle with Butter, Parmesan, and White Truffles

—Mario Batali, Babbo (New York City)

Homemade Yolk-Filled Ravioli in Truffle Butter

—Odette Fada, San Domenico (New York City)

artichokes, Jerusalem

butter

cheese, Parmesan

cream / milk

eggs

Italian cuisine

onions

pasta

pears

pepper

potatoes

prosciutto

risotto

salt

thyme

I really look forward to **truffle** season. I love a poached egg with truffle, or a truffle salad. A truffle needs to be the central component and the dish needs to be simple. One of my favorite dishes is Jerusalem artichokes with a poached egg and shaved white truffle. We serve this in a [mason] jar that clamps on the side, and when you pop it open you get a burst of truffle aroma.

—GABRIEL KREUTHER, THE MODERN (NEW YORK CITY)

When you have a nice ripe **truffle**, it will have a sweet, fruity pear smell to it. I mix pear and truffle together to make a little salad. I make a sauce with chicken stock, olive oil, and add little bits of tarragon, then serve it with langoustine, which is a very sweet shellfish.

—GABRIEL KREUTHER, THE MODERN (NEW YORK CITY)

Flavor Affinities

truffles + eggs + pasta

TUNA

Season: summer–autumn

Weight: heavy

Volume: moderate

Techniques: braise, broil, grill, poach, raw (e.g., sushi, tartare), sauté, sear, steam, stir-fry

Dishes

Marinated Yellowfin Tuna with Anchovy Dressing: Quail Egg, Haricots, and Fried Panelleria Capers

—Daniel Boulud, Daniel (New York City)

Spicy Tuna Tartare with Cured Lemon, Harissa, Cucumber Yogurt

—Daniel Boulud/Bertrand Chemel, Café Boulud (New York City)

Tuna Marinato with Zucchini, Gaeta Olives, and Orange

—Andrew Carmellini, A Voce (New York City)

Grilled Rare Marinated Tuna with Cumin Wafers and Cilantro Dressing

—Sanford D’Amato, Sanford (Milwaukee)

Signature Sushi: Tuna with Roasted Almond, Kalamata Olive, Foie Gras, or Italian Black Truffle

—Kaz Okochi, Kaz Sushi Bistro (Washington, DC)

Grilled Tuna with Wasabi and Pickled Ginger

—Chris Schlesinger, East Coast Grill (Cambridge, Massachusetts)

Toasted Cumin and Tangerine Seared Rare Tuna: Wasabi Mash Potato, Green Papaya Slaw, Pineapple-Ginger Nage

—Allen Susser, Chef Allen’s (Aventura, Florida)

Japanese Hamachi with Roasted Bell Pepper, Kalamata Olive Sorbet, Spanish Paprika, and Basil Oil

—Charlie Trotter, Charlie Trotter’s (Chicago)

Bluefin Tuna with Spicy Miso

—Charlie Trotter, Charlie Trotter's (Chicago)



aioli

anchovies

arugula

asparagus

avocado

bacon

basil

bass, black

bay leaf

beans: black, fava, green, white

beets

bell peppers, esp. green, red, yellow

butter, unsalted

cabbage, green

capers

caponata

carrots

caviar

cayenne

celery

chervil

CHILE PEPPERS: dried or fresh, esp. green (e.g., jalapeño, Thai)

chili oil

chili sauce

CHIVES

CILANTRO

coconut milk

cognac

coriander

corn

cornichons

cucumbers

cumin

curry

daikon

dashi

dill

eggs (e.g., hard-boiled)

fennel

fennel pollen

fennel seeds

fish sauce, Thai

frisée

GARLIC

GINGER: pickled, fresh, juice

honey

jicama

leeks

LEMON: juice, zest

lettuce, red oak

LIME, juice

mayonnaise

mint, esp. spearmint

mirepoix

mirin

miso, sweet

mizuna

mushrooms: cultivated, shiitakes

mustard: Dijon, seeds

nectarines

noodles: angel hair, vermicelli, rice

nori

OIL: canola, grapeseed, peanut, sesame, vegetable

olive oil

olives, esp. black, kalamata, niçoise

ONIONS: green, pearl, red, Spanish, spring

orange, blood or regular, juice

pancetta

paprika

PARSLEY, flat-leaf

passion fruit

pasta

PEPPER: black, green, white

pine nuts

potatoes

prosciutto

radicchio

radishes

rice

rosemary

sage

sake

SALT: kosher, sea

SCALLIONS

scallops

SESAME: oil, seeds

shallots

shiso

SOY SAUCE

spinach

stock, chicken

sugar

sweet potatoes

Tabasco sauce

tahini

tarragon

THYME

TOMATOES, tomato juice, tomato paste

veal and veal cheeks

vinaigrette

VINEGAR: balsamic, champagne, red wine, rice wine, sherry, white wine

vodka

wasabi

watercress

wine: dry red (Grenache, Pinot Noir, Syrah), rosé

yuzu: juice, rind

One dish that we always make the same is **bluefin tuna** over braised veal cheeks. It is our take on *vitello tunato*. This dish has to be made with bluefin because it is meatlike and gets seasoned like meat. The fish is cooked rare and served with a little *tunato* sauce and arugula.

—**SHARON HAGE**, YORK STREET (DALLAS)

Flavor Affinities

tuna + aioli + capers + tomatoes

tuna + anchovies + green beans + olives + potatoes

tuna + arugula + bacon

tuna + avocado + ginger + radish

tuna + avocado + lemon + soy sauce

tuna + beets + lemon

tuna + black pepper + cilantro + cucumber + soy sauce

tuna + cilantro + cumin

tuna + cilantro + dill + garlic + mint

tuna + cilantro + dill + mint

tuna + cucumber + ginger + miso + shiso

tuna + fennel + fennel pollen

tuna + ginger + mustard

tuna + ginger + vinaigrette

tuna + jalapeño chile + cilantro + ginger + sesame oil + shallots + soy sauce

tuna + lemon + olive oil + tomatoes + watercress

tuna + sesame + wasabi

TURBOT

Weight: medium

Volume: quiet–moderate

Techniques: bake, broil, grill, poach, roast, sauté, steam

asparagus

butter, unsalted

Champagne

chervil

chives

crème fraîche

fennel

garlic

ginger

hollandaise sauce

leeks

lemon: juice, zest

marjoram

miso

mushrooms

olive oil

parsley, flat-leaf

pepper: black, white

potatoes, esp. red, white

rosemary

saffron

sage

salt, sea

shallots

spinach

stocks: fish, mussel

tarragon

tomatoes

vanilla

wine: Champagne, white

Flavor Affinities

turbot + butter + lemon + marjoram

turbot + caviar + Champagne

turbot + lemon + miso + mushrooms

When I create a dish, I start with the fish and ask, What is the inspiration of the moment? I will choose a culture and start there. For a recent dish, I was in a Japanese mood and wanted something light and refined. I used a piece of **turbot** and paired it with miso and mushroom broth. The mushrooms don't relate so much to the culture but the miso definitely does. I created a lemon miso paste with white miso and lemon confit. The fish would sit on the paste and at the last second the waiter would add the mushroom broth. If you add the broth too soon, the miso kills the mushroom flavors.

—**ERIC RIPERT**, LE BERNARDIN (NEW YORK CITY)

Turbot is a beautiful, delicate fish that calls to mind special occasions and celebrations. It poaches well, and takes on richer garnishes such as caviar or truffles.

—**BRADFORD THOMPSON**, MARY ELAINE'S AT THE PHOENICIAN (SCOTTSDALE, ARIZONA)

When you get in fresh **turbot**, you automatically think of pairing it with delicate flavors. It is like looking at the Queen of England: You look at it with unbelievable respect, and there is no way you are going to overload this delicate piece of fish. I like turbot with a nage with periwinkles, chervil, and parsley puree. Or I'll make it with tiny pearl onions with a drizzle of red wine reduction made from the bones of the turbot.

—**CARRIE NAHABEDIAN**, NAHA (CHICAGO)

Dishes

Steamed Turbot with Osetra Caviar in Champagne Sauce

—David Bouley, Danube (New York City)

TURKEY

Season: summer–autumn

Weight: medium

Volume: quiet

Techniques: braise, grill, poach, roast, sauté, stir-fry

allspice

apples

bacon

bay leaf

bread crumbs

butter, unsalted

cardamom

carrots

celery

cheese: white sheep or goat's milk (similar to feta)

chestnuts

chile peppers: dried red (esp. sweet); fresh green

cinnamon

cloves

corn bread

cranberries

cumin

fenugreek leaves

figs, dried

garam masala

garlic

ginger

grapes, white

innards: turkey heart, liver

juniper berries

leeks

lemon, juice

lime, juice

mushrooms, esp. wild (e.g., chanterelles)

oil: canola, grapeseed, peanut, vegetable

olive oil

onions, esp. sweet, white

orange, juice

paprika

parsnips

parsley, flat-leaf

pepper: black, white

phyllo dough

pine nuts

potatoes

raisins, esp. yellow

rosemary

sage

salt, kosher

sausage, esp. Italian

shallots

soy sauce

spinach

stocks: chicken, turkey

stuffing

sugar

tarragon

thyme

tomatoes

vermouth, dry

walnuts

wine, dry white, rosé

yogurt

TURKISH CUISINE

beef
chicken
cinnamon, esp. in desserts
cloves, esp. in desserts
cumin
dill
eggplant
fish
garlic
goat / sheep cheese
honey, esp. in desserts
kebabs, meat, esp. lamb
lamb, esp. grilled
lemon
mint: dried, fresh
nutmeg, esp. in desserts
olive oil
onions
paprika
parsley
pepper, black
phyllo dough
rice
sesame seeds
spinach
tomatoes
walnuts
yogurt

Flavor Affinities

chicken + garlic + paprika + parsley
cumin + lemon + parsley
eggplant + garlic + meat + onions + tomatoes

fish + dill + lemon + black pepper

lamb + cumin + dill + mint

TURMERIC

Season: year-round

Taste: bittersweet; pungent

Function: heating

Weight: light–medium

Volume: medium

Asian cuisine

beans

beef

butter

Caribbean cuisine

cheese

chicken

chile peppers

chutneys

cilantro

cloves

coconut milk

coriander

cumin

***CURRY LEAVES, POWDER**

eggplant

eggs

fennel

fish

garlic

ginger

Indian cuisine

Indonesian cuisine

kaffir lime, leaves

lamb

lemongrass

lentils

meats, esp. white

Middle Eastern cuisine

Moroccan cuisine

mustard

mustard seeds

North African cuisine

paella

paprika

parsley

pepper

pickles

pork

potatoes

poultry

ras el hanout (key ingredient)

rice

saucers, esp. creamy

sausage

seafood

shallots

shellfish

shrimp

soups

Southeast Asian cuisine

spinach

stewed dishes

tamarind

Thai cuisine

vegetables, esp. root

yogurt

Fresh **turmeric** gives you fruitiness and upfront flavor, plus a touch of acid that perks up a dish. If you add fresh turmeric to your curry, you will make a world of difference. When you smell the powdered stuff, it smells like nothing. Dried turmeric hurts me. It hurts the soul. It is really not what turmeric is. Unfortunately, frozen turmeric isn't a good substitute, either. You have to use it

fresh.

—**BRAD FARMERIE**, PUBLIC (NEW YORK CITY)

Turmeric is always the first spice I add to a curry, like the primer on a canvas. The amount of turmeric controls the entire path that curry will take. I cook in layers of flavor, so only when I am happy with the aroma of one layer will I then add ingredients to create the next layer. If I am making curry, the pan will have onions, garlic, and tomatoes, and then the very first thing to go in is the turmeric. If I use a lot of turmeric, it's destined to be a richer-spiced curry, as I'll also have to put in more of all the other spices to balance the flavors.

—**MEERU DHALWALA**, VIJ'S (VANCOUVER)

Flavor Affinities

turmeric + cilantro + cumin + garlic + onion + paprika + parsley + pepper
(Moroccan chermoula)

turmeric + coriander + cumin (Indian cuisine)

TURNIP GREENS
(See Greens, Turnip)

TURNIPS

Season: year-round

Taste: sweet

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: moderate–loud

Techniques: boil, braise, deep-fry, roast, simmer, steam

bacon

bay leaf

butter, unsalted

carrots

celery root

cheese, Parmesan

cream

curry

dill

duck, esp. roasted

garlic

honey

juniper berries

lamb

leeks

lemon, juice

marjoram

nutmeg

onions, esp. green, yellow

parsley

pepper: black, white

poppy seeds

pork, esp. roasted

potatoes

prosciutto

salt: kosher, rock, sea

shiso

stock, chicken

sugar (pinch)

sweet potatoes

thyme

vinegar

UMAMI

Taste: savory or savory + salty

aged foods (e.g., cheese)
anchovies
beef, esp. aged
bonito flakes
broccoli
carrots
cheese, aged (e.g., blue, Gruyère, Parmesan, Roquefort)
chicken
clams
cured foods
fermented foods
fish sauce, Asian
grapefruit
grapes
ketchup
lobster
mackerel
meats
miso
mushrooms, esp. shiitake
oysters
pork
potatoes
ripe ingredients
sardines
sauces, meat-based
scallops
seafood
seaweed, dried
soy beans
soy sauce

squid
steaks, esp. dry-aged, grilled
stocks, meat-based
sweet potatoes
tea, green
tomatoes and tomato sauce
truffles
tuna
vinegar, balsamic
walnuts

VANILLA

Taste: sweet

Weight: medium

Volume: quiet

allspice

almonds

apples

apricots

BAKED GOODS, e.g., cakes, cookies

bay leaf

beans, black

beef

berries

beverages (e.g., eggnog, soft drinks)

brown butter

butter

butterscotch

cakes

candies

caramel

cardamom

cheese, ricotta

chicken

chiles

CHOCOLATE

cilantro

cinnamon

cloves

coconut

COFFEE

cookies

CREAM AND ICE CREAM cream cheese

custards

DESSERTS

eggs

figs

fish

fruits, esp. poached

ginger

honey

***ICE CREAM**

lamb

lavender

lemon: juice, zest

lemongrass

lobster

mascarpone

meats

melon

Mexican cuisine

milk

mint

mussels

nutmeg

nuts

orange

peaches

pears

plums

pork

puddings

rhubarb

rice

rosemary

saffron

salads, fruit

scallops

seafood

seeds: poppy, sesame

shellfish

soups

stocks

strawberries

SUGAR

tamarind

tea

tomatoes

vegetables (e.g., root)

vinegar, balsamic

whiskey

wine, Champagne

yogurt

Dishes

Vanilla Bean Bavarese with Brown Butter and Laurel

—Gina DePalma, pastry chef, Babbo (New York City)

Vanilla Bean Pain Perdu with Mascarpone Custard, Tondo Balsamic Syrup, Strawberries

—Emily Luchetti, pastry chef, Farallon (San Francisco)

I always overlooked **vanilla** when I was growing up. After I made my first vanilla ice cream, however, it was no longer just “the white one”! I like the nuances that different kinds of vanilla offer. Working at Le Bernardin where quality is paramount, for our ice cream it has to be Tahitian. When vanilla is the star, this is the bean you choose. It has an interesting woody, cherrylike flavor to it that I just love. Bourbon vanilla is a great workhorse bean that does well in a supporting role.

—MICHAEL LAISKONIS, LE BERNARDIN (NEW YORK CITY)

If I poach a pear, I will always add **vanilla**. Vanilla also pairs really well with sweet herbs, especially tarragon and bay leaf.

—GINA DEPALMA, BABBO (NEW YORK CITY)

So many dessert recipes call for **vanilla** that it is like salt for dessert. But sometimes it doesn't have a place and can muck up things. Vanilla should be the star of the show. I love vanilla in dairy desserts. I do a vanilla bean Bavarese (an Italian Bavarian cream) that I serve with brown butter and bay leaf. Vanilla and fresh bay leaf bring each other alive, it is a fantastic combination. Bay leaf is very sweet; it is like a truffle in that it is more about the aroma than the flavor.

—GINA DEPALMA, BABBO (NEW YORK CITY)

Flavor Affinities

vanilla + almonds + cream + whiskey

vanilla + bay leaf + brown butter

vanilla + chicken + cream

VEAL—IN GENERAL

Season: spring

Weight: light–medium

Volume: quiet

Techniques: braise (shanks), pan roast (chops), roast, stew (breast, shoulder)

almonds

anchovies

apples

asparagus

basil

bay leaf

beans, esp. flageolets, haricots verts

beef, short ribs

beets

bell peppers: green, red, yellow

brandy

bread and bread crumbs

butter, unsalted

capers

caraway seeds

carrots

celery

celery root

cheese: Emmental, Gruyère, Parmesan, Swiss

chervil

chile peppers

chives

cider

coconut milk

cream

crème fraîche

cucumbers, sautéed

dill

eggs, esp. hard-boiled

French cuisine

GARLIC

gremolata

ham: smoked, hock

hazelnuts

Italian cuisine

leeks

LEMON: juice, zest

lemon verbena

lime: juice, leaves

Madeira

marjoram

milk

MUSHROOMS: button, chanterelle, morels, oyster, porcini, shiitake, white, wild

mustard, Dijon

nutmeg

OIL: canola, corn, peanut, vegetable

olive oil

olives, black

ONIONS, esp. pearl, sweet, white

orange: juice, zest

parsley, flat-leaf

parsnips

pasta, esp. fettuccine

peas, spring

PEPPER: black, white

polenta

potatoes

prosciutto

rice

rosemary

sage

SALT: kosher, sea

shallots

spaetzle

spinach

STOCKS: beef, chicken, veal, vegetable

tarragon

thyme

TOMATOES: canned, paste, plum, sauce

truffles

tuna

turnips

vanilla

vinegar: balsamic, champagne

watercress

WINE, DRY WHITE

zucchini

Flavor Affinities

veal + asparagus + morels

veal + basil + lemon

veal + capers + lemon

veal + cream + mushrooms

veal + cucumber + mustard

veal + garlic + Parmesan cheese + tomatoes

veal + gremolata + orange

veal + Marsala wine + mushrooms

veal + orange + polenta

veal + prosciutto + sage

VEAL—BREAST

Techniques: braise, grill, roast

beans, white

cheese, Fontina

garlic

olive oil

onions, esp. Spanish

pancetta

parsley, flat-leaf

rosemary

stock, chicken

thyme

wine, white

VEAL—CHEEKS

When we make **veal cheek** osso buco on polenta, each dish gets a squeeze of orange and orange zest on it.

—ANDREW CARMELLINI, A VOCE (NEW YORK CITY)

VEAL—CHOP

Techniques: braise, grill, pan roast, sauté, stuff

artichokes

basil

beans, esp. fava

broccoli rabe

butter

Campari

capers

chives

cilantro

coriander

garlic

ginger

gnocchi

leeks

lemon, juice

Madeira

marjoram

mint

mirin

miso

mushrooms (e.g., black trumpet)

mushrooms, wild, esp. chanterelle, porcini

mustard, Dijon

olive oil

olives: black, kalamata

onions

parsley, flat-leaf

peas

pepper, white

pine nuts

polenta

potatoes
prosciutto
radishes
red pepper flakes
salt
sesame: oil, seeds
shallots
soy sauce
stock, chicken
sugar, brown
thyme
tomatoes, sun-dried
watercress
wine, dry white

Dishes

“San Angelo” Veal Rib Chop with “Texas Grits” and Saffron Aioli

—Monica Pope, T’afia (Houston)

Ericassee de Veau Printanière: Savory Veal Stew with English Peas, Asparagus, Morels, and Spring Vegetables

—Michael Romano, at the 2005 James Beard Awards gala reception

Sautéed Wisconsin Veal Chop, White Polenta, Wild Mushrooms

—Jean Joho, Everest (Chicago)

Veal Chop with Truffled Leek Pierogies, Roasted Spring Onion, Creamed Spinach, and Chive Crème Fraîche

—Peter Nowakoski, Rat’s (Hamilton, New Jersey)

Organic Veal Chop with Madeira Sauce and Truffled “Macaroni and Cheese”

—David Waltuck, Chanterelle (New York City)

Flavor Affinities

veal chop + artichokes + basil

veal chop + celery root + cream + Dijon mustard

veal chop + garlic + chanterelle mushrooms

veal chop + leeks + peas

veal chop + leeks + polenta

veal chop + mushrooms + watercress

VEAL—LOIN

Techniques: braise, grill, pan roast, roast, sauté

arugula

basil

cheese, Fontina

chestnuts

cider, apple

citrus

cranberries

garlic

mushrooms, wild (e.g., chanterelles, morels)

nuts (e.g., almonds, hazelnuts, pine nuts, pistachios)

onions

oregano

pasta

pumpkin

risotto

rosemary

sage

stock, veal

tarragon

thyme

tomatoes

wine, red

VEAL—SHANKS

Techniques: braise

bay leaf

carrots

celery

cilantro

cinnamon

cumin

garlic

gremolata

horseradish

lemon: juice, **zest**

marjoram

mushrooms, porcini

olive oil

olives

onions, esp. red, white

oranges

osso buco (ingredient)

parsley

pepper

pine nuts

raisins, yellow

risotto

rosemary

salt

stocks: chicken, veal

thyme

tomatoes: paste, sauce

truffles, white

WINE, WHITE

Flavor Affinities

veal shanks + capers + gremolata + olives

veal shanks + lemon + olives

veal shanks + onions + tomatoes

veal shanks + tomatoes + thyme

Dishes

Grilled Veal Loin Medallions on Pumpkin Fettuccine

—Marcel Desaulniers, The Trellis (Williamsburg, Virginia)

Pan-Seared Tenderloin of Veal with Wild Morel Mushrooms, Local Asparagus, and Raviolis of Virginia Country Ham and Fontina Cheese

—Patrick O’Connell, The Inn at Little Washington (Washington, Virginia)

Roasted Veal Loin with Caramelized Onions, Almonds, Pine Nuts, and Pistachios

—Charlie Trotter, Charlie Trotter’s (Chicago)

VEAL—TENDERLOIN

Techniques: braise, grill, sauté, sear

asparagus
bacon
basil
capers
cheese, Fontina
cream
ham
mushrooms, morel
mustard, Dijon
onions, red
sage
tarragon
thyme
truffle oil
wine, white

Flavor Affinities

veal tenderloin + asparagus + morel mushrooms
veal tenderloin + cream + morel mushrooms
veal tenderloin + garlic + pancetta

VEGETABLES

(See specific vegetables)

Tips: Onion enhances the flavor of vegetables, and brings out their sweetness.

All year long, I make a *pistou* [a **vegetable** soup seasoned with basil, garlic, and olive oil]. However, it changes not only by the season, but by the week. In the spring, I'll add peas. In the summer, it will have zucchini and basil. In the fall, I'll add salsify, scallions, and leeks, and in the winter, broccoli and even soybeans along with parsley.

—**DAN BARBER**, BLUE HILL AT STONE BARNS (POCANTICO HILLS, NEW YORK)

VEGETABLES, ROOT

(See specific root vegetables, e.g., Carrots)

Techniques: roast

Root vegetables are so sweet and full of sugar in the fall. Fall and winter vegetables thrive on cold and frost. The plant's water converts to sugar and when it is picked you have a really sweet vegetable. A root vegetable, like a sweet carrot or parsnip, is similar in sweetness to fruit, so you can put the two in a salad and they will go well together.

—**DAN BARBER**, BLUE HILL AT STONE BARNS (POCANTICO HILLS, NEW YORK)

VEGETARIAN DISHES

Tips: To add a deep, meaty flavor to vegetarian dishes—without adding meat—try:

chile peppers, chipotle—use adobo sauce from canned chiles
liquid smoke
miso
mushrooms
onions, roasted
paprika, smoked
shallots, roasted
soy sauce



VENISON

(See also **Game—In General**)

Season: autumn

Weight: heavy

Volume: moderate–loud

Techniques: braise, broil, grill, roast, sauté

Because **venison** doesn't have much fat, you need to be careful how you cut its richness. I will use chutney that has nice fruit acids with the addition of a little vinegar.

—**BRAD FARMERIE**, PUBLIC (NEW YORK CITY)

We offer **venison** medallions with huckleberry sauce and glazed pears. Venison is a pretty sweet meat. Huckleberries are found in the woods and pears are autumnal. The pears are poached with star anise and cinnamon, and then they are roasted to caramelize them a little, which adds extra depth to them and to the dish.

—**GABRIEL KREUTHER**, THE MODERN (NEW YORK CITY)

One of my favorite dishes is medallions of ranch **venison**, huckleberries, roasted chestnuts and Brussels sprouts, celery root, and Honeycrisp applesauce. I love a sweet flavor with venison. A traditional marinade is with vinegar, red wine, herbs, and juniper berries. A natural pairing would be roasted pears or apples.

—**CARRIE NAHABEDIAN**, NAHA (CHICAGO)

Dishes

New Zealand Venison Crusted in Pink Peppercorns: Jerusalem Artichoke and Young Garlic Confit, Roasted Brussels Sprout Leaves

—David Bouley, Bouley (New York City)

Shiitake-Crusted New Zealand Venison Loin, Peppered Spinach, Sweet Potato Dauphinoise, and Sour Cherry Compote

—Brad Farmerie, Public (New York City)

Smoked New Zealand Venison Carpaccio with Licorice Pickled Onions

—Brad Farmerie, Monday Room (New York City)

Medallions of Ranch Venison with Huckleberries, Roasted Chestnuts and Brussels Sprouts, Celery Root, and Honeycrisp Applesauce

—Carrie Nahabedian, Naha (Chicago)

Venison Medallions, Grilled Grits, and Green Peach Relish with Okra and Tomato

—Frank Stitt, Highlands Bar and Grill (Birmingham, Alabama)

Millbrook Farm Venison Loin with Kohlrabi, White Runner Beans, Pickled Garlic, and Spiced Dates

—Charlie Trotter, Charlie Trotter's (Chicago)

American cuisine

apples

artichoke, Jerusalem

bacon

bay leaf

beets

bourbon

brandy

Brussels sprouts

butter, unsalted

cabbage, red

cardamom

carrots

celery

cheese, Asiago

cherries, dried or fresh, esp. black

chervil

chestnuts

chiles

chives

cinnamon

cloves

cognac

coriander

corn

cranberries

cream

currants, dried or fresh, esp. red

curries and curry powder

fennel

garlic

gin

ginger: grated, ground, minced

greens: arugula, chicory, dandelion, mâche, radicchio, spinach

honey

horseradish

huckleberries

JUNIPER BERRIES

lemon, juice

lemongrass

lime, juice

Marsala

mirepoix

mushrooms: button, porcini, shiitake, **wild**

mustard

nectarines

nutmeg

nuts: almonds, cashews

oil: canola, grapeseed, peanut, walnut

olive oil

ONIONS

orange: juice, zest

pancetta

parsley, flat-leaf

parsnips

peaches

PEARS

PEPPER: black, green, pink, Szechuan, white

pineapple

pomegranate

port

potatoes

pumpkin

raisins

rosemary

sage

salt, kosher

savory

shallots

soy sauce

spinach

squash: acorn, butternut

star anise

STOCKS: beef, chicken, venison sweet potatoes

thyme

tomatoes and tomato paste

turnips, esp. yellow

vinegar: balsamic, red wine, rice, sherry

watercress

WINE: red (e.g., Cabernet Sauvignon), dry white

Flavor Affinities

venison + curry + pomegranate seeds

venison + garlic + juniper berries + rosemary

venison + garlic + peppercorns

venison + garlic + rosemary + tomatoes + red wine

venison + parsnips + pepper

venison + pears + rosemary

VERJUS

Taste: sour–sweet

Tips: Use instead of vinegar or lemon juice, or as a seasoning. *Verjus* is often more wine friendly than vinegar.

apples
apricots
asparagus
berries
cheese, goat
chicken
cranberries
cucumbers
fennel
fish (e.g., halibut, salmon, tuna)

foie gras

FRUIT

garlic
ginger
herbs (e.g., dill, mint, thyme)
lamb
lettuces
marinades
meat
melon
mustard, Dijon
olive oil
onions
pears
pomegranate
pork
poultry
quail
quince

rabbit

SALADS: FRUIT, GREEN

sauc

shellfish (e.g., crab, scallops, shrimp)

soups

soy sauce

spinach

strawberries

sugar: brown, white

tuna

vegetables

vinegar, rice wine

VIETNAMESE CUISINE

basil, Thai

bean sprouts

beef, in soup (*pho*)

chicken

chile peppers

cilantro

cucumbers

fish

fish sauce

garlic

ginger

lemon

lemongrass

lettuce

lime

milk, sweetened condensed (e.g., in coffee)

mint

noodles

pork

raw foods

rice

scallions

shallots

shellfish

shrimp

star anise

sugar

Flavor Affinities

chile peppers + fish sauce + lemon

fish sauce + herbs

fish sauce + lemon

VINEGAR—IN GENERAL

I use a variety of **vinegars** and right now I am using cider vinegar, balsamic, and white balsamic. What vinegar you grab really depends on how far you can push the product. When we make a walnut sauce, it can handle a good-sized dash of cider vinegar. In a fluke tartare, we'll only use a drop of vinegar.

—MICHAEL ANTHONY, GRAMERCY TAVERN (NEW YORK CITY)

VINEGAR, BALSAMIC

Taste: sour, sweet

Weight: medium–heavy (depending on age)

Volume: moderate–loud

Tips: Use when you want a sweet, low-acid vinegar.

Add at end of cooking (and never boil!) or use to finish a dish.

apricots

arugula

basil

beans, green

bell peppers: green, red

berries, esp. strawberries

brown butter

cabbage

cheese, Parmesan

cherries

chicken

chicory

eggplant

endive

fish, esp. white

fruit

greens, salad

grilled dishes

hazelnut oil

honey

Italian cuisine

marinades

meats

mustard, esp. Dijon

mustard: dry, seeds

oil

onions

pepper, black

radicchio

raspberries

SALADS AND SALAD DRESSINGS

sesame oil

steak

***STRAWBERRIES**

***TOMATOES**

vegetables

vinaigrette

vinegar: red wine, sherry (blending vinegars)

walnut oil

watercress

white truffle oil



High-quality **vinegars** such as Gegenbauer vinegars [from Vienna, Austria], have a place in my kitchen. I'll use a few drops of cucumber vinegar with cucumbers, a raspberry vinegar with raspberries, and a tomato vinegar with tomatoes to intensify the flavor of the ingredient.

—SHARON HAGE, YORK STREET (DALLAS)

Balsamic vinegar is wonderful with fruit. I love the Italian dish of strawberries with balsamic vinegar.

—**GABRIEL KREUTHER**, THE MODERN (NEW YORK CITY)

I like **white balsamic vinegar** because it has fruitiness and a hint of sweetness to it, but not aggressive acidity.

—**DANIEL HUMM**, ELEVEN MADISON PARK (NEW YORK CITY)

Flavor Affinities

balsamic vinegar + brown butter + fish

white balsamic vinegar + white truffle oil + whole grain mustard

VINEGAR, BANYULS

Taste: sour–sweet

Weight: light

Volume: quiet–moderate

Tips: Can substitute for red wine vinegar. Use to deglaze a pan.

beets

cheese: blue, Parmesan

cream

duck

fish

foie gras

honey

lettuces

marinades

meats

mushrooms

nuts

oil: hazelnut, walnut

olive oil

pears

pepper, black

quail

salads and salad dressings

salmon, ivory

salt

saucés

scallops

shellfish

tomatoes

vegetables

walnuts

Flavor Affinities

Banyuls vinegar + blue cheese + lettuce + pears + walnuts

I'll use **Banyuls vinegar** as our everyday vinegar for finishing dishes. A crispy fish like ivory salmon served on the rare side will get a drop of Banyuls vinegar right before it goes out to the table. I'll also use it as a delicate finish for birds like quail.

—**SHARON HAGE**, YORK STREET (DALLAS)

VINEGAR, CABERNET SAUVIGNON

We finish most of our *jus* for meat dishes with **cabernet vinegar**. If you use it at the beginning of the cooking process, it cooks out because it is so light.

—BRAD FARMERIE, PUBLIC (NEW YORK CITY)

VINEGAR, CHAMPAGNE

Taste: sour

Weight: light

Volume: quiet–moderate

Tips: Champagne vinegar is the most delicate vinegar.

artichokes

avocados

delicate dishes

fennel

fish

greens, delicate salad (e.g., baby greens, butter lettuce)

leeks

oils: nut, truffle

olive oil

potatoes

raspberries

salads

shellfish

strawberries

vegetables

Sorbet is about pure flavor and should be a very intense experience of the fruit's flavor. You can jack up the flavor of your sorbet by choosing the correct acid to balance it. For example, lemon juice is really strong. If you have sweet sorbet, you can add a ton of lemon juice that will balance the sweetness but give you a lemon dessert. For some sorbets, I prefer to use **champagne vinegar**. It is light and easy to use. Vinegar is a more potent fruity acid, so you can use less and bring up the fruit of your dessert. I use champagne vinegar for mango or raspberry sorbet. It is made from grapes, which are berries, and is a natural for berry desserts—berries with berries.

—GINA DEPALMA, BABBO (NEW YORK CITY)

Most of our ingredients are pickled with **cider vinegar** and a touch of sugar. I like its fresh green appley flavor and the way it makes things pop.

—**BRAD FARMERIE**, PUBLIC (NEW YORK CITY)

VINEGAR, CHARDONNAY

Chardonnay vinegar is a sweet acid, so you don't have to add additional sugar to your pickling mixture.

—BRAD FARMERIE, PUBLIC (NEW YORK CITY)

VINEGAR, CIDER

Taste: sour

Weight: light

Volume: quiet–moderate

American cuisine

apples

coleslaw

fruits, esp. in salads

ginger

grains

herbs

oil

pears

peas

pork

salads and salad dressings

sauces

smoked fish

smoked meats

sugar

Flavor Affinities

cider vinegar + ginger + sugar

VINEGAR, FRUIT

Taste: sour, sweet

Weight: light

Volume: quiet–moderate

avocados

chicken

fruit salads

hazelnut oil

meats, white

oils, esp. nut

peanut oil

pears

salads and salad dressings

turkey

walnut oil

AVOID

cheese

eggs

VINEGAR, ICE WINE

Taste: sour, sweet

Weight: light

Volume: quiet–moderate, with 5 percent acidity

berries

FOIE GRAS, ESP. TERRINE

fruit

lobster

oil: grapeseed

onions

oysters

peaches

salads

sauces

scallops

seafood

sorbets

strawberries

vegetables

Inniskillin **ice wine vinegar** is really delicious, but expensive. It is delicious with foie gras. It is a fairly reduced sweet and sour vinegar and works as just a drizzle on a plate. It is also good dressed on a salad that you would serve alongside a foie gras terrine.

—TRACI DES JARDINS, JARDINIÈRE (SAN FRANCISCO)

Minus 8 is an **ice wine vinegar**, so named because the grapes are frozen to minus 8 degrees and then squeezed to make the vinegar. It still has acid to it, but it is more viscous, sweet, and tart. It is great with foie gras.

—SHARON HAGE, YORK STREET (DALLAS)

VINEGAR, MALT

Taste: sour

Weight: light

Volume: loud, with moderate acidity

Tips: Sprinkle on foods judiciously.

dressings

fish, fried

oil: hazelnut, peanut

olive oil

pickles

AVOID

sauces

VINEGAR, RED WINE

Taste: sour

Weight: light–medium

Volume: loud, with high acidity

Tips: Red wine vinegar can stand up to spices and stronger herbs.

beans, green

chard

cherries

chicken

cinnamon

cold dishes

dandelion greens

greens: salad, stronger

grilled dishes

heartier dishes

kale

marinades

meat, red

mushrooms

mustard

oils, nut

olive oil

salads and salad dressings

sauces

spinach

tomatoes

vinaigrettes

Red wine vinegar is my workhorse vinegar for cold dishes. I use it in dressings and marinades.

—SHARON HAGE, YORK STREET (DALLAS)

VINEGAR, RICE WINE

Taste: sour, sweet

Weight: light

Volume: quiet, with lower acidity

Asian cuisine

cilantro

coriander

cucumbers

fruit, esp. salads

ginger

honey

Japanese cuisine

lemon

mirin

noodles

oils: peanut, sesame

pepper: black, pink

rice (e.g., for sushi)

salads

salmon

scallions

sesame seeds

soups, esp. creamy, potato

soy sauce

star anise

wasabi

VINEGAR, SHERRY

Taste: sour, sweet

Weight: light

Volume: moderate

apples

asparagus

beans

chicken

cucumbers

duck

figs

fish

gazpacho

greens, esp. bitter

meat dishes

mustard, grainy

nuts

oils: nut, walnut

onions

orange

pancetta

pears

radicchio

rich dishes

salad dressings

salads, esp. with apples, nuts, pears

sauces

Spanish cuisine

tomatoes

tortilla, Spanish

vegetables

The minute **sherry vinegar** is added to a dish, the music gets turned up. It's not just its flavor, but its aroma as well. It makes things sizzle. It is not just when it is used in salads, but it is also the spark that makes gazpacho the unique soup it is. It is the spark that makes a humble lentil stew made with carrots, garlic, onion, and water a new thing. At the end, you add just a touch of vinegar and you have this wonderful flavor that sparkles.... We have made sorbet out of sherry vinegar and what you get is something that makes “the king of refreshing” even *more* refreshing! You can go either savory or sweet with this sorbet: You could serve orange segments with the sherry sorbet on top, a touch of olive oil, an anchovy, a couple of black olives, and you have a salad. Or you could take the same oranges, add a touch of honey on top, manchego cheese, the sherry vinegar sorbet, and have a sweet dessert.

—JOSÉ ANDRÉS, CAFÉ ATLÁNTICO (WASHINGTON, DC)

For our meat dishes, we deglaze with vinegar or *verjus*—and most often it will be **sherry vinegar**. That's my workhorse vinegar for hot dishes.

—SHARON HAGE, YORK STREET (DALLAS)

There is a range of **sherry vinegar** from light to heavy, and I use them all. I love sherry vinegar on almost all vegetables, but especially asparagus and cucumbers.

—KATSUYA FUKUSHIMA, MINIBAR (WASHINGTON, DC)

VINEGAR, TARRAGON

(herb-flavored vinegar)

Taste: sour

Weight: light

Volume: moderate–loud

endive

lettuces, esp. Bibb, iceberg, romaine

oil, mild (e.g., peanut)

olive oil

Vincotto is a byproduct of balsamic vinegar, and is sweet and sour. It is very syrupy and good drizzled over fruit or cheese.

—SHARON HAGE, YORK STREET (DALLAS)

VINEGAR, VINCOTTO

(Cooked Wine)

Taste: sour–sweet

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: moderate–loud

almonds

bacon

cheese, burrata

desserts

fennel

figs

fruit

Italian cuisine

peaches

pears

plums

meats, esp. grilled, roasted

salads and salad dressings

yogurt

VINEGAR, WHITE WINE

Taste: sour

Weight: light

Volume: quiet–moderate

Tips: Can substitute champagne vinegar if needed.

artichokes

avocados

delicate dishes

fennel

fish

leeks

oils: safflower, sunflower

olive oil (extra virgin)

potatoes

shellfish

VODKA

Weight: light–medium

Volume: quiet

amaretto

apples and apple juice

beef consommé

beet juice

berries

blackberries

caraway

carrots, juice

caviar

celery and leaves

celery root

cilantro

cinnamon

cloves

coffee

coconut

cranberry juice

cream

cucumber

currants, black

ginger

grapefruit juice

honey

horseradish

kaffir lime leaf

Kahlúa

LEMON, JUICE

lemongrass

lemon thyme

lemon verbena

licorice
lime, juice
mangoes
maraschino liqueur
melon
oats
olives, green
orange, juice
pepper, black
pineapple juice
Polish cuisine
pomegranate juice
raspberries
rose
RUSSIAN CUISINE
smoked fish
star anise
sugar (simple syrup)
tomato juice
triple sec
vanilla

Using **vodka** as a base spirit in a cocktail makes it drier, while propelling flavors and knitting them together.... I love the combination of Chopin vodka, carrot juice, lemon thyme. If I have it, I'll use Farigoule—a liqueur from Provence made with wild thyme—and lime.

—**JERRI BANKS**, COCKTAIL CONSULTANT (NEW YORK CITY)

I love to draw on the roots of a spirit, and to link a cocktail back to the foods of the table of their country of origin. I'll pair [Eastern European] **vodkas** with the flavors of the *zakuski* table [which historically features several small dishes of beets, cabbage, eggplant, and mushrooms], such as beets, caraway, and horseradish.

—**JERRI BANKS**, COCKTAIL CONSULTANT (NEW YORK CITY)

Flavor Affinities

vodka + amaretto + cream + Kahlúa
vodka + apple + beet + caraway + horseradish
vodka + apple + cinnamon + cloves + cranberry
vodka + beef consommé + celery leaf + horseradish
vodka + blackberries + black pepper + rose
vodka + carrot juice + lemon thyme + lime
vodka + celery + lime juice
vodka + cilantro + coconut + lime + sugar
vodka + cilantro + lime
vodka + coffee + cream
vodka + cranberry + orange
vodka + cranberry + star anise
vodka + grapefruit + maraschino liqueur
vodka + honey + oats
vodka + lemon + lemon verbena
vodka + lime + pineapple

WALNUT OIL
(See Oil, Walnut)

WALNUTS

(See also Nuts—In General)

Season: autumn

Taste: bitter, sweet

Function: heating

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: quiet–moderate

almonds

anise

APPLES

apricots

Armagnac

bananas

bourbon

brandy

breakfast (e.g., pancakes, waffles)

butter, unsalted

buttermilk

caramel

carrots

cheese: blue, Cheddar, goat, Parmesan, ricotta, Roquefort, Stilton

cherries

chestnuts

chicken

chocolate: dark, milk, white

cinnamon

coffee

cognac

cookies

corn syrup: light, dark

cranberries

cream

cream cheese

crème fraîche

cumin

dates

ENDIVE

figs, esp. dried

garlic

ginger

grapefruit

grapes

hazelnuts

HONEY

ice cream

Italian sauces

kumquats

lemon: juice, zest

liqueurs, orange

maple syrup

mascarpone

Mediterranean cuisine

Mexican sauces

molasses

nectarines

oatmeal

olive oil

orange: juice, zest

peaches

PEARS

pecans

pepper, esp. white

persimmons

pine nuts

plums

pomegranates

port

praline

PRUNES

pumpkin

quince

raisins

raspberries

rum

salads

salt

sauces

stuffings

SUGAR: brown, confectioners', white

sweet potatoes

tea

vanilla

walnut oil

whiskey

wine: dry, sweet

yogurt

Walnuts are my favorite nut. I like their bitter quality. They pair well with honey, apples, and pears.

—GINA DEPALMA, BABBO (NEW YORK CITY)

Walnuts are not as versatile as other nuts. If you look at its flavor, it is the opposite end of the spectrum from a macadamia nut because it has a more complicated flavor. You are not getting something that is buttery that coats your palate; you are getting more nut flavor. I can't think of many times when you wouldn't use it, but you might use a smaller amount.

—MARCEL DESAULNIERS, THE TRELIS (WILLIAMSBURG, VIRGINIA)

Walnuts are an oilier nut but still not as strong or dominating as a pecan. I like to combine walnuts with maple in desserts. They work with apples as well as pears or quince.

—EMILY LUCHETTI, FARALLON (SAN FRANCISCO)

Flavor Affinities

walnuts + anise + dried figs + orange

walnuts + apples + honey

walnuts + caramel + prunes

walnuts + coffee + cream

walnuts + cumin + prunes

WARMING

Function: Ingredients believed to have warming properties; useful in cold weather.

alcohol
barley
chile peppers
coffee
cranberries
fruits, dried (e.g., dates)
garlic
grains (e.g., polenta, quinoa)
honey
hot beverages
meat, red
mustard
nuts
oils: almond, mustard
olive oil
onions
spices, warming (e.g., black pepper, cayenne, cinnamon, cloves, ginger, nutmeg, turmeric)
vegetables, root (e.g., carrots, potatoes)
vinegar
walnuts

Dishes

Warm Apple and Walnut Budino with Cinnamon Gelato

—Gina DePalma, pastry chef, Babbo (New York City)

Walnut-Prune Tart with Thyme Sherbet and Caramel Gastrique, Served with a 30-Year-Old Tawny Port

—Ellie Nelson, pastry chef, Jardinière (San Francisco)

WASABI

Taste: hot

Weight: medium

Volume: very loud

avocados

beef

crab

cream

fish

ginger (e.g., with seafood)

JAPANESE CUISINE

mirin

miso

olive oil

onions, green

rice

salmon

sauces

seafood

sesame: oil, seeds

shrimp

soy sauce

sushi and sashimi

tofu

tuna

vinegar, rice wine

WATER CHESTNUTS

Season: summer–fall

Taste: sweet

Weight: light–medium

Volume: quiet

Techniques: raw, stir-fry

bacon

chicken

Chinese cuisine

garlic

ginger

scallions

sesame: oil, seeds

soy sauce

sugar

vinegar, rice wine

WATERCRESS

Season: spring, autumn

Taste: bitter, sweet

Weight: light

Volume: moderate

Techniques: raw

almonds

apples

asparagus, esp. white

bacon

bean sprouts

beef, esp. roasted

beets

bell peppers, esp. red

butter, unsalted

buttermilk

cheese: blue, goat, pecorino

chervil

chicken, esp. roasted

Chinese cuisine

chives

cilantro

cream

crème fraîche

cucumbers

duck

eggs

endive

fennel

fish

fish sauce, Asian

French cuisine

garlic

ginger

Italian cuisine

lamb

leeks

lemon, juice

lime, juice

mascarpone

meats, roasted

mint

mushrooms

mustard

OIL: grapeseed, sesame, vegetable, walnut

OLIVE OIL

onions: red, white, yellow

orange

oysters

parsley, flat-leaf

pears

peas

pepper: black, white

potatoes

radicchio

rice

salads

salmon

salt: kosher, sea

scallions

scallops

seafood

sesame seeds, black

sesame oil

shallots

shrimp

smoked salmon

sorrel

soups, esp. Asian, vegetable

soy sauce

STOCKS: chicken, fish, seafood, vegetable
sugar (pinch)
tarragon
tea sandwiches
tomatoes
veal
vinaigrette
vinegar: champagne, red wine, rice, sherry
walnuts
wine: rice, white
yogurt

Dishes

Insalata “A Voce” with Green Apple, Marcona Almonds, Watercress, Pecorino

—Andrew Carmellini, A Voce (New York City)

Watercress and Endive Salad with Mediterranean Cucumber, Marinated Beets, and Mascarpone Croutons

—Judy Rodgers, Zuni Café (San Francisco)

Flavor Affinities

watercress + almonds + green apple + pecorino cheese

watercress + bacon + cream

watercress + endive + Roquefort cheese + walnuts

watercress + ginger + lemon + shrimp

WATERMELON

Season: summer

Taste: sweet

Weight: light

Volume: quiet–moderate

Techniques: raw

anise hyssop

basil

beverages

blackberries

blueberries

CHEESE: FETA, goat

chili powder

cilantro

cinnamon

cream

cucumber

fennel

honey

jicama

kaffir lime

lemon: juice, zest

lime, juice

melon, esp. cantaloupe

mint

olive oil

orange

parsley, flat-leaf

pepper: black, white

pistachios

pomegranate

raspberries

salads, fruit

salt: kosher, sea

sorbet

soups, esp. chilled

sugar: brown, white

tequila

tomatoes

vanilla

vinegar: balsamic, rice, sherry

I thought the combination of **watermelon** and feta cheese sounded horrible when I first heard it. Then I tasted it, and it works.

—MICHAEL LAISKONIS, LE BERNARDIN (NEW YORK CITY)

Lemony herbs like basil or anise hyssop work with **watermelon**.

—JERRY TRAUNFELD, THE HERBFARM (WOODINVILLE, WASHINGTON)

Flavor Affinities

watermelon + cilantro + cream + tequila

watermelon + fennel + lemon juice + parsley + salt

watermelon + feta cheese + red onions

watermelon + kaffir lime + vanilla



I started working on my **watermelon** salad years ago at Jean Georges restaurant. It started out as a watermelon and goat cheese salad for summertime. The dish was a very refreshing summer dish with the rich goat cheese and the fresh sweet watermelon. You felt like you were eating in a garden! It then went on to become watermelon with fresh tomatoes, but I still wasn't happy with it. The texture of the tomato didn't work with the texture of the watermelon. I then turned the tomatoes into a confit, cooking them in the oven over two hours with olive oil to concentrate their flavor. The dish is now watermelon, with a layer of tomato confit, topped with pistachios that just get browned in the oven, then a drizzle of olive oil and salt and pepper. The whole thing is then flashed in the oven for just a minute or two to warm it. Just before serving it gets a drizzle of balsamic vinegar. It is not only a beautiful play of flavors, but of colors as well.

—**GABRIEL KREUTHER**, THE MODERN (NEW YORK CITY)

WHISKEY

(See also Bourbon)

Weight: heavy

Volume: loud

allspice

chocolate

cinnamon

cream and ice cream

dried fruits

figs

ginger or ginger ale

honey

lemon juice

orange curaçao

pears

spices: cinnamon, star anise

sugar: brown, white

sweet potatoes

vanilla

Flavor Affinities

whiskey + cinnamon + dried fruits + ginger + lemon + star anise

whiskey + lemon + orange curaçao

WILD RICE
(See Rice, Wild)

WINE

(See individual varieties)

WINTER

Weather: typically cold

Techniques: bake, braise, glaze, roast, simmer, slow-cook

bananas

beans

beef

braised dishes

broccoli (peak: February)

Brussels sprouts (peak: December)

cabbage

caramel

chocolate

citrus fruit

dates (peak: December)

game

grains, heavy

grapefruit (peak: February)

greens, winter

lemons (peak: January)

lentils

limes

lobster

maple syrup

mushrooms, wild (peak: December)

mussels

orange, mandarin (peak: January)

passion fruit

pears (peak: December)

plantains

pork

potatoes

roasted dishes

root vegetables

rosemary
sage
soups
spices, warming
squashes, winter
squid
stewed dishes
sunchoke
sweet potatoes (peak: December)
tangerines (peak: January)
turnips (peak: December)
venison
water chestnuts (peak: February)
yams (peak: December)

Winter vegetables work with winter herbs. Sage and rosemary work with potatoes and root vegetables.

—**JERRY TRAUNFELD**, THE HERBFARM (WOODINVILLE, WASHINGTON)

I think of beef and pork as **winter** meats.

—**MICHEL RICHARD**, CITRONELLE (WASHINGTON, DC)

With my desserts, I focus on chocolate all year round, but use it even more in **winter**. In California, the fruit is so wonderful in the summer that that is the place to focus. In summer, I can write my whole menu and forget chocolate—that is how good the fruit is here! In winter, it is the opposite. There are not eight unique things to focus on. So chocolate comes into play because it is a real comfort food and warming, too. Winter with its cool nights becomes soufflé season. Winter is when all the special citrus fruits are available. Thank God for that, because you can work with Cara Cara oranges, lemon, and tropical fruits like passion fruit. Mangoes are available year-round, but winter is when I use them because there's no competition from berries and other summer fruits. What is great about the tropical fruits in winter is that they also bring color to the menu. Pies and tarts work year-round because you can put anything in them, from chocolate to fruit.

—EMILY LUCHETTI, FARALLON (SAN FRANCISCO)

YAMS

(See Sweet Potatoes)

YOGURT

Taste: sour

Function: heating

Weight: medium–heavy

Volume: moderate–loud

almonds

apricots

bananas

beef

beets

blackberries

blueberries

breakfast

cardamom

cayenne

chicken

chickpeas

cilantro

cinnamon

coconut

coriander

CUCUMBER

cumin

curry

desserts

dill

Eastern Mediterranean cuisine

eggplant

fruit

garlic

grapes

Greek cuisine

honey

Indian cuisine

lamb

LEMON: JUICE, ZEST

lemon, preserved

lime

mangoes

maple syrup

meats

Middle Eastern cuisine

mint

nectarines

nutmeg

nuts

oatmeal

okra (e.g., Indian cuisine)

onions

orange: juice, zest

parsley

pasta

peaches

pecans

pepper, white

pineapple

pistachios

potatoes

radishes

raisins

raspberries

rhubarb

saffron

salt, kosher

scallions

squash

strawberries

sugar: brown, white

tamarind

Turkish cuisine

vanilla

veal

vegetables

walnuts

zucchini

Flavor Affinities

yogurt + apricots + pistachios

yogurt + caramel + pine nuts + balsamic vinegar

yogurt + cilantro + garlic

yogurt + garlic + lemon + salt

Dishes

Yogurt with Caramel, Aged Balsamic, and Pine Nut Brittle

—Gina DePalma, pastry chef, Babbo (New York City)

One of my favorite desserts is Greek **yogurt**, warm caramel sauce, and aged, 25-year-old balsamic vinegar. The yogurt is really rich and not too acidic. On the yogurt, I put a salty pine nut brittle, and then the drizzle of vinegar. It works because of the beautiful balance of salt, sweet, and acid.

—GINA DEPALMA, BABBO (NEW YORK CITY)

YUZU FRUIT

Season: winter–spring

Taste: sour

Weight: light–medium

Volume: loud

Fresh **yuzu** is expensive, so I use yuzu juice to add acid to a dish. It is great on seafood. It is not as pungent as lime, and has a little sweetness to it. When you put it on something hot like fish, it also brings out its floral notes.

—KATSUYA FUKUSHIMA, MINIBAR (WASHINGTON, DC)

I had just come back from Japan and was inspired, so I made a **yuzu** curd served with green tea ice cream. The dish has some small bit players like segments of grapefruit which I have always liked with green tea. When you have a perfect grapefruit, it is a little bitter and sweet, just like green tea. Grapefruit reinforces the yuzu because though it is citrus it is a very different flavored citrus. I'll be honest—it looks cool as well, with the pink and green being served together. For texture I add caramelized Rice Krispies. This makes it a homage to Japan: You have rice, green tea, yuzu, and a little ginger caramel.

—MICHAEL LAISKONIS, LE BERNARDIN (NEW YORK CITY)

Just like the lemon that is often served on the side with grilled fish, just a splash of **yuzu juice** makes a lot of things delightful. I love both its aroma and flavor with lighter fish, such as flounder, fluke, and scallops. I recently went to a restaurant where a young chef was trying to be creative, and he paired sweet shrimp with scallion oil, which hid the flavors of the shrimp. I tried to politely suggest that he try yuzu juice instead, which would bring out the sweetness of the sweet shrimp.

—KAZ OKOCHI, KAZ SUSHI BISTRO (WASHINGTON, DC)

Dishes

Yuzu Green Tea Tart with Lychee and Green Tea Marshmallows

—François Payard, Payard Patisserie and Bistro (New York City)

apricots

beef

beverages

caramel

carrots

ceviche

chicken

Chinese cuisine

fish, esp. sweeter, either cooked or raw (e.g., ceviche, sashimi)

flounder

fluke

garlic

gin

ginger

grapefruit

greens

hamachi

hoisin sauce

Japanese cuisine

lemon

mangoes

mirin

miso and miso soup

mushrooms, Japanese

OIL: canola, GRAPESEED, vegetable

olive oil

onions, esp. green

orange, juice

pepper, black

poultry

rice

salmon

scallops

seafood

sesame seeds

shellfish

shrimp

soy sauce: regular, white

sugar

tea, green

teriyaki

Thai basil

tofu

tuna

vinegar, rice wine

vodka

Flavor Affinities

yuzu + caramel + grapefruit + green tea

ZUCCHINI

(See also Summer Squash)

Season: spring–summer

Taste: sweet, astringent

Function: cooling

Weight: light–medium

Volume: quiet–moderate

Techniques: fry, grill, pan roast, roast, sauté

BASIL

bell peppers: green, red, yellow

bread crumbs

butter

CHEESE: cheddar, **dry feta**, **goat**, Gruyère, mozzarella, **PARMESAN**,
pecorino, queso fresco, **RICOTTA**

chile peppers: dried red (e.g., chipotle), fresh green (e.g., jalapeño)

chives

cilantro

cinnamon

coriander

corn

cream

curry leaf

dill

EGGPLANT

fish

French cuisine, esp. Provençal

GARLIC

Italian cuisine

lemon: juice, zest

lemon balm

lemon thyme

marjoram

meats

mint

mustard seeds, esp. black

OIL: pecan, vegetable, walnut

OLIVE OIL

olives, esp. black, niçoise

ONIONS, esp. Spanish, white

oregano

PARSLEY, FLAT-LEAF

pasta

pecans

PEPPER: BLACK, WHITE

Pernod

pesto

pine nuts

red pepper flakes

rice or risotto

rosemary

saffron

sage

salmon

SALT: KOSHER, SEA

sausage, esp. chorizo

scallions

scallops

sesame seeds

shallots

shrimp

sour cream

squash, yellow

stocks: chicken, veal, vegetable

tarragon

THYME

TOMATOES

vinegar: balsamic, champagne, red wine, sherry, white

walnuts

wine, dry white

yogurt

zucchini blossoms



My wife was the inspiration for my **zucchini** dish. She makes a fantastic zucchini soup. She peels the zucchini and boils them in water, then purees them with a little of the water and adds a white cheese like goat or Philadelphia [cream cheese], then some olive oil and salt. It is amazing! It is creamy, velvety, and refined. We cook the zucchini and use the cooking water to make a gelatin. Then we take the white zucchini meat and make a mousse with olive oil. So the bottom of the dish is the mousse, then a layer of seeds—cleaned one by one, which is very labor intensive—then a layer of gelatin that is topped with Spanish caviar. The dish is sweet and savory, and we are proud of its simplicity [of taste].

—**JOSÉ ANDRÉS**, CAFÉ ATLÁNTICO (WASHINGTON, DC)

Dishes

Zucchini–Olive Oil Cake with Lemon Crunch Glaze

—Gina DePalma, pastry chef, Babbo (New York City)

Flavor Affinities

zucchini + basil + garlic

zucchini + cream + Parmesan cheese

zucchini + eggplant + garlic + onions + tomatoes

zucchini + pecorino cheese + pecan oil + pecans

zucchini + Pernod + walnut oil

ZUCCHINI BLOSSOMS

(See also Zucchini)

Season: early summer

Weight: light

Volume: quiet

Techniques: fry, steam

basil

cheese: goat, mozzarella, Parmesan, ricotta

corn

eggs

flour

Italian cuisine

lobster

marjoram

Mexican cuisine

olive oil

onions

parsley, flat-leaf

pepper, black

pesto

risotto

sage

salads

salt, kosher

savory

shrimp

soup

stock, chicken

tomatoes and tomato sauce

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

“We don’t accomplish anything in this world alone... and whatever happens is the result of the whole tapestry of one’s life and all the weavings of individual threads from one to another that creates something.”

—SANDRA DAY O’CONNOR

We’d like to thank some of the many people whose invaluable threads helped to create the tapestry that is *The Flavor Bible*.

First and foremost are all the experts who took the time to speak with us at length about the way they approach flavor development and innovation—and whose insights in this book will surely inspire the next generation to new heights of creativity in the kitchen.

At Little, Brown, thanks to our editor, Michael L. Sand, whose advice and counsel we are both lucky and grateful to have had leading this team. He was not only a trusted sounding board for editorial issues, but his great taste extends from his keen eye overseeing this book’s gorgeous design to our delectable lunches at restaurants including Alto and Park Avenue Winter.

We’d also like to thank the other fabulous folks at Little, Brown, including Sophie Cottrell, vice president and Hachette communications director; Michael Pietsch, publisher; Carolyn O’Keefe and Luisa Frontino, publicists; Peggy Freudenthal, Jayne Yaffe Kemp, and Julie Stillman, copy editors; Jean Wilcox, designer; and Zinzi Clemmons, editorial assistant. Thanks, too, to Karen Murgolo and Jill Cohen, our acquiring editor and publisher, for kicking things off.

Many thanks to our inimitable literary agent Janis Donnaud of Janis A. Donnaud and Associates, for sharing her wisdom and her own delicious taste in everything from publisher matchmaking to Moroccan tagines to barbecued spareribs.

Photography: Our heartfelt thanks to our photographer and very dear friend, the multitalented Barry Salzman, who created the extraordinary photography for this book. Barry traveled all over to get the right shot and even supplied his own

home as a studio. We join Barry in extending thanks to all of the restaurants (and professionals, plus their staffs) who were enormously helpful to us in setting up the photo shoots. They include: August (Tony Liu), A Voce (Dante Camara), Babbo (Gina DePalma), Bette (Amy Sacco), Casaville (Lahcen Ksiyer), Chikalicious (Chika and Don Tillman), Chinatown Brasserie, Darna (Mourad El-Hebil), Despaña, DiPalo, Essex Street Market, Fairway Market, Formaggio Essex, Gilt (Tobie Cancino), Inside (Charleen Badman and Anne Rosenzweig), Kalustyan's (Aziz Osmani), La Esquina, Maremma (Cesare Casella), Saxelby Cheesemongers (Anne Saxelby), Solera (Ron Miller), and the Modern (Gabriel Kreuther).

Friends and Family: Thanks to all of those without whose love and support our lives wouldn't be a fraction as delicious: Susan Bulkeley Butler; Rikki Klieman and Bill Bratton; Laura Day, Samson Day, and Adam Robinson; Cynthia and Jeff Penney; Gael Greene and Steven Richter; Susan Davis and Walter Moora; Julia Davis; Blake Davis; Susan Dey and Bernard Sofronski; Valerie Vigoda and Brendan Milburn; Michael Gelb and Deborah Domanski; Ashley Garrett and Alan Jones; Jimmy Carbone and Pixie Yates; Heidi Olson; Deborah Pines and Tony Schwartz; Steve Beckta and Maureen Cunningham; Jody Oberfelder and Juergen Riehm; Julia D'Amico and Stuart Rockefeller; Rosanne Schaffer-Shaw; Katherine Sieh Takata; Steve Wilson; Trey Wilson; Stephanie Winston; and everyone else we inadvertently missed.

Our DC Outpost: Thanks to our editor, Joe Yonan, and his talented Food section staff at the *Washington Post*, with which we've been proud to be affiliated since March 2007.

Rave: Thanks to all of our friends and family who were among the first online buyers of *What to Drink with What You Eat*: Craig Atlas, Gerry Beck, Ken Beck, Gregory Bess, Susan Bishop, Bill Bratton, Stacey Breivogel, Susan Bulkeley Butler, Jimmy Carbone, Chris Crosthwaite, Laura Day, Carla Dearing, Mark Dornenburg, Meredith Dornenburg, Amy Drown, Robyn Foster, Ashley Garrett, Steven Greenberger, James Incognito, Alan K. Jones, Rikki Klieman, Laura Lau, Dave Mabe, Susan Mabe, Brendan Milburn, Elizabeth Morrill, Marilynn Scott Murphy, Jody Oberfelder, Kelley Olson, Scott Olson, Juergen Riehm, Ann

Rogers, Josh Silverman, Gina Silvestri, Renie Steves, Sandra Suria, Valerie Urban, Valerie Vigoda, Janet McCabe White, and Pixie Yates.

Virtual Book Tour: We wouldn't have had as much fun introducing our last book, *What to Drink with What You Eat*, to the world if it hadn't been for the overwhelmingly warm support of the Web sites and blogs who agreed to host a stop on our Virtual Book Tour in October 2006. We gratefully thank them for their participation: Sally Bernstein of Sallys-Place.com; Betsy Block of MamaCooks.com; Enoch Choi of EnochChoi.com; Paul Clarke of CocktailChronicles.com; Hillel and Debbie Cooperman of TastingMenu.com; Joe Dressner of JoeDressner.com; Chef James T. Ehler of FoodReference.com; Jeremy Emmerson of GlobalChefs.com; Jack Everitt and Joanne White of ForkandBottle.com; John Foley of AllBusiness.com; Ayun Halliday of DirtySugarCookies.blogspot.com; Robert Hess of DrinkBoy.com and TheSpiritWorld.net; Ron Hogan of Beatrice.com; Meg Hourihan of MegNut.com; IACP Blog Team of international-iacp.blogspot.com (including Ruth Alegria, Scott Givot, Elena Hernández, Kate McGhie, and Yukari Pratt); David Lebovitz of DavidLebovitz.com; David Leite of LeitesCulinaria.com; Chris McBride and Jennifer McBride of SavoryTidbits.com; Paul McCann of KIPlog.com; Amy McDaniel of MexicanFood.BellaOnline.com; Dave McIntyre of dmwineline.com; Brett Moore of GourmetFood.About.com; David Nelson of Chef2Chef.net; Adam Roberts of AmateurGourmet.com; Derrick Schneider of ObsessionWithFood.com; Amy Sherman of CookingWithAmy.blogspot.com; Cheri Sicard of FabulousFoods.com; Charlie Suisman of ManhattanUsersGuide.com; Lenn Thompson of LennThompson.typepad.com; and Molly Wizenberg of Orangette.blogspot.com.

Others Who Got the Word Out: We're grateful to the award-winning host Leonard Lopate of WNYC Radio for being the first journalist to put *What to Drink with What You Eat* on the map in a big way, and to Executive Producer Jessica Stedman Guff, who turned it into a series for ABC's *Good Morning America Now*.

Where Better Books Are Sold: We'd like to give a special thank-you to Brad Parsons, Lee Stern, and Scott Ferguson, without whom you'd never be able to

find our books in the nation's leading bookstores. And a special thank-you to Barbara-Jo McIntosh of Barbara-Jo's Books to Cooks in Vancouver, Ellen Rose of the Cook's Library in Los Angeles, and Nach Waxman of Kitchen Arts & Letters in New York City, whose stores are specialty treasures.

... And the Rest: We can't imagine working or living without the seasoned professionals supporting these restaurants, an invaluable source of help and even inspiration to us: Tobie Cancino, Christopher Day, Jason Ferris, and Christopher Lee (Gilt); Heather Freeman (Café Atlántico); Heather Gurfein and Ryan Ibsen (August); Ron Miller (Solera); Rubén Sanz Ramiro (The Monday Room); Rachel Hayden (The Inn at Little Washington); Michael Poli (Wild Edibles); Heather Ronan and Scott and Heather Fratangelo (Spigolo).

Thornton Wilder wrote, "We can only be said to be alive in those moments when our hearts are conscious of our treasures." As we think of those who have been there for us with such generosity, we feel very much alive indeed.

—ANDREW DORNENBURG AND KAREN PAGE
April 2008

P.S. from Andrew Dornenburg: *The Flavor Bible* is our first book with Karen's name listed first on the cover, even though she has always been the prime conceptualizer and writer of all of them. Karen generously suggested before our first book came out in 1995 that we list our names alphabetically—a tradition that continued more out of publishing convenience (having all our books alphabetized together on bookstore shelves, for example) than anything else. However, she is long overdue to be properly credited as the primary force behind our work together. I couldn't be happier about the change!

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The expert contributors listed here invite you to learn more about their work at the Web sites they have provided at the end of their biographical notes.

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ABOUT THE AUTHORS

Karen Page and **Andrew Dornenburg** are the award-winning team behind some of today's most groundbreaking books on gastronomy, including their most recent, *What to Drink with What You Eat*, the first book in history to win both the International Association of Culinary Professionals Cookbook of the Year Award and the Georges Dubeouf Wine Book of the Year Award. Their previous books *Becoming a Chef*, *Dining Out*, and *The New American Chef* were all winners of or finalists for Gourmand World Cookbook, IACP, and/or James Beard book awards. The couple, frequent guests on radio (National Public Radio) and television (*Good Morning America* and *Today*), were cited as two of a dozen "international culinary luminaries" in the Winter 2007 issue of the Relais & Châteaux magazine *L'Ame & L'Esprit*, along with Gael Greene, Patrick O'Connell, Alice Waters, and Tim and Nina Zagat. Since March 2007, they have penned a weekly column for the *Washington Post*, in which capacity they served as judges of the Oyster Riot wine pairing competition. A native of Detroit, Karen Page holds degrees from Northwestern and the Harvard Business School. San Francisco native Andrew Dornenburg is a former restaurant chef who studied with the legendary Madeleine Kamman at the School for American Chefs and was cited by Regis Philbin on *Regis and Kelly* as one of the most famous former employees of McDonald's, along with Jeff Bezos, Jay Leno, and Sharon Stone. Paired personally as well as professionally, the couple have been married since 1990, when they ran the Montreal International Marathon together on their honeymoon. They reside in New York City. Their Web site is www.becomingachef.com.

ABOUT THE PHOTOGRAPHER

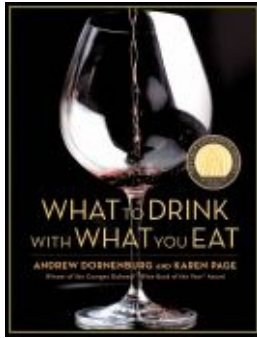
After a twenty-year corporate career, **Barry Salzman**, a Harvard MBA who ran a large global media organization employing thousands of people, embarked on a career transition to pursue his passion on a full-time basis. He is a professional photographer focused primarily on lifestyle, food, and travel. Salzman is a winner of the international Golden Light award, which is judged by Jeff Rosenheim, associate photography curator of the Metropolitan Museum of Art, and Susan White, photography director for *Vanity Fair*. Salzman's work has appeared in such publications as *Vanity Fair*, *Vogue Entertaining + Travel*, *Harper's Bazaar*, *AdNews*, *Australian Geographic*, and *OutTraveler*. His work can be seen at www.barrysalzman.net.



Recently cited as two of a dozen “international culinary luminaries” along with Patrick O’Connell, Alice Waters, and Tim and Nina Zagat (in Relais & Châteaux’s *L’Ame et L’Esprit* magazine), the awardwinning authors **Karen Page** and **Andrew Dornenburg** have written several groundbreaking books chronicling and celebrating America’s culinary revolution. *What to Drink with What You Eat*, *Becoming a Chef*, *Dining Out*, and *The New American Chef* were all winners of or finalists for Gourmand World Cookbook, IACP, and/or James Beard book awards. In March 2007, Page and Dornenburg were named weekly wine columnists for the *Washington Post*. Karen Page is a graduate of Northwestern and Harvard Business School. Andrew Dornenburg studied with the legendary Madeleine Kamman at the School for American Chefs and has cooked professionally in top restaurants in New York and Boston. The couple reside in New York City. Their Web site is www.becomingachef.com.

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Jacket photographs by Wendell Webber

Jacket design by Wilcox Design

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Visit our Web site at www.HachetteBookGroupUSA.com

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DELMONICO, NEW ORLEANS

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Little, Brown and Company
Hachette Book Group
237 Park Avenue, New York, NY 10017
www.hachettebookgroup.com
www.twitter.com/littlebrown

Second e-book edition: September 2008

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ISBN 978-0-316-03984-0